I Have a Story

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PREFACE

Gabriel Garcia Marquez reportedly told Gerald Martin, who wrote his biography: “Each of us has three separate lives: our public, private, and secret lives…” I was very much aware of the distinction between private and public life, because my life was shaped by the tension between the two. The memoirs you are about to read are simply the story of what I lived through along the axis of that tension. I believed that my secret life was an inseparable part of my private life and hoped to tell as much of it as possible. But as the writing progressed, I realized the need to draw the line between private and secret life as carefully as I could. Perhaps because I could hurt others even more than myself, my secret life will not be part of these memoirs; if I live long enough, it may become the subject of another, fictional book.

Fatma was the protagonist of my entire life—public, private, and secret. In all three of my lives, the greatest role always belonged to her. The celebrated English novelist Iris Murdoch wrote in her first novel, “To find a person inexhaustible is simply the definition of love.” Fatma was my inexhaustible, indeed ever-growing love. Because I lived my life anchored to Fatma, I am the luckiest person I know. On the days when I felt happiest, when I told her, “My dear Fatma, you gave me heaven on earth!” I was expressing my most heartfelt emotions.

Yes, I can say that Fatma, too, chose to live her life anchored to me; she shared her private, public, and secret life with me. Did she regret it? Yes, from time to time… I have no doubt that she deserved a more fulfilling life, one with less hardship, sorrow, and suffering. I am sure that if she had had the opportunity to attend the schools she desired and to pursue a profession she loved, her life might not have been anchored to mine, and she might have led a happier existence. As she always said, perhaps it was for the sake of our daughter Elvan that she did not leave me. Perhaps one of the things that made my love for her immortal was that I was never certain of her love. She showed her devotion to me through her actions.

Fatma and I lived a shared life that lasted 55 years. For that reason, I did consider naming the book *My Life with Fatma*. But however much we shared, this is *my* life story. Our 55-year partnership, five years of which I was forced to spend apart from her, came to an end in a completely unexpected way on October 6, 2018, when my Fatma suffered a brain hemorrhage and suddenly departed in the office of Prof. Dr. Hasan Yazıcı, my friend of 60 years and her doctor of 20 years. During roughly the last six months we spent together after my release from Silivri prison, we had resolved never to look back, never to speak of the past, and to live our remaining years thinking only of each other. It was not meant to be… During our last days together in Ayvalık, she had promised that once we returned to Istanbul she would tell me about myself. That, too, was not meant

to be. Consequently, the memoirs you are about to read have, regrettably, remained very incomplete.

Despite all the adversities I have been through, I believe I lived a life worth writing about. The fundamental reason for this is that I spent nearly all of my adult life with Fatma, the most beautiful woman and the most flawless person I have ever known. With her intelligent, sensible, sensitive, realistic, grounded, cool-headed, capable, honest, sincere, self-assured, dignified—in a word, noble—character, Fatma gave me so much; she was one of the two women who made me who I am, even more so than my mother. I owe her a great deal; above all, the brilliant children she raised, my Elvan and Acar, and my brilliant grandchildren Defne and Leyla…

On October 10, 2018, the day we laid Fatma to rest, we gathered around a table on the terrace of her house in Çamlık with close friends who had come to share my grief. “If I could have foreseen that Turkey would come to this, I would have lived my life very differently,” I said. I was not unaware that this was a pipe dream, but what I meant to express was this: If I could go back to the beginning, I would have devoted my life entirely to Fatma; like her, I too would have wanted not two but four children; I would not have stayed apart from her for a single day, let alone five years. The response from my friend Nuri Çolakoğlu at the table was: “Why do you say that!.. You’re writing your memoirs. When you’re done, you’ll look at the book and say, ‘What a life I’ve lived!’…” I don’t know if that will be the case, but this much is certain: I am writing my memoirs for myself and for Fatma; to record how happy she made me; how powerless I was to make her happy; and what we shared together—first and foremost for my children and grandchildren. My memoirs do not aim to bear witness to the domestic and world politics of the long era I lived through; they merely describe the effects of these on my own life.

Yes, I could have named this book *My Life with Fatma*. But however much we shared, this is *my* life story… The other day, while I was chatting with Fatma’s nephew Cenk, the son of my late sister-in-law Ayşe, he said, “Uncle, you have a story… I wish I had a story too…” Inspired by him, I decided to give my memoirs the title *I Have a Story*.

CHAPTER I / HOW I BECAME WHO I AM

The foremost factor in making me who I am was undoubtedly the family I was born into. It would be fitting to begin the story of my family with the person who perhaps played the greatest role in it: my maternal grandfather, Halit Remzi Bey. What I know about him is very limited. Who his parents were, whether he had any siblings—I do not know. As far as I know, his interesting story goes as follows: He was born in 1868 in Üsküp (Skopje); he attended the Mülkiye Rüştiyesi in Salonica, a school that Atatürk also attended for a time. He entered business life at a young age. He worked as a contractor on the construction of the Salonica quay. He later joined the Ottoman Public Debt Administration (Düyun-u Umumiye, 1876–1939) as an official. His first wife, whom he married in Salonica, contracted tuberculosis and passed away shortly after the birth of their son Celal (the grandfather of writer and translator Celal Üster).

In the early 1900s, Halit Bey was appointed head of the Public Debt Administration for the district of Midilli (Lesbos), and moved to the city of Midilli, bringing along his son Celal and Celal's Greek nursemaid Eleni. The town notables wasted no time in finding him a new bride through the traditional matchmaking custom. He married Rasime Hanım in a religious ceremony. When it became apparent on the wedding night that the bride was intersex (hermaphrodite), he divorced her and returned her to her family. What befell him caused a great stir in Midilli; satirical songs were composed about him: "O plane tree, mighty plane tree / Every bird comes to perch on it / Neither girl nor boy / Halit Efendi, my heart aches for that one…" (For the preservation of these lyrics, as for most of what I know about our grandfather Halit Bey and our grandmother Nazire Hanım, I am indebted to the matchless memory of my cousin on my aunt's side, the painter Gaye Baykal-Kazancıgil, who was as close to me as a sibling. May she rest in peace.)

The search for a new wife for Halit Bey began. This time he said, "I won't marry without seeing her first…" A scenario was accordingly devised: the approved new bride candidate, Nazire Hanım—"the Customs Officer's daughter"—clad in her black çarşaf, rode in a phaeton with her aunt's daughter Şaziment (or Şaziye) Hanım, passing slowly through the courtyard of the central mosque. Halit Bey watched them from a window overlooking the courtyard, and immediately took a great liking to Nazire on account of her ample bosom, deciding to ask for her hand from her father, Osman Bey, the customs director of Midilli (originally from the village of Kalunya).

About Halit Bey's lineage we know nothing, but about Nazire Hanım's we have some information. Her maternal line goes back several generations to Hacı Ahmet Ağa of Midilli. The Ağa had three children (İshak, Ayşe, Ahmet). Of these, Ayşe also had three children (Hanife, Münevver, Adile). Münevver Hanım married Alaybeyi Ahmet Bey and bore five children (Nimet, Hüsnü Esma, Hatice, Süveyde, Ahmet). Of these, Hatice Hanım married Hafız Ahmet Bey and they had two daughters (Rıfat, Faika). Faika married "the Customs Officer" (Customs Director) Osman Bey, originally from the village of Kalunya, and they had four children (Zihniye, Cavit, Nazire, Servet). Of these, Nazire —my maternal grandmother—married Halit Remzi Bey of Üsküp and had three children (Remzi, Şefika, and my mother Sabiha). My mother's aunt Servet Hanım also had three children (Şaziye, Aziz, Meseret). Of these, Şaziye Hanım (the maternal grandmother of Ottoman cultural historian Prof. Dr. Çiğdem Kafesçioğlu and architect Murat Kafesçioğlu) was the cousin mentioned in the marriage story of Nazire Hanım that I related above.

From Midilli to Harput

Halit Bey and Nazire Hanım married in 1903. Their first child, my late uncle Remzi (Karatal), was born in 1904 in Midilli. The following year, Halit Bey was assigned by the Public Debt Administration to Kemah (then part of Adıyaman province, today part of Erzincan). The family moved to Kemah with their belongings loaded onto mules, on a long and adventurous journey via Ayvalık. My late aunt Şefika (İpekel) was born in 1906 in Kemah; at one year of age she came down with ringworm of the scalp (tinea capitis). Halit Bey took his daughter to Istanbul for treatment. There, Şefika was successfully treated with "hacamat" (cupping—a procedure involving the extraction of bad blood from

the body). Two years later, Halit Bey was transferred, this time to Harput (Elazığ). My late mother Sabiha was born there in 1908. Remzi and Sabiha both developed “Oriental sores” there. Both would bear scars from the sores that, once healed, were believed to become beauty marks.

Halit Bey’s next post in the Public Debt Administration was the directorship of the Istanbul Fish Market. The family settled in a house with a garden near Zeyrek. In the evenings, Halit Bey frequented the small unlicensed back-street taverns known as “koltuk meyhaneleri” with the well-known writers of the day, foremost among them his friend the author Ahmet Rasim. After a while he resigned from his post and entered the world of commerce; he partnered with Halil Bey, nicknamed “Moskof” (“the Muscovite”), to export lemons to Batumi. Halit Bey and his family moved, presumably on the eve of the First World War, to Ankara, settling in a house with a garden in the “Armenian quarter.” Their neighbors were the (Vehbi) Koç family, who ran a grocery shop. During the “Deportation” (Tehcir) of 1915–16, Halit Bey and Nazire Hanım hid two Armenian girls in their attic for months; they later converted them to Islam and arranged their marriages.

Halit Bey’s business in Ankara was army food supply contracting, primarily “kavurma” (preserved meat). For a time he worked at the “Yeni Gün” newspaper, which Yunus Nadi had begun publishing in 1920. A man with a great passion for classical Turkish music who spoke Greek and French well, Halit Bey arranged for his daughters Şefika and Sabiha to take violin and oud lessons (from the Greek Aleko) as well as French lessons from a French lady. When the Greek occupation army reached as far as Eskişehir, Halit Bey, who was in İnebolu on business, summoned Nazire Hanım to leave Ankara immediately and join him. Nazire Hanım, together with the President of the Criminal Division of the Court of Cassation Mustafa Asım Bey and his family, traveled by horse-drawn carriages over the Ilgaz mountains—where bandits roamed—and reached İnebolu.

Ayvalık

Victory was won in August 1922. Upon the news that a population exchange with Greece was to take place, Nazire Hanım traveled several times from Ankara to Midilli; she gathered documents relating to the properties she owned there; after the exchange, these documents enabled her to be allocated a house and several hundred olive trees in Ayvalık. The family was now bound for Ayvalık; it was there that they celebrated the proclamation of the Republic on October 29, 1923. Shortly afterward, Halit Bey was appointed mayor of Ayvalık by the single-party government. During his five-year tenure, among other things he had the city’s first electricity plant built along with a cinema hall where silent films were shown. He had some of the stone pine trees planted that still adorn the hillsides of the city today. He organized Republic Day balls attended by İsmet İnönü and Kazım Orbay, among others. According to family lore, he was removed from the mayorship in 1928 because of his project to build a quay where ships could dock. The owners of the barges that transported the region’s principal products—olive oil and soap—to ships were opposed to the construction of the quay.

Halit Bey had been initiated into Freemasonry during his years in Salonica. In his political views, he felt an affinity with the Unionists (İttihatçılar) and later with the Kemalists. His religious convictions were weak, perhaps nonexistent. (According to my mother, he was “an atheist.”) His wife Nazire, by contrast, was devoutly religious, praying five times a day, never going out without her çarşaf. When angry at her husband she would complain, “That wretched Freemason… He made my children irreligious…” Nevertheless, at Nazire Hanım’s insistence, the Ramadan and Sacrifice festivals (Eid al-Fitr and Eid al-Adha) were duly celebrated in the family. Halit Bey did not fast but did attend the festival prayers. During his mayorship, until the state monopoly administration was established in 1926, he also produced “Ayvalık” brand rakı, cognac, and wine at 74 Dereboyu Avenue.

In those years, the family’s chief entertainment was hosting fasıl (classical Turkish music) evenings at home, with the participation of neighbors and relatives. Şefika and Sabiha would play the oud, kanun, and piano at these evenings and sing. Another amusement for the family and their friends was holding séances. Nazire Hanım believed that the spirits summoned at these séances truly came to visit. For Halit Bey, it was merely entertainment. Because of the fright these sessions caused her as a child, my mother Sabiha was never able to stay home alone for the rest of her life.

Sabiha, the beloved youngest child of Halit Bey and Nazire Hanım, was a very beautiful girl. Nazire Hanım was determined to betroth her to their relative Salih (Komili) Bey. Although Halit Bey was not at all in favor, the engagement took place in 1925. However, at a ball that Sabiha attended with her father, she danced with a guest (who had come “from Atatürk’s circle”). Thereupon Salih’s brother Necmi Bey (father of Halis Komili, a former president of TÜSİAD) told Salih, “Your fiancée danced with a stranger…” When Salih reacted furiously, Halit Bey declared, “I don’t want such an uncivilized son-in-law…” and immediately broke off the engagement, returning the gifts. Although the deeply upset Sabiha insisted for a while that she would not “take off the ring,” she soon forgot the matter. In 1926, she married Ahmet Saim Bey, the son of one of the wealthiest families of Midilli. On August 16, 1928, the couple’s daughter (my eldest sister) Sumru was born.

Sadly, Ahmet Saim Bey contracted tuberculosis a year later and went alone to Davos, Switzerland, for treatment. In 1930, a week after undergoing surgery in a hospital in Vienna, he passed away at the age of only 22 and was buried there. His grave would later be searched for by family members but never found.

Approximately a year after Halit Bey died of a heart attack in Istanbul on February 7, 1931, at the age of 63, the 53-year-old Nazire Hanım also passed away. Despite their very different personalities, she had been bound to her husband with a great love; unable to bear the grief of losing him, her heart simply stopped.

Having lost first her husband, then her father, then her mother within two years, Sabiha was left a widow with her two-year-old daughter Sumru. She was so beautiful that five handsome young men from the Ayvalık gentry proposed marriage to her. But she fell in love with Ahmet Muharrem Bey—born in Serres (Greece), nicknamed “the Handsome,” four years her junior and only 21 at the time—whom she visited at his soap factory (at 1

Gülbahar Street) to sell tickets for a ball organized by the Ayvalık Philanthropic Society. “If I could live three years with this man, it would be enough for me!” she used to say. This encounter paved the way to their marriage.

Serres

Ahmet Muharrem Bey belonged to the largest landowning family of the city of Serres in Greek Macedonia, whose population, as Mark Mazower recorded in his book *Salonica*, was two-thirds Muslim before the Balkan Wars. Located 80 km north of Salonica, Serres is the place where Sheikh Bedreddin of Simavna—the subject of Nazım Hikmet’s famous poem—who rebelled against the Ottomans with his egalitarian ideas, was hanged in 1420. Ahmet Bey’s paternal lineage traced back to Halil Bey, the brother of Muharrem Bey, Governor of Alexandria, who was the son of Çorbacıbaşı Hüseyin and the nephew and son-in-law of Mehmet Ali Pasha of Kavala (Muhammad Ali, the founder of modern Egypt).

The agricultural lands and real estate of the very wealthy and childless Muharrem Bey were consolidated in a waqf—an Islamic endowment—established in Alexandria (the Muharrem Bey Waqf). When Halil Bey returned from Alexandria to his hometown of Serres toward the end of the 19th century, the management of the waqf passed to his brother Hasan Berto. Over time, Berto transferred the waqf’s assets to himself. (Our relatives on my father’s side, the Alantar brothers, tried hard in Egypt to claim our shares; they even asked me in 1983 to obtain a court ruling confirming we were heirs. Unfortunately, their efforts came to nothing.)

Halil Bey, who returned from Alexandria to Serres, had four sons (Mahmut Pasha, Hacı Osman, Hacı Ali, Hacı Mestan). Hacı Ali Bey, to whom Sultan Mahmud II had granted nine estates as fiefs, also had three sons (Muharrem, İlyas, İbrahim Pasha). İlyas Bey is our ancestor on the paternal side. As famous for his miserliness as for his wealth, İlyas Bey owned some 20,000 dönüm (roughly 2,000 hectares / 5,000 acres) of land in the villages of Radiloz and Oteligos between Serres and Drama; he also sponsored wrestlers who competed at Kırkpınar. (I will tell the story of meeting one of these wrestlers, a white-bearded old man, later on.)

İlyas Bey had seven children from four wives (Ali, Ziba, Siyavuş, Ata, Behiye, Aliye, Tayyar). Of these, Ali Bey had two children (Baise and Muharrem); Muharrem Bey was my grandfather. (One interesting thing I learned about my father’s grandfather Ali Bey was that he sided for a time with Tepedelenli Ali Pasha, the Governor of Ioannina who rebelled against the Ottoman state.) Ali Bey’s brother Tayyar Bey also had three sons: İlyas, Yahya, and İhsan (Alantar). I am glad I had the opportunity to know these three nephews of my father; all three, whom I called “uncle,” became people I loved dearly. (İlyas and Yahya were not at all religious, but the youngest brother İlyas, when I visited him in Adapazarı near the end of his life, would reveal to me that he belonged to the Kadiri Sufi order.)

I learned the family genealogy I have recounted above primarily from Yahya Alantar, with whom I had a close relationship (and whose influence made me a Beşiktaş supporter at the age of five or six). My Uncle Yahya read my columns in Milliyet and greatly enjoyed

them. In a letter of his that I kept, he wrote that he found some of them comparable to the editorials of Şükrü Baban in Yeni Sabah and Nadir Nadi in Cumhuriyet. He described my refusal to deny that I was a Marxist in my youth as “a noble stance.” Despite the heavy cost it imposed on the family, he was in favor of the 1923 population exchange with Greece; “otherwise we would have ended up like Lebanon,” he used to say.

Another detail from that letter that struck me greatly was his mention of the sense of “reticence, of hiding” that having sided with Tepedelenli Ali Pasha—who rebelled against the Ottoman state—had instilled in the family. According to information I obtained from another relative (Nurhan Gençel Bey) about our paternal ancestors, our lineage had initially embraced the Alevi faith before later choosing Sunnism.

Now let me turn to the roots of my father’s maternal side: My paternal grandfather Ali Bey married his son Muharrem to Mukaddes Hanım, the daughter of Agâh Efendi, the Mevlevi Sheikh of Serres. Agâh Efendi had inherited his sheikhdom from his grandfather Şükrü Bey (the earliest known ancestor on my paternal grandmother’s side), through his father Osman Bey. When Serres fell under Bulgarian occupation during the Balkan Wars, Agâh Efendi fled in 1913, taking with him his wife Güllü Hanım, his daughter (my paternal grandmother) Mukaddes Hanım, his son-in-law (my grandfather) Muharrem Bey, and their one-year-old son (my father) Ahmet—first to Salonica, then to Edirne, and shortly thereafter to Istanbul. (My father’s only sibling, Fahire Hanım, had died in childhood.)

The family took refuge in the Mevlevi lodge in Kasımpaşa. When Agâh Efendi realized he would never be able to return to Serres, his heart, consumed by grief, gave out. Muharrem and his wife Mukaddes, who had suffered various traumas during the migration, faced great hardships in the new homeland to which they had been uprooted. Whereas they had been very wealthy in Serres, here they fell into dire poverty. My grandfather Muharrem Bey fell ill while working as a laborer at the Agricultural Equipment Agency in Adapazarı to support his family, and died at a relatively young age. My paternal grandmother Mukaddes Hanım, unable to recover from the effects of the massacres she had witnessed, suffered a mental breakdown after her husband’s death; she was committed to the Bakırköy psychiatric hospital by her sisters (Üftade and Zehra Hanım) who lived in Istanbul. She died there in the late 1930s.

My father Ahmet, left an orphan, was taken in by his aunts Üftade and Zehra, who lived in Laleli, and by his father’s aunt (who was childless) Aliye Hanım and her husband, the retired captain Salih Bey, who lived in Anadoluhisarı. After the population exchange agreement, my father came to Ayvalık in 1926, at the age of only 14, together with his aunt Üftade. (Aunt Üftade, whom I vaguely remember, was a very pleasant person. She was the wife of Colonel Saadettin Bey, who fell as a martyr in Shkodër; she was widowed before they had even spent a year together and never remarried.) As a result of his aunt’s application, my father was allocated, as an exchangee’s entitlement, five to six thousand olive trees—mostly in Ayvalık with some in Yalova Esenköy—along with a soap factory, oil warehouses, and a house (at No. 80 on Sefa—later Barbaros—Avenue) in Ayvalık. The property allocated to my father as an exchangee corresponded to only a very small fraction of what the family had owned in Serres. There had been considerable

corruption in the allocation of property to exchangees. Some had bribed the allocation commissions to acquire far more property than they had owned in Greece. Having attended Istanbul Erkek Lisesi while staying with his great-aunt, Ahmet settled in Ayvalık in 1930, when he turned 18, to take actual possession of his property and build a life there. Because he was very handsome and impeccably dressed, the people of Ayvalık soon nicknamed him “Handsome Ahmet Bey.” He took part in community life; among other things, he served as president of the İdmanyurdu Sports Club, supported by partisans of the ruling Republican People’s Party (CHP). Supporters of the Free Republican Party (Serbest Fırka), meanwhile, backed Akınspor. When a brawl broke out between the two clubs’ supporters in August 1939, both clubs were shut down.

Ahmet and Sabiha

Many families and young women had their eye on the very handsome and quite wealthy Ahmet Bey. But Ahmet chose Sabiha, the famously beautiful widowed daughter of Ayvalık’s first Republican-era mayor Halit Remzi Bey. Sabiha, who had gone to meet Ahmet Bey on the pretext of selling a ball ticket, used to say, “I would give ten years of my life to be with this man.” They married in 1934 and took the surname Alpay in accordance with the law enacted that year. Their wedding was held at the house (now the Bonjour Guesthouse) of Süeyde Hanım, the mother of Sabiha’s first husband (and father of her first child Sumru), the late Ahmet Saim Bey.

Ahmet and Sabiha built a very happy partnership in the first ten years of their marriage. They began living winters in a rented apartment in the Kaptan family’s building in Ayvalık, and summers in the small house in the resort neighborhood of Çamlık that Sabiha and Sumru had inherited from Ahmet Saim Bey. Their first child, Olcay (my second-eldest sister, wife of the late Ünal Karacan, an engineer and Istanbul Technical University (İTÜ) graduate), was born in 1935 in that house; their second child, my elder brother Acar (whom we lost in a tragic traffic accident in 1977, father of former TÜSİAD president Ümit Boyner and of Cihan Alpay), was born in 1938 in İzmir. Ahmet Bey was a true gentleman. He was a husband in love with his wife and a father devoted to his children. He was extremely affectionate toward his children, including his stepdaughter Sumru. He was a man who loved to read; the works of Nazım Hikmet were among his bedside books.

Sabiha Hanım, in her own words as a result of a “stray bullet,” became pregnant again six years after Acar. She considered having an abortion, but the doctors would not allow it, saying it was too late. Ahmet Bey, for his part, had decided that their third child would also be a boy and had already chosen the name: “We placed the order—Şahin is coming from America!” he would say. (This must have been a reflection of the admiration for the United States prevalent toward the end of the Second World War.) In those years, the Alpay family spent the winter months in the apartment building that their family friend and Çamlık neighbor Mustafa Lütfü Kaptan had built on the seaside in Ayvalık. The Kaptans lived on the third (top) floor; the Alpays, their tenants, on the second (middle) floor.

In those years, the population of Ayvalık consisted almost entirely of exchangees who had been settled there, mainly from Midilli, Crete, and Greek Macedonia, pursuant to the Lausanne Treaty signed between Turkey and Greece in 1923. The treaty had subjected approximately 1.2 million Greek Orthodox living in Turkey—including the Karamanlıs, some of whose mother tongue was Turkish—and approximately 400,000 Muslims living in Greece, including Cretans, some of whose mother tongue was Greek, to compulsory exchange. The Kaptan family, the Alpays' neighbors, were one of a handful of Black Sea-origin families who had come to Ayvalık through internal migration from the Trabzon region before the exchange. The Kaptans' story, too, helps one understand what kind of place my hometown Ayvalık was—and, more importantly, what kind of place Turkey was in its transition from Empire to Republic.

My other family: The Kaptans

The second milieu that was perhaps as influential in making me who I am as my own family was the family of Fatma—my love, and my wife. The pioneer role in the Kaptan family's settling in Ayvalık—then still entirely a Greek city (known to the Greeks as Kidonia, or more commonly Ayvali)—was played by Salim Bey from the village of Hamandos (now Aydoğdu) in the Sürmene district of Trabzon. Salim Bey was a ship captain. He was a commercially astute "Black Sea lad." He grew wealthy through trade between Trabzon and Romania. In the course of his travels he learned Romanian and even served as an interpreter at the Ottoman consulate in Constanţa. When he married his fellow villager Rukiye Hanım, whether she could wear the modern wedding dress her husband had ordered from Bucharest became a great subject of debate in Hamandos, but in the end the dress was worn.

Salim Bey was not a man of conservative inclination (presumably because of his openness to the world), and this trait would be passed down to the Kaptans to a great degree. Before the First World War, he moved to Istanbul and settled in Sarıyer to expand his business. Rukiye Hanım bore him two daughters named Fatma and Leman. When Istanbul was occupied, Salim Bey moved his family to Manyas. He opened a grocery shop there. According to family memory, he played a role in bringing weapons by ship to the nationalist forces (Kuvva-yı Milliye). When he learned that Çerkes Ethem intended to abduct his beautiful daughter Fatma, he packed up everything, loaded his family onto horse-drawn carts, and migrated to Ayvalık (presumably in 1918), at a time when the War of Independence had not yet been won, the Republic had not been proclaimed, and the population exchange with Greece had not taken place.

When he settled in Ayvalık—where only the district governor and security forces were Muslim and the rest of the population was Greek—there was only one other Turkish-Muslim family living in the city. The only village inhabited by Turks was Araplar (now Mutluköy). In other words, Salim Bey was in a sense the pioneer of Muslim settlement in Ayvalık. His daughters Fatma (who would pass away a few years later, at the age of 16) and Leman learned to read and write at the Greek school they attended in Ayvalık.

After the proclamation of the Republic, Salim Bey turned to olive oil and soap trading between Ayvalık and Istanbul. Because his wife Rukiye could not give him a son, he took a second wife, the widowed Hanife Hanım, also from the village of Hamandos. His

first wife Rukiye Hanım would be deeply upset when she learned of this marriage from others. Hanife Hanım, whose husband had been killed during the 1877 Russo-Turkish War, had buried three children who died of typhus on the road as she fled westward from Trabzon. She bore Salim Bey the twins Kenan and Neriman in 1920, and İsmet in 1925. (Kenan Kaptan was one of the founding partners of Pak Maya. İsmet Kaptan studied agricultural engineering in Italy and, after serving as İzmir Fair director, became one of the founding partners of Ege Seramik.) Living in Ayvalık with his two wives housed in two separate homes on the same street, Salim Bey sold hardware and (in the words of his late son Hakkı Kaptan, who told me all this) “maritime supplies” at the shop he had opened, while searching for a reliable partner to handle the Istanbul side of his commercial operations. His brother Mehmet (known by the nickname “the drunken womanizer”) recommended Mustafa Lütfü Bey, a hardworking “Black Sea lad” from Vakfıkebir who was then engaged in trade at the Oil Wharf in Eminönü, Istanbul.

Mustafa Lütfü of Vakfıkebir had been conscripted during the First World War, sent first to the Albanian front and then to the Syrian front, and had served as Cemal Pasha’s headquarters sergeant. He fought with distinction on the Palestine and then the Galician (Romanian) fronts, was wounded in the forehead and leg, and received a veteran’s certificate. Upon his discharge, he divorced the wife he had married before his military service with a curt “You are divorced”—the traditional repudiation formula; he married for a second time in Istanbul, to Mahmure Hanım, a fellow Black Sea native. When Mahmure died young of tuberculosis, their six- or seven-year-old son Hakkı was left motherless.

Salim and Mustafa Lütfü agreed in the 1930s to form a partnership. Salim Bey, whose original surname was Erol, and Mustafa Lütfü Bey, whose was Kodalak, both changed their surnames; together they adopted the surname Kaptan, fitting for their Black Sea origins. Salim Kaptan married off the 32-year-old Mustafa Lütfü Kaptan to his elder daughter (from his first wife Rukiye), the 16-year-old Leman. Mustafa Lütfü in turn married his son Hakkı from his first marriage to Neriman, daughter of Salim Bey’s second wife Hanife Hanım. The Kaptan family’s kinship relations, which even many Ayvalık residents found difficult to untangle, were based on the fact that a father (Mustafa Lütfü) and his son from his first wife (Hakkı) married sisters born of the same father (but two different mothers)—Leman and Neriman. Despite their Black Sea origins, the Kaptans had little attachment to conservative values, whether in terms of religiosity or traditionalism. The adventures that had carried them from the eastern Black Sea to the northern Aegean had played a role in their adapting to the not particularly conservative values of the Ayvalık community, composed as it was of exchangees.

Salim Kaptan died in Istanbul in the early 1940s, where he was being treated for cirrhosis; he was buried in the Sarıyer cemetery, beside his first daughter Fatma. After his death, Mustafa Lütfü Kaptan took over the management of the Kaptan firm, and his son Hakkı Kaptan from his first marriage took on the accounting. Hakkı, who had wanted to become a history teacher and remained passionate about history throughout his life, was forced to take on the role of his father’s accounting director after graduating from Galatasaray Lycée and the Higher School of Commerce. Mustafa Lütfü Bey’s second wife Leman bore four children: the eldest a boy (Suat), the other three girls (Bingül,

Ayşe, and Fatma, in that order). Suat contracted tuberculosis in 1946 and died at only 18, plunging the family into mourning.

Mustafa Lütfü Kaptan was a very hardworking businessman. He invested the money he earned from the construction materials trade he had established with his father-in-law Salim Kaptan in the olive and soap business. Over time he came to own thousands of olive trees, an olive oil factory, a soap works, warehouses, and numerous properties. He had Ayvalık's first apartment building—three stories—built on the seaside. He gave the two-story house he had purchased in Çamlık, originally belonging to Greeks, to his son; in its large garden he had a two-story house built for himself. By the 1940s, the "Black Sea lad" from Vakfıkebir who had fought for years on various fronts in the First World War and earned a veteran's certificate had become one of the wealthiest businessmen in Ayvalık. He remained true to his roots and always employed seasonal "Black Sea lads" at his workplaces. In 1956, at the age of 65, he decided to learn to drive; he took the exam and obtained his license. However, shortly afterward, he died in an accident while driving his jeep to Burhaniye to inspect a farm he was considering purchasing. His wife, my future mother-in-law Leman Hanım, was widowed at 49.

In early 1944, there was great commotion in the Kaptans' three-story seaside apartment building in Ayvalık. Leman Hanım went to Istanbul to give birth to her fourth child and on February 14 brought her third daughter, Fatma Nur, into the world. Shortly afterward, Sabiha Hanım, the wife of the Kaptans' tenant on the middle floor, Ahmet Alpay, also went to Istanbul to give birth to her fourth child and on April 18 gave birth to her second son, Şahin. Both mothers returned to their hometown soon after giving birth. Thus, by a twist of fate, Fatma and Şahin—who would marry in 1965, when they turned 21—found themselves under the same roof in the very first days of their lives. One might say that my life with Fatma began right there.

The mental crisis that shook the family

Let us return to the Alpays: Ahmet and Sabiha were very happy together, but their happiness did not last long. Ahmet Bey was under the influence of various traumas caused by the upheavals that had begun with the Balkan Wars, which had uprooted his family. Following the Capital Tax Law enacted in 1942, he had filed an income declaration of 1.5 million liras and been assessed a tax of 10,000 liras. He suffered great distress over how he would pay this amount and the anxiety that if he could not, he would be sent to Aşkale. From that date onward, he fell into an increasingly chronic mental crisis.

My mother, with the best of intentions, had moved the household to Istanbul for my father's treatment; following the advice of certain relatives and doctors there, she first sent my father, under medical supervision, to a clinic in Paris. My father escaped from the clinic, climbed onto a train car, managed to reach Marseille and apply to the Turkish consulate there, and with the consulate's help boarded a ship and returned to Istanbul. Upon his return he endured the agonizing electroshock treatments prescribed by doctors in Istanbul, but when he heard that brain surgery was being considered, he fled the house and took refuge with his aunts, turning hostile toward the woman he had once

loved—my mother. What is both deeply saddening and thought-provoking about these events is that a case of depression that could in later years have been managed with medication alone led, as a result of the coercive methods employed, to the disintegration of the family.

As a result, my father, with the help of his aunts Üftade and Zehra, was freed from guardianship, divorced my mother, and began a solitary life that would last until the end of his days. The last time I recall seeing him in our house in Teşvikiye was in 1950, the year I started primary school. He would later settle in Ankara, where until the 1960s he ran a shop in the Maltepe district selling Ayvalık olive oil and soap. He would then return to Ayvalık and live on the income from leasing the olive groves he owned. Until his death on September 9, 1981, at the age of 69, when his heart stopped, both my siblings' and my own relationship with him remained very limited. His closest companion was a small dog he named Fidel (faithful).

"A woman worthy of seven novels"

For the reasons briefly described above, I essentially grew up as the child of my mother, who passed away on January 24, 1992, at the age of 84. My mother, described by one relative as "a woman worthy of seven novels," led a very unfortunate life as a result of the upheavals of Turkey in the first half of the 20th century in general and of those in her own life in particular. She was widowed from her first husband at only 22. Although she divorced my father at around 40, she never remarried; she devoted herself to her children. Her greatest entertainment was card games. She was one of the best bridge players in Ayvalık. She was a very affectionate but, when necessary, authoritarian mother. She raised her children with love and ensured they received a good education.

I owe her gratitude for ensuring I attended the best schools despite the limited financial means she had after divorcing my father. Another matter for which I owe her gratitude is her encouraging me from an early age to help her with housework. When needed, I went to the market, washed dishes, and cleaned. I believe these experiences helped me acquire the ability to adapt to all manner of circumstances later in life.

The fundamental pillar of our family was undoubtedly my mother. She herself had only a primary school education, but perhaps under the influence of her father, who was quite educated and experienced, she placed great importance on her children receiving a good education. She ensured that all four of us attended Istanbul's best schools and learned English. My eldest sister Sumru finished middle school and my second-eldest sister Olcay finished high school at the American College for Girls in Arnavutköy. My elder brother Acar finished middle school at Robert Academy in Bebek and high school at Işık Lisesi in Nişantaşı before going on to Istanbul University's Faculty of Law. I, as I will recount in detail later, attended middle school at the English High School for Boys in Nişantaşı, high school at Robert Academy in Bebek, and university at Ankara University's Faculty of Political Science.

My mother's great influence on my upbringing certainly had a political dimension as well. She greatly admired Atatürk. I believe all Turkish and Muslim families forced to emigrate from the Balkans believed they owed their finding peace in the "motherland" Turkey—

where they took refuge after so much suffering and pain—to his capable leadership. My mother had been more influenced by her father Halit Bey, who held positivist views, than by her devoutly religious mother Nazire Hanım. Her religious sentiments were not at all strong. I remember that shortly before she passed away, she asked, “Şahin, I wonder, do heaven and hell really exist?”

Despite having grown up in a Mevlevi family, religious beliefs played virtually no role in my father Ahmet Bey’s life either. Among my mother’s relatives, I knew no one who was devout. Among my father’s relatives, however, there were religious people. Aunt Üftade, whose officer husband was martyred in Shkodër during the First World War, prayed five times a day but only covered her head. Dudu Bengi Hala, a distant relative of my father who lived alone in Bursa, occasionally visited us in Ayvalık, and never married, was the sole “devoutly religious” person in the family—she fulfilled all the obligations of Islam and covered herself from head to toe. The relatively devout member of our nuclear family was my eldest sister Sumru, who never neglected fasting during Ramadan until her final years and whom I occasionally witnessed praying.

In short, I grew up in an entirely secular family, far removed from conservatism, and quite “modern” by Turkish standards. I received no religious education. During the 1955–60 period when I attended middle school, religious instruction was elective, not compulsory. My mother readily agreed to my request to be exempted from religion class. Her secularism did not, however, prevent her from placing a miniature Quran in the inner pocket of my jacket, in the belief that it would help me succeed in exams. The family environment must have played a significant role in shaping my views on religion during my youth. In my mature years, I would come to see having received no religious education in a society where religion plays such an important role as a significant deficiency. My consolation on this score was that some of my devout friends nonetheless attributed to me the moral qualities one would expect to find in a religious person.

I cannot say that either my father or my mother were conscious Kemalists in the sense of being wholly committed to Kemalist ideology, to authoritarian secularism and identity politics, but both admired Atatürk. They were Kemalist in the sense of seeing women and men as having equal rights and of respecting education, science, and differences in religious belief. As I mentioned above, I believe they felt they owed their finding peace and security to the Turkish Republic founded under Atatürk’s leadership. Perhaps the fact that Atatürk, like them, was a child of Rumelia also played a part in their devotion to him. Despite their families having been subject to the compulsory exchange, neither my mother nor my father instilled in us children any form of hostility toward Greeks or foreigners. What my mother said about the exchange was this: “It was a time of war. In war, both sides committed great crimes against each other. But the war ended, and the enmities were left behind…”

The Turkish-Greek peace that began in 1930 and would last until 1955 may have played a role in her acquiring this understanding. In the 1930s, until the island fell under Nazi occupation, mutual friendship visits took place between the notables of Ayvalık and Midilli. Unlike in Crete, there had been no conflict or war between Greeks and Turks,

between Orthodox and Muslims, in Midilli. I had heard from elderly “Islanders” that when the Turks migrated from Midilli to Ayvalık, they were seen off in tears by their Greek neighbors; and that they were able to take their movable possessions, right down to their flocks of sheep, across the water.

My late mother held a worldview that could be described as far from nationalism, cosmopolitan and humanist. Her influence was in that direction. It was she who instilled in me the awareness that people are of equal worth regardless of their nation, religion, or language. I can say that her influence was decisive—even before the schools I would attend—in my developing from childhood onward a mentality open to the world and to different nations and cultures. I believe that the policies of Kemalist Turkey to turn a new page and consign the past to oblivion played a role in the fact that I never heard from either my mother or my father any narrative about the suffering and traumas experienced by their families when they were exiled from their homelands. Not having probed their memories on these subjects has been one of my greatest regrets.

My eldest sister Sumru, who passed away in 2011 at the age of 83, also played a very great part in my upbringing. I can say she was a half-mother to me. When, in 1950, she married my much-loved late brother-in-law Özbek Cömert (1925–2010), the son of Ali Cömert, one of Ayvalık’s leading businessmen, I apparently wanted to go with her. My second-eldest sister Olcay (Karacan), with the love and affection she showed me throughout her life, became one of the people closest to me in life. My late elder brother Acar Alpay was my role model. From how to shave to how to cut one’s nails, how to wash one’s hands, how to tie a necktie—I learned many things from him. With his rich library and his passion for literature, he was the one who instilled in me a love of reading. He showed me great love; he approached me as a guardian and protector. He must also have spoiled me somewhat, because as a child I enjoyed provoking him and going against him. Perhaps the most important example of this is that despite his being a fervent Fenerbahçe supporter, I became a Beşiktaş supporter from the year I started primary school, influenced by a relative. Even this my brother took in good grace. I will recount in detail the great role he played in my fate and my life later on. In short, my siblings and I were always bound to one another with great love and solidarity. My late mother’s sheltering our divided family under her wing, and the strong love and solidarity that developed among us as siblings, laid the foundations for the deep attachment I feel to my family.

Had my parents not divorced when I was only six, had my father been able to sustain his initially successful business career, I too might have had a “normal” life—one that would not have strayed beyond the framework drawn by the established order, like that of most of my school friends. Growing up in a divided family directed me and all my siblings toward marrying young and founding families of our own. Having grown up virtually fatherless may have played a role in my gravitating toward unconventional views and choices, toward knowledge rather than money as a source of power, and toward the search for an alternative social order. The fact that, while holding views that could generally be described as Kemalist (statist-nationalist) under my family’s influence until middle school, I then moved toward socialism and eventually its totalitarian varieties from high school onward, may also be related to this. Growing up in a fractured family

whose financial situation was rapidly deteriorating may have engendered in me, on the one hand, a distinct sense of self-confidence and the ability to stand on my own feet, and on the other, a feeling of exclusion from society. My tendency to avoid being at the very forefront in almost every milieu I found myself in, preferring instead the position of the important figure in the background—the “éminence grise”—may also be related to this.

My Hometown Ayvalık

Ayvalık, where I spent the greater part of my childhood and nearly all my summer holidays, is an exceptional place not only for its lace-like coves, its islands, its magnificent beaches, and its paradisiacal natural setting where olive and pine forests intertwine, but also for its architecture, which reflects its character as a prosperous Greek city based on agriculture and trade in the 19th century. Ayvalık, or Kidonia in Greek, was a quite wealthy settlement during the Ottoman period when it was inhabited almost entirely by Greeks. This character was in significant measure related to its having an autonomous structure during the period from 1773 to 1821, when the Greek independence movement triumphed. As one of the trade centers between the Anatolian hinterland and European countries, it bore the identity of one of the Ottoman Empire’s gateways to the West. Indeed, nearly all the major Western powers maintained a consulate here. Until the religion-based compulsory population exchange between Turkey and Greece under the 1923 Treaty of Lausanne, only Greek Orthodox Ottoman citizens lived here, apart from state officials and gendarmes.

Perhaps the best descriptions of what Greek Ayvalık was like before the exchange are the vivid portrayals in the memoir titled “Anatolia and Syria a Century Ago” by Dr. Şerafeddin Mağmumi. The articles of the modern Greek historian, (my late friend) Oxford University history professor Richard Clogg, are perhaps the most important witnesses to late-19th-century, pre-exchange Ayvalık. The books of my late friend Ahmet Yorulmaz are indispensable reading on life in post-exchange Ayvalık.

With the exchange, all of Ayvalık’s Greeks were subjected to compulsory migration to various parts of Greece, primarily Midilli; in their place, Turkish-Muslims from three main regions were settled. The largest group were those of Midilli origin; the second largest were Cretan exchangees, settled primarily on Cunda Island. The third group, considerably smaller than the others, consisted of those who, like my father, came from Greek Macedonia—mainly the Serres, Drama, and Kavala regions. Ayvalık in the 1920s and 1930s was, one could say, the embodiment of the modern, European Turkey that the Kemalists envisioned. A few families whose origins traced to freed black slaves in Midilli, one or two families of Dobruja-Romanian origin, and a small number of Kurdish families driven from the East, some of whom began fishing in Cunda, completed post-exchange Ayvalık society.

After the Second World War, Bosnians fleeing Tito’s communism in Yugoslavia were settled in Küçükköy, just near Sarımsak Beach. Ayvalık, where I spent a significant part of my childhood and youth, thus had a cosmopolitan character, composed of immigrants from very different regions of the dissolving empire, all of them Muslim. Over time, these

immigrant groups intermarried and merged. Although Ayvalık gradually lost its character as a city of exchangees with the internal migrations that began in the 1970s, it continues to be a city of immigrants. (It is known that of today's population of around 70,000, only 5,000 were born in Ayvalık.)

The years I spent entirely in Ayvalık can be counted on one hand. When I was only three or four, my family moved to Istanbul, partly for my father's treatment and partly to ensure the children could attend school there, and began spending winters there. Only the 1953–54 school year, when I attended third grade of primary school, did I spend entirely in Ayvalık. For me, Ayvalık was my hometown where I spent summer holidays at our summer house in Çamlık throughout my childhood; after marrying Fatma, it became our shared homeland as well. I always felt I essentially belonged there.

The Ayvalık that began to take hold in my consciousness was, in those years, a city where Greeks no longer lived but which was, in its entire architectural fabric, still a Greek city. The magnificent buildings left by the Greeks, including the monastery in the Çamlık square, which would be demolished in the 1950s and 1960s, were still standing. With the city's historic structures being placed under the protection of the Monuments Board in the 1970s, the city's historical character was preserved to a degree. With its cosmopolitan social milieu formed by immigrants from different cultures, its natural setting of unparalleled beauty composed of lace-like coastlines and islands intertwined with the Aegean, and its urban environment based on the distinguished Greek architecture of the 19th century, Ayvalık profoundly influenced both my intellectual and my spiritual world. I believe that not only the values instilled in me by my family and the schools I attended, but also Ayvalık's community and environment nurtured in me the idea—which would take root from my youth onward—that people of all nations and religions deserve equal respect and that all of humanity constitutes a single community.

Çamlık

Ayvalık, in yet another respect, gave rise to my resentment of a class-based society. In the years I grew up, the general picture of social stratification in the town was as follows: most of the olive-owning proprietors lived in Çamlık, most of the middle class including civil servants lived in Sefa or Orta Çamlık, and those who lived by their labor lived mostly in the town center. The Çamlık neighborhood where my family lived was the settlement of the Ayvalık bourgeoisie, primarily those engaged in olive cultivation, olive oil and soap production and trade. The people of Çamlık were, in their dress, values, and behavior, a quite European community. They had as secular a culture as was possible in the Turkey of those days; religion did not play an important role in their lives.

In Ayvalık, which until the 1950s was one of Turkey's wealthiest and highest tax-paying districts, many of the Çamlık families (including mine) had one foot in Istanbul or İzmir; they spent part of the year there and had their children schooled there. Most lived in houses left by the Greeks and employed servants, usually of village origin. Many families had young girls from impoverished villages who had been entrusted to the wealthy out of desperation and put to work as domestic servants. From the 1960s onward, as the production of alternative cooking oils—sunflower oil foremost among

them—became widespread, Ayvalık's wealth and with it the general prosperity of the Çamlık families would go into decline. There is no doubt that the reactions stirred in me by Ayvalık's marked class differences played an important role in my embracing socialist ideas at university age.

I should open a parenthesis here and touch upon the story of Cemile—which could be the subject of a novel in its own right—a nine- or ten-year-old girl whom a woman from one of the impoverished mountain villages of Balıkesir brought and entrusted to my mother in the late 1950s. To her credit, my mother looked after Cemile well; she hired a tutor to teach her to read and write, provided for her every need, raised her as a complete urbanite, but at the same time also had her running every errand. Cemile was as good-natured as she was dignified. In her youth she had a love affair with a young man from the Çamlık upper class, but as might be expected, she was abandoned. My mother was planning to marry her off to a well-mannered young man who worked as an apprentice at the pharmacy of her in-law Osman Bey in Istanbul. Cemile would not agree. Presumably sometime in the late 1960s, Cemile, by then in every respect a complete city dweller, said, "I want to return to my village," and when she insisted, word was sent; her mother came and took Cemile back to her village. In time we would learn that she had married and had children.

Years later, on a summer day in the early 1980s, Cemile turned up with her children. From head to toe—in her dress, her speech, her manner—she had become a villager again, had returned to her origins. That she said she had made a great mistake in returning to the village, that she regretted it, was perhaps the saddest aspect of her story. My mother said she could stay and not go back to the village if she wished, but Cemile said, "I have a husband, children—it is no longer possible…" She was right. She left and was never seen again. As one of the most unsettling events of my life, it has never lost its place in my memory. On one occasion, I had (shamelessly) struck Cemile because I caught her smoking. Even though she forgave me, the guilt I felt left a mark on my soul. Cemile was only one of the village girls given to Çamlık families as "besleme"—girls raised in the household as unpaid servants. They must have been among the factors that prepared the resentment I would feel toward a class-based society.

Ayvalık, with its natural beauty, its architecture, and its social fabric, is an exceptional place that can give the impression of being somewhere outside Turkey. As with most people from Ayvalık, it has lodged itself in my very being. I always wanted to go to Ayvalık at the first opportunity. In the years I was forced to stay away, I ached for it. Going to Ayvalık filled me with joy, leaving filled me with sadness. It was a peerless place to experience childhood. Çamlık was for me a place as safe as the womb. There, we lived in a house (now number 179) originally belonging to Greeks but later expanded. With the neighborhood boys—foremost Yusuf (Kaptan), two years older than me, and Azmi (Heper), a year younger and a distant relative—we played cowboys, soldiers, pilots, truck drivers, and so on in the wooded area behind our houses. With the neighborhood girls, especially Fatma and Emine (Kaptan), we played house, doctor, telephone, and so on. Swimming several times a day from the piers in front of our houses; fishing for hours under the blazing sun with rods made of reed and nylon line;

sitting on the piers and greeting the long-nosed Austin municipal bus that came twice a day from Ayvalık along the dusty road with the refrain we had composed beginning “The blue bead is coming…”—these were the aspects of my exceptionally happy childhood that overshadowed every adversity.

Nilüfer Hatun Primary School

My family had moved to Istanbul in the mid-1940s, when I was, I believe, only three years old, partly to ensure the children attended school there and partly so that my father could receive the treatment he needed. We lived in a large rented house on Operatör Raif Bey Sokak in Şişli. I am surprised that I remember the interior partitions of this house, the décor of the rooms, the corridor where I rode a tricycle, the garden where my brother, six years my senior, got up to mischief with his friends, and that I have some vivid memories relating to the neighbors. For we left that house in 1948, when I was only four, and moved to a rented apartment on the third floor of the Umur building on Hüsrev Gerede Caddesi in Teşvikiye. In 1949, my mother enrolled me in a nearby nursery, but gave up on sending me when I reacted with great protest. In the 1950–51 school year, I was enrolled at Nilüfer Hatun Primary School (formerly “Primary School No. 15”) on Şakayık Sokak in Nişantaşı.

My teacher at this school was (may she rest in peace) Müveddet Hanım, who took us from the first grade and graduated us in the fifth. (I do not remember her surname.) She must have been about 60 at the time, but she was a simply magnificent teacher because she managed to keep a class of 80 students under control and succeeded in teaching reading, writing, and arithmetic while also instilling a certain discipline. She was the first teacher to encourage me to study, to read and learn, to be a good student. The most important piece of advice she gave me, which would never leave my mind for the rest of my life, was this: “Remember, children, you are first and foremost human beings, then Turks, then Muslims…” These words of hers were, I believe, a summary of the official identity policy that Turkey began pursuing in the 1950s upon joining the Western alliance, based on the core idea that “We are not Central Asians but Anatolians; we are the heirs of all civilizations that have passed through Anatolia…” It was a succinct expression of the policy implemented during the phase that Etienne Capeaux, in his book examining the evolution of Turkey’s identity policies, aptly titled “From the Turkish History Thesis to the Turkish-Islamic Synthesis,” described as the “humanist” phase.

My first acquaintance with the press, in which I would spend many long years, came in 1950, when I started primary school and learned to read. I remember following with great interest the news in the Hürriyet newspaper, which had just begun publication that year and was being delivered to our home, about the Turkish soldiers going to fight in Korea. I can say that my interest in events at home and in the world began in those days. In the summer when I finished second grade, we were forced to vacate the apartment in the Umur building, I believe at the landlord’s request.

Fatma enters the stage

I spent the 1952–53 school year in Ayvalık, staying with my eldest sister Sumru, who had married two years earlier and had begun living with her husband and small children in the expanded family house in Çamlık, and attended the Cumhuriyet Primary School. In those years the Cumhuriyet Primary School was housed in a building of magnificent architecture that greatly impressed me, one that had housed a college during the Greek era. Consisting of a courtyard with a small pool in the center and classrooms opening onto the courtyard, the building, like many other splendid buildings left by the Greeks, was demolished by the municipality in the late 1950s (for reasons I can perhaps only describe as vandalism). Today in its place stands a school building constructed in the Black Sea architectural style with a concrete courtyard. Because it holds precious memories of my childhood, its present state strikes me as very sad.

The beginnings of my interest in my childhood playmate, the neighbor girl Fatma—with whom I played house during summer holidays in Çamlık—date back to the 1953–54 school year, when we attended third grade together at Cumhuriyet Primary School. We were only nine or ten years old. There was something that excited me about this slender, fair-skinned, rosy-cheeked, blonde girl with greenish hazel eyes. I would sulk at her, then find a way to make up. Six or seven years had to pass before I became conscious that I was in love with her and dared to declare my love. In the summer of 1960, when I had just finished middle school, while swimming from the pier in front of the Kaptans' house —two houses down from ours—in Çamlık, as we always did, one day the other children had gone and Fatma and I were left alone. I was in the three-sided enclosed "cabin" at the end of the pier; she was in the sea. I summoned all my courage and said, "Fatma, I think I'm falling in love with you…" She was not expecting it at all… She was very surprised and could only manage, "That's just how it seems to you…" And I said, "Yes, it definitely seems that way to me!.."

We were both sixteen. At the time, Fatma was seeing a young man from the same neighborhood, two or three years older than us. She was therefore quite bothered by my beginning to pursue her. Despite her wounding my pride many times, I could not give her up. Perhaps one reason I could not escape her allure, besides her beauty, was her personality, which had begun to manifest itself as early as primary school. This personality was reflected in the composition she wrote on April 20, 1956, when she was in the fifth grade, on the topic "What do you want from your parents?" In the composition, which I discovered about ten years ago among papers kept in our house in Çamlık, she had written the following: "1) I want there to be no fighting at home. 2) I want them to give me the right to speak at home. 3) I want them not to beat me. 4) I want them to allow me to spend money. 5) I want them to tell me what is going on at home. 6) On my holidays, I want to go to the places I like and play. 7) I want them to love me. 8) I want them not to embarrass me in front of my elders and juniors. 9) I want my mother and father to be kind-hearted and cheerful. 10) I very much want them to send me to college. Grade: 5, Age: 11, Written by: Fatma Kaptan, Address: Gümrük Caddesi, Balıkhane Sokak, No. 5, Ayvalık."

Our classroom teacher at Cumhuriyet Primary School, Muhsine Hanım (a close friend of Leman Kaptan, who would later become my mother-in-law), was a kind-hearted, likable person and a teacher of very gentle character. The most important event of that year for me was being in the same class as Fatma. Fatma and her cousin Emine (Kaptan) were my girl classmates. That year I also made two close male friends, both now deceased. Osman, the son of Enver Örnek, who ran a guesthouse and restaurant in Çamlık, and I got into a great deal of mischief together. Osman was a very smart boy. After finishing Galatasaray Lycée he spent a few years in Belgium but was unable to continue his studies. When the Çamlık girl he was in love with left him, the brilliant future expected of him never materialized. For many years he worked at the reception of İzmir's most famous hotel. In later life he married a girl much younger than himself; they had a daughter. He drank rakı and smoked heavily. He developed lung cancer at only around 60 and passed away.

My other friend, Dinçer (Görç), belonged to one of a handful of black-skinned families of Midilli origin in Ayvalık. The ancestors of these families had been sold as slaves from Africa to Midilli, then converted to Islam and freed by their owners. Dinçer, who had a slight stutter, was the son of "Arap" ("the Arab") Bayram—a huge man who hated talking and was famous for his drunkenness, a truck driver who worked for my brother-in-law Özbek. Dinçer's importance to me was that, until university, he was my first friend from the lower classes and the only friend of a different race. Because I was close friends with Dinçer, in the face of Ayvalık's sharp class differences and the division between "those above" and "those below," I felt almost privileged, different from everyone else. He had become my confidant. I could easily share with him thoughts and feelings I could not share with others. In later years Dinçer attended the technical high school in Ayvalık, became a skilled lathe operator, and emigrated to Germany. He returned a few years later and worked at the shipyards in Maltepe, Istanbul. He married a white girl. A few years after retiring and settling in Cunda in the 1990s, he fell ill and died.

Nişantaşı, Gaye Apartment

In 1954, when my mother purchased an apartment at No. 34 Valikonağı Caddesi in Nişantaşı, Istanbul—in the Gaye Apartment building—I returned for the fourth grade to Nilüfer Hatun Primary School and to Teacher Müveddet. Teacher Müveddet was pleased that the student in whom she saw promise had come back. She frequently held me up as an example to the class. Her encouragement played a great role in my developing the habit of studying and, above all, a curiosity for learning. May she rest in peace. My closest friend in the class was Hamit (Dalkılıç), the son of a military officer. I remember that during nearly every recess, Hamit and I would pace the school garden, conversing with a show of expertise about the news we had read in the papers. We were conscious that we were far ahead of the rest of the class in our knowledge of Turkey and the world.

Many years later, in the early 1990s, I looked up Hamit, a friend who had left a mark on me, and found him through the telephone directory. He had studied at Istanbul University; he was working somewhere as a civil servant. He was perhaps dejected at not having achieved the career he had hoped for. When I called to meet again, his telling me that "we have walked very different paths and can no longer be friends" both greatly

surprised and saddened me. I never saw him again, but as my first close intellectual friend, he never left my mind.

In the 1950s, Nişantaşı was a far more multicultural, cosmopolitan neighborhood than it is today. The Greeks had not yet left, nor the Jews, nor the remaining Armenians.

In the six-story Gaye apartment building at the intersection where Valikonağı and Rumeli Avenues meet, besides us there lived another Turkish and Muslim family (the Ferhatoğlu family from Edremit), an Armenian family ("Monsieur Garbis"), and a Jewish family ("Monsieur Jak"). We had very good neighborly relations with all of them. Our Armenian doorman Aram Efendi lived in the basement with his adult daughter Stella. The delicatessen at the front of the basement (which became Konak Pastanesi after the 1960s) was run by "Yorgo Efendi," a Greek. The taste of the tongue-and-pickle sandwiches my brother and I bought from him is still on my palate. The image of the Greek delicatessen seller who set up his counter in the doorway of the apartment building across from ours on winter evenings, selling cured bonito, has also lodged itself in my memory.

When I returned to Istanbul at the end of September from Ayvalık, where I had gone for summer vacation in June 1955 after finishing primary school, I would learn what had happened in Istanbul on September 6–7. From that date on, our non-Muslim neighbors would leave the apartment building one by one. I was filled with mixed feelings. I was caught between the nationalist sentiments instilled by school, newspapers, and the radio on the one hand, and the humane values imparted by my family and close circle on the other. I was aware that what had happened was related to the Cyprus question. I had listened to radio reports about demonstrations where the cry of "Either partition or death!" was raised. I recall that what took place in the year I turned twelve stirred in me an indescribable unease. I can say that the September 6–7 events—which went down in history as the assaults and looting targeting non-Muslims by crowds whipped into a frenzy by nationalist provocations and handed clubs—were the first event to awaken in me the thought that something was wrong in Turkey. Years later, I would learn from the statements of retired General Sabri Yirmibeşoğlu, head of the Special Warfare Department, that the savagery of September 6–7 had been carried out through a "magnificent organization" spearheaded by the state itself.

English High School for Boys

It was time for middle school. My mother, who herself had only been able to attend primary school and had always seen her highly educated father as a role model, placed great importance on her children receiving a good education and learning foreign languages; she had begun having me take English lessons in the fifth grade of primary school. Perhaps partly encouraged by this, I wanted to attend the English High School for Boys (hereafter EHSB), which was just a few streets away, and learn good English. Due to increasing demand, EHSB had in recent years begun admitting students by examination. My mother must not have been very confident I could pass the exam, for she would say, "If you can pass, wonderful… Otherwise I'll enroll you in Şişli Terakki…" I passed the exam with a middling score among the 35 students admitted that year and

was overjoyed. From 1955 to 1960, I studied there for a total of five years—two years in the (English) preparatory program and three years in middle school.

EHSB was an exceptional school, one of the finest secondary education institutions in Turkey in those years. In the preparatory classes, we received intensive English instruction from British (English, Scottish, or Welsh) teachers. The science courses were also taught in English, again mostly by British teachers. Courses in the social subjects were taught in Turkish by distinguished Turkish teachers. The school's headmaster was English, his deputy Turkish. Classes of 30–35 students made it possible for teachers to engage more closely with their pupils. I need not elaborate on what learning English—a language that over the course of the twentieth century became the world's lingua franca—gave me. Knowing proper English is a privilege even today; in my youth, it was all the more so.

I can say that thanks to learning good English, my frame of reference transcended Turkey's borders; I entered the world's sphere of influence. There is no doubt that this had a profound effect on my intellectual development and, consequently, on my destiny and life story. EHSB's contribution to opening me up to the world was not limited to the English I learned. There I came to know teachers and students from foreign nations; I had many friends from minority communities. Nişantaşı's multicultural, cosmopolitan atmosphere was experienced even more intensely at school. The foundations of my belief—one that would grow stronger over time—that all people are of equal worth regardless of language, religion, or race were laid here.

I can say that I acquired the skills of expressing myself by speaking before audiences and communicating easily with others by taking roles large and small in the plays staged by EHSB's theater club (the Dramatic Society), starting from the preparatory years. I played the lead role (Shylock) in Shakespeare's *The Merchant of Venice*. In our graduation year, I performed in Bernard Shaw's *Androcles and the Lion*. I remember being very happy when the English teacher who wrote a review of the play for that year's school yearbook wrote, "And particular mention must be made of Alpay's speech which was to my mind the best in the play…" The inclusion in the school's 1960 yearbook of a poem I adapted from Shakespeare's *As You Like It*—a tribute to our teachers that could be described as a panegyric, titled "As We Like Them"—had also made me quite proud.

At EHSB we received a very good education not only in terms of coursework but also in standards of conduct. The school had an educational philosophy that encouraged competition among students in every area. The report card we received at the end of each term was in the form of a large booklet. Grades were given out of a hundred, and according to the average, each student's class ranking for that term was recorded. The school's policy of encouraging competition played a major role in my rise from the bottom ranks in the preparatory years to the top ranks in middle school. Although I took not the slightest pleasure in mathematics or the sciences, by studying hard (by "memorizing" or "cramming") I managed to earn high marks even in those subjects, and thereby succeeded in winning the favor of our mathematics teacher Isaac De Leon—

may he rest in peace. Unfortunately, however, I was unable to catch the attention of our physics teacher Clifford Ellison, who would later also be my teacher at Robert Academy.

In the social subjects, from the first year of middle school onward, I was among the most successful students in the class. The encouragement of our teachers—all of them now departed—above all our English teachers Robert T. Shade and Godfrey Goodwin, our geography teacher İsfendiyar Erkut, our history teacher Muazzez Yazgaç, and our Turkish teacher Tahir Alangu, was a tremendous source of motivation. The Scotsman Mr. Shade and İsfendiyar Bey, with their seriousness and the authority they commanded, became role models for me. I can say that the competitive drive instilled at EHSB left a mark on me that would last my entire life.

Another important dimension of education at EHSB was athletic activities. Because I had grown up by the sea in Ayvalık, I was a good swimmer. But I had no particular talent in any of the other sports I played. Athletic activities, especially football, created a great atmosphere of fun and competition and reinforced attachment to the school. For five years, every Wednesday afternoon and every Saturday morning, we were bused to the large sports grounds on the Hill of Eternal Liberty (over which the E-5 highway now passes). As members of one of four teams to which we were automatically assigned on the day we enrolled, we carried on a fierce competition for five years. As right-back Alpay of the red-and-white Charnwood House football team (left-back was Tayfur Altay, who remained a close friend), I tried to play as well as I could but never rose above mediocre. (However, as I will relate later, the football I learned at EHSB would be enough to make me one of the two star players of the school team at the Webb School of California, where I would go on an AFS scholarship in the 1961–62 academic year, alongside the Filipino Carlos Perez-Rubio.)

I made some of my closest friends at EHSB. Foremost among them was certainly Ömer Madra, who enrolled in the school a year after me and was also a distant relative on my mother's side. In the pages ahead, you will read about the striking parallels between our life stories, brought about by a friendship that deepened not only at school but during the summer holidays we spent together in Ayvalık, the place of our origins. I should relay some of my memories of Ömer from the middle school years: With our tremendous curiosity about Western pop music, we would press our ears to the radio and compete over who heard a newly released song first; playing disc jockey, we would record pop music programs onto my brother-in-law Özbek's hulking but in those years exceedingly rare tape recorder in Ayvalık.

We went to a dance class in Beyoğlu to learn to dance. Our instructors were the couple Gönül and Erdoğan. Since it was mostly Erdoğan Bey who worked with us, we would laugh a great deal at the sight we presented while partnering him in dances ranging from the slow and swing to the cha-cha and waltz. At the time, we were both smitten with Ömer's neighbor girl in Nişantaşı, Gülsün (Kamu). I had also quite fancied Nazlı (Ilıcak), a family friend's daughter to whom Ömer introduced me. (Perhaps sixty years later, when I revealed this secret to her, Ilıcak would say with a mischievous expression, "Darn! If only I'd known…")

The epitome of EHSB students' cosmopolitan character was our classmate Godfrey Scotchbrook. Godfrey had a very interesting story. His father, an officer, had been posted at Britain's military attaché office in Istanbul during the Second World War. While staying at a guesthouse run by a Greek lady, he had fallen in love with the young daughter of the house and married her. Shortly after the birth of Godfrey, the product of this marriage, the war ended and his father was recalled to London. Major Scotchbrook, after purchasing tickets for the ship that would carry his wife, son, and mother-in-law to Britain, set off for London on a military aircraft and tragically lost his life when the plane crashed. Godfrey grew up without a father and was educated partly in Istanbul (at EHSB) and mostly at schools in England. Now the owner of a very successful consulting firm in Hong Kong, Godfrey never lost his interest in Turkey. Since we decided, years after graduation, to revive our relationships as EHSB classmates, we get together every time he comes to Istanbul. (Godfrey has promised to tell me his life story.)

The closest among my classmates was Metin (Kılıçlı). (I will return to the interesting story of our friendship in due course.) I recall that in the conversations Metin, Salamon (later Selim Razon), and I had during our lunchtime walks from the school to Maçka Taşlık, political topics also came up, though my interest in politics was still very limited. Until the student demonstrations of April 1960, I had no negative attitude toward the ruling Democrat Party (DP). Tayfur Altay, Mehmet Atakan, Nedim Demirelli with whom I shared a passion for pop music, Ahmet Kutman (with whom I would later make the AFS journey to the United States), Yavuz Sökmen, Mehmet Soyarslan—the only classmate who like me was a Beşiktaş supporter—the late Ümit Tolun who like me was from Ayvalık, Şefik Yüksel whose path would cross mine on various occasions throughout life, Vahit Çelikbaş, Marcel Erdal, Alp Pekuz, Mehmet Önkal, and of course Godfrey Scotchbrook—all became friends with whom I have kept up ties despite the passage of so many years. Fifty-three years later, in 2013, we came together with these friends and even prepared a yearbook commemorating our school memories. This much is certain: among all my schools, EHSB was the one to which I felt the greatest attachment.

Among the publicly recognized figures I came to know during the EHSB years and with whom I maintained a friendship, I can name from the upper classes Ergun Göknel, Rıza Türmen, Faruk Birtek, Osman Ulagay, Ahmet Yücekök, Murat Belge, Niyazi Dalyancı, and Müfit Özdeş; and from the lower classes Celal Üster (my maternal uncle's grandson), the late ambassador Nabi Şensoy, Reha Uz, and Mehmet Arda. Nearly all of them went on to distinguish themselves in their careers. My EHSB friends bestowed on me a nickname that stuck even after I transferred to Robert Academy: "Dayı" (Uncle). This nickname was inspired by the fact that I was among those in our class whose voice deepened earliest and who grew tall earliest (only to level off quickly afterward), and by my habit of standing up to students in the upper classes—that is, my "dayılanma." I may well have acquired the habit of challenging authority when necessary in those years.

A Turning Point: 1960

My last year at EHSB, the 1959–60 academic year, became one of the turning points in my life. My elder sister Olcay had married Ünal Karacan, a civil engineer and graduate of Saint Joseph and then İTÜ, in 1958 and moved to Germany. My brother Acar, who

had been studying at Istanbul University's Faculty of Law while also managing the pharmacy run by his future father-in-law Osman Çokay in Nişantaşı, had also left home. My mother, whose financial situation had been deteriorating as her income dwindled steadily after her divorce from my father, decided in the early months of 1960 to rent out the Nişantaşı apartment and move to Ayvalık, to be near my sister Sumru. As a result, I spent the remainder of that year living with my maternal aunt Şefika and her husband Hamit (İpekel) in 2nd Levent.

The İpekels were avid readers of the newspaper *Cumhuriyet*, subscribers to *Akis* magazine, and staunch supporters of the CHP. While staying with them, I too began reading *Cumhuriyet* and *Akis*. By spring, relations between Prime Minister Adnan Menderes's Democrat Party (DP) and İsmet İnönü's opposition Republican People's Party (CHP) were growing increasingly tense, and the country was experiencing a deep political polarization. Every evening, the state radio would read out the long lists of those joining the Fatherland Front, spearheaded by the DP.

Then, on April 28–29, large-scale demonstrations by university students against the government took place in Istanbul and Ankara. We followed the news about these demonstrations—in which my brother also took part—with great excitement. Rumors had spread, later revealed to be fabricated, that the police had killed some of the demonstrating students and ground them into mincemeat. My aunt's anger toward the DP government was growing by the day. On the morning of May 27, 1960, I was preparing to go to school for the graduation ceremony when we learned from the radio that the army had seized power and a curfew had been declared. I remember feeling deeply disappointed that the graduation ceremony could not take place. I would later learn that I had graduated third in my class.

The coup of May 27, 1960, was the first of the military interventions my generation would witness. My relatives in Istanbul, above all the İpekels and my brother, had greeted the coup with joy. In their view, the army had said "enough" to the increasingly authoritarian, dictatorial DP government. As far as I remember, I too was mostly under their influence. The news coming from the Ayvalık branch of the family, however, was bad. Ali Cömert, my sister Sumru's father-in-law, was the region's most prominent businessman. He had extensive olive groves; factories processing olive oil, soap, and cotton (ginning); and a large farm where various crops were cultivated. He was like the Ayvalık branch of the DP government. Banks competed to extend him credit. President Celal Bayar, when he visited Ayvalık, had been hosted at his seaside mansion.

Though he was somewhat overbearing toward those who worked for him, he was a man I found quite endearing with his large build, paternal manner, and "islander" (Lesbos) accent. The fun days we spent with the other children of the family during summer holidays on his farm in Altınova, full of fruit trees, hold an unforgettable place among my childhood memories. Witnessing "Uncle Ali Bey's" eyes fill with tears as he gazed at the lights of his homeland Lesbos from the balcony of the farmhouse at night had given me much to think about.

The May 27 intervention paved the way for Ali Cömert's bankruptcy. The military government imposed price controls on olive oil; banks cut off credit and demanded

immediate repayment of debts. As if this were not enough, when his two barges carrying tons of olive oil to the Oil Wharf at Eminönü in Istanbul sank in the Sea of Marmara, the Cömert firm was first forced to seek a composition with creditors and ultimately went bankrupt. Ali Cömert lost his entire fortune. The considerable number of olive trees my sister Sumru had inherited from her father were also sold by the bankruptcy estate, since they had been mortgaged against the loans taken out by her father-in-law. In short, May 27 had brought ruin upon the family of my eldest sister, to whom I was deeply attached. My beloved brother-in-law Özbek, a graduate of Galatasaray High School and the Istanbul Faculty of Economics, not only lost his position as heir to what was perhaps Ayvalık's wealthiest family but was tried on charges of fraudulent bankruptcy brought by creditor relatives and sentenced to two years in prison. After his release, he would make a living as an accounting manager at his uncle's company.

In my final year at EHSB, it became clear that the school's high school science section would be closed. Most of my classmates thereupon decided to continue at Robert Academy in Bebek. Although I had not the slightest interest in science courses and all my attention was focused on the social subjects and literature, I decided to take Robert Academy's entrance examination, partly out of a desire to follow my close friends and, more importantly, because we no longer had a home in Istanbul and I needed to attend a boarding school. That year, for the first time in Robert Academy's history, students were admitted through an examination that even its own middle school graduates were required to take. It caused a stir that those from EHSB, myself included, placed at the top of the entrance exam. And so, from the 1960–61 academic year onward, I became a boarding student at Robert Academy. Great changes in my life awaited me.

At Robert Academy

Robert College, founded in 1863 by American Protestant missionaries, was the oldest American educational institution abroad; it was at that time one of Turkey's most prestigious and influential educational institutions. The institution had a coeducational college (Robert College, RC) in Bebek, a boys' high school (Robert Academy, RA), and a girls' high school in Arnavutköy (American College for Girls, ACG). (In 1971, the college section would be nationalized and become Boğaziçi University, while the high school sections would be merged on the Arnavutköy campus and begin offering coeducational instruction under the name Robert Lisesi.)

Having changed homes and schools quite frequently since childhood, I had little difficulty adapting to the new environment, new friends, and new teachers. I was placed in the dormitory on the top floor of the building then known as Anderson Hall, where some thirty students slept. Boarding was enjoyable in itself. The school's campus was of a beauty rarely matched anywhere in the world. I was no longer among the concrete masses of Nişantaşı but in the midst of extraordinary nature, looking out over the Bosphorus from the hills of Bebek. I was seventeen. With the help of the school's educational approach, which reconciled discipline with freedom, I had begun to feel like an individual. On weekends, I could go down to the city, to the cinema, the theater, or the tavern with friends. Courses were taught by highly qualified foreign and local teachers and demanded a great deal of study. The teacher who appreciated me most

was our Turkish literature teacher, the late Münir Aysu. The school offered opportunities to participate in a wide variety of extracurricular activities. My main interest, however, was theater. I joined the Drama Club (Robert College Players) and took a supporting role (the judge) in Ayn Rand's *The Night of January 16th*, staged that year.

Founded as a Protestant missionary school, Robert College had in the Ottoman period served primarily the empire's non-Muslim subjects. With the Republic, it had transformed into a completely secular educational institution, serving an overwhelmingly Turkish-Muslim student body. Looking back years later, I have thought that the education we received at foreign-founded schools, both EHSB and RA, made us quite privileged in the country but left us considerably deficient in the context of Turkish culture. To give a pointed example, in English literature classes we read passages from the New Testament and the Old Testament, but in Turkish literature classes the Quran was never a subject in any way.

My interest in politics was virtually nonexistent; I was hardly interested in anything beyond literature. The most important event of my first year at RA, from my standpoint, was learning of the existence of an organization called the American Field Service (AFS). AFS offered scholarships to high school students from nearly every part of the world to stay with a host family in the United States and attend their senior year there. (AFS had been founded during the First World War to assist in the evacuation of wounded and dead Americans from the battlefield, and had assumed an entirely new role after the war ended.) I told my mother and my brother of my intention to apply for an AFS scholarship. We decided it would be a good idea for me to apply. My brother and I filled out the application forms together. I sat for the oral selection exam conducted by former AFS scholarship recipients. I was not very hopeful, but I managed to become one of five students from RA to win the AFS scholarship that year. Two of them were close friends who had come from EHSB (Ahmet Kutman and Yavuz Sökmen), and another was the late Mustafa Gürsel, who would in time become one of my closest friends.

As summer approached, it became clear where I would be going: I would attend the Webb School of California, a prestigious private school in the town of Claremont near Los Angeles, and stay with the family of Gordon A. Wilson, the school's dean of students. When I learned that the school was an all-boys boarding school, I was deeply disappointed. The hope of studying at a coeducational school alongside American girls had been one of the things that made the scholarship attractive. I had always attended boys' schools. Apart from Fatma, the girl next door in Çamlık, no girl had truly caught my eye. When I learned that Webb was the most prestigious school on the West Coast of the United States, attended by the children of celebrities, I would find little consolation in that.

Summer of 1961

I passed my first year at RA on the Honor Roll. At the end of June, I went to Ayvalık for a short stay to see my mother, my father, and my sister before the trip to America. There I learned that Ömer (Madra) had also passed the entrance exam and transferred from EHSB to RA, which made me very happy. The great event of the summer of 1961,

however, was that Fatma—the girl I had lost my heart to since primary school and whom I believed to be the most beautiful girl in the world—unexpectedly showed me favor. She had fallen out with the other one and was turning toward me for the first time. My love blazed… I lived the most beautiful days of my life up to that point during that July. Fatma was beauty itself… Sadly, just a month later, at the end of July, I had to set off for the United States. I can say that this was the first of the conflicts between my private and public lives that would persist throughout my lifetime. My heart wanted to stay with Fatma; my mind favored going. I cannot forget the great heartache of parting from Fatma. And yet, it never crossed my mind to give up going. We were very young, and I was very curious about America. But I would not make this mistake again…

CHAPTER II / OPENING UP TO THE WORLD

In the first days of August 1961, we departed Istanbul for New York on a large four-propeller aircraft filled with roughly a hundred male and female students who had won AFS scholarships that year. For the first time, I was going abroad, to spend a year with people I did not know, living on the other side of the world. My soul was filled, on the one hand, with the pain of separation from Fatma, and on the other, with curiosity about the new world. I suppressed some of my anguish by chatting with newly made friends along the way. (It was on that journey that I met my dear friend Güven Nil from the German High School, whom we lost in 2001. I will describe Güven's place in my life later.) The plane made its first refueling stop at Shannon airport in Ireland, and its second at Gander airport in Newfoundland in eastern Canada. At Gander airport, an ultramodern structure for its day, I felt to the marrow of my bones that I was stepping into a world that was entirely new, in every sense, and very different from anything I had known. This feeling would become even more striking when we landed at New York's Idlewild airport (its name before it was renamed JFK in December 1963).

We spent a few days in New York before being sent off to our host families. While trying to explore New York by walking its streets with friends, I felt as if I were being crushed beneath the skyscrapers. When I looked out over the city from the top of the Empire State Building, then the tallest of those skyscrapers, I was seized by a great fear. It was there that I first realized I had a fear of heights. As we wandered the city, we nearly got run over, since until then we had never encountered such a thing as a road where pedestrians were forbidden. The terror of cars hurtling toward us is still in my mind. Finally, AFS officials put Yavuz Sökmen and me on a plane bound for Los Angeles. This would be my first trip on a jet aircraft. I had taken off toward an unknown, exhilarating future. We landed at Los Angeles International Airport as night was falling.

I remember as if it were yesterday the excitement aroused by the boundless lights of Los Angeles spreading across a vast expanse as seen from the plane, and the apprehension of being about to meet the completely foreign people with whom I would soon be staying. Father (Gordon) and mother (Mollie) Wilson met me at the airport. White-haired Father Wilson, who walked with a limp due to childhood polio, showed

great warmth and was trying to help me acclimate to the new environment. He told me that at Webb he served as dean of students and also taught ancient Greek history, classics, and English; that his interest in Turkey stemmed from this; and that he had visited Turkey in the late 1950s. When they applied to AFS to host a foreign student, they had indicated that a Turk would be their preference. His wife Mollie was a homemaker. They had five children—three girls and two boys—and two dogs.

After a brief dinner stop upon leaving the airport, we headed east in the Wilsons' car along the widest roads I had ever seen, approximately 150 kilometers to the town of Big Bear Lake in the San Bernardino Mountains; we reached the summer house located on the shore of the eponymous lake (which had disappeared that year due to severe drought). I stayed there until the Webb School in Claremont opened in September. I met the family's five children: in order, Bettie, eight years my senior; Gordie, five years older; Jackie, three years older; Tom, three years younger; and Barbie, six years younger. Bettie had married Marty and settled in Oakland. Gordie and Jackie no longer lived at home since they were away at university. The family did not have a member my own age, as AFS rules required, who was supposed to help me adjust. Tom attended Webb School and Barbie was in primary school. I knew that Webb was a private boarding school for boys, and that in this respect I would be in a different position from the other Turkish students.

The weeks I spent at Big Bear were quite difficult.

I was experiencing the deep sorrow of being separated from Fatma only a few weeks after winning her love. The Wilsons were doing everything they could to help me adjust. Father Wilson, taking Tom along with us, drove me on a trip lasting more than two weeks that extended all the way to Oregon. I saw San Francisco for the first time then. It was then that I discovered the incredible beauties and national parks of Northern California. There I rode a jet boat racing across a river. In Yosemite Park, I drove through tunnels carved through the trunks of redwood / sequoia trees.

When we returned from the trip, in the time remaining before school opened, Jackie offered to teach me to ski in the mountains; Tom, to teach me to ride the horses tethered in the garden. Jackie and Barbie wanted to take me ice-skating. I accepted none of these very thoughtful offers. I remember saying exactly this: "Thank you so much for thinking of ways to entertain me. But I'm afraid of getting injured. I don't want to take risks. Because this year is very precious to me…" At the Wilsons' summer house in Big Bear Lake, a classical music record collection and a world literature library that struck me as incredibly rich were helping to soothe, if only slightly, the ache that parting from Fatma had carved into my heart.

Letters to Fatma

Fatma and I had only been able to be "sweethearts" for a few weeks in June–July 1961. I missed her desperately, and I was anxious that she might leave me in my absence. Several times a week, I was writing and sending her pages and pages of letters expressing my love and longing. She was responding with answers that grew increasingly infrequent and brief. In one letter she wrote, "It never would have crossed

my mind that I'd call you my sweetheart…" Finally, in a short letter in January 1962 in which she wrote that she would be going to Ayvalık for the holiday, she said, as if preparing the ground for a break, "You'll find someone prettier than me there…" A few weeks later, she stopped writing altogether. I understood that she had gone back to the other one.

I did not keep the letters she sent me; I destroyed them in hurt and anger. I had asked her to do the same. I cannot describe the astonishment and joy I felt when I learned, years later, that my Fatoş had kept all but the first two of the sixteen letters I wrote to her between August 7, 1961, and May 14, 1962… For her having kept them showed that even though she had ended our relationship and returned to the other one, she had preserved me somewhere in her heart—or (at the very least) could not bring herself to destroy my love-filled letters. (And yet in the last letter I sent, I had written in capital letters, "IF YOU NEVER WANT TO SEE MY FACE AGAIN, DISPOSE OF MY LETTERS…") When I began writing my memoirs, I reread these letters with great excitement. The letters not only expressed the great love I felt for Fatma but also reflected my thoughts during that period.

The most obvious conclusion I drew from these letters was that I had probably frightened Fatma with them and perhaps encouraged her to give up on me even if she did not want to… As a fledgling "existentialist," reading Sartre, Camus, Kierkegaard, and so on as best I could, and perhaps partly driven by a desire to seem interesting, I was writing her variations on "the meaninglessness of life": *"I find the world utterly meaningless and living unnecessary… What do you expect from a phony man like me in such a phony world? Am I committing a great crime by tying you to myself?.. You are free! You don't have to wait! Never force yourself! Don't give up on yourself, on your feelings! One is responsible only for oneself!… Perhaps among your suitors there is someone who wants you, needs you more than I do. Perhaps you want them more too. Why should I stand in your way then…"* But then: *"No one can love you the way I do… I'm going crazy for you."*

In these lines there were traces both of my superficial existentialism and of the insecurity I felt, forcing her to make a choice ("either the other one or me"): *"Know this: life with me will not be one of those lives you see lived around you. If you wish to live that way, look to rid yourself of me… I am an unknown person… Which one am I… Should one fear this person… I hate living a balanced life… You can expect any kind of action from me… I know that I am not a normal person…"*

My atheism, which I was discovering and taking pride in at the time, was also reflected in the letters: *"I need you to love me more than to believe in God… I told you from the very first day that I wanted to live my whole life with you…"* In what I wrote, there were also hints of my uncertainties about what I wanted to do and become in the future: *"I don't know which university I'll attend… If I say now that I'll study literature, it's certain to change tomorrow… Maybe I'll be forced to work in some wretched science field."* About the United States: *"I don't want to study here… but I should leave the door open, I'll try to get a scholarship. In that case, either we'll need to get married right away or I don't know what will happen…"* (As I will relate later, I would win a full scholarship to study in

the US but would give it up so as not to be separated from Fatma once again.) And then there were these lines, worth recording: *“In the future, perhaps I’ll write the story of what passed between us; only as a keepsake for my children, of course… I had never thought until now that I would have children; but I suppose they’ll benefit from what I’ve been through.”*

There were also a few lines in the letters about politics in Turkey. Since my connection to the country had been almost entirely severed, I was writing the following about Menderes’s execution (in September 1961), which I had probably learned about from my elder brother’s letters: *“Zorlu and Polatkan don’t matter, but when will we ever see someone like Menderes again… How can you not grieve for the second most important person after Atatürk?.. As for İnönü, I will say this: I take comfort in being part of the generation that will write history. We will deliver his eternal punishment…”* (My view of İnönü would change over time, and I would come to see the positive aspects of his legacy as well.)

Claremont

About a week before the Webb School opened at the start of September, we moved to the Wilsons’ home in Claremont, near the school campus—a spacious, extremely modern, single-story house built a few years earlier, with a large living room, six bedrooms, and four bathrooms. I settled into Jackie’s room. Before school opened, the classrooms needed to be cleaned. Mr. Wilson asked whether I would like to do the job and earn a little money. I gladly accepted; for the first time in my life, I performed physical labor and earned money. Like his own children, I too called Mr. Wilson “Dad.” He treated me well enough to make this feel natural. Mother (“Ma”) Wilson, who was of a reserved nature, perhaps could not show the same degree of closeness, but it was obvious in everything about her that she was a very good person.

When school opened, my introduction to the class went as follows: It was the custom, apparently, for senior students to gather on Sunday evenings, with a different student giving a talk each week. Mr. Wilson told me that because my name came first in alphabetical order, and because this would also be a good occasion to introduce myself to the class, the school administration thought it fitting for me to give the first talk. I agreed. I began my talk by sharing information about my family and my homeland: I was the child of a family from Ayvalık. My father and mother had been settled in Ayvalık under the compulsory population exchange agreement between Turkey and Greece in 1923; they met and married there. My father was born in the Greek city of Serez. My mother was originally from the island of Lesbos, just across from Ayvalık…. The moment I said, “My mother comes from Lesbos; she is a Lesbian…” a terrifying storm of laughter erupted in the classroom. I could not understand what had happened, but without missing a beat, I continued my talk.

When my talk was over, one of my classmates came up to me and introduced himself. A dialogue ensued between us: “Şahin, I don’t think you know what the word ‘lesbian’ means…” / “Doesn’t it mean someone from Lesbos?…” / “In English, with reference to the island’s famous ancient female poet Sappho, it is also used to mean a woman who

loves women…" This amusing incident had two consequences: The ice between me and my classmates, who had jumped to the conclusion that I was a very witty person, melted on the spot… And thus began the friendship, which has lasted to this day, with Tor Krieger, who came over and explained to me what the word "lesbian" meant. Tor became one of my closest friends in life.

I should open a parenthesis here and touch on Tor's interesting story: After Webb, he studied comparative literature at Wesleyan, one of the prestigious universities in the US. He spent his sophomore year at the Sorbonne in Paris. During this time, he developed a passion for philosophy. He was among the founders of the Wesleyan chapter of Students for a Democratic Society (SDS), one of the important student organizations of the New Left movement, which took a critical view of American democracy. After graduation, prompted by his atheist beliefs, he decided to deepen his knowledge of religious matters. With his first wife, whom he married in 1966, he volunteered among Native Americans as part of the Domestic Peace Corps program. (He would go on to marry two more times and live with three more partners, and from these relationships would have two children, a daughter and a son.)

He was admitted to the doctoral programs in divinity at both Columbia and Harvard. In the meantime, he was drafted to be sent to Vietnam. He filed for conscientious objector status to avoid going, but since this right was recognized in the US only for members of religious groups, he had to wage a great legal battle and go into hiding for several months. He joined the Peace and Freedom Party, which opposed the war and fought for fundamental rights. When Columbia and Harvard refused his request to transfer from the divinity to the philosophy doctoral program, in deep indignation he gave up on an academic career. He never lost his interest in literature and philosophy, but he decided to make his living as a carpenter, and so he did. He is one of the most intellectually formidable people I have known in life.

Tor came to Turkey on several occasions to see me. The first time, at the end of the summer of 1966 while he was in France, he drove to Istanbul in his old-model Volkswagen after a rather adventurous journey crossing Europe from one end to the other. He went to Robert Academy, the only address he had; there he learned that I might be in Ayvalık, and by asking around, he found me. We were able to spend a few days together in Ayvalık and Istanbul… Our second meeting came many years later. In 1995, when I happened to be in the US, he came to New York to see me. Later, he came to Istanbul in 2005 and to Ayvalık in 2007; he was our guest for a week or two. Our last meeting took place in Santa Rosa, where I went to visit him in September 2015 and stayed as his guest for a week. We continue our friendship through correspondence.

Returning to Webb: The Wilson family treated me extremely well. Mr. Wilson was a true gentleman, and his wife a true lady. Father Wilson, together with his son Tom, made his second visit to Turkey in the summer of 1966. They drove to Ayvalık from Switzerland; together, we made a three-week journey through the Aegean, the Mediterranean, and Central Anatolia that also helped me get to know Turkey. From 1970 until I wrote to them again in 1974, we lost touch. In 1975, he was planning to come to Turkey with his wife,

but sadly he did not live long enough. (I will relay my most important memory of him later, when the time comes.)

After Father Wilson's death, Mother Wilson and I corresponded several times a year until her passing in 2015 at the age of 104. Nearly every New Year and on my birthday, she would send me small dollar checks enclosed in letters. With that money, I acquired many books. I had the opportunity to visit her in Big Bear Lake, where she had settled, twice: on my own in 1985 and with Fatma in 1988. Jackie and her husband Bob; before them their son John; Gordie's daughter; and Tom and his son all came to Turkey. Among the Wilsons, my "intellectual companion" turned out to be Gordie, who shortly after Webb opened was in a serious car accident and had to stay home for several months. His misfortune was my good luck. I think he too has not forgotten the pleasure of our conversations, in which my consciously or unconsciously existentialist ideas clashed with his radical libertarian views. We are still in correspondence.

Webb School was one of the most prestigious private secondary schools in Southern California. (It still is. It has grown considerably and has also begun admitting female students.) Among my classmates were members of very wealthy and well-known families. (For example, the sons of the famous actor Robert Mitchum and of the family that owned Parker Pens were among them.) A number of my classmates showed me great warmth and invited me to their homes during holidays. You can imagine how happy it made me that some of those who took little interest in me that year later came to Turkey to visit me, and from 2007 onward became devoted readers of my columns in *Today's Zaman*.

Without exception, all the teachers at Webb treated me very well. The most interesting was our English teacher, Lachlan P. MacDonald, a fairly well-known short-story writer. I always received As in his courses. I was successful in all the courses I took except one. In the chemistry laboratory, when everyone else's experiment came out blue while mine came out red, I was considerably embarrassed. I gained quite a bit of sympathy by distinguishing myself as one of the school's best football players (!). Our football coach always played me in the starting eleven. However, in a match in which we were defeated 7–0 by a high school team in Northern California that we visited as part of the private schools league, I had to ask to be taken off the field after the seventh goal. The one who showed me the most favor was the elderly track-and-field coach, who put me on the A team despite my finishing last in the trial races.

What I disliked about Webb School was that, just like EHSB and Robert Academy, it was an all-boys school. Ulla, a Swedish girl who like me had come on an AFS scholarship and been placed with a family in Claremont, attending the local public high school, nearly swayed me when she said, "If you came to my school, you'd have a great time with the girls here…" Mr. Wilson would talk me out of this enthusiasm by telling me that such a transfer would be very difficult. Being an all-boys school was not the only thing that bothered me at Webb. The instruction was entirely secular, but the Webb family who had founded the school were devout Protestants. Every morning at eight o'clock, all students gathered at a chapel on campus, sang hymns, and listened to talks on subjects unrelated to religion. Partly because I came from a Kemalist family and was gradually

developing critical views toward religion, being required to go to the chapel every morning irritated me considerably. I asked to be exempted, but my request was denied on the grounds that the gathering was not religious in nature, that I was not required to speak, and on other grounds. There was no recourse but to sit in the chapel in silence, with a sullen expression conveying my displeasure. Yet this experience would help me grasp the role religion played in American society.

What I loved most about Webb, however, was riding down to the town of Claremont every Saturday on the geared bicycle the Wilsons had given me, passing through the orange groves (none of which remain now). Claremont was a quintessential college town: at the time it had no fewer than five universities. For this reason, there were bookshops with rich collections. From these I would purchase quite a number of books on existentialism and bring them back to Turkey. The most noteworthy book I acquired was, without a doubt, Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels's famous *Communist Manifesto*. In the year I attended Webb, I took my first step into Marxism by reading this book. I would later produce one of the first Turkish translations of it as well.

I had experiences at Webb that deeply affected me. One day Mr. Wilson told me that a Turkish doctor named Osman, living in Pasadena, had called him; the doctor had heard that they were hosting a Turkish student and wanted to meet him if possible. When Wilson asked, "The doctor would like to invite you to dinner at his home—would you go?" I gladly accepted. Osman Bey came one evening in his car, picked me up, and took me to his house. On the way, he explained that he was originally from Adana and had settled here after studying medicine in the US. When we arrived at the house, I saw that there were eight or ten other guests besides me; from their names, I gathered that most were Armenian. I was the first to speak up and introduce myself. After explaining the purpose of my stay in the US, I asked them what had brought them to the US and what they did. The Armenians told me that their elders had been expelled from Turkey through forced deportation and had emigrated to the US via Lebanon, and that they themselves had been educated here and entered various professions. I was in shock!!! I was hearing of the "Deportation" for the first time. I sensed that they were deeply wounded on this subject, and I did not press the matter further.

After returning home, I told my mother about the Armenians I had met in Pasadena and asked whether what they had told me was true. She then told me that it was true; that the Deportation had taken place while they were living in Ankara; and that her father had hidden two young Armenian girls in the attic of the house for a time and then arranged for them to convert to Islam and be married. I asked reproachfully, "Mother, why did you never mention any of this to me before?!" It had never occurred to her (!)… It was then that I came to understand how impenetrable the veil that Republican Turkey had drawn over the past truly was. The truth was that neither my father nor my mother had properly told their family stories; what I managed to learn, I mostly learned later, by asking relatives.

Love at First Sight

The year I spent at Webb also taught me what is called “love at first sight.” At a graduation party held on the yacht of one of our very wealthy classmates, anchored near Catalina Island off the Los Angeles coast, I met Linda Ann Wesson, who attended Azusa High School. We had both come to the party with different dates, but almost the moment we saw each other we were smitten, and before long we had thrown ourselves into each other’s arms. When I met her, unfortunately only a few weeks remained before my departure from Claremont, and we only managed to see each other a few more times. The Wilsons were quite worried about the consequences of the stormy love affair I was living through. In truth, in those days the thought of returning to America just to be with (to marry) Linda even crossed my mind.

Our farewell was very sorrowful. On the way back and after returning to Istanbul, I wrote Linda quite passionate love letters. However, after a while, perhaps thinking that our relationship had no future, I asked her to burn all my letters. In her reply she wrote: *“I once spoke of a certain ‘magic.’ I used this word to describe what I felt when I was with you. You had the ability to make me feel there was no other world besides ‘our’ world. You made me forget so many things—being with you was like being outside all of humanity. I first experienced this at the party where I forgot who I was with and put everything aside and listened to my heart. Burning your letters would be a great loss for me, because they are so beautiful—I have difficulty believing they were written to me alone. There is nothing else to say; you said it all. And I don’t think I could express it any better with my limited understanding and intelligence. But this too is true: the things we shared are still so beautiful to me that no matter how much time passes, it is impossible for me to forget. I am so grateful to you for the happiness you gave me; it is very hard to get used to the idea that I will never find that happiness again. Şahin, I will never forget you, never. Please don’t forget my feelings for you; you made your choice. Always and forever, Linda.”*

I hope to tell the full story of our “love at first sight,” which lasted perhaps a month and was spent going back and forth a few times between Claremont and Azusa, in “Human Landscapes from My Life,” which I plan to write in the future. This much is certain: had I not been consumed by my true great love, my love for Fatma, Linda might never have left my mind. During visits I made to California years later, I wanted to look up her phone number in the directory and call her, but I could never muster the courage.

Back Home

At the beginning of July 1962, I said farewell to the Wilsons and to Linda and set off on a journey organized by AFS. As AFS scholars who had spent the year in Southern California, we piled onto a Greyhound bus; starting from Los Angeles, passing through the northern states of the US, we made a trip lasting approximately a month that took us to Washington, D.C., and from there to New York. Nearly every evening, we were guests of a different family in a different state. There were students from many nations on the bus, most of them European. Getting to know them, as well as the students in the families that hosted us, was both great fun and very educational. In Salt Lake City, the

capital of Utah, the family I stayed with was in the funeral business. The way John, the boy my age in the family, left me behind and rushed headlong off to work when word came would remain in my mind as a tragicomic anecdote. My closest friends on the bus, those with whom I spent the most time, were two Dutch girls around my age. One of them, Beatrice, developed a crush on me; while studying at university in Amsterdam and working at her father's shipping company, she would (fruitlessly) insist that I marry her.

The Greyhound journey was an extraordinarily rich experience in terms of forming an understanding of the diversity of the United States and the world. When we arrived in Washington toward the end of August, we toured the White House together with all of that year's AFS students. Hundreds of students gathered in the White House garden. President John F. Kennedy, with Jackie at his side, addressed us. I had never before been so close to a political leader. As I listened, I reflected that I was face to face with the most powerful leader in the world. The Kennedys were truly a very handsome couple, and Jackie was a very beautiful woman; together they were deeply impressive. (JFK's assassination would coincide with my first days at Ankara University's Faculty of Political Science, and I would be deeply saddened by it.)

By the time we arrived in New York to embark on the return journey from Washington, I had begun to consider myself a "citizen of the world" who now knew Americans and Europeans alike. Cosmopolitan, universalist, humanist values seemed to have seeped into me a little more deeply. From New York, I flew to Zurich on a plane carrying Swiss and Austrian students. There I was met by my elder sister Olcay and my mother, who was visiting her at the time. After staying as a guest of my sister and brother-in-law for about ten days in the small town of Pratteln, my mother and I boarded a train from Geneva to Istanbul. After an adventurous and exhausting journey of about a week through Italy and Yugoslavia, we reached Istanbul at the very end of August 1962.

When I returned home, my elder brother told me what had happened in the country during my absence. The military junta that had come to power on May 27, 1960, had executed Prime Minister Menderes, Foreign Minister Fatin Rüştü Zorlu, and Finance Minister Hasan Polatkan in September 1961. Following the general elections held in October, the Republican People's Party and the newly established Justice Party had formed a coalition government under the premiership of İsmet İnönü. Military Academy commander Colonel Talat Aydemir and his associates had attempted an unsuccessful coup in February 1962 and been pardoned. The question that arose in my mind in my first days back in the country, and that perhaps would determine my fate, was this: "Why was the US so rich and free, while my country Turkey was so poor and so far from freedom?" By the time I returned to Robert Academy in September 1962 to complete my senior year, the idea that some things needed to change in Turkey had begun to gnaw at my mind.

As I began my senior year at Robert Academy, my self-confidence had grown and my sense that I could steer the course of my life had strengthened. I was staying in a three-person room in the building called Theodorus Hall. My roommates were Ahmet Kutman, who had been one of my close friends since EHSB, and Güven Nil, with whom I had made the AFS journey and who upon return had transferred from the German High

School to ours—someone I was very fond of despite our relatively short acquaintance. I should open a parenthesis here and say a little about Güven.

After finishing RA, he attended Robert College and became a mechanical engineer. After working at various firms for a time, in the 1980s he made a great deal of money through the company he founded, taking advantage of the export mobilization ushered in by the January 24th decisions. Believing that the future lay there, he invested his earnings in agriculture. First in Sakarya, then in Gallipoli, he established vineyards for winemaking, olive groves, and almond orchards. His pride and joy was the Sarafin Farm in Gallipoli. He had discovered the place while touring the region, driven by his deep curiosity about the history of the Battle of Gallipoli, and had purchased it. Together with Ahmet Kutman, who had taken over Doluca Wines after his father's death, they began producing Sarafin-brand wines, perhaps the finest in the country.

Güven was extraordinarily intelligent, extraordinarily sensitive, and a voracious reader. He was a good athlete and passionate about basketball. He played guitar. The popular music trio of Güven, Münir, and Mürüvvet was quite well known in school circles. When he died of a heart attack while playing basketball in February 2001, I simply could not believe it. His loss was one of the greatest I have suffered. He had become very close to me. Throughout the 1980s and 1990s, he was the friend I saw most often and with whom I was most in intellectual agreement. He read my columns in *Sabah* and *Milliyet* without fail and would call to share his thoughts. He was insistent that I write my memoirs; he would say he was prepared to invest quite a lot of money in a film based on a screenplay derived from them. He believed that democracy would take hold in Turkey, that the Kurdish question would soon be resolved, and that the PKK would lay down arms and join democratic politics. Had he lived, he too would have suffered the same disappointments as we did.

Among my teachers in the senior year, the one I probably respected the most was Godfrey Goodwin, from whom I learned a great deal and under whom I took classes in classical music history at EHSB and in the history of visual arts at RA. After his retirement, Goodwin settled in London, and I had the chance to see him again only briefly, in Istanbul, a few years before his death, when he came for the launch of one of his new books. The obituary published in *The Guardian* upon his passing said: "Godfrey Goodwin, who has died aged 84, was best known for his 'History of Ottoman Architecture.' First published in 1971, this book remains in print and is one of the standard reference works on the subject, documenting the British scholar's deep love of Turkey." (September 6, 2005)

Among the teachers who supported my intense interest in literature in my final year at RA, one was our Turkish literature teacher Münir Aysu, and the other was our English literature teacher Charles Klopp. The late Münir Bey had a tremendous memory; he never forgot the countless students he had taught and kept track of what they were doing. We met on various occasions until the 2000s. Klopp, who would later specialize in Italian literature and history, mentioned in the foreword of his book *Sentences: The Memoirs and Letters of Italian Prisoners from Benvenuto Cellini to Aldo Moro* (1999) that a distant source of inspiration for the book was a student of his who, while he was

teaching at Robert Academy in Istanbul in the 1960s, had told him, “In the future, I might go to prison because of my political views.” That student was not me. For at that time, my interest in politics was not yet at a level where it could bring to mind the possibility of going to prison for it. What I was thinking at the time was that I might one day become a good novelist.

“Reflections”

1963 was the year my love of literature peaked. I did not merely read intensively; short stories and numerous poems I wrote in English were published in the school’s literary magazine “Spectrum,” for which Mr. Klopp served as advisor. I was also one of the editors of that year’s yearbook (*Reflections ’63*). I prepared the section containing brief profiles of the graduating class and wrote many of the entries myself. The late Mustafa Gürsel and Mehmet Araslı said that in the profiles I wrote about them, I had practically read their characters and futures. The profile about me was written by my close friend from EHSB, Metin Kılıçlı, who said: “Known by almost everyone by the nickname ‘Dayı’ (Uncle), Şahin possesses the ability to communicate effectively with his friends through his powerful written and oral expression… Thanks to his intensive reading and talents, he promises to be a writer for future generations.” (p. 30.)

Metin’s prediction did not come true. In 2006, in Stockholm where I had gone for the Nobel Prize ceremony, I said to Orhan Pamuk, wanting to express my admiration and partly because I genuinely thought so, “Orhan, you are the only person in my life I’ve been envious of…” Sadly, he misunderstood. He must have thought of those who resented him out of jealousy and adopted a hostile stance, for he replied, “Şahin, you couldn’t possibly be jealous of me…”

I graduated from Robert Academy on the “High Honor” list. Outside of classes, I was one of the most active students. Hüsnü Özyeğin, who would later become one of Turkey’s most successful businessmen, was elected president of the school’s Student Council, and I was elected vice president. My friendship with Hüsnü, who would become the most famous member of our class, would grow closer in later years. In addition to the yearbook, I contributed to the school’s literary magazine “Spectrum.” One of my closest friends in the Book Club was Cem Kozlu, who was then in his first year of high school (and would later become one of our school’s most famous graduates, the CEO who paved the way for Turkish Airlines to become one of Europe’s largest carriers). Cem, who also served for a time as an executive at the Komili company and thereby established a connection with Ayvalık, remains one of my closest friends today.

As at EHSB, I became one of the active members of the Drama Club at Robert College. In the first term, I performed in William Shakespeare’s *Julius Caesar*. Güven Nil played Caesar, Mehmet Atakan—another friend whose friendship began at EHSB and continued throughout life—played Marcus Antonius, and I took on the role of Marcus Brutus. In Alejandro Casona’s *Trees Die Standing*, staged by the ACG Players (the American College for Girls Players), I appeared on stage with Nevra Şırvan Serezli (who would later become a famous actress) and Evin Sander İlyasoğlu (who would gain renown as a music critic), among others. In the second term, I appeared as Dr. Bauer in

a play about the life of Sigmund Freud (whose title I cannot recall), in which the lead roles were shared by the late Ali Taygun and Mürüvvet Somuncuoğlu.

When I graduated from Robert Academy in June, I shared with Hasan Yazıcı—who would in time become one of my closest friends—the trophy awarded to the school's most successful student in both academics and extracurricular activities, established in the name of the late Kaya Kaynar, the child of a family from Ayvalık who had died at a young age. During our school years, I had not been close to Hasan. Our friendship, which continues to this day, essentially began when I returned home from Sweden in the early 1980s. After completing his degree at the Cerrahpaşa Faculty of Medicine, Hasan went to the US and specialized in rheumatology. Today he is one of the world's leading experts on Behçet's disease; he also gained renown for the battle he waged against plagiarism in Turkey. I will return to the story of our friendship in the pages ahead.

One of the events that left its mark on me in my senior year was a trip organized by the "Social Services Club" near the end of the school year to Talas College, also an American school, in which students from the Arnavutköy and Üsküdar American girls' colleges also participated. The most important aspect of the journey, which we made by train to and from Kayseri, was that it was my first trip east of Ankara. It was on this occasion that I first encountered what was called a "village." The poverty I witnessed in the villages of Kayseri gave me a jarring sense of the scale of social injustice in the country. I can say that one of the foundations of my leftism, my socialism, which would accelerate during my university years, was laid on that trip. After the trip, I fell seriously ill; diagnosed with scarlet fever, I spent ten days in the school infirmary with a temperature reaching 43 degrees Celsius. I cannot forget my late elder brother's coming to visit me nearly every day to boost my morale, and the tenderness he showed. Because of this illness, I was unable to sit some of my final exams and completed high school through make-up exams taken afterward.

Another unforgettable memory from the final year at the College was the turmoil in May caused by Colonel Talat Aydemir's second failed coup attempt. I had been unaware of Aydemir's first attempt in February 1962 because I was in the US at the time. My elder brother had told me that he had received no punishment for that attempt and had merely been forced into retirement. This time, Aydemir was tried before a military tribunal together with his principal accomplice Major Fethi Gürcan, sentenced to death, and executed in June 1964. After the successful military coup of May 27, 1960, we had now witnessed an unsuccessful coup attempt in May 1963. We were becoming ever more closely acquainted with the military's political role.

"Columbia"

From my standpoint, one of the most important matters of 1963 concerned the question of where I would attend university. Like many of my classmates, I was planning to go to the United States. I took the examinations required to apply to American universities; with the aim of studying in the social sciences, I applied for scholarships to several of the US's elite universities, foremost among them (also on Mr. Wilson's recommendation) Columbia University in New York. Yet I was not without hesitations. In those days, the

only means of communication, let alone with the US, even within Turkey, was by letter. The possibility that if I went for four years I might not be able to come home every summer was unsettling.

On the other hand, I had also been influenced by new ideas. The discourse of the Workers' Party of Turkey, which was reaching our ears with increasing intensity, was providing a fairly clear answer to the fundamental question that had arisen in my mind on the way back from the US: "Why is the US so rich and free, while Turkey is so poor and so devoid of freedom?" Because we were being exploited under the yoke of an alliance of American imperialism and its domestic collaborators, the comprador bourgeoisie and the big landowners… To change the country's fate, it was necessary to free ourselves from the imperialist yoke and build socialism… Seen from this perspective, going to the US to study looked like a kind of "treason against the homeland."

On one of the last days at school, I ran into Nuri Çolakoğlu, who had graduated a year earlier and was attending the Faculty of Political Science in Ankara, and with whom I had not been particularly close until then. Nuri, who would later become one of my closest friends, subjected me to a kind of barrage of persuasion: What was I going to do going to the US… Like him, I could study at the Faculty of Political Science and become a diplomat, I could have a good career… Turkey's future was being charted in Ankara, at the Faculty of Political Science… I must also have been considering the possibility that even if accepted at American universities I might not receive sufficient scholarships, for I applied to sit the entrance examinations for the Philosophy Department of Istanbul University's Faculty of Letters, for its Faculty of Economics, and for Ankara University's Faculty of Political Science.

Toward the end of June, news came that I had been accepted to Columbia University in New York to study sociology. I had also won a full four-year scholarship, including a work-study position at the university library during the summer months. The scholarship I won offered the opportunity to study at one of America's most prestigious universities without my family having to spend a single penny. It was one of the best scholarships won by Robert Academy students that year, perhaps the very best. I suspected that the reference letters written by the Webb School teachers, including Mr. Wilson, had played a major role in this. A few weeks later, I received information about which dormitory, which room, and which roommate I would have at Columbia University. The time had come to prepare for the journey to New York. Flying was unthinkably expensive. Most students were making the journey to New York on cargo ships, a trip lasting roughly a month. With my elder brother's help, I too reserved a place on a cargo ship to depart in August.

I Went to Ayvalık and My Life Changed

In the first days of July 1963, I went to Ayvalık to see my mother, my father, and my elder sister Sumru, and to holiday for a few weeks, before a separation that would last years; had I not gone, my life might have followed an entirely different path. I went to Ayvalık and my life changed… There I ran into Fatma. The previous summer, we had ignored

each other. This time, it was different. We came together. After finishing Işık High School, she had been studying in the Pedagogy Department of Istanbul University's Faculty of Letters for two years. She had definitively separated from "the other one." My love for her—which had never died, only been suppressed—immediately blazed anew. My love was not unrequited. I was madly in love with Fatma; she loved me too. The world was mine! We decided to get married right away. (As I will recount later, on March 20, 1964, we would become engaged with rings we bought and put on at the Grand Bazaar, and on November 29, 1965, we would marry in Ankara and build a home.)

Right in the middle of these extraordinary summer days when I was reunited with Fatma, my closest friend from Webb School, Tor Krieger (as I mentioned above), turned up, having driven thousands of kilometers in his Beetle Volkswagen. He had been attending a school in Paris for a year and had seized the opportunity to come to Turkey to see me before returning to America. I was bewildered about what to do in the face of my reignited love for Fatma: Was I going to go to Columbia, or wasn't I? Could I leave Fatma and go once again? It was a terribly difficult decision… I returned to Istanbul with Tor, who had met Fatma and understood the difficulty of my decision. The results of the Istanbul University entrance exams had been announced. Tor and I went to Beyazıt to see the results, which at the time were posted on bulletin boards. I was very happy to have placed third in the Philosophy Department of the Faculty of Letters. I was quite upset, however, to find myself only on the reserve list for the Faculty of Economics; there must have been a mistake. This was the first and last failure of my educational life.

A few days after Tor returned to France, the results of the Faculty of Political Science entrance exam also arrived in the mail. I had placed somewhere near the top of the list. I did not hesitate much: My future was now charted… I decided not to go to New York. I would go to the Faculty of Political Science, become a diplomat, and marry Fatma; period! As in the famous poem by the American poet Robert Frost, "The Road Not Taken," two roads had diverged before me. I (contrary to the poem) took "the one more traveled by," and (as the poem says) "That has made all the difference…"

Fatma greeted my decision not to go to the US with her characteristic cool-headedness, but she did not hide her satisfaction. We were going to get married. I wrote a letter to Columbia informing them that "due to family reasons, regrettably" I would not be able to come, and reiterating my thanks for the scholarship. And so the New York chapter closed. Interestingly, the idea of marrying Fatma and going together never arose; probably out of fear: In that case, Fatma would have to join me later, and once again a long separation would be necessary. I did not want to risk being apart from her yet again. Yes, in later years, I did occasionally ask myself why we had not gone to New York together. (This was theoretically possible, since Fatma had inherited from her late father the means to comfortably finance it.) Nevertheless, I would ultimately conclude that the decision to go to Ankara rather than Columbia was, in the final analysis, despite everything, the right one.

The person most pleased by my decision not to go to the US was my mother. She would not be separated from her beloved son for years. She was also glad that the reason was Fatma. Fatma was the daughter of a family she knew, her neighbor and playmate

Leman Kaptan; she was a fine bride-to-be. Interestingly, my father was pleased as well. When I told him I had given up going to the US and was thinking of marrying Fatma, he said, “Whoever she may be, if she is someone you love, everything in life is worth doing…” He also said he would help me as much as he could with getting married, but his promises would not be kept.

Mr. Wilson, who had been a great support in my winning the Columbia scholarship, made no reproach. The one who was deeply vexed by my not using the scholarship was Cornelius Bull, the headmaster of Robert Academy at the time. About a year after my graduation, I had gone to the school on an occasion I cannot recall. Hearing that the students were assembled in Albert Long Hall, I headed there. When I eavesdropped from the doorway, I heard Bull saying from the podium: “I hope none of you does what Şahin Alpay did and turns down a rarely won scholarship for the sake of a girl!..” That I should appear there at the very moment Bull was speaking about me was an almost unbelievable coincidence… I turned away from the door and quickly left the school.

After spending what were perhaps the most dramatic days of my life with Fatma in Ayvalık until October, I set off for Ankara. My mother had spoken with my maternal uncle Remzi Karatal, who lived in Ankara, and they had agreed that I would stay in the apartment on the ground floor of their building, which belonged to my aunt Perihan’s elder brother, who was in America at the time. Thus my housing problem for the first year was solved. A year later, my elder sister Olcay and my brother-in-law Ünal decided to settle in Ankara after returning home from Switzerland, and they began living in the Karacan family’s apartment on Selanik Street. In my second year, I was their guest. In the third year, Fatma and I would get married. In this way, my university life was quite separate from that of the Faculty of Political Science (Mülkiye) students who lived in dormitories. Throughout the first two years, nothing occupied my mind besides being with Fatma. I went to Istanbul nearly every weekend. Fatma was in her third year studying in the Pedagogy Department of Istanbul University’s Faculty of Letters, staying with her late maternal uncle İsmet—also known for his tenure as Director of the İzmir Fair—and his wife Aysun Kaptan; she too sometimes came to Ankara.

Finally, one spring day in 1964, during one of her visits to Istanbul, my mother and I went to visit my future mother-in-law Leman Kaptan, who was at the time visiting her middle daughter Ayşe in Kadıköy. My mother asked, “Leman, these children have decided to get married—what do you say?..” And when Leman Kaptan replied, “Since they’ve decided between themselves, there’s nothing to be done…” the path to our marriage was opened. On March 20, 1964, Fatma and I went to the Grand Bazaar; we bought a pair of wedding bands and became engaged right there on the spot. At that point, we intended to have the official wedding ceremony when I finished university. But we would not be able to hold out that long…

CHAPTER III / BECOMING A REVOLUTIONARY

The winter of 1963-64 in Ankara would be the harshest winter I would ever experience. Since the Faculty of Political Science (SBF) had opened its doors to such a crowded

class for the first time due to Ankara University's first centralized entrance examination, classes were held in a sports hall without any heating during the harsh winter conditions. We were simply freezing… The conditions of the apartment I lived in were the complete opposite: it was excessively hot and humid because it was on the lower floor of the sauna operated by Dr. Hami Koçaş.

Nuri Çolakoğlu and I had become inseparable friends. With his encouragement, I joined the SBF Theater Club. Thus, my acting that had begun in the preparatory classes at EHSB continued at SBF. I played the lead role, Harrison Fish, in the play "The Last Hour of Harrison Fish" written by Juan Areola. The play, directed by Nuri, was performed one evening at the French Cultural Center in Kızılay and another evening at Gazi Education Institute in January 1964. Among those who had roles in the play were Deniz Gökçe (who would later become a well-known economics and sports writer), the late Cenk Duatepe (who held critical positions in the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and served as Turkey's Ambassador to Damascus during the period when Abdullah Öcalan was expelled from Syria), and Necati Utkan, Tansu Okandan, and Ayşe Aksoy (who would later serve as ambassadors).

The faculty member who left the greatest impression on me during my first two years at Mülkiye was undoubtedly Mümtaz Soysal, who was then a newly appointed associate professor and taught the course "Introduction to Constitutional Law." Soysal had represented the CHP in the constitutional commission of the Representative Assembly established to draft the new constitution after the May 27 military intervention. He was also among the founders of the magazine *Yön*, which was published between December 1961 and June 1967 and served as the voice of the nationalist left movement in the post-May 27 period, along with Doğan Avcıoğlu, İlhan Selçuk, and İlhami Soysal (all now deceased). After the March 12, 1971 military intervention, he would be accused of "communist propaganda" in his textbook titled "Introduction to Constitutional Law," sentenced to approximately 7 years in prison by a martial law court, and serve 14 months. The truly impressive aspect of Soysal's lectures was his delivery that captured the complete attention of students. Being influenced by his ideas led me to develop an increasing interest in what was written in *Yön* magazine. My conversations with Nuri increasingly focused on the discourses of TİP (Workers' Party of Turkey) and *Yön* magazine.

Between two fires

I can say that the foundation of the tension between my private life and public life, which I could describe as being "between two fires," was laid in the summer of 1965. That summer, while continuing to experience my passionate love with Fatma and making plans to marry at the end of that year, I was simultaneously developing an increasingly intense relationship with TİP and the idea of socialism. That summer, I participated in the meetings of the Ayvalık TİP district organization and in the election campaign it conducted in the villages of Ayvalık for the elections to be held on October 10, 1965. On that occasion, I would learn for the first time that some of these villages were inhabited by Alevis, whose existence I had not been much aware of until then. That summer, Ömer

and I covered the Ayvalık-Çamlık asphalt road with TİP slogans that we wrote in oil paint.

The story of my friendship with Ömer could be the subject of a book in itself. I am also related to Ömer through the distant kinship between his paternal grandmother Beraat Madra and my maternal grandmother Nazire Hanım, both of whom were of Lesbos origin. Neither of us knows exactly when our friendship began. But he too had entered EHSB one year after me, in 1956, and our friendship had grown closer in Ayvalık where we spent our summer holidays. When we were in middle school, our passion was to press our ears against radios and listen to American-British pop music through the static, competing over who heard the new songs first. I reunited with Ömer in Ayvalık in the summer of 1964, after not seeing him for a long time because he entered Robert College one year after me and graduated one year later, and because I had spent my sophomore year in the USA. He was planning to go to France to study cinematography. It was not very difficult for me to dissuade him from this “empty and meaningless” career idea and convince him to study at SBF like me, “to become a diplomat and serve the Turkish state.” Just as Nuri Çolakoğlu had persuaded me to go to Ankara and study at SBF instead of going to New York to study sociology at Columbia University…

Our lives with Ömer would continue to follow an astonishing parallelism. I married Fatma at the end of 1965, he married his classmate Tanju at the end of 1966. My first child (Elvan) was born in 1968, his first child (Cem) in 1969. Like me, he began his Ankara adventure with the SBF Theater Club, then like me joined the socialist youth movement, the Fikir Kulübü (Ideas Club), TİP, and the Aydınlık movement. We lived through the disappointments of revolutionary politics together. After the March 12, 1971 military coup, he went to prison while I fled abroad. After the September 12 military intervention, while I was not admitted to universities, he resigned from his position at SBF. Our journalism period began with me starting to work at *Cumhuriyet*, and shortly after, him at *Milliyet*… I will return to the long history of my friendship with Ömer as appropriate.

We are getting married

On November 29, 1965, Fatma and I got married in Ankara. Our wedding ceremony was held at the marriage office located in the Türkocağı building in Ulus. Fatma was the most beautiful bride I had ever seen, wearing the most beautiful wedding dress I had ever seen. The famous marriage registrar Mr. Müctaba Yetişen performed our ceremony with great solemnity, giving the occasion a sublime atmosphere. He spoke as follows (I quote verbatim since it is a now-abandoned form of discourse):

“You have previously informed us in writing of your decision to marry each other. Upon this request of yours, we conducted the necessary examinations. We investigated your civil status. We made the announcement according to the provisions of our Civil Code and marriage regulations. There is no obstacle to your marriage. It has been determined that you are legally eligible to marry. Now, please state verbally, before me and your witnesses, the wish you have communicated to us in writing. Do you wish to marry each other? Mr. Şahin Alpay, do you wish to marry Miss Fatma Nur Kaptan? - Miss Fatma Nur Kaptan, do you wish to marry Mr. Şahin Alpay?… You have stated before me and in the

presence of witnesses that you wish to marry each other. By virtue of the authority vested in me, I inform you that your marriage has been legally contracted. I have registered your marriage in the marriage registry. I will also notify the population administration for it to be recorded in the civil registry. May it be auspicious and blessed."

After Fatma and I, along with our witnesses my maternal uncle Remzi Karatal and Fatma's brother-in-law (at that time) Arman Onaran, signed the marriage register, Mr. Mücteba stood up. We stood up with him. He continued his speech: "*With this ceremony, from this moment on, your marital union has been established. You are obligated to ensure the continuation and happiness of this union toward each other, and as husband and wife, you are bound by fidelity and mutual support to one another. You will bear the responsibility of jointly caring for the sustenance and upbringing of your children. The husband is the head of the union. The proper sustenance of the wife and children belongs to him. The woman is her husband's helper and advisor to the extent of her ability in ensuring mutual happiness. The woman looks after the home. The husband represents the union. For the permanent needs of the household, the woman also has the right to represent the union just like the husband. From this moment when your marital union has come into being, I remind you of these obligations imposed by our Civil Code as duties that must be observed as long as your life continues, and I wish you health and happiness."* (I found the late Mr. Mücteba's standardized speech text in the late Güngör Uras's column dated July 16, 2000.)

Our marriage was celebrated with a dinner reception at my elder sister Olcay and my brother-in-law Ünal's home on Selanik Avenue, attended by most of our close relatives who could come to Ankara and my close friends from Robert College and SBF: Ömer Madra, Nuri Çolakoğlu, Erdal Yavuz, and Ümit Hassan. A girl of Fatma's beauty and worth certainly deserved to be married with a magnificent wedding… Undoubtedly, if her father had been alive, he would have allowed his precious little daughter neither to marry me nor to marry without a proper wedding. Indeed, years later, we would both feel regret and sorrow for not having had a wedding ceremony. Around midnight, Fatma and I headed to the attic apartment we had rented in the Güneş building in Maltepe. And what do we see: the elevator was broken! Unfortunately, I was not strong enough to carry Fatma in my arms seven floors up.

We were both still 21 years old. This was considered a very early marriage for the male side in urban families of those years. Among my classmates, no one got married earlier than me. (Interestingly, I would later learn that my close friend from Webb, Tor Krieger, also had the first of his three official marriages that year.) The most important factor in our hasty marriage was certainly that we were experiencing a passionate love; but I think an equally important factor was that Fatma had grown up without a father since age eleven due to her father's death, and I had grown up without a father since age six due to my parents' divorce. I think for this reason we both felt the need to have a home as soon as possible. The small rented apartment on the top floor of the ten-story Güneş building in Tandoğan became our first home.

Fatma had completed her fourth year in the Pedagogy Department of the Faculty of Letters at Istanbul University; she would graduate if she passed the remaining few final exams. At that time, we thought she would pass the exams sooner or later and graduate. However, over time she gave up on the idea of graduating and getting a diploma. Unfortunately, I acted very selfishly and did not object to this. We thought: I was going to become a diplomat anyway, and therefore she would not be able to work. My plans to become a diplomat encouraged us to establish a traditional type of family where the man worked and had a career, while the woman took on the role of housewife. Another factor that played a role in Fatma eventually dropping out of university was that she had not enjoyed studying pedagogy. With her strong intelligence, sound logic, and sensible and cool-headed character, she could have been a first-class medical doctor. However, her mother had not encouraged her to get a good education; she had wanted her to marry someone from Ayvalık who would look after her properties at as early an age as possible.

Our marriage was made possible by the income Fatma received from the olive groves she had inherited from her father. My mother, who herself was barely making ends meet, could hardly contribute to our budget. Did living on Fatma's income create any discomfort for me?.. Honestly, it both did and did not. Because, above all, there was no other way for me to marry her. On the other hand, I consoled myself thinking this was anyway a temporary solution, a kind of educational scholarship my beloved was providing me. I had now moved on to the third year; I was studying successfully in the Diplomacy and Foreign Relations Department. In any case, I would graduate in two years and start working at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs… My beloved thought the same.

During the more than two years from the summer of 1963 until we married in the fall of 1965, I can say that only Fatma occupied my mind; marrying her and being with her at all times had become my main aspiration. In those years, Fatma was studying at the Faculty of Letters at Istanbul University; she was staying at the home of her uncle İsmet and aunt Aysun in Taksim-Talimhane. While studying in the first and second years at Mülkiye, I went to Istanbul most weekends to see Fatma. However, from the spring of 1965 onwards, developments began to occur that were preparing a life for me without Fatma. When I returned from the USA to Turkey, the seed had been planted; I had begun to believe that the left movement, then represented by the Workers' Party of Turkey (TİP), would find remedies for the poverty, injustices, and restrictions on freedom in Turkey that tormented my conscience.

"Dönüşüm"

My entry into the leftist youth movement came through the magazine *Dönüşüm* (Transformation), whose first issue was published in April 1965 and which only produced 5 issues. The pioneers of this first magazine published by leftist youth in the 1960s were Ataol Behramoğlu, İsmet Özel, and Abdullah Nefes, childhood friends from Çankırı (all three would become famous as poets). The magazine, prepared in a room in the editorial office of the journal *Sosyal Adalet* which served as TİP's publication organ, was owned by Ataol Behramoğlu, while Ümit Hassan (my friend from Robert College who

was then, like me, studying at Mülkiye) served as its managing editor. I believe I joined the editorial board at Ümit's suggestion. Among the editorial board members, I also knew Hüseyin Ergün, the President of the SBF Fikir Kulübü (Ideas Club). The editorial board of the magazine, which published in line with TİP ideology and featured articles by TİP leaders, included, in addition to those mentioned above, İsmet Özel, Alper Aktan, Kurthan Fişek, Yurdakul Alpay, Aslan Sonat, and myself. *Dönüşüm* also engaged in polemics with *Yön*, the magazine of the left outside TİP. Ataol Behramoğlu had written an article titled "A response to a magazine with a clear direction" in response to a criticism of TİP published in *Yön*.

All 45,000 copies of the first issue of the magazine, which attracted considerable interest and was published on April 22, 1965, were sold. Copies reached not only Istanbul and Izmir but also some provinces of Anatolia. The attacks organized by right-leaning students under police protection against the young people selling the magazine in Kızılay and Ulus also contributed to the interest it generated. From these attacks, which were the first examples of the right-left conflict that would grow among students, my share was a few punches to my head in Kızılay. These attacks disturbed the TİP leadership, which (in Hüseyin Ergün's words) "did not want fighting and brawling," and the magazine was asked to cease publication, which it did.

Since I was still keeping my intention to become a diplomat at that time, I had written in the first *Dönüşüm* under a pseudonym. I remember that my article signed "Salim Altay" targeted American cultural imperialism. I was uncomfortable with my Robert College graduate and AFS scholarship background alongside the leftist identity I was acquiring. The main event reflecting this discomfort was my resignation from the membership of the association (whose name I no longer remember) established by young people who went to study in the USA on AFS scholarships, by writing an angry protest letter. I recall that I shared the leadership of this "action" with the late Yalçın Yusufoğlu, who was one of the founders of the Turkish Socialist Workers' Party (TSİP), the first socialist party organized after March 12. (Just as years later we would talk and share our disappointments with the left movement.)

Dönüşüm, which served to establish communication among leftist youth groups, began to be published again in late 1966. This time Abdullah Nefes took on the ownership and editorial directorship. After the closure of the journal *Sosyal Adalet*, *Dönüşüm* II, which acquired the identity of TİP's publication organ, published a total of 7 issues, from the 6th to the 12th. This time, those on the editorial board included, besides Nefes, Behramoğlu, Ergün, and myself, Doğu Perinçek, Atilla Sarp, Osman Sakalsız, Ayhan Başaran, Murat Koğacıoğlu, Nuri Çolakoğlu and Ömer Madra (who joined at my suggestion), and Sinan Cemgil (one of the founders of THKO who was killed by the gendarmerie in the Nurhak mountains in May 1971). I also met Doğu Perinçek on this occasion. I would write in the second *Dönüşüm* under my own name. My articles in *Dönüşüm* reflect the transition in my political ideas from roughly nationalist-statist-secularist Kemalism to roughly TİP socialism. (Unfortunately, I was unable to find copies of either the first or second *Dönüşüm*. More than fifty years later, at our meeting in Ankara in April 2016, even Abdullah Nefes, who passed away in 2021, would say that he had no copies of the magazine left.)

Turkish Labor Party Ayvalık branch

My interest in politics, socialism, and especially TİP intensified in the summer of 1965. Those I met in Ayvalık who had been arrested and imprisoned in the 1951 Turkish Communist Party trial and members of the TİP district organization played an important role in this. As far as I remember, the key figures were tailor Ali Çolakoğlu, a former TKP member, and his son Mustafa Çolakoğlu, also a tailor, who was active in the TİP Ayvalık district organization. Ali Çolakoğlu introduced me to the "old guard": the late Ahmet Bilge, who was then working as a contractor and had taken on the restoration of the mansion left by Greeks two houses away from our home in Çamlık, his partner Güner Eliçin (father of journalist Işın Eliçin), and old Ahmet Usta, a shoemaker from Cunda, or rather from Crete (whose surname I don't remember). Through Mustafa Çolakoğlu, I had also met the main members of the TİP district organization: watchmaker Hüseyin, gardener Hasan, grocer Fethi (Namlı), electrician Işık, and salt merchant Muvaffak.

In the summer of 1965, I frequently got together with the people I mentioned above. I participated in the election campaign the TİP district organization conducted in the villages of Ayvalık during the 1965 elections. As I described above, Ömer Madra and I wrote fiery slogans against American imperialism and in favor of socialism in oil paint on the asphalt of Çamlık, Ayvalık's "bourgeois" neighborhood and our own. Although Fatma found what I was doing strange, she had adopted a benevolent perspective. Starting from our engagement period, she had begun to develop the principle of not interfering in my public life. She probably thought "he must know what he's doing."

In the 1965-66 academic year, I was studying in the third year at SBF in the Diplomacy and Foreign Relations department. Nuri Çolakoğlu, whom I had met at Robert College and who had played a major role in my going to Ankara, and I were inseparable. Nuri had failed that year and had come to the same class as me. We frequently got together at the attic apartment on İzmir Street where he lived with his girlfriend Sezi (Ergun), who was then a TRT programmer and would later become his first wife. We had divided the courses between us. I would attend some and take notes, he would attend the others. This way we could devote more time to our other interests.

Peace Association

My first step into socialist youth organizations was with the Peace Association, of which I was among the founders in December 1965, about a month after my marriage to Fatma. Among the founding members of the association, I remember Hüseyin Ergün (the first president of Fikir Kulübü), Alper Aktan, Kutlay Ebiri, Ahmet Ali Arlı, Sami Urfalı, Ömer Madra, Tuğrul Eryılmaz, Necmiye Alpay from the Faculty of Language, History and Geography, and Henri Çerniyak, my friend from Robert College who was studying at ODTÜ. (Çerniyak later emigrated to Israel and, I believe, started working for Mossad.) On the first board of directors of the association, besides Kutlay Ebiri who was elected president, there were Sema Erder (whose beauty attracted the attention of many of us), Ayhan Başaran, my classmate from Robert College Erdal Yavuz, and myself. At that time, I was closely following leftist literature and felt great affinity for TİP, but perhaps

because I had not yet abandoned the prospect of becoming a diplomat (which I had promised Fatma), I had neither joined Fikir Kulübü nor registered with TİP.

The Peace Association defined its purpose in its founding declaration as follows: “The principle of peace at home, peace in the world outlines the main lines of the association’s work. The association is against any behavior that could endanger peace.” The vast majority of the association’s founders and members were students from and around the SBF Fikir Kulübü. Some members were also members of TİP. The association served as a kind of “front organization,” functioning to recruit left-leaning youth to Fikir Kulübü membership. Years later, when asked about his memories of the Peace Association, Hüseyin Ergün said: “It was an initiative started by bourgeois and aristocratic youth…” President Kutlay Ebiri remembered the association differently: “I know that there were no aristocrats among us, except perhaps Sami Urfalı. There were one or two wealthy (Ömer Madra, Şahin Alpay) or middle-class (Erdal Yavuz) College students. I was living on a 250 lira per month scholarship from the Ministry of Finance, and I was sending the money I saved to my mother.” (See: Pınar Selek, *Barışamadık*, İthaki Özyürek Publications, Istanbul, 2004, p.274)

Kutlay said the following in a letter he wrote to me years later (in early 2016): “The idea to establish the Peace Association came to me from the fact that the SBF Fikir Kulübü was somewhat too closed in those years and the negative atmosphere created by some whose heads were in the clouds (meaning quite radical leftists) like İsmet Özel. Our aim in founding the association was to attract more Mülkiye students to the left and to emphasize anti-imperialist themes (especially against the Vietnam War). We contacted Bertrand Russell, prepared panels with brilliantly printed photographs against the Vietnam War that he sent, and soon 50-60 students who had not really thought of joining Fikir Kulübü joined the association. We also opened the Istanbul branch under the presidency of my high school friend Fahrettin Yağcı.” Founding president Kutlay Ebiri and the late Fahrettin Yağcı from Istanbul University Faculty of Economics would both do economics doctorates on government scholarships in England after graduating from the faculty and become experts at the World Bank. (Both were among my close friends in the club of those disillusioned with the belief in socialism.)

Kutlay was a distant relative of Altay Egesel, the notorious chief prosecutor of the Yassıada Trials. What he said about the association’s founding process gives an idea about our confusion: “…Russell’s efforts regarding Vietnam and his universal fame had appealed to us… We looked at the guerrilla and liberation movements in Latin America with sympathy, we studied them, but we never thought of applying their methods in Turkey. We were of the view that there were serious differences between the class character, striking power, and political spectrum positioning of Latin American armies and those of the Turkish army.” (Selek, pp. 272-273.)

An internal conflict reflecting “the spirit of the times” occurred in the Peace Association. The supervisory board, of which Sema Erder was also a member, expelled Kutlay from the association on the grounds that he had “deviated from the revolutionary line and turned the association into a supporter of the junta.” This was perhaps a harbinger of the “who is the real revolutionary” competition that would grow and eventually lead to

revolutionary youth being at each other's throats. Years later, Kutlay explained this incident to Selek as follows: "I think the junta supporter image came from me telling my friends what my distant relative Altay Egesel said when I occasionally went to visit… Egesel was very much involved with the junta supporters at that time. This was probably a habit from before May 27…" After Kutlay's expulsion, Ayhan Başaran took over the association presidency, and later Erdal Yavuz. Cengiz Çandar became Erdal's vice president. (Erdal and Cengiz would be among my lifelong friends.) The association was closed after the March 12, 1971 military intervention.

Two Nuris

I had achieved my goal, married the girl I loved, and set up a home of my own in Ankara. I now had the opportunity to engage more closely with the political subjects I was being educated in and was quite curious about. Indeed, the 1965-66 academic year, the first year of our marriage, would be a turning point in my life.

It was late March 1966. One day Nuri Çolakoğlu came to our home in Maltepe-Tandoğan. Mahir Çayan, the newly elected president of Fikir Kulübü, had called him and broached the subject: Fikir Kulübü wanted to win the SBF Student Association elections to be held in April. For this purpose, they had decided to nominate Nuri, a Robert College man, whom they believed could attract votes from a wider circle of students. However, Nuri had not accepted the proposal, using his engagement with the Theater Club as an excuse; he had suggested me instead on the grounds that I could be even more successful.

I remember being excited when Nuri brought up the subject. Being the presidential candidate of Fikir Kulübü at Mülkiye, the main headquarters of socialist-revolutionary youth, was no small matter. Nuri introduced me to Mahir Çayan, whom I would meet for the first time. Mahir made a very positive impression on me. I was proud of the offer he made. Still, I asked for permission to think about it for a day or two. I talked with Fatma. Since she didn't know where this could lead, and mainly because of her attitude of leaving decisions about myself to me as she almost always did, she did not take a position for or against. If she had taken a position against, could she have changed the decision I would eventually make? Perhaps…

When it became known in our circle of friends that Fikir Kulübü had offered me the candidacy, Nuri Yıldırım, one of the few Robert College graduates at Mülkiye and one of my lifelong friends (later ambassador), came to my door unexpectedly. A very bright future awaited me as a diplomat; if I accepted the offer, became Fikir Kulübü's candidate, and especially if I were elected Association president, I would ruin my future. I was facing quite an ironic situation: while one Nuri from Robert College was opening a path for me, another Nuri from the same school was insistently warning me not to take that path. My interest in politics was growing steadily. The urge to prove myself must have prevailed, because after some thought I accepted the proposal and became Fikir Kulübü's candidate for SBF Student Association president. I was more or less aware that if I were elected, my plan to become a diplomat would come to an end. For this reason, I began to think of a future for myself as a faculty member at SBF. After my candidacy

was announced, without further delay, I registered as a member of the TİP Çankaya District organization, then headed by my brother-in-law, the late Ünal Karacan, my sister Olcay's husband. (My brother-in-law would later, angered by my going over to the ranks of the "proletarian revolutionaries," strike my registration from TİP, so I would not need to resign.)

I won, by a single vote, the election between me and Şükrü Tufan, the candidate of the Hür Düşünce Kulübü (Free Thought Club), which brought together students close to the Justice Party and had been established by Celal Güzel, Mehmet Keçeciler, Abdülkadir Aksu (all of whom would later become ministers) and their friends. The fact that I won the election as a "Robert College student" who did not stay in the dormitory because he was married, who was rarely seen at the faculty, who did not know many people at school, who was called "bourgeois," and who was rumored to "own half of Ayvalık" was truly a miracle. Cenk Duatepe, a fourth-year student who was the election committee chairman and a Fikir Kulübü sympathizer, would explain to me how this was possible: "When we noticed that the rightists were stuffing the ballot boxes with plenty of fake votes, we also took precautions…" (When Duatepe passed away on March 26, 2010, Milliyet newspaper reported: "Duatepe had served as Turkey's Ambassador to Damascus during the period when terrorist Abdullah Öcalan was expelled from Syria and played an active role in the process that ended with Öcalan's extradition to Turkey.")

The SBF Fikir Kulübü, composed of TİP-leaning students, was winning the Student Association elections for the first time. Upon the announcement of the results on April 20, club members and sympathizers held jubilant celebrations inside the faculty. Various revolutionary marches were sung, including "The Internationale" and the famous march of the Italian communists "Avanti Popolo." These demonstrations had tragi-comic consequences. Upon a denunciation by some right-wing students, two of the friends who sang these marches were tried without detention for nearly 5 years on charges of "communist propaganda," in the language of the indictment against them. One of them was our friend İsmet Özel (later a famous poet), who was a very dogmatic Leninist at the time but adopted a rather dogmatic Islamism from the second half of the 1970s onwards, and the other was Erdal Yavuz (later a professor of economic history), one of my closest friends from high school to this day.

Although they were acquitted in 1971 due to insufficient evidence, the Court of Cassation overturned the decision on grounds of incomplete investigation upon the prosecutor's objection. The court finally decided at the end of 1972 to acquit Özel based on the unanimous decision of the SBF Board of Directors that no action was necessary under the disciplinary regulations, and to interrogate Erdal Yavuz when found, as he had not come to give a statement after the reversal. Had the Court of Cassation's final acquittal not come in time, this ongoing case would very nearly have prevented Erdal from going to Strasbourg University to do his doctorate on the scholarship he had won from the Ministry of Finance, and we would not have been able to join him there a while later.

The election won by a single vote and through a fraud for which I bore no responsibility played a decisive role in deepening my politicization. The majority of the Student

Association board of directors, of which I was president, consisted of Fikir Kulübü members. Among them, I remember Erdal Yavuz, Nuri Çolakoğlu (who would later become a journalist-writer), and Tuğrul Eryılmaz, as well as Ali Külebi, Erçin Odman, Suat Asutay, Atilla Vural, and Özkan Mert. İstemihan Talay from the Social Democracy Club (who would become DSP Mersin/İçel MP for the 18th-21st terms and Minister of Culture in the 55th-57th governments) and Esat Güçhan from the Hür Düşünce Kulübü (who served as Tekel General Manager and Wrestling Federation President for a while) were also among those who entered the board by breaking through the Fikir Kulübü list.

The day after the election, on April 21, 1966, we visited Anıtkabir as the board of directors. I wrote the following in the memorial book: “Immortal Atatürk, the Supreme Leader of our people in our National Liberation War! We are the owners and guardians of the Turkish regime, of the Turkish revolutions!” My views at that time, I believe like those of many of my leftist friends, were a strange mixture of Kemalism in the sense of nationalism-statism-secularism and a kind of “soft” socialism meaning state-led development, land reform, and distancing from the West, which TİP advocated in its early years. Atatürk was respected as a great revolutionary among leftist youth at the time. Indeed, the picture of “Mustafa Kemal wearing a kalpak at Kocatepe” in my study at home would not come down from the wall until 1970…

Turkish left in the 1960s

With my election to the presidency of the association, which we would soon rename “SBF Student Association,” I began to participate more actively in the leftist youth movement. For the purpose of understanding the place I envisioned for myself within this movement, it would be useful for me to provide a general description of the left in Turkey in the period from the second half of the 1960s to the March 12, 1971 military intervention. I would like to emphasize that the summary description you will read below has no claim beyond reflecting my understanding.

During this period, the Turkish left was essentially divided into four currents. The one that initially carried great weight was TİP, established in 1961. One of the rival currents consisted of intellectuals and politicians gathered around the “Socialist Culture Association” founded by Doğan Avcıoğlu and the magazine *Yön* (1961-67) that he began to publish. The other was the National Democratic Revolution (MDD) movement led by former communists. In addition to these, there was also a leftist youth movement that harbored various tendencies within it.

After Mehmet Ali Aybar was elected chairman in 1962, TİP began to increase its influence among left-leaning intellectuals and youth. Along with Aybar, sociologist Behice Boran, economics professor Sadun Aren, and newspaper columnist Çetin Altan were the party’s leading spokespersons. In its program adopted at its first congress in 1964, TİP spoke of “development by the non-capitalist path” as an intermediate stage on Turkey’s way to socialism and of a “second war of liberation for independence.” TİP received 2.9% of the votes in the 1965 elections, its first election, and won 15 parliamentary seats thanks to the proportional representation system in effect and the distribution of votes according to the National Remainder method. Emboldened by this electoral success,

party spokespersons began to speak of “socialist transformation.” From the summer of 1966, Aybar began to speak of the inseparability of the struggle for national independence and the struggle for socialism. The success of the independence struggle in underdeveloped countries was only possible by ending the power of the comprador bourgeoisie and landlords who collaborated with imperialists. The idea of a struggle to be waged simultaneously for national independence and socialism was also supported by the party’s other leading figures.

The group referred to as MDD supporters, whose spokesperson was Mihri Belli, opposed Aybar’s theses at TİP’s second congress in November 1966 and put forward the thesis of a two-stage revolution. In the first stage, the goal was the National Democratic Revolution (MDD), that is, gaining national independence by ending the power of imperialist and domestic collaborators and eliminating feudal remnants through land reform; the socialist revolution could only come on the agenda after this. The great majority at the congress supported Aybar’s theses, but the first signs of division within the party were also seen. Complaints began about Aybar’s dominance and the lack of democracy in the party.

The ideological split in TİP emerged following the Soviet invasion of Czechoslovakia in August 1968. While Aybar strongly opposed the invasion, he began to speak of the need for a socialism that included liberal democratic institutions, “socialism with a human face.” He called on socialists to read the works not only of Karl Marx and Vladimir Ilyich Lenin but also of Karl Kautsky and Eduard Bernstein. He argued that the democracy inherent in socialism could be realized for the first time with “Turkish socialism.” While Aybar’s theses were supported by people like Çetin Altan, Şaban Erik, Rıza Kuas, and Tarık Ziya Ekinci, Behice Boran, Sadun Aren, and the party’s general secretary Nihat Sargın opposed them.

Boran argued that, contrary to what Aybar claimed, human history was not a history of struggle for freedom but of class struggles; Şaban Erik argued that Aybar’s views meant a revision of scientific socialism. Despite fierce opposition, Aybar emerged successfully from the third congress held in November 1968 as well. One of the congress resolutions emphasized that “Turkish socialism” was a completely independent current and that socialist parties and states should respect each other’s independence. At this congress, a resolution describing TİP as “socialist” was adopted for the first time. Immediately after the third congress, Çetin Altan, who had been one of his supporters until then, published an article criticizing Aybar’s authoritarian attitudes. When Aybar demanded his expulsion from the party, Altan claimed that Aybar accused everyone who opposed him of being a “Moscow communist.”

Intra-party divisions negatively affected TİP’s work considerably after the third congress. At the extraordinary congress convened in December 1968, Aybar said that he had been advocating “individualist socialism” since 1945 and that if TİP came to power, it would preserve the institutions of liberal democracy. Aren accused Aybar of imposing his own views on the party, and Altan accused him of authoritarianism. The “National Democratic Revolutionaries” directed harsh criticism at both Aybar and the Aren-Boran faction. Before the general elections on October 12, 1969, Aybar’s supporters also split among

themselves: the trade unionists who were among the party's founders opposed the method used in determining parliamentary candidates. The party's vote share dropped from 2.9 percent to 2.65 percent, and as a result of the abandonment of the national remainder method in the distribution of parliamentary seats, TİP could only win 2 seats. The election results were interpreted by MDD supporters as proof that the struggle for socialism and the struggle for independence were different from each other and as a defeat of the thesis of coming to power through parliamentary, democratic means. The MDD thesis began to spread especially among leftist youth. Opponents demanded that Aybar, whom they saw as responsible for the electoral failure, step down from the chairmanship. Aybar resigned from the party in November 1969.

At the fourth congress held in October 1970, the Aren-Boran faction dominated the party. When a resolution was adopted stating that advocacy of MDD theses was incompatible with TİP membership, MDD supporters were purged from the party through forced resignation or expulsion. The Aren-Boran faction continued to adopt Aybar's theses that the struggle for independence could not be separated from the struggle for socialism and that power would be achieved through democratic means, but they claimed to advocate "scientific socialism" against his "individualist/democratic" understanding of socialism. According to them, socialism was a "mode of production" based on public ownership of the means of production and a planned economy. Following the March 12, 1971 military intervention, the Constitutional Court would decide in July 1971 to close TİP not on the grounds of "communist propaganda" but on the grounds of "separatism" by mentioning the existence of Kurds in the east of the country in a resolution adopted at its last congress.

"National Democratic Revolutionaries"

According to the "proletarian revolutionaries" opposing TİP, whose leading spokesperson was Mihri Belli (one of the former central committee members of the TKP), the revolution in Turkey would be two-staged; the National Democratic Revolution (MDD) stage and the Socialist Revolution (SD) stage were separate from each other. Turkey was politically and economically dependent on Western imperialist states, primarily the USA, and the remnants of feudalism were hindering socio-economic development. The first task of revolutionaries should be to ensure national independence and to eliminate feudalism. The establishment of socialism was a later goal. Belli first developed these views in the summer of 1966 in *Yön* magazine, and after 1968 in *Türk Solu* and *Aydınlık* magazines. According to Belli, besides the comprador bourgeoisie, there was also a national bourgeoisie in Turkey; even if it could not be made to join the MDD, at least it could be neutralized. The Kemalists were representatives of the national bourgeoisie.

Belli directed two fundamental criticisms at the TİP leadership: 1) By confusing the MDD and SD stages, it was alienating important allies from the movement. 2) Coming to power through peaceful and democratic means was an illusion. TİP's program was only compatible with MDD goals. Belli saw no difference between Aybar and the Aren-Boran leadership, speaking of the "opportunist Aybar-Aren clique." The MDD supporters, on the other hand, supported the invasion. Belli argued that the Kurdish question (that is, the

question of the suppression of Kurdish citizens' identity rights) would be solved when MDD was achieved and equal rights were granted to all citizens of different origins.

Differences of opinion arose among MDD supporters who characterized themselves as "proletarian revolutionaries" on the question of who would lead the revolution. Belli initially (in the 1966-68 period) argued that the vanguard would be assumed by the "military and civilian intellectual stratum" (the fashionable concept of the time), which he characterized as "the most conscious section of the petty bourgeoisie," but later changed his views and adopted the view that the vanguard would be assumed by "the proletariat and poor peasants, the most revolutionary forces of society." His making this change was influenced by criticisms that he was engaging in "petty bourgeois tailism" by drawing closer to the views advocated by the magazine *Devrim* edited by Avcıoğlu. In the autumn of 1970, an attempt by Belli to establish a legal party "to lead the MDD" together with Hikmet Kıvılcımlı (a former TKP member) and his supporters, as well as the faction led by Mahir Çayan among leftist youth, came to nothing. Belli fled abroad after the March 12 intervention. After returning to the country with the 1974 political amnesty, he founded the Turkey Labor Party with his supporters in 1975, but the party was closed by the Constitutional Court on grounds of "separatism." Belli would pass away in 2011.

"The Junta Supporters": The Yön-Devrim Circle

The leftist group that was perhaps the most influential on Turkish politics in the 1960s was the current that published the magazines *Yön* (1961-67) and later *Devrim* (1969-1971). A narrow circle that included names like Mümtaz Soysal, İlhan Selçuk, and İlhami Soysal alongside Doğan Avcıoğlu acted as its spokesperson. It never claimed to become a broad-based movement, but the magazines it published had widespread influence among intellectuals. In its declaration published in its first issue dated December 20, 1961, signed by about 150 intellectuals, *Yön* magazine advocated the implementation of "a new and progressive type of statism." "New and progressive statism" essentially envisaged a planned public sector, a mixed economy system, and land reform. In 1962, the magazine pioneered the establishment of the Socialist Culture Association, which adopted the aim of advocating "Turkish socialism."

The *Yön* writers, especially Avcıoğlu, essentially advocated the following ideas: Turkey had gained political independence under Atatürk's leadership but had not gained economic independence. The path to economic independence, rapid industrialization, and development passed through an "anti-imperialist and anti-feudal national liberation revolution." Turkey should leave the NATO alliance and join the non-aligned movement. The current multi-party system served the power of "reactionary classes consisting of comprador bourgeoisie and feudal landlords" and prevented the necessary reforms from being made. For revolution, an alliance of progressive forces including the "vital forces," that is, the left wing of the military-civilian intellectual stratum, trade unionists, revolutionary youth, and the small and medium bourgeoisie, needed to be established. The vanguard of the revolution should be the military and civilian intellectual stratum. Avcıoğlu placed great hope in the Turkish army, which he saw as very different from the armies in the West and Latin America that served the ruling classes. The army,

composed of officers from poor families and committed to Kemalist principles, was one of the most important forces of the revolution. Revolutionary youth would play the leading role in the national liberation struggle.

Relations between TİP and *Yön* magazine were never friendly. Although some TİP executives initially supported the magazine, others opposed the establishment of the Socialist Culture Association. The Yön circle also opposed the socialist slogans that TİP began to use after the 1965 elections on the grounds that they alienated the progressive sections of the bourgeoisie from the revolution. TİP under the Aren-Boran leadership, on the other hand, saw the "Center-Left" movement in the CHP as the main rival.

Avcıoğlu ended the publication of Yön in 1967 and wrote *Türkiye'nin Düzeni* (Turkey's Order) (1968), one of the most influential books among intellectuals of that period. In October 1969, he began to publish *Devrim* magazine. With *Yön* magazine and *Türkiye'nin Düzeni*, the intellectual infrastructure of the "national liberation revolution" had been prepared, and now it was time for action to realize it. Avcıoğlu and his friends, together with officers of various ranks, longed for a left junta that would come to power through a military coup. They also secured the support of army and air force commanders. Revolutionary youth undertook the task of preparing public opinion for the coup through bombings, robberies, and kidnapping actions from the first weeks of 1971.

The junta known as the "Cemal Madanoğlu junta" planned to seize power on March 9, 1971. However, its activities were being closely monitored by MİT (National Intelligence Organization). The coup attempt came to nothing when two force commanders switched to the other side at the last moment after receiving information from MİT that they would be purged if the coup succeeded. Three days later, on March 12, 1971, the TSK (Turkish Armed Forces) high command declared martial law and had a government loyal to itself formed. In the atmosphere of repression following the kidnapping and killing of Israeli Istanbul Consul General Efraim Elrom on May 22, Avcıoğlu, İlhan Selçuk, İlhami Soysal, and some officers including retired general Cemal Madanoğlu (who had been a member of the National Unity Committee that seized power on May 27, 1960) were detained by martial law authorities.

The members of the "Madanoğlu Junta" remained in detention for a few months, but the military court decided on their release in 1973. What played a role in this was that an investigation of the coup attempt in all its details would have revealed that some force commanders had also been involved. Deniz Gezmiş, Yusuf Aslan, and Hüseyin İnan were tried by military courts on charges of attempting to abolish the constitution, sentenced to death, and executed in May 1972. Hasan Cemal, one of the managing editors of *Devrim* magazine, wrote the story of the March 9 coup attempt, which had remained covered up until then, with all its details in his book *Kimse Kızmasın, Kendimi Yazdım* (Don't Let Anyone Be Angry, I Wrote Myself) (Doğan Kitapçılık, 1999). Doğan Avcıoğlu dedicated the rest of his life to writing comprehensive works including *Türklerin Tarihi* (History of the Turks); he developed stomach cancer and passed away in 1983, when he was only 57 years old.

Political historian Mete Tunçay would make the following assessment about him in the article he wrote upon Avcıoğlu's death: "Avcıoğlu was a Revolutionary from the very

beginning. What he understood by Revolution was Turkey entering a socialist line through the intervention of a well-intentioned, progressive military junta. He experienced the denial of these expectations twice, but he did not give up or back down… He simply did not want to understand that Turkey was too developed to be taken further by an army intervention… It is clear, I think, that the military socialist regimes established in some African countries are not at all something to be envied for a fairly advanced country like Turkey. Doğan Avcıoğlu never accepted that being a democrat was a necessary, though not sufficient, condition for socialism. In this respect, he should be seen within the tradition of 'enlightened despotism' in the history of political thought. May God forgive his faults." ("After Doğan Avcıoğlu," *Yapıt*, Issue 47: December-January 1983, pp. 93-95.)

The revolutionary youth movement

During the 1966-71 period, youth organizations were an important part of the left movement. Fikir Kulübü was first established at Ankara University's Faculty of Political Science in 1956, by mostly conservative-leaning academics. However, from the mid-1960s onwards, it came under the domination of socialist-leaning youth and spread to universities in major cities. In 1967, the umbrella organization Fikir Kulüpler Federasyonu (FKF - Federation of Ideas Clubs) was established. FKF members initially consisted almost entirely of TİP-leaning university students, but from 1968 onwards, the SD (Socialist Revolution) - MDD (National Democratic Revolution) split was reflected in the organization's ranks as well. In January 1969, MDD supporters took over the leadership of FKF and expelled the others from the organization. At its congress in October 1968, FKF took the name Devrimci Gençlik Federasyonu (Dev-Genç - Revolutionary Youth Federation). Members felt an affinity for Marx, Engels, Lenin, Stalin, Mao, Fidel Castro, and Che Guevara alike.

Students belonging to Dev-Genç eventually split into two main currents. The first sought the magic formula that would bring the revolution in books, while the second sought it in "revolutionary action." Under the influence of the international climate of the second half of the 1960s, the first were mainly inspired by the literature of the Proletarian Cultural Revolution in China, while the second were inspired by Latin American revolutionaries. (See Igor P. Lipovsky, *The Socialist Movement in Turkey: 1960-1980*, Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1992.)

"Proletarian Revolutionaries"

A group of young people, former TİP members who adopted the MDD strategy, began to publish the monthly magazine *Aydınlık Sosyalist Dergi* (ASD - Enlightenment Socialist Magazine) from November 1968. The founding editorial board of the magazine included Doğu Perinçek, Şahin Alpay, Erdoğan Güçbilmez, Atıl Ant, Gün Zileli, Oral Çalışlar, and Cengiz Çandar. The ASD circle later merged with the circle around the magazine "Türk Solu," which Mihri Belli and his friends had begun publishing in Istanbul some time earlier. Vahap Erdoğdu, Seyhan Erdoğdu, and Münir Aktolga joined the editorial board representing the Mihri Belli circle. However, differences of opinion emerged between the ASD circle and the Mihri Belli circle due to different assessments regarding the attitude

to be adopted toward Mao Zedong Thought and the political line represented by *Devrim* magazine. The magazine's editorial board split in two in October 1970. Since the publishing license was under Münir Aktolga's name, the magazine came under the control of Belli supporters in January 1971, while the other editorial board members (later joined by Halil Berktay) began to publish the magazine under the name *Proleter Devrimci Aydınlık* (PDA - Proletarian Revolutionary Enlightenment).

There were also different views among the youth in PDA ranks. After intense debates, Maoist ideology was generally adopted. In its January 1971 issue, the magazine declared that it adopted Marxism-Leninism-Mao Zedong Thought as its guiding ideology. A group from the magazine circle founded the illegal Turkey Revolutionary Workers' and Peasants' Party (TİİKP) in May 1969. After the March 12, 1971 military intervention, while a group from this circle was sent to Palestinian Resistance Movement camps for military training, some sought to settle in rural areas among peasants, and others began to publish an underground magazine called *Şafak* (Dawn) in cities. TİİKP members also split in late 1971 among groups directing accusations of "opportunism, revisionism, tailism" and other charges at each other. The faction led by İbrahim Kaypakkaya split off and founded a party called the illegal *Turkey Marxist-Leninist Communist Party (TKP-ML)* and its armed wing, the *Turkey Workers' and Peasants' Liberation Army (TİKKO)*. By the end of 1972, members of all groups on the Mao line were arrested by security forces and imprisoned. Kaypakkaya died under torture in May 1973.

Turkey People's Liberation Party-Army The group of young people gathered around *Aydınlık Sosyalist Dergi* and dominating Dev-Genç, led by Mahir Çayan, Ertuğrul Kürkçü, Yusuf Küpeli, and others, remained attached to Mihri Belli for a while but then split off and began to publish a magazine they called *Kurtuluş* (Liberation). Roughly speaking, organizations that took the armed revolutionaries in Latin America as their model, focoism in its different branches (THKO) and urban guerrilla (THKP-C), engaged in armed actions. Mahir Çayan from the THKP-C group, Dev-Genç president Ertuğrul Kürkçü, and those with them (Hüdai Arıkan, Cihan Alptekin, Nihat Yılmaz, Ertan Saruhan, Ahmet Atasoy, Sinan Kazım Özüdoğru, Sabahattin Kurt, Ömer Ayna, Saffet Alp) kidnapped two British and one Canadian technician serving at the NATO base in Ünye on March 27, 1972. On March 30, 1972, they were surrounded by security forces in the village of Kızıldere in Niksar. When they refused to surrender, all except Ertuğrul Kürkçü were killed. Kürkçü remained in prison for 14 years until 1986; in the 2000s, he was elected to the TBMM (Grand National Assembly of Turkey) in the ranks of the *Halkların Demokratik Partisi (HDP - Peoples' Democratic Party)*.

Turkey People's Liberation Army (THKO)

The group of direct action youth led by Deniz Gezmiş, who stood out during the student demonstrations in Istanbul in the spring and summer of 1968, organized around the Devrimci Öğrenci Birliği (DÖB - Revolutionary Student Union). This group's views were close to the ideology of the *Yön-Devrim* magazines published by Doğan Avcıoğlu. In 1970, together with Hüseyin İnan and Yusuf Aslan, Deniz Gezmiş founded the Türkiye Halk Kurtuluş Ordusu (THKO - Turkey People's Liberation Army). THKO engaged in violent actions such as bank robberies and kidnappings aimed at creating public opinion

for the leftist military coup that the “Cemal Madanoğlu junta” planned to carry out on March 9, 1971. After the coup attempt failed, Gezmiş, İnan, and Aslan were captured and tried in a martial law court.

Sinan Cemgil, one of the group’s members, after the March 12, 1971 memorandum, went up to Nurhak Mountain near Elbistan with his friends and established a guerrilla camp. The group’s members, who had set out to raid the NATO Kürecik Radar Base, were surrounded by security forces upon a tip-off from villagers and were killed in the clash that broke out on May 31, 1971. Meanwhile, the sentencing of THKO leaders Gezmiş, İnan, and Aslan to death by the military court and their execution on May 6, 1972, represents the end of the revolutionary youth movement known as the ’68 generation.

SBF Student Union

Having drawn the general picture of the left movements that were suppressed by the March 12, 1971 military intervention above, I can now return to my own adventure in this context… I was aware that my candidacy for the presidency of the SBF Student Association as Fikir Kulübü’s candidate and winning the election meant the end of my plan to become a diplomat. After graduating in June 1967, I turned my attention to an academic career for a while. At that time, I was acquainted with and occasionally met with Mete Tunçay, who had become an associate professor at the faculty with his work *Türkiye’de Sol Akımlar 1908-1925* (Leftist Currents in Turkey, 1908-1925), and Alaaddin Şenel from the same department. Both were left-leaning faculty members. Nermin Abadan, who had recently become a professor, also showed me considerable warmth and counted me among her most successful students. Under these conditions, I thought I could become an assistant at the History of Political Thought chair headed by Yavuz Abadan.

When Yavuz Abadan passed away around the time I graduated from the faculty, Bülent Daver, who was an associate professor at the time, took over the chair. Daver, most likely in order to prevent a “registered communist” like me from entering, did not hold an assistantship examination that year despite there being a vacant position. He also gave hope for a while to Ömer Madra, who graduated a year after me and was, like me, “registered,” before giving up on holding an examination. Thereupon, Ömer took the examination for the International Law chair headed by the late Seha Meray and passed. Becoming an assistant at the History of Political Thought chair would eventually fall to Ümit Hassan (our classmate from Robert College), who was perhaps less “registered” than us and who suffered considerably under Daver.

One of the first things I did after being elected president of the SBF Student Association was to write an article, published in the newspaper *Akşam* in the “Thoughts of Thinkers” section right next to Çetin Altan’s column titled “What the Devil Bids You See,” reflecting my ideology at the time, which was a mixture of Kemalist secular nationalism and TİP socialism. Cengiz Çandar entered the faculty in 1967, when I was a senior, and immediately joined Fikir Kulübü; his account of having been left “in awe” when Mahir

Çayan introduced him to me, under the influence of having read this article, would be quite a source of laughter between us years later.

One of the first acts of my presidency was changing the name of the SBF Student Association from “Talebe Cemiyeti” to “Öğrenci Derneği.” This was a requirement of our Kemalist advocacy of pure Turkish. During my presidency in the period after the 1966 summer break, I increasingly acquired a deeper Workers’ Party identity. The harmony in ideas ensured a smooth relationship between me and Fikir Kulübü president Mahir Çayan. (Mahir’s saying that he “sensed MDD sympathies” in my article published in *Akşam* was perhaps a sign of what was to come.) As the Fikir Kulübü majority on the SBF Association board of directors, we invited none but TİP leaders to speak at the faculty. Mehmet Ali Aybar, Çetin Altan, Behice Boran, and Sadun Aren spoke in turn in the large meeting hall. It was the year before 1968; boycott actions had not yet spread to universities. The first boycott took place at SBF in 1967, during my presidency of the association. We refused to attend classes in reaction to the faculty administration’s limiting the number of exams that could be taken before being expelled from school. Our dean, the late Prof. Dr. Aziz Köklü, was an extremely gentlemanly and soft-natured person. We ended the boycott in favor of students by cooperating with him.

What was expected from the association administration was, naturally, work aimed at meeting students’ needs. It was certain that the administration I headed was quite inadequate and unsuccessful in this regard. I had assigned myself entirely political tasks; I had left the conduct of the association’s other, normal functions to the other Fikir Kulübü member friends on the board of directors. Unfortunately, the result was that Fikir Kulübü’s candidate (Tuğrul Bayaz) lost the board of directors elections held in April 1967. We handed over the administration to the board headed by Uluç Gürkan, the candidate of the Center-Left group who won the elections.

Immediately after my graduation from the faculty in June, a public prosecution was brought against the administration I had headed, seeking 1-5 years’ imprisonment on grounds of corruption in the accounts. I remember feeling extremely ashamed of this and losing sleep over it. The case must have been seen as having a political dimension, as our defense was undertaken by the late lawyer Halit Çelenk, a person I loved and respected very much, who at that time handled revolutionaries’ cases. I was so happy when the white-haired judge found the evidence against us insufficient and gave an acquittal verdict in the case where the treasurer member and I were defendants…

A noteworthy event occurred in the autumn of that year. I had graduated and was unemployed. I enrolled in SBF’s graduate program. On this occasion, when I went to the faculty one day, I ran into Mete Tunçay. “Mete abi” told me that the Turkish Political Science Association had secured financial support from Americans for some translations, that in this context Karl R. Popper’s two-volume book *The Open Society and Its Enemies* would be translated into Turkish, that he would translate the first volume on Plato, and he suggested that I translate the second volume on Friedrich Hegel and Karl Marx. The only thing I knew about Popper in those days was that he was a thinker who criticized Karl Marx quite severely. Of course, I firmly rejected the proposal. How could “Mete abi” think I could endure such a humiliation?!.. This is one of the most ironic

events of my life. Because Popper would be the thinker who perhaps influenced me the most in my post-socialist period. Decades later, when *Taraf* newspaper asked, “Who is your hero?” I would unhesitatingly say “Popper”…

Doğu Perinçek and I

From the end of 1967, my friendship with Doğu Perinçek, who had a steadily rising profile within the revolutionary youth movement and served as FKF president from February to the summer of 1968, began to deepen. Through him, I met many Law Faculty members, including the late Uğur Mumcu and Ergun Özbudun, with whom my friendship has continued to this day. The first product of my growing closeness with Perinçek was two jointly signed articles published in the April 15 and May 15, 1968 issues of *Forum* magazine. *Forum* had begun to be published in 1954 by a group that included, primarily, Professor Aydın Yalçın and well-known professors of the time such as Bahri Savcı and Turhan Feyzioğlu, as well as politicians like Bülent Ecevit and Ziya Müezzinoğlu; professors like Cahit Talas, Muammer Aksoy, Şerif Mardin, Mümtaz Soysal, Sadun Aren, and Haluk Ülman had also begun to contribute to the magazine after a while. The intellectual father of the magazine, Aydın Yalçın, had joined the Hürriyet Party formed by those who left the Democrat Party due to its turn toward authoritarianism, and after May 27, the Yeni Türkiye Party, one of the parties established to replace the DP; he was an academic who was not at all acceptable in Mülkiye circles due to his liberal tendencies or anti-left views.

Forum magazine, which had lost the influence it once had in the mid-1960s, had tilted toward the left through a process of which I know nothing. The one who invited us to write there was the poet Hasan Hüseyin Korkmazgil (1927-1984), whom I had met in TİP ranks and who took on first the art and then the general editorship of the magazine from 1968. Our jointly signed articles with Doğu Perinçek published in *Forum* were the first signs of our turn toward becoming MDD supporters. It was also I who introduced Doğu to Mihri Belli, whom I had met during my visits to the Sol Yayınları (Left Publications) office. We had now come to give credence more to the biweekly *Türk Solu* magazine that Belli and his supporters had begun to publish in Istanbul than to *Yön* magazine.

In the article titled “The first step toward alliance” published in the May 15, 1968 issue of *Türk Solu*, written by me, the following was said:

“The May 27 revolution is, without doubt, a movement of the secular and democratic Turkish bourgeoisie against the power of the Imperialism-Comprador-Landlord alliance of 1950, which came out of the ballot box and abolished our country’s independence and surrendered our people to imperialism. It is obvious that the 1961 Constitution brought by the May 27 revolution… is an obstacle to the Imperialism-Comprador-Landlord alliance that the counter/revolution has reinstalled in power through the ballot box, and that it has allowed the development of anti-imperialist and democratic forces in Turkey… The task before *socialists* (italics mine: we are not yet speaking of socialists or revolutionaries) is to unite all national and democratic forces… that will realize the establishment of a national democracy in Turkey. In light of this task, in the current revolutionary stage, the closest allies of *socialists* are the military-civilian intellectual

stratum who have demonstrated with all their behavior that they are the greatest obstacle to imperialism." (p. 3)

These lines reflected well the mindset I held in those days, one that would soon undergo rapid change. According to our understanding at that time, the May 27, 1960 military intervention was the secular and democratic Turkish bourgeoisie's challenge against the reactionary alliance of imperialists and domestic collaborators. With the 1965 elections, the alliance of reactionaries had come to power again. The task falling to "socialists" was to unite the forces that would realize national democracy; their closest allies were the "military-civilian intellectual stratum" (represented by the *Yön* magazine circle).

My articles published in leftist magazines were increasingly drawing me into the "revolutionary" movement in my public life. Developments in my private life, however, were in a very different direction.

Elvan is coming

Fatma had become pregnant in a way we had not really planned; she was expected to give birth at the beginning of April 1968. I had no objection to having a child, but I desperately needed a job and income. Refet Erim, the secretary general of TÜBİTAK, was the brother of my classmate Feryal from Mülkiye (who would marry my classmate Emiri Mikelay from EHSB). Through Erim, whom I had met in Ayvalık where he spent his summer vacation with his family, I started working at TÜBİTAK at the beginning of March as a "researcher" with a meager salary. This was the first job I ever held for a wage.

I shared an office with Gülören, the wife of Uğur Cankoçak (the late trade unionist, one of Mehmet Ali Aybar's close friends), whom I had met in TİP ranks. During the three months I worked there, Cankoçak, who dropped by frequently, and I had plenty of conversations about socialism. Interestingly, through them I met Erdoğan Teziç there, who was then still an associate professor and would later become rector of Galatasaray University and president of YÖK (Council of Higher Education). Those who hired me knew that for me, with quite a good education by Turkish standards, this would only be a temporary job. I, too, had my eye on finding a job at a university.

Our daughter Elvan came into the world a few days earlier than expected, at noon on March 31, 1968. Since my mother and mother-in-law, who had come to Ankara to welcome the birth, and my elder sister Olcay, who lived in Ankara, had gone to a women's matinee at a nightclub, I was the only one with Fatma during the birth. When the nurses brought our baby to the room where I was waiting excitedly, I spent a long time alone with her. My daughter was the most beautiful of all the babies I had ever seen; she was a living synthesis of my beloved and me. I had become a father under conditions where my future showed great uncertainty. I cannot forget the happiness I felt that day, despite my anxieties about the future… When I went out to the street to get the news to my mother and mother-in-law, I ran into Cengiz Çandar face to face. Cengiz, my close friend with whom I would share many things, was the first to visit Fatma and Elvan at the hospital. Later, I ran to the apartment of Nuri Çolakoğlu, with whom I was then inseparable, on İzmir Street to give him the news. Nuri was not home. I wrote a note and

stuck it on the door: “Fatma gave birth to a girl!..” Nuri would keep this piece of paper for years.

Shortly after her birth, Elvan developed jaundice. Despite all of Fatma’s objections, I insisted on showing Elvan to Dr. Sevim Belli, a pediatrician and Mihri Belli’s wife. (Apparently Fatma prioritized professional competence, while I prioritized ideological competence…) When Mrs. Sevim said that the baby’s blood needed to be changed, Fatma (probably out of maternal caution) firmly decided to take the child to another, “normal” doctor. In the end, it turned out that a blood change was not necessary, and the jaundice, which is sometimes seen in newborn babies, passed on its own after a short time. A lesson was emerging from what we experienced: one should not confuse ideology with health.

The growing tension between my private life and my public life had now acquired a new dimension. I was in love with my wife and I also loved my newborn daughter very much, but the idea of dedicating myself to revolution was also increasingly attracting me. I was beginning to receive increasing signs that I was being dragged toward an impasse. Good news would come from Doğu Perinçek, who was completing his doctorate in those days. Doğu was trying to get me into the Law Faculty as an assistant, but there was a staffing problem there. Thereupon, Doğu introduced me to Prof. Dr. Bülent Nuri Esen, the head of the Constitutional Law Chair who also taught at the Faculty of Education; he also succeeded in convincing him to take me on as an assistant at the Constitutional Law and Human Rights Chair he headed at the Faculty of Education. Esen was at that time one of the Law Faculty’s staunch Kemalist professors who was opposed to the Justice Party and close to the CHP, and he was distinguished by his patronage of “left”-leaning academics. (I will tell the story of how he would disappoint me later.)

In May 1968, I started working as an assistant at the Faculty of Education; I was placed in the office of Esin Konanç, who would later become a professor and RTÜK member. Together with Perinçek, we founded a “Marxist Study Group” in which faculty members and assistants from the three neighboring faculties (Political Science, Law, Education) also participated. Among its members, I remember Erdoğan Güçbilmez, Türkkaya Ataöv, Cem Eroğul, Kurthan Fişek, Nuri Çolakoğlu, and Ömer Madra. Unfortunately, during the three years until May 1971, when I would be dismissed due to “absenteeism” and during which I increasingly acquired the identity of “professional revolutionary,” I made almost no contribution to the faculty. I cannot say that I felt any inner unease because of salaries I did not deserve on the grounds that I was working for “the revolution.” Meanwhile, I enrolled in SBF’s graduate program after passing the entrance exam in the autumn of 1967; in the autumn of 1968, I also passed the doctoral qualifying examination. The doctoral courses provided an occasion for me to come together years later with Rıza Türmen, whom I had known as “head boy” at EHSB. Mümtaz Soysal, who was then an associate professor, and I agreed that I would write, under his supervision, a doctoral thesis on “foreign schools in Turkey and their political effects.” However, this project would remain on paper.

Another important event for me in 1968 was being tried for “communist propaganda” because of a book translation. I continued to meet occasionally with Erdoğan Berktay

(who used the pseudonym Erdoğan Başar), one of the “old guard” whom I had met through Sol Yayınları and found very respectable. He was the father of Halil Berktay, who was two classes below me at Robert College and was studying at Yale University in the USA. He lived in Tandoğan, at an address close to our first home in Maltepe, with his wife Yegan Hanım, who was a very pleasant person. In those days, the distance between Erdoğan Berktay and Mihri Belli reflected the division among the “old guard”: Belli favored solidarity with the Yön circle, Berktay with TİP; but it was the former who was proving influential.

Mr. Erdoğan, who had left Sol Yayınları due to the same division and founded Anadolu Yayınları, had suggested that I translate Sartre’s book titled *Jean Paul Sartre Describes Cuba* (from the English translation titled “Sartre on Cuba”) into Turkish, and the book was published later that year. Our esteemed novelist Adalet Ağaoğlu was doing a program on TRT Radio at that time where books were also reviewed. At the beginning of 1969, she invited me as the Turkish translator and Türkkaya Ataöv, who was then an associate professor, as the commentator to the program where Sartre’s book was discussed. Some time later, a prosecution was brought over the program under Article 142 of the Turkish Penal Code, that is, on the charge of “communist propaganda.” The case resulted in acquittal some time later.

“Annus Mirabilis”

Another important event of 1968, which would later be called “Annus mirabilis / Year of miracles” and during which student and youth uprisings against the established order would occur in almost every corner of the world including Turkey, in the West and the East, was the decision that Doğu Perinçek—who was elected president of the Fikir Kulüpleri Federasyonu in March of that year but removed from the presidency in July because he stood close to the MDD line—and I made to publish a monthly theoretical magazine. Doğu, who probably thought of the magazine as a tool for the role he wanted to play in the revolutionary movement, suggested that its name be taken from “Aydınlık” (Enlightenment), which Şefik Hüsnü Değmer had published in 1921, as a reference to the tradition of the communist movement in Turkey. The first editorial board meeting of *Aydınlık Sosyalist Dergi* was held in late September at the home of Ergun Göknel, whose name was not mentioned in the magazine because he was doing his military service at the time, whom I had known as a few classes senior to me during my student years at EHSB, who had studied chemical engineering in Germany and returned to the country (who would later become İSKİ general manager, be tried on charges of corruption and serve time in prison).

In addition to Doğu and myself, Erdoğan Güçbilmez, a close friend of Doğu’s who was then an assistant with a doctorate at SBF, and Ergun Göknel attended the founding meeting. Later, students whom Doğu had met during his FKF presidency would also join the founders: Atıl Ant from the Ankara Law Faculty, Gün Zileli from DTCF, and Cengiz Çandar from SBF, as well as, presumably to emphasize the magazine’s pro-MDD character, Vahap Erdoğdu, known for his closeness to Mihri Belli, his wife Seyhan Erdoğdu who was an assistant at ODTÜ (who would enter the CHP Party Assembly in 2010 and rise to vice chairmanship), and ODTÜ student Münir Aktolga… Interestingly: In

those days, Doğu Perinçek and I were so close that I would say to Fatma: “I love and appreciate Doğu so much that if we ever fall out, I would be very surprised…” (In time we drifted so far apart that the like of it is rarely seen.)

The first issue of the magazine was published in November 1968, after a summer that was stormy for the left movement due to the boycotts at universities in the spring and then the debates that arose over the Soviet invasion of Czechoslovakia in August. With this magazine, we had drawn quite close to the MDD line. As the *Aydınlık* editorial board, we visited Mihri Belli at his home. Belli was very impressed by the cadre and expressed his satisfaction by saying “This is it…” (The “it” he meant was probably the hope that MDD would succeed.) As in the rest of the world, the Soviet invasion of Czechoslovakia had also caused differences of opinion within the left in our country. The most pronounced of these occurred within TİP ranks. The TİP leadership, which initially opposed the invasion collectively, soon showed signs of division. While Aybar openly opposed the invasion, Behice Boran and Sadun Aren adopted the opposite view. The invasion had also caused bewilderment within the *Aydınlık* editorial board. Since I had started paying attention to what was happening in China, it would not be long before I took a stance against the invasion.

In those days, I was both devoting myself intensively to reading leftist literature and also doing translations. The book *People’s Army, People’s War* by Nguyen Van Giap, the legendary commander of the Vietnam People’s Army, was published by Sol Yayınları in 1968. Also that year, I had done the translation of Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels’ *Communist Manifesto*, which was published by Bilim ve Sosyalizm Yayınları (Science and Socialism Publications), founded by Süleyman Ege. Probably because I didn’t have the courage to give my name as translator at that time, the pseudonym “M. Ardos” was used in the first book, and Süleyman Ege’s name was written as translator in the second.

My growing curiosity about Marxist-Leninist literature played a role in my approaching the MDD line. When I read Lenin’s book *State and Revolution*, I experienced the event (expressed by Orhan Pamuk in what has now become a cliched famous sentence) of “I read a book and my life changed…” Revolution could only succeed through the seizure of the state through armed uprising. I had now begun to see the socialism represented by TİP as a kind of “freshwater socialism”—tame and watered-down. Our ideas were rapidly changing, becoming increasingly radicalized. Years later, I would write about those days as follows: “The idea developing at Mülkiye was socialism. First Çetin Altan’s *Swedish and Kibbutz Socialism*, then Mehmet Ali Aybar’s *Turkish Socialism*… I discovered that the most genuine of these was Karl Marx’s socialism. For young people like me who knew foreign languages and were curious about reading, it was now time to discover the socialist literature that was forbidden (and therefore very attractive). Reading Lenin was a completely different experience. When I finished reading *State and Revolution*, I now considered myself a true socialist. I had found ‘the key to heaven on earth.’ Just at this time, the salvos of the Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution in China began to be heard in Turkey, and it was time to discover Mao. Some friends had discovered local syntheses of nationalism and Marxism, some had discovered Castro, Che Guevara, Focoism, Tupamaros.” (Milliyet, May 23, 1991.)

The SBF Foreign Relations Institute library was a rich treasure trove for leftist youth. It was possible to find many sources there, from the complete works of Lenin and Stalin to *Peking Review*, the English-language weekly publication of the Chinese Communist Party. However, the books of Mao, about which I had begun to feel great curiosity, could not be found anywhere. I think it was the spring of 1969; I wrote a letter to Mr. Wilson, the head of the American family with whom I had spent the 1961-62 academic year in the USA, to approximately this effect: “Dear Mr. Wilson, the books of Chinese leader Mao Zedong that I am very curious to read cannot be found in Turkey. I know that the Selected Works are published by Lawrance & Wishart Publishing House in New York. If possible, could you send me those books as this year’s birthday present?” The reply from Mr. Wilson was approximately as follows: “Dear Şahin, I am not of the opinion that there is anything worth reading in those books. However, since you want to read them, I am ordering them for you right away…”

Indeed, Mao’s 5-volume Selected Works was delivered to our door by the postman a few weeks later. I well remember how excitedly and curiously I took the books out of their packages and began to read them while underlining. There were two noteworthy aspects of this event: 1) Mr. Gordon Wilson, whom I had begun to see vaguely as a role model during the year I stayed with them, was a fairly liberal-minded American committed to the Protestant faith who generally voted for the Democratic Party in presidential elections. Although he did not approve of it in any way, he had not hesitated to send me the books, thinking that I had the right to satisfy my curiosity. (His wife Mrs. Mollie Wilson, although she generally voted for the Republican Party, would not refrain, in her later years, from participating in the anti-Vietnam War demonstrations held every weekend in the small town of Big Bear Lake where she lived.) 2) Thus, Mao Zedong Thought came to one of its first followers in Turkey through the USA, quite ironically.

Now that I had begun to read Mao at the original source, I was rapidly moving toward adopting both his theory of MDD as armed revolution based on the strategy of encircling the cities from the countryside under the leadership of the working class party, and his theses that the Soviet Union, which had failed to create socialist man, had turned into a bureaucratic dictatorship and was revisionist and social imperialist.

One of the important contributions to this during the winter of 1968 and spring of 1969 was my correspondence with Halil Berktay, who was then a senior at Yale, one of the leading universities in the USA. In this correspondence, we shared commentaries suggesting that the most advanced expression of Marxism-Leninism was found in Mao Zedong Thought. Our correspondence may have played a role in Halil’s decision to return definitively to Turkey in the summer of 1969, giving up his plan to do a doctorate at Yale (and his girlfriend, the daughter of a very beautiful and very wealthy American family, to whom he read Nazım Hikmet’s poems in spontaneous translation), despite his father’s opposition as far as I know. (Unfortunately, these letters were not preserved.)

That summer I introduced Halil to Doğu Perinçek. According to what Halil related years later, one of the first things Doğu said to him was “Unlike Şahin, we don’t openly take sides in the China-Soviet dispute, we adopt the Ho Chi Minh stance…” At that time, Mihri

Belli and his followers, that is, most of the former members of the communist party called “old guard,” had also adopted this stance.

Becoming an “MDD supporter”

From the spring of 1968, I had believed in the necessity that the socialist revolution in Turkey must first pass through the MDD stage. My first article as an MDD supporter was the article titled “What is the non-capitalist path?” which appeared on page 6 of the October 1, 1968, issue 46 of *Türk Solu* magazine, which Mihri Belli and his friends had been publishing in Istanbul for some time. In the article, I was saying that there was no debate that the path to be followed by socialists in countries with a “semi-colonial, semi-feudal” structure like Turkey was MDD, but that there were two different theses regarding the leadership of MDD: 1) I explained the “First Thesis” defended by Moscow as follows: “Revolutionary democrats” consisting of intellectuals and officers who had lost hope in capitalism would lead national liberation movements, and the revolution would follow a “non-capitalist path” leading to the industrialization of society and the quantitative and qualitative strengthening of the working class. This would give rise to an increasingly powerful working class power alternative against the power of these ‘revolutionary democrats.’” 2) The most important, distinguishing element of the “Second Thesis” represented by Beijing was that MDD must be based on the organizational and ideological leadership of the working class, not the “revolutionary democrats.” The guarantee of transition from MDD to socialist revolution lay here. Apparently, the second thesis seemed more convincing to me.

The section on the world in the article titled “The World, Turkey and Revolutionary Struggle” (pp. 1-17), which explained the views of the magazine’s founders and appeared in the November 1968 first issue of *Aydınlık*, was written by me. Like many of the editorials, this article was largely a joint production of Doğu and myself. The points that caught my attention when I read it about half a century later were: - In addition to the Soviet-China (and Albania) dispute in the socialist camp, the existence of those who did not take sides in this dispute (the parties of Cuba, Vietnam, and North Korea) was pointed out. (p. 6) - It was claimed that ideological disagreements among socialist countries did not affect fundamental policies, and, as an example that could be cited, it was mentioned that the liberation struggle in Vietnam was supported by both Moscow and Beijing. (p. 8)

- It was mentioned that Czechoslovakia had “come to the threshold of counter-revolution with a movement that began under the name of democratization” (p. 6); it was said that “the current that imperialists blessed as ‘liberalization in socialism’ was a counter-revolution contrived by revisionist Dubček and his cronies.” (p. 9)

All of this was a sign of the debate “Who is right: Moscow or Beijing?” which would continue for some time in Aydınlık ranks, or of the avoidance of taking a position on this issue. Although my own conviction strongly leaned toward Beijing, it was apparent that I was trying to accommodate the indecision in the ranks.

“We can only learn from books”

My first signed article in *Aydınlık* was titled “Revolutionary Theoretical Education” (Issue 2, December 1968). In the article, which listed the books that “scientific socialists” should read and which had a quote from Lenin placed at the beginning—“Without revolutionary theory there can be no revolutionary movement”—I said: “One cannot become a socialist without participating in the revolutionary struggle, but one can never become a socialist without knowing revolutionary theory. No one can call themselves a socialist without reading, without knowing scientific theory, without applying this theory to practice. What makes a person a socialist is not being of working class origin, but having adopted working class ideology, that is, scientific socialism. We can only learn scientific socialism from books. For this reason, we will read books (emphases in the text)… A revolutionary book is a revolutionary weapon. For this reason, today in China millions of people point to the book of scientific socialism as the most powerful weapon against all the weapons of imperialism…” (p. 146)

Continuing: “A class acquires the quality of being a class through the coexistence of two subjective and objective elements. The objective element of being a class is the place that class takes in the production process, its situation in terms of ownership of the means of production. For example, the proletariat, which has nothing to sell but its labor power and is employed by the capitalist in exchange for wages and exploited through surplus value, in this state possesses the objective element of being a class; in this state it is a class in itself. The proletariat only becomes a class for itself by adopting its own ideology, that is, scientific socialism, and only by acquiring this quality can it attain the power to turn the wheels of society forward. The proletariat that does not possess working class ideology cannot play its revolutionary role and remains under the political, economic, and ideological domination of the bourgeoisie and merely becomes a tail of the bourgeoisie.” (p. 148) “The working class movement is inconceivable without a cadre of socialist intellectuals, whether of working class or bourgeois origin, who will provide ideological leadership to the working class and are equipped with scientific theory. The development and success of the working class movement depends on the existence of a cadre of vanguard intellectuals who have organized ties with the working masses, who are in ideological solidarity with the working class, and who participate in working class action.” (p. 149)

This article pointed to the following matters that dominated my understanding at the time: 1) I was now speaking of “scientific socialism,” the socialism based on Marx and Engels’ “discovery of the laws of development of societies,” not of the socialism represented by TİP or any other kind; 2) By revolution I understood a Leninist one, that is, a revolution of the type that would violently, by force of arms, overthrow the bourgeois state through a popular uprising under working class leadership; 3) I was saying that there could be no revolution without intellectuals equipped with “scientific socialism” theory raising the consciousness of the working class and making them a class for itself; 4) I had come a long way in adopting Mao Zedong Thought: I was referring to the “Little Red Book” as “the book of scientific socialism”; 5) If, as Lenin foresaw, socialist consciousness was to be brought to the working class by intellectuals, I was emphasizing the need for serious intellectual preparation. I was complaining about the

inadequacy of “socialist consciousness” around me, especially among university students; 6) Probably to indicate the importance of people like me, I was strongly emphasizing the role of intellectuals in the revolution.

My article titled “19th Century Trade Treaties and Their Effects on Ottoman Social Structure,” published in the April 1969 issue 6 of *Aydınlık*, essentially developed the thesis that trade treaties made with Western states, starting with the 1838 Baltalimanı treaty with Britain, played a role in “the emergence process of Turkey’s semi-feudal, semi-colonial structure that has continued to this day without fundamental change.” When I read it about fifty years later, the main points the article indicated were as follows: 1) Doğan Avcıoğlu’s book *Turkey’s Order* had convinced me. I understood the process that began with the Tanzimat not as modernization but as a process of colonization. (After abandoning Marxism, the opposite would seem correct to me.); 2) Claiming that 1960s Turkey was in a semi-colonial and semi-feudal structure, as I did in this article, was an expression of trying to understand the country not through facts but through ideological clichés, by imitating analyses specific to other countries (China).

The editorial written by me titled “Let Us Steel the Revolutionary Ranks!” published in the October 1969 issue 12 of the magazine was like a harbinger of the splits that would occur among pro-MDD youth. I think the quote I made from Stalin’s book translated into Turkish as “On Right and Left Deviations” in the introduction of the article reflected my diagnosis about the source of the emerging differences of opinion: “…there is a long or short period during which one must work with all one’s might to convince the masses of the correctness of our policy. This period cannot be skipped. To think that this period can be skipped is foolishness. It can only be overcome and eliminated through patient political explanation and exposition conducted among the masses.” (Translated by: M. Ardos, Ankara: Sol Publications, p. 53)

In the article, I was criticizing the “left deviation” emerging among revolutionary youth, that is, hasty revolutionism (called “adventurism”) and the tendency toward violent actions, and I was saying: “In Turkey, the proletarian revolutionary movement is engaged in the struggle to raise the consciousness and organize the proletariat, the vanguard force of MDD.” This could be “a right deviation in the form of neglecting” the struggle, as well as “a deviation that appears to be ‘left’ but is essentially right in the form of engaging in actions that destroy alliances… *terrorist and anarchist actions disconnected from the masses* are not a deviation but directly individualist petty bourgeois revolutionism.” (p. 424)

In the same article, reference was also made to the basic argument I had developed in the article titled “The proletarian revolutionary line is the mass line” published a month earlier in the September 16, 1969 issue 96 of *Türk Solu* magazine: “The intellectual and youth segment of the petty bourgeoisie constitutes the main social source of both proletarian revolutionaries and Kemalist revolutionaries. The proletarian revolutionary movement is just beginning to take steps beyond being a movement of socialist intellectuals of petty bourgeois origin. Neither MDD nor the socialist revolution can succeed unless revolutionary theory is made the property of the masses. Making calls

for struggle in the sharpest form while the masses have not yet been made conscious is adventurism, a ‘left’ deviation…” (p. 6)

“Objective and subjective conditions”

In addition to my criticisms of “adventurist” actions “disconnected from the masses,” the “left deviation” emerging among revolutionary youth, the arguments I put forward in my article on Doğan Avcıoğlu’s book “Turkey’s Order” published in the October 1969 issue 12 of ASD, especially the thesis that the proletariat in Turkey did not have the conditions to lead the national democratic revolution, paved the way for a split in the magazine’s editorial board. Since it expresses my views at that time well, I quote at length from this article below:

“The national democratic revolution is a preparation for the socialist revolution. It is necessary to make a correct distinction between the national democratic revolution and the socialist revolution, and at the same time to correctly combine these two… National democratic movements only turn into a national democratic revolution after the leadership of the proletariat and its party is established. Because national democratic struggles conducted under the leadership of the petty bourgeoisie will not achieve lasting victories. The proletariat that provides leadership in the national democratic revolution will not stop halfway after the power of all national classes under the hegemony of the proletariat is secured, and will immediately proceed to the socialist revolution, relying on its own organized forces conscious of the necessity of revolution. If the proletariat has monopolized leadership in the national democratic revolution, consolidated the worker-peasant alliance, and the joint power of the national classes has been established, a peaceful transition to the socialist revolution will be possible. The bourgeoisie will not be strong enough to resist either politically or economically. The immediate task before the national democratic power in this transition period is to manage the progress from capitalist ownership to socialist ownership over the basic means of production through state capitalism. The transition period will end with the completion of the socialist transformation over the ownership of the basic means of production. After this, the stage of building socialism will begin…” (p. 463)

Continuing: “The socialist revolution is a process of revolutionary transformation in all political, economic, and ideological fields. In the political field, it is a process of consolidating working class power. In the economic field, it is a process of transition from private ownership to collective ownership, to large-scale socialist production. In the ideological field, it is a process of relentless struggle against bourgeois ideology, bourgeois habits, and bourgeois culture. Until the victory of the socialist revolution in the ideological field, that is, until the completion of the socialist revolution in the superstructure as well, it is not certain whether socialism or capitalism will ultimately prevail…” (p. 464)

The question of leadership in revolution

Continuing: “In Turkey, the proletariat today does not fully possess the objective and subjective conditions to lead the revolution. The main task of proletarian revolutionaries

today is the struggle to bring the proletariat to these conditions. This is the essence of the proletarian revolutionary line. Why is the proletariat not in a position to lead the revolution today? The objective conditions that the proletariat must have in order to gain leadership in the revolution are as follows: First, the proletariat must exist as a class, that is, as a mass of proletarians who have nothing to sell but their labor power. It must be concentrated mainly in the industrial field where large-scale capitalist production takes place. Only in this way will it be able to acquire the conditions necessary for organizing and coming under discipline. All ties with the peasantry and private property must be completely severed.

“However, the Turkish proletariat today is mostly semi-proletarian in character. The existence of the working class’s ties with the peasantry constitutes an advantage in terms of establishing the worker-peasant alliance that forms the basis of the revolutionary united front. However, its ability to take advantage of this depends on the existence of the subjective conditions for the leadership of the proletariat. The subjective conditions for leadership are: the vanguard section of the proletariat gaining class consciousness, that is, assuming the task of building socialism; fully grasping that the road to socialism passes through national democracy; organizing on the ideological basis of scientific socialism together with intellectuals who have adopted scientific socialism as a guide to action, and establishing the party that will lead the class and its allies. However, the Turkish proletariat today lacks these subjective conditions. Today, the conscious sections of the proletariat are still in the stage of economic struggle and are waging a democratic struggle so that the democratic rights that entered the constitution and laws through the struggles of the petty bourgeois military-civilian intellectual stratum can genuinely be exercised. Today, the Turkish proletariat lacks a vanguard party…” (pp. 464-465)

(Looking back from today, that is, from 2022, the above lines seem to me, although they cannot be accepted as a creative application of M-L-MZT, quite realistic and based on a concrete analysis of concrete conditions.)

Continuing: “Today in Turkey, the struggle of proletarian revolutionaries and the proletariat to gain leadership in the revolution is being waged. Under these conditions, Avcıoğlu’s statement that ‘At the present stage of development of our country, nationalist revolutionaries appear to be candidates for playing a leading role once again’ is not wrong, at least for a while. It is possible to influence the flow direction of class struggle, to chart its course, when we are in a position to guide the masses, when the masses have acquired political consciousness. We cannot give direction to the class struggle on our own, from where we stand, with the subjective intentions and wishes in our heads. The proletariat will not become the vanguard just because we want it to. Only if we work to give political consciousness to the proletariat and all national classes, if we can awaken the masses, if the revolution is based on the political consciousness of the masses, can the national democratic revolution succeed. Only if we wage the struggle to bring the proletariat to class consciousness can the proletariat attain the conditions under which it will lead the revolution.” (p. 465)

Continuing: “If we proceed from the concrete analysis of concrete conditions and do not deviate into idealism, we see that the military-civilian intellectual stratum will play an important role in the revolutionary movement in Turkey for some time to come. Even today, the main struggle nationwide is taking place between collaborators and this force. Proletarian revolutionaries are only just now, and mainly based on the youth movement, taking part in the struggle. Let us not exaggerate the opportunities provided to proletarian socialists by the youth movement being an important democratic force… let us not forget that we are still in the stage of the unorganized struggles of proletarian socialist intellectuals and let us keep our feet on the ground.” (p. 466)

Continuing: “We proletarian socialists struggle for the proletariat to gain class consciousness and thereby gain leadership in the revolution so that national democratic movements can turn into a national democratic revolution. This struggle cannot be accomplished without the vanguard party of the proletariat. For this, we will defend to the end the political, ideological, and organizational independence of the proletariat in the revolution…” (p. 474) “To leave the proletarian movement without organization, without a vanguard, to attach it to the tail of the petty bourgeois revolutionary movement, is in the final analysis not to be for complete and definitive victory against imperialism, to submit to imperialism, to compromise with it… The conditions for turning the proletarian movement into a mass movement in Turkey are increasingly maturing. The Left Kemalists must take this movement into account.” (p. 475)

Continuing: “Today, the struggle for both the proletariat and the petty bourgeoisie to attain their own parties is one of the main conditions for united action among revolutionaries… Those who argue that the national front can be established within a single ‘revolutionary party’ representing the revolutionary united action, by undermining genuine revolutionary united action, will have prepared the eventual defeat of the national front.” (p. 474) Avcıoğlu’s idea of “first revolution, then securing popular support ‘as soon as possible’ is idealist. Revolution can only be real if it is based on organized popular support, that is, on conscious masses… The belief that revolution can occur with the desire of a few people is the essence of all types of petty bourgeois revolutionism.” (p. 475)

My article ended with these sentences: “Proletarian socialists believe that revolution can only occur when the masses become aware of its necessity and voluntarily join the revolutionary struggle with the will and determination to achieve it. Therefore, we will patiently convey the correct ideas specific to the proletariat to the masses and struggle to make our movement a mass movement. We can only achieve success if we base the revolution on the masses, not on a handful of people, not on a few individuals. Let us make these principles, this mass line policy prevail in all revolutionary ranks, whether proletarian socialist or Kemalist. Then we can be sure that our revolution will reach victory.” (p. 477)

The following excerpts from the long two-part article titled “Why is the opportunism of Aybar and Aren the same?” published in *Türk Solu* issues 106 and 107, dated November 25 and December 2, 1969, shortly after issue 12 of *Aydınlık*, also help in understanding the views that dominated my mind at that time:

“All the opportunists, from Aybar supporters and Aren supporters to Küçükömer and Divitçioğlu, are of the opinion that the further one goes in hostility to the military-civilian intellectual stratum, the more ‘socialist’ one becomes. According to them, the authoritarian regime of the military-civilian intellectual stratum based on an army that fought a national liberation war against imperialism is fascism… any regime based on the army is fascism… democracy is the opposite of dictatorship… there can be no such thing as dictatorship of the majority, democratic dictatorship… Atatürk’s regime was authoritarian, but at the same time it was the power of the majority, the most democratic regime Turkey has experienced. The administration of the National Unity Committee was also authoritarian, but it was incomparably more democratic than the rule of imperialism and its collaborators, a tiny minority, represented by the reactionary-parliamentarist DP and AP…

“It is no coincidence that the views of the opportunists plaguing the socialist movement are also seen exactly in the rightist ideologues plaguing the Kemalist movement. We ask Ecevit and the like: are they also calling the Atatürk and National Unity Committee governments fascism like the opportunists? But they dare not openly accuse Him of fascism. They cannot, because in our country the strength of the forces committed to the cause of national liberation cannot be determined by looking at the seats in parliament. Atatürk is still today the symbol of revolution around which all national liberationists, whether socialist or Kemalist, rally… Whoever opposes this symbol of revolution today is in the final analysis in the camp of imperialism and collaborators.” (Issue 106, p. 10)

I was also writing the following about leadership in the revolution: “National democratic movements can only turn into a national democratic revolution with the realization of the revolutionary ideological, political, and organizational leadership of the proletariat… According to the Arenist opportunists, since the working class exists, it is ‘objectively’ the vanguard in the revolution. The objective existence of a class cannot mean that it automatically possesses class consciousness. Today in our country, the most conscious sections of the proletariat are in the position of a class fighting for economic and democratic rights, with the majority under the influence of the most reactionary ideologies; it has not yet risen to the position of a class for itself. To claim under these conditions that the proletariat is the vanguard in the revolution is to sweep under the rug the struggle that will bring the working class to the conditions of leadership, and objectively to oppose the leadership of the working class in the revolution.” (Issue 107, p. 11)

“The Eastern question”

One of the most interesting aspects of the article I quoted above is the section titled “The Eastern Question,” which generally reflects the Aydınlık circle’s view of the Kurdish issue: “Another possibility that cannot be ignored is that a reactionary Kurdish movement under the leadership of Kurdish feudal lords will be pitted against a revolutionary government through imperialist provocations. Both our own history and experiences in neighboring countries are sufficient to show this… Today, for all revolutionaries of Turkey, the struggle against both Turkish and Kurdish chauvinism is one of the important tasks of our national democratic revolution struggle. Because all the people of Turkey,

whether Turkish or Kurdish, are under the pressure of imperialism and feudal remnants, and the path to liberation is to stand shoulder to shoulder in the same struggle. The chauvinist tendencies widespread especially in the military cadres of the military-civilian intellectual stratum must definitely be eliminated through an intense ideological struggle. We must not allow imperialism to divide the people of Turkey!" (p. 476.)

My ideology at the end of 1969

As of the end of 1969, the views I advocated with the claim of applying Marxism-Leninism-Mao Zedong Thought to Turkish conditions, which are also reflected in the quotes I made above, may be summarized in the following points:

1) Turkey has a kind of capitalist social structure under the yoke of imperialism, semi-colonial in nature, harboring feudal remnants. It is under the domination of imperialism and its native collaborators, that is, the comprador bourgeoisie (intermediary to and partner in the country's exploitation by the imperialists) and the landlords.

2) In the absence of a bourgeoisie of national character, the petty bourgeois-origin military-civilian intellectual stratum that assumed its role liberated the country from the yoke of imperialism through the national revolution led by Mustafa Kemal Pasha and the Kemalists. However, the parliamentary democratic regime adopted in 1950 resulted in the collaborators of imperialism, that is, the reactionaries, seizing power. The May 27, 1960 military intervention objectively represents the resistance of the military-civilian intellectual stratum against the power of the reactionaries. The regime established by Atatürk was authoritarian, but democratic in terms of representing the interests of the majority; so is the National Unity Committee established with the May 27 intervention. Atatürk is the symbol of revolution around which all national liberationists, whether socialist or Kemalist, rally. (Atatürk's role in Turkish history is likened to the role played by Sun Yat-sen, who led the transition from empire to republic in China.)

3) Just like the 1920s, the 1960s are essentially the scene of the struggle of three political lines: Kemalists, Reactionaries, and Socialists. The Kemalists are divided into two wings: the national revolutionary Left Kemalists, whose spokesman was Doğan Avcıoğlu and who were represented by the magazines Yön and Devrim, and the opportunist parliamentarist Right Kemalists represented by Bülent Ecevit as spokesman in the CHP. At the current stage, the task of proletarian revolutionaries is to form a united front with the Left Kemalists against both the Right Kemalists and the opportunist, parliamentarist Socialists represented by Aybar and Aren.

4) The task of proletarian revolutionaries is, on the one hand, to maintain a relationship based on the principle of both friendship and criticism with the national revolutionary Left Kemalists, and on the other hand, to organizationally and ideologically build the working class movement and make it Turkey's main revolutionary, vanguard force. The guarantee of transition from MDD to socialist revolution lies here.

5) However, under present conditions, the working class does not have the objective and subjective conditions necessary to lead the revolution. Objectively, it continues to maintain its ties with the peasantry and has not been able to go beyond being a class in

itself. In terms of subjective conditions, it has neither attained scientific socialist consciousness nor has a vanguard party equipped with this ideology. Under these conditions, the Left Kemalists are candidates for playing a leading role in the revolution, even if temporarily. Just as not supporting the nationalist revolutionary movement on the grounds that the proletariat is not the vanguard is a kind of opportunism, so not working for the leadership of the proletariat and completely surrendering the revolution to the initiative of nationalist revolutionaries is another kind of opportunism.

6) For the working class movement to attain the consciousness and organization necessary to gain leadership of MDD requires revolutionaries to carry out patient and long-term construction work. Proletarian revolutionaries believe that revolution can only occur when the masses become aware of its necessity. For this, they must patiently wage the struggle to raise the consciousness and organize the masses. The concept of “mass line” expresses this. To flee from this work, to argue that there is a hasty, shortcut road to revolution, is a left deviation.

7) There is no Kurdish issue (referred to as “the Eastern question”) independent of the national democratic revolution, which is the common cause of Turks and Kurds. A reactionary movement to be led by Kurdish feudal lords incited by imperialists undermines the MDD struggle. Turkish and Kurdish revolutionaries should be in the same camp and should fight together against chauvinist nationalism and the chauvinist tendencies in the military-civilian intellectual stratum (Kemalist) ranks.

Looking back approximately half a century later, I can gather the main characteristics of the views I adopted in those years in the following points:

1) I was trying to directly apply the revolutionary theories developed for China or Third World countries with semi-colonial, semi-feudal structures to Turkey. Time would show how empty this effort was, how far removed from reality.

2) With the courage given by my youth and ignorance, I was belittling the efforts of Aybar, Divitçioğlu, Küçükömer, and even Avcıoğlu to understand Turkey’s unique class and power structure and to develop a unique revolution and socialism strategy.

3) My views were not without some realistic aspects either: a) During the import-substitution development period extending from 1962 to 1976, both real wages and support prices for agricultural products were on an increasing trend. There was no demand for (national democratic or socialist) revolution among the Turkish people. There never was later either. b) According to Marxist theory, the working class envisioned to lead the socialist revolution was quantitatively weak and maintained its ties with the peasantry, and according to the same theory, did not have the consciousness and organization necessary to make a revolution. In short, the observation that the working class did not have the “objective and subjective conditions” to lead the revolution within the context of said theory was not far from reality. c) Therefore, within the context of the same theory, my thesis that if Turkish revolutionaries or communists were to mobilize Turkish workers and peasants first for a national democratic, then a socialist revolution, this required a long-term, patient effort of consciousness-raising and organizing was also not wrong.

The stance of the majority in the Aydınlık editorial board (including myself) who acted independently of Mihri Belli against both the “left deviation,” that is, tendencies to form rural and/or urban guerrillas, and the “right deviation,” that is, Belli and his circle who seemed to have pinned their hopes on the success of the Avcıoğlu junta, in other words “juntaism,” drew the reaction of both groups targeted. The majority in Aydınlık began to be accused of “pacifism, revolutionary empty talk, revolutionary in words but conservative in reality.” The thesis I put forward that the “objective and subjective” conditions necessary for the working class to lead the revolution did not exist also began to be shown as the theoretical basis of the majority in Aydınlık’s “right deviation character, pacifism, tailism…” (The most detailed effort on this subject would be made by Mahir Çayan in the article titled “On the nature of the new opportunism,” which appeared in the 20th issue of Aydınlık Sosyalist Dergi, published in June 1970, 6 months after the split.)

Aydınlık splits

The emerging differences of opinion led to a split in the *Aydınlık* editorial board at the end of 1969. The trio of Vahap Erdoğdu, Seyhan Erdoğdu, and Münir Aktolga, who took a stance close to Mihri Belli, took control of the magazine by taking advantage of Aktolga’s having assumed ownership. The others, including myself, began to publish “Proleter Devrimci Aydınlık” (PDA - Proletarian Revolutionary Enlightenment) from January 1970. PDA was called “White Aydınlık” by its opponents in reference to its cover color, while ASD was called “Red Aydınlık.” “Red Aydınlık” was characterized by the majority publishing PDA as the publication organ of the “Unprincipled Unity Front” (consisting of “Adventurists” and “Tailists”). However, this “front” would also disintegrate at the end of 1970 when Mahir Çayan, Ertuğrul Kürkçü, Yusuf Küpeli, and Münir Aktolga took a stance against the Belli circle, which they characterized as “right deviation,” and left “Red Aydınlık.” (Çayan would explain the reason for their departure from ASD in a pamphlet titled “Open Letter to Aydınlık Socialist Magazine” published by Kurtuluş Yayınları in January 1971.)

The response of the PDA circle, and mine in particular, to Çayan’s accusation of “right deviation” was an article about 40 pages long titled “The Working Class and the National Democratic Revolution” (PDA, No. 3-17, March 1970, pp. 353-392). In summary, I was saying: “In the current period, there are essentially two wrong tendencies. One of these is the tendency that aims to keep our developing revolutionary movement within the limits of a youth movement, that cannot grasp the importance of establishing revolutionary ties with the worker-peasant masses and working among the masses, that cannot see that our main task is to raise the consciousness of and organize the worker-peasant masses… that gives a secondary place to political consciousness and ideological solidity among militants, and that tries to pass off the petty bourgeois ideology expressed in Regis Debray’s book (I mean *Revolution in the Revolution*) as scientific socialism…

“The second wrong tendency argues that the national democratic revolution can be achieved without the leadership of the working class and its party, takes the leadership of the working class to mean ‘the vanguard role of socialists,’ separates the democratic

revolution from the socialist revolution with a ‘Great Wall of China,’ relies primarily on petty bourgeois intellectuals rather than its own forces for the revolution, and sees the divergence between true Marxists and modern revisionists in our age as ‘a divergence over nuclear strategy.’ We must wage a struggle on two fronts against these wrong tendencies.” (pp. 354-355.)

With this article, I was also raising the banner of Mao Zedong Thought against “modern revisionism” in my own way: “In the period we are in today, proletarian revolutionaries are engaged in an intense worldwide struggle against modern revisionism, and Mao Zedong Thought has elevated Marxism to a brand new stage, to the stage of Marxism of our era in which imperialism is rapidly advancing toward a worldwide collapse and the forces of socialism are rapidly heading toward a worldwide victory…” (p. 355)

“Faced with the revelation that the views they defend are views that have been condemned in every theoretical-practical respect internationally, some circles that have panicked (especially meaning the Mihri Belli circle) want to prevent the international ideological debates from being known in our country and thereby prevent the level of consciousness in the ranks from rising. For this, they put forward the claim that the international debate is being used to create ‘an artificial split’ among revolutionaries in our country. There is a tight unity between the revolutionary struggles of the world proletariat and the Turkish proletariat. Without fighting against the wrong views that have emerged worldwide, there is no way to bring the Turkish proletariat to success. Every national democratic revolution struggle inevitably comes face to face with modern revisionism and cannot advance without purging it from its own ranks.” (p. 356)

In the same article, I explained the splits in the international communist movement with a diagram as follows: Proletarian revolutionary line = National democratic revolution = “Without party leadership, there can be no revolution… Working class leadership is necessary…” / Modern revisionist line = Non-capitalist path = “It would be good to have a party, but it’s okay without / Working class leadership is good but not necessary…” / Castro-Guevara-Debray line = Socialist revolution = With or without a party = The leader is the Foco representing the alliance among all the toiling classes. With this diagram, I was implying/claiming that in Turkey, PDA represented the proletarian revolutionary line; Mihri Belli and his circle the modern revisionist line; and Mahir Çayan and his friends the Focoist line. (p. 367)

Against the criticisms directed at my views on “objective-subjective conditions,” I also made this defense: “The objective reasons that delay consciousness-raising and organizing are not important from the perspective of our consciousness-raising and organizing struggle. It is a factor that needs to be taken into account in grasping the current level of consciousness and organization, but it is not important from the perspective of our practice, our action, our political line. We want to state this definitively.” (p. 373) Mahir Çayan would respond to this article of mine as well in the article titled “On the nature of the new opportunism” published in the June 1970 issue 20 of ASD, with arguments similar to those in his previous article.

The “old guard” who published *Türk Solu* magazine in Istanbul had initially taken a stance supporting PDA due to their reaction to the “adventurist-Focoist” circle following

the split in *Aydınlık*. Indeed, my article titled “The only consistent national liberationist current is the proletarian revolutionary current!” would be published in Türk Solu. (Issue: 123, March 24, 1970, pp. 8-10). In this article, I criticized Mihri Belli’s views, which I interpreted as surrender to “petty bourgeois radicalism,” as follows: “In Turkey, the army under the command of petty bourgeois radicals has until now been the executor of progressive movements and may be so in the future as well. But just because petty bourgeois radicals realized progressive movements by using the power of the army, proletarian revolutionaries cannot be asked to be militarist…” (Here I was referring to Belli’s call for proletarian revolutionaries “not to be anti-militarist” in his article titled “Turkey’s Reality” in issue 64 of *Türk Solu*.)

A topic that played a role, albeit secondary, in the split in ASD was the stance to be adopted toward “Mao Zedong Thought.” In the editorial board, Halil Berktay and I defended the Mao line. I was also pleased with parting ways with Mihri Belli and his circle, who adopted the “not taking sides” stance (characterized as the Ho Chi Minh stance) on ideological differences in the international communist movement. However, the majority consisting of Perinçek and others in PDA was not resolute on this matter. (Indeed, there was some truth in Cengiz Çandar’s statement, even years later, that “I was never a Maoist.”)

The first step toward the PDA circle accepting Mao’s thought at least in words was the article published on the occasion of Lenin’s 100th birthday, signed by the editorial board, titled “Living Lenin” (PDA, Issue: 4-18, April 1970, pp. 436-438). In the article, there was mention of “Mao Zedong, Lenin’s greatest follower, who has creatively developed Lenin’s thought in our time…” I had written the article, but because of this article, Çandar, who had assumed the managing editorship of the magazine, would be sentenced to 7.5 years in prison.

Hikmet Kıvılcımlı’s influence

After parting ways with Belli, it appeared that Perinçek had become anxious that we had broken from the tradition and entirety of the socialist movement, that there was no authority left to rely on. For this reason, every time he went to Istanbul, he would visit Hikmet Kıvılcımlı and make efforts to bring him together with the PDA movement. The attitude to be adopted regarding Kıvılcımlı’s ideology would lead to tension between Perinçek and me, and gradually to my loss of confidence in him.

The first event in this context occurred on the evening of May 22, 1970. Mustafa Kuseyri, one of the SBF students, was accidentally shot and killed by his close friend Nejat Arun while playing Russian roulette. The incident, which showed how dangerous familiarity with weapons was becoming, was covered up by revolutionaries with the claim that “fascists killed him,” and Arun disappeared. On that tragic day, Nuri Çolakoğlu and I were in Antalya, where we had gone for a weekend getaway with our wives. We were shaken by the news of the death of Kuseyri, a friend we loved dearly. The day after Kuseyri’s death, a “Respect for the Constitution” march was organized in Ankara to condemn fascism; many faculty members from the SBF and Law faculties participated in the march. (Hasan Cemal would relate the following about this incident in his book titled

“Let No One Be Angry, I Wrote About Myself”: “One of those who knew the inside story of the Kuseyri incident at that time was Doğu Perinçek. I will never forget, that day as the march was starting in front of the Law Faculty, he leaned toward my ear and said to me, ‘Is what you are doing acceptable?’; ‘It wasn’t fascists who killed Kuseyri…’”) However, neither Perinçek nor any other friend from the PDA circle told me the real story behind the incident. I would learn the truth that Kuseyri was accidentally shot by his friend while playing with weapons months after the incident.

Perinçek was not from a working class family. (His father Sadık Perinçek, a retired judge, had served as a member of parliament from Erzincan for the Justice Party.) In April 1970, he had married Sırma Ersanlı (Osman Ulagay’s ex-wife), with whom he had been friends for some time. Sırma could not be considered a working class child either. In short, there was no difference between us in terms of our class origins. However, the signs that Perinçek was beginning to see and characterize me as “an unreliable bourgeois” were increasing.

One evening in late summer 1970, at the apartment on Kızılırmak Street where we were living at the time, we met with Perinçek and a few friends from the editorial board—which ones, I can no longer remember. At one point Perinçek said: “If an illegal revolutionary party, a communist party had been founded, what would you do?..” I remember answering as follows: If a communist party had been founded, I would probably have known about it. On the other hand, I don’t think the revolutionary movement, consisting of some intellectuals and university students in Turkey, which has not yet reached the working people, has come to the stage of organizing… The second part of the answer reflected my sincere opinion. The view I also developed in my writings was this: For the revolution, the party of the proletariat is absolutely necessary, but for this, a long, patient construction work reaching the working masses needs to be done. The first part of the answer, however, reflected my naivety in the face of Perinçek’s cunning…

As I would learn later, Doğu and some friends from the editorial board had decided to establish a “Leninist party” after the split in the magazine and the break with the Mihri Belli circle, and had begun working in this direction. In the statement Perinçek gave to the police after his capture in the summer of 1972, he would say that he, Ömer Özerturgut, and I had founded the Türkiye İhtilalci İşçi Köylü Partisi (TİİKP - Turkey Revolutionary Workers’ and Peasants’ Party). The fact that Özerturgut was in Germany and I was in the Palestinian Resistance Movement at that time had led him, perhaps to protect the others, to speak this way. In reality, my becoming aware of TİİKP’s existence and my membership in TİİKP would come much later, after I began to be sought by security forces following the March 12, 1971 memorandum. My being invited to join the organization much later reflected the increasing mutual distrust between Perinçek and me.

Who is more revolutionary

The competition of who was more radical, more revolutionary among the revolutionary youth groups continued. An important development for the PDA movement in this

context was our coming into contact with the ideas of the monthly theoretical organ of the Communist Party of India Marxist-Leninist, “Liberation” magazine, and its leader Charu Mazumdar. Because this party, founded in 1967, had begun its first actions in the village of Naxalbari in the West Bengal region of India, the members of this movement were called Naxalites. The “Maoist” friends studying at Robert College’s upper division, especially Garbis Altınoğlu, had met an Indian student and begun avidly reading the articles signed by Charu Mazumdar (Charu Majumdar) in the “Liberation” magazines they obtained from him. They also delivered these magazines to me. I too began avidly reading Mazumdar and making translations of his articles to be passed from hand to hand. His article titled “Let’s make the 1970s years of liberation” that I translated was also published in PDA’s August 1970 issue, numbers 8-22. The article stated:

“We must prepare the material necessary for waging a revolutionary war. What is our war material? Is our war material dynamite, explosives, and firearms? Of course not. The essential material in a revolutionary war is human beings… Once people are equipped with revolutionary theory, that is, Mao Zedong Thought, they become thousands of atoms and Chairman Mao’s more powerful spiritual atom bombs… Comrades, a heavy responsibility rests on our shoulders. Let us overcome all hesitation and remember Chairman Mao’s teaching: True revolutionaries are those who voluntarily ‘shoulder heavy burdens.’ Think of our country’s poor and landless peasants and the limitless poverty, endless oppression, and crushing misery that have brutally crushed them for thousands of years and continue to crush them. Comrades, it is you who possess the magic weapon that will put an end to the exploitation and oppression that crushes them, that will bring happiness to tens of millions of our citizens—Mao Zedong Thought. Nothing can be more sacred and valuable than giving one’s life for this great cause, and we are fortunate to be among those who sacrifice everything for this great cause. This is why we are Communists, followers of Chairman Mao. The war of annihilation launched by our party and led by the poor and landless peasants must be advanced toward the goal of establishing Red political power in various regions, and this war must spread to all provinces and all of India. Thus, the poor and landless peasants will gain self-confidence, become politically conscious, and develop their creative powers through guerrilla warfare.” (pp. 334-335.)

The method Mazumdar proposed for communists was, in summary, this: Revolutionary intellectuals would “proletarianize,” purify themselves of all their bourgeois aspects, melt into the poor and landless peasants, become one of them, and together with them lead the revolution that would advance through the annihilation of class enemies, that is, landlords and rich peasants. Firearms were not needed to annihilate class enemies; weapons like knives, arrows, spears, and so on were sufficient. The use of vehicles like automobiles, tractors, and trucks on roads would be strictly avoided; one would walk. The landless and poor peasants would become politically conscious through this war of annihilation and be equipped with Mao Zedong Thought…

In short, the Naxalites proposed a quite violent, brutal class war. It may be hard to believe, but the Naxalite movement that Mazumdar (1918-1972) started has managed to survive to this day and spread to some regions of India, although it has remained quite marginal. It may be hard to believe today, but the path to revolution that Mazumdar

proposed seemed quite logical to me in those days. However, I thought that a long preparatory period would be needed to make revolution in Turkey through this method, that is, by annihilating class enemies in rural areas using weapons other than firearms. But Mazumdar was right: To proletarianize, to purify oneself of all bourgeois aspects and habits; to dedicate oneself entirely to the revolution was the indispensable condition of being a revolutionary.

The Mazumdar thought that I was pioneering the spread of was leading me into an ever-growing dilemma: The tension between my public life and my private life was increasingly growing. How was I going to make revolution while continuing to live like a bourgeois? The conflict between my increasingly radicalized understanding of revolution and the ideal of dedicating myself entirely to the revolution on one side, and my great love and attachment to my wife and daughter on the other, was preparing the ground for the decisions I would have to make in the near future.

The publication of one of Mazumdar's articles that seemed publishable in Turkey of those days was a step toward the acceptance of Mao Zedong Thought by the PDA circle. I remember placing on the last page of the magazine this quote from Mao, which I believed also reflected my own thoughts: "We must completely purge from our cadres the ideas that we can win easy victories through lucky coincidences without waging a hard and arduous struggle and paying for this struggle with our sweat and blood."

The real, serious sign of the adoption of Mao Zedong Thought by the PDA circle was reflected on the cover of the magazine's November 1970 issue, number 25. On the cover celebrating the magazine's entering its "Third Year," alongside the profiles of Marx, Engels, Lenin, Stalin, and Mao arranged side by side—which was then the symbol of Mao supporters—was this quote (which I found and translated from *Peking Review*): "Invincible Marxism-Leninism-Mao Zedong Thought is the powerful weapon of the proletariat for learning about the world, transforming it, and advancing history. When Marxism-Leninism-Mao Zedong Thought is fused with the hundreds of millions of revolutionary masses and with the concrete practice of people's revolution in all countries, it will bring forth the inexhaustible revolutionary power that will crush and shatter the entire old world. Then victory will belong to the peoples of the world."

"Down with Soviet Social Imperialism!"

Partly emboldened by the cover of PDA's November 1970 issue, Maoist-leaning friends, most of whom were studying at Boğaziçi University and İTÜ (Istanbul Technical University) in Istanbul, organized a meeting one day at the end of November at İTÜ's Gümüşsuyu campus. At this meeting, for the first time in Turkey, a poster with "Down with Soviet Social Imperialism!" written in large letters was hung on the podium. Shortly after I began my speech amid the protest shouts of THKO and THKP-C sympathizer militants in the hall, some were seen drawing their weapons and beginning to fire at the ceiling. It never occurred to me that things would go so far as killing me, but it became clear that it would be impossible for us to continue the meeting; we had to end the meeting and leave the hall. The incident was a sign of the extent to which Mao Thought was not accepted among revolutionary youth.

In the days after the meeting was adjourned, some friends from our circle conveyed: When asked what he thought about the “Down with Soviet Social Imperialism!” slogan being chanted at the meeting organized at İTÜ, Doğu Perinçek had said “This is Şahin’s personal opinion, it doesn’t bind me…” When I returned to Ankara a few days later, I would see that Perinçek was sincere in this statement: The walls of the meeting room at PDA’s headquarters on Adakale Street were decorated all around with “Long Live Hikmet Kıvılcımlı Thought!” posters. It appeared that Perinçek, who had seemingly become anxious that the PDA movement had broken from the communist tradition after the split with Mihri Belli and his circle, had been in contact with Hikmet Kıvılcımlı in Istanbul for some time and had concluded that getting closer to him would benefit the movement. Indeed, in one of the last issues of PDA, an evaluation article on the program of the Vatan Partisi (Homeland Party), which Kıvılcımlı had founded, would be published with the signature of “Program Preparation Committee.”

As I mentioned before, I did not think that Kıvılcımlı had views different from Mihri Belli, nor that he expressed his ideas in an understandable language. The “Long Live Hikmet Kıvılcımlı Thought!” posters at the PDA headquarters had further eroded my already shaken trust in Perinçek. Under these conditions, I began to think that I could not continue to remain in the PDA circle. When Perinçek returned to Ankara, I told him that the Kıvılcımlı posters disturbed me greatly; that we needed to make a decision about which one to follow—Mao Zedong Thought or Kıvılcımlı Thought—and that I wanted an editorial board meeting to be held at the first opportunity for this purpose.

The meeting was probably held in the first days of December 1970.

Perinçek opened the meeting by stating that I had requested an evaluation of Kıvılcımlı and his ideas, and called on the board members one by one to explain what they thought on this matter. I don’t remember if all members of the editorial board were there, but everyone in the majority present took the floor and expressed positive views of varying degrees about Kıvılcımlı’s ideas. The one who went furthest in this matter and surprised me considerably was Halil Berktay. Banging his fist on the table, he said that Kıvılcımlı was the thinker who had made the greatest contribution to historical materialism, one of the main teachings of Marxism, since Friedrich Engels. I think the thought that Halil had assumed the role of a kind of “Doğu’s Suslov” first crossed my mind there. (Mikhail Suslov was the party ideologue who supported the policies of Soviet Communist Party leaders, especially Leonid Brezhnev, with fatwas taken from Marxist-Leninist literature.)

When my turn came to speak, I said that I did not agree with Kıvılcımlı’s views in any way, and that if the PDA movement was determined to follow these views, there was no reason for me to remain there. Perinçek had the last word and said the following: “Democratic centralism applies in our movement. Everyone has the right to express their opinion. We may all be wrong, only one of us may be right. Şahin is one of the founders of this movement and his departure from among us is unthinkable…”

“Mao! Mao!”

I felt that we were heading toward a period full of uncertainties. It was becoming clear that the Avcıoğlu junta would attempt a coup in the near future. I did not know what kind of developments this would lead to, but it was very clear that extraordinary days awaited Turkey. Perinçek had not won me over with his words at the last meeting, but there was nowhere I could go after leaving PDA. I no longer trusted the circle I was with, especially the person in the leadership position, but I was committed to the idea of revolution. Whatever was going to happen would happen… At that time, I poured out my troubles about the situation to Erdoğan Güçbilmez and Ömer Madra, the two friends I saw as closest to myself in Ankara. Their trust in Perinçek had also been shaken. (Indeed, Güçbilmez went to military service, hoping he could escape the trouble that was felt to be approaching, but it didn’t work; after March 12, they would arrest and imprison him while he was doing his military service.)

Perinçek and his friends’ “flirtation” with Hikmet Kıvılcımlı was of necessity short-lived. Because Kıvılcımlı, just a few days after the PDA editorial board meeting I mentioned above, in his article titled “Mao! Mao!” published in ASD on December 15, 1970, mocked those who advocated Mao’s ideas and said the following: “To pretend to be a Maoist in Turkey today is to confuse Turkey with the Ottoman Empire that was 50 years behind…” (In truth, he might have been right about this.) Kıvılcımlı did not stop there; in his article titled “The army has drawn its sword!” published on March 13, 1971, just one day after the TSK High Command issued its memorandum to the Demirel government on March 12, 1971, he called on the army to seize power directly.

A few weeks after the March 12 memorandum, Ferit İlsever, one of Doğu Perinçek’s most trusted friends, said he wanted to meet with me privately. We met. He said that our movement had established a party named TİİKP, and that he had been assigned the task of “organizing” me into this party. Without asking whether I wanted to become a member, he informed me that a cell had been formed consisting of me along with student friends named Abdurrahman Taşçı and Serhat Hürkan, and that I had been appointed cell secretary. İlsever, when we met I believe the day after May 22 when Prime Minister Nihat Erim announced that “Operation Sledgehammer” would be conducted against leftist organizations, informed me that our assignment location would be Çukurova, that I had been assigned as the party’s regional coordinator, and that we needed to proceed to the assignment location as soon as possible. Our mission was to settle among the region’s poor peasants and raise their consciousness and organize them on the path of revolution.

I did not believe in the slightest that a communist party consisting of a handful of intellectuals and students could be established, or that such a party could make revolution. As certain as I was that a long period of consciousness-raising and organization was needed for this, I believed in revolution. Even though I did not know Çukurova at all, had never gone there before, there was nothing to do but try to accomplish the given task. I don’t remember what excuse I made up for Fatma, but saying I was going on a trip for a few days, I kissed her and my daughter Elvan and left home. I did not know whether I would be able to return home again.

“What is this kid doing among you?”

On April 20, we met with my cell comrades and set off for Adana. After staying in Adana at an inn where porters usually lodged for 1 lira per night (in 1971 values), we headed to the Çukurova villages. Abdurrahman, assuming we might receive a warm welcome there, first suggested we go to Yenice village in the Karataş district where Yılmaz Güney’s family had migrated from Siverek and settled. We did so. We found Güney’s father. The old man we spoke with in a coffeehouse under the curious gazes of the villagers asked what we were looking for there. We began to play the role we had decided on beforehand: I was an assistant at Ankara University Faculty of Education and was conducting research on the sociological structure of Çukurova. Those with me were university students helping me. I was twenty-seven years old, and my circumstances and appearance suited the role quite well. It was certain that Abdurrahman also looked like a university student, but Serhat, who was perhaps only in his first year of university at the time, looked at most 16-17 years old. Güney’s father asking “What is this kid doing among you?” would later make us burst into laughter… The situation was clear; it would not be possible to settle in that village. It was evident from their every manner that the villagers were very uneasy.

This time we headed to the mountain villages to the east of Karataş. According to Abdurrahman, the chances of finding shelter there might be greater. In the first village we reached, the villagers did not find the story we told very convincing. They said they knew the gendarmerie was after revolutionary youth; they could only host us for one night on the condition that we leave the next morning. They offered bread, bulgur pilaf, and ayran. I could hardly sleep that night. There was a full moon in the sky. Looking toward the plain, one could see night lamps or candles burning everywhere among the crops. We would learn that the villagers were collecting snails to be exported abroad.

The next morning, we set off without really knowing where we were going. After walking quite a bit, we took a break near a village, in a place like a sheepfold. Loud radio sounds were coming from the sheepfold where MHP posters were hung. The date was April 26, and the radio was announcing that martial law had been declared in 12 provinces, primarily Ankara, Istanbul, and İzmir. I panicked… I told my cell comrades that it would be good for us to return to Ankara as soon as possible, otherwise the gendarmerie would catch us. Abdurrahman said he saw no reason to return to Ankara; he implied that he saw my attitude as defeatism. I swallowed it. We began walking toward Karataş. Behind us, a tractor driven by a villager was coming. I suggested to my friends that we ride this tractor to the nearby village. Abdurrahman refused very firmly. Referring to the Mazumdar literature, he reminded us that revolutionaries could under no circumstances make use of motor vehicles… I had fallen into the pit I myself had dug: So you’re the one who translated and spread Charu Mazumdar’s teachings!… I couldn’t help but laugh inwardly. Worried that I would be accused of treachery if I insisted on getting on the tractor, I kept silent; the tractor passed by us, and we continued walking.

From Karataş to Tunceli

It soon became clear that the first thing the villager driving the tractor did was to alert the muhtar (village headman). For when we reached the village named Kızıltahta, we saw that the muhtar was waiting for us with a large group of villagers, shotgun in hand. They sat us in a coffeehouse and surrounded us. Our story of conducting sociological research did not seem convincing to the muhtar in the least. He merely said that according to the instructions they had received, they were obligated to report suspects to the gendarmerie. After a while, two gendarmerie NCOs arrived in a jeep, took us, and brought us to the gendarmerie station in Karataş. I don't think the gendarmerie commander there believed our sociological research story either, but when he couldn't find our names on the list of those wanted by martial law despite all his searching, he released us a few hours later.

From Karataş, we went by bus (Abdurrahman no longer objected) directly to Tarsus. There, in a house, as I remember, we met with friends from the PDA circle, primarily Ferit İlsever and Oral Çalışlar. Ferit, my boss within the organization, gave us the order to make our second attempt at settling in villages in the Pazarcık plain of Kahramanmaraş. We headed there. Unfortunately, our Pazarcık adventure also yielded no results. Upon hearing news that villages where revolutionary youth went were being raided by the gendarmerie, after being able to shelter for only one or two nights in villages where it was clear we were unwelcome, we returned to Tarsus, the regional headquarters (Oral Çalışlar's hometown). Ferit gave us the order to make our next attempt in the villages of Dersim/Tunceli.

Since Serhat had left us, we continued on with Abdurrahman. When we arrived in Tunceli center on May 6, we could feel that the atmosphere was not very favorable for going out to the villages. We learned the location of Kurdish writer and politician Kemal Burkay's house. Mr. Kemal, whom I knew from the TİP ranks, bless him, hosted me in his home that night despite all our "ideological" disagreements. He advised us that Tunceli was not at all safe and that we should leave there as quickly as possible. As soon as I left Burkay's house in the morning, I was surrounded by plainclothes police and taken to the Police Directorate. The police also brought Abdurrahman, who had been staying at a hotel that night, shortly after.

For the Police Chief, I adapted the sociological research story to Tunceli. It was obvious that the Chief did not find the story convincing, but like the gendarmerie commander in Karataş, when he couldn't find our names on the list of those wanted by martial law, he directly called the Ankara martial law command. When he couldn't get any information from there that we were wanted either, he released us, admonishing us to return to Ankara as soon as possible. He would very much regret this a few days later, for in the first wanted list of 19 people announced by the Ankara Martial Law Command a few days later, that is, at the end of May, I was also on the list along with Doğu Perinçek from the PDA group and Erdoğan Güçbilmez (who had left the movement in November 1970 and decided to go to military service).

We returned to Ankara. I went straight home and embraced Fatma and Elvan. Fatma had grown quite cold toward me; she sensed that our life together was nearing its end. She had adopted an indifferent attitude to what we were experiencing. The situation was very different for me: I was attached to my wife and daughter with all my heart, but a fate I could not control was taking me away from them. On the one hand, I was committed to the idea of revolution and socialism; on the other, I saw the country as very far from revolutionary conditions. Moreover, my trust in the people I was acting with had been greatly shaken. I was aware that we were being dragged toward an impasse. I no longer had any chance of escaping from this. I would go wherever fate took me.

Elvan was three years old. I was not a loveless or conscienceless father. On the contrary, not knowing when I could be together again with my wife and daughter whom I loved so much was deeply painful. A great weight had settled on my heart. At that time, we were living in a flat in the Çim Apartmanı building on Tunus Avenue. Fatma had sold the three-story house in Ayvalık left to her by her father (in which we had both been born) and bought this place. (How I would later regret that we had let go of that three-story house in which we had both been born…) In my last days at home, when I took my dear daughter to nearby Kuğulu Park, the thought that I might be doing this for the last time seared me inside.

On May 10, I met for the last time with Ferit İlsever, for whom I felt deep antipathy. İlsever told me to ask Fatma to give ten thousand lira as aid to the “movement.” (I would comply with this order too…) On May 22, 1971, as soon as the Ankara Martial Law Command announced the “wanted” list, I said goodbye to Fatma and Elvan and left home. I began hiding in the homes of colleagues that Sezi, the wife of Nuri Çolakoğlu, worked with at TRT. I moved between two or three houses. Interestingly: People I had never met before were taking the risk and accepting me into their homes. I owe them gratitude to this day. As for some friends I thought were close turning me away at the door with apologies, to tell the truth, I was hurt but understood. The owners of the last house, where I would stay for quite a long time—Mustafa, a TRT employee and leftist sympathizer, and his wife—were not staying at their home at that time, for a reason I don’t remember. (Perhaps they had vacated the house for me.) In the apartment where I stayed alone, I behaved as if I were not there at all; I made no sound, didn’t turn on lights or the radio. My connection to the world consisted only of Mustafa who occasionally came and went bringing me food. Once, there was a knock at the door. When I looked through the peephole in the door, I saw that the visitor was a soldier with epaulettes and became quite worried. Fortunately, after knocking on the door a few times, he left. He was a friend of Mustafa’s…

TİİKP’s directives

One day Halil Berktay showed up. Not as two friends who had known each other for years, but with the attitude of two “party members” in a subordinate-superior relationship, he conveyed to me the orders of TİİKP, that is, of Doğu Perinçek. I was to join the Palestinian resistance movement and receive armed training there. We would go together with Atıl Ant and Cengiz Çandar. Atıl would be the cell secretary, Cengiz the member responsible for external relations, and I would be an (ordinary) member. When

he said we would join the Democratic Front for the Liberation of Palestine organization under the umbrella of the Palestinian Liberation Movement, I asked if they were aware that the organization's leader Nayef Hawatmeh was a well-known Trotskyist. It appeared he was not very aware, but he merely said "We are aware… You will convince them, win them to the correct views…" Before leaving, he reminded me that if we were captured, I should be prepared to bite off my tongue if necessary but not talk under any circumstances. He said he himself had been putting out cigarettes on his arms in preparation for bad days. (When he was captured in the summer of 1972, he too would give one of the most detailed statements to the police.) I asked him to send Fatma to me so I could see her one last time. He left after telling me what day and where to meet with Atıl and Cengiz.

(Years later, in 2023, during a conversation, Gün Zileli told me that when he asked Doğu Perinçek "Why did you send them to Palestine?" he received this answer: "They were going to be a burden to us anyway; let them go and do whatever they do there…")

When Fatma came to where I was staying a few days later (June 26), my heart was pounding as if it would leap out of my chest. I remember saying to her approximately the following: "I'm very sorry my love… I'm in love with you as on the first day; I'm attached to you and my daughter with all my heart, but unfortunately, I'm being sought by martial law. For this reason, I will have to leave Ankara soon… I don't know when we can meet again. Embrace my daughter for me, take good care of her…" I also had the shamelessness to say: "The revolutionary movement is going through extremely difficult days. I have one last request from you; I would be very happy if you could give ten thousand lira to the comrades…" (My face turns red whenever I remember this. I would learn that Fatma gave the money in question.) Fatma never asked where I was going or what I would do. When I hugged her for the last time before leaving, she was rightfully quite cold. I felt to the bone that she had neither the intention nor the hope of seeing me again. I will never forget the pain, sadness, and sorrow I felt inside when the door closed and she left. But I had deserved it… (However, my brother-in-law—my wife's sister's husband—would tell me, a few days before her death, that even in that summer of 1971 full of unknowns, Fatma had not given up on me.)

CHAPTER IV / IN THE PALESTINIAN RESISTANCE MOVEMENT

In the early evening of June 27, 1971, we met with Atil and Cengiz at the home of the late theater actor Erkan Yucel (1944-1982) in Sihhiye. Atil had dyed his hair platinum red, presumably to avoid being recognized. He looked comical. It was obvious from his demeanor that he was very pleased about being appointed cell secretary. Both of them seemed quite cheerful, behaving as if they were in a university cafeteria. I, on the other hand, was not in good spirits at all. We were heading into the unknown. Shortly after, Nuri Colakoglu came to deliver some necessities to us travelers. He was acting like a

“revolutionary comrade” rather than a friend of many years - that is, ice cold. Perhaps he was doing this to avoid giving the meeting a dramatic atmosphere, I thought.

After spending that night at Yucel’s house, the next morning we set off toward Antep on a Cayiragasi bus, sitting in seats far apart from each other. On the bus, we met Saim, who, we were told, would guide us across the Syrian border and help us join the Palestinian resistance movement. As the bus left Ankara, I felt I was experiencing one of the most dramatic moments of my life. The folk song blasting from the radio, which the driver had turned up to full volume, went like this: “I am swept away by the winds of my fate / O horizons, I say, there is a journey to tomorrow / Though separation has appeared, my beloved does not hold my hand / Today I am a guest to the evenings of exile…” The lyrics of the song perfectly reflected my state of mind.

How had Perincek made the decision to send us to Palestine? According to what Cengiz told me later, after Cengiz was sentenced to 7 years in prison because of the editorial titled “Living Lenin!” that I had written, Perincek decided to send Cengiz first, asking him to research which organization under the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO) umbrella would be appropriate to join. Cengiz found the Democratic Popular Front led by Hawatme to be suitable, as it appeared to be the “most revolutionary.” (I don’t think Cengiz had any idea about the organization’s Trotskyist identity at that time.) It was decided that Atil and I would join Cengiz, and contact was made with Saim, a tea-stall keeper and smuggler from Tarsus whom Oral Calislar knew, to organize our journey.

In Akcakale

When we arrived in Antep, we hired a taxi under Saim’s guidance and went on to Akcakale. There we stayed at the house of one of Saim’s relatives, located close to the border, until dark. When darkness fell, we set off in a jeep toward the border. When the jeep suddenly broke down, we walked the remaining 300-400 meters in plain sight of the crowd sitting in the surrounding coffee houses - we were worried they might report us, but they apparently concluded we were smugglers and paid no attention - and took shelter in a hay barn near the border. From there, guided by a dark-skinned Kurdish youth who was clearly a master smuggler, we walked toward the railway that marked the border.

On the night of June 29, 1971, the full moon shining brightly in the sky illuminated the plain almost like daylight. As we were advancing along the railway, we were suddenly startled by the command “Squad halt!” About 20-30 meters ahead of us, a squad of gendarmes was resting on the ground. It was obvious from their demeanor that they had been informed about our crossing in advance and appropriately rewarded. They paid no attention as we passed in front of them; we continued walking and crossed into Syria at what we would learn was one of the villages of Tel Abyad. Sami, who spoke Kurdish and Arabic fluently, asked the villagers to call a taxi; we immediately set off toward Aleppo with the taxi that arrived. At midnight, we stopped in Raqqa and bought drinks.

When we arrived in Aleppo, our driver found, by asking around, the office of the organization whose full name was the Democratic Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (hereafter abbreviated as DC). It was clear that no one there knew we were

coming, but we were still welcomed warmly. They seemed familiar with young people coming from Turkey. At the office, each of us was given a “mukatil” (fighter) identity. Atil was given the name Musa (I don’t remember his second name), and I was given the name Selim Tariq. Cengiz, by his own choice, took the name Zekeriya and (in honor of his father) Ihsan. Now we had a semi-official identity to carry with us, and we believed we had achieved a relatively safe status.

We set off from Aleppo to Damascus in the same taxi. We stopped at the facilities of a dam along the way and ate at its restaurant. There, a comical situation occurred that could have been very costly, potentially resulting in imprisonment in Syria - Atil mistook an officer among the customers for a waiter and waved him over with his hand. (We would later learn that some people who were caught after crossing the border spent months in prison. One of them was my friend Mufit Ozdes from the English High School.) When we reached Damascus in the late afternoon, we began searching for the DC office, which we knew was near Shara el Baghdad (Baghdad Street) in the El Ezbekiye district. We mistook the Baath Party Headquarters for the address we were looking for. Fortunately, the taxi driver went and found out it was not the address we were looking for. We finally found it: the DC office was located in the basement of an apartment building, accessed by stairs. As if it wasn’t surprising enough that the office of the “mighty” DC was in a cramped basement apartment, it also turned out that the few people there had no idea we were coming. It was clear that our joining the Palestinian resistance movement had not been organized with much care. Still, I was grateful that we had made it this far without being caught by either Turkish or Syrian security forces.

Malula

It was a great stroke of luck that Dr. Omer, whom Cengiz knew from Ankara and who was a graduate of Ankara University Medical School and spoke Turkish very well, happened to show up at the DC office - this helped get our affairs in Damascus on track. Dr. Omer showed us enough warmth to host us at his home for several days; he made us feel right at home. He also gave us the good news: “You’re lucky, the training starts in a week…” He took us to a famous dessert shop in the city center. I cannot forget the shambaba sweets (a syrup-soaked dessert) he treated us to. (That day while walking in the streets of Damascus, we saw Mihri Belli from afar. Cengiz and Atil went to greet him; I didn’t feel like it at all.) The greatest feast in Damascus, however, was the lunch we had at a shabby restaurant near the DC office, run by a Christian Syrian named Abu Muhammed. The menu consisting of omelette, hummus, fava, shepherd’s salad, and flatbread is perhaps my most striking memory of Damascus.

On July 4, 1971, we were sent to the camp near the town of Malula, located about 60 km northeast of Damascus, where the Arameans, one of the ancient Christian ethnic groups, lived, to receive guerrilla training. As soon as we arrived, when the staff there equipped us with khaki military uniforms and French-made cafe-au-lait colored boots (which had become famous in Ankara through Deniz Gezmis and his comrades), we felt that we were truly taking a step toward becoming guerrillas. The approximately 30 people other than us three Turks were all young Arabs, some Palestinian and some of Iraqi and Lebanese origin, mostly poor and unemployed. Among our Arab comrades, all

using code names, one character I cannot forget was the Lebanese Abu Fen. He distinguished himself from the others by knowing a few words of English and by the great importance he attached to himself. He told anecdotes about his friendship with Arafat and Hawatme.

Initially, we communicated with our Arab comrades through sign language. Over time, our Arabic vocabulary expanded. By the end of the approximately nine months I stayed in Syria, I would learn enough Arabic to engage in political discussions, albeit with great difficulty. However, this Arabic, picked up entirely by ear, would quickly evaporate after I left Syria. Among us, only Cengiz, because he stayed in the Palestinian resistance movement for nearly three years, would be able to retain his Arabic language skills even though he never learned to write it.

The Malula training camp was set up in a valley stretching between a steep cliff on one side and a gently sloping hill on the other. In the makeshift hut in the valley were the camp commander's office and the space where the elderly camp cook Abu Vahit stored provisions and cooked meals. Right in the middle of the camp was the physical training area called "halaka" (Arabic for "circle"), where the toughest exercises were performed. Just above the Halaka was the hill where "theoretical" training took place - weapons, explosives preparation, and guerrilla tactics - with a "shajara," a large plane tree, in the center. Further up the hill were the cave-like shelters where we spent our nights, shivering in the desert cold during summer months.

A few days later, a Syrian captain (with the code name) Abu Veyl arrived at the camp to manage the training program. He was a dark, tall, handsome young man and a sharp soldier. He spoke perfect English. Although not every day, he was usually at the camp during the daytime, supervising the training, and returned to Damascus at night. (Perhaps for this reason, the Arab comrades spread the legend that Veyl had a very beautiful wife.) When he was absent, the camp command was taken over by Abu Fadil, a stern but not unpleasant blue-eyed blond Arab. Over time, Zekeriya and I developed a certain friendship with Veyl and had conversations with him.

At Malula, we received "mukatil" training until the beginning of September, that is, for more than a month. Training began by waking up at 6 am, running approximately 10 km up and down the valley, followed by physical exercises until 8. Afterwards, we usually had breakfast consisting of flatbread with accompaniments like cheese, olives, and canned sardines, alongside well-steeped, dark-red Ceylon tea, immediately followed by the distribution of Du Maurier brand long filtered cigarettes. Those cigarettes, dangled before us like bait, were our greatest luxury. Between 9 and 13, Palestinian instructors gave lessons on topography, weapons, tactics, etc. Following lunch eaten between 13-14, weapons training took place under the shajara - which scorched our lower bodies in the sun while chilling our upper bodies in the shade - ranging from Kalashnikov machine guns to shoulder-fired bazookas, until 18. After dinner, from 20:00 onwards, political meetings or night exercises were held. Meanwhile, at any hour of the day or night, we would be invited to the "halaka" to crawl under barbed wire.

About two weeks later, friends from Turkey began arriving at the camp, and within a few days we became a group of at least 15 people. Among those who came were Sabetay

Varol (code name Adil) from Istanbul Technical University (ITU) and Ismet Tufanyazici (Faris) from Ankara Law School, both close acquaintances of mine. A few evenings later, at sunset, someone with a Che Guevara appearance arrived - bearded, wearing a beret, with a machine gun on his shoulder. His arm was in a cast from being wounded in the Black September of 1970, when the Jordanian army attacked Fatah and inflicted heavy casualties. The arrival was Halit Sait, an experienced Turkish “mukatil.” (Years later, we would learn that his real name was Mumtaz Celtik; he was a volunteer fighter who, fed up with things, had left Thrace on his own, crossed into Syria alone, and joined Fatah.) His joining us gave our group an even more authentic guerrilla identity.

Not everyone could adapt with equal ease to the challenging conditions at the Malula training camp, which were nothing like the university cafeterias of Ankara and Istanbul. Thinking that I would be there for a long time, perhaps years, I made an effort to adapt to the environment as best I could. My concern about not breaking down psychologically also demanded this. I ran at the front of the group during the ten-kilometer morning runs and threw myself into military training wholeheartedly. On one hand, this helped me adapt to the conditions and forget myself; on the other hand, I was (in my mind) setting an example for others as a role model. Through these efforts, I soon became the informal military leader of the group.

Perhaps another factor that played a role in my showing this motivation was my resentment at Perincek having appointed Musa to the leadership of the group (presumably finding me unreliable). Our friend Musa was clearly the one having the greatest difficulty adapting to the conditions. He shirked the training as much as possible and set a negative example for the group with his undisciplined behavior. During our first nights at the camp, while trying to cope with the desert cold in the cave where we were placed, Musa’s selfishness in pulling our blankets - Zekeriya’s and mine - onto himself had greatly surprised and angered us. As the days progressed, the difficulties Musa was experiencing began to manifest in various ways. After a while, Zekeriya, who had not shown his hand on this matter until then, and I began discussing Musa’s negative behaviors among ourselves.

Crawl!

My whole body had started itching. I concluded that I was sick. One day in late July, with Abu Veyl’s special permission, I was taken to Damascus, to the hospital where Dr. Omer worked. (I remember meeting Comrade Memduh, one of the top leaders of the DC and the Palestinian resistance movement, there. We would have contact with him on various occasions later on.) The diagnosis was clear: I had lice. They advised me to wash and sent me back to camp. As soon as I returned, I asked “Refik” (meaning comrade) Abu Fadil for permission to wash. “Carry water from the hill, heat it, and wash…” he said. Under the barely concealed mocking gazes of my friends, I did exactly that. Honestly, it was the most laborious but also the most enjoyable bath I ever had in my life. I felt better than I had since arriving at the camp. After washing, I put on the brand new, spotless underwear that Abu Suphi had specially brought out of storage for me. I was extraordinarily relieved… I was happy… But barely half an hour had passed when the “icma” (assembly) order was given at the ‘halaka’; then came the command to “Crawl!”

under the barbed wire… All my efforts to get clean had been wasted… I got the impression that Comrade Fadil did this partly to rub my nose in it, perceiving me as the leader of the Turkish group, and partly to emphasize the intensity of the training; I deeply resented it. As for the lice, they would continue to exist on me, pleasantly making me itch, until I washed months later at my elder sister's house in Ankara.

One day, when we climbed the hill where the fountains were located to carry water to the camp as usual, we saw that there was a makeshift detention facility there, containing about 10-15 people dressed in guerrilla clothing like us. We would never learn what crime these people had committed to be there; a few days later they would disappear from there. We couldn't help but notice that they were wearing Mao badges on their collars. "I told you these people (the DC) were Trotskyists!…" I couldn't help but mutter. Where had they sent us?..

One day a major night exercise was held. The most delicate, most dangerous part of the exercise, conducted on the surrounding hills under the light of the full moon, involved placing explosives in a cave-like target, lighting the fuse, and then quickly returning to the trench. The first task was assigned to Zekeriya. I knew that although Zekeriya had excellent control of his feet (he played football well), he didn't have much control of his hands. I worried. How would he carry out this task?! Under my anxious gaze, Zek (his shortened name) placed the explosive in position, lit the fuse, returned to the trench, but the expected explosion did not occur. It was clear he had failed to ignite the fuse. Comrade Fadil ordered Zekeriya to go back and light the fuse again. We held our breath… After Zekeriya repeated the action and hurriedly jumped back onto those of us in the trench, I was the one underneath him. My head hit the ground, my glasses flew to one side. I don't know what I would have done if they had broken. I complained quite a bit. Fortunately, the explosion occurred this time.

The training program at Malula was completed with a major exercise lasting three days and three nights. We walked 30-40 km over mountains and hills; we performed various maneuvers along the way and used different weapons. After this exercise, which was like a graduation exam, in the first week of August we were suddenly loaded into jeeps and transported to the village of Jaba in the Golan Heights, located right across from the city of Quneitra under Israeli occupation. On the way, we stopped at the city of Daraa; there each of us was given a Kalashnikov machine gun. We had now become "mukatils."

The commander of the Jaba camp, Comrade Halit, was a man of 30 to 35 who spoke poor English and was chubby, likeable, and rather naive, to a degree quite at odds with his post. At first we thought he was an important figure, but over time it became clear he was not at all. Since we had completed military training and become mukatils, at Jaba we focused on ideological training. Days began with a run on a route parallel to the Quneitra border, with afternoons dedicated to ideological training. The training had become quite lax compared to Malula. Our presence there didn't seem very meaningful. Our leader Musa had completely fallen apart. He hardly participated in the runs or the training; he sat cross-legged puffing on his cigarette… The girls from the neighboring village waving from afar seemed very attractive to us. We hadn't completely

disconnected from worldly interests, you understand… In September, the moonlight at Jaba was something else entirely. During the full moon, the stars seemed close enough to touch. It reminded me of moonlit nights in Ayvalik and made my heart ache. What were Fatma and Elvan doing, I wondered? Would I ever see them again?

One day we found the opportunity to go from Jaba to Damascus to demonstrate our Maoism. Our leader Musa, Zekeriya who was responsible for external relations, and I as the third member of the executive cell visited the Chinese Embassy for “official contact” through a connection Zekeriya had established. We told the officials there that we were Turkish revolutionaries following Chairman Mao’s path. After exchanging good wishes, we returned to the camp with many small red plastic-covered books (“Quotations from Chairman Mao”), other literature from Beijing, and boxes of Chinese tea as gifts. This visit made us quite proud, especially Musa.

Rashidieh

In mid-September, we were loaded into jeeps again and after bidding farewell to Comrade Halit, we crossed into Lebanon via hidden dirt roads winding through the hills. For a while, we stayed in tents at the Bir Hassan refugee camp in Beirut. Through another arrangement prepared by Zekeriya, Musa, Zekeriya, and I put on civilian clothes and went down to the city for two days, staying at a hotel. On one of these days, we took a walk through the city center, where Maronite Christians were concentrated, including the city’s most famous street, Shara El Hamra. The stores selling the most famous French brands reflected the high level of prosperity prevalent in Beirut in those years. On the street, elegantly dressed men and women walked alongside soldiers and guerrillas with weapons on their shoulders.

One evening we went to a cinema in that elegant neighborhood. The beauty and elegance of the women we saw in the cinema hall was dazzling… This was civilization, and how far we had fallen from it… The second evening, Musa and Zekeriya decided to go to a brothel; I didn’t want to. When they returned and told us what had happened to them (!), we laughed until we couldn’t breathe… I don’t remember laughing that much during the entire Palestinian adventure.

One day we were hastily taken from Beirut to the DC camp set up right next to the refugee camp in the town of Rashidieh, located in the south of the country, near the city of Tyre and about 15 km north of the Israeli border. The camp consisted of tents set up on a wide beach stretching along the Mediterranean coast and dug trenches. The natural surroundings were extraordinarily beautiful; it was as if we had come to a corner of paradise. Behind us were lush green hills covered with palm, banana, and pine trees, and before us stretched the deep blue Mediterranean. The scenery both gave me a measure of peace and drowned me in pain and sorrow. Much time had passed since I left Ayvalik. Looking at the horizon, I wondered whether, if I set out onto that vast sea in a small boat, I could reach my homeland and be reunited with my wife and daughter.

What was Fatma doing, I wondered? Had she completely erased me from her heart? (When I found the answer to this about two years later, in a letter Melek Ulagay sent me on October 2, 1973, before Fatma had come to Stockholm, how sad and at the same

time how happy I had been: “After martial law, during certain periods in the winter of 1971, I stayed at your house in Ankara with Fatma. Despite all the wrong behaviors our friends showed toward her in those days, Fatma’s trust and love for you, the strength of her own character, had deeply impressed me. The strength that many people who claimed to be revolutionaries could not show, Fatma showed alone by persisting to the end. She believed that one day she would meet you. Now that many obstacles have been overcome, it is very sad that you still cannot meet.”)

At the beginning of October, a new group of friends from Turkey joined us. Among those who came were Ali Mercan (code name Sami), whom I knew from Ankara, and Ahmet Ozdemir (Saban) from Istanbul, whom I would meet there and come to love very much. We visited the Palestinian refugee families in the camp at their makeshift homes. The ordinary Palestinians, whose cause we felt great affinity for but whose existence we had only known theoretically until then, were living in great poverty and deprivation; they were surviving mainly on aid from the United Nations, Arab countries, and some socialist bloc countries. My deep sympathy for the oppressed Palestinian people, expelled from their homeland, would deepen considerably with what I saw and experienced here. The only heartening sight I encountered at the camp was the blonde, shapely Italian nurse in her early twenties who was working as a volunteer at the health clinic. She seemed as beautiful as a film star to me, and I was smitten…

We witnessed dramatic events at the Rashidieh camp. One of these occurred among the many Iraqi volunteers who joined the camp a few days after us. One afternoon, while I was in the trenches dug into the beach, I was startled by a gunshot that went off very close by. One of the Iraqis had pressed his Kalashnikov to his stomach and pulled the trigger. It was clear that the young man, far from his homeland, unable to adapt to the conditions, could not bear the distress he was suffering. My own inner turmoil, caused by the conflict between my public life and my private life, also peaked at Rashidieh. It was, I suppose, in the hope that the storm raging inside me could only end this way that I informed Comrade Fadil, who had come from Malula to take command here, that I wanted to volunteer for the first “operation” against Israel. I thought I could resolve the contradiction between my commitment to the revolutionary cause and the love and longing I felt for my wife and daughter by giving my life for the cause of the oppressed Palestinian people. (Sabetay, who witnessed this request, would tell me years later when we met how surprised he had been by it.) However, not only was no operation against Israel carried out during our time at Rashidieh, but we would not witness any combat during the approximately nine months I spent in the Palestinian Resistance Movement. It was as if an “invisible hand” was protecting me…

Rashidieh was also where we came closest to armed combat. One night the alarm was raised; we took positions on the beach, ready for combat. In the open Mediterranean, Israeli commandos were coming toward us, firing illumination flares as they pursued Palestinian guerrillas returning from an operation against Israel. We watched as the pursuit approached the shore; we thought our end might be near. However, after a while the illumination flares stopped, and the pursuit ended. We never learned what happened, but the Palestinian guerrillas must have either been captured or killed.

With the friends who joined us at the beginning of October 1971, we had become a group of at least twenty people from Turkey. Meanwhile, two more “Halits” had joined the camp - one a blond Irishman, the other a black Haitian. “Halit the Irish” was a member of the Irish Republican Army (IRA), fighting for Northern Ireland to join the Republic of Ireland. “Halit the Haitian” was a member of one of the leftist organizations fighting against the dictatorship of Papa Doc (Francois Duvalier). It was exciting to find comrades who spoke English, coming from distant corners of the world. Their presence emphasized the internationalist nature of our environment. Those of us who knew English had plenty of conversations with them about world revolution.

While Musa’s leadership completely hollowed out at Rashidieh, my de facto leadership became firmly established. Most of those who newly joined us also recognized me as their leader. I shared my tent with a young friend with the code name Ismet, about whose real identity I only knew that he was from Bakirkoy and a graduate of Capa Education Institute, who inspired great confidence. We had hung in our tent a photograph of Chairman Mao together with Marshal Lin Biao, the hero of the Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution, who was expected to succeed Mao upon his death. This was an expression of our recognition of the Chinese Communist Party as the vanguard of world revolution. (I would learn much later that Lin Biao, who allegedly attempted a military coup against Mao and when unsuccessful tried to flee to Moscow, had died when his plane crashed en route. What I would learn over time about the internal struggles in the Chinese Communist Party and the tragedies experienced in China under the communist regime would play a role in the collapse of the Marxist-Leninist paradigm in my mind.)

“Chairman Mao died”

One day we received news from Palestinian friends that “Chairman Mao” had died. As the now natural, de facto, and military leader of the group, I requested that a memorial ceremony be organized. A squad of our friends lined up and fired a salute into the air with their Kalashnikovs. We tried to relieve the grief caused by “Chairman Mao’s” death in this way. The camp residents apart from our group from Turkey watched the show we staged with curiosity and amazement. Shortly afterward, we would learn that the news was not true and that Mao was alive. The Palestinian comrades had probably made up the news of his death to mock our Maoism.

In mid-October, we were informed that we would be relocating. Around October 15, we were transferred to empty land in the heights of the mountainous village of Aita El Foukhar, located east of the Lebanese Mountains running parallel to the Mediterranean, near the Syrian border. We built a camp with the tents we set up. After a while, another group of friends from Turkey and Germany joined us. Thus our group, perhaps reaching 30 people, had never been this large; the number of Arab or Palestinian guerrillas alongside us had also never been this small. This place had now become a camp that the DC had essentially allocated to those of us from Turkey. Since there was no official from the DC present, I had become the de facto commander of the camp. The situation was somewhat strange…

The first dramatic event I experienced at Aita El Foukhar was the arrival of our friend Ayhan Ozer from Ankara. Ayhan, an engineer who was a graduate of ITU, was married and had recently had a child. Dogu Perincek must have decreed that he too, like me, needed to separate from his wife and child in order to "proletarianize," to be freed from bourgeois ways. One evening, I was alone with Ayhan (whose code name I don't remember) on dish-washing duty. I thought he might be in great distress. Deciding to open up to him, perhaps as a consolation, I said something like this: "Ayhan, we have something in common. Both of us came here leaving our wives and children behind. Yes, we have dedicated ourselves to the revolution, but that doesn't mean we have been purged of our feelings for our loved ones… Sometimes we may need to share our troubles…" His response was very harsh. He said something like: "Comrade Selim, we have dedicated ourselves to the revolution and we should no longer look back, we must forget the past!…" I had been severely rebuffed. He must have been right…

(Long after I left the Palestinian resistance movement, when we met in Amsterdam, I would learn from Cengiz that Ayhan had suffered a severe mental breakdown. The comrades had been forced to hand him over to the Turkish Embassy in Beirut; his family came and took him back home. About ten years later, in the mid-1980s, we got together in Istanbul. One day he came to see me at the *Cumhuriyet* newspaper where I was working at the time. We talked privately. He had retired and was not working anywhere. He said he was still a socialist and revolutionary, but that he regularly performed his prayers and went to the mosque. Praying was good for his soul… I never saw him again. In 2014, I read in the newspapers that he had passed away in Ankara and that his funeral was conducted by the Workers' Party, of which he was a member, led by Dogu Perincek. He remained in my memory as a living example of how people break when their psychology is strained too much.)

We had formed a management committee under my leadership, consisting of friends who had known each other for a long time. News came that some friends, primarily Musa, but also including Saban (Ahmet Ozdemir) and Ismet (whom I valued greatly), had been called back to Turkey. When we were at Rashidieh, we had conveyed our complaints about Musa's behaviors "completely incompatible with being a revolutionary" to the "party inspector" (Muzaffer Orucoglu) who had been sent there. (When we learned that Musa was appointed to head the organization's Istanbul operations upon his return, we would not be too surprised. For the story of Orucoglu, who later settled in Australia and became a painter and novelist, see: <http://www.muzafferorucoglu.net>)

I pulled aside Ismet, whom I valued greatly and who was still a young man in his early 20s, and spoke to him privately. I strictly warned him not to forget that the revolutionary movement was in a period of self-defense, to absolutely refuse if he was asked to participate in bomb or armed attacks, and to focus his energy on organizational work. (Unfortunately, what I feared would come to pass: Some time after returning home, Ismet was given the task of throwing a bomb at the Israeli Embassy in Cankaya. On the way, the bomb exploded in his hand and he died. When I learned this, I was deeply pained. By coincidence, Omer Madra, who was passing by there at that time, would later tell me that he came upon the scene of this incident.)

Aita El Fukhar

One day in mid-November, the snow suddenly set in. I had always had a kind of snow phobia; when it snowed, an unexplainable anxiety would fill me that we would be unable to find food or get to a doctor. Perhaps partly because of this, when the snow depth gradually reached a meter and our food supplies dwindled significantly, I gathered the committee and proposed abandoning the camp and retreating down to the village of Aita El Fukhar. My proposal was accepted. Except for one, the few Palestinians did not object either. Only one said he would absolutely not leave the camp based on the decision of us Turks and set up a tent for himself. (When the snow let up and the sun came out, the image of him sitting on the chair he placed in front of his tent, listening to melancholy songs on his radio, is still before my eyes today.) We oiled the weapons and other valuable equipment, put them in containers and buried them in the ground, and one day in late November we descended to the village. My first task there was to go to the church and speak with the priests. I told them we had taken refuge there fleeing from the snow, and asked them to support us until help arrived from our organization.

They showed us a half-finished reinforced concrete building for us to stay in; they gave us water and food. We lit a fire to warm ourselves; the friends picked each other's lice, starting with Adil who had the most, and burned them crackling in the fire. A few days later, finally an official from the DC arrived. Although they were the ones who had left us out on the mountain, they were not very understanding about our having abandoned the camp, but a day or two later we were informed that we would be moving to a new camp. We were first taken by jeeps to Beirut, to the Burj El-Barajneh Palestinian refugee camp. A few days later, we were transferred from there to near the Nahr Al-Bared camp just north of Tripoli. We began to shelter in the camp consisting of tents we set up by the seashore.

In December 1971, we followed the developments of the India-Pakistan war, which resulted in Bangladesh gaining its independence from Pakistan, on a small transistor radio we had somehow acquired. We stayed at that camp for about a month; we welcomed 1972 there. The DC officials had left us completely on our own here as well. Our number had dropped to around 15 after some had returned to Turkey. Military and physical training activities were increasingly replaced by conversation and even playing football in the wide area by the river. The feeling that our presence there was gradually losing its meaning was spreading among us. We began to think that the time had come for the veterans of the group to return to Turkey - that we had learned what we could learn in the Palestinian Resistance Movement and could go back.

An important development occurred at Nahr Al-Bared. A Kurdish friend with the code name Sadik, a student at Capa Teachers' College, pulled me aside and said he wanted to return to the country and continue his education. I raised the issue with the management committee consisting of old friends. A couple of them said we couldn't allow him to return to the country, that if he were caught he would give information about us to the security forces. Some even argued that he should be killed. I was shocked. In short, I said, "Being a revolutionary is entirely voluntary work, we have no right to force anyone into it, we have no authority to take anyone's life. I am taking responsibility and

we are sending Sadik back home with the first group to return." (Years later, one day in late 1975, on the ferry from Kadikoy to Karakoy with Sabetay, we ran into Sadik, whose real name I didn't know. He saw us and came over to us smiling. He hadn't been caught, had finished school, and was working as a teacher in Istanbul. I cannot express how happy I was to see him safe and well and happy.)

Finally, due to our deep doubts about the commitment of the TIIKP (the Revolutionary Workers' and Peasants' Party of Turkey), and primarily of Dogu Perincek, to Marxism-Leninism-Mao Zedong Thought, we decided to leave TIIKP and, upon returning to Turkey, join the Communist Party of Turkey - Marxist Leninist, which we had learned was founded by Ibrahim Kaypakkaya and his friends. Initially, Sabetay, Ismet and I would return, while Cengiz would stay in Lebanon for now to maintain our external relations. Cengiz contacted the Kurdistan Democratic Party representatives in Beirut to secure the necessary support for our safe return to Turkey. We conveyed our decision to return to the DC officials. They were helpful in every way. They must have also thought there was no longer any reason for us to stay at their camps.

In mid-February 1972, Sabetay, Ismet, Cengiz and I crossed into Syria via mountain roads in a jeep provided by the DC. Our first stop was Malula. No trace remained of the training camp; only the hut that had once been used as the administration building and for storing provisions still stood. Friends who had come from Germany had stored the large amount of clothing they had brought with them here, thinking it would be needed by those returning. We put on the civilian clothes we found there. We were taken by the DC to the Yarmouk camp, the largest camp housing Palestinian refugees in Damascus, and settled in a small house. At a meeting we held there, the four of us decided to establish what must have been the umpteenth Communist Party of Turkey (Marxist-Leninist) organization. All of us except Cengiz would return to Turkey and join Kaypakkaya. I kept expressing the view that this was a time not for attack but for preserving forces, that there was nothing we could do during martial law except protect ourselves. The decisions we made certainly reflected our distrust and reaction toward Perincek and his circle, but I think they also expressed an attempt to calm the anxieties forming within us about the future, a search to not be left without purpose. We felt in our bones that we were walking toward an uncertain future.

From Damascus to Qamishli

The Kurdistan Democratic Party (KDP) organized our return journey from Damascus to Turkey. It was clear that the DC and the KDP had cooperated to ensure that upon our return we would engage in armed struggle against the military regime in Turkey. Cengiz, who conducted contacts with them, had informed us that we would fly from Damascus to Qamishli in northeastern Syria, and from there cross the Tigris to enter Turkey. We received a bag full of hand grenades and a bag of pistols, given to us to take along and use. One day in mid-February, we went to Damascus airport in vehicles provided by the KDP. After embracing and saying farewell to Cengiz, we headed toward the (Dakota model) plane that would take us to Qamishli, with the bag full of hand grenades in my hands and the bag with the pistols in Faris's hands.

Just as I reached the plane's stairs, the handle broke off in my hand and the bag dropped to the ground with a thud! Without showing any reaction, I picked up the bag from the ground, pressed it to my chest, and climbed the stairs.

The sight we encountered on the plane was striking. Everyone except us was a Turkish pilgrim returning from the hajj, dressed in special pilgrim's garments. We sat in different places from each other. Throughout the journey, I tried not to talk to those sitting next to me. After about an hour of flight, the plane landed in Qamishli at the Turkish border. We were waiting curiously to see what would happen now. Looking out the window, I saw several cars approaching the plane's stairs. Clutching the bags, we got off the plane, and as soon as we got into the waiting cars, we quickly left the airport. It was clear that the KDP and the Syrian Mukhabarat (intelligence organization) had cooperated to have us secretly delivered to Turkey.

The cars first took us to a house in Qamishli. After spending one night there, we were moved to a village on the banks of the Tigris. The KDP officials said they would take us across from here to Turkey. The three of us gathered. Taking into account the dangers of crossing with the bags in our hands, I suggested that we wrap up the weapons inside them and bury them in a pit, to come back and retrieve them when we found the opportunity. The friends agreed with this idea. We did so. Whether we would find such an opportunity was doubtful, but we had no doubt that crossing the border with these would be very dangerous.

On the night of February 21, 1972, brightly illuminated by the full moon, we descended to the banks of the Tigris, and a giant, elderly Kurdish smuggler took us across one by one to the opposite shore, carrying us on his back when necessary and loading us onto a raft made of boards placed on tractor inner tubes. I remember admiring his strength and skills. Throughout this entire activity, the cigarettes glowing in front of the border post on the Turkish side showed that the gendarmerie was aware of our arrival and was content to just watch. It was clear that the necessary money for them to turn a blind eye had been paid.

When we found ourselves in Turkey, the initiative suddenly passed to Ismet. I was somewhat bewildered. He suggested we hide among the rocks on the other side of the road until morning; we did so. When morning came, we went up to the asphalt road running along the shore and began waiting for minibuses coming from Silopi and heading to Cizre. None came by at all. We decided to slowly start walking toward Cizre. We walked past the border posts, which were set up at quite frequent intervals. Nobody paid any attention. It was clear that all of them knew we would be passing through. Finally, a minibus came from the Silopi direction and stopped to pick us up. The driver's pointed questions implied that he believed we, in our suits, were smugglers.

The minibus was stopped by gendarmes on the Cizre bridge and identity checks were conducted. We showed the fake identity papers we had used when going from Turkey to Syria. I don't know if the gendarme sergeant at the bridge was also informed, but we passed through the not-too-strict control and continued on our way. In Cizre, we boarded a bus going to Mardin. Faris suspected he had run into an acquaintance at the bus station, but we paid no attention… Once the bus started moving, perhaps owing to the

sense of ease that came from having survived so many ordeals, I began to feel like an ordinary, “clean” Turkish citizen. Even though I was “wanted,” I felt a quiet joy inside for having returned to my country. Taking on the role of a pharmaceutical company employee, I chatted with the rather talkative villager sitting next to me, using my imagination to its fullest about what I was doing there.

From Mardin, we went to Diyarbakir by minibus and spent the night of February 22 at a hotel there. The next day, traveling by bus via Ergani and Elazig, we reached Malatya, our intended destination. We had addresses (I don’t remember how we obtained them) that we hoped would enable us to reach Ibrahim Kaypakkaya. Ismet volunteered to go to these addresses. Adil and I waited at the bus station. On the walls of the bus station hung posters showing those wanted by security forces - I suspected I was among them but avoided approaching to look closely. When Faris returned a few hours later with the information that all those addresses had been raided by security forces, we decided we had no choice but to continue to Ankara. A vague joy stirred inside me. When I arrived in Ankara, perhaps I could see my beloved and my daughter…

How I had missed them!…

When we got off the bus in Ankara in the morning hours of February 24, our paths separated. Ismet and Sabetay continued to Istanbul; I got in a taxi with the few liras left in my pocket and went to my elder sister Olcay’s house on Kizilirmak Street. When my sister opened the door and saw me, she didn’t know what to do from shock and joy… I saw my niece Sedef, whom I had left as a baby, for the first time as a 2-year-old child. I will never forget: with her blue eyes and blonde hair, she resembled a fairy. My sister immediately notified Fatma. How I had missed her!.. She stayed with me for two nights. We decided it would not be right for her to show me Elvan. One afternoon, Omer and Tanju also came to see me. The day I was to leave, I don’t know how I found the strength to tell Fatma that my fate was bound to the revolution, that she should now consider herself free… Was I sincere, or was it that a hope, however small, of being reunited with her had not yet died inside me? Fatma received it with her usual composure. Were storms raging inside her, or had she come to believe that the expected end had come? I could never read what was going through her mind…

After staying at my sister’s for three nights, washing and getting rid of the lice and getting new clothes, on the night of February 28, 1972, I set off for Istanbul by bus. I remember we crossed the Bosphorus by car ferry. As soon as I got off, I called my elder brother from a phone booth. He was very excited. He said he had been terribly worried and that I should immediately come to his house on Kore Sehitleri (Korean War Martyrs) Street. I did so. My sister-in-law Ayla had taken my young nephews Umit and Cihan to her mother’s so they wouldn’t encounter me. My brother and I embraced like never before… How happy he was to see me… But he was very worried; he feared what seemed inevitable - that I would eventually be caught and imprisoned. With all his love and devotion to me, he didn’t even consider the dangers my presence posed for him. I told him I would be leaving soon and just wanted them to host me for a few days. I was determined not to abandon the revolutionary cause - or I was convincing myself of this, wanting to believe it.

I stayed at my brother's until March 4. That day I met with Omer. Omer took me to the home of our mutual friend Alev on Asmali Mescit Street in Tunel. Alev (Seref) was married to Taner at the time and pregnant with her daughter Su. Without hesitation, she agreed to shelter me for a while. The next day, I went to the house of Adil Ovalioglu and his friends in Baglarbasi, which we had agreed upon as the meeting place with Sabetay and Ismet (we had learned that Adil had joined Kaypakkaya). Adil and I agreed that our primary issue was the matter of shelter. He said he would make some contacts. We would decide together in the coming days what we would do. A few days later, at the agreed place and time in Tepebasi, I met with Sabetay and we went to a coffee house in Kadikoy to talk over with Adil what we would do. Adil was saying that there were some caves in the Bingol countryside, that we could spend the martial law and heavy pressure period by hiding there. I don't know whether he himself was fully convinced of this, but I certainly was not; it would soon become clear that Sabetay wasn't either. Indeed, he did not come to our appointment on April 1.

CHAPTER V / I CHOOSE FREEDOM

With Sabetay's disappearance, a new chapter opened in my life. I made a decision that had probably been forming in my subconscious for some time. I went to my elder brother and asked him to help me escape to Europe. He encouraged me, saying, "I'll do everything I can, and that's what I should do." Through him, I sent a message to Fatma. The essence of my message was this: "My love, I have wronged you; don't pay me back in kind; forgive me… I'm going to escape to Europe, and I want you to come join me. I'm giving up revolutionary activities. I will never, ever leave you again, never, ever hurt you… Please, please come to Istanbul immediately, we need to talk…" How did I convince myself of a scenario that seemed completely unrealistic to achieve under the prevailing conditions? What probably made this possible was the desperation I was in, and the glimmer of hope awakening within me that I might escape the dead end I had fallen into. And my dear brother was fueling this hope: "Whatever it takes, I'll send you abroad…" he said. I felt as if I had been reborn. I was now a different person… A great burden had been lifted from my conscience… I no longer had any practical involvement with revolution and revolutionary activities, even if ideologically I still had some connection.

(In the following section, I made use of notes I took during my first days in Stockholm, where I would seek refuge. This is why I am able to give exact dates.)

Drunk with happiness

I continued staying with Alev. Since she and her husband Taner were on bad terms at the time, he wasn't staying at home, only dropping by occasionally. Alev showed me one of the greatest friendships I have ever witnessed by sheltering me for days. Yes, she too was a "leftist" sympathizer, but the solidarity she showed had nothing to do with political stance; it was entirely about friendship and companionship. This would be one of the experiences that made me realize the deep distinction between being ideological comrades and being true friends.

My dear Fatma came and stayed with me for three nights at Alev's house between March 19-21. I practically threw myself at her feet; I begged her to give me one last chance. She was uneasy, but surprisingly, she wasn't saying "It's over, I've closed the chapter on you"…

Did she think I was deluding myself, or was she also hopeful that we could be together again?.. I wasn't sure, but because she hadn't ended our relationship, I was flying with happiness even though the future was completely uncertain. My love for her was more intense than ever. The plan we agreed upon was this: My brother would somehow obtain a fake passport for me, I would escape abroad with it, and have Fatma and Elvan join me. My Fatma came again on April 7 and stayed with me for a few more days. I now trusted that she hadn't abandoned me. I believed that one day I would be reunited with her and my daughter.

On March 30, I was shaken by the news. Security forces had surrounded and killed Mahir Cayan, Cihan Alptekin, and their comrades in the village of Kizildere in the Niksar district of Tokat; only Ertugrul Kurkcu had survived the massacre and was captured alive. Although we had had arguments that reached the level of serious accusations, Mahir was an old friend of mine. (Fatma had found only him likeable among my leftist friends.) Unfortunately, the competition among young leftists over "who is more revolutionary" was costing the lives of comrades who had dedicated themselves to the cause of a more just Turkey and had also been swept up in the dream that armed revolution was possible.

After that date, I would stay alternately at two houses: My brother's mother-in-law Aunt Mueyyet and father-in-law Osman (Cokay) Bey accepted me into their home as if there were nothing unusual about it, as if there were no danger. The apartment of Fatma's close friend from university, Konca, and her husband Erdal (Aktulga) in Atakoy became my second home. (I owe a lifelong debt of gratitude to these people.) Omer came to see me in Atakoy. We talked at length about our troubles. He too had experienced disappointments and had completely broken away from the revolutionary movement. I told him about my plan to escape to Europe; he thought it was right. We parted with an embrace. Unfortunately, not long after, he would be arrested along with Altan Oymen and others on charges of "hijacking a plane" and would spend more than two years in prison in Ankara, being tried in the TIIKP (Revolutionary Workers' and Peasants' Party of Turkey) case, until he was released with the 1974 amnesty.

On April 15, I met with Ahmet Ozdemir (Saban), who had contacted me through my brother, in the then-empty lot in front of the Hilton hotel, overlooking Dolmabahce. Saban was one of the comrades who had returned from Palestine before us. He was one of the most pure-hearted, decent, and idealistic friends I have ever known in my life, someone I loved dearly. He suggested we go together to Syria, and from there to Lebanon, to rejoin our comrades. I told him I was determined to escape to Europe and seek refuge in one of the countries there. (This would be my last meeting with him. Ahmet managed to return to Syria and from there to Lebanon. But this was a very unfortunate success. Sadly, he would be one of the comrades killed in the raid by Israeli commandos on the Nahr Al Barad camp in February 1973. Seeing how deeply saddened I was when I

learned of this in Stockholm, my Greek friend Anestis Kombokis, with whom I was sharing a house at the time, painted on a piece of wood, in memory of Ahmet, a small torch that would burn forever. This painful memento still stands in my bookcase today.)

On April 17, I met with Adil Ovalioglu somewhere in Dolapdere. He told me that Saban had gone to Elazig and would head south from there to cross the border. He repeated his suggestion that we settle together in the caves of the Bingol mountains. I told him I had made my final decision and would escape to Europe, and we said our farewells. When I returned to Alev's house that evening, I found Omer and Tanju waiting for me. On April 18, we celebrated my 28th birthday together. This would be my last time seeing them until we met again in 1975.

Days were passing but my hope that my brother would find a way to obtain a fake passport for me was not fading. I had lost contact with Sabetay. I didn't know what had happened to him. (Years later, when we met in Istanbul, he would tell me that he had escaped abroad with a fake passport his brother had obtained by bribing the police heavily, and had sought refuge in France.) I was left alone. Months had passed since my return home in early March, June had arrived, but my brother had made no progress in obtaining a passport. One night while I was staying at the Cokays' house, my sister-in-law Ayla sat me down. She reminded me that she had lost hope they could help me escape, that the protection they were providing me was creating an increasingly dangerous situation for them, and asked me to fend for myself as soon as possible. She was absolutely right…. I told my brother that I had no choice but to try to return to the Palestinian resistance movement. My dear brother again said to me, "If you can't manage it, come back…" There was nothing I could do but set off saying farewell to my Fatma, farewell to my Elvan, farewell to my hopes and dreams.

The only thing I could do now was to return the way I had come to Cizre, from there somehow to Syria, and from there to Beirut, to rejoin Cengiz. I felt deep regret that I hadn't met up with Saban to go together. Even if I would eventually be caught, I had to try. My brother was very upset, but he too had nothing left to say. He had been unable to find a way to smuggle me to Europe. I put the fake identity card I had used when first going to Syria in my pocket and on June 18 set off by bus via Adana, Gaziantep, Urfa, and Mardin toward Cizre. From there, I would somehow find a way to return to Syria the same way I had come.

I spent the first night on the bus. On the second day, the bus I was on was stopped by police between Urfa and Mardin. Everyone on the bus except me was a villager. With my suit and tie, I had a conspicuous appearance. The police officer conducting the identity check immediately approached me. I showed my ID; I said I worked as a marketing employee at a pharmaceutical company and was going to Mardin. The police officer thanked me and returned my ID. (As I had tested and would test on other occasions, my appearance left the impression that I was someone completely "innocent / clean.") It was unnerving to see so many military vehicles pass us as the bus made its way toward Mardin.

In Mardin

On the night of June 19, I arrived in Mardin and went straight to a hotel near the bus station that had caught my eye (the Yildiz Palas), and immediately shut myself in my room. I couldn't sleep for a long time, but then exhaustion took over and I fell asleep. I woke up at 8 in the morning and immediately got up and went to the bus station. Hawkers were announcing buses going in two directions. One was shouting "Cizre - Silopi!", the other "Antep, Antep!"… A deep anxiety descended upon me that if I got on the Cizre bus I would be caught in a short time, and without thinking much, almost instinctively, I bought a ticket for the Antep bus. When the bus started moving, there was a relief inside me as if I had survived a great ordeal. A peace filled me similar to what I had felt during the Cizre-Gaziantep bus journey at the end of February (and similar to what I would feel later, in January 1981, when being transported from the police detention center in Izmir Basmane to the military detention center in Narlidere). I began chatting comfortably about this and that with the citizen from Mardin sitting next to me, as if I were a "normal" person. I couldn't believe I could do this. Apparently, I had become thoroughly frightened that I would be caught if I continued toward Cizre…

Returning to Istanbul the way I had come, I arrived in Kadikoy late on June 21. I went to a random hotel on Rihtim Avenue and immediately withdrew to my room. I had made my decision: I would get up early the next morning, go to Adil Ovalioglu's house in Baglarbasi, and surrender myself to him so that he could take me to the caves in the Bingol mountains. I had no other choice. My only concern was that I might not find the house, whose location I only vaguely remembered… On the morning of June 22, 1971, I left the hotel and walked to the Kadikoy ferry pier. I bought a cheese sandwich, a glass of lemonade, and a copy of Milliyet newspaper from the buffet. When I opened the newspaper, the headline story I encountered was titled "The Trunk Murder!" The summary of the news was this: Bogazici University student Banu Erguder had been detained by police in Pasabahce; when the trunk she was carrying, which she said contained her books, was opened, the dismembered corpse inside was found to belong to Adil Ovalioglu, who was wanted by the police… I was horrified!.. If I had gone to Ovalioglu's house without buying the newspaper and reading the news, I would probably have been greeted by the security forces with "Welcome, Sahin Alpay!" and interrogated about the murder. (The police investigation would conclude that Ovalioglu had been killed by Zeynel Altindag, one of the "Maoist" youth at Bogazici University whom I had also known at one point, due to an intra-organizational dispute.) By sheer luck, I had escaped another disaster…

Without thinking too much, I swallowed my pride and decided to call my brother. (I don't know why it never occurred to me to go and surrender to the police. I was probably afraid of spending many years in prison and falling among Dogu Perincek and his comrades again. If I had surrendered, I couldn't have known that I too would be released like the others with the 1974 amnesty.) I crossed to the other side by ferry, to Kabatas, and called my brother from the first phone booth I found. My dear brother had been very upset about my departure, hadn't slept for days; he was overjoyed that I had returned safe and sound. They had closed up the house on Kore Sehitleri (Korean War Martyrs) Avenue and moved to his father-in-law's house in Zincirlikuyu. He told me to come there

in the evening, that he would be waiting for me. “Whatever it takes, I’ll make sure you escape to Europe,” he said… My sister-in-law Ayla, contrary to my expectations, was also pleased about my return. I remember as if it were yesterday what an enormous boost of morale my brother’s words gave me. That night (and for days afterward) I stayed at the home of my sister-in-law’s sister Ayhan and her husband Altan (Demirkol). They sheltered me in their home as if there were no risk involved, as if I were an ordinary guest. I cannot put into words my debt of gratitude to the friends and relatives who took the risk of hiding me. (In this context, you can imagine how moved I was when I learned that my elder sister Sumru’s elderly father-in-law Ali Comert had sent word saying, “Let him come, I’ll hide him on the farm.”)

I started looking for new friends who would hide me in their homes and help me escape. The first thing that came to mind was to look for Metin (Kilicli), a close friend from middle and high school. I hadn’t seen him for a long time, but I had no doubt about his friendship. The year we graduated from Robert College, his father had passed away, and the responsibility of supporting his mother and two sisters had fallen on his shoulders. For a while, he had bet on horse races by closely studying the horses’ performance and had, incredibly, won considerable sums of money. Later, he had started working as an assistant to a director in Yesilcam (the Turkish film industry), and in the meantime had had a great love affair with the director’s wife. Metin, who was one of the brightest minds in our class and should have studied on scholarship in the USA to become a physicist or chemist if circumstances had allowed, had studied architecture at Mimar Sinan University, calculating that he could only support his mother and sisters by working as a contractor after his father’s death. I learned he was living in Atakoy. I somehow found his address and knocked on his door. He was quite surprised to see me. He didn’t invite me inside, but said the following through the crack in the door: “I live here with my mother and two sisters. I can’t put them in danger. But I’ll help you in any way I can other than sheltering you.”

At Metin’s suggestion that I could stay at hotels there until I found a safer place, I went to Kumburgaz. With the fear that I could be reported and caught at any moment, I stayed there for a few nights at a place called “Marmara Family Pension.”

Metin and I started thinking together about how I could escape to Europe. We had heard that our close friend from middle school, Sefik (Yuksel), was a senior executive at THY (Turkish Airlines). Metin was saying, “If Sefik gives you his passport, I’ll make the necessary modifications to it, and you can go.” He tracked down Sefik and conveyed my request. Sefik’s answer was (of course, and quite rightly) negative. (According to what Sefik told me when we met years later, when Metin received the negative answer, he had lashed out at him saying, “What kind of man are you! How could Sahin have trusted you enough to send me to you!..” and had caused Sefik sleepless nights.)

I didn’t lose hope. I continued waiting for my brother to find an opportunity. Since I couldn’t find a place to stay in Istanbul, at the end of June I went to Erdek via Bursa; I stayed there for a few nights (in a very anxious state of mind) at a place called “Deniz Hotel.” Playing the role of a young man vacationing alone was quite unsettling, and I was quite afraid of being caught; but there was nothing to be done. At the beginning of

July, I returned to Istanbul and started staying at Ayhan's again. There was good news!.. My brother was about to buy a passport… I had photographs taken to use in the passport and took them to Metin. But this time the news was discouraging: The man had changed his mind! But my brother continued searching… On July 7, I went to Cinarcik via Yalova to stay for 3-4 days. I stayed at a hotel called "Manolya Palas." In the oppressive heat, overwhelmed with anxieties about what would become of me, I spent terrible nights. One day I ran into Sanar (Yurdatapan), an old acquaintance of mine. Bless him, he said he would help if there was anything he could do.

On July 14, hope was born again: My brother had found a police officer who would secretly get me on a THY plane going to Frankfurt; (the man was asking for 15 thousand liras, which was no small amount for that time). My brother went to Ayvalik to talk to Fatma. Fatma immediately put up 8 thousand and promised to send the remaining 7 thousand. In preparation for the operation, a ticket was purchased for the plane departing on July 30 for 3,200 liras. However, when the man raised his demand to 20 thousand liras, the operation was abandoned. (This was perhaps my greatest stroke of luck. Out of desperation, the cost of this adventure I would have embarked on without even a fake passport could have been very high.) On the night of July 30, I was staying at (our dear friends) Konca and Erdal's (Aktulga) in Atakoy; I watched the plane on which I was a ticketed passenger take off without me.

On August 9, I met my brother Acar. "A new opportunity has arisen. We can buy a passport, and you can travel abroad at any moment, but we need to find 10 thousand liras to pay for the passport," he was saying. It occurred to me that I could ask my high school friend Ahmet (Kutman) for a loan. Metin and I called Ahmet. Bless him, Ahmet gave the money saying, "You can pay your debt when you have the means in the future." The man demanded an additional 2 thousand liras to also give his identity card along with the passport. I met with my classmate from high school, Riza (Asi), and borrowed 2 thousand liras from him as well. (These two loyal friends would refuse when I wanted to repay my debt three years later.) This problem was also solved. Then, on August 15, my brother announced the big news: The person who agreed to let me use his passport and identity card in exchange for money was a bartender acquaintance. His condition was that the passport and identity card be returned to him after the job was done.

A true friend

I was flying with joy!.. Now it was time to adapt the passport to me, that is, to change the photograph and forge the embossed and inked official stamps on it. There was not the slightest doubt about who could do this. This was exactly a job for Metin. I handed over the passport I received from my brother to Metin. I was locked away in the Demirkols' apartment in Etiler. The hosts were on vacation. As long as I was in the apartment, I could not turn on the lights or make any noise. Altan would come every few days to bring food. There was no choice but to endure any and all conditions.

About a week later, word came that Metin was waiting for me at a friend's architecture office in Osmanbey. When I arrived at the office, Metin had mounted my photograph on

the authentic passport and had also taken care of the embossed stamp. Under my amazed and excited gaze, he drew the reverse image of the inked stamp with a ballpoint pen on an eraser and, with great composure, using his one chance, perfectly set the inked stamp in place as well. The passport I needed to leave the country was now ready. I was finally going…

(Here I want to open a parenthesis and tell a bit about Metin: When I returned to the country in 1975, I found him working as a contractor. We started meeting frequently. He had married his girlfriend from university, Nuray, and they had a daughter, Ozge. Because his business wasn't going very well, after a while he started working for a close friend's construction company; reluctantly, he took on responsibility for the company's operations in Libya. I was working at Cumhuriyet at the time. One morning in April 1986, concerned by news that the US had bombed Libya, I called Nuray. Surprisingly, there was no sign of anxiety in her voice. A little later she said, "Let me put someone on for you." Metin had sensed that the bombs were coming and had managed to return to Istanbul by boarding the last plane out!.. This was another demonstration of Metin's intelligence and resourcefulness.

However, Metin was as unlucky as he was smart and resourceful. The year he graduated from high school, his father, who was a tailor, died leaving considerable debt, which darkened his future. His misfortunes continued. When the company he worked for abandoned its operations in Libya due to the war, Metin had started overseeing the company's construction projects in Istanbul. One day Nuray called; she said Metin had broken his hip by falling into an elevator shaft and had narrowly escaped cracking his skull. When I went to visit him at the American Hospital, he was quite exhausted. He recovered over time, but his health problems continued. A year or two later, he had to have part of his stomach removed due to an ulcer.

It was he who would react most strongly to my starting to write for Zaman in 2002. He believed not in democracy but in secularism and looked upon religious beliefs with suspicion. It upset me greatly when he said that, had he known I would one day start writing for Fethullah Gulen's newspaper, he would never have supported me; but our friendship was not shaken. This time he had started working at a brokerage firm owned by a friend; meanwhile, he was again betting on horse races. Then he started battling prostate cancer. The treatment was successful. I called him when I was released from Silivri in 2018. He said he was very upset about my imprisonment. His daughter Ozge had gotten married and settled in Canada. He said he was going to Montreal to look after his grandchildren. He returned from there. Our friendship continues.)

Meanwhile, Fatma had shared the developments with her maternal uncle Ismet Kaptan (the former general manager of Izmir Fair) and his wife Aysun, and they had said they definitely wanted to see me. I went to their apartment in Atakoy where they were living at the time. I explained my escape preparations with complete openness. Uncle Ismet asked me to give him the passport. He would show it to Nihat, the director of the Istanbul Police Department's 4th Division (Passport Division), who was his blood brother from Galatasaray High School, and make sure there was no problem with me setting off with it. (This is what family solidarity was all about!..) A few days later, the answer came:

Mr. Nihat had been amazed at the “uniqueness” of the modification made to the passport and had said, “It’s come out perfect; he can go with this comfortably…” After receiving this assurance as well, there was no obstacle left to my setting off…

Bosfor Tourism

Now it was time to organize the journey. My brother and I made the plan together: the safest way for me to travel would be by bus. I would go to Munich by the comfortable Bosfor Tourism bus, then continue to Geneva by train. There I would apply for political asylum in Switzerland. There would be advantages to seeking refuge in a country at the center of Europe. Moreover, my elder sister Olcay’s sister-in-law Mrs. Ayhan lived in Geneva with her Swiss husband; she could be of help throughout the application process.

My brother bought my ticket from Bosfor Tourism for me to set off on the morning of August 20, 1972. A day or two earlier, we had gone to a store in Pangalti and bought a gray suit for me to wear on the journey. On the night of August 19, there was feverish activity at the Cokays’ house with my brother, my sister-in-law, and her late mother Aunt Mueyyet participating. My hair was dyed black so I wouldn’t be recognized on the road. Aunt Mueyyet gave me strong anti-depressant pills to use during the journey to suppress my excitement. It was decided that my brother and sister-in-law would follow my bus in their car, so they would know whether or not I had made it through safely. (What would happen if I didn’t make it safely??? I didn’t even want to think about it…)

On the morning of August 20, my brother, my sister-in-law, and I set off for Taksim. The bus was departing at 9:00. We said our farewells excitedly and I boarded the bus. While boarding, I thought I saw Nedim (Demirelli), a close friend from middle school. Had he seen me too? Even if he had, I was sure he wouldn’t say anything. (Years later I learned that he hadn’t seen me.) I was more excited and tense than I had ever been on my previous “fugitive” journeys. As soon as the bus started moving, I swallowed one of the pills Aunt Mueyyet had given me. The bus made a rest stop halfway to Edirne; I got out and had a glass of tea. The pill had taken effect and I had begun to feel like a “normal” passenger. It was great luck that there was no one sitting in the seat next to me; there was no need to make unnecessary small talk.

When we arrived at the Kapikule border crossing, the bus hostess began collecting passports under my amazed gaze. So (hooray!) I wouldn’t have to go to passport control in person… As the hostess took my passport, she said, “You can go out to the garden while waiting.” Concerned that staying on the bus might raise suspicion, I immediately did so. (Meanwhile, my brother and sister-in-law were watching what was happening from a distance; but I wasn’t aware of this.) After a while, the hostess invited the passengers back to the bus and returned the stamped passports one by one. I couldn’t believe it!.. I had sailed through passport control without the slightest hitch. Just as the bus was about to cross the border, it stopped. A police officer came inside and told us to take out our passports. After checking them one by one, he wished us a good journey and left… The barrier at the border lifted and our bus crossed to the Bulgarian side…

Farewell Dogu Perincek!

I was beside myself with joy… The operation had succeeded or was about to succeed. The thought that the Bulgarians might become suspicious and take me off the bus did cross my mind, but the Bulgarian police collected our passports, stamped them, and (thank goodness) returned them. While waiting, I went to the bathroom and there, quite literally and in actual fact, I did a belly dance for joy; I remember shouting inwardly, “Farewell Dogu Perincek, farewell Mihri Belli…” My managing to escape from Turkey was a true miracle. I would learn later: About ten days after I left, my brother had been interrogated by the political police: “We’ve received reports that you’ve been in contact with your brother… Do you know where he is?” My brother had been able to say with a clear conscience, “I have no information.” What if this interrogation had happened before I left? Then we would inevitably have had to cancel the whole operation; I would have had no choice but to go and surrender to the police.

(I always believed I was “God’s lucky servant.” I could only explain surviving so many ordeals with this… Sabetay told me when we came together years later: His brother had also smuggled him abroad. Although he had never made such a request of him, his brother, presenting him with a fait accompli, had enabled him to escape to France by paying large sums to a gang within the police. So we owed our salvation to our brothers, to our families… My dear Fatma would say she was very amazed that I could have asked my brother for such risky help. When I learned of Sabetay’s escape story, my conscience was somewhat relieved. I wasn’t the only one who had put his brother at risk…)

When the bus set off toward Sofia, I had already begun to feel like a free person… So much so that I was daring to chat with those sitting in the adjacent seats. This time I had become “an accountant going to visit relatives in Germany”… We passed through Bulgaria without stopping and entered Yugoslavia. I was sailing through passport controls without a hitch. We stayed one night in the city of Nis (in today’s Serbia). After a rest stop in Belgrade, we continued to Maribor (now in Slovenia); we stayed there for one night too. Then, passing through Austria, on to Munich!

The Americans are bewildered

That evening, after a dinner of a sausage in bread and a beer at a place resembling a train station, I went to a random hotel. As I had done in Mardin, anxious not to be seen around, I immediately went to bed and slept. In the morning, I got up, went to the station, and bought a train ticket to Geneva. There were two American young men in the compartment I settled into. While I was deep in conversation with them, the Swiss passport police arrived. The fact that after looking at my passport they thanked me and returned it greatly surprised the Americans: How had a Turk’s passport been returned without being examined, without being questioned, and moreover with thanks?.. (If only they knew the passport was fake!..) To be honest, I too was a bit surprised but extremely pleased.

When I arrived at the Geneva station on August 23, I immediately went to the office that helped find hotels. Soon I had a room at the address “Hotel Kaufmann, Boulevard des Tranchees 48.” My next step was to use the address I had to go to the home of Ayhan (my brother-in-law’s elder sister) and her husband Guy. There was no answer at the door. After several attempts, I knocked on the neighbor’s door. Since I didn’t know French, it was only with great difficulty that I learned the homeowners hadn’t been in the city for some time. But the neighbor woman was kind enough to give me Guy’s sister’s address. When I arrived there, a great disappointment awaited me: His sister was saying that Guy and Ayhan had gone to Turkey… In all my naivety, I thought for a while that maybe they would return to Geneva after learning I had arrived here. I was wrong. I would later find out that as soon as they heard I was coming to Geneva, they had left the city for fear that I would knock on their door.

What was I to do now? Out of concern that I might encounter an unfavorable situation, I didn’t want to approach the Swiss police without someone knowing of it and being able to bear witness. I was afraid that something might go wrong and I would be sent back to Turkey. (Of course, this was an entirely meaningless worry, but it reflected my psychology in those days.) Meanwhile, some nights at the hotel where I was staying, I could hear Turkish conversations. In the mornings, I would see Cumhuriyet newspapers thrown in the trash bin in the corridor. Since many Turks lived in Switzerland, I saw nothing surprising in this.

My brother and I started corresponding by letter. I wanted two things: The money I had with me was about to run out; what would I do?.. It would be good if Fatma’s cousin Ahmet, who lived in Strasbourg, came and took me to France. The answer came: Ahmet would come at the first opportunity and take me to Strasbourg. I would go to a friend of Ismet Kaptan’s who lived in Geneva and get 500 dollars from him. And that’s what I did. While waiting first for the Ayhans, then for Ahmet to come, I walked the streets of Geneva for about 20 days. Out of old habit, to avoid arousing suspicion, I would leave the hotel early in the morning and return late in the evening; to save money, I lived on sandwiches all day. My biggest entertainment was watching broadcasts about the Munich Olympics that were taking place at the time on screens in shop windows. This is how I learned of the Palestinian guerrillas’ attack on Israeli athletes on September 5-6. I remember being troubled, thinking that these actions would turn Western public opinion against the Palestinians. This was also one of the first signs of my beginning to take a stance against armed struggle, against weapons in general.

Ahmet Kaptan

Ahmet Kaptan showed up at my hotel on September 11. I was flying with joy. His first question was: “Do you realize where you’ve been staying?!” I didn’t. It turned out that the Turkish Consulate General in Geneva was in the building adjacent to my hotel… This was the reason for the Turkish conversations I had heard, the Cumhuriyet newspapers I had seen… Apparently, I had even avoided looking carefully at my surroundings.

On the afternoon of September 12, Ahmet and I departed for Basel to catch the train going from there to Strasbourg. We encountered a big problem at the border: The

French police were asking what work I did, how much money I had, why I wanted to go to France, etc. As usual, I said I was an accountant and would return to Turkey after visiting my nephew Ahmet for a few days. The police asked me to show how much money I had on me. After paying the hotel bill, I only had about 200 dollars left… The police curtly told Ahmet, who said he would take full responsibility for me, “You can pass, but this person cannot enter France…” I was at a loss as to what to do. The thought began to cross my mind that I would have no choice but to apply for asylum in Switzerland. With minutes left before the Strasbourg train departed, the police chief appeared. Ahmet managed to convince him, and we ran and boarded the Strasbourg train at the last moment. I breathed a deep sigh of relief… My skill (!) at crossing borders through illegal means had shown itself once again.

I started staying at Ahmet’s one-room apartment in Strasbourg. Ahmet worked at a restaurant at night and slept at home during the day. Therefore, I would leave the house as soon as he arrived in the morning and walk the streets of Strasbourg until evening. I had no idea what I would do: First of all, I decided to find Erdal Yavuz, a friend from high school and university who I knew was doing his doctorate at Strasbourg University. Despite Ahmet sending word here and there, we couldn’t get any information about where Erdal was living. The only thing being said was that he hadn’t been seen around for a long time…

Days later, information came that Erdal was living somewhere on General De Gaulle Boulevard. From that moment on, I started walking up and down that boulevard, reading the names written on apartment doors one by one. On September 22, I came across the name Taner Beygo on the door of one of the multi-story apartment buildings. I was tremendously happy. I had met Taner while he was working as an assistant at Istanbul University Law Faculty, through my friend Bulent Tanor. I had also heard that he had started working at the Human Rights Commission in Strasbourg. Without hesitation, I rang the bell. When Taner opened the door and saw me in front of him, he was stunned, but immediately invited me in and introduced me to Duygu, who was (at the time) his wife. We talked at great length. The most important information he gave was that Erdal was living in the building just behind. He was saying I could seek asylum in France. He promised to discuss this matter with his acquaintances at the European Human Rights Commission. A door of hope had opened.

Oblomov Erdal

It was late. I waited until the next day to go to Erdal. When he opened the door and saw me in front of him, Erdal’s shock was even greater than Taner’s. We embraced… He hadn’t left the house for about forty days; while his girlfriend Irene worked, he was taking care of the housework, cooking, sweeping the house, and in the meantime playing chess, backgammon, or bridge with friends who came and went. He still hadn’t completed his doctoral studies. When we were in high school, I had nicknamed him “Oblomov” (after Goncharov). His state that day fit this description perfectly. (Erdal and Irene got married after a while and had a son they named Devrim [Revolution]. I remember teasing him saying, “You made your revolution at home too!”) That very day I moved in with Erdal and stayed as their guest until I left Strasbourg.

Taner, whom I saw a day or two later, had discussed my situation with a Czech judge named Vasak who worked at the Human Rights Commission. Vasak had said he would soon go to Paris and discuss the matter with the Interior Minister; he had instructed me to wait for him before making an asylum application. He had also mentioned that an assistantship and doctoral opportunity at Strasbourg University could be arranged for me. I was so hopeful that I would immediately write to my brother and Fatma that the possibility of staying in France had arisen.

A day or two later, Taner came with this information: The French Interior Minister had preferred not to have heard about this matter. Given this, Vasak recommended that I go to Sweden, where I could easily obtain asylum. He had written down the phone number and home address of Associate Professor Goran Melander, a human rights expert at Lund University, and sent it to me. The goal had become seeking asylum in Sweden, which had never crossed my mind until that day. The fact that I would be able to contact Melander, and that I saw this as a safeguard, played a role in my being immediately convinced. There was someone who would help me in Sweden. Moreover, I knew that Sweden was a country governed by social democrats, following a policy of neutrality, quite civilized, and with very beautiful women too. Taner and I started planning the trip to Sweden. Once again without delay, I informed my brother and Fatma that my route had turned to Sweden.

Meanwhile, Taner told me that Prof. Dr. Bulent Nuri Esen, who was my department chair at Ankara University Faculty of Education and who had taken me quite under his wing at the time, was in Strasbourg; however, when he mentioned me to him, Esen had firmly stated that he did not want to see me. I wasn't surprised by this. But I wasn't without doubts about whether the information Taner conveyed to me fully reflected the truth. Why hadn't he arranged for me to meet the Czech judge? Was he directing me to Sweden to get rid of me? But if that was the case, I owe him gratitude. Because as I will describe in detail below, my affairs in Sweden would go smoothly, and my life would settle into order in a short time. (As I later learned, Sabetay's asylum application to France had not been easily accepted at all. The French police had asked him to inform on Turks, or failing that, on Latin Americans; because he refused, he had to wait a year for his application to be accepted.)

On the way to Sweden

On October 26, 1972, I set off from Strasbourg toward Sweden. Taner and his wife drove me to Karlsruhe, the nearest German city, in their car, which had diplomatic plates and was therefore not subject to passport control. There, after buying a thick jacket that would keep me warm in Sweden's harsh winters (with the money I got from Ahmet), I bid farewell to the Beygos and boarded the train that would take me to Kiel. I remember that Duygu, Taner's wife, had tears in her eyes as we said goodbye and warmly wished me good luck. I think it had seemed to her as if I were setting off on a journey with an uncertain end.

I spent one night at a hotel in Kiel, which seemed very cold and repellent to me, almost reminiscent of Germany's Nazi past. The next day, I went by train via Lubeck to

Travemunde. On Friday, October 27, when I arrived in Malmo in the evening hours on the German ferry I boarded from there, I was extraordinarily excited.

Now the moment of truth was at hand.

CHAPTER VI / A REFUGEE IN SWEDEN

I had arrived in the country where I would apply for asylum and, if all went well, spend years of my life. When I said I had come to see Associate Professor Göran Melander from Lund University, thinking this would provide security if anything went wrong, and that I would return to Turkey in a few days, the passport police immediately stamped my entry. The customs officer asked me to open my small bag. I was prepared: I had bought a Playboy magazine in Travemünde and placed it on top of the items in the bag. The customs officer made a few jokes about the Playboy and let me pass. When I stepped into Malmö, I could barely contain my joy. The blue-flamed torches lining the avenue from the ferry to the city center told me I had arrived in the land of the Vikings and filled me with hope.

I immediately found the train station and bought a ticket to Lund, only about 20 km away. I would later learn that the small city of Lund housed one of the country's most distinguished universities. While waiting for the train, a rather well-dressed young man carrying beer bottles in a plastic bag sauntered toward me and said something. When I said I didn't know Swedish, he asked in quite fluent English if I had a few kronor (Swedish currency) to spare. When he got no result, he didn't insist. This would be my first encounter with the gentleman beggars of Sweden, or rather of the Nordic countries.

Panic in Lund

My first task in Lund was to find a hotel. I had just started settling into my room when the receptionist woman came upstairs and asked something in Swedish, and I panicked. Had she noticed my passport was fake? Had she notified the police? I hastily said I had to leave immediately and fled the place. I found another hotel. When I realized I had left my bag containing my shaving kit in the previous hotel room, I reluctantly went back to retrieve it. The poor woman had no idea what was going on; she was looking at me in astonishment. This was the first of the senseless panics I would experience in my new country. I wouldn't feel safe until my asylum was granted.

Saturday morning, my first task was to call Melander. The phone rang but there was no answer. So I spent some of my limited pocket money and took a taxi to his address. Dog barking responded to my persistent ringing of the doorbell. The Melanders weren't home. I thought I might learn where they could be from the neighbors across the street. I knocked on the door of the villa directly opposite. The door was opened by a white-haired lady of about 80 who was very courteous. After telling me in fluent English that she didn't know the Melander family and that they might have gone to their summer house, she invited me to have tea with her, and I was so shocked I almost swallowed my tongue. My state of mind wasn't at all suitable for accepting the invitation; I politely thanked her and left. However, after walking a few steps, I knocked on the elderly lady's

door again to ask a question that came to mind, though I don't remember what it was now.

She didn't know the answer to my question, but she said: "You didn't want to have tea with me, but please wait here a moment, there's something I want to show you…" She had surprised me again. I waited curiously. Shortly after, she appeared with a small pot containing a single newly bloomed flower. "I've been taking great care of this plant for months. It finally bloomed today. Unfortunately, I have no one to share my joy with. That's why I wanted to show this to you…" she said. I was shaken. As I would mention in an article I wrote for the German newspaper Die Zeit about "what being European means to me," this incident told me that loneliness among the elderly was a serious problem in Sweden. From my perspective, however, it was a sign that things would go well for me in Sweden.

Associate Professor Melander and his unforgettable wife

There was no chance of seeing Melander until the beginning of the week. Nothing was disturbing me at the hotel where I was staying. I had relaxed a bit. On Saturday, I took the train to Malmö. Before exploring the city, I went straight to the post office and mailed the fake passport and identity card I had used to the address in Beirut where my elder brother wanted them sent so they could be returned to their owner. A great weight had been lifted from my shoulders. The following Sunday, I killed time wandering around Lund. The beauty of the Swedish girls I encountered on the streets was simply dazzling. Exchanging a few words with one of them at a café had done me good.

Early Monday morning, I grabbed the phone. Melander immediately invited me to his home and welcomed me very warmly. He knew I was coming. (Apparently, the Czech judge in Strasbourg had informed him.) He introduced me to his wife, who had Elizabeth Taylor's complexion and eye color, but was perhaps even more beautiful than her. They served coffee and cake and listened to my troubles. Melander said in summary: Getting asylum from Sweden won't be a problem for you. If you wish, you can apply right here. Finding an opportunity to do a doctorate at Lund University won't be difficult either. But "I think you would prefer to drown in the ocean rather than in a lake…" Therefore, I recommend you go to Stockholm. You can be sure I will follow up on your asylum application.

Yes, I also thought it would be wiser to go to Stockholm and that I could find broader opportunities there. I thanked the Melanders warmly, left, and that night of October 30th, I departed for Stockholm by train. As soon as I arrived in the city in the morning, following Melander's directions, I went to the Police Headquarters building located in Kungsholmen, within walking distance of the station. Young and beautiful girls were handling applications at the reception. I approached the most beautiful one and said directly that I wanted to seek asylum in Sweden. She didn't seem to have encountered an extraordinary request at all; she directly asked for my passport. When I said I didn't have a passport, she said without any surprise, "please wait a moment." Shortly after, 2-3 police officers came, took me to one of the upper floors; there they took almost all

my belongings and locked me in a room, paying no attention to my insistent requests to call my lawyer (meaning Melander).

“Everyone must answer for the crimes they commit”

In the room where I was placed, a young man who appeared to have passed out from alcohol or drugs was lying on a bed on the floor. Then the young man’s lawyer or visitor came, and they talked about something. The man didn’t respond at all to my request for help in contacting my lawyer. After a while, a police officer came and took me to a room on a lower floor. A white-haired, stern-looking, rather heavy commissioner interrogated me. When I said I wanted political asylum, he said, “Everyone must answer for the crimes they commit,” and added, “We don’t need people coming to Sweden to work either.” When I said I hadn’t come to work but was seeking political asylum, he said, “I served in Cyprus, I know what liars the Turks are…” (This would be the first and last ill treatment I would encounter in Sweden.) My soul darkened. I spent that night in detention almost without sleeping, fearing I would be deported to Turkey the next day. That was the impression the commissioner had given.

But the opposite happened. Early in the morning, police officers came; they ignored me as I walked toward them saying “I want to speak with my lawyer,” told me in English that I was being released following instructions from the State Immigration Office (Invandrarverket); they returned my belongings and just let me out onto the street. I was flying with joy… I was very happy, but what would I do now, how would I find shelter, how would I feed myself?! I thought: If I were in Turkey, I would go to the student association at the university and ask for help. That’s what I did. I found the address of Stockholm University Student Association (Stockholm Universitets Studentkar) in the phone book. At the association’s reception sat a blonde girl who again struck me as stunningly beautiful. When I explained my situation, she told me I had come to the wrong place, wrote down the address of the nearest “social bureau” (a name I was hearing for the first time) on a piece of paper, and explained how I could get there by metro. I had now learned to use the metro and was able to get help from people in finding addresses. Were Swedes good people, or was my good English helping? Both seemed possible.

I found the address at Medborgarplatsen; I explained my situation to an elderly female clerk. She wanted to see my passport, and when I said I didn’t have one, she wasn’t surprised at all. After immediately calling the Police Headquarters and getting information about me, she said I would receive a certain amount of financial assistance each month until my asylum application was concluded, and that she could find me a place to stay if I wanted. I accepted, flying with joy. Before I left, she reminded me that I needed to go to the Police Headquarters twice a week to sign in.

Parkgatan 20

I went to the address Parkgatan 20, near Friedhemsplan metro station. An elderly Swedish couple, Mr. and Mrs. Erik Öhman, were renting out a furnished room in their apartment. After listing one by one the conditions I needed to follow while using the room in their fluent English, they left me alone. I sensed this would be a temporary solution. I

can’t forget the nightmare I had the first night I stayed there: I was in Istanbul. I was surrounded by police in the house where I was hiding. I woke up in a sweat… When I looked out the window and saw the trees in the park in front of the house, I remembered I was in Stockholm. This would be the first and last nightmare I would have in Sweden.

On one of the days I went to sign at the Police Headquarters, they informed me that I needed to be there for an official interrogation on November 6th at 2 PM. I went there on the given day and time. I was taken into a room. The police commissioner who came to interrogate me said, “By law, we have to interrogate you. I will ask ten questions. You are free to answer them or not. You know English, but by law, I must have a Turkish interpreter with me. If you need, you can ask for his help,” and introduced the Turkish university student Doğan Tüney who was with him.

He was extremely polite. I gave detailed answers to all his questions except one. When I said I wouldn’t answer the question about how and with whose help I escaped from Turkey, the commissioner said, “If I were in your place, I wouldn’t answer this question either.” I would later run into this commissioner in Stockholm city center and we would greet each other. I would become friends with the interpreter Doğan Tüney, who had confined himself to listening to the interrogation. A few weeks after this interrogation, my asylum application was accepted; the obligation to go to the police station was lifted. I received the Swedish Alien’s Passport that I would use as identification from then on from the State Immigration Office. This passport allowed me to travel without a visa to many Western European countries. I wasn’t a Swedish citizen, but now I had a proper Swedish passport in my pocket. I now felt completely safe.

Tomas Hammar

Doğan Tüney was a political science student at Stockholm University. When I asked him who could help me pursue a doctorate at Stockholm University, he unhesitatingly gave me the name of Associate Professor Tomas Hammar and wrote his phone number on a piece of paper. How valuable Doğan’s recommendation would be would soon become apparent. The next morning, I called Hammar; I explained my situation. He said he would be waiting for me on November 10th at 2 PM in his office on the 8th floor of Building A at the university’s Frescati campus. What was happening?!.. I could only describe my experiences in Sweden as the English say, “Too good to be true.”

I had a long meeting with Hammar. I told him that I was a graduate of Ankara University Faculty of Political Science; that I had passed the doctoral qualifying exam there and reached the thesis stage, but when I started being sought by the military regime that seized power in 1971 due to my articles published in leftist magazines, I had to flee the country and sought refuge in Sweden. (I wouldn’t mention to anyone in Sweden for many years, including Tomas, that I had joined the Palestinian Resistance Movement. I was concerned—perhaps completely unnecessarily—that this could have consequences against me.)

The proposal Hammar made that very day was unbelievable: A major research project on the political values and behaviors of immigrants living in Stockholm was being prepared at the Political Science Department of Stockholm University. The project,

called “Political Resocialisation of Immigrants” (PRI for short), envisioned conducting a comprehensive field study on the variables affecting immigrants’ adaptation to Sweden’s political culture. Since the government was preparing to grant immigrants voting rights in local elections, the research, expected to be financed by the Central Bank, was important not only academically but also politically.

It had been decided that the research would cover Finns and Yugoslavs as the largest immigrant groups, as well as Poles who consisted entirely of political refugees. He said they were debating whether to include Turks or Greeks, who mostly consisted of economic migrants, and if I agreed to join the research team, the decision would be made in favor of Turks. In that case, I could be admitted to the doctoral program “through the back door” without taking the highly competitive entrance exam. The expected funding from the Central Bank needed to come through for the research to begin. Therefore, I had time to decide.

I simply couldn’t believe that such a proposal was being made to me as soon as we met, trusting only what I told about who I was and my education, my word, without any documentary evidence in my hands. Had I come to paradise on earth??!! I was facing an offer I couldn’t refuse. Was the happy future heralded by the flower that had bloomed that very day at the elderly lady’s home in Lund coming true?

There was some hesitation in me regarding the offer I received. Since I generally tended toward theoretical work, the idea of undertaking empirical research based on interviews didn’t seem very appealing. Additionally, I was being asked to write an undergraduate thesis to be able to work on the research.

Due to my hesitations, during the months when the project was expected to start, I did consider studying Sinology, that is, Chinese culture and history, also utilizing my background (?!) on China. I even contacted the relevant department at Stockholm University for this purpose and learned that I could be accepted. Fortunately, on one hand the difficulties of learning Chinese scared me, and on the other hand, strong reservations expressed by both Fatma and my elder brother would dissuade me from embarking on this adventure.

While waiting for the PRI Project to start, I thought it would be very wise to learn the language of the country (where I might stay for years, perhaps until I died). The Swedish government provided free Swedish courses for immigrants. At that time, courses were organized by the Workers’ Trade Union Confederation (ABF), the Civil Servants’ Trade Union Confederation (TBV), and other public education organizations. Completely by coincidence, I enrolled in TBV’s Swedish courses. After attending full-time courses for about five months, I took the Swedish proficiency exam at Stockholm University in April 1973 and passed. My knowledge of English played a major role in this, as Swedish is a language close to English grammatically and close to German lexically.

Üstünel and Abadan

At our second meeting in spring, Hammar asked if I knew the Turkish professor Besim Üstünel, who was a visiting faculty member in the economics department located just

one floor above the political science department; he said things would be easier if I could get a letter from him confirming I was a graduate of the Faculty of Political Science. I was very happy to hear this. Üstünel had been my professor. There was no way he wouldn't know me, because I had served a quite eventful term as president of the student association at the Faculty of Political Science. I immediately went upstairs and knocked on Üstünel's door. He recognized me immediately when he saw me and asked how I was. I explained that I would be doing a doctorate by working in a research group, but since I didn't have my diploma with me, I needed a letter stating that I was a graduate of the Faculty of Political Science. He said he couldn't provide such a letter without giving any reason. I was surprised.

It was apparent that he saw supporting a "Maoist" as dangerous. Honestly, I wasn't expecting this. Still, I thanked him and left, and of course I never saw him again. When I explained what happened, Hammar was also surprised; he said he would discuss the matter with department head Prof. Elias Berg. Berg, who hadn't even seen my face until that moment, unhesitatingly signed the letter confirming I was a graduate of Ankara University Faculty of Political Science. Thus my diploma problem was solved. I don't think I need to say what this incident told me about the general quality of Swedish and Turkish academics. (Years later, when I returned to my homeland and started working at newspapers, I met Üstünel on various occasions. He was quite friendly. I didn't see the need to tell him that Elias Berg, who didn't know me at all, had signed the letter he had refused to sign.)

I have another memory that makes one think about the quality of Turkish academics; let me tell it since the occasion has come. I think it was late 1979, early 1980. I was about to finish my doctorate. Prof. Dr. Nermin Abadan-Unat had come to Stockholm to attend an international conference on migration and had met Hammar. When Hammar mentioned me, Mrs. Nermin had said I was one of her former and best students at the Faculty of Political Science and wanted to see me. So we met at a reception Hammar gave at his home. Mrs. Nermin asked how I was and said complimentary things about me. We parted amicably.

The quite strange part Hammar told me later: Some time afterward, they met at a migration conference in another European city. Tomas told Mrs. Nermin that although they wanted me to stay in Sweden and continue working in the department, I was insistent on returning to my homeland. He asked if, in that case, she could help me get into a university in Turkey. The answer he received was: "Şahin is known as a Maoist: Therefore, unfortunately, I cannot help him…" Upon my return to the homeland, I met Mrs. Nermin a few times but never let on that I knew about this answer. I never wrote about these memories on any occasion. When I shared it with him, Hasan Cemal was surprised; he insisted, "Let me write about it…" but I didn't let him either. I'm recounting these memories here because they give a good idea about the intellectual class's fear of the state in Turkey.

Coming to my first year in Stockholm: I was friends with Doğan Tüney, whom I had met during the police interrogation, for a while; through him I also met a very interesting person. This was Hans Von Frankenstein, Doğan's womanizing buddy. Hans was a real

member of the world-famous Frankenstein family. He had lived in Istanbul, where his father was stationed, for a long time during his childhood and had gone to school there. It was quite interesting to meet, in Stockholm, a Frankenstein who spoke Turkish like a native and knew Turkey very well.

I was corresponding frequently with Fatma and my elder brother. I was very excited because I would be reunited with my wife and daughter sooner or later. I wanted them to come as soon as possible, because it had become clear that I would have a secure future in Sweden. I kept writing to Fatma insisting she come as soon as possible, that if necessary she could leave Elvan with her mother for a while. Fatma, partly thinking about the dangers that traveling with the Alpay surname might cause, and perhaps partly wanting to see whether I had "reformed," was determined to divorce before coming to Stockholm and take custody of our daughter Elvan, who was only 6 years old.

Letter from Fatma

In one of her first letters after I informed her that an opportunity had arisen for me to work at the university, she said: *"The news in your letter is wonderful. You can't know how happy it made us. We feel relieved and I'm now looking at our future with hope… You know I'll come to you but I think we shouldn't rush. We've been patient for so long, being a bit more patient will be good for all of us. I find it more appropriate to come without causing trouble. We waited 18 months; waiting 4-5 more months won't matter. I didn't like the idea of leaving Elvan either. If I leave her, she'll be devastated… Besides, my mother won't accept it. I can't trust her either. Also, you know they won't give me a passport… it would cause us trouble. The only thing left for me to do is divorce. I know you don't want us to separate. It scares you, doesn't it? That's why you're racking your brain and suggesting other ways… You're so sweet and amazing. I love you, don't worry, that's why I can't break away from you, haven't you realized yet? Stay faithful to me, I want you."* (22.11.1972)

I'm copying here some excerpts from her subsequent letters reflecting her unique personality, without changing a letter: *"Your loneliness makes me very sad. I can imagine what state you're in… You must find a solution as soon as possible… You must do something until we come. I believe you've imposed certain prohibitions on yourself. You must lift these prohibitions. Even if you don't feel like it, make friends with a girl. You can establish such a relationship as soon as possible. What's important for me is you. I want you to stay healthy. You're making even small matters into problems. These may not last either. You can be angry at me for everything I've written. But I don't want you to be upset and get caught up in new thoughts about me… If you think I want you to make me do what you want to do yourself, you'll make me very sad. Because I know you, I have to write these things too. Nothing and no one can change your love for me anymore. I believe in you. I want you to believe in me too. Nothing can shake my faith in your love and affection. The rest doesn't matter. You are mine… The decision about the work you'll do and the field you want to work in is yours. Whatever you want, whichever you find beneficial, make your decision."* (March 2, 1973)

In another letter she said: *“Apparently you’ve made everything dependent on my coming. I write in every letter that I’ll come to you. You must believe me… But I can’t leave Elvan… The child isn’t happy like everyone else’s child. There’s a big void in her life. Even though she doesn’t want to show it, I’d have to be stupid not to understand. I can’t describe her uneasiness to you… She cries every time I leave the house and says don’t go. Every time I leave, she thinks I won’t come back and is scared… I can’t be separated from Avoş [her pet name for Elvan] even for a few months. I have to think more about my child. I know there are a few possibilities to bring her to us. But I don’t act on possibilities. Especially in this environment… I don’t want to write more about this. And I don’t want you to say ‘leave Elvan and come’ in every letter.*

I’m not unaware of the state of your love for me. Yours, as you write, has ceased to be love and has become an obsession, a sickness… You take everything to extremes. I know you very well. A few years ago you also idolized certain people. I told you then too that what you were doing wasn’t right. After some time, for whatever reason, they would lose their greatness in your eyes and fall to zero. That’s the kind of man you are—so passionate, with a rich inner world, and also a bit inconsistent…

You’ve probably made me the sole purpose of your life these days. I would have wanted to always be the same thing for you. Then you would have been the same thing for me too… I don’t forget what you said to me in front of your friends. (In the days leading up to March 12th, I had said “If the revolutionary struggle requires it, I’ll leave you” and I had done just that…) *When you set aside your feelings, what you said showed how honest you are. None of your friends could be as honest as you…*

I want to spend my life with you, and very happily too. I can’t live with anyone else but you. I’ve compared you with many people… I find you superior to all of them. You always won. (Don’t get spoiled please.) I can’t know a second person with your qualities. Because there isn’t one. I accepted most of what you did to me in the old days as childishness. I believe the same things won’t happen again. The fact that your ideas have changed while your essence hasn’t is enough for me to believe in you. I don’t want your essence to change. I love and appreciate your human side (because it’s so strong).

Please don’t forget what I want from you. The first and most important of these is to love living life. And enjoy living. Life is very beautiful. For us, it will be even more beautiful from now on. I love living very much. I’m very attached to life. You should love it even more. Because you will give me pleasure. In return, I will make you love life too… If you love life, you’ll find many things to love, and thus you’ll love me normally too. You know me. I’m a normal person. I have no superior qualities. I think, what do I have to be loved this much? Then I say, since my husband loves me that way, I must have superior qualities. For this reason, I’m afraid of developing a complex. I see myself as superior to everyone. It’s not a good thing of course. So you see, my love, thanks to you, I’ve already started to get complexes. Will you get rid of them?… You don’t find me silly, do you?“ (March 29, 1973)

The divorce drags on

Fatma would do what she set her mind to. But as the divorce dragged on, her morale was deteriorating: *“The lawyer said we’ll get a decision in September. I’m agreeable to that too. I’m afraid of it dragging on even more. I received your letter, which says”come” from beginning to end. How many times have I written to you, my love. I can’t leave my daughter and come. I’m sorry, but I can’t think of being separated from her (unless God separates us). You seem to forget that I’m a mother. Motherhood and fatherhood are not the same. She’s the creature I gave life to… My priority is my daughter… Maybe I’m upsetting you but you need to appreciate me too. She’s very scared that I’ll leave her… Let’s put these aside. Who could she stay with? The mothers are getting old. You know your mother’s attitude already. And mine now needs to be taken care of… I don’t want to write these things again… I’m tired of hearing the same things and writing the same things. Besides, I’m not like I used to be. If they had told me I would become like this, I wouldn’t have believed it. My health isn’t good, nerves are terrible. In short, my situation is awful… my morale is zero too. I’m bored, bored, bored… How much longer will I have to swallow things. You’ve all ruined me as a family. And I was very patient… This is quite an unpleasant letter but I’m determined to show myself as I am. I have nothing left to give for morale. I need it now. I wish you patience and good luck.”* (19.06.73)

What she wrote was frightening me. Was I losing her? Her letter a month later increased my worries even more: *“Coming to your doctorate issue; you may have given up. You say you can’t give another year. You want to learn a new language and direct your studies that way. You’ve reached 30. Make your own decisions. I’m tired of making decisions… I also want you to be someone who makes the right decision for me. I’m tired of thinking. I don’t want to think about anything. Besides, your decision didn’t surprise me. You are you. No matter how much you want to change, it means you can only go so far. I don’t have much to say about this. I also can’t say I like it. But I’ll still say do what you want. What’s important is that you work on something you feel passionate about. I wish you healthy good days. I’ll write when I find the opportunity.”* (14.07.1973)

Another three months had to pass, and the divorce case had to be concluded, before the letter that relieved my worries arrived: *“My dear love, I don’t understand where you got the idea that you lost me… You still haven’t understood that I love you, apparently. If I didn’t love you, I wouldn’t have done any of the things I did, you know. You really screwed me over. Since I’m still thinking of coming, there must be some reasons, right, my darling. If I had thought of leaving you, I would have started building another life for myself long ago… I can’t think of someone else until living with you becomes impossible. I miss you. My love who is both mature and still a child. You’re a sweet man. You’re not an easy type to find. That’s why I didn’t even see the need to look. I want to come as soon as possible now. I’ll take care of the passport issue after the elections. (If they don’t give it, I’ll be devastated.) I don’t even want to think of such a possibility.*

I want to set out at the end of November. Some days I’m full of joy, some days I walk around with a long face. Damn this goiter, it’s causing me a lot of trouble. You’ll give me a beautiful life, won’t you. The past years have worn me out. Your life-filled wife isn’t like she used to be anymore. I don’t want the desires inside me to be destroyed. I’m fighting

my unwillingness toward life. I want to enjoy everything like before, to be joyful, to truly live. I love living very much. I want to not care about anything. I believe I'll gain these by your side… If I can't gain them, then I'll be destroyed, my love. I believe in you. I want our life to continue like the early days of our marriage. You'll give me such a life, won't you? We have the right to be happy now. We've suffered so much, my love.

I went to the doctor for the goiter. I learned that it's not very serious and can pass quickly with treatment… I've dropped to 50 kg. I'm like a model but my nerves are terrible. The lines on my face have increased. But don't worry, I'm beautiful. I'm still a conceited person. What do you say. I'm right, aren't I?.. So much time has passed that even if I had no special qualities, I must seem very pleasant to you. When will you become a doctor? You know I won't be a worker's wife… My sweet love, you're no longer my husband. Isn't that funny. Get ready to struggle with me. I'll make you suffer a lot. My anger is at its peak by the way… Your daughter and I kiss you thousands of times. (She kisses your photos secretly.)" (09.10.1973)

Letters from my elder brother

The letters from my elder brother were quite upsetting to me. (His story, which is also reflected in these letters, doesn't fit into my story. I will write his story separately.) Shortly after I left the country, they had a car accident, fortunately no one was hurt. He wasn't happy with his life at all. He was having financial difficulties. As if that weren't enough, the person from whom he had bought the passport for me kept asking him for money. In one of his first letters to Strasbourg, he wrote: *"Oktay has worn me out. I have no patience left. I want to end my relationship with him as soon as possible. The cost to me has come to twice the amount we committed, and not only have I received no financial help from anyone, but I've been in a very difficult situation due to the financial burdens caused by the accident afterward."* (28.10.1972)

Oktay wouldn't leave him alone: *"It was the last days of April. Oktay came to me. He said he would go to Germany as a worker. The financial side of the affair came to about 4 thousand lira. Since he had no money, I had to provide this too. I had to find 4 thousand lira. I had only been at the job for three days. I asked the boss, got an advance, and the passenger flew on May 14th. With all his sins, he was a good kid… I don't begrudge him a thing…"* (24.05.1973) Oktay said in the letter he sent him from Germany: *"I finally came to Germany and started working… for once I wanted to see you without asking anything of you, but it wasn't meant to be… I thank you again and again for your sacrifices in every way…"*

In almost every letter, I expressed my debt of gratitude to him, which I could never repay: "At a moment when everyone, everyone had given up hope on me and abandoned me to my fate, if I hadn't had a gem of a brother like you, everything would have been over for me. If a rebirth was possible for me, I owe it entirely to you." His response was: *"I was proud of you throughout my life. Because I found in you everything I felt I lacked in myself… I was proud even of your political ideas. Perhaps I wasn't a man of that struggle. Life's winds had steered me in another direction. Sometimes I had been against you too perhaps. The reason was the environment. They were pushing me*

to talk like that. Though I didn't want to, I was saying the things they themselves couldn't say—they were putting the words in my mouth… I simply acted as an elder brother to a brother whose very existence made me proud. If I couldn't have shown it, I would never have forgiven myself for the rest of my life… If something had gone wrong and I had been caught, it would have caused the loss of many things I valued in my life. But rest assured I would never have felt regret." (07.04.1973)

I also wrote: *"The pain of the burdens I've placed on your back, both spiritually and materially, weighs on me. And the fact that I can't do anything to help you other than sit and express my distress in letters crushes me spiritually, crushes me… Believe me, the guilt I feel often makes me say this: The water jug should have broken on its way to the water. What did this wretched self of mine, this selfishness, have that was worth so much trouble?.. The solution was always an honorable death that I longed for but never happened. Perhaps the closing of this file would have been better for all of us, all of us. You'll say, it's easy to say these things now. True… I apologize for everything I put you through. Despite everything, forgive me. I didn't want to rub salt in the wounds of the various troubles you've encountered in life. But it's easy to say these things now. Forgive me."* (13.06.1973)

He was changing jobs frequently in an effort to improve his financial situation. At the same time, he was expressing his desire to emigrate to Sweden if it were possible. But with my warnings about the unfavorable conditions, he was aware of how difficult this would be. In one of his letters, he said, *"When I started thinking very seriously about coming to Sweden to work, I realized I couldn't do it…"* He finally fulfilled his desire to come to Stockholm and see me during a trip to England for the company he worked for, between November 2-5, 1973. Seeing me having rebuilt my life pleased him greatly. And perhaps he envied it.

What he wrote upon returning to Istanbul reflected his disappointments about his own life: *"You write that you saw me in a very good mood in Stockholm. True. I was. But it was temporary. I was happy. I had come to see you for three, even 2.5 days… Not to harass you by telling my depressions… I tried to appear as I should be… For several years now, deep down I haven't been the Acar seen from the outside. I know the reasons for this very well. There was an Acar in my ideal, my friend. No matter what I did, I couldn't become that Acar. Various incidents, coincidences, impossibilities, and mistakes I sincerely made thinking they were right at the time. And mistakes… They distanced me so much from that ideal Acar that, since it's no longer possible to go back and start over, I have to continue the fight as a type I never wanted to be. Helplessness. The more one struggles, the more one is dragged into the swamp… Your wife, your siblings, worst of all even your children can't know you well… for a thinking person like me, it's a disgrace… I've entered such a cycle that I can't turn back… Actually, I don't know how to turn back. A new year is coming… it would have been good to start life in another country and build it as I wanted again. But even dreaming of it is forbidden to me."*

Karin and Gunnar

Fatma's divorce, getting passports, and coming to Sweden would take until January 1974. Among the noteworthy things that happened to me until she came were the following. My sister-in-law Ayla sent me a letter with the addresses and phone numbers of their Swedish acquaintances Karin and Gunnar, and informed them that I would call them. Partly so as not to embarrass my sister-in-law, I called Karin and went to visit their home in the far south of Stockholm. Karin and Gunnar were a couple in their 70s. They had been in Turkey as journalists to follow Ecevit's election campaign and had somehow met my sister-in-law in the meantime. They received me very warmly. They were good people. Their twin children, daughter Pia and son Pier, were still of high school age. It was obvious they had become parents quite late. (Gunnar would commit suicide a few years later, unable to bear the cancer pains.) Karin helped me find a more suitable place to stay. Meanwhile (even though she knew I was married with a child), she wanted me to befriend her daughter Pia. I wasn't very keen on this idea.

The place Karin found for me by looking at newspaper ads was an address in the Tensta-Rinkeby area, densely populated by immigrants from Turkey and quite far from the city center. A young Polish woman in her 30s, whose name I don't remember, was renting out a small independent unit consisting of one room and a bathroom-toilet across from her own apartment. Tensta didn't have a metro in those years; one commuted by bus. I had started attending Swedish courses. Because I was somewhat bothered by the distance of the house and somewhat by my landlady's expectations of companionship, I asked Karin to find me a different place.

Östermalmstorg

The new place she found was this time right in the heart of the city, at Jungfrugatan 5 in Östermalmstorg, one of the most prestigious neighborhoods. Since the address was very attractive, I immediately called the landlord and went to visit. A middle-aged Swedish woman named Ulla was working as a night secretary at the country's best-selling newspaper Dagens Nyheter. She had started living separately from her husband and needed someone who could stay at night with her young son and daughter, who attended elementary school. She wasn't asking for rent for the room I would stay in. She must have liked me, because she said, "Many people applied, but if you want, I can give you the room."

I had now started living in the heart of the city. However, as days passed, it became clear that this arrangement wouldn't work either. Doing a kind of babysitting for the children was difficult. Ulla was introducing me to her drunk husband as if I were her boyfriend. Then one night she opened my door and jumped on me naked. I barely escaped. I had to find a new place as soon as possible. I met two Greeks in the Swedish courses. One of them, Yorgo, who sat right next to me, one day addressed me in Turkish after avoiding it for a long time. He had learned village Turkish from his mother, who was a Karamanlı / one of the Karamanlides (subjected to forced migration to Greece under the 1923 population exchange agreement; Turkish in mother tongue, Greek Orthodox in faith).

I quickly became friends with the other Greek, Anestis (Kombokis). Anestis was around my age. He had aspirations of being a painter and would never give up on this aspiration. He was like-minded in many ways. He lived in an apartment near the police station in Kungsholmen with his Swedish girlfriend at the time, a nurse named Anna. (He would later marry two Swedish women and divorce the second one, who gave him three children.) Through him, I met many Greeks. The friendship I established with Kostas Ladopulos, his wife Margareta Mellberg whose father was Swedish and mother was Greek, his brother Dimitris, and their circle confirmed the observation that Turks become friends with Greeks abroad.

Fred Krimgold

I had interesting teachers in the Swedish courses. The first, Emma, was an extremely pleasant, intelligent, cultured, middle-aged woman. She had mixed-race children from her Black Sierra Leonean husband. My Swedish teacher after Emma, with whom I had established good dialogue, was even more interesting: Anna, who was only in her twenties, came to me during a coffee break on one of the very first days of the course and said that her American friend named Fred had been in the same class with a Turk named Halil Berktay at Yale University. She asked if I knew Berktay… The world was truly small. Shortly after, Anna introduced me to Fred (Krimgold). Fred was an architect specializing in disaster engineering. He was doing his doctorate at Stockholm Technical University (Tekniska Högskolan) and was interested in disaster problems in Turkey. He lived in the old town, Gamla Stan, in a historic building near the Slussen bridge (Skeppsbron, No. 46). As soon as we met, he immediately offered to rent me a room in his apartment. I suspected that behind the warmth shown at the time by Fred, who is still my friend, lay his aim of using Anna's interest in me to get closer to her. Fred achieved his desire a few years later and managed to marry Anna; although their marriage didn't last long.

From May 1973, I rented one of the rooms in Fred's apartment. The greatest benefit of meeting Fred would be meeting through him (the late) architect Dinç Gürs and his Finland-Swedish wife Bambi (Barbro), who would be our lifelong friends. (There is a Swedish minority in Finland that makes up about 5 percent of the population. Swedish is one of the official languages.)

Anna von Celsing

Anna had a very interesting identity. Her lineage went back to Gustaf von Celsing, one of Sweden's first ambassadors to the Ottoman Empire in the 18th century, and his sons Gustaf and Ulric von Celsing. (Her father was also Sweden's ambassador to Argentina at the time.) When the von Celsings returned from Istanbul, they placed the items they brought with them in their estate in the town of Biby, about 130 km southwest of Stockholm, on about a thousand dönüms (roughly 100 hectares) of land. Anna took me to Biby by car one weekend. The lower floor of the estate was full of the Celsings' belongings. The decor evoking 18th century Istanbul was exciting. (As I learned later, when the Celsing family faced financial problems, they put the property up for sale in 2001. Various furniture and other items including 103 watercolor and oil paintings inside

were first offered to the Turkish, then Swedish culture ministries. Unfortunately, when no positive response was received, it was sold to the Orientalist Museum in Doha, Qatar for 30 million dollars.)

That day Anna also took me to the historic Katrineholm castle near the Celsing estate, protected by the Swedish culture ministry, which housed many oil paintings related to the Ottoman Empire. The painting depicting the Ottoman dynasty tree was the one that stayed in my memory the most. What I saw that day was quite impressive for me, who knew nothing about the history of Sweden-Turkey relations other than Demirbaş Şarl ("Charles the Fixture," as the Turks called Charles XII), who took refuge with the Ottomans and was "the Swedish king fed from the treasury." When I went with Anna to visit her sister and the sister's Austrian husband, who lived near Drottningholm, where the Swedish royal family's summer palace is located, I had the opportunity to meet the world-famous sculptor İlhan Koman, who was living with his wife on a boat. He showed me around his sculpture studio that he had set up in a cave. His Swedish wife whom I met was quite drunk. Koman's works, however, were admirable.

After taking classes at TBV for about five months from December 1972, I took the Swedish proficiency exam at Stockholm University in May 1973 and passed. I had started speaking Swedish haltingly. Since I didn't want to continue living on social assistance, I applied to the employment office to work during the summer months. In April 1973, I started working at an ice cream factory owned by the Glasbolaget company in the Nacka district, not far from Slussen pier. I wrote to my elder brother, "I've finally joined the international working class! I get up at 4:30 in the morning, get on the bus at 4:48, start work around 5:35… When work ends, I'm limp as a rag…"

Female urologist

Most of the factory workers consisted of young girls, mostly Finns. The relatively heavy work was handled by a small number of male workers from various countries. The work I did consisted of dipping ice cream-filled cones placed on a metal tray coming out of a giant refrigerator into chocolate sauce. The cold air that the refrigerator blew toward my lower body had a price. When I started having difficulty urinating, I had to go to the hospital. They referred me to a female urologist. In quite an embarrassed state, I explained my problem. She asked me to lie on the examination table and expose my penis. After examining it thoroughly, she determined that my penis had caught cold and prescribed medicines that made me recover quickly. I was quite embarrassed while the urologist, who was a very beautiful woman, held my penis and examined it. I was getting to know another aspect of Swedish culture that didn't recognize the boundaries I was used to from my homeland.

In the fall of 1973, I started working on the pilot project of the PRI research. I started commuting by train a few days a week to the city of Södertalje, about 30 km southwest of Stockholm. There I interviewed about 50 randomly selected citizens of Turkey registered as residents there. What was surprising was that most of them were Assyrians from Mardin and Midyat. Many said they had fled to Sweden not from the military regime but from Kurdish oppression, and they had no complaints about the

military. On this occasion, I was learning an aspect of Turkey I didn't know, that there was a dense Assyrian population in the Southeast, and that some Kurds had driven a significant portion of them out of the region through various forms of pressure. (I would later learn that Assyrians fleeing from Turkey had also taken refuge in other European countries, especially Germany.)

In the fall of 1973, Dinç Gürs offered to hand over to me the Turkish courses he was giving at TBV. Of course, I accepted with pleasure and continued this work for several terms. I could now mainly teach the lessons in Swedish, but since all the students knew English, I was using a Turkish textbook prepared in England and could resort to English when necessary. We held the courses in a high school building in the evening hours. The walls of the classroom I used were decorated with, among other pictures, photographs showing in what ways women's genitals could be shaved. I was getting to know yet another aspect of Swedish culture.

I met interesting people in my Turkish courses. One of my students, most of whom consisted of Swedish women married to or friends with Turks, was Ann-Marie, wife of the famous photographer Lütfü Özkök. A Finn married to a Turkish lady and a Hungarian-born architect (Adrian) who came to the courses out of admiration for the musicality of Turkish were among the others who stayed in my mind. But the one who impressed me most among the students was definitely Madeleine. One evening when she opened the door and entered just as the lesson was about to start, the attention of all 15-20 people in the class focused on her. A strikingly beautiful woman with her white skin, green eyes, blonde hair, tall stature, elegant black outfit, and graceful posture—I can say she was the most beautiful woman I saw in Sweden.

Dinç and Saygun

At the end of courses that lasted about twelve weeks, it was customary for the teacher to have a farewell dinner with attending students and their spouses. I was quite surprised when Madeleine showed up at the dinner at the end of that term with her Kurdish architect husband, who barely came up to her shoulder and was far from handsome. I learned at that dinner that they had been married for a long time and had three sons. When I learned during a Stockholm visit after returning to Turkey that Madeleine had suddenly left her husband and children and settled in America with her young Swedish lover, I honestly wasn't too surprised. The fact that almost all of the Turks or Greeks I knew who were married to Swedish women, with one or two exceptions, eventually divorced their spouses gave me an idea about the institution of marriage in Sweden.

Dinç had opened a clothing store near Odenplan, one of Stockholm's main squares. Besides the Turkish courses at TBV, he had also handed over to me the job of teaching mother tongue classes to children of immigrants from Turkey. In those years, the Swedish administration was committed to the ideal of a multicultural society; in this context, immigrant children were granted the right to take mother tongue lessons. (Literacy lessons were also given to immigrant women from Turkey who needed them.) My most striking memory from the mother tongue teaching I conducted for a few months was this: When I realized one of my students was Kurdish, I asked his father, whom I

had the opportunity to meet, why he enrolled his son in Turkish rather than Kurdish mother tongue lessons. His answer was simple: “We’re thinking of returning to Turkey in a few years. When we return, Turkish, not Kurdish, will be useful for his work…” I know that in the following years, for the vast majority of immigrants from Turkey regardless of their origin, the dreams of returning to the homeland were not realized; and that the number of families who wanted their children to receive mother tongue education steadily declined.

Thanks to Dinç, I also met Saygun Kuyumcu, who would become one of my lifelong friends. Saygun’s story is interesting enough to briefly mention here. He had completed his secondary education in Egypt, where his mother’s second husband was stationed (at Turkey’s Alexandria consulate), and learned Arabic well. He later settled in Istanbul and started studying at Robert College, but finished high school (like all unruly students) at Yeni Kolej. Later, in Sweden, where his path somehow led him, he married Eija, a Finn, and they had two children.

When I met Saygun, he was teaching mother tongue and physical education to Turkish children at a high school in Tensta-Rinkeby. Toward the end of the 1970s, even before we did, he and his wife decided to take the children and return to Turkey. However, due to the increasing violence in the country, they regretted it two years later and returned to Stockholm. In 1979, I was looking for a rental house in Istanbul. Saygun told me to talk to his late mother Mrs. Nermin, and if I could convince her, she could rent us her apartment in Akatlar. We were able to rent Mrs. Nermin’s apartment only after her death in 1985, unfortunately, and we lived there for exactly 33 years until my Fatma’s death in 2018; our children grew up there. To this day, I’m amazed at how Saygun, one of my closest friends (originally Circassian), can still be so Turkish and equally Swedish. He is like the embodiment of multi-identity/multiculturalism.

Through one of my students in the TBV courses, I also met Zeynel Çelikel, who would become one of my closest friends in life. Years later, Zeynel divorced his Swedish wife and returned to Turkey; first he settled in Datça, then in Keremköy near Ayvalık… I will tell his quite dramatic story in “Human Landscapes from My Life,” which I plan to write if I live long enough.

Stockholm

My time in Sweden was approaching one year, and my impressions were accumulating. How right I was to come to Stockholm. Stockholm was a very orderly city with wonderful nature, intertwined with forests and the sea. It lay on the shore of an archipelago of some 22 thousand islands and islets. Swedes lived in prosperity. They owed this prosperity to the Social Democratic Party, which had been in power since 1932. The social democrats had achieved a good synthesis of liberal economy and democracy. Step by step, my respect for Sweden and Swedes was increasing.

Swedes were a highly educated society. Income distribution was quite fair. The strong position of women in society was very impressive for someone like me coming from Turkey. The equality in male-female relations, sexual freedom, and the prevalence of cohabitation instead of marriage quite surprised me. The Protestant Swedish Church

was under state control, but there was complete freedom of belief. Unfortunately, I would learn too late that everyone, including immigrants, had to pay church tax (unless they objected). The separation of church and state, promised by the Social Democrats, would only happen in 2000. Yes, Swedes were quite cold people, but they were very honest and polite. The prevalence of suicides, despite how happy they seemed, was ironic. One reason for this could be the harshness, length, and darkness of winters; but the rapid urbanization experienced in the 20th century had also led to social isolation, people becoming distant from each other, and alienation.

The process of radical change in the paradigm (the macro theory) I carried in my mind for trying to understand the world had begun. This process continued until the late 1970s. In my first years in Sweden, I was aware that “real socialism,” that is, “scientific socialism” as practiced in the world, had major problems, but I thought these stemmed more from implementation issues. Perhaps the best witness to this is the late architect Oğuz Öztuzcu, whom I met in Stockholm (again through Dinç) and who would become one of my lifelong friends. I had met him and his wife at the time, Duygu, shortly before Fatma came to Stockholm. As Oğuz often reminded me, in the first days after we met in 1973, I would say that I was a communist and that I believed the world revolution would happen someday. I remember that we had quite a lot of exchange of ideas about Marxism and real socialism with Ishtiaq Ahmed from Lahore (Pakistan) and Gautam Navlakha from Mumbai (India), whom I met at the university. (Their stories will certainly be the subject of “Human Landscapes from My Life” that I plan to write.)

I find Sabetay and Cengiz

In October 1973, Sabetay’s response to the letter I sent after finally learning his Paris address had arrived. He described his incredible encounter with Cengiz in Paris like this: “I had no contact with any Turks until I ran into Zekeriya with my eyes wide open in amazement at a cafe I frequented. You can imagine what state of mind I was in…” About his political views, he also wrote: “I haven’t lost my belief in the revolution for a moment. But I’m not ready to enter a long, complex struggle that requires endurance. Even the effort I need to show to create the conditions seems daunting to me, and more than anything, after what we experienced in the past, I’m afraid of taking wrong steps that will be repeated every day…” These lines well reflected our common thoughts and feelings of those days. Sabetay remained one of my closest friends in terms of our intellectual adventure.

I started corresponding with Cengiz. In his first letter, he said, “You can’t know how happy I was with your letter. Since we parted, I kept thinking with a bitter feeling whether we would ever meet again. For more than a year, I’ve been sending various news to the homeland trying to find you” (24.09.1973). His second letter ended like this: “Remember that you’re not alone, that there’s a group of people who love you, and among them is Zek, who loves you from the heart, who has known you as his most dear, most beloved comrade for two years, and who reserves a special place for you above everyone else.” (02.10.1973)

Cengiz's letters had made me extremely happy. Contrary to what I feared, all the time that had passed and all the different experiences we lived through had not distanced us from each other, but on the contrary, had brought us closer. In one of his letters, he summarized well what we had been through: "My dear, one or two books, five or ten strikes, ten or fifteen demonstrations and hop, we found ourselves on the threshold of armed struggle! This Turkish revolutionary movement was just like the upstart who's never seen anything before—honestly, looking at it now." (22.10.1973) Our ideas would follow quite different paths over time, but Cengiz and I always remained very close friends.

I learned from Cengiz's letters that we had been sentenced to death by the TİİKP (Revolutionary Workers' and Peasants' Party of Turkey) as turncoats who had betrayed the revolution. (Many years later, it would be possible to meet the person who was assigned to execute me and learn the story. Oğuz had joined the TİİKP ranks while doing his physics doctorate at Birmingham University in England on a state scholarship, and had abandoned the doctorate to become a full-time revolutionary. When he received the assignment, he tried to find me for a while, then gave up on it. He had decided to return to Turkey and was caught and imprisoned for a while. When I met him, he was living with his wife somewhere in the hills of İznik.) Cengiz, like me, had escaped execution: He had encountered the TİİKP member assigned to kill him in a house in Paris and had managed to convince him of the meaninglessness of this execution. Apparently, the execution sentences issued against us didn't have much of a serious side.

The days of the Marxist paradigm in my mind were numbered, but it would still take another year or two for it to reach the point of collapse. Perhaps the final point of my communism would be when I stepped aside and stood in a moment of silence upon learning from a newspaper headline in the Stockholm metro in September 1976 that Mao Zedong had died.

In October 1973, when Fred had to vacate the apartment in Slussen, I moved to Anestis's apartment at Hjarnegatan 2 in the Kungsholmen district. I must share an unforgettable memory from my days there: One night when I lay down to sleep, I heard such vulgar screams from the room directly above that it gave me the impression someone was being murdered. I woke Anestis in concern and said, "Anestis, I'm worried, I think they're slaughtering a woman upstairs…" His reply was: "Don't worry, my friend, that woman gets slaughtered every night…" I don't remember ever laughing so much at my own naivety.

My hope for reunion

In September 1973, my hope of soon being reunited with my Fatma and my Elvan grew. My Fatma wrote in her letter informing me that the divorce case had concluded and she had obtained custody of Elvan: *"Our case is over, my love. I got the decision too. You're forbidden to marry for one year. But not me. Funny, isn't it?.. Not many people know we got divorced. I don't really tell anyone. It somehow feels shameful to me…"* (26.09.1973)

However, she thought it would be risky to set off immediately after the divorce decision. After another two months passed, she applied for a passport in early December 1973. In her last letters before coming, she wrote: *"I want to live without thinking about anything anymore. I'm tired, you know?.. I have a world of problems in my life. I don't know how I'll solve them. It's best to just let everything take its course… I'm not closing up the apartment for now. The people I know here will probably take care of it while I'm there… My first attempt for the journey was to have my photograph taken. This week I'll officially start the passport process… The other day Avoş asked me again when you're coming. He won't come, let me get you a new father, I said. I don't want one, she said. I won't call him father, she said. Then what will you call him, I asked. I'll call him uncle, she said. Then she asked me, what will you tell my father if he comes. I'll say I waited, he didn't come, so I got someone else… Then I'll go with my father, she said… Seeing she was getting really upset, I said don't worry, I'll take you to your father. My little one relaxed. The shameless thing also said she loves you more. How much she must miss you, right? Who knows what she thinks about you. I'm very curious about how you're doing there. We have a very sweet daughter. And she's getting more beautiful. It won't be easy to hold her back. She's an incredible feminine creature. She doesn't resemble me at all… I'll give you more definite news in my next letter. Hopefully it will turn out well. I don't know what I'll do if they refuse. I'm even afraid to think about it. May all the luck be ours…"* (02.12.72) And finally: *"I can give you the good news now. Today we got our passports. I'm letting you know immediately… I'll come after New Year's… I'm so happy, my life."* (20.12.73)

My excitement had reached its peak… I had been longing for my Elvan since April 1971, for my Fatma since July 1972. My struggle to bring my family back together was finally bearing fruit… I had made my preparations, and in early November, with Tomas's help, I had rented one of the apartments in the Lappkarsberget (Lappis) housing complex in the university district of Frescati, available to teaching staff. The two-bedroom apartment with all modern comforts at Professorslingan 45/4 would be the Alpays' first home in Stockholm, where they would stay until May 1975.

I was keeping my relationships in Stockholm limited to as few people as possible. Until I settled in Lappis, I didn't have a phone of my own. The consequences of getting a phone were immediately apparent. One of the first days I was staying in Lappis, the phone rang; the voice on the other end said: "Şahin abi [elder brother, a respectful form of address], I'm İsmail, Hanife's brother. How are you?.." I couldn't collect myself at first. Who was this İsmail? He reminded me. He was a young fellow townsman from Ayvalık whom I hadn't seen for many years. I had met his sister Hanife and İsmail in our youth when they worked for Ömer Madra's grandmother, and I hadn't seen them for a long time. He had been working as a deckhand on cargo ships for a while. He had heard from his sister Hanife that I was in Stockholm, and when his ship happened to stop in Stockholm, he had wanted to look me up right away. But how had he obtained my phone number? "I went to the central station, asked the first Turk I ran into. He pulled it right out and gave it to me…" can you believe it?! It turned out later: the person İsmail had run into was the husband of one of the Swedish students attending my Turkish courses.

Stockholm Central Station, like for all immigrants, is full of memories for me too. At one point, I did freelance interpreting work for extra income. I would usually meet the people from Turkey I was going to help at the “meeting point” right in the middle of the station, and from there we would head to wherever we needed to go. Once, as soon as I entered through the station door, the compatriot I was going to interpret for stopped me, saying “Hello, Şahin Bey…” In astonishment, I asked how he had recognized me immediately. His answer was, “I recognized you by your walk, abi…” Apparently, I had no chance of hiding my Turkishness.

The day I had dreamed of

As I waited to greet Fatma and Elvan at Arlanda Airport on January 15, 1974, my heart felt like it would stop from excitement. The day I had dreamed of had finally come. I hadn’t seen my daughter for about 3 years, my wife for about 2 years. Finally, they came through passport control… First, I embraced Elvan. She had grown so much; to me, she was the most beautiful girl in the world… She was only 6 years old but extraordinarily mature. My beloved, now 30 years old, seemed even more elegant and more beautiful than ever. I cannot describe with what happiness I embraced them…

In our first weeks together, my Fatma seemed distracted and troubled. After about three years, as she began living with me again in a completely different environment, she must have had doubts about whether our relationship would work… There were things she wanted to discuss with me. It took a few months for us to talk through all these things and for her to conclude that our relationship could continue. Elvan’s happiness with her new life gradually played a role in convincing her to stay with me.

My little Elvan showed an incredible ability to adapt. One of the first things I did when renting the apartment was to secure a spot for Elvan at the nearest kindergarten. Just a few days after she arrived in Stockholm, I took her to the nursery she would now attend five days a week. They had said that at least for the first week, the mother or father would need to come with the child. Just a few minutes after meeting the caregivers and other children at the nursery, she came over and said, “You can go, dad…” which both surprised and delighted me greatly. The warmth of the nursery’s reassuring, motherly caregiver Else Marie played a big part in Elvan’s quick adaptation, but the main thing was my dear daughter’s extraordinary ability to adapt, which she would display throughout her life. Learning Swedish didn’t take long either. In the first days in front of the color television we had bought and started watching, Elvan would say “What’s he saying?.. What’s he saying?..” waiting for me to translate, but a few weeks later she started answering the phone in Swedish. One weekend, she answered those calling for me like this: “Pappa inte hemma, han stadar… / Dad’s not home, he went to clean…” I was proud of Elvan’s speed in learning Swedish.

About two months after they came to Stockholm, Fatma described my relationship with Elvan in a letter she wrote to my elder brother and sister-in-law: *“Little Elvan has lost the concept of father in three years. Because she was very small before, the concept probably never took hold. For Elvan, Şahin is a friend named father… She loves him, scolds him, and argues with him. She sees herself as equal to her father. The funniest*

part is that both of them report their complaints to me. I often laugh because the situations seem so strange. I'm the authority at home. When coming here, I had decided to hand this responsibility over to Şahin, but it's an impossible thing…"

She also reflected her impressions of Stockholm: *"I really liked the location of the apartment and Stockholm. It's especially good that where we live is comfortable for children. Having the nursery across from us makes things easy for Elvan… I stayed home for days from morning to evening and it was starting to get to me. Starting the Swedish courses was positive in this regard. I met people of various nationalities; I should add that most of them are funny types. For now, I'm both having fun and learning something at the courses. Yesterday we entered the third week since I started the course. As you can imagine, I still show no signs of speaking. My conversations with classmates in class are like Tarzan's; a mix of Turkish, English, and Swedish. I laugh a lot at my words afterwards. Last night a young boy selling eggs and potatoes came to the door. If you had been with me and heard me bargaining, I would have been good material for you… When I tell Şahin, he laughs a lot at the states I get into. Everything here is comfortable and nice, but not having friends creates a very big void in my life. Although the people here are helpful, they are very foreign types to me. I like Stockholm but I don't love it. I don't know if I'll be able to get used to it here. I'll only be able to answer all these questions after a long time. It probably wouldn't be right for me to speak definitively about such matters these days…*

"Dear Acar, why are you thanking me? I wanted to come here. I thought of all three of us when making this decision. I can't decide whether I did right or wrong. But this path seemed right to me… As for my health, it's zero. I'm falling apart in every way. I don't seem to have a healthy spot. I've had gastritis in my stomach for a long time. It's probably going to turn into an ulcer soon. I haven't started treatment yet. We're waiting for the residence permit so we can get it done cheaply… I need to wake up at 7:00 tomorrow. One of my great pleasures was waking up late. Of course, I've been deprived of that since starting the courses. What would it matter if they started at 10:00 instead of 8:30!…" (19.03.1974)

As the days passed, Fatma, like Elvan, gradually began to adapt to the new environment. She was enjoying herself and having a good time at the Swedish lessons. As she met Turkish friends, she also began to embrace Stockholm. When summer came, our new life together fell into place and never experienced another upheaval.

Are you from inside or outside?

In June 1974, my nephew Ahmet, the son of my elder sister Sumru, who was attending university in Belgium, came to join us, taking advantage of the work permit and earning opportunity granted to foreign students in Sweden during the summer months. First, he worked as a waiter for a while at a cafe near the central station. When he addressed the Turkish young men he was serving in Turkish, they were surprised and asked: "Are you from inside or outside?.." The young people Ahmet encountered were from the Kulu district of Konya, like the majority of Turks living in Stockholm in those years, and they were actually asking: "Are you from Kulu or not?.." This anecdote of Ahmet's was a clear

expression of how Turks living in Stockholm at that time were divided into “Kulu people and others.”

Since the Turkish courses I was teaching had ended, schools had closed, and the Södertalje pilot research was completed, I had to find a new job. I never wanted to live on welfare from the social office. Together with Ahmet, we found a rather heavy but well-paying job; we started doing factory cleaning. On one of the days I wasn’t working, Ahmet was late leaving the factory when evening came and got locked inside. When he informed me of the situation by phone, I was annoyed at his delay and simply told him to find a way out. Thereupon, Ahmet jumped over the iron railing surrounding the yard, and while jumping, his little finger got caught on the sharp point of the railing. Fortunately, the people around helped get him to the hospital. When I got there, the doctors said they unfortunately had to cut off the tip of his little finger. I cannot forget the sorrow and guilt I felt for not immediately going to help him… My only consolation was that this incident had not ended in a much more disastrous way.

As her mood gradually improved, it would become clear that Fatma’s health problems were not physical but psychological. Although she couldn’t make much progress in the Swedish courses, she was having quite a good time. The lifelong friendships we formed with the couples Dinç and Bambi Gürs, Oğuz and Duygu Öztuzcu, Saygun and Eija Kuyumcu, Zülfü and Ülker Livaneli, and Sait and Gülder Koçaş made the greatest contribution to Fatma’s adjustment to life in Sweden. Thanks to them, we had many beautiful days in Stockholm.

One of my unforgettable memories from our first days in Lappis was the young man I encountered in the courtyard in the middle of the housing blocks. I was surprised when he called out to me with a fluent “Merhaba!” in Turkish. Because with his blonde hair, blue eyes, and height of at least 1.80 meters, he resembled a Swede; but he was a genuine, dyed-in-the-wool Turk, and then some, who had been living in Stockholm for years. Nurgun and I quickly became friends. He showed great warmth; he helped me solve everyday problems. He was very capable. In the following years, he had managed to work three different jobs simultaneously and get elected to the municipal council from the Social Democratic Party, but in the meantime, he had to close the pide (Turkish flatbread) shop he opened because he couldn’t give it proper attention. We would be sad to hear years later that his Swedish wife Lotta, who was a very kind-hearted person and put up with all his eccentricities, couldn’t take it anymore and divorced him.

The 1973 elections

The general elections held in Turkey on October 14, 1973 unexpectedly and as a result of parliamentary mathematics led to the formation of a coalition government between Bülent Ecevit’s Republican People’s Party (CHP) and Necmettin Erbakan’s National Salvation Party (MSP), with Ecevit as prime minister. It had become clear that a period of relaxation would open in the country’s political life. My elder brother was writing that a political amnesty was being discussed and that my return to the country might be possible in the not-too-distant future. I was astonished. I was writing to my elder brother: “The political news from Turkey is heartening. To be honest, it never crossed my mind

that Ecevit could win the elections or form a government and pass an amnesty. That's how far we are from being able to understand Turkey…" (03.02.1974) I would continue to remain far from understanding Turkey.

The general amnesty law adopted on May 18, 1974 excluded political convicts. However, upon CHP's application, the Constitutional Court expanded the amnesty in its July 2 decision to also include political prisoners based on the principle of equality. Shortly after this, the law granting university graduates the opportunity to do military service as short-term reserve officers was also passed. Doing only 4 months of military service starting from July 1975 and being discharged as a reserve officer was an opportunity not to be missed. Still, I had hesitations. I was writing to my elder brother: *"Almost everyone I know abroad has decided to return. Fatma's attitude is 'I can't guarantee that I'll always be with you either here or in Turkey. Nor can I decide for you. Don't ask me anything, decide what you'll do yourself…' I suppose the best thing is to benefit from the amnesty, do the military service, and then return to Sweden. But the dangers also make me think… The chauvinist nationalist atmosphere stirred up because of Cyprus doesn't make me optimistic. If I'm going to spend even one day in prison, let's not bother with this. If I come, I should be able to return to Sweden within 6-7 months and continue my doctorate. If they don't give me a passport to return, all my efforts will be wasted…"*

From Damascus to Amsterdam

Cengiz Çandar had managed to cross from Beirut to Europe at the end of 1973 and had received political asylum from the Netherlands. We had been corresponding for a while. To see him and decide together what we would do, I went to Amsterdam by train between September 11-15, 1974. We had said farewell in Damascus in February 1972, under extraordinary circumstances; about two and a half years later, we met in Amsterdam… In the few days I stayed with him, we took stock of what we had been through. After Sabetay and I returned to Turkey, he had gone through very difficult days in Beirut. Eventually, he had found a way and managed to make it to the Netherlands. However, he had no intention of staying there. He was absolutely determined to benefit from the amnesty and return to the country.

After talking with Cengiz, my decision to return to the country was not delayed. Upon returning from Amsterdam, I talked with my doctoral thesis supervisor Tomas Hammar and we agreed: I would be appointed as a research assistant for 6 months starting October 1, 1974, and I would take leave from the university from April 1975 until the end of the year to do my military service and return to duty. I would join the doctoral courses upon my return. In the letters I sent to my elder brother in those days, I was writing: "Despite having had to save my own skin at one point, feeling great distrust of the revolutionary movement of Turkey and being worn down by the pressure of fascism, I neither turned my back on my people nor was my belief in the rightness and legitimacy of the cause to which I devoted my most productive years shaken. My judgment about myself is that I was not a fighter worthy of this cause…" (19.09.1974) "I suppose one needs to have a different nature than mine to be able to live for a long time somewhere other than one's homeland, provided one doesn't go to prison…. Despite speaking the

language and loving Sweden, I feel more foreign now than ever. I can see at most 3-4 more years of my life in this country… The idea that even if one is to die, it should be among one's own people is gaining strength… I suppose I'm getting over the shock of the first half of my life…" (09.11.1974) These lines indicated that while I was preparing myself for returning to Turkey, on the other hand I had definitely left behind the period of revolutionary activism.

In early October 1974, my mother-in-law Leman Kaptan came to visit us in Stockholm and stayed for about a month. This visit was also an opportunity for me to regain her affection. In early November, Fatma returned to Turkey with her mother, taking Elvan as well, to rent out her apartment in Ankara, and stayed for 5-6 weeks. Before she set off, we discussed all the matters related to our relationship and fortunately decided to face the difficulties together. This was a sign that she had decided to "continue" with me. Partly to celebrate this, we went to Frankfurt for two weeks between December 23, 1974 and January 6, 1975; we were guests of Alev Şeref and her then-husband Necmettin Baykal.

According to news from Turkey, those returning to benefit from the amnesty were not encountering difficulties. The State Security Court had dismissed the case in which I was also tried. There was no longer any obstacle to my return. On February 24, 1975, I applied for a passport at the Stockholm Embassy. I received the passport, valid for 3 months with the note "must return to the country by June 1" for those benefiting from the amnesty to return to Turkey, from Consul General Burhan Ant, whom I knew from Mülkiye. On April 2, 1975, Fatma, Elvan and I departed for Istanbul by Scandinavian Airlines (SAS). Dinç and Zeynel came to see us off at Arlanda Airport. I was very excited. In my eagerness to board the plane as soon as possible, I had gone ahead leaving Fatma and Elvan behind. During the journey, I was eaten up inside. For the first time in a long while, I was going to my country, and legally at that. But there was also some anxiety within me: Would it be possible for me to leave the country again?..

After embracing my elder brother and sister-in-law who met us at Yeşilköy Airport, we continued by plane to Izmir and from there by taxi to Ayvalık. After reuniting with my mother, father, elder sister, brother-in-law, and other relatives whom I hadn't seen for more than four years since 1970, I set about handling the necessary matters for my military service. Due to a piece of misinformation, I was only able to obtain the required health report in the final days of the allotted period, which made me quite anxious. Because I had always been in Turkey illegally in the period after March 1972, I had a certain apprehension in everything I did, an anxiety within me of encountering a setback at any moment. It would turn out that this anxiety was not at all unfounded.

Çanakkale is impassable

It became clear that I would do my military service in Çanakkale, a few hours by road from Ayvalık, at the 116th Gendarmerie Private Training Regiment Literacy School. Our conscription for short-term service was postponed from July 1 to July 15; we would be discharged 15 days earlier than expected, on September 15, doing about 70 days of net military service. Probably no one had done such short and such comfortable military

service since Turkey was founded. We were lucky in this regard. (Especially for Cengiz and me, who had previously done serious “military service”…)

On July 15, we gathered at the barracks gate. We lined up before the captain (Sabri Arıkan). The captain, calling names one by one for roll call, paused after reading my name and scrutinized me carefully (under the astonished gazes of the others). It was clear he had been informed about my identity. About half of those sent to Çanakkale were Mülkiye graduates, most of the others were Police College graduates; most of my squad consisted of old friends. Our commander, by virtue of his tall stature, was (academic) Zafer Toprak. The squad members consisted of (my revolutionary comrades, journalists-writers) Cengiz Çandar and Ömer Madra, (academic-writer) Gündüz Vassaf, (journalist) Şefik Kahramankaptan, (journalist and later one of President Recep T. Erdoğan’s chief advisors) İlnur Çevik, and relatively young Mülkiye graduates (diplomat) Cengiz Aslantepe and (finance inspector) İlkay Bayram. We did military service alongside (former THY general manager) Cem Kozlu, (professors) Ömür Sezgin, Şevket Pamuk, Sabri Sayarı, (the late) Murat Sertel, Hasan Köni, Süleyman Gedik as well as (journalists) Koray Düzgören, Okay Gönensin, and Edip Öymen, all friends of mine. Mesut Yılmaz (ANAP party leader between 1991-2002 and three-time prime minister) and (state minister) Mehmet Ali İrtemçelik were also politicians doing their “national service” with us in Çanakkale. I would meet both of them later.

The regiment’s dormitories were of a quality that could be called comfortable. About 300 of us reserve officer candidates collected money among ourselves and had showers installed in bathrooms where we could bathe with hot water every day. The training we received essentially consisted of plenty of marching and firing 3-5 rounds with M1 rifles left over from World War II; it would not be an exaggeration to say that most of the time was spent idling. It was clear that the Turkish Armed Forces’ only expectation regarding us was to get rid of the “bekaya,” that is, the conscripts who were in a state of draft evasion, as soon as possible.

From the very first day, when I got the signal that the Turkish Armed Forces had their eyes on me, I tried to be as disciplined a soldier as possible. I never joined the trio of Cengiz Çandar, Ömer Madra, and Gündüz Vassaf, who escaped from the regiment almost every weekend to go drinking in town. In fact, one weekend they went to Ayvalık without me and ate and drank with Fatma while gossiping about me. But in the end, they got caught and spent a week in detention in a chicken coop-like place set up on one side of the regiment. However, for some reason, when being discharged, while all of them got “excellent” for “conduct and behavior,” the grade assigned to me was “average” despite all my disciplined behavior; even though the captain said he had been watching me from the first day and had seen no fault of mine.

As soon as I was discharged, I set about getting a passport. How would the foreign travel ban against me be lifted? The CHP-MSP coalition government formed after the 1973 elections had fallen from power in September 1974 following Ecevit’s resignation, and in April 1975 a coalition government known as the “Nationalist Front,” consisting of AP, MSP, MHP, and CGP under Süleyman Demirel’s leadership, had been formed. Getting a passport seemed difficult. I set up camp in Ankara and started looking for

connections. Fatma's late maternal uncle (one of the founders of the Pakmaya company) Kenan Kaptan had a friendship with the Director General of Security Celalettin Tüfekçi; he sent me to him with a request for help. Tüfekçi behaved quite politely, but ultimately no result came from this contact. Weeks, months were passing, and I didn't know how I could solve the problem. Time was slipping by, and my return to Stockholm was being delayed. My thesis supervisor Tomas Hammar, whom I informed of the situation, said in his letters: "We're happy to hear from you. If a problem arises, we'll do whatever is necessary for you to come here… In the letter I received from the Swedish ambassador, he writes that he's in contact with you and can testify that you worked at the university. Write if there's anything I can do… We're completing preparations for the research. We have a little more time for you to come…"

Rıza Türmen

During an Ankara visit, I ran into Rıza Türmen, who was then a first secretary at the Foreign Ministry (he would become a judge at the European Court of Human Rights between 1998-2008). We knew each other from the English Boys' High School. We had reconnected at doctoral courses at Mülkiye and become friends. When I explained my problem, he said he had an acquaintance at MİT (the National Intelligence Organization) and could learn from him whether I had any hope of getting a passport. After two days spent in anxious waiting, I visited Rıza and his wife Dr. Tomris Türmen (Executive Director of the World Health Organization between 1992-2006) at their home. The news Rıza gave made me jump for joy. The MİT official he had spoken with had said "as far as we're concerned, there's no obstacle to him getting a passport." Rıza didn't stop at just giving this information, he also offered advice: I could see Deniz Baykal, who had served as Energy Minister in the previous CHP-MSP government, and ask him to help me get a passport. Baykal must have had some closeness with Oğuzhan Asiltürk (MSP), who retained the Interior Ministry seat in the new government… Following his advice, I immediately called Deniz Baykal. Baykal graciously gave me an appointment right away; I visited him at CHP headquarters.

I knew Baykal from my years studying at Mülkiye; at that time he was a young faculty member who showed warmth toward leftist students. I explained to him that I was doing doctoral studies at Stockholm University, had returned to the country under the general amnesty and done my military service, but couldn't manage to get a passport. Although he didn't welcome me with the warmth he had shown in the Mülkiye years, he took an interest. He told me to see Mehmet Can, a Mülkiye graduate who had served as Minister of Customs and Monopolies as well as Minister of Justice, and was then a CHP deputy for Adana, saying he would solve my problem. Mehmet Can received me very warmly at his home. After speaking with Asiltürk on my behalf, he called me and said I could get my passport. I didn't know how to thank him. I also called Baykal and thanked him heartily. Despite there being no legal obstacle, I had managed to get a passport after about four months of effort and only thanks to connections at the highest level. I was walking on air with joy…

I immediately informed Tomas Hammar of the news and asked for his help (as usual) regarding a place to stay upon our return to Stockholm. In early January 1976, we flew

to Stockholm as a family. At Arlanda Airport, just as they had seen us off, Dinç Gürs and Zeynel Çelikel met us. We settled into the apartment at the Wennergren Center (where mostly foreign academics were hosted for short periods) that Hammar had arranged for us to stay temporarily. Hammar welcomed me with joy. From February 1, 1976, I started my research assistant position at Stockholm University's Political Science Department. On the day I started work, finding on my desk a letter from my father saying "Welcome to Sweden" both surprised and delighted me. Hammar would do me another favor: With his encouragement, I applied for the non-repayable state scholarship given to doctoral students and obtained the right to benefit from this scholarship for 4 years from April 1, 1977 to April 1, 1981. We immediately enrolled Elvan, who had started elementary school in Ayvalık, in the nearest elementary school to our home. Her teacher was Barbro ("Babba"), a very sweet and very beautiful young woman. Unfortunately, she was an unlucky woman. A few years later, we would learn that she had died in a traffic accident.

Renewing our vows

In one of the first letters I wrote to my elder brother after returning to Stockholm, I said: "After staying in Turkey for eight months and being together with you for a long time, this place seemed so strange to me… But I feel very at ease. If I hadn't benefited from the amnesty, it would have been a terrible mistake. Seeing my presence here as temporary also gives such comfort. I'm thinking of staying for as short a time as possible and returning after getting the greatest possible benefit. Life isn't life without the sun… When I reach the stage of writing my doctoral thesis, that is in early summer 1978, Fatma and Elvan will return, and I'll return in the fall. We're determined to return to the homeland and settle in Istanbul." (As I'll explain later, Fatma, Elvan, and our family's new member who would be born on March 11, 1978, our son Acar, made a permanent return to the homeland in the fall of that year, due to a decision of ours that was not at all sound. I, on the other hand, would travel back and forth to Stockholm and suffer greatly until I completed my work in April 1981.)

The PRI research project

The team that would carry out the PRI (Political Resocialisation of Immigrants) research project headed by Associate Professor Tomas Hammar at Stockholm University's Political Science Department had been determined. Ko-Chih Tung, of Japanese-Chinese mixed heritage, would take on coordination in the project; Markku Peura would be responsible for Finnish immigrants, Stepan Udovich for Yugoslavs, Andrej Berkowicz for Poles, and I for immigrants from Turkey. The comparison group section of the research regarding Swedes would be done by the Swede Birgitta Ornbrant. The academic assistantship of the project was undertaken by Andrej's wife Halina; the administrative secretariat by another Pole, Wojciech Luterek. I would like to briefly mention the very interesting life stories of my project colleagues here.

The project director, my doctoral thesis supervisor Tomas Hammar, is without doubt the smartest, most knowledgeable, best, and most honest person I have known in life. He is one of the most important figures in my life. His offering me a job in the research project he would start as soon as he met me shaped my future. Tomas was an associate

professor during my years in Sweden; in the early 1980s, he was appointed to Sweden's first professorship in migration research. I have detailed above how he supported and looked after me. Tomas's interest in migration and immigrant issues stemmed from his parents. His family had an interesting story. His father and mother had opened a folk education center (Birkagårdens folkhögskola) in Stockholm and had taken a close interest in the problems of those who fled the Nazis and took refuge in Sweden during World War II. Tomas's wife Stina was an academic who had studied pedagogy and literature; had developed theories on dreams, myths, and fairy tales; and had published books on these subjects. (We lost Stina, to whom I owe gratitude for her warmth, in 2020. I remember her with respect.)

The person I met through the PRI research project and who would become my lifelong friend was Ko-Chih Tung. His Japanese father had married a young Chinese woman who was a member of a Mandarin family and an expert in Chinese philology while serving as a marine biologist in Manchuria under Japanese occupation; the couple had three sons, one year apart, with Ko-Chih, born in 1944, being the eldest. When the war ended in 1947, the Soviets had occupied Manchuria and taken the Japanese there prisoner, including Ko-Chih's father, deporting them to Siberia. The father was released after a while and managed to take his wife and sons and return to Tokyo, where he was the sole heir of the influential Tanaka family. After some time, following a conflict between the Japanese mother-in-law and the Chinese daughter-in-law, the Tanaka family rejected their daughter-in-law and grandchildren (whom they disparaged as "Mao's seeds"). The Mandarin family to which the mother belonged had never recognized the marriage to a Japanese man from the occupation army.

Ko-Chih's mother had managed to subsist in Tokyo with her sons for a long time by teaching Chinese philology courses at Japanese universities. During this time, as a result of a crisis she went through, she attempted suicide by jumping in front of a train with her children, but the eldest son Ko-Chih grabbed her arm at the last moment and prevented the attempt. Taking advantage of an opportunity that arose in the early 1960s, she emigrated to Hawaii with her sons, obtained US citizenship, and through hard work ensured that each of her sons studied at the best American universities. Ko-Chih had married Margareta, a Swede he met while studying political science at Dartmouth College, settled in Sweden, and begun doctoral studies at Stockholm University like me. Being a qualified statistics expert, he was in the position of chief assistant for the research. Ko-Chih would become one of my foreign friends whom I loved and admired very much and with whom I gradually developed a close relationship.

Perhaps the person with the most dramatic story in our research group was the Pole Andrej Berkowicz. Andrej had been expelled from the Polish Communist Party during the campaign it launched in the late 1960s to purge Jews from its ranks, and had found the remedy in taking refuge in Sweden with his wife Halina. I would become friends with Andrej and have the opportunity to follow what happened to him during my various visits to Stockholm in the 1980s. During my visit in 1982, I learned that Andrej, who was approaching 70, had recently divorced Halina and married a young Polish woman who had taken refuge in Sweden. When he invited me to his home for a dinner with plenty of vodka, I met his young and beautiful wife, who was carrying in her arms their son Adam,

then only a few months old. During my visit to Stockholm about a year later, I had learned that Andrej's Parkinson's disease had progressed considerably. What I learned during my Stockholm visit two years later was even more distressing. Andrej, saying "my illness is progressing, I want to buy an apartment for my wife and child, but I don't have enough money," had borrowed large sums from many acquaintances including Hammar and Wojciech, then gone to Bangkok and squandered the money there on Thailand's famous prostitutes. When he returned to Stockholm, he told the creditors who wanted him to pay his debts, "God has never treated me well… I'm sorry for you, but I have no money left to give…" and had passed away some time after this.

Perhaps the one with the most interesting story among the Swedes I knew in Stockholm was Beatrice Ceyhan, who was my student in the Turkish courses I gave at TBV. She had met her Turkish husband while he was studying architecture in Stockholm, they had fallen in love and married. Unfortunately, a few years after their son Metin was born, her husband had committed suicide after going through a severe psychological crisis. Beatrice, who remained faithful to the memory of her beloved husband, never married again and never lost her interest in Turkey and Turkish. She frequently visited Turkey and her husband's relatives. She was also one of the rare Swedes who hosted Fatma and me in their home. After I returned to the homeland, we continued to correspond with her for many years.

Let me come to one of my closest friends I made in Stockholm. One day in 1975, my home phone rang. The caller was a young Turk studying at the university. He said he got my number from someone who knew me and that he absolutely wanted to meet me. His voice was so convincing that I couldn't say no. We met. While studying at METU, he had been detained for participating in boycotts, a case had been opened against him at the State Security Court when "banned publications" were found in his locker at the dormitory, and when he was finally sentenced to 2 years and 4 months in prison, he had decided that leaving the country would be the right thing to do. He had sought asylum in Sweden and started studying journalism in Stockholm. His name was Yavuz Baydar. The elder brother-younger brother relationship that began with him would turn into a close friendship over the years, and Yavuz would be in my life in one way or another in every period.

Turks in Stockholm

From January 1976, while continuing with doctoral courses on one hand, I also embarked on the fieldwork of the PRI research on the other. I was quite successful in the courses; I passed all exams on the first attempt. I left only one exam for the end so I could continue to use the state scholarship. What surprised me most was receiving one of the highest grades in the statistics exam, probably because I had studied quite hard for it.

In the field research, we conducted detailed interviews with a random sample of 265 citizens of Turkey residing within the municipality of Stockholm, covering their socio-economic conditions as well as their political values and behaviors. I personally conducted 30-40 of these, while Turkish students we specially trained administered the

others. After the September 1976 elections, in which for the first time in Europe immigrants were granted the right to vote in local elections, I also conducted phone surveys with about 80 people from Turkey, asking which party they had voted for and why.

My doctoral thesis, which I wrote based on the research findings, was published in Swedish in 1980 by the LiberFörlag publishing house under the title “Turkar i Stockholm: En studie av invandrare, politik och samhälle” (Turks in Stockholm: A Study of Immigrants, Politics and Society). I wrote the thesis in English; but Hammar suggested it be published in Swedish on the grounds that it would receive much broader interest from relevant circles. The translation was done by Göran Licke, one of my students from the Turkish courses I gave at TBV. I added a long Turkish summary at the end of the book (titled “Turks in Stockholm: A Social and Political Study on Immigrants”). I thought I would have the opportunity to publish English and Turkish translations of the thesis in the future. Unfortunately, after returning to Turkey I would have to leave my academic career and work at newspapers for a long time, and I would find neither the time nor the desire to return and deal with my doctoral thesis.

The results of the research were interesting. I won’t go into a detailed explanation of them here. After the forty-odd years that have passed, as well as the quantitative and qualitative changes in migration from Turkey to Sweden, these findings have little validity for today. However, I can mention a few findings (that perhaps still remain valid): As expected, those from Turkey were seen to be less “adapted” to Swedish society compared to immigrants from other countries. When I examined their values and behaviors in roughly three groups (Urban origin with high school and higher education / Urban origin with relatively low education / Rural origin with low education), the following findings stood out: Almost all of them were quite satisfied with their life in Sweden in terms of material conditions, but quite dissatisfied in terms of non-material conditions. While the majority maintained the tendency to return to the country, the proportion of those who thought they were permanent was also rising. The most striking finding in terms of their political socialization was undoubtedly that while the vast majority had voted for right-wing parties in the last election they had taken part in back in Turkey, 80% voted for left (social democratic and democratic left) parties in the 1976 local elections when they voted for the first time in Sweden. It appeared that most voted for left parties because they believed they would better serve the interests of immigrants.

Our wonderful neighbors

In our new home, we had neighbors with very interesting stories whom we loved very much. We frequently met with the Italian Fabio Manzetti and his Norwegian wife Margrete, who lived right across from us, with their four adorable small children (three girls and one boy) born one year apart. Fabio served us the best pasta sauces we ever ate, and Margrete the best coffee we ever drank. Fabio was a faculty member at Stockholm Handelshögskolan / School of Economics, Sweden’s equivalent of the London School of Economics. We had quite enjoyable conversations with him on political and economic matters. (Fabio and Margrete would be greatly affected by our decision to return to Istanbul in late 1978 and would shortly after move to Milan.

However, they regretted it because of the air pollution in Milan and emigrated to Oslo a year or two later. The couple's life in Oslo was not very happy. Fabio, who got bored with economics and took up horse training, would divorce Margrete after a while and marry a young Norwegian woman.)

In the apartment right next to the Manzettis lived an Iranian couple, Mustafa and Efi Tabatabian, with their newborn baby girl. They were very lovable people. We also developed a close friendship and neighborly relations with them, and ate their pilaf. Their life after we left unfortunately also brought them separation. The family was torn apart following the Islamic Revolution in Iran in 1979. Mustafa, who admired Khomeini, returned to Tehran. The last information I obtained about Efi, who sympathized with the leftist People's Mojahedin organization, was that she was among the Iranians who stormed the Iranian Embassy in Norway.

We essentially lived among our Turkish friends. The Gürs, Öztuzcu, Livaneli, Kuyumcu, and Koçaş couples were the friends we saw most frequently. We also established lifelong friendships with Zeynel Çelikel and his wife Kerstin; with Haluk Soydan, who was then living in Uppsala, and his (now late) wife Lillian. When friends who came from Turkey and stayed for short periods were also taken into account, we had in a way become part of the Turkish ghetto.

Zülfü Livaneli had also taken refuge in Sweden as a victim of March 12. We were among the first to hear some of the compositions he made in Stockholm that would earn him fame far beyond Turkey's borders as a musician. One weekend while Zülfü was preparing to give his first concert in Stockholm, we went shopping with our wives to get his concert clothes. As a result, Zülfü would long wear the stage outfit Fatma chose—a white shirt and a black vest—at his concerts in Turkey as well.

We had a funny experience with Zülfü. Following an advertisement, we applied in September 1976 to make programs in the Turkish section of Swedish Radio. Ulla, the Swedish wife of the late Demir Özlü, who had settled in Sweden in those days, was also among those in charge of that section. Looking at our resumes, we believed they would hire us for the two open positions. However, when it became clear that this was not the case and that they would make us compete with other applicants, we withdrew (being a bit arrogant about it).

One innovation that Stockholm brought to our lives was Fatma starting to work outside the home for the first time. In the Tensta-Rinkeby area, where immigrants from Turkey were concentrated, she worked in kindergartens on one hand and gave literacy lessons to women from Turkey on the other. And thus she had an income that contributed to the family budget more than mine.

Now confident that I had won her heart back, I declared my love to her once more and proposed that we renew our vows. Our marriage was officiated by the Mülkiye graduate and Stockholm Consul General Burhan Ant on March 31, 1976, the day we moved into our new home in Stockholm, which was also Elvan's eighth birthday. Dinç was Fatma's witness, Oğuz was mine. It was one of the happiest days of my life. On the same day, we moved into our three-bedroom apartment at Professorslingan 35/3 (which I found

with Tomas Hammar's support). My affairs in Sweden had now completely fallen into place. However, I had started to see our presence in Sweden as temporary.

We are drowning in sorrow

In July 1976, upon the invitation of the Gürses, we went on a trip to Finland together with the Livanelis. The trip took us to Helsinki, and from there to the town of Ekenäs in the region where Finns of Swedish origin lived, which was Bambi's homeland, and we met Bambi's mother and father; from there we went to the island owned by Bambi's father. We had a great time. Bambi would later tell us: Fatma, whose beauty Bambi's father admired, had started to adorn his dreams… I would very much agree with Bambi's late father. She always adorned my dreams too…

We also had plans for after Finland. After returning to Stockholm and staying one night, the next morning we were to set off for Amsterdam, where Ömer was on a 3-month scholarship from the UN, to see the Madras. Our train tickets had been purchased. However, when we came home after Finland, I found a letter in the mailbox from my father sent from Ayvalık. The letter contained my mother-in-law Leman Kaptan's death notice that appeared in the newspaper and my father's brief condolence note. My dear Fatma was understandably very, very upset by this sudden news of death. Leman Kaptan had passed away on July 20 while we were in Finland and had been buried the next day. We cancelled the Holland trip and the next day, taking Elvan as well, we all flew to the homeland. My elder brother met us at Yeşilköy; we continued to Ayvalık via Izmir by plane. We visited Leman Kaptan at her grave. I loved my mother-in-law. (I agree more than ever today with her judgment about me that I "have intelligence but no common sense.") I returned to Stockholm a few days later, Fatma and Elvan a few weeks later.

Four months passed. One morning in November 1976, the phone rang. A woman from Ayvalık whom I barely knew and had never spoken with on the phone before was calling and saying: "Şahin Bey, Bingül, Hasan, and Neriman had a very terrible accident in Susurluk last night while returning from Istanbul. Very terrible… Do you understand???…" A car driven by a chauffeur had crashed into a truck parked by the roadside without any warning signs near Susurluk; Fatma's brother-in-law Hasan Önen and her maternal aunt Neriman Kaptan had died at the scene, and her elder sister Bingül, who had been taken to a health center while still conscious, had died there from internal bleeding. The driver had managed to survive the accident with injuries. You can imagine what a heavy blow this was to all of us, but especially to Fatma. Again we immediately went to the homeland. Again my elder brother met us at Yeşilköy. Again we continued to Ayvalık via Izmir by plane. Three funerals at once—it was heartbreaking. This time Fatma was completely shaken. Sorrows would not let go of us. I didn't know how to console her. After staying in Ayvalık for a few weeks, we returned to Stockholm.

Tension was escalating in Turkey both between right and left groups, and within left groups. Ömer described the situation in Ankara in his letter as follows: "Around 1972, we were in a position to more or less influence events, or at least we thought so. Now everything is very different: I seriously doubt whether we even have the power to

analyze developments or make predictions, let alone have any influence… When taking Cemo to gymnastics, if there's a rally in an area on our route, we have to detour for kilometers; if I have to leave school a bit late, at an hour when darkness is falling, I jump into the car and race home with my heart pounding, constantly scanning all around; even in the middle of the day, watching out for places where young people are somewhat concentrated and staying away from them; constantly complaining with friends at school and home that 'Boy, the situation is so bad, there's no security left'… That's how our life passes." (February 13, 1976) "I seriously doubt whether we even have the power to analyze developments or make predictions, let alone have any influence…" These words of Ömer's were a most apt expression of how far we were from understanding the country in which we were born and raised.

During the May Day celebrations on May 1, 1977, when a few gunshots were fired in a clash between two opposing groups in the packed Taksim Square, 5 people were killed by bullets and 29 were crushed to death in the panic that ensued; hundreds were injured. This grave incident triggered developments that would escalate with mutual killings between right and left and result in the military coup on September 12, 1980. I had started to think that returning to Turkey would not be possible… On May 2, my elder brother called from Istanbul. He had thought that I might have suspected he could have been in the square and worried about him, although this had never crossed my mind. He told me what he knew about what happened in Taksim. He said how happy he was that we had escaped from Turkey. After sharing our sorrow over the state of the country, we hung up the phone.

A very dark day

On May 6, 1977, toward noon, the phone rang. My sister-in-law Ayla was calling from Istanbul: "Şahin, we lost Acar…" she said. I couldn't believe my ears… It didn't occur to me that the word "lost…" would mean death… In his last letter, he had written that he had started working as sales manager for a company that produced forklift machines and how pleased he was with his job and the company allocating him a car. He had finally found some peace. However, on the morning of May 6, he had set off in his car to go to the company's factory in Kartal; when he reached the Soğanlık intersection, he was crushed under a bus coming from the İzmit direction that had swerved into the opposite lane to avoid hitting a minibus that suddenly appeared in front of it… The accident had made the news in the next day's Hürriyet newspaper. Under the photo of the car reduced to a pile of metal, it said: "The car that the bus entering the wrong lane smashed to pieces ended up like this. The body of Acar Alpay, who was driving the car and died terribly trapped in the pile of scrap, could barely be extracted…"

His watch had stopped at 9:22, the moment of impact. Had he lived, he would have turned 39 on July 16. His daughter Ümit was 13, his son Cihan was only 10. From my childhood on, he had been a compassionate elder brother to me, had made it possible for me to escape to Sweden—meaning he had given me back my life and my family. I remembered what he had written in the letter he sent in late 1973: "A new year is coming… it would be good to start life in another country and rebuild my life as I want. But even dreaming of it is forbidden for me…" Despite how much he longed for it, I

couldn't support the idea of him coming and settling in Sweden. If I could have, he might be unhappy now, but he would be alive. My heart was bleeding. This was yet another blow to my mother, who had already suffered every misfortune imaginable. We buried my mother's eldest son on May 8, "Mother's Day." I tried to pull myself together by walking the streets of Istanbul for three or four weeks. My relationship with my elder brother had been more than that of siblings. In this relationship, he was always the giver, I was the taker. (I will tell his life story, which cannot fit here, in the book "Human Landscapes from My Life" that I am planning.)

I took leave from the university and we stayed in the homeland for about three months. Bless them, Tomas and Stina came to Istanbul in early June to show solidarity in our difficult days. With them, we first went to Kulu via Ankara and visited the home region of most of the people from Turkey living in Stockholm. The people of Kulu had built gleaming houses with the expectation that they would return one day and equipped them with all modern appliances. But very few would be able to return. From Kulu, we went to Konya and visited the tomb of Mevlana (Rumi). From there, we came to Ayvalık again by bus via Antalya, Denizli, Aydın, and Izmir. I would be grateful to the Hammars for life for this visit they made to console and distract me.

Our sorrows would not end… Shortly after the Hammars returned to Sweden, Ömer and Tanju along with Alev and Necmettin came to Ayvalık to see us. Their visit helped me considerably to recover. In mid-August, around the time Elvan's school was opening, we returned to Stockholm. About a month later, on the morning of September 19, the phone rang again. It was Ömer on the other end. He said Tanju had died. I went into shock… This was the fourth phone call announcing the sudden death of someone close to us… Tanju, a dear friend of ours whom I likened to French film actress Jeanne Moreau, had fallen ill shortly after their return from Ayvalık to Ankara and had said farewell to life at only 32 years of age, diagnosed with colon cancer. Her two sons, Cem born in 1969 and Ege born in 1976, had been orphaned. The life of Ömer, my closest friend, was becoming very difficult. He insistently prevented me from going to Ankara to attend the funeral.

Ecevit in power

After returning from Turkey, I focused on writing my doctoral thesis. Events that would affect our future were taking place in the homeland. The Taksim events of May 1, 1977 had triggered the decision to hold early general elections. In the election held on June 5, Bülent Ecevit's CHP won 213 parliamentary seats with 41.4 percent of the vote, but could not achieve the majority needed to govern alone in parliament. Thereupon, the Second Nationalist Front government was formed as a coalition of AP, MSP, and MHP under Süleyman Demirel's leadership. However, when CHP won the local elections held on December 11, 1977, the balances began to change; when a group of deputies left AP, the government had to resign on December 31. Ecevit formed the new government on January 1, 1978, with the support of 10 deputies who had left AP and remained independent, in return for giving each of them a ministry. We welcomed this development with great joy in Stockholm. We believed that under Ecevit's rule, Turkey

would leave political tensions behind and find stability. Hope was awakening that the time to return to the homeland would soon come.

Fatma was pregnant. Upon the death of my elder brother, my cousin Gaye's husband Dr. Aykut Kazancıgil (Gaye being my maternal aunt's daughter) had advised that a baby would lift our spirits shaken by the tragedies we faced. We had decided; if the child to be born in March was a girl, we would give her late elder sister's name (Bingül), if a boy, my late elder brother's name (Acar). In those days, the sex of babies couldn't be known in advance. After a healthy pregnancy, Fatma gave birth to our son Acar on March 11, 1978. She gave birth at the hospital in Danderyd, one of Stockholm's most exclusive neighborhoods. The doctors allowed me to watch the birth process while holding Fatma's hand. When the nurse, placing Acar in an incubator so his body temperature wouldn't drop, said, "You have a healthy, handsome son…" I was on top of the world. It was one of the happiest days of my life. Ten years later, I had become a father again and now I had a daughter and a son. But even during those days she stayed in the hospital, I managed to upset my dear Fatma: by saying I was very sad about the death of a communist leader whose name I can't even remember now… She nearly threw me out of the room she was in. But she was so happy to have given birth to Acar; she would look at him again and again saying "I can't believe this beautiful baby is mine." The birth of Acar had reconnected us to life.

After a while, Fatma and I began to think that since the political situation in Turkey was hopeful and I was close to completing my doctoral thesis, we could now make a permanent return. Meanwhile, Oğuz and Duygu had returned; Zülfü and Ülker were also planning to return. We calculated that Fatma could take care of the baby more comfortably in the homeland; and if I stayed alone, I could finish the thesis faster. Unfortunately, almost all our calculations would prove wrong. In October 1978, together with the Livanelis, we loaded our belongings that we could take into the country duty-free into a freight car. Fatma took the children and returned to the homeland on the Stockholm-Izmir flight that SAS was operating at the time. Until we learned that the freight car had gone to Izmir instead of Istanbul due to a dispute, we remained in suspense about what happened to our belongings. I won't tell of the difficulties I encountered in getting our belongings cleared from Izmir customs with the help of a customs broker found by Fatma's maternal uncle İsmet Kaptan, obtained in exchange for bribes, storing them in Ayvalık for a while, and then transporting them to Istanbul.)

Alone again in Stockholm

After Fatma and the children left, I didn't vacate the apartment we were living in; I shared the rent with Gunilla, my student from the Turkish courses. The plan didn't work out as expected; life away from Fatma and the children was terribly difficult. Levent, Gunilla's boyfriend who was doing his doctorate at Grenoble University in France, was also coming and going to Stockholm like me. We would socialize with him. Meanwhile, to dispel my distress, I would sometimes play chess with him for hours.

I started going to Ayvalık frequently. When Ayvalık's freezing winter cold set in, Fatma had almost regretted returning. Acar burning his palm by pressing it against the coal

stove was an accident from which we got off lightly. Although the foreign travel ban had been lifted and I had documentation of this, I was stopped by the passport police on every flight from Istanbul to Stockholm, sometimes taken off the plane. I had many photocopies of the document made and left a copy with the passport police at each departure. I can't describe what I went through… (I would later learn that a METU faculty member with the same surname as mine was also being dragged off the plane every time he traveled abroad.)

The separation from Fatma and the children had made life in Stockholm unbearable. My mind was on them. What was happening in the homeland also did not match our expectations of the Ecevit government at all. *Milliyet* newspaper's editor-in-chief Abdi İpekçi was shot and killed in front of his house on February 1, 1979 by someone named Mehmet Ali Ağca. This event shook us greatly. What kind of country had we decided to return to? When I thought that if I couldn't find an opportunity to enter a university in Turkey I could do journalism, I would say to myself "If all else fails, I'll go to Abdi İpekçi and ask him to hire me." This door had closed.

In the summer of 1979, I simply fell into depression. One day while sitting at home trying to write one of the final chapters of the thesis, suddenly the letters started growing larger and coming toward me. I immediately stopped working. I called Refik Erzan, my military service friend Gündüz Vassaf's brother-in-law who was then doing a doctorate in the economics department at Stockholm University; I said "I'm having a breakdown, please help me." Bless him, he immediately came with his car, picked me up and took me to a swimming pool; he calmed me down by chatting. From there, I called Zeynel, who was vacationing on an island in the Stockholm archipelago belonging to his wife Kerstin's family. Zeynel (Çelikel), who remains one of my closest and most loyal friends to this day, immediately jumped in his car and came; he took me to the island; he brought me back to normal. Only with the help of these friends, to whom I will always be indebted, was I able to pull myself together and continue working.

Writing the doctoral thesis was no small effort. In those years, personal computers hadn't come out yet; typewriters were used. I was struggling with the F-keyboard typewriter I had brought from Turkey. For statistical analyses, we used the giant ("mainframe") computers at the university's computer center. I would leave the cards I punched in the evenings and pick up the outputs in the mornings. A single wrongly punched hole in one card could render the outputs unusable. There's no way today's youth, who work with highly capable personal computers, can know what we went through. They may not even understand what I'm talking about. That's why I must confess that I avoided very sophisticated types of statistical analysis when writing the thesis. After my permanent return to Turkey, when I went to Stockholm for a conference in 1982 and saw that the entire university had switched to personal computers, I would deeply regret this.

At the end of summer 1979, I finished writing the thesis, which I had drafted in English. Tomas Hammar thought it would be good if it were translated into Swedish on the grounds that it could be more widely read. Göran Licke, one of my students from the Turkish courses, took on the translation into Swedish. Tomas and I agreed to publish the

English version of my thesis, perhaps the first empirical study in the field of the political consequences of labor migration to Western Europe in the post-World War II period, at the first opportunity. However, due to the difficulties I encountered after returning to the homeland on one hand, and the weariness caused by working on the thesis for a long time on the other, I would unfortunately never be able to fulfill this goal.

At the end of summer 1979, while waiting for the thesis to be translated into Swedish and published by LiberFörlag in Stockholm, I set about moving Fatma and the children to Istanbul. Finding a rental apartment was extremely difficult at that time. There were even days when my temperature rose from stress and I had to stay in bed. Finally, at the end of August, I rented the apartment in the Zerrin Apt. building on Peker Street in Levent, where we would live for 6 years until 1985, for quite a steep rent, and we moved in. We enrolled Elvan in Levent Primary School for her final year. My affairs seemed to be getting on track. The date for my thesis defense was set as November 29, 1980, which coincided with my 15th wedding anniversary with Fatma. After defending the thesis in Stockholm, I would start looking for work in Istanbul. Winter had set in in Istanbul; the heating wasn't working because there was no fuel, and we could only heat the house somewhat with a wood stove we set up in the living room. The children were constantly getting sick. Fatma also had to take to bed several times that winter with unexplained fatigue and a low fever. These symptoms could have been harbingers of the health problems she would experience later.

Things were getting complicated in the country. We had completely lost hope in the Ecevit government, which we had deluded ourselves into thinking would find solutions to economic and political problems and put an end to polarization and violence. While Ecevit gave long speeches on television every evening, problems continued to grow. Some ministers began resigning from the government. As clashes between right and left groups spread, it was felt that the government's days were numbered. In the by-elections held on October 14, 1979, CHP's vote share dropped from 41% to 29%. Ecevit resigned; in his place, a minority government was formed on November 12, 1979 under Süleyman Demirel's leadership. The economic decisions announced by the new government on January 24, 1980 meant Turkey's adoption of a growth strategy through an outward-oriented market economy led by the private sector instead of import substitution led by the public sector. Turgut Özal, appointed as undersecretary of the State Planning Organization, was the architect of the new policies. The January 24 decisions brought an immediately perceptible improvement in the economy; however, the right-left clashes, which in the words of a foreign observer resembled a "slow-motion civil war," had escalated to a point where an average of ten people were being killed every day. Being forced to continue traveling back and forth to Stockholm while leaving my wife and children in Istanbul in this environment was greatly upsetting me.

No to nuclear energy

I took great interest in the "stop or continue?" referendum on nuclear energy held in Sweden on March 23, 1980. Until that date, the only serious accident recorded at nuclear power plants had occurred in 1979 at the Three Mile Island plant in Harrisburg, USA. After this incident, opposition to nuclear energy was growing in Sweden, which

derived a significant portion of its electricity from its existing 6 nuclear plants and had 4 more completed and 2 under construction. When the ruling coalition of right-wing parties couldn't reach an agreement on what to do with the nuclear plants, they decided to hold a (non-binding, consultative) referendum.

Three options were presented in the vote: The first two options envisioned closing nuclear plants as it became possible to meet electricity needs from other sources, and in any case not building more than 12 plants. The only difference between the second option, supported by the Social Democrats, and the first option, supported by the Conservative party, was that it envisioned prioritizing the safety criterion in closing plants. The third option, supported by the Center party, which had a strong environmental awareness and was the largest party in the coalition government at the time, contained a radical proposal: No more than the existing 6 plants would be put into operation, and the existing ones would be closed within 10 years. In the vote, in which 75% of voters participated, the first option received 19%, the second option 39%, and the third option 38% of the votes. Thereupon, parliament decided to close all 12 plants by 2010. (However, this decision could not be implemented. On July 17, 2010, parliament, violating all three options in the referendum, would decide to build new plants to replace existing ones that had completed their lifespan. According to the decision taken in 2015, four old plants were closed in 2020. Six nuclear plants are currently operating in Sweden.)

In the first referendum in which immigrants with residence permits in Sweden were granted the right to vote, I cast my vote for the third option, that is, the option envisioning the end of nuclear energy. What I learned by following the campaign during the referendum made me a determined opponent of all forms of nuclear energy. After returning to Turkey, I wrote many articles against nuclear energy in newspapers and gave many speeches. (Like many of my writings and speeches, they too would be in vain…)

Since I was close to completing my doctorate, I began searching for a job at one of the universities in Istanbul. We had decided not to return to Ankara even though Fatma had an apartment there, because air pollution had reached incredible levels. Also, I definitely did not want to return to the environment of my "revolutionary" days, which I didn't even want to remember. My close friend Zafer Toprak introduced me to Prof. Dr. Tarık Zafer Tunaya in the summer of 1980; the late Tunaya had said he would hire me as an assistant at Istanbul University's Faculty of Political Science, where he was dean, when I completed my doctorate. However, unfortunately, immediately after the September 12 military intervention, Tunaya would be dismissed from the university along with about five thousand faculty members and staff, including many of my acquaintances and friends, under Martial Law Act No. 1402.

I think again on Zafer's recommendation, I visited Associate Professor Dr. Yaşar Gürbüz, who was then the head of the political science department at Marmara University's Faculty of Economics and Political Sciences. He received me very positively; he said things like "We need to bring a talent like you to the university." He asked me to leave a phone number where he could reach me. But apparently someone must have warned

him, because not only did he never call, but when we met at a gathering he pretended not to see me. Thereupon, although not very hopeful, I also knocked on Boğaziçi University's door. I called my classmate from Robert College, Taha Parla, who worked as a faculty member in the Political Science Department. He said there was no open position in the department, but I could discuss this matter with the dean. The dean at that time was Üstün Ergüder, a friend of my late elder brother. He was very frank; he said, "For you to find a job at a university, you'll need to introduce yourself to society with your new identity." He was being realistic. I gave up searching for jobs at universities.

September 12 is coming

After spending the summer of 1980 in Ayvalık, we returned to Istanbul around the time school was starting for Elvan, who had passed the Galatasaray High School entrance exam. It was felt that the country was heading toward a new military coup. Prime Minister Demirel was advocating for elections to be renewed; opposition leader Ecevit was advocating for a national coalition government between the two major parties. When, in utter heedlessness, they failed to compromise, on September 12, 1980, the military once again seized power.

On September 11, Ömer Madra and I had gone to visit Gündüz Vassaf to spend a night at his house on Sedef Island. I was awakened by Gündüz toward dawn. What had been expected had happened. It was understood that for the past year the military had turned a blind eye to the growth of right-left clashes in order to ensure society's support for the seizure of power. The thought that "this time it was inevitable," which the military intervention also aroused in me, turned into a great reaction against military rule (in society and in me) following the arrest of hundreds of thousands of people, widespread torture incidents, and the execution of over 50 people shortly after. My anxieties had multiplied: Would I be able to go to Stockholm for my doctoral thesis defense? Would it be possible for me to find any job in Istanbul in this environment? Had we made a mistake by returning to Turkey?

In mid-November 1980, I went to the airport to fly to Stockholm. The relief I felt when I passed through passport control by presenting the document showing that my foreign travel ban had been lifted was no less than what I felt when I managed to escape from the country in 1972. My thesis defense took place as scheduled on November 29, 1980. The task of critiquing my thesis was given to Diane Sainsbury, an American faculty member from Uppsala University. Sainsbury's not being too hard on me did make me wonder if she was going easy on me… The support from Tomas Hammar and some colleagues, as well as the endorsement I would receive years later from Olof Petersson, one of Sweden's leading political scientists, would convince me that I had done good work; regarding the thesis, only the regret of having settled for publishing it only in Swedish would remain. At that time, completing doctoral studies at Stockholm University's Political Science Department took an average of 7 years. I, on the other hand, had completed the doctorate in less than 4 years, a record time, having started in 1976 and finished in 1980. In order to be able to use the full four-year state scholarship I had started receiving in April 1976, I had left one of the doctoral qualifying exams until

after the thesis defense. I took the final exam in April 1981 and returned to Istanbul triumphantly with my diploma.

Detention at the Ayvalık police station

In the last days of December 1980, I went to Ayvalık to see my mother, my elder sister, my father, and my mother-in-law. As I was leaving my father's house, he now being mostly bedridden, a black police car that had apparently been following me pulled up in front of me. Plainclothes police detained me on the grounds that I was wanted by martial law and locked me in a room in the building left over from the Greeks that had formerly been used as a hospital, then a tax office (now the municipality building), and at that time was being used as martial law headquarters. Toward evening, they took me and handed me over to the police station in the city center. At the station, I was locked in a detention cell 2 x 2 meters wide, with a low ceiling, looking out through a narrow slit. This was the harshest treatment the state had applied to me until that day.

Just about a month before, I had been able to fly to Stockholm without any obstacle. If I were wanted by martial law, they wouldn't have let me go. There was an unusual situation. I spent that night standing without eating or drinking anything. The next morning, the commissioner took me out and sat me in an armchair, had some food brought, and explained the situation: I was not wanted by martial law. If I were, he would be the first to know in Ayvalık. However, the captain, who was a very strict martial law commander (who raided rich people's houses in Çamlık and emptied whiskey bottles into toilets), had ordered my detention based on a tip from a teacher who was a hardcore MHP fascist in the town saying "The notorious communist Şahin Alpay is walking around freely." The commissioner was treating me well. He said he had inquired first from Balıkesir, then from Ankara whether I was wanted, and that this was not the case, that it had originated from the captain. (There was a military-police jurisdictional conflict going on.)

I spent four or five days and nights at the police station, sitting in an armchair. Even my relatives didn't dare come to see me. On the last day of the year, I learned that the police would come to take me, apparently because the captain insisted on transferring me to the Izmir martial law command. Indeed, toward evening two young plainclothes policemen appeared. My brother-in-law Özbek hired a taxi. Thus we went to Izmir by car, not by bus. The policemen were saying on the way that there might be a mistake, that such mistakes do occur. I was handed over to the First Branch on the top floor of the police center in Basmane. It was apparent from the electrical shock equipment and the bastinado on the floor that the room I was first taken to was a torture chamber. A gray-haired commissioner informed me that he was sure my name was not among those wanted, but that they had to hand me over to martial law; and that this could only be done on Monday. It was Friday. I would spend at least three nights at the first branch. The gray-haired commissioner sat me on a chair in the corridor. The weather was terribly cold. The howling wind entered from one corner of the corridor and exited from the other.

On the last night of 1980, I witnessed scenes that could only be seen in horror films. Near the chair where I was seated, there was a young man lying on the floor, handcuffed to the legs of a bench. Policemen kicked him as they passed by. Nurses in white coats were entering and exiting a nearby room. At one point, about a hundred young people being held in the detention compartments on that floor were lined up under the supervision of plainclothes police and taken to and from the toilet on the lower floor. It was evident from the various limbs of the young people being covered with bandages that they had been tortured, and that the nurses walking around were tending to their wounds. From the television in the room where the gray-haired commissioner sat, belly dance music was rising. That's how we entered 1981.

The next morning they locked me in the First Branch's archive and of course handcuffed me by the wrist to metal shelves so I wouldn't rummage through the files. I had no chance of moving from my spot. The outside was visible through the window, which still meant a positive change of environment. I wasn't forgotten in the archive; three times a day they gave me a kind of toast sandwich and water, took me to the toilet and back. Spending two days and one night between January 1 and 3, 1981 under these conditions further enriched my experiences of being patient and enduring difficulties.

On Monday, January 3, a new and harsh commissioner came in place of the moderate gray-haired one and ordered me to be thrown immediately into the detention ward. I was taken out of the archive and locked in one of the detention rooms behind iron bars, packed with dozens of people. There was no room to move in the room. For some reason, I didn't want to talk to anyone. Then a face appeared in the narrow window between the adjacent room and ours. My friend Ahmet Aras, from the TİP days and then Stockholm days, his hair all disheveled and unkempt, was calling out to me in astonishment at seeing me there. I didn't feel like talking much even with him. During a group bathroom break, I found the opportunity to ask one of the policemen what would happen to me. "We'll hand you over to Martial Law today," he said.

Fatma comes to my rescue

Late in the afternoon they took me and along with several other people put us on a bus and took us to the barracks I would learn was in Narlıdere. During the bus journey, with the joy of seeing daylight after days, I felt like a normal citizen going on an outing. Just like the normality I felt years ago when traveling from Mardin to Gaziantep. I was locked in one of the dormitory wards being used as detention at the barracks in Narlıdere. There were many young people in the ward. Some of the bunks had dirty mattresses on them. Some of the young people, probably because of my age, showed me warmth and I lay down on one of the mattresses. Again I tried to talk to people as little as possible. This must have been a kind of defense mechanism. For a long time I had been in search of saving my own skin. I had no desire to listen to what others had been through. I spent that night, curious about when I could get out of here, sometimes dozing off, sometimes staring at the ceiling. Martial law commands had the authority to hold people in detention for a long time. There were those who remained in detention for years without being brought before a court. I was very worried about my future. For me, life now seemed to

have been reduced to a struggle for survival. I was brooding over what Fatma and the children were doing and would do.

On the morning of Tuesday, January 4, the privates took me from the ward and brought me out to the courtyard. A petty officer with some civilians beside him approached me; “Şahin Bey, we’re going to release you today…” he said. I couldn’t believe my ears. Freedom had appeared again. After the soldiers took various photographs of me, they put me in a vehicle and, at my request, dropped me off at Alsancak square. The first thing that came to my mind was to go to the house where Fatma’s niece Aslı and her husband Ali lived. I cannot describe the joy and happiness I felt when the door opened and I saw that Fatma was also inside.

As always, Fatma had come to my rescue again. My release had been made possible as follows: Our Ayvalık friend, the well-known writer and translator Ahmet Yorulmaz, had called Fatma on his own initiative and offered help. His wife Işık’s cousin was serving as a martial law prosecutor in Izmir. After getting the information needed to contact him, Fatma had left the children with relatives and come to Izmir. She had explained my situation to the military prosecutor, and the prosecutor, bless him, had given the necessary orders for my release. I had gotten off very, very lightly. You cannot know how I embraced my Fatma. I am forever grateful also to Ahmet and Işık Yorulmaz, both now deceased. My Fatma, as always, was sad and tired because of the troubles I had brought upon her, but also happy to be reunited with me. We immediately returned to Istanbul, to the children. My little Elvan was 12, my little Acar was 2 years old. Once again I was experiencing the joy of being reunited with my children.

In April I flew to Stockholm, took the final doctoral qualifying exam I needed to pass, and received my diploma. Thus I had become the first research assistant to complete a doctorate from the PRI research project directed by Tomas Hammar. Chief assistant Ko-Chih Tung would complete his doctorate shortly after me. No other doctoral thesis would come out of the project. Hammar was very pleased with me; he would have wanted me to stay in Sweden and at the university; but as he told Nermin Abadan, I was “very nationalistic, very determined to return to the homeland.” I said farewell to Tomas and my friends in Stockholm and returned to Istanbul.

“Classy renegade”

A period in my life had closed. I was returning to the homeland from Sweden with a new paradigm in my mind. What might be the points worth underlining once again regarding the years I had left behind? I could list them as follows:

1) The upbringing I received from my family, the education I received at my schools, and the values instilled in me by my circle of friends and social environment had made me quite distant from the nationalist worldview that was widespread in the society in which I was born and raised and was also instilled by the state. The understanding of “we are human first” instilled by my mother and by teacher Müveddet at Nilüfer Hatun Primary School had deeply influenced me, and this understanding had been increasingly reinforced during the year I spent in the USA on an AFS scholarship. As I explained above, when returning from the USA to Turkey in 1962, the question in my mind was:

Why is the USA so rich and free, why is my country so poor and lacking in freedom? The answer given to this question by the Workers' Party of Turkey had seemed justified: Poverty was widespread and there was no freedom in Turkey because we were a country that had been left behind, exploited by imperialism, primarily the USA, and their local collaborators.

I had read Karl Marx's "Communist Manifesto" for the first time in the USA and was influenced by it. The Ankara and especially the Mülkiye environment had surrendered my mind to increasingly radical interpretations of Marxism. Reading Lenin, primarily the books titled *State and Revolution* and *What Is to Be Done?*, had opened the door in my mind to the violent and totalitarian interpretations of the left, and I had gradually adopted Mao's interpretations: For the establishment of socialism, nationalizing the means of production and replacing the market with planning was not enough; a revolution in minds was also needed. This is what the "Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution" was for…

2) During my years studying at Mülkiye, I had gradually become a radical revolutionary, "Marxist, Leninist, even Maoist," but I had never believed that revolution would be possible "tomorrow" in Turkey, and I had thought that a long and patient preparatory period was needed. I had never been a "man of action." Because I had received a good education and knew English well, with the opportunities these provided, I was essentially concerned with the "theory" of revolution. Despite this, despite thinking that the revolutionary movement in Turkey was far behind the stage of organization and party formation, I couldn't refuse to join the TİİKP. Because even though I didn't believe in the TİİKP at all, even though I thought it was very distant, I believed in revolution.

I hadn't been able to object to Doğu Perinçek sending me to the Palestinian resistance movement either. This was partly related to being desperate (being wanted by martial law), but it was more related to commitment to the idea of revolution, to the belief that behaving otherwise would be incompatible with honesty. Perhaps my subconscious was saying: I'll go, I'll die for the cause, and thus I'll be freed from this agonizing contradiction between my private and public lives, and find peace. Indeed, with this hope, while at Reşadiye, I had volunteered for the operation to be conducted against Israel.

3) I had two friends (or if you prefer, "comrades") who were quite influential on my increasingly radical revolutionary activism. The first was Doğu Perinçek (henceforth DP). As I described above, I had initially experienced a great intellectual affinity and friendship with him. Later he had greatly disappointed me, and my trust in him had been completely destroyed. It was clear that DP's purpose in sending me to the Palestinian Resistance Movement was to rub my nose in it, to remind me that he was the real boss, to strip me of the privileges I had (my family, my status) and to "proletarianize" me. (According to what I heard later, he had said about Atıl, Cengiz, and me, "We sent the loose elements to Palestine so they wouldn't become a problem for us later…") Between 1966 and 1971, DP and I had been very close. After that date, I ran into him only once, at a meeting in the 1990s; we merely exchanged greetings. I refrained from sharing my opinions about him publicly. I think he was pleased with this, as he characterized me as a "classy renegade" in one of his writings.

4) The other “comrade” was Halil Berktay. The seeds of Maoism in Turkey had been sown through the joint efforts of the two of us. I had been close to his father Erdoğan Berktay and members of his family. We had common aspects stemming from being of population exchange origin and from studying at Robert College. However, when we parted in 1971, I thought he had “lost his soul” and had become Doğu Perinçek’s “Suslov.” (I should remind you: Mikhail Suslov was the ideologue of the Soviet Communist Party from 1965 until his death in 1982.) Halil’s closeness with Perinçek continued until the end of the 1980s. He later left politics and turned to history. We got together again several times; we remembered that we were friends. What I experienced with these two friends who had roles in my life would lead me to this conclusion: Being of like mind is one thing, friendship is another. What I would experience later would also confirm this.

5) At the end of the approximately 9 months I spent in the Palestinian Resistance Movement, my sympathy and love for the Palestinian people had deepened and become permanent. However, I gradually came to hate weapons and violence. I now believed that violence breeds violence; no one has the right to kill anyone for any reason.

6) Communism, fascism, Islamism, or similar authoritarian-totalitarian ideologies resulted in the enslavement of the individual. The subject of freedom was not class, nation, or religious community, but only and only the human being, the individual.

7) The practice of the left in the world and in Turkey had gone bankrupt. When I understood this, I had become unable to think of anything other than saving myself and being reunited with Fatma and Elvan. I had found no place to take refuge other than my family, my elder brother, and my old close friends. I had not hesitated to risk the safety of my dearly beloved elder brother in order to save myself from the impasse I had thrown myself into. Fatma was right to find this strange and to reproach me for it.

8) Sweden had shown me that it was possible to establish a society as free and as just as possible. In Sweden, I had found the opportunity to put my life back in order with the opportunities provided by civilized society. I couldn’t have found the opportunities offered to me there in any other country. For this reason, I was eternally grateful to the Swedish state and to Swedes. I likened Sweden to “the world’s washing machine”: It took in radicals and revolutionaries from one end, washed them, and liberals and social democrats came out from the other end. (What I would experience in Turkey years later would also strengthen these feelings. My Swedish friends would also play a considerable role in my rescue from the Silivri pit.)

9) I had great admiration for what the Swedish state had achieved; for Swedes’ commitment to human values, their honesty, their industriousness in general. I had made many Swedish friends. I greatly appreciated Swedish politicians. The civilized way they competed and behaved like ordinary citizens had greatly impressed me. Despite all this, I was aware that I didn’t belong there. If Fatma had left me, if no amnesty had been declared and I had been condemned to stay in Sweden for life, I think I would have been miserable and would have withered away. Despite what would happen to me, I never regretted returning to the homeland with the opportunity the amnesty provided. While returning, the thought of applying for Swedish citizenship did cross my mind, but I gave

up on it thinking that living in Turkey and obtaining citizenship from Sweden would be morally and legally problematic.

During the process of returning from Sweden to Turkey, a paradigm shift had occurred in my mind. This had not happened all at once, but through a process similar to what Thomas Kuhn described. The roughly Marxist-Leninist paradigm in my mind had developed ever-growing gaps in the face of reality, and eventually collapsed and gave way to a new paradigm that could be called liberal. In this process, the film reel in my mind was rewinding step by step: Mao had taken the place of Chinese emperors… The Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution was nothing but an intra-party power struggle… In Russia, the "revisionists" of the Second International who advocated democracy had been proven right, and Lenin and the revolutionaries had paved the way for Stalin's personal dictatorship… In reality, the fish was rotting from the head; at the source of totalitarianism was the Marxist paradigm, the idea of the dictatorship of the proletariat… Freedom of expression and criticism, in short political freedom, was the indispensable means of establishing a free and just society… Without establishing a competitive market economy, political freedom could not be achieved in a system where the state, not society, dominated the economy…

In this paradigm shift in my mind, what I had experienced as well as what I had read, but above all one book, had played a great role. Karl R. Popper's *The Open Society and Its Enemies* had become my bedside book. (As I mentioned above, when Mete Tunçay suggested in 1967 that I translate the second volume of the book concerning Marx into Turkish, I had felt insulted and immediately refused.) I had started reading all of Popper's works that I could get my hands on and comprehend. Leszek Kolakowski's *Main Currents of Marxism* and Jon Elster's books *An Introduction to Karl Marx* and *Making Sense of Marx* would also help me see the gaps in the "old paradigm." The articles by Swedish economist Assar Lindbeck that I would translate into Turkish under the title *Piyasa Ekonomisi ve Demokrasi* (Market Economy and Democracy, Birey ve Toplum Publications, Istanbul 1985) explained very well the differences between the liberal, pro-market interpretations and the statist-centralist interpretations of social democracy. As I read the world and Turkey in line with the new paradigm in my mind, I now defined myself as a liberal social democrat or social liberal.

The weaknesses of the positivism of Auguste Comte, which had long dominated the social sciences, that is, the thesis that science would gradually replace religion with modernization, were also becoming clear in my mind. Religious beliefs that addressed people's spiritual rather than material needs maintained their power even in the most advanced modernized societies. In the face of life's uncertainties, pains, and deprivations, people felt the need to believe. My own individual experiences also confirmed this. In my most troubled, most difficult days, I had felt the need to pray in my own language, to beg God to save me. It was not religious beliefs that were retreating in the world, but religious institutions. I now defined my beliefs not with atheism but with a kind of deism. In parallel with this new understanding, my views on religion and secularism had also changed considerably: In Turkey, the authoritarian secularism practice of the state controlling and monopolizing religion was pitting the state against the religious segment of society and leading to the development of Islamist authoritarian

political movements. (As I write these lines, I now also have difficulty defining myself as a “deist,” and see myself more as agnostic. Why? This should be the subject of a book called “Religion and Me.”)

CHAPTER VII / BACK TO ISTANBUL AND *CUMHURİYET*

In April 1981, I passed my final examination, which I had left until the last day in order to fully utilize the four-year Swedish state scholarship I had received for my doctorate at Stockholm University, received my diploma, and returned home for good. Through my friend Zafer Toprak, who never withheld his support, I found a temporary job and began working as an editor at Yurt Ansiklopedisi (Homeland Encyclopedia). But the time had come to find myself a permanent job. My dear Fatma was saying that finding a job would be difficult in this extraordinary period, and since I loved reading and writing, perhaps starting a bookstore-publishing house would be a good idea. This way, I could both do work I loved and make a living. She was also willing to help me in this endeavor. As always, I did not follow her advice. On the grounds that I had no business acumen and that if we embarked on such a venture we would quickly lose all our capital, I said “no.”

In the autumn of 1981, I had to leave Yurt Ansiklopedisi as well. The general publication director had changed, and a classmate of mine from Robert Lisesi had been appointed in his place. This friend’s first act was to convey through an intermediary the message that I was “working little but receiving much pay; I either needed to work more or accept less money.” Being treated this way by someone I considered a friend and thought would value my work hurt me considerably. I immediately submitted my resignation. The job I had obtained through one friend had been terminated by another friend; I was completely unemployed. When I went to Ayvalık to see Fatma and the children, I felt myself on the verge of depression, also due to the extreme heat.

My father’s health had deteriorated considerably, and he had become quite frail. He could no longer leave his house on Sefa Avenue in Ayvalık, a house left over from the Greeks. I made an arrangement with a family we knew who lived nearby to look after him and meet his needs, including meals. His money was running out. He had leased his olive groves for six years in exchange for an amount to be paid in liras; the inflation that reached 100% in 1980 had rendered the money he received worthless. In the first days of September, I took him to the Kaptan family’s house in Çamlık and gave him a bath; then, with a heavy heart, I took him back to the run-down house where he lived alone. A few days later, the caretaker family informed me that he had passed away in his sleep. On September 9th, we buried him in a solitary grave in the Ayvalık municipal cemetery. A life that had seen happiness in very few moments and was mostly filled with sorrow had come to an end. He was born in 1912 and died in 1981, at the age of 69; he had chosen to be alone for approximately half of his life.

Toward *Cumhuriyet*

When I thought that if university did not work out upon returning to Turkey, I could work in the press, Abdi İpekçi, whom I thought I could ask for help, had unfortunately been assassinated. But my friend from Mülkiye, Hasan Cemal, had been appointed as the general publication director of *Cumhuriyet* newspaper in April 1981, which was a fortunate coincidence for me. Hasan and I had a friendship that continued since the 1960s. In 1968, when the office of *Devrim* magazine, where he was the managing editor, was across from the office of *Aydınlık Sosyalist Dergi*, where I was an editorial board member, in an apartment on Adakale Street, we had started seeing each other frequently.

Even during the years I was in Stockholm, we maintained contact with Hasan; when he was the Ankara bureau chief, he had given me a free subscription to the newspaper. I had also sent *Cumhuriyet* an article under the pen name Mehmet Çağ, about "Swedish imperialism" (!), titled "The Most Advanced Monopolization is in Sweden," which was published as a full page for two days (October 5-6, 1976), and Hasan had it published. When chief columnist Nadir Nadi read the article criticizing Sweden, he was quite surprised and gave Hasan a mild reprimand. But in the letter Hasan sent to Stockholm, he wrote that the article was well-received and widely read in CHP (Republican People's Party) circles, and he was awaiting my new contributions.

A more realistic assessment came from Ömer Madra: "Mehmet Çağ's article was read with considerable interest here. Generally, it was well-liked. There are also some who find it a bit schematic. I also have a criticism: It seemed like some sections were written assuming the reader was more knowledgeable than they actually were. Just one example: Why the 'reform' proposal about making workers shareholders in company capital was a crappy thing was not explained but brushed over in one sentence… And so on." (7.11.1976) What I was trying to convey was this: The project envisioning that funds formed from deductions from workers' wages would gradually grow and own industrial property had faced harsh criticism on the grounds that it would eliminate competition in the economy. These criticisms, which also seemed very reasonable to me, would eventually lead the social democrats to shelve this proposal. Meanwhile, the truth was that by the end of the 1970s, I no longer saw Sweden as an "imperialist" country.

I decided to go and ask Hasan for a job. One of the newspaper's writers, Uğur Mumcu, was a friend I had met during my days working at Ankara University. His father had served as the land registry and cadastre director in Ayvalık for a while, and through a housing cooperative formed by employees at the directorate at that time, he had become the owner of a summer house in Armutçuk, on the shore facing Lale Island. Uğur and his wife Güldal spent their summers in this house, and we had good relations with them. During the long walks Uğur and I took, we largely agreed that Turkey's problems could only be remedied with a Western-style democratic regime. Thinking that Uğur could also support me, I went to Hasan. I said: "As I understand it, you're trying to turn *Cumhuriyet* into a 'reference paper' similar to Western examples… You know I completed my doctorate in Sweden and returned, but they won't hire me at universities because of my communist past. With my writing experience, I can help with what you

want to do at the newspaper. For example, all serious newspapers in the West have book pages. I could prepare such a page for *Cumhuriyet*…"

Hasan, after consultations that I believe included Uğur and İlhan Selçuk, invited me to prepare the book page I had proposed at the newspaper starting from the new year. The page began publication on January 28, 1982, under the title "Review and Research in the Publishing World." I also started working as a staff member at the newspaper from September 1, 1982. Thus, I was taking my first step into journalism within the framework of Hasan Cemal's project to give *Cumhuriyet* the identity of a reference newspaper that highly educated people of all political persuasions could read.

When I started working at *Cumhuriyet*, it seemed inevitable that a conflict would occur between the views I had adopted during my years in Sweden and the nationalist-statist and laicist (in the sense of advocating state control of religion rather than separation of church and state) ideology that dominated the newspaper's employees in general, but especially the senior writers led by İlhan Selçuk (whom Hasan Cemal would increasingly refer to as "sugar big brothers"), as well as the mentality that saw the armed forces as the guardian of this ideology. This mentality would be best described by Hasan Cemal in his book dedicated to the memory of Doğan Avcıoğlu, published years later. (*Let No One Be Angry, I Wrote About Myself*, Doğan Kitap 1999.) However, working at *Cumhuriyet* was the only meaningful job opportunity I had at the time. I needed to be patient. On the other hand, the impression I got from Hasan Cemal gave me hope that views closer to mine, more liberal in orientation, could eventually find ground within *Cumhuriyet*.

İlhan Selçuk's Gulag

From September 1982, I began working at *Cumhuriyet* newspaper as the Head of the Research Department. Along with me, Aydın Emeç, a close friend of my late elder brother, started as culture editor, and Celal Üster, my maternal uncle Celal's grandson and from the Aydınlık circle, started as his assistant. My friend from the English High School for Boys, Murat Belge, was preparing a weekly popular culture page for the newspaper, while my friend Osman Ulagay, also from the same school and the *Aydınlık* circle, began writing economics articles. Of my close friends from the *Aydınlık* circle, Cengiz Çandar was covering foreign policy, and Kenan Mortan was working as an economics correspondent. In other words, *Cumhuriyet* presented quite a familiar environment for me. In a short time, I would also make new friends such as foreign policy editor and writer Ergun Balcı, News Director Yalçın Bayer, and back page editor Mehmet Yaşin. From the Ankara bureau, especially the late Ufuk Güldemir, Yalçın Doğan, Sedat Ergin, and Yasemin Çongar would become lifelong friends. Cengiz, with his usual mischievousness, would tease: "So what if you got a doctorate in Sweden? Here we went round and round and ended up meeting here…"

On one hand, I was preparing the (half) page we named "Review and Research in the Publishing World" which came out weekly, and on the other hand, at Hasan Cemal's (hereafter HC) request, I was attending the morning editorial meetings, voicing the deficiencies and errors I saw in that day's newspaper and making suggestions. Over time, my functions would diversify to include giving HC reports on possible innovations

at the newspaper, editing the newspaper's yearbooks, preparing the speeches HC would deliver at International Press Institute (IPI) meetings, as well as occasionally conducting interviews for the newspaper and writing for the supplements the newspaper published. One of HC's suggestions was that I write the history of *Cumhuriyet* newspaper. Because I could foresee the problems this would cause me, I procrastinated on this task; HC did not insist. As is known, during World War II, *Cumhuriyet* newspaper had followed a pro-Nazi Germany editorial policy for a while; for this reason, rumors had spread that they had received money from the Germans. In other words, writing an objective history for *Cumhuriyet* newspaper was not easy. It still has not been written.

Another idea of HC's was to establish an "Advisory Board" for himself. Its members would consist of the managing editor (my military service friend, SBF graduate) Okay Gönensin, Osman Ulagay, Ergun Balcı, Aydın Emeç, Osman Ulagay, Aydın Emeç, Şükran Ketenci, Cengiz Çandar, and Yalçın Pekşen, and I would serve as secretary. I was recording what was discussed at the Advisory Board's first meetings held on October 19 and November 2, 1982, as follows:

"It was emphasized that Cumhuriyet*, being Turkey's only opinion newspaper, had this quality as its strongest aspect and that it needed to preserve and develop this quality. It was stated that our newspaper had a great impact and responsibility on the intellectual development of especially the newly emerging intellectual generations. It was said that in the short term, at a time when the struggle to expand and establish democracy would be waged, this responsibility was even heavier.*

It was observed that the experiences of the last twenty years in the world and in our country had brought the young intellectual generation to a consciousness of criticizing tested and defeated political stances and learning lessons from them; that the young generations were directed to look at various intellectual currents in the world and at home more democratically and without prejudice.

It was emphasized that in the upcoming period of struggle for democracy, our newspaper, with its line defending pluralism in politics, economy, and culture; fundamental rights and freedoms; national interests against foreign interests; and workers' interests against the interests of capital, should provide representation opportunities for all intellectual currents within the framework outlined above. It was said that only in this way could it gain readers' trust and find the opportunity to expand further.

It was discussed that in the upcoming period, while continuing its publication on a pluralist-democratic line domestically and a line defending national interests externally, it was also necessary to establish the understanding that the private sector makes important contributions to our economy, and that not every foreign relation involves malice or enmity. It was said that the newspaper's ability to sell more and expand further would only be possible by adhering to this correct understanding.

The matter that the participants emphasized importantly and unanimously was related to the newspaper's 'image.' It was stated that the newspaper's general atmosphere suggested 'pessimism'; that it left the impression on readers that everything in the world

and in the country was going badly and nothing was good. While the generally negative aspects and events of society were persistently dwelt upon (even under today's conditions, even under much worse conditions), it was said that the perspective that there were and could be many good, positive events in society was being neglected. It was pointed out that everything was viewed with a critical eye 'for the sake of criticizing,' and that this had permeated from columnists to the entertainment and Ciddiyet (Seriousness) pages.

It was agreed that the newspaper's much-complained-about tedious atmosphere came not essentially from layout and printing technique, but from this 'pessimism.' It was requested that more space be allocated to positive developments achieved in our country, to positive work done; that a 'balanced' approach be provided to the reader.

It was discussed that in cases where Cumhuriyet *newspaper's self-evaluation was concerned, it should not proceed from the assumption that it was right and justified in every period.*

The damages caused to the newspaper by the failure to achieve complete objectivity in news, and even by the grave errors made in this regard, were discussed, and it was hoped that the important success achieved in this matter in the last year would be continued, and that complete objectivity would be achieved in news language and presentation." (For the full text of my report, see Hasan Cemal, *I Loved Cumhuriyet So Much*, Doğan Kitap, 2005, pp. 75-77.)

I was not sure that these views about the newspaper were fully adopted by the Advisory Board members, except perhaps Osman Ulagay. The report I drafted perhaps more expressed the new direction HC was trying to set for the newspaper, as I understood it. The board, which was planned to meet weekly, dispersed after meeting only a few times. I think İlhan Selçuk (hereafter İS) did not like the emergence of an alternative to the board composed of senior writers. In my first months at the newspaper, during a dinner we had alone during an Istanbul visit, Uğur unexpectedly asked if I wanted to write a column. Honestly, I did not want this yet, because I knew my pen would not be free; I was wary of the senior writers who shared the newspaper's statist-nationalist-laicist views, especially İS, taking a stance against me; I thought I had to be cautious for a while. It would soon become clear that I was not at all wrong about this.

In October 1983, HC asked me to write a report answering the question "How can *Cumhuriyet* become a newspaper that resolutely defends libertarian democracy based on human rights and at the same time applies universal journalism rules?" The report dated October 29, 1983, which HC quoted in full in his book titled *I Loved Cumhuriyet So Much!*, is interesting in that it reflects my excessively optimistic views of those days, quite detached from reality (substituting my wishes for facts), as almost always. I reproduce it below.

The democracy graft has taken hold

"Why couldn't a pluralistic democratic order based on political rights and freedoms be established healthily in Turkey? Where should the reasons be sought for its interruption

by the 1960, 1971, and 1980 interventions, and for our entering the 1980s with an anti-democratic legal framework like the 1982 Constitution? In light of the answers to these questions, is the establishment of democracy as practiced in Western European countries a pipe dream for Turkey? If not, what are the lessons to be drawn in light of past experiences? What should be done to establish and protect democracy? Before briefly answering these questions, it is necessary to very roughly address some theoretical issues related to social development.

I am of the opinion that theories claiming that social events develop according to certain immutable laws constitute a great obstacle to our understanding and directing social development. I think such theories are related to religious beliefs that explain events through fate and destiny.

Today, science accepts that it is not capable of explaining everything, and teaches that scientific truths constantly change, that is, knowledge considered correct is always falsified, and that science progresses not through the accumulation of correct knowledge but through replacing knowledge understood to be wrong with what appears more correct, and that no knowledge is absolutely correct.

Science, whose primary purpose is said to be seeking certain regularities (laws) in nature as well as in society, today shows that even in nature such regularity occurs very rarely, that it is impossible to establish laws. The understanding that natural and social events are directed by certain laws has remained in the 19th century. In natural sciences, Einstein's theories replaced Newtonian physics. In social sciences, the positivist understanding that social events (like natural events) are directed by some laws has been largely abandoned. It is generally accepted (except by party ideologues and a very limited circle of scientists) that the theory of historical materialism, which constitutes a positivist interpretation of Marxism, has also been breached in many respects and is inadequate in explaining social developments.

Parliamentary democracy, which had grown and developed in the environment of Western European societies, had been planted in Turkey, which had no such tradition of governance, like a foreign "sapling" by a conscious actor, a political elite that wanted to Westernize Turkey (through a process that began with the Tanzimat and even earlier).

The Ottoman political elite, in constant cultural exchange with the West and influenced by this civilization, introduced the aspects they saw as achievable into Turkish society. Although the structural characteristics of society did not seem at all favorable, they waged a hard struggle against traditionalist forces that wanted to keep society in its traditional structure and gradually brought the institutions of Western civilization to the country. I accept as a secondary explanation that the difficulties we have encountered since the 1950s in establishing parliamentary democracy stem from the difficulties this foreign "sapling" encountered in taking root in our social soil. In my opinion, by the time we reached the 1970s, the graft had essentially taken hold. The sapling had begun to weave its roots in a way that would be difficult to uproot. These roots are democratic institutions to the extent we have been able to establish them, rights and freedoms to the extent they are respected, etc. I reach this conclusion by comparing with "Eastern" and

“Southern” societies where the sapling of democracy could not be planted at all, could not find the opportunity to develop.

The democracy graft has taken hold in Turkey. The issue is how it will be developed and protected. Here, the influence of the most general economic and political conditions in the world and in Turkey must be taken into account. But I believe the main knot lies in the stance the Turkish political elite will take. As can be seen, I advocate the thesis that political action and the political elite are of great importance. I agree with those who think the political elite is primarily responsible for the defeats and setbacks democracy has suffered in Turkey.

Although each of the 1960, 1971, and 1980 military interventions had its own specific causes and consequences, the general conditions that gave rise to these interventions lie neither at the economic nor the cultural (structural) level. From the 1950s to the mid-1970s, Turkey was experiencing unprecedented economic development in its history. During the same period, the general and political education of the people was increasing to an unprecedented extent in Turkey’s history.

I see our political elite’s failure to reach a consensus on “pluralistic democracy” as the main culprit for the defeats and setbacks democracy has suffered in our country. Relatedly, our political elite has not been able to unite on the principle that politics should command arms, that the army should be under the command of parliament.

Within our political elite, four fairly strong currents are against democracy, two on the “right” in the conservative sense and two on the “left” in the reformist sense (on the right, fascists and Sharia supporters; on the left, the thousand and one factions of communists and nationalist-revolutionaries). The “populist” wing (DP - AP, the Democrat Party and the Justice Party) of the Westernist-reformists who founded democracy sees democracy as majority dictatorship, while the “elitist” CHP could only accept that the right to govern lies with the majority in the 1970s.

However, the two democratic parties that could agree on the principle of “parliamentary supremacy” after the March 12, 1971 intervention, with the aim of “being in power at any cost,” committed the folly of portraying each other as outside the constitution and cooperating (at various levels) with anti-democratic currents, one on the right and the other on the left, giving these anti-democratic currents the opportunity to have a say in the country’s fate with a power they never possessed among the people.

“Democratic” parties failed to save the regime by reaching a compromise in an environment where fascist, communist, or Sharia forces ran rampant; they in a sense prepared their own end. Along with the political elite, some of the intellectuals also cut the branch they were sitting on.

Under these conditions, the army, which has always seen itself as having a say in the country’s fate, was “compelled” to intervene in the regime. (I attach no value whatsoever to the theory that the environment created in the second half of the 1970s was a conspiracy to bring the army to power.) And on a foundation of legitimacy and consensus unprecedented in the country’s history… And the army, in accordance with its

own traditions and logic, reorganized society in a "barracks" order, in a statist-centralist direction.

A point that should not be forgotten is that the army is aware of the limits of the public support and legitimacy it relies on. That limit is that the majority of the people will not long allow their right to determine political power with their own vote and to change a government they do not like to be taken from them.

In succinct terms, if we want democracy, democracy can exist. (It is of course not possible to protect and develop parliamentary democracy with those who advocate it because it provides a good environment for preparations to destroy it.)

Those who advocate parliamentary democracy based on political freedoms have three tasks ahead:

1. To consider protecting democracy more important than coming to power and to cooperate for this. 2. To draw a clear line between themselves and those who do not believe in democracy on the right and left. 3. Not to accept "the freedom to destroy democracy." There is indeed a problem in Turkey of limiting the freedoms of enemies of democracy. Is it sufficient to determine this limit by the element of coercion?

This question is a question worth discussing.

I think the main responsibility in achieving these goals falls on the political movement we have now begun to call the social democratic current. Because I believe that true democrats are social democrats. I believe that social democracy in Turkey needs to achieve clarity primarily on the following points:

1. The parliamentary order based on political rights and freedoms, on universal suffrage, is not a bourgeois democracy in the West either, but the work of a workers' and laborers' movement led by social democratic parties.

2. Pluralistic political democracy can only be healthy together with a pluralistic economic and cultural structure. Pluralistic democracy requires a cultural structure that is as open to the outside as possible and as decentralized as possible. The polycentric structure in the economy must also be established in culture.

3. The social democratic state's intervention in society should be for establishing and developing a pluralistic structure. The market economy is the mechanism that most effectively mobilizes the productive power of the people. Humanity is not at a level of maturity to put a stronger motivation in place of personal gain. This means that a fundamental change in mentality is needed in the Turkish social democratic current, which continues a centralist-statist economic mindset.

4. Turkish social democracy must now see that the world economic system is a system of interdependence. Integration with the European Economic Community (EEC) does not conflict with the aim of developing our political and economic relations with Islamic and southern countries.

5. Integration with the EEC is also important in terms of supporting our political democracy with solid external foundations. Turkey should be within the military alliance of Western democracies (NATO). The problems between us and Greece should be resolved as soon as possible." (For the full report, see: Hasan Cemal, *I Loved Cumhuriyet So Much*, Doğan Kitap, 2005, pp. 118-122.)

In Sirmen's room

At that time, the newspaper's administrative headquarters was in Cağaloğlu, in a masonry building constructed right next to the wooden building that once housed the headquarters of the Committee of Union and Progress and was now used as a warehouse. In the large room at the end of the top floor was the owner and chief columnist Nadir Nadi, in the room next to him the general publication director Hasan Cemal, and in the following rooms were the offices of senior writers (İlhan Selçuk, Oktay Akbal, Ali Sirmen, in that order) and the "Opinions" page editor Sami Karaören. The room closest to the entrance of the floor belonged to Ali Sirmen, who at that time was in prison, convicted in the Peace Association case. In the first days, Hasan Cemal placed me in Sirmen's room by having an additional desk put in. (I heard that when Sirmen heard this, he made the joke about me: "The fastest-climbing man in the newspaper's history.") However, I would soon descend as quickly as I had climbed. For the books I introduced on the page I prepared and my choices regarding interviews drew reactions not only from senior writers but also from employees who at that time were committed to Cumhuriyet's traditional line.

In my first days of work, I first visited Nadir Nadi and introduced myself; then I stopped by İlhan Selçuk and paid my respects. I had no prior acquaintance with Selçuk; we knew each other from our writings. Since his views seemed too statist-nationalist-laicist to me, I tried to avoid dealing with him. One day, as he was passing in front of the room where I sat, in an unusual manner, without entering, he poked his head through the door and greeted me; he said it would be beneficial for us to get together and talk from time to time, thus avoiding unwanted disagreements. It was clear that from my first days, he was uncomfortable with my presence at the newspaper. He must have somehow made this felt to HC as well, because after a while HC no longer stopped by or greeted me when passing in front of my room. It was becoming clear that my days in that room were numbered.

I'm getting on their nerves

Those whose nerves I was getting on with my presence were not limited to the "sugar big brothers." Okay Gönensin, the managing editor and the newspaper's second-in-command after HC, who graduated from Mülkiye a few years after me, was also not at all pleased with the criticisms and suggestions I made about the newspaper's content at morning meetings. (Unfortunately, my relationship with the late Okay, with whom I would later work at *Sabah* newspaper as well, was never good.) My choices regarding the ten most noteworthy books of the year, which I had made a habit of ranking on the page I managed at year-ends, were also generally not approved of. The absence of Yalçın

Küçük's book *Theses on Intellectuals* in the 1983 ranking had caused veiled grumbles reflected in the writings of both Oktay Akbal and Yalçın Doğan.

The September 12 military administration had ended, and the Motherland Party (ANAP) founded by Turgut Özal had won the 1983 general elections. I found it very positive that Özal was pursuing a policy of eliminating polarization and reconciling society under the slogan of "uniting four currents" and pioneering steps toward transition to a market economy. For this reason, I wrote a letter expressing my appreciation to him. (Unfortunately, I could not find a copy of this letter in my archive.) I had HC and Cengiz Çandar read the letter. HC said, "Don't send this, if the sugar big brothers see it they'll really give us hell…" Cengiz's reaction was, "Well, well… You've gone from Maoism to Özalism…" (Cengiz would resign from *Cumhuriyet* in 1987 and would become an advisor to Özal some time later.)

Like most of our past (and future) politicians, Turgut Özal also had two faces, positive and negative. I most liked his statements "my mother is Kurdish" and "What if we discussed federalism." (I would have liked to meet Özal. Taha Akyol, with whom I gradually became close friends, wanted to introduce me to Özal at one point after I left *Cumhuriyet* in 1992, but it was not meant to be.)

I'm being relegated to the archive

Finally, I was brought down from the top floor as quickly as I had climbed. First, I was placed in an empty room in the adjacent building where the administrative units were located. Some time later, I was transferred to a narrow, glass-enclosed compartment specially built for me in the newspaper's archive; in short, I was "relegated to the archive." Subsequently, my attendance at morning meetings was no longer wanted. This was how HC prevented me from being visible and getting on people's nerves. He stopped coming by my compartment too. But gradually his nerves were also starting to fray. I had lent him Karl Popper's book *The Open Society and Its Enemies*, containing his political philosophy, and then Bryan Magee's book on Popper's philosophy of science. He was quite influenced by these, and when Enis Batur mentioned a Popper interview published in a French magazine, he asked him to translate it into Turkish and had it published in the newspaper's newly launched "Politics '84" supplement. (December 10, 1984).

Contrary to what HC would write in his book about Cumhuriyet, I had no role whatsoever in the translation and publication of this interview. Indeed, HC would later correct this: "I had begun to know Popper and *The Open Society and Its Enemies* thanks to Şahin Alpay in the early 1980s. When we devoted two pages to Karl Popper in the politics supplement of *Cumhuriyet* newspaper, which I was managing at that time, I think it was 1984, there was an uproar within the newspaper, and İlhan Selçuk promptly declared the philosopher a counter-revolutionary in his column…" he wrote. (Milliyet, December 28, 2010.) What was more interesting was that I had notified Enis by letter, after having Seyfettin Gürsel check them since I did not know French, about sentences in the Turkish translation that were incompatible with Popper's thought; because of this, a rift had developed between Enis and me.

HC would describe what happened following the publication of Enis's Popper translation as follows: "According to İlhan Selçuk, (Popper) was a 'counter-revolutionary.' For this reason, all hell had broken loose between us. There were 'counter-revolutionary infiltrations' at Cumhuriyet. He did not name them explicitly, but Şahin Alpay was at the top of these. And I, as general publication director, was not doing my duty properly regarding these 'infiltrations.' A few days after the Popper interview in the politics supplement, İlhan Selçuk took up his pen and wrote a piece in his column that slammed Popper, concluding with 'Despite Popper and his likes, history marches on!'" (*I Loved Cumhuriyet So Much*, Doğan Kitap, 2005, p. 141.)

"Intellectuals' hell"

The İS column in question was published on 13.12.1984 under the title "Intellectuals' Hell." From that date on, İS and I never reconciled; we did not get together unless necessary. Upon HC's insistence that it was "indispensable," I had to include İS in the interviews I conducted during my last year at *Cumhuriyet*, about how intellectuals, academics, and politicians envisioned the country thirty years into the future. (See "Turkey in the Year 2020", *Cumhuriyet*, 26/3 - 13/4 - 1991. The series was published as a book the same year by AFA Yayınları, owned by my old and late friend Atıl Ant.)

I had long since stopped reading İS's writings. When articles targeting me without naming me came out, friends would immediately call and inform me "he's writing about you." That's how I learned about his article declaring Popper a "counter-revolutionary." I ignored it, but it did not escape others' attention. Taha Akyol, who would later become a friend but whom I had not yet met at that time, was criticizing İS as well in his column, while emphasizing the value of Popper's criticisms directed at totalitarian ideologies, in his usual polite style. ("The Karl Popper debate," *Tercüman*, 18.12.1984.) Tahsin Yücel also said in an article, "…starting from a two-page conversation, we had writers who mocked and slammed Karl Popper, one of the most consistent defenders of free thought." ("Our Cultural and Artistic Life from 1984 to 1985," *Milliyet*, 8.1.1985.)

Following the debates that arose, HC came to see me one day in my compartment in the archive. In a very low voice so as not to be heard around, he told me not to pay attention to what İS wrote; that he, just like Doğan Avcıoğlu (1926 - 83), was consuming himself; that the future of the newspaper belonged to our generation, and he left. I too, in those days, mistakenly as always, believed that our generation would fully take over the newspaper after a while. Under HC's management, the newspaper's circulation (according to sales department reports) had risen from around 82,000 in 1983 to around 125,000 in 1987; and had reached around 120,000 in 1990. I greatly appreciated the understanding of journalism that HC expressed at morning meetings; I thought "If there is a journalist worthy of the title in Turkey, it is HC after Abdi İpekçi."

"Conservatives selling progressivism"

Cumhuriyet's senior columnists who embraced a strange synthesis of Marxism and Kemalism were the main elements preventing HC from making the newspaper he wanted. The late Oktay Akbal (1923 - 2015), who was the representative of views close

to pure statist-nationalist-laicist Kemalism, was also one of those writers. The letter that Mete Tunçay sent to Akbal (with a copy to me as well), titled “Not a right-left issue, but a matter of level,” requesting publication in the newspaper, described the common mentality of the “sugar big brothers” very well:

“In your Yes/No piece published in the December 31, 1984 Cumhuriyet*, you mentioned me without giving my name. According to you, a study I did (actually together with a friend), published in* Tarih ve Toplum *magazine last October, made me ‘ridiculous.’ When you say ‘some left-looking ’new right’ researchers, pseudo-scientists,’ you apparently mean to describe me. Dear Mr. Akbal, it is obvious that in your Yes/No, Black/White world, there is no room for ‘maybes,’ for ‘intermediate tones.’ But that world in your head has no relation to the real world woven of contingencies and grays. You are a conservative selling progressivism! I don’t know why you still torment yourself in vain by reading things. Unless you are open-minded, let alone being able to think something new, you cannot even understand and learn what others think! You say ‘I don’t believe in the science called history, I don’t even consider it a science.’ Since you consider yourself (presumably by God) as having been made privy to the secret of everything, you cannot grasp today’s reality just as you cannot grasp yesterday’s reality; you just keep repeating what you knew before.”*

I had developed an antipathy, an allergy toward the late İS that seems quite meaningless when I look back from today. However, this was not simply a case of reacting against someone because of their different ideas, which is a typical form of intolerance; it was partly the result of the hostility I received from him. While I was trying to explain that I had purged myself of my past ideology, his persistent characterization of me as a “Maoist” was also getting on my nerves. HC would write about this:

“Ah, those Maoists at *Cumhuriyet*… I was the one who gathered them. I was the one who brought trouble upon *Cumhuriyet*… Şahin Alpay, Cengiz Çandar, Kerem Çalışkan, Mehmet Ataberk, Hadi Uluengin, Sabetay Varol, Celal Üster, Alev Er, even Osman Ulagay and many more… I was taking over the newspaper from within with them.” (*I Loved Cumhuriyet So Much*, p. 199.) The truth is that all these people whose names were listed had long since abandoned Maoism by the time they started working at Cumhuriyet. Cengiz Çandar even claimed he had never been a Maoist. But İS would not stop talking about the “Maoist conspiracy!” against *Cumhuriyet*. (ibid., p. 252)

While I, helplessly, was consumed by the feeling that I could not make the contribution I wanted to the newspaper, that I could not use my potential, İS continued to be disturbed by my presence and pestered HC. HC would write: “Without naming names, he was criticizing Şahin Alpay and Osman Ulagay; he was saying ‘If you don’t have the courage to say some things, the Editorial Board will say them.’” (p. 374) If HC had happened to let me write a column in those days, the “civil war” at the newspaper, as he called it, might not have broken out much earlier, but I would certainly have found myself out the door long ago.

I came across the following letter in my archive that I wrote to HC, reflecting my feelings about İS. In summary, I was saying: *“Dear Hasan Cemal, Recently in your (!) issue dated September 27, 1987, I came across an article by İS titled ‘What is Philosophy?’ It*

caught my interest and I read it. The authors of the book İS recommended to readers who asked him what to read are Galina Kirilenko and Lydia Korshunova. It was published in Moscow in 1985, and its Turkish translation was printed in Istanbul the same year. It is clear that the book has no value beyond being a philosophy book that the Soviet state deemed appropriate to be taught. It is known by everyone that İS has made a habit of writing on subjects he knows nothing about and does not understand at all. But it is hard to think that he recommended this book without knowing and understanding that it was an official philosophy book of the Soviet state… What can I say, may God grant you ease in your effort to produce a quality and respectable Cumhuriyet *newspaper, which I follow with great appreciation. I apologize for troubling you with this small detail among your many intensive and important tasks. Respectfully, A* Cumhuriyet *reader. October 10, 1987."*

I continued to prepare the book page, which was receiving considerable interest among the newspaper's readers whose numbers were steadily increasing under HC's management, and which had no equivalent in the press. This page served a function of establishing a connection between the academic world and the general reading public. My former teacher Şerif Mardin was telling our mutual acquaintances that I was "doing a very important job" with this page. The writings of many well-known academics and intellectuals were published on this page. Among these, I can name Ahmet Arslan, Mübeccel Kıray, Ergun Özbudun, Aptullah Kuran, İlkay Sunar, Feroz Ahmad, Şirin Tekeli, Stefanos Yerasimos, Fahrettin Yağcı, Zafer Toprak, Yeşim Arat, Binnaz Toprak, Asım Erdilek, Oral Sander, Hüseyin Pazarcı, İlhan Tekeli, Selim İlkin, Hilmi Yavuz, Şevket Pamuk, Nora Şeni, Arda Denkel, Taner Berksoy, Ayşe Buğra, Seyfettin Gürsel, and Selim Deringil. The first newspaper articles of people who would later become columnists at newspapers (such as Ertuğrul Özkök, Şükrü Hanioğlu, İlber Ortaylı, Ali Bayramoğlu) would also appear on this page.

Inspired by the interest the book page was receiving, HC had asked me for a report on a "Book Supplement" that the newspaper would publish. The report I submitted on March 11, 1984, which also reflected my views on the publishing world at that time, began as follows:

"In the last ten to twenty years, both the world and our society have gone through very rich experiences. In light of these experiences, questions have arisen in the minds of most intellectuals in our country as in the whole world. Many of the explanations and theories that were previously considered sufficient are now viewed with skepticism. It can be said that an intellectual environment is being experienced in almost all democratic countries where new intellectual currents are being born and 'old' ideas are being viewed critically.

Leaving behind the years of turmoil in the late 1970s and the military regime in the early 1980s, we are in a process of transition toward a democratic order. What kinds of wrong views and policies endangered democracy in our country in the past? What are the philosophical, 'scientific,' etc. foundations of these wrong views and policies? What can our intellectuals do for democracy to be strengthened, what mistakes can they avoid repeating? Such questions are the main questions in the minds of our intellectuals. A

thirst for knowledge, discussion, and intellectual development is observed among our newly emerging intellectuals, the young generations.

This being the situation, universities have been put under barracks control and have been almost prevented from producing intellectual work. The university's intellectual products, for example its publications, are quite far from responding to the needs of our intellectuals. It is very doubtful that the mostly intellectual journals outside the university, which are published every two or three months and reach at most 2-3 thousand people, respond to these needs.

Under these conditions, there is a dire need in Turkey for a publication that provides information to intellectuals who read books, think and discuss our social problems, about what they can read on the questions that trouble their minds, that addresses different approaches at a popular (but quality) rather than academic level while doing so, and that features articles of reasonable length.

Since 1980, an increasing trend has been observed in the number of books published in our country, especially in the fields of review-research-thought. Demand for books, while far from a satisfactory level, is growing. However, worrying trends are seen in terms of quality in both original and especially translated publications. Frankly, low-quality original/translated books are multiplying. Criticism is the only way to democratically control the quality of books. Due to the absence of a critical tradition, the labor, capital, and time wasted on the production and consumption of extraordinarily worthless books is at a heartbreaking level. Exposing low-quality books is of great importance for consumer protection.

Cumhuriyet, as our country's oldest and only opinion newspaper, will publish a book supplement aimed at meeting the needs briefly mentioned above, serving the expansion of the pluralistic intellectual environment in our country, similar to examples seen in the West such as* Times Literary Supplement*,* New York Times Book Review*, but surpassing them in some respects…"*

"Sugar big brothers" don't want it

The "Book Supplement" in question could only be realized six years after my report on this subject, starting from February 1990, under the editorship of Celal Üster. The last of the book pages I prepared was published on January 11, 1990. I was not asked to contribute to the book supplement. My contributions to the newspaper were becoming increasingly sparse because the "sugar big brothers" did not want them. Still, I was happy about some things I could do. In this context, I would like to mention my series of articles, each of which could have been turned into a book, but which I unfortunately could not: I had written the series "Political Parties in the World and Turkey" (January 10-17, 1983); "Liberalism, Conservatism, Social Democracy in the West" (April 26-30, 1983); and "Transition to Democracy in South America" (May 27-30, 1983) as contributions to the process of returning to multi-party life from the September 12 military regime. When I raised the flag of opposition to nuclear energy with the series titled "Nuclear Energy, the World and Turkey" (May 27-31, 1984), the Chernobyl disaster (1986), which would awaken the world to the dangers, had not yet occurred. The "YÖK

File” (September 29 - October 5, 1985), which I prepared together with Ömer Madra, who had resigned from his faculty position at Ankara University Faculty of Political Sciences after the YÖK (Council of Higher Education) law was passed (but which was published only under my signature), contained the most comprehensive evaluation up to that date of the turning of universities into barracks.

The series I prepared together with Seyfettin Gürsel, titled “Where Do the SHP and DSP Converge - Where Do They Diverge?” (May 25-31, 1986), on the Social Democratic Populist Party and the Democratic Left Party, was a product of our efforts to graft social democracy onto Kemalism. This series was published as a book under the same title (AFA Yayınları, September 1986). The book ostensibly covered our interview with DSP leader Rahşan Ecevit, but the one speaking was Mr. Bülent himself, who at the time continued to be banned under September 12. On this occasion, we had the opportunity to meet Bülent Ecevit; and we were quite hopeful. The meeting would also result in Gürsel serving as DSP Istanbul provincial chairman, until he became disillusioned and resigned shortly after.

Some of my contributions to *Cumhuriyet* that I was happy about were the interviews I conducted. Upon the recommendation of my friend Zafer Toprak, after reading his main works, especially “Mentality and Religion: Islam, Sufism and the Economic Ethics of the Dissolution Period,” I developed great admiration for and curiosity about Sabri Ülgener (1911 - 1983) and visited him at his home for an interview (Cumhuriyet, 25.03.1982). Ülgener, one of Turkey’s most brilliant social scientists ever, was both surprised and quite pleased that someone from the Kemalist-oriented *Cumhuriyet* newspaper had come forward and taken an interest in him. I was very proud when he came to visit me at the newspaper to express this.

The Ülgener and Mardin discomfort

Because the Marxist paradigm in my mind had collapsed, in my effort to get to know our social scientists in the Max Weber tradition, that is, those who prioritize and research the role of ideas rather than production technology in the development of societies, I also did an interview based on the book titled *On Ideology* with Şerif Mardin, who was my teacher at SBF, but whom I had considered too right-wing when at school and attended his classes only out of duty. (*Cumhuriyet*, 29.04.1982) The consecutive Ülgener and Mardin interviews also caused discomfort at the newspaper, leading to a reaction from dear Yalçın Doğan, who was then Ankara bureau chief, directed at me: “this guy is filling the newspaper with right-wingers!”

Some of the other names with whom I conducted noteworthy interviews were: Tarık Zafer Tunaya, İsmail Cem, (my friend philosophy professor Arda Denkel, one of the most brilliant minds I knew, whom we lost at a young age), (Education Minister and my classmate from SBF) Hasan Celal Güzel, (editor-in-chief of Sweden’s best-selling newspaper Dagens Nyheter) Christina Jutterström, (Danish Social Democratic Party leader and prime minister) Svend Auken, (French Prime Minister) Lionel Jospin, (Anna Lindh, who fell victim to a murder while serving as Swedish foreign minister in 2003), (the legendary coach of the Black Eagles, as the Beşiktaş football club is known, who

led the team to three consecutive championships) Gordon Milne, (renowned Swedish liberal social democrat economist) Bo Södersten, (director of Spain's Social Science Research Center) Jose Maravall, (Ottoman historian) Stanford Shaw, (Oxford University Middle East expert) Philip Robins, (Iraqi Kurdish leader) Celal Talabani, and (Gorbachev's chief economic advisor) Stanislav Shatalin.

During the approximately ten years I worked at *Cumhuriyet*, some scattered political analyses of mine were also published in the supplements the newspaper put out. However, the feeling that I could not use my potential was increasingly growing, and I was becoming increasingly unhappy. So much so that after a while, I would describe my years at *Cumhuriyet* as "the unhappiest period of my life." I was trying to make my existence and views known by writing for magazines and doing translations. I translated Swedish social scientist Ingvar Johansson's article "Anglo-Saxon Philosophy of Science" (Books 4 and 5, 1982/1983) from Swedish for the *Yazko Felsefe Yazıları* (Yazko Philosophy Writings) journal prepared by Selahattin Hilav. Mete Tunçay added my translation from Popper, titled "Prediction and Prophecy in the Social Sciences," to the end of his translation of Bryan Magee's book, published as *Karl Popper's Philosophy of Science and Political Theory* (Remzi Kitabevi, Istanbul 1982). Popper's article "The Logic of the Social Sciences" was published in *Yazko Felsefe Yazıları* / Book 7 (Istanbul 1983). A selection from the articles of famous economist Assar Lindbeck, the chief representative of the liberal, i.e., pro-market wing of the social democrats in Sweden, was published under the title "Market Economy and Democracy: A Critique of the New Left's Economic Views" (Birey ve Toplum Yayınları, Istanbul 1985). With these translations, I was sharing the fundamental ideas of the new, liberal paradigm in my mind with my readers.

Respect to Kemal Kurdaş

In this context, I also had original publications. The article titled "Views for a Contemporary Social Democracy" published in *Banka ve Ekonomik Yorumlar* (Bank and Economic Reviews) journal (January 1987, pp. 35-45) was the result of my acquaintance with Prof. Dr. Kemal Kurdaş, former finance minister and founder of METU. My acquaintance with Kurdaş had come about through Asaf Savaş Akat and Seyfettin Gürsel, with whom I shared ideas at the time as liberal-oriented social democrats. Kurdaş, whom I greatly respected, was one of the rare people who shared my political philosophy and quite liked my writings. Not having been able to visit the late Kurdaş (1920 - 2011) in the years after his retirement is something that weighs on my conscience.

Another person who would leave a mark on me like Kurdaş was the late businessman İshak Alaton. Alaton, *whom I met during the years I worked at Cumhuriyet*, had founded Alarko Holding, one of Turkey's largest family companies, together with Üzeyir Garih, who fell victim to a dark murder in 2001. I met Alaton in the mid-1980s, at the opening of the architecture office of my friend Dinç Gürs, who had made his permanent return from Sweden a few years after us. Alaton had worked in a factory in Sweden for two years in his youth, and during those two years had learned Swedish better than I had in 9 years. (His Swedish wife, whom he met and married there, certainly had a role in this.) A

friendship developed between us because we shared the liberal social democratic understanding in Sweden. Alaton was a cultured capitalist; he had both Marx and Popper in his library. He liked my writings and enthusiastically supported them. One day he came to visit me at the newspaper, and we had lunch together. Then we stopped by to see Emine Uşaklıgil, who was then the Managing Director and one of the newspaper's partners, and who was married to Asaf Savaş Akat at the time. I think following this visit, there was considerable gossip in the newspaper corridors against me, about my closeness to a big, and moreover Jewish, capitalist.

Alaton, in a letter he sent to İlhan Selçuk in those days, was saying: *"I regularly read* Cumhuriyet *and your writings. I try to understand you, mostly I fail. I experienced the same frustration in 'The Goods of the Sinking Ship.' You say 'Don't let it go cheap, don't let it go to foreigners'… Millions of Turks have been going cheap, going to foreigners for thirty years, most of them miserable abroad. We accept this exploitation, so why are we opposed to attracting foreign capital here, opening job opportunities, and saving these people from being disgraced abroad, from being humiliated by Neo-Nazis? Which exploitation do you think is less bad? How have you not been able to see this truth for thirty years?… I present my respects with wishes for your success. Attachment: Foreign Capital Phobia."* (22.02.1989) Alaton noted at the end of his letter that he had also sent a copy to me. There was now nothing preventing my promotion in the late Selçuk's eyes from"Maoist" to "spokesperson of the Istanbul bourgeoisie, of TÜSİAD (the Turkish Industrialists' and Businessmen's Association)." My friendship with Alaton would continue until his death while I was imprisoned in Silivri.

The dream of social democracy in Turkey

One day in my early years at Cumhuriyet, Hüseyin Sönmez, who was then the founder of Hil Yayınları and nowadays Pandora Kitabevi, called and asked, "Brother, I have a text on social democracy in hand. Can you take a look and tell me if it's worth publishing?" As soon as I read the text he brought, I called Sönmez: "An excellent work. You should publish this immediately… And introduce me to the author Haluk Özdalga right away!.." Özdalga's book, which I found successful enough to abandon my idea of writing a book on social democracy in Sweden, was published under the title *The Formation of Contemporary Social Democracy: Swedish and German Social Democrats* (Hil Yayınları, 1984). This is how I met Haluk, who would become one of my close friends. Haluk had convinced me of this: Just as social democracy originating from Marxism was possible in the West, social democracy originating from Kemalism could very well be possible in our country. Our (futile) effort to derive contemporary social democracy from Kemalism began like this, together with Haluk and other friends.

One initiative that I supported thinking it could be effective in the context of this effort was the "Pera Palas Meetings" we started in 1987. I designed this initiative, which would later serve as a model for many similar series of meetings, together with Mehmet Kabasakal and İskender Aruoba, whom I met around that time. Our aim was to bring together SHP-oriented academics, journalists, businessmen, and other professionals to discuss the problems of the left in Turkey and the path it should follow. These meetings would continue until 1994. I continued attending the Pera Palas meetings until 1992,

when I went to Ankara as chief advisor to Deniz Baykal, the general chairman of the CHP, which had been reopened in the context of the hope, not yet dashed, of deriving social democracy from Kemalism. (Mehmet Kabasakal compiled information about these meetings in a book: *Searching for Solutions to Turkey's Problems: Selections from Pera Palas Meetings: 1987-1994*, [Boyut Yayınları, 1994.]) Another initiative in the same context was the magazine called *Sosyal Demokrat* (Social Democrat), published by Ercan Karakaş, who had returned from Germany and started doing politics in the SHP ranks in those years. I, along with Asaf Savaş Akat and Seyfettin Gürsel, also made contributions to this magazine, which were frankly not very noteworthy.

"In the manner of a prosecutor"

The article titled "An essay on the '68 generation" (Issue 41, Spring 1988, pp. 167-185), which contained a kind of reckoning with my radical left past, that I sent to the *Toplum ve Bilim* (Society and Science) journal published by left-leaning academics, caused an uproar. Some members of the editorial board, especially my friend Ümit Hassan from Robert Lisesi and SBF, had argued that this article should be rejected on the grounds that it was written "in the manner of a prosecutor"; the article was published as a result of Prof. Dr. Sencer Divitçioğlu putting his weight behind it. The late Divitçioğlu told me what had happened one day when he came to visit me at *Cumhuriyet* and we had lunch together.

The late Divitçioğlu (1927-2014), who at that time was explaining the non-development of capitalism in the Ottoman Empire with the concept of the Asiatic Mode of Production (ATÜT), was an original thinker and social scientist who had a Marxist perspective but behaved very differently from those who, with the "imitative" method I would call it, which was common at the time, proceeded on the assumption that the Ottomans had a feudal structure. I regret not having created the opportunity to meet with Divitçioğlu in the years after this meeting.

My article that caused debates in the *Toplum ve Bilim* journal editorial board ended as follows: *"The elimination of the rights and freedoms of individuals, of those in the minority, for the freedom and liberation of the class, the people, the majority, the nation, etc., is the beginning of the enslavement of the class, the people, the majority, the nation. Because the views, currents, parties that are in the minority today may in fact be the true representatives of the interests of the majority. There is no single, infallible, absolute truth, reality. Things we know to be true today may turn out to be wrong tomorrow. Those we trust today may turn out to be the most untrustworthy people tomorrow. Wrong views, wrong policies, and faulty administrators must be able to be changed. Therefore, the freedom to choose among different views, policies, and administrators cannot be renounced. Freedom of thought for the individual and the freedom to change one's thought… I think this is the fundamental value that the great majority of the '68 generation believes in today."* In these lines, one can find a summary of the paradigm that can generally be described as liberal, which I adopted from the 1980s onward. Attributing these thoughts to the majority of the '68 generation was, as the debate that erupted in the journal showed, a complete pipe dream.

Özal's Turkey

Excerpts from the text titled "Some observations worth questioning/discussing regarding Özal's Turkey," which I wrote at the end of 1988 / beginning of 1989 at HC's request, are worth conveying in that they reflect my observations about Turkish politics at that time (some of which I would not share later):

"By the end of the 1970s, Turkey:

- Had reached a point of deadlock with the closed and import-substitution industrialization policies that had been in place since the early 1960s.

- The political polarization that had escalated since the mid-1970s had rendered the multi-party democratic order inoperable.

Under these conditions, the September 12 intervention received the approval of the vast majority of society, including civilian politicians. With this intervention, restructuring in the political and economic order came onto the agenda. (The political ambition of the five generals probably does not go beyond being "a drop in the ocean" in explaining September 12.)

With the strength given by the public support behind it, the September 12 regime, unlike the two previous coups: Closed all political parties and subjected the political elite to "pruning." It renewed the constitution and fundamental laws related to the regime "from head to toe." Thus, it drew the new framework of politics. It also gave the authority and opportunities for economic restructuring to civilians.

With the 1983 elections, the return to democracy with a step-by-step normalization strategy began with a "surprise" from the start (i.e., under the direction of ANAP instead of MDP, the Nationalist Democracy Party). Turgut Özal, the only link between the last Demirel government and the September 12 regime who was tasked with carrying out economic restructuring in the 1980s, who played the leading role in taking a fairly rapid step toward normalization as the "surprise" winner of the guided 1983 elections, and who finally won the 1987 elections with an electoral system that eliminated parties in conflict with the regime and the possibility of coalition, became, like it or not, the politician who marked Turkey of the 1980s.

Turkey of the 1980s is, like it or not, a very different Turkey from those of the 1960s and 1970s. "New" Turkey is to some extent the result of the September 12 military regime, largely of the ANAP administration, and to a significant extent of the political-economic-ideological climate that dominated the world in the 1980s. (…)

We can also discuss the characteristics of Turkey of the 1980s around the following points. (Each of these propositions can be questioned, of course.)

<u>In Politics</u>

- Depoliticization: The exclusion of political currents and parties in conflict with the regime, various bans and restrictions brought depoliticization.

- Apoliticization: Especially the segments of society that had become excessively politicized in the previous period (students, workers, etc.) became apoliticized both due to the force of depoliticization measures and the effect of reaction against politicization.

- Depolarization: Alongside the exclusion of currents and parties in conflict with the regime, a tendency toward softening/seeking consensus in relations between different currents/parties (though weak) is observed, partly due to the effect of lessons from the past.

- Significant renewal in the party system has come onto the agenda. The conservative-liberal ANAP has gained the character of the major party in the center-right, and the political cadre of the mainstream on the right has been almost entirely renewed.

- The debate about whether ANAP is here to stay or going has ended. ANAP has gained the position of the major party on the right with a strategy whose basic principles can be summarized as follows: + With the claim of uniting four currents, it has both benefited from the reaction against division and polarization in society, and has pursued a policy of melting the fascist and religious right and/or leaving them outside parliament through electoral system manipulation. + By benefiting from the reaction against old leaders, it has pushed back the AP-DYP cadre; by extending a hand to the left as well, it has secured as much support as possible from those ranks.

- Turkey of the 1980s is an incomparably more optimistic society than Turkey of the 1970s. Part of this optimism has been made possible by breakthroughs achieved in various fields, and part by successfully maintained psychological conditioning.

- ANAP claims to be a brand new party. It has shown that it is not the continuation of AP. It has pioneered some important innovations in the economic field. It has succeeded in building a new discourse for itself by advocating the superiority of an open economy not surrounded by prohibitions, economic rationality, dynamism in doing business, and modernization in material culture with the slogan "leaping an era." It is successful in giving society an image of being new, even if not actually new.

- The religious right has largely maintained its strength but has not been able to develop as much as feared.

- The fascist right is in a decline that can be called a rout. It has lost a large portion of its voters with a major loss of prestige.

- The democratic left has emerged for the first time with the label "social democrat." SHP, with the claim of being the continuation of CHP, has rejected the necessity of renewal; Ecevit has emerged with the claim of renewal on the left, but it has been seen that he actually wanted to establish a one-person party/movement. The demand for renewal on the left has remained weak.

- Revolutionary communists have suffered a great loss of prestige. Within the generally declining communist left, Maoism has been almost completely erased due to developments in China, and the Moscow-aligned left has strengthened.

- The nationalist/Kemalist left has almost completely withdrawn from the scene.

- While Armenian terrorism as a destabilization factor has gradually declined, the Kurdish issue has tended to become the fundamental political problem in the 1980s.

- In the 1980s, new and marginal currents such as environmentalist and feminist movements, though weak, have emerged in political life.

In the Economy

- ANAP pioneered some liberal practices such as changes in the law protecting Turkish currency, abandonment of fixed exchange rate and interest policies, and import liberalization measures. On the other hand, economic decisions became centralized and arbitrary to an unprecedented degree; practices that were diametrically opposed to the requirements of a free market economy became established. How liberal is ANAP in the economy?

- ANAP pioneered opening up to the outside in the economy. Important developments achieved in exports and tourism, Turkish businessmen doing business in other countries occurred during this period. On the other side of the coin, there are problems of fictitious export cases and having reached the limits of exports. On the other hand, fund practices raise the question of to what extent liberalization has occurred in foreign trade.

- The economic stagnation of the second half of the 1970s gave way to growth along with inflation in the 1980s.

- Greater deterioration in income distribution became another characteristic of ANAP's Turkey.

- It can be said that there has been a revolution in economic mentality. It can be said that economic rationality has begun to dominate society. "Money" has moved to the center of all values.

- An immoral consequence of economic rationality, the development of the philosophy of getting rich quick, the understanding of "Make money, no matter how you make it" has become widespread.

In Culture

- Collapse occurred in the education system at every level. Science, education, and culture were pushed to the back of the priority order.

- Along with the heavy blows to the freedom of science and art, parallel to money becoming the fundamental value in society, the prestige of science, education, and culture in society's eyes witnessed a complete collapse.

- Both scientists and teachers became ordinary people as representatives of professions that have no prestige and do not bring money.

- Arabesquization/degradation came to dominate mass culture.

- Intellectuals suffered a loss of prestige.

- Political ideologies largely declined among intellectuals. Being an individual rather than belonging to a current/circle/group gained greater value.

- A television revolution occurred. Print media gradually lost to visual media. Reading newspapers, magazines, and books was replaced by watching television, cinema, and video.

- Due to the state monopoly on TV, there was a revival in the press's commentary function, in investigative journalism that illuminates what goes on behind the scenes.

- While the space allocated to sex and sensation in newspapers expanded, a development from mission journalism toward professional journalism was also seen.

- Turkey opened up a bit more to the outside, became more internationalized. Western standards seemingly gained the quality of standards to be emulated in every area of society in the 1980s."

My search for escape from *Cumhuriyet*

During the years I worked at *Cumhuriyet*, I gained two lasting friends: Sedat Ergin, the only Robert Lisesi graduate journalist I knew besides myself (moreover a Beşiktaş supporter like me), and the late Ufuk Güldemir. When Sedat was assigned as Washington D.C. correspondent by Hürriyet newspaper in 1987, Hasan Cemal sent Ufuk with the same assignment so as not to fall behind in the competition. Sedat continues to write at *Hürriyet* today, in 2022. Ufuk, unfortunately, would leave us in 2007, when he was only 51 years old.

From the mid-1980s, I began to look for opportunities to escape from *Cumhuriyet*. My close friends like Ömer Madra and Seyfettin Gürsel, who had to leave universities between 1982-85, were working at *Milliyet* at the invitation of Altan Öymen, who was then the newspaper's "general publication coordinator." When I met with Öymen on one occasion, although he seemed to be sounding me out about moving to *Milliyet*, I was sorry that he did not follow through. In September 1985, *Hürgün* newspaper began publication under the direction of my old friend from the AFS circle, Haluk Şahin. Although Haluk invited me to join the team, I did not embark on this adventure because the newspaper's future did not inspire confidence at all. Indeed, *Hürgün* would close down without even lasting two months.

It must have been 1987: I called Ertuğrul Özkök, who showed considerable interest in what I was doing at *Cumhuriyet*, who had left the university in 1986 and started working as a publication consultant at *Hürriyet*, and who would be appointed as the newspaper's general publication director in 1990, to sound him out about whether there might be a job for me. Perhaps because he was still very new at the newspaper, he was quite cold. A hope was born in February 1989. Famous Cypriot businessman Asil Nadir had brought my classmate and close friend from Mülkiye, Metin Münir, to head *Güneş* newspaper, which he had purchased. Cengiz Çandar had also left *Cumhuriyet* and moved to *Güneş*. Metin called me by phone and said he was thinking of me for *Güneş* as well. But

whatever happened happened; he never mentioned it again. (According to Mehmet Ataberk, who also left *Cumhuriyet* and moved to *Güneş*, some in his close circle had said I was "useless.") In any case, not much later, in October 1990, Metin would also leave the general editorship. In short, no other opportunity appeared in the press; I was bound to *Cumhuriyet*. During a meeting of ours in those days, HC would say that he was aware of my contacts with both Haluk Şahin and Metin Münir, that I had done well not to embark on these "adventures," and that I should "be patient."

İlhan Selçuk's Gulag

It's not that I didn't also look for opportunities outside the press to escape from *Cumhuriyet*, which I described (with reference to Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn) as "İlhan Selçuk's Gulag" (prison camp) in conversations with my friends. Hikmet Özdemir, whom I met because of his successful book titled *Yön Movement* (1986), was insisting that I apply for the associate professorship examination; he said I could easily pass the exam with my series of articles published in the newspaper. Somehow, perhaps assuming that everything was possible under the YÖK system, I listened to him. This was the only attempt at opportunism I made in my life. After passing YÖK's foreign language proficiency exam, I took the associate professorship exam at Boğaziçi University, before a jury that did not include my professor friends Binnaz Toprak and İlkay Sunar, who had encouraged me for this. The jury, very rightly, merely recommended, on the grounds that I did not have sufficient publications, that I reapply once my deficiencies were remedied. I was quite embarrassed; I was also very resentful toward Hikmet for directing me to this mistake.

Another "escape from Gulag" attempt of mine occurred in 1988. This time, at the insistence of my late and dear friend Mustafa Gürsel, one of my two classmates from Robert Lisesi who, like me, had joined journalism (the other being Niyazi Dalyancı), I applied for the fellowship of Harvard University's Niemann Foundation, which he had won and benefited from some time earlier and which provides senior journalists with the opportunity to benefit from the university's resources for one year. Although I was hopeful, I was disappointed. The reason for not being accepted was probably that I did not have sufficient journalism experience.

My search for escape from *Cumhuriyet*'s suffocating environment led, again through Mustafa's mediation, very ironically in the 1987-88 academic year, to my giving a course on "Opinion writing" at Anadolu University's School of Press and Broadcasting in Eskişehir, even though I was not (able to do) opinion writing. Several well-known journalists would emerge from among my students in that course. One of them, Güven İslamoğlu, would make environmental programs at CNN-Türk for many years.

Mustafa, who at that time was serving as the Turkey representative of an American cigarette company, did not tire in his efforts to help me escape from *Cumhuriyet*. This time he introduced me to an American woman who was a "head hunter" (that is, someone who recruits executives for various companies). We had a warm conversation at the Hilton hotel that gave me hope, but she must not have liked what she saw, or

perhaps found me overqualified for the job, because she would never be heard from again.

As I had done for almost our entire life together, I constantly complained to Fatma about the difficulties I encountered in work life. My Fatma was complaining about becoming a “wailing wall.” She would say, “I told you; when we returned to Turkey and couldn’t get into a university, you should have started your own business.” Since the salary I received from *Cumhuriyet* could not cover our expenses, I spent all weekends (with an opportunity provided by my friend Zafer Toprak) doing translations for the *Britannica* encyclopedia. Because of this, I could not adequately attend to my children; the main burden of raising them fell on Fatma. During these years that I worked at *Cumhuriyet*, our daughter Elvan had finished Levent elementary school and enrolled at Galatasaray High School after passing the entrance exam; our son Acar had also started at Levent Elementary School.

Fatma falls ill

1986 had been a very unpleasant year for me. With terrible pains from a herniated disc, sometimes with tears flowing from my eyes, I spent a total of five months in bed over three occasions. During these months, Fatma became exhausted from caring for me and began complaining about it in an uncharacteristic manner. The hardships Fatma had endured since almost the time she married me resulted in her health deteriorating in 1987. What the problem was emerged when we went to the doctor with complaints of fatigue. The doctor, a famous internist working at the American hospital, first did not take the complaints seriously, but when she saw the test results and Fatma asked “is there treatment?” didn’t she say “Organ transplants are successful in young people…”???!!! Upon this, we went to four different doctors. Two of them said “a liver biopsy should be done,” while the other two said “an insignificant virus attack.” This time I ran to my classmate from Robert Lisesi, my close friend, the scientist and intellectual I greatly respected, Dr. Hasan Yazıcı.

Hasan recommended that we go to London to see the famous liver specialist Dr. Ian Murray-Lyon and also made an appointment. Murray-Lyon, whom we met at his office on Harley Street, the address of famous doctors, was one of the most gentlemanly and confidence-inspiring doctors I have known. After examining Fatma and also seeing the test results, his saying that there was nothing to worry about, that he could do a biopsy immediately, but that one could wait 6 months given the possibility that it might not be necessary, was very soothing. Fatma and I assessed the situation; we chose to wait and dedicated that week to touring London, which Fatma was visiting for the first time.

Unfortunately, when the test results did not improve, we went to London again 6 months later. My dear Fatma was as cool-headed as ever, but the liver biopsy was a very distressing process; she had to lie on her back for 12 hours without moving to prevent bleeding. Murray-Lyon inserted a needle and took a sample from her liver. After the second biopsy he would do about a year later, he made the diagnosis: cirrhosis was a possibility, not in the liver cells but in the bile ducts. However, three of the four indicators

of cirrhosis were present. He recommended a drug that was still in the experimental stage at the time. My dear Fatma would use this drug for the rest of her life.

The very valuable doctors who took over her care in Turkey (first Prof. Dr. Atilla Ökten, and after his retirement Prof. Dr. Sabahattin Kaymakoğlu) determined that the illness was not progressing and told her not to worry about it anymore. Meanwhile, we learned that Fatma's illness was now defined as cholangitis rather than cirrhosis. I remember both doctors with deep gratitude.

Fatma's illness upset me extremely. I cannot describe the distress I suffered until we went to London. I couldn't sleep at night, and every night I prayed to God in my own language and in my own way to protect my wife. In 1987, between the two biopsies, when I went to Japan on an invitation, I tied ribbons to the wishing trees I encountered in parks; I hung the Buddhist amulets I bought at the head of our bed upon my return. I believed that these and my prayers protected my Fatma against cirrhosis. What would take her from me would not be a liver problem.

Takeda-san

While on the subject, I should describe my first Japan trip in 1987, which is a colorful memory. One of the good things about working at *Cumhuriyet* was being invited to foreign trips from time to time. Accepting invitations of the kind where the hosts cover the expenses was not correct from the standpoint of journalistic ethics, but I could not resist the allure of trips that I could not make with my own means. In 1985, the American Information Center had invited me on a one-month US tour together with a group of journalists and academics from several countries, the tour, covering several states, had been very educational, and I had written my impressions for the newspaper.

During this time, at his request, I had prepared a report for HC on establishing an "Education - Science Service" at the newspaper. In 1986, the service in question was established; I was also assigned to the editorship of the Education - Science Service instead of the Research Service. After a while, it began publishing an "Education - Technology Supplement" under Orhan Bursalı's direction, but I was not given a role and was returned to my old position. In those days, a report prepared by the US Department of Education on education reform in Japan had come into my hands. According to the report, which I found extraordinarily interesting, the Japanese education system (just as in our country) encouraged rote learning and hindered creativity. For this reason, no one from Japan was winning Nobel Prizes.

I had met Keisuke Yamanaka (who would become my friend over time), the official responsible for media relations at the Japanese Consulate General, a graduate of Istanbul University Faculty of Letters, who also knew Turkish very well. My audacity got the better of me, and I asked Yamanaka: Would it be possible for me to be invited to Japan to study education reform? Shortly after, I was called to see Consul General Tatsuo Takeda. Takeda was sitting behind his desk with a very serious demeanor. In English, he asked me one by one why I wanted to go to Japan, what I knew about Japan, what work I did at *Cumhuriyet* newspaper, etc. At one point, when this almost turned into an interrogation, I got annoyed; I showed a sharp reaction along the lines of

“Look, Mr. Takeda, yes I would like to go to Japan to research education reform, but this is not indispensable for me…”

Then Takeda asked if I had been to other countries. When I mentioned that I had done my doctorate in Stockholm in the 1970s, his eyes lit up and his attitude changed instantly. When he asked “Talar du Svenska? / Do you know Swedish?” we began speaking in Swedish between us. Our conversation deepened; as he was seeing me off, he said definitively “Of course you will go to Japan.” Takeda had served in Scandinavia, including Sweden, before being assigned to Istanbul. When he was very pleased with the series I wrote after returning from Japan (“The Japanese Miracle in Education,” May 1-4, 1988), he frequently invited Fatma and me to receptions given at the Consulate General, and we had very interesting conversations. The late Takeda would also write a book containing very positive views about Turkey after his retirement.

The Gorbachev - Ligachev conflict

In the years I joined the newspaper, I thought “If there is a journalist worthy of the title in Turkey, it is HC after Abdi İpekçi,” and I believed that his share in the negative things I encountered in practice was small; that the problems stemmed from the “sugar big brothers.” However, eight years later when 1990 came, this conviction of mine had begun to change, and I had no hope left that HC would eventually take over the newspaper. I had come to think that Hasan was too attached to the “old plus new generation synthesis”; that he had given himself a mission doomed to failure, that of preserving it. Osman Ulagay and I would occasionally discuss the intergenerational tension at the newspaper. On one occasion, I told him that I compared HC at the newspaper to the reformist Gorbachev in Russia, and İS to Ligachev who defended the dominance of the communist party. (HC recorded this as an anecdote in his book on Cumhuriyet. See: p. 387) This was quite a successful analogy; there was also no Yeltsin in sight.

Because I was very far from the newspaper’s management, I was not very aware, but the Gorbachev - Ligachev conflict was escalating. In his book, HC would convey the increasing tension in what he wrote in his diary on January 8, 1991 as follows: “Today İlhan Selçuk and I had a conversation for the first time in a long while. I didn’t think he had so much pent-up resentment toward me. On one hand, he sees me as disloyal, on the other as a ‘scoundrel’ who will unite with capital and purge him from Cumhuriyet. He said: ‘At one point I was so angry at you that I could have done anything.’ But now it seems like he has filed down his negative feelings due to our long history and relationship. During the conversation, he couldn’t contain himself once or twice and spoke almost shouting: ‘You’re mentally ill! You always worked against me, conspired against me, first with Doğan Avcıoğlu, then with Şahin Alpay and Cengiz Çandar, then with Emine.’ I was left astonished.” (p. 401)

When circulation fell below 100,000 after the newspaper’s price was raised from 1200 to 1500 liras (!), HC convened the Advisory Board on February 14, 1991 and asked “What can we do?” In those days, I was quite dejected, hopeless about the newspaper’s future and my future there. Still, according to HC’s notes, I said the following at the meeting:

*“*Cumhuriyet *has certain taboos that we need to overcome. We cannot overcome the deadlock without overcoming these. A chorus and the same ideas being expressed… That is, expanding the range of commentary…* Cumhuriyet *has lately been run as a ‘one man show’ or ‘two man show’ (*a dig at me and Okay*). Also, an authority confusion has begun to emerge (a dig at the Editorial Board)…“* (p. 407)

Hasan Cemal’s vase

Yes, HC wanted to keep Gorbachev and Ligachev together, and thought the newspaper had no other option for survival. I, on the other hand, was of the opinion that the “vase” would inevitably break, and that without breaking it could not become the newspaper HC wanted. Indeed, the “vase” broke; and it was the owners who broke it. It happened like this: they split among themselves and first handed the newspaper over to HC. Upon this, the “sugar big brothers” left the newspaper and, with the outcry of “seized by TÜSİAD,” called on readers to boycott the newspaper. Sales fell to around 45,000. The owners then sent HC away and called back the “sugar big brothers.” However, there was no significant increase in the newspaper’s circulation.

In those days, rightly or wrongly, I was thinking as follows: If the owners had stood behind HC, *Cumhuriyet* could gradually have become the trusted newspaper of educated people of all political persuasions, and could have made an important contribution to the establishment of libertarian democracy in Turkey. However, from that day on, the *Cumhuriyet* newspaper evolved ever further away from what HC had envisioned.

What was experienced at *Cumhuriyet* in the 1980s was, roughly speaking, a fight between the wing led by İlhan Selçuk that advocated a synthesis of Kemalism and a kind of Marxism on one side, and the wing led by Hasan Cemal that saw the need for a libertarian renewal on the left. As is known, this fight did not subside even after the vase broke. About 30 years later, the conflict between the mission newspaper in the “sugar big brothers” tradition and the search for a reliable, quality newspaper this time represented by Can Dündar and his colleagues would lead to the “vase” being broken once again in September 2018.

Hasan Cemal described the first breaking of the “vase” in detail in his book. Everyone who wants to know the story of the press in Turkey should read that book. In any case, in my opinion, HC has three books that shed light on Turkey’s political life and are essential reading: *I Wrote About Myself, Let No One Be Angry* (1999) describes the March 12, 1971 military intervention; *I Loved Cumhuriyet So Much* (2005) describes what went on behind the scenes of the fight at the newspaper; *Life Just Passes By Like This* (2018) is his life story.

Regarding the “breaking of the vase” at *Cumhuriyet*, it may only be meaningful for me to describe what I experienced. It happened like this: One day in early November 1991, HC called me and invited me to his home in Nişantaşı where he was living with his wife at the time, Necla. I sensed something exciting was happening. He explained that the “sugar big brothers” had decided to leave the newspaper over the dispute that had erupted regarding an article by Osman Ulagay and the increase of his articles from one

to three per week. The majority of the owners (that is, Yunus Nadi and his heirs) had left the management of the newspaper to HC; we could now set about making the newspaper we had dreamed of…

Two jobs fell to me in the new *Cumhuriyet*: I would edit the "Views of the Thinkers" section on the second page and also write a column twice a week. From my first days at the newspaper, HC had thought of having me write a column but had not been able to realize this due to the opposition of the "sugar big brothers." I was being promoted to column writing for the first time. However, it was felt from the very first days that the new management would not be long-lived. The first of my column pieces at *Cumhuriyet* was published on November 9, 1991, and the last on February 19, 1992.

On this occasion, I would like to say a few words about my column writing: If you ask me, I wrote noteworthy pieces at *Cumhuriyet* and later at *Sabah*, *Milliyet*, and *Zaman* where I would work, but not only did I never think of collecting these and turning them into a book in any period, I also could not respond to the invitations I received from publishers in this regard. Despite all of dear Taha Akyol's insistence, I could not manage to turn my columns and articles published in magazines into a book. Perhaps because it seemed like "too easy" a task to me; perhaps because going back to finished work was difficult… Whatever the reason, I quite regret not being able to do this.

Earthquake in parliament

Some of the articles that were published twice a week at *Cumhuriyet* for only about four months are important in that they reflect my intellectual world in those days. In the first of these, while commenting on Leyla Zana's speech in the Turkish Grand National Assembly, I was saying the following in an article containing my views on the Kurdish issue that would not change much in later years:

"The other day I was watching the swearing-in ceremony in the Turkish Grand National Assembly out of the corner of my eye on television. Meanwhile, I watched the Leyla Zana incident almost entirely. It seemed to me that an earthquake was happening in parliament. It was as if outdated structures were creaking and something new was emerging. I think what was experienced in parliament was the earthquake undergone by the policy expressed by the slogan 'How happy is the one who says I am a Turk!' The Republic of Turkey has until now followed a policy of melting its plural ethnic structure in one pot with this slogan. It also largely succeeded in melting in this pot the great majority of large and small ethnic groups coming from the Balkans, the Caucasus, and other places and existing in Anatolia. As long as they did not insist on their ethnic identity, no discrimination for or against any ethnic group in the area of rights was applied in principle. During the single-party period and after the transition to democracy, the main ethnic groups were represented in parliament. The Parliament and political parties of the Republic of Turkey did not exclude any ethnic group. Everyone who said 'How happy is the one who says I am a Turk' was given a place at the table.

"Now there is a new demand at this table. The most numerous ethnic group that also shows the greatest resistance to melting in the pot for other reasons, that is, the Kurds, is expressing this new demand for the first time so openly and powerfully. They want to

take their place in the Parliament of the Republic of Turkey by freely expressing their ethnic identities. If our political leaders and parliament continue to approach this demand with the view of ‘disgrace, scandal, traitors’ like some of the press, this will be the real separatism. If those who come to parliament saying ‘I defend Turkish and Kurdish brotherhood’ are suppressed from expressing their ethnic identities, they too will be pushed outside the political system, into the arms of chauvinist Kurdish nationalists who are enemies of the unity of the people. Parliament will largely lose its ability to represent the people. Whereas those who defend Turkish and Kurdish brotherhood are in the overwhelming majority. Confusing these with chauvinist nationalists would be ‘murder.’ Our politicians and writers now need to see this:

“In the 1990s, the world and Turkey do not resemble at all the world and Turkey of the 1960s and 70s. In the 2000s, they will resemble even less. Both socialist and liberal thinkers of the 19th century believed that national (and religious) feelings would disappear in the 20th century. This did not happen. National (and religious) feelings maintain their vitality. This is also a fact demonstrated by the earthquake-like changes experienced in the world in recent years. We must learn to live with this fact. Their being able to be expressed through democratic means is an important chance for stability.

“I think we have also come to a fork in the road on the Kurdish issue. From now on, the Republic of Turkey will either solve the Kurdish problem within democracy by recognizing the freedom for Kurds to freely express their ethnic identity as a natural requirement of the libertarian and pluralistic order, or it will not. Choosing the future is in our hands.

Today there is a widespread demand for democracy, freedom, and peace in the world and in our society. Conditions for solving our problems within democracy are more favorable than ever. All societies are in an effort to adapt themselves to new conditions, to renew themselves. In our country, the majority of the people want the suppression of identities and ideas, intolerance of difference to end. Parliament must respond to this demand. In this way, it will also find the opportunity to repair its worn prestige. Here, the greatest duty falls on the political leaders who guide parliament and society. Are our political leaders and parties ready to take on this duty? That is another question.” (“Earthquake in Parliament,” 9.11.1991)

Internal enemies, external enemies

Another piece of mine that I believe has not lost any of its value was titled “External Enemies, Internal Enemies.” I am quoting it verbatim:

“Sometimes I get the impression that we suffer from a national ‘paranoia,’ that is, a disease of harboring unfounded fears. Those among us who think that almost all of our important problems are created by external enemies who want to divide and fragment Turkey, destroy and scatter our state, or at least want it to remain constantly weak, and their domestic extensions, are so numerous. According to some, all the negatives and evils in Turkey are the work of ‘communists and their local agents.’ (This interpretation is rarely encountered anymore after the collapse of communism in the Soviet Union and Eastern Europe.) According to some, behind all the evils lie the games of ‘imperialists

and their local collaborators'; according to some, these evils are the work of Zionists or Christian missionaries.

"This perspective leads to the most unlikely interpretations: The May 27, 1960 military intervention? It was organized by the Americans who were alarmed that Adnan Menderes, who had decided to go to Moscow, would approach the Soviets… The right-left conflict heading toward a civil war in the 1970s? It was instigated by communists and/or imperialists… The strengthening of religious movements and Sharia advocacy in the 1980s? It is essentially a scheme of Saudi Arabia and Iran… The strengthening of Kurdish currents, Kurdish nationalism? It can only be a result of Western states' plans to fragment Turkey… In my opinion, the most 'amazing' of these interpretations is that Mustafa Kemal himself, the founder of the Republic of Turkey, was a British agent tasked with destroying the Ottoman state…

"According to the perspective I have tried to briefly describe above, Turkey's fate is determined by conspiracies organized by 'foreign powers' who want to dig its grave. There is nothing surprising about those who have obsessions that our path is drawn by 'fate,' 'laws of history,' 'laws of the development of societies,' 'imperialism that has taken the place of God,' etc. reaching such interpretations. But the fact that this understanding is sometimes encountered even in our most rational and sensible people makes one think that rationalism has still not been fully established in our intellectual world.

"The fact that rationalism has still not been established also prevents us from making correct diagnoses of our problems. Let us take the religious movements and Kurdish nationalism that have strengthened in recent years. We should be able to see that these developments are essentially a result of the rapid social changes that have been experienced in our country in the last 20-30 years; that they are deep-lying social and economic processes surfacing. Rapid urbanization; the transition from a traditional agricultural society to a modern industrial society has upset the social bonds and sense of identity that millions of people have lived within for centuries. In the effort to adapt to new conditions, some cling to religious feelings and solidarities, some to national feelings and solidarities.

"The 'roots' of the problems we face are not outside, but inside. If we cannot make this diagnosis correctly, we may not be able to solve our problems. We live on lands that different peoples and states have wanted to establish dominion over for centuries. Today too, we are surrounded by neighboring countries with which we have various disagreements and conflicts of interest. Many different forces making policy both globally and regionally, each to the extent of their power, are striving to direct developments in our country in ways suited to their interests, some are setting up games, organizing conspiracies. All of this is real.

"But Turkey is not Vanuatu or New Caledonia, that is, one of the United Nations' many so-called states that have just been freed from colonialism. Turkey has a state tradition stretching back centuries, a population approaching sixty million, a fairly strong economy, and perhaps more importantly than all of these, a democracy that has been standing for 45 years, for better or worse, in a patchy way. Turkey is a considerable power in international politics, a trustworthy actor. Turkey's fate is not in the hands of

foreign powers. We can trust ourselves. Choosing our future is largely in our own hands." (*Cumhuriyet*, 27.11.1991)

"Is socialism dead?"

One of my articles summarized well what I was thinking about socialism by the early 1990s:

"After the adoption of the 1961 Constitution, the idea of socialism settled in a central place in our intellectual life. During most of the 1960s and 1970s, as in many other countries, a significant portion of intellectual energy in Turkey was devoted to thinking about and discussing socialism. Could socialism happen in Turkey? By what path could it be realized? Which of the socialism experiments in the world were real socialism, which were not? Was true Marxism being practiced in the Soviet Union, or in China or Cuba? Or had it not been realized anywhere yet? Which of the hundreds of interpretations of Marxism was the 'correct' one? For these and similar questions, some gave their minds, some their freedoms, some their lives.

"By the 1980s, the idea of socialism began to rapidly lose its central place in intellectual discourse. Finally, at the end of the 1980s, with the collapse one after another of regimes based on the totalitarian interpretation of socialism in Eastern Europe and the Soviet Union, the place of the idea of socialism in intellectual discourse became increasingly marginalized both in the world and in our country. It must be admitted that questions about socialism now interest very few people. Very few intellectuals now find it worth their time to think and write about socialism. The few remaining socialist regimes in the world are now seen as an anachronism, a historical error. There is no doubt that neither infallible laws of history nor coincidence brought us to this point. Behind this point that has been reached are very rich experiences acquired by humanity both in the world and in our country. Experiences acquired at the cost of the painstaking labor, sweat, blood, and lives of millions of people.

"After these experiences, asking the following kinds of questions today seems meaningful. Is socialism dead or does it have a future? Should Marxism be completely abandoned or are there aspects of it that remain valid? Continue with socialism or is it over? It appears that if socialism means 'proletarian' dictatorship or any other kind of dictatorship, people will not favor such socialism hereafter. If socialism means the concentration of all economic, political, and cultural power in the hands of the state; the 'nationalization' of politics, economics, and culture; the enslavement of the individual and society to the state, it can be expected that it will not be possible to establish such socialisms hereafter.

"If people know how to learn lessons from experience, it can be said that the end has come for totalitarian socialism; and for Marxism to the extent that it is responsible for the totalitarian interpretation of socialism. As a scientific theory, Marxism too will be abandoned to the extent that it has been shown to be wrong. But the idea of socialism neither began with the totalitarian statist interpretation of socialism nor will it end with it. Socialism existed before Marx, and will exist after Marxism.

“The democratic, pluralistic, libertarian interpretations of socialism or social democracy have always maintained their vitality. Totalitarian socialism eventually collapsed, but democratic socialism led giant reforms that made societies freer and more equal in the countries where it came to power. Socialism is, in essence, the ideal of building a society where equality is achieved among people, where peace rather than war, brotherhood rather than enmity, solidarity rather than struggle prevails. Of course, as long as history does not end, this ideal will not disappear. The goal will continue, but the means will change. The understanding of socialism based on society and democracy rather than on the state and dictatorship will continue to develop.

“As long as we continue to develop conceptions and theories about what a good society would be like, the idea of socialism representing the search for equality will also live on. Just like liberalism representing the search for freedom and conservatism emphasizing the virtue of traditions distilled from centuries of experience. The ‘continue with socialism or is it over’ meetings held by the Socialist Unity Party last weekend made me think of these things.” (*Cumhuriyet*, 4.12.1991)

“Oh, that imperialism!”

In the article reflecting the conclusion I reached in the 1990s on the concept of “imperialism,” which tired our minds so much throughout the 1960s and 1970s, I was saying verbatim:

“MÇP (Nationalist Labor Party) leader Alpaslan Türkeş said, ‘The events experienced in our country are monstrous activities organized by imperialism. Terrorists are the servants of imperialism’ (*Türkiye newspaper*, 8.2.1992). In his new year article for *Milliyet* newspaper, Türkeş had dwelt on the need to activate the spirit of the National Forces against imperialism that wants to divide and fragment us. In reality, from the most right-wing to the most left-wing, we have become so accustomed to explaining all the negatives and evils in our country with imperialism. Have we fallen behind economically? The reason is imperialist exploitation. Is our democracy limited? Because imperialists do not want democracy in the Third World. Military coups? Imperialists organized all of them. The Kurdish problem? An imperialist game. Terrorism? Imperialist provocation. There have even been those who claim that the War of Independence was the work of British imperialism.

“Behind the understanding of explaining everything with imperialism lies the ‘theory’ that philosopher Karl Popper called the ‘social conspiracy theory.’ According to this theory, which is widely believed in our country and other countries where scientific thought is not well developed, social events are the work of some powerful centers that have an interest in them. According to some, all events are the work of imperialists, according to some capitalists or communists, and according to some Zionists or missionaries.

Hasn’t the time come to set aside these superstitions that are entirely outside of reason and science? Such understandings, which hinder us from investigating the deep-rooted and very diverse economic, social, and political causes of the negatives and evils in our society, and which lead us to look for the main culprits outside our society, prevent our problems from being resolved.

“We also need to now accept some facts about imperialism. The main ones are:

- Borrowing from developed countries, importing capital, doing trade with them does not inevitably result in being exploited, falling behind. On the contrary, countries that cannot manage to benefit from these opportunities or choose self-sufficiency fall behind. Isn’t this why all underdeveloped countries, whatever their political regimes, are now struggling to attract foreign capital, to be able to do trade with the developed ones?

- The poverty of the Third World cannot be explained by the wealth of the First World. Colonialism may be the cause of the West’s wealth. But the only reason for the poverty of underdeveloped countries is not that they were subjected to colonialism. The role of many different factors such as poor management, waste, lack of education, etc. cannot be underestimated. The fact that some underdeveloped countries in the Far East or elsewhere have succeeded in industrializing is perhaps the most important proof that the Third World is not condemned to backwardness.

- Today, a very large portion of both capital flows and trade, around 80-85 percent, takes place among developed countries themselves. The need of developed countries for raw materials is also gradually decreasing as a result of technological developments. This is perhaps the really worrying situation for underdeveloped countries.

- Our world does not consist of “independent” countries on one side and “dependent” countries on the other. We live in a world where interdependence is increasingly strengthening. Economic stagnation in the First World hinders the development of the Third World. Poverty in the Third World does not allow the First World to live in peace and security.

- Does imperialism not exist? Of course it does. But it is not ‘the highest stage of capitalism.’ Imperialism existed before capitalism, and was also seen together with socialism after capitalism. Not only great powers, but almost all countries try to develop and spread their national interests in proportion to their power using various political, economic, cultural, and military means. The US occupation of Vietnam, the USSR’s occupation of Afghanistan were imperialism, so what are Vietnam’s occupation of Cambodia, Iraq’s occupation of Kuwait? Interestingly, none of them succeeded. (*Cumhuriyet*, 15.2.1992)

The two faces of *Cumhuriyet*

Hasan Cemal resigned from the general publication directorship in the last days of February 1992. He called me and explained his reasons. It had become impossible for him to do his job in the face of the “sugar big brothers.” He was right. He said he had no idea what he would do next. (He would start writing at *Sabah* after a while.) Regarding me, he said “You will probably go back to the university now.” I think he thought there was no place in the rest of the press for the kind of journalism I did at *Cumhuriyet*. (However, our paths would cross at *Sabah* in the mid-1990s, and at *Milliyet* in the late 1990s. I must have reminded him on one occasion of the distinction between news and commentary journalism and that I did the latter, but it was clear that he did not give credence to this distinction.)

Regarding the approximately ten years I worked at *Cumhuriyet*, I can say that I have two main criticisms of myself: First, I very much regret not listening to HC's advice in my very first days to "Keep a diary, you will produce many books from these in the future." Not keeping a diary was a bad habit left over from my communist days, and moreover it was a task I found very boring at the time. My second fundamental mistake was not heeding HC's warning to "Know your power as a journalist…" The reason for this was probably the cautiousness instilled by being a former communist, and always having preferred (in Nuri Çolakoğlu's words) to be "the important person in the background / eminence grise."

I can say that my years at *Cumhuriyet* had two faces from my perspective, one positive and the other negative. On one hand, it had enabled me to readapt to Turkey, to gain a new identity in the eyes of the literate public; on the other hand, it had quite upset me with the feeling that I could not realize my potential under that roof. On the day Hasan submitted his resignation, I also submitted my resignation and left. Most people from the team that HC had put together, especially Emine Uşaklıgil and Okay Gönensin, inevitably reconciled with the "sugar big brothers," but they would later have to leave the newspaper one by one.

CHAPTER VIII / AT TÜSES AND THE CHP

On March 1, 1992, I resigned and left *Cumhuriyet*. I had no idea what I would do. But shortly after, I received an offer. The government of the DYP (True Path Party) and SHP (Social Democratic Populist Party) under Süleyman Demirel's leadership had taken office on November 30, 1991, and some time later, Korel Göymen, the president of the Turkish Social Economic Studies Foundation (TÜSES), was appointed undersecretary at the Ministry of Tourism, while the foundation's director Emre Kongar was appointed undersecretary at the Ministry of Culture. Kongar, having heard that I had left Cumhuriyet, called to say that Prof. Dr. Taner Berksoy had taken over the foundation's presidency; he asked whether I would be interested in taking over the foundation directorship since he would be starting his new position at the beginning of April. I had been a member of TÜSES's board of directors since the last general assembly. Since there was no other visible job opportunity at the time, and being idle was depressing me, I accepted the offer (with Fatma's reluctant approval, as she wasn't happy about me being unemployed) to work until a better opportunity came along, even though the salary was at the lower limit of what was acceptable. My appointment as foundation director was made at the board meeting on April 8; I would remain in this position until February 1993.

At that time, TÜSES's headquarters was located in a spacious apartment in Kabataş, Setüstü. Apart from me, there was only Muharrem in the office, a very polite young man who did cleaning and served tea and coffee. Having always worked in crowded workplaces, I found this desolate environment quite strange. But the space was comfortable, and commuting home was easy. Moreover, since I wanted to contribute to discussions about Turkey's problems, TÜSES was a good platform for this. With this reasoning, I tried to motivate myself for my new job. In the 10 months between April

1992 and February 1993, I organized one local and two international conferences on behalf of TÜSES; I completed two international conferences whose preparations had already begun. President Taner Berksoy and the board members were always supportive of my work.

TÜSES had an established cooperation with Friedrich Ebert Stiftung (FES), Germany's parliament-supported, social democratic-oriented research foundation. The first conference I attended right after starting was the meeting titled "New Regional Order: Turkey-France Perspectives," which had been prepared before I took office and was jointly organized by FES and France's socialist-oriented research institution, the Jean Jaurès Foundation, in Istanbul on June 15-16, 1992. The opening speech was given by SHP General Chairman Erdal İnönü. My only significant memory of the conference was meeting Olivier Roy, the French academician famous for his research on Islamism.

What meaningful thing could I do at TÜSES? Since my return from Sweden in the early 1980s, I had been thinking that for liberal democracy to take root in Turkey, the regime first needed to be compatible with the identity rights of Kurds on one hand, and the religious rights of the Muslim majority on the other. My first initiative was to organize a meeting on the Kurdish question. In the early days of the AP (Justice Party)-SHP coalition government, Prime Minister Süleyman Demirel had gone to Diyarbakır together with his deputy Erdal İnönü and declared from the podium "We recognize the Kurdish reality…" The SHP's "Southeast Report" aimed at this recognition had been published in May 1990. Hope had emerged for the state to make peace with the Kurds. A civil society initiative called "Peace Initiative for the Kurdish Question" had organized a meeting at the Etap Hotel in Tepebaşı on February 15, 1992; I had attended the meeting where Mehmet Ali Aslan, Murat Belge, Bülent Tanör, Asaf Savaş Akat, Mahmut Alınak, Tarık Ziya Ekinci, Feridun Yazar, and others gave speeches. The atmosphere seemed quite favorable for TÜSES to also organize a meeting aimed at resolving the Kurdish Question.

"The Kurdish Question from a Social Democratic Perspective"

The conference titled "The Kurdish Question from a Social Democratic Perspective" was held on June 19, 1992, in Ankara, at a hotel in Tandoğan. The following speeches were given at the meeting chaired by Prof. Dr. Asaf Savaş Akat: "Social Democratic Parties and the National Minorities Question / Şahin Alpay"; "A Look at Our State Policy Regarding the Kurdish Question / Hikmet Özdemir"; "The Kurdish Question and Democratization / Algan Hacaloğlu"; "Social Democrats and the Kurdish Question / Ercan Karakaş"; "The Kurdish Question and Its Solution / Aydın Güven Gürkan." The meeting was attended mainly by SHP politicians as well as some Kurdish politicians, among them the late Şerafettin Elçi, whom I greatly valued for his opposition to the use of violence (i.e., to the PKK, the Kurdistan Workers' Party) and with whom I gradually developed a friendship. The speech texts would be collected in a book titled *The Kurdish Question from a Social Democratic Perspective* (TÜSES Publications, 1992).

After the usually inactive summer months, we organized a conference titled "Principles of Democracy, Institutions, and the Turkish Experience" in Baku on October 17-18, 1992,

with the Ministry of Foreign Affairs as the intellectual originator, financial support from the Ministry of Culture, and cooperation from the Azerbaijan Parliament. I remember that among the large delegation attending the meeting were politician Necdet Uğur and academics Binnaz Toprak, Oya Araslı, İlkay Sunar, İlter Turan, and Rona Aybay. This first visit to Azerbaijan was a good opportunity to see firsthand the results of the regime change the country experienced after gaining independence from the Soviet Union. It was predicted that not much might have changed in the regime. Indeed, it would soon be seen that the regime had merely changed its guise under the power of the same person/family, with nationalist autocracy replacing communist autocracy.

"Islam and Democracy"

The international meeting that I was the intellectual originator of as TÜSES foundation director and that I considered important because I hoped it could contribute to distinguishing between relatively liberal/libertarian interpretations of Islamism and radical/authoritarian interpretations was the conference titled "Islam and Democracy" held at The Marmara hotel in Taksim on November 29-30, 1992. In organizing this conference, I worked closely with Dr. Matthes Buhbe, the Istanbul representative of FES with whom I got along quite well. The considerable expenses of the meeting, which included inviting many foreign speakers, were entirely covered by FES. Many renowned social scientists and journalists presented papers at the conference. In addition to Ishtiaq Ahmed (Sweden), Abdullahi Ahmed An-Naim (Sudan), David Barchard (England), Marie Bennigsen Broxup (England), François Burgat (France), Rudolf Chimelli (Germany), John Esposito (USA), Klaus Patzold (Germany), Reinhardt Schulze, Udo Steinbach (Germany), and Marvin Zonis (USA), the local participants were Nilüfer Göle, Fehmi Koru, and Sabri Sayarı.

I agreed with Marie Bennigsen Broxup, the daughter of the famous Central Asia expert Alexandre Bennigsen and herself on the staff of the Society for Central Asian Studies in London, to prepare an English book consisting of papers presented at the conference. She had immediately contacted South Carolina University Press and the publisher had agreed to publish the book without seeing the text in advance. Later, despite Dr. Buhbe also reaching an agreement with Christopher Hill Publishers in London for the book's publication, unfortunately the project fell through because I left TÜSES shortly after. Following up on the translation and Turkish publication of the book was left to Yurdakul Fincancıoğlu, who was appointed foundation director in my place when I left. The book could only be published exactly ten years later with Taner Berksoy's foreword (*Islam and Democracy*, TÜSES Publications, Istanbul 2002).

I had put great effort into organizing this conference; I would have very much liked to undertake the preparation for publication of both the English and Turkish versions of the book, and to write the foreword myself. Publications on Islam and Islamism were gaining new momentum in the world. This book could have opened new horizons for me in the academic world. Unfortunately, this too would become one of my unfinished projects because I didn't follow through. My habit of always looking forward to new work and being unable to look back was probably the main reason for this. This was why neither the English nor the Turkish version of my doctoral thesis, which was one of the first

studies on the political consequences of international migration to Europe after World War II, could be published. This is also why I haven't produced any book from the thousands of columns and dozens of articles published in various newspapers and magazines over the years. The truly noteworthy report of the research on "Turkey's Political Culture" that we conducted with Boğaziçi University professors İlkay Sunar and Yılmaz Esmer during the 1992-93 period when I worked at TÜSES also unfortunately couldn't become a book. Unfinished work is what I regret most about my working life.

"Do You Think This Is Sweden?"

It was time for my CHP adventure. It happened like this: The book *Yeni Sol* (New Left) that Baykal published together with İsmail Cem in early 1992 was raising hope that Kemalism could gradually become more liberal, or at least it seemed that way to me. At that time, I agreed with Haluk Özdalga: if Marxism could be reinterpreted and transformed into liberal social democracy (as it had in Sweden, for example), then a liberal interpretation of Kemalism could certainly be made. However, it would be understood with time that this was nothing but a pipe dream. (Here I would like to mention my late wife Fatma's words warning me about my wishful thinking: "Şahin, do you think this is Sweden or England?")

The reopening congress of the Republican People's Party (CHP), which had been closed by the September 12 military administration, convened on September 9, 1992, and I had gone to Ankara to observe it. Deniz Baykal's speech was exciting. The press reported his words as follows: "We will redefine the CHP… The goal is not to make poverty an ideology, but to create a welfare society… From here I address all the people: There is no longer a Kurd-Turk, Alevi-Sunni fight. From now on there is peace. The CHP is coming to realize this great claim. It is coming to reconcile labor and capital. It is coming to reconcile Eastern and Western cultures. We are coming to embrace both the youth who goes to İmam Hatip school and the youth who goes to the disco… The CHP should no longer be understood as a state party, but as a society and people's party…" It couldn't get better than this.

Deniz Baykal, the Antalya Deputy elected as CHP General Chairman, resigned from the SHP on September 11. The CHP formed a parliamentary group of 21 deputies with others who left the SHP; the party assembly appointed Ertuğrul Günay as general secretary. Baykal also made hopeful statements about the CHP becoming more liberal in a statement. In summary, he said: "Turkey can no longer be governed only by decisions made from Ankara. Therefore, we propose the creation of a new administrative structure, a system of decentralization (local governance) within a unitary structure… Political parties have become institutions controlled by professional politicians. Delegates also work like political brokers. For this reason, we will move toward a party organization without delegates… We are not against privatization; we will close state enterprises that are losing money… We will put our weight behind having Alevis represented in the Directorate of Religious Affairs…" (*Hürriyet*, September 28, 1992)

Baykal's Offer

Encouraged by the hopes that had been awakened, in late 1992 I invited Deniz Baykal to give a speech at the Pera Palas Meetings, of which I was the intellectual originator and among the organizers. Baykal's speech on December 29 seemed even more liberal in tone than I had expected. After the meeting, I congratulated Baykal and said: "Deniz Abi (Brother Deniz), if you walk this path, you will be Turkey's prime minister tomorrow… You should establish a team of young and knowledgeable advisors to support you on this path. Look, at least two prime ministers emerged from the brain trust of Sweden's legendary 1950s Prime Minister Tage Erlander. You too should build a strong political cadre that will serve Turkey for many years…" Despite my objections that I wasn't young enough for this job, Baykal went ahead and invited me to the CHP to build this cadre…

Of course, my first task was to share Baykal's offer with Fatma. My dear Fatma, who always listened patiently to my complaints, was well aware that I wasn't happy with my current job. It was certain that she wanted to see me in more important roles. I think she gave her support immediately, also thinking that this job could open the door to my entering politics and being elected as a member of parliament. But we were still cautious. The children were studying in Istanbul; there was no reason to move home to Ankara without seeing the future. As soon as I accepted Baykal's offer and agreed to go to Ankara to work at the CHP, I did something I wouldn't do again until my days at Silivri prison: I started keeping a diary. As you will see below, my memories of the approximately eight months I would spend at the CHP, coming face to face with "normal" (ordinary) politics in Turkey, would become quite detailed.

On January 11, 1993, Baykal called; as if we were discussing the subject for the first time, he asked, "Will you work for us?" I was a bit surprised because I thought we had already agreed on this, but I said "Yes, I'm coming." On January 14, Besim Üstünel called and said, "Important duties await you in Ankara. I called Baykal and said TÜSES is also important; Şahin should carry out both duties together." My going to the CHP was being received positively in my circle of acquaintances. Almost all were curious about what path the CHP under Baykal's leadership would follow. Most thought I could contribute to this path.

On the Path to the CHP

The TÜSES general assembly was held on January 16; I gave a farewell speech there summarizing my work. Erdal İnönü and the SHP's top team came to the cocktail reception after the general assembly. I didn't talk about anything but pleasantries with them. I was now with the CHP. On January 18, I went to Ankara to meet with Baykal. On the plane, I ran into CHP member Mustafa Özyürek; his warning "Baykal's habit is to approach negatively, don't let your enthusiasm be dampened…" was interesting.

On January 19, at 1:00 PM, I met with Baykal in the TBMM (Grand National Assembly) group room. He proposed that I take on the CHP Research Center directorship in addition to being advisor to the General Chairman and the parliamentary group. "We should benefit from your experience in creating a think tank for the CHP," he said. His

words excited me greatly. When I said I could also join the CHP's central executive board, he said, "Of course." When I returned to Istanbul the next day, I discussed my new job with my close friends Seyfettin Gürsel, İlkay Sunar, Oğuz Öztuzcu, Asaf Savaş Akat, Ömer Madra, Burhan Şenatalar, and of course Korel Göymen. Despite some doubts, Seyfettin and İlkay said I should take advantage of this opportunity. Asaf Savaş, referring to those who shared our understanding of social democracy, said "your taking this position is good for us too." Burhan said, "This will shake up the SHP." Seyfettin was cautious; he suggested I get confirmation from Baykal once more. At his warning, I called Baykal by phone. I told him that my family council (meaning Fatma) had approved my decision to work at the CHP, and that I would explain the matter to the TÜSES board tomorrow. There was no problem. "You will add political strength to us," he said. We agreed that the public announcement would be made when I started work. He asked me to write an "education reform" proposal within fifteen days; he gave extensive directives. When I spoke with Korel, he said "I'm sorry for TÜSES; but now we'll secure our balanced position between the SHP and CHP…"

The TÜSES board meeting was held on January 21. Taner Berksoy, Asaf Savaş Akat, Gülten Kazgan, Tavit Köletavitoğlu, Meryem Koray, and I attended. Mr. Tavit thanked me for my work with a very complimentary speech. The others also supported my new job. The general opinion was that although my departure would be negative for TÜSES, it would be positive for TÜSES-CHP relations and for social democrats in general. It was decided to find a foundation director to replace me. Yurdakul Fincancıoğlu was mentioned as a possibility.

On January 22, I had lunch with FES representative Buhbe. When I told him I would be leaving TÜSES, he was devastated, for he had established a good working relationship with me and was very pleased with it. He didn't hide that he was upset.

Uğur's Assassination

January 24, 1993, was the first anniversary of my beloved mother's death. I was in the grip of strange feelings aroused by the year that had passed without her. I went to Ayvalık to commemorate her together with my elder sister and her family. While I was there, Turkey was shaken. The death of Uğur Mumcu from a bomb placed in his car caused a great shock. It was an extraordinarily painful event… Yes, Uğur and I had had intellectual disagreements, we had remained on opposite sides during the Cumhuriyet split, but I had always loved him dearly as a sincere friend, an honest person, and a writer with a very powerful pen. He was one of the most important writers in the Turkish press. Everything aside, we had a friendship of nearly 30 years. Exactly one year earlier, on January 24, 1992, in the middle of the Cumhuriyet dispute, he hadn't neglected to send a condolence telegram upon my mother's death.

It hadn't occurred to me that Uğur's death would also affect my future. I called Hasan Cemal and Ufuk Güldemir to share my grief. Hasan wrote beautiful pieces about Uğur on two consecutive days after his death. On this occasion, I told him I was going to the CHP and that I saw this as an important duty. "You could do that job with your little finger…" he said. I had lunch with Ahmet Yorulmaz at the Ayvalık City Club. Yorulmaz,

whom I called “Ahmet abi,” was the Mumcus’ neighbor in the Kadastro Evleri quarter of Ayvalık and a very close friend of theirs. We were in the grip of the event’s deep shock.

That day Nebil İlseven called by phone; he said Haluk Ülman, with whom he had spoken, was very happy about the news that I was going to the CHP, and had called Baykal to suggest that I stay in Istanbul and continue my position at TÜSES, but Baykal’s response had been “He will come to Ankara and sit in the room next to mine.” Friends who heard I was going to the CHP generally received the news positively. But there were exceptions. According to Hurşit Güneş and Ercan Karakaş, “it won’t work with the CHP…” İshak Alaton said he had “mixed feelings” about this, that he didn’t trust Baykal, and that he would “need to whisper in my ear what to do”; he described my acceptance of working at the CHP as a “great sacrifice.” That day I ran into Osman Kavala. He too said he didn’t trust Baykal, but that I could work with Ertuğrul Günay. On the evening of January 29, after Haluk Özdalga’s speech at Pera Palas, we had dinner together with Seyfettin Gürsel joining us. According to my notes, I said to them: “This is perhaps the last chance for us liberal social democrats… We must do everything we can to enter parliament with the CHP…”

Mete Tunçay’s reaction was interesting. When he came to the TÜSES office on one occasion during my last days there, he said, “I had advised you not to wage war against Marxism, you didn’t listen… I recommend that you not come to the forefront too much in the first few months at the CHP…” He meant that I could face considerable hostility because of my liberal views. (He would be proven right.) Fatma’s maternal uncle Captain Kenan did not receive the idea of my going to the CHP positively at all; “Even you can’t make Baykal fly,” he said. (It would turn out he wasn’t wrong.) I talked to Taha Akyol. He didn’t look at it very positively either. When I brought up the subject with my friend from Mülkiye, Murat Karayalçın, who was SHP General Chairman at the time, I wasn’t surprised when he said “Wasn’t working at TÜSES better?” My friend Rıza Türmen, an ambassador at the time, was pleased that I was going to Ankara; “Looking from Ankara, the future seems to belong to Mesut Yılmaz and Baykal…” he said.

On February 2, Ayşen Gür from *Milliyet* called, “I learned you’re going to the CHP…” she said. She said she saw this as a very important development; she asked me to fax my resume because she was going to write a story. There must still have been some doubt in me, because I called Baykal and told him Milliyet was going to report on my going to the CHP. In response, he said my room at the General Headquarters was being prepared; I was relieved when he said I would be staying in Ali Dinçer’s deputy residence. The next day, Ayşen’s story appeared in *Milliyet* at the bottom of page 5 in 3 columns. After the news, my close friends İlkay Sunar, Oğuz Öztuzcu, Dinç Gürs, Asaf Savaş Akat, Haluk Özdalga, Seyfettin Gürsel, and Hasan Cemal called to wish me well in my new job. Hasan Cemal advised me to behave “low-profile” at the CHP. “I did that at Cumhuriyet and did it turn out well…” I said. I talked to Kemal Kurdaş; his positive reception made me happy, because I had great respect for him and valued his opinions greatly. My friend Cem Kozlu, who was an ANAP (Motherland Party) deputy at the time, also pleased me. He both saw a future in Baykal and, as far as I was concerned, said “where there’s movement there’s abundance.” He even said “You never know, we might start a party together…” (But he too wouldn’t stay in politics for very long.)

Yes, I was going to the CHP. I thought I didn't have a better opportunity at that time to serve a freer and more democratic Turkey. There was doubt within me: Could Baykal be trusted? There was also the distress of being separated from my family inside me. "Everyone goes to Libya, Siberia, etc. for their livelihood, I should also be able to go to Ankara on work days," I consoled myself. On February 15, 1993, I flew to Ankara. I met with Baykal at the CHP headquarters on Çevre Street. As we had agreed, I started work with great fanfare as advisor to the General Chairman and the TBMM Group, as well as Research Center Director. But as would soon be understood, my job had unfortunately ended before it began. For apparently Baykal, looking at the mass reactions to Uğur Mumcu's brutal murder on January 24 and the sudden spike in *Cumhuriyet* newspaper's sales, had decided that the CHP didn't need to renew itself and that "inherited" Kemalism still held its validity.

On my first day in Ankara, I visited CHP General Secretary Ertuğrul Günay. He received me very well, "I'm very glad you came," he said; his adding "I hope you won't regret it…" was noteworthy. "I won't regret it, at least I will learn a lot here," I replied. I spoke with Baykal by phone around 5 PM; we agreed that I would prepare the "administrative decentralization reform" report as a priority. During the approximately 8 months I stayed in Ankara, I traveled to Istanbul every weekend to see Fatma and the children; from Sunday to Thursday nights I stayed at the Mülkiye Association guesthouse in Kızılay. A spacious apartment on Cinnah Avenue was allocated to me as an office; a young high school graduate girl was also assigned as my secretary. Following the signals I received, I changed my manner of addressing Baykal. The "Deniz Abi" of years past was gone, replaced by "Mr. Chairman"; our relationship took on a very formal air. During the eight months I stayed in Ankara, Baykal came to see me a total of three times; I also visited him in his office at headquarters maybe four or five times. Each time we were together for at most 15-20 minutes. At each meeting, almost only he talked. These visits would lead me to think that the esteemed chairman, since he knew everything best himself, didn't need advisors, and increasingly to question what I was good for at the CHP.

Notes from My CHP Diary

February 17, 1993 / In the morning at headquarters, I visited Hasan Fehmi Güneş, one of the deputy general chairmen (former interior minister), and explained what I wanted to do at the CHP. His saying "We need to renew ourselves, we're like paper money that has lost its value…" was encouraging. In the afternoon I met with Baykal. I stated my needs. He said the facilities provided to me were very exceptional, that I should make do with the office and secretary, and that an additional computer wasn't needed. He implied that I should focus on micro projects that would attract public attention rather than macro projects. He didn't allocate much time; his tone (discourse) seemed to be changing. I got the impression that he wouldn't expect initiative from me, and therefore this job of mine couldn't be very long-lasting. As early as the third evening, I wrote in my notebook: "I hope I won't regret coming here as Ertuğrul Günay said!"

That evening at Haluk and Elisabeth Özdalga's house, I met Fuat Atalay and his wife Nevbahar. We agreed on these points: Baykal was one of the country's most qualified politicians, but his image in society was weak, he needed teamwork. Ideological-

intellectual unity needed to be achieved in the CHP. I had also added this note to the diary: “The fundamental political division in Turkey was between center and periphery in the 1950s, between right and left between 1960-80; in the 1990s it will be between change and status quo. Today the main item on the political agenda is the transition to a market economy and establishing liberal democracy. Baykal is a politician of change, but the CHP is a party where the status quo dominates.” Apparently we hadn’t yet given up hope on Baykal.

February 23 / In the morning Taha Akyol called by phone. Baykal, with whom he had spoken, had said very complimentary things about me. He played these to me on tape… “I’m extraordinarily pleased, they appreciate your value,” he said. He said he would write an article about this soon… In the evening I had dinner with Rıza Türmen. He was of the opinion that the CHP had no weight in politics, but Baykal had weight.

February 24 / “Ankara gives me claustrophobia. I hope I’ll overcome this feeling…”

February 26 / Taha Akyol wrote in his column in Milliyet under the title “Producing policy.” “The research center newly created at the CHP and headed by Şahin Alpay will work to base politics on research-examination, information storage and systematization beyond intuition and plain logic. Baykal says ‘Şahin Alpay was the ideal name for this job’ which is true. Alpay has academic training; he conducted political and social research abroad for a long time. Alpay also made important contributions to social democracy in Turkey being purified of Marxism, Third World leftism and Jacobinism. He served as general secretary of the TÜSES Foundation for a while. Alpay’s very close relations with university circles are a great opportunity for the CHP to benefit from scholars… Baykal’s choice of Alpay as the head of the research center and his advisor, we think, gives an idea about the answer to the question ‘Which left?’ Alpay is the liberal left.” Thanks Taha.

In the afternoon I went to visit Yenimahalle Mayor Abdurrahman Oğultürk in Baykal’s official car. “We expect you to bring a lot to the party,” he said. He said they would cover my monthly salary together with Keçiören municipality. I learned how my salary problem would be solved. Apparently the party municipalities were bearing the party’s expenses.

March 2 / I was invited to a seminar at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs by my classmate from Mülkiye, Ambassador Ali Arsın. Sedat Ergin, who was the Ankara representative of *Hürriyet* newspaper, also invited me to dinner on the evening of March 11 with US Ambassador Morton Abromowitz. Being in Ankara provides the opportunity to get to know political actors.

March 3 / I was pleased by a call from my classmate from Robert College and one of Turkey’s most important bankers, Hüsnü Özyeğin. Bless him, he congratulated me on my new job in a very warm manner and said he would support me in every way he could, that he didn’t want the left to be crushed, and that he was worried about the Welfare Party’s growth… I talked to Haluk and Seyfettin. Both are troubled, both by the state of politics and by the CHP. I said to Haluk again: “The CHP is our last attempt in politics.” (It would be for me and Seyfettin. But Haluk would be elected as an AKP (Justice and Development Party) deputy twice in the 2007 and 2011 elections.) When I went to bed that night I asked myself: Am I really interested in politics?.. I feel like this

CHP business will last until summer at most. There should be a place for me in the media…

“Entering Politics”

March 5 / I attended the “Information/Idea Exchange” meeting that the Ministry of Foreign Affairs organized, opening itself to outsiders for the first time. Many acquaintances, mostly from Istanbul, including Osman Kavala, were there. The most noteworthy aspect of the meeting was Özdem Sanberk, Rıza Türmen, and İnal Batu from the ministry saying that Kurds should be granted the freedom to freely express their language and culture. Ambassador Cem Duna said he received my new job, which he described as “entering politics,” very positively. He and Murat Karayalçın had been talking about me the night before…

I also ran into my high school friend Ambassador Ahmet Banguoğlu. “Maybe you’ll become our minister…” he said. Was he serious, or was I being made fun of… Late afternoon Deputy General Chairman İsmail Cem called. He said he was very happy that I had started working at the CHP…

In the evening on the phone I complained to Fatma about my troubles. We bickered a bit… My endless complaints are understandably annoying her. Ankara is suffocating me. I won’t be able to do it…

March 6 / In the afternoon at headquarters we worked with İsmail Cem until 6:30 PM on congress decision drafts. I had never done such “bad” work in my life. We dealt with editing nonsensical texts. The CHP’s condition is terrible; there’s no one who can bring two ideas together! Cem also complained about Baykal’s overly cautious style. He openly expressed concern that “If we can’t present our new identity, we’ll disappear.” He warned “If you don’t push hard, nothing can be done…” He invited me to program commission meetings that he chairs… I shook hands with dozens of people at headquarters. Among them, my friend from the revolutionary period, Gaziantep Mayor Celal Doğan, embraced me very warmly. İstemihan Talay (my fellow executive board member from the SBF [Faculty of Political Science] Student Association), who had transferred from the DSP (Democratic Left Party) to the CHP, also showed friendliness.

March 7 / I attended the meeting of the commission that would prepare the new party program for the first time. Besides Cem, other acquaintances were Algan Hacaloğlu and Haluk Özdalga. The commission reflected how politically cosmopolitan a party the CHP was. The meeting was spent on debates about “supremacy of labor or supremacy of productive labor” and what secularism means. I still got the impression that a radical party program could be written if the leadership supported it… In the afternoon I went to the CHP Youth Branch congress in Keçiören. I got the impression of attending an amateur performance and was quite bored. However, it was pleasant to meet and talk with people in the lobby who questioned the CHP’s Kemalism and found the secularist-Muslim conflict wrong. I thought if the leadership shows the way, a liberal social democratic party could be built… Both Seyfettin and Haluk advise me not to move to Ankara before next March. This reflects their hesitations about the party’s future.

March 8 / Today the CHP Women's Branch congress convened at Ankara Hilton. Baykal gave a long speech. It was a speech and meeting with a high dose of Kemalism. Baykal saw me as I was leaving the meeting and made an affectionate remark like "Şahin, were you here too?"… Haluk is working hard to get into the Party Assembly (PM). Let's see if Baykal will put me in the PM?

March 9 / The CHP's 26th Ordinary Congress convened. At the congress I sat with Hasan Cemal. I described the scene in the party to him as follows: On one side are Kemalists, on the other liberal left elements, in the middle Baykal and his close circle trying to maintain balance. Hasan said "In other words, the situation at our *Cumhuriyet*…" I hadn't thought of it. Yes, my position also resembles the one at *Cumhuriyet*. Again I'm the top man's advisor and on the liberal left, and I'll probably experience the troubles I had at the newspaper in the party as well… After the congress I met up with Seyfettin and Haluk. Seyfi had already concluded about the CHP, as about the DSP, that "there's no democracy, one man rules, it won't work out…" "The DSP was better; at least there the one man supported us… here that doesn't exist either…" he said. Maybe he's tired of politics, wants to get out. Haluk, on the other hand, is trying to get into the PM; he probably wants to be elected to parliament in the next election.

Repositioning and the CHP

March 10 / This morning I got out of bed with the decision to write about the CHP and took notes. I didn't go to the congress. I didn't leave the office either and started writing a piece called "Repositioning in the Turkish political system and the CHP." (When I joined *Cumhuriyet*, I had also given Hasan Cemal a piece on "Turkish media and *Cumhuriyet*"…) In the afternoon Seyfettin came; he complained that there was "more Baykalism than Baykal himself" in the party.

March 11 / I wasn't elected to PM membership. Haluk and my new friend Fuat Atalay were elected. In the afternoon they came to the office; we discussed the Kemalism-New Left tension within the party and so on. Apparently Sencer Ayata is in favor of criticizing Kemalism; because some Kurds were saying if things continue like this there's no place for us in this party… It would be good if I recorded my views on the Kurdish issue most clearly. Haluk argues that just as there are no insurmountable walls between Marxism and social democracy, the new left understanding can be built on Kemalism.

March 15 / Baykal made the suggestion "Let our advisor also join the PM"… In the evening I stopped by to see my friend from English High School and Stockholm, Ambassador Müfit Özdeş. He is an extreme—that is, hardcore nationalist—DSP supporter; he claimed Baykal was "pro-American." It was a bit rude but I couldn't help saying "That's a bit thuggish."

March 16 / Haluk and Fuat came to the office. Haluk suggested some additions to my piece titled "Repositioning in the Turkish political system and the CHP." I found Fuat pessimistic. Baykal said "I don't want opposition in the party"! A terrible mentality! Fuat was disappointed at not being elected to the MKYK (Central Executive Committee). They suggested I give the report to Erol Çevikçe and speak openly. I'll do just that. I had

dinner with Timur Ertekin. He said “Şahin’s coming to the CHP is more important than Baykal being elected chairman…”

March 29 / Erol Çevikçe came to the office. I pressed him on the importance of the program issue, that there was no other way to clear up the confusion. He agreed while being a bit on the defensive. As far as I understand, he sees Haluk, Fuat, and me as a kind of “power base” for himself and wants to stand by us. He opened up quite a bit: he said there was confusion in the party, that it wasn’t clear what should be said, that Baykal wasn’t tackling this in the name of being a unifier and was immersed in daily routine, that he had brought me from Istanbul and left me stranded, that he himself now needed to shake off the inertia and get to work, and that the Research Center was attached to him. His suggesting we also invite Bilsay Kuruç to the economics seminar we’re planning for May was surprising. When I said we were looking for “a minimum consensus among speakers” he backed down…

Ertuğrul Günay invited me to lunch. I expressed my concerns about the CHP standing still. He agreed. He said the pressures the party was subjected to after Uğur Mumcu’s assassination had “set the party back.” “There are those among us who are politically hesitant, but you as an outsider should bring up issues related to the program,” he said. I said the leadership couldn’t act according to public opinion trends. He agreed. Günay is someone who generally thinks positively but doesn’t act decisively. Perhaps he too is drowning in daily affairs. During the meal Seyfettin also joined us, then I walked to the office with him. We decided to continue the struggle within the CHP, but also to raise our voices before the public… Taha Akyol called. I told him about my pessimism regarding the CHP. When I said I was giving up going “low profile,” he said Baykal wouldn’t like this. I met Haluk for dinner. He too is of the opinion that we need to ignite the intellectual debate.

March 31 / In the morning I spoke with Prof. Dr. Melih Celasun on the phone. He said he was pleased that I was attempting to establish a research center for the CHP, but that it was also necessary “to be effective.” He was right… In the afternoon I met with Çevikçe, Haluk, and Fuat; we discussed the report to be presented to the PM. Çevikçe had conveyed my complaints to Baykal about not being able to contact him; and he had said something like “I don’t have time, let him work with you.” After Çevikçe left, Haluk, Fuat, and I talked among ourselves. We dwelled on the fact that there was a leadership vacuum in the party and that it was believed one could come to power without saying anything new… Unfortunately, Baykal is not behaving “correctly.” He has withdrawn all his promises regarding the “Research Center.” My PM membership wasn’t mentioned… My observations about the party are as follows: Leadership is weak. It’s assumed that one can come to power without saying anything new. Upper management is incompetent and confused. A crowd of “worn out” politicians who don’t know what to say. They’re taking refuge in the CHP’s old discourse. This includes İsmail Cem; even though he blames Baykal for nothing new being said. What Hasan Fehmi Güneş said very openly about the party is true: “we’ve become as outdated as money out of circulation…” Günay is also right: perhaps only people who come from outside like me can bring up fundamental issues… I’ve started thinking that if things don’t work out, I can stay here until June at most.

April 1 / Ömer (Madra) called. He suggested Baykal give a statement protesting the decision to close private radios. Using this as an opportunity, I called Baykal. After briefly reporting on the work I was doing, I asked if he had found the opportunity to read my March 15 report (titled “Global Trends and Turkey” on the subject of globalization). Contrary to my expectation, he said he had read it and found it good. “I’m very pleased to learn your opinion,” I said. My question “I’m thinking of making a speech on this at the Party Assembly, what do you think?” was answered with “that would be good.” When I asked “I’m thinking of publishing it, do I have your approval?” he said “Yes.” His response to “I’m distressed because I can’t see you” was also “Me too…” My morale naturally suddenly spiked. I went to Istanbul for the weekend with the decision to “keep trying.”

April 4 / It’s understood from Canan Barlas’s article in *Milliyet* that in his speech at the Mülkiye Association Foundation on the night of April 1, Baykal had taken up the themes from my report.

Complaining About “Lack of Leadership”

April 5 / In the afternoon Denizli deputy Adnan Keskin came to the office. He complained about “lack of leadership” in the party. He doesn’t see things going well. As he was leaving he said “I’ve dampened your spirits too…” Today they were dampened again; tomorrow? I spent the night mostly sleepless with distress.

April 6 / Keskin invited Fuat and me to lunch. He complained about “the absence of someone to manage things” in the party. He said that contrary to what was known publicly, Baykal was very gentle in nature, and couldn’t take charge of things because of his gentlemanly manner. His morale is low. According to the polling firm PİAR, the CHP’s vote is 3.2%.

In the afternoon I discussed the report to be presented to the PM with Gökhan Çapoğlu, Seyfettin Gürsel, and Yahya S. Tezel. We’re a team agreed on liberal social democracy. In the evening I spoke with Merih Celasun on the phone. He was very sincere. For the cause of liberalizing the New Left, he said “Your job is difficult… We’re also trying to contribute in classes.” I ran into Erol Çevikçe at the restaurant where I had dinner. He said tomorrow at the MKYK the Program Commission (PC) members would be determined, and Fuat and I would be included.

April 7 / I spent the day writing the report for the PM. Çevikçe said Haluk, Fuat, and I were admitted to the PC, and the commission would meet on April 19. Let’s see what we’ll do with commission chair İ. Cem who proposes inflated texts?

April 8 / I went to the reception of Milliyet Ankara representative Derya Sazak. CHP notables were there. I just exchanged greetings with Baykal. I ran into Altan Öymen. He was hearing for the first time that I had started working at the CHP. “Why don’t you unite those parties…” he joked. I was quite bored at the cocktail: the feeling of not belonging here engulfed me. I kept asking myself what am I doing here.

April 10-11 / I was in Istanbul with Fatma and the children. For the first time I told Fatma that the possibility of us moving to Ankara was weak; the best thing was to commute this year and see what happens. On the way back to Ankara I ran into my old friend Halil Berktay on the bus. According to him, Baykal is hesitant to express his views…

April 12 / Erol Çevikçe said the introduction of the report to the PM "wasn't good," and asked for it to be rewritten. Apparently Baykal wanted it so. Atalay was annoyed; "This party won't amount to anything," he said. At dinner I was with Faruk Şen. He and Ercan Karakaş had talked about me. Ercan said about me "He'll get bored and run away…" He's a smart man after all…

April 13 / Çevikçe came and spoke openly: Baykal said "These views are correct, but we have a very conservative support base, we can't say these things…" I couldn't help saying "If you don't have the courage to tell the truth, you might stay at 3.5%"… In the afternoon İ. Cem called, he invited me to tomorrow's PC meeting. Apparently the program draft he wrote (which to me was flowery fluff) would be discussed. At one point I thought of not going, then I decided to go and criticize. It's clear that, as I said to a friend, "advisory work where you meet for 1 hour in 2 months" won't produce anything… Should I hang on until June or not?…

April 14 / Çevikçe called around 9:40 in the morning. He said they had reviewed and shortened the report to the PM, and sent it on a diskette. Apparently he and Baykal had worked all night… Baykal also came to the Program Commission meeting. He invited Fuat and me to the empty seats next to him. He gave a substantive speech lasting about an hour and a half. "This commission is the most important body and will do the most important work," he said. He advised discussing the topics thoroughly. I'm now sure he's playing us "reformists" against the other "status quo defenders." We dominated the agenda at the meeting; İstemihan Talay and Algan Hacaloğlu also backed us up. İsmail Cem yielded. He kissed me on both cheeks in front of Baykal. (Did he want to show how close we were?) In the afternoon session of the meeting, Haluk, becoming a "6 Arrows" defender, almost took a stance against me and Fuat. I was surprised.

What to Do with the "6 Arrows"?

After the meeting we went to Çevikçe's room. When he asked "Did you like the general chairman's room?" and Atalay said "We liked it but it could be a bit fuller," Çevikçe said "You mean ideas?" showing he understood the sarcasm. Then together with PM member Adil Özkol we went to my office. We discussed what to do with the "6 arrows." I argued for renewing the principles as freedom, equality, solidarity, democracy, reformism, secularism. I said let's consistently defend these principles and leave the ideological burden on the CHP's back to the SHP. I mentioned Baykal's two faces: knowledgeable and mature, but lacking courage and a poor manager. He makes good analyses but can't manage to "run the show" as Çevikçe puts it. I said I couldn't coexist with the İlhan Selçuks at the CHP either, that I had nothing to lose but my chains, and that I would fight… When I complained to Adil that I couldn't find the opportunity to write in the press after leaving *Cumhuriyet*, he explained this as my being "over qualified." He said he would talk to Zafer Mutlu; maybe I could do a weekly interview at *Sabah*. He said

at the first PM meeting Baykal had proposed that I attend PM and MKYK meetings. But when I said no one had invited me, he said “there’s probably people who don’t want it or it’s an oversight.”

April 15 / I decided to defend the “new six arrows” at the PC: Democracy, Equality, Freedom, Solidarity (or Patriotism), Reformism, Secularism… I called Baykal: “I’m in favor of preserving the 6 principles as historical principles,” he began, but he yielded to my arguments. I said the following: How could the CHP carry the claim of renewing society without renewing itself? The propaganda value of six new principles couldn’t be underestimated. We needed to show we were different from the SHP. “Revolutionism, Nationalism, Statism” were principles incompatible with social democracy… “Okay, bring your proposal, let it be discussed,” he said. I said I had heard he had proposed that I attend MKYK and PM meetings, but no invitation had come to me. “Of course you’ll come, we’ll go together,” he said. At noon, together with his driver, bodyguards, and secretaries, we held a party for the “April-born Baykal supporters,” myself included. It seems the Baykal supporters are a kind of “clan/tribe”…

April 16 / In Istanbul I visited İshak Alaton. He asked if I was getting my money regularly, then he spilled the beans: together with Bülent Eczacıbaşı, Üstün Ergüder, Can Paker, Osman Kavala, Fikret Tokgöz, and others, they were thinking of establishing a new think tank. He had proposed me for the directorship, but the objection was “he has another important position right now.” I asked them to wait for me until June. When I left his office I was flying; an alternative job to the CHP had appeared on the horizon, and in Istanbul no less! Fatma was also very pleased; we agreed not to mention this to anyone. Our decision not to move to Ankara was finalized.

April 17 / It was announced that President Turgut Özal had died. I was sad because market reforms and the Kurdish issue were left without an advocate. I had always valued Özal. I also thought this was an opportunity for Baykal to take the lead on reforms.

April 19 / I attended the PM meeting; it was the scene of debates between conservative Kemalists and reformists. Baykal took a conciliatory stance. He sent word that I shouldn’t speak because I wasn’t a PM member. (This was the first sign that he was beginning to see me as a risk.) İsmail Cem pulled me, Haluk, and Fuat aside and suggested we agree on the flowery program draft he had written. Fuat is uncompromisingly opposed like me, while Haluk has a compromising attitude.

April 20 / My 6 new principles proposal stirred up the PC. There were those who ardently supported it and those who vehemently opposed it. Atilla Sav distinguished himself as the spokesman for the conservatives. He explained that there was nothing in the Six Arrows that was incompatible with today’s needs. An agreement was reached not to leak the debate to the press. İsmail Cem took an ambivalent stance as usual. First he tried to get his own flowery text accepted, then he proposed working together with me to reconcile the two texts.

April 22 / In the afternoon Erol Çevikçe came. “There are three elements in the party. You, the conservatives, and the Baykal supporters. You and we will win, but Baykal is afraid of the conservatives (Ali Topuz etc.) leaving the party and creating a negative

atmosphere. Keep doing what you're doing, but know that there's such a sensitivity," he said. Haluk, Fuat, and I decided to write a new program; if it's accepted fine, if not so be it. Apparently there's quite a bit of grumbling in the party group. Algan Hacaloğlu, who recently said to me "Maybe a new party is needed," is now saying "You're talking like TÜSİAD."

April 25 / Fatma and Acar came to Ankara for two days; we stayed at Mola Hotel. As Fatma was boarding the bus to return to Istanbul she said: "This time I didn't find Ankara charming. If I had a home I would probably get used to it, but this isn't the Ankara I left crying. You're an intellectual not a politician. I don't think you'll succeed in this environment. While we're still healthy let's spend this summer together in Ayvalık. We'll fish, we'll have a good time together…" These words were very touching to me.

April 26 / Nesrin Baytok (Baykal's secretary) had spoken with the Keçiören mayor. The mayor said they were "waiting for a tender to be concluded" for my salary to be paid… Falling into such situations nauseates me… Today I told Nur Çekirge, Haluk, and Fuat that "I can't see myself as permanent in this job"… Apparently unrest is spreading in the party. İstemihan Talay, Veli Aksoy complained to Fuat. I told Fuat, "Baykal can't provide leadership, it's time we recognized this." Still, unless I'm fired, I'll continue working until the end of June.

What a State We've Come To

April 27 / Baykal cancelled the advisory board meeting I had arranged for today. I felt I was being slighted, that my value wasn't recognized. The end of this business came into sight… Let's finish the economic policies conference I arranged for May 11 with our heads held high, let's see what happens after… If the strategic research foundation general secretaryship Alaton mentioned were guaranteed, maybe I'd quit right away…. Erol Çevikçe said he was working to sort out my salary issue. What a state we've come to… Note: According to Sencer Ayata, the CHP needs to determine its mayoral candidates as soon as possible, otherwise "fluidity" between the CHP-DSP-SHP cannot be prevented (!) He's looking for the reason for fluidity in the wrong place. The CHP couldn't show its difference from the others; it gives no hope for the future.

April 28 / Fuat said the morale of Çevikçe and Keskin, whom he had talked to, was very low. Apparently our report to the PM had been butchered… I talked to Merih Celasun on the phone. "We're getting older, we need to speak with courage now. At the seminar I'll say that wage increases are excessive…" he said.

April 29 / We finally completed the text titled "A proposal for the CHP '93 program" and faxed it to İ. Cem. It seems to me this text will be the beginning of my end at the CHP. Before noon I stopped by the Milliyet office to see Derya Sazak. He said he "didn't see any sparkle in Baykal," and that maybe the rest of us could do something. In the evening I went to dinner at the Ayatas'. They complained about Baykal. Apparently their relations had been severed for 3-4 months. They said Baykal couldn't play team games, would avoid bringing young people in, and so on. Late at night Sencer said, in summary,"There isn't much new to say. There are other parties saying the same new things. If we also lose those who say the Second Republicans killed Uğur Mumcu, we'll have nothing left,

because they're the ones who bring votes in the provinces." I said the CHP base wasn't limited to "Dikili festival-goers"; there was also an innovative base that was pro-secularism and pro-freedom and wanted social justice. We ended the discussion pleasantly with a proposal to brainstorm on these issues.

May 5 / In Istanbul, through the contact Hüsnü (Özyeğin) provided, we met with Satel's American Entertainment Manager, and he really liked our television program proposal called "Money, Power and Love" that we had prepared together with Refik (Erzan) and Ömer (Madra); he said he would strongly support it. We'll present the program proposal and budget to him by May 17. Satel was to start test broadcasts on June 15 and regular broadcasts on September 15. (Satel was founded in December 1992 by Sabah newspaper owner Dinç Bilgin, and took its name from combining the words Sabah and Television. It would start broadcasting as ATV in 1993.) I talked to Alaton. Ergüder was insistent on Sabri Sayarı for the directorship of TESEV (the Turkish Economic and Social Studies Foundation). He had lost hope for me. "What will you do if the CHP thing doesn't work out?" he asked. He suggested the World Bank-funded Zonguldak Development Foundation General Secretaryship!.. What have I come to…

May 10 / After a long absence I'm in Ankara. I talked to Baykal on the phone. He kept it short; he said he was expecting me tomorrow at 9:30, "for half an hour" (!) While I was away Fuat had stirred up the PM. Baykal couldn't take it and snapped "Are you going to break up the party!" Baykal's job is difficult; by constantly managing he might end up with nothing. Seyfettin said: in the Istanbul CHP provincial program commission of 18 people, 16 advocated switching to a presidential system (unbelievable!)… Taha Akyol mentioned in his article the seminar titled "Where Is the World Economy Going?" that we prepared as the CHP Research Center, bless him. I told him my position here was the same as at *Cumhuriyet*, and that Baykal reminded me of Hasan Cemal before the vase broke. He asked if I would consider becoming an ANAP deputy in the future. I said intellectualism and politics don't mix, and besides Mesut Yılmaz was too conservative for me. He asked what I would do if I left the CHP. I mumbled something like I'd find a job…

My salary seems safe until July. But will I be able to hold out until then? My future depends on the Satel job. I'm thinking: God has made me lucky in everything; despite all the troubles I've been through I've managed to stay standing. I owe gratitude for this. However, I haven't been successful in my working life; I admit this at age 49. I don't have much energy left anymore either…

The "Where Is the Turkish Economy Going?" conference I organized is meeting tomorrow at the Hilton. We'll see the result of Nur Çekirge's announcement efforts; if no one comes it'll be bad…

May 11 / Taha Akyol, unstinting in his support, wrote the following in *Milliyet* about our conference: "Today in Ankara there is a seminar organized by the CHP Research Center at the Hilton Hotel. The topic: Where Is the Turkish Economy Going? All the speakers except one are names known as advocates of the market economy in Turkey:
Prof. Merih Celasun, Assoc. Prof. Gökhan Çapoğlu, Prof. Yahya Sezai Tezel,
Dr. Seyfettin Gürsel, economist writer Osman Ulagay, businessman İshak Alaton. The only speaker at the CHP seminar who opposes the market economy is Şemsi Denizer,

the famous face of the Zonguldak strike and General Secretary of the Türk-İş trade union confederation…"

Thank God, the seminar was very successful! It started with about 100 people in the morning but the audience quickly rose to 350. Baykal gave the opening speech. The speeches were very high quality and very liberal! Alaton even advocated opening forests to foreign capital!!! Amazingly, no one objected to this except Ankara provincial chairman Nail Gürman (and even he half-heartedly). In Fuat's words, with this meeting "A major blow was dealt to the conservatives." Maybe it went a bit too far, but it was good… I left the meeting very happy. Baykal and the speakers also left satisfied. Baykal even said things to Fuat meaning "Except for a few backward-minded people, the party base is with us." (Osman Ulagay would write the following about the seminar in his article titled "The footsteps of hope" in *Sabah*: "On a day when politics had become so prominent, a political party finding it worthwhile to discuss the economy, CHP General Chairman Deniz Baykal spending his entire day at this meeting could be considered a ray of hope in my view. However, as we also expressed to the CHP executives, this interest shouldn't be limited to the period when parties are in opposition.")

In the evening I talked to Fatma. She had had dental surgery and was in pain. "What am I doing here, I should be by her side. How many more days can we be together anyway…" such thoughts welled up again.

May 12 / I talked to Alaton; Üstün Ergüder asked "Is Şahin happy with his job." But apparently the new director candidate for TESEV is Orhan Güvenen (head of the DİE, the State Institute of Statistics). In short, I'd better just get on with my own work…

"If You Insist the Party Will Fall Apart"

İsmail Cem's second program draft arrived. In a word, "hopeless case." Haluk and I were almost dumbfounded… We decided to tell the commission members to read both our draft and Cem's and decide. Haluk is worried about a debate that could lead to the party falling apart. He may not be wrong…

May 13 / At the PC meeting Cem's draft clashed with the Atalay-Özdalga-Alpay draft. Cem brought it to "if you don't like it that's all from me." Hayrettin Uysal and Algan Hacaloğlu hurled the threat at us "if you insist on your draft the party will fall apart." İstemihan Talay, on the other hand, was positive. "Let's not say something we'll be ashamed of," he said. When I asked what that was, he said "Statism for example." (Later when we talked privately he said prejudices about Baykal were the problem, and that the party might remain without growing.) At the end of the meeting it was decided that Cem's draft would be reviewed by Hacaloğlu. Hacaloğlu said the draft was "literary," but unfortunately Cem was insistent on this text…

I was furious: I've been here for three months, Baykal hasn't even deigned to have a meal with me! I need to leave here as soon as possible… I have no intention of getting into internal party debates and conflicts either. There's no chance here for those with my views. Ertuğrul Günay is no use either. In the early days he was implying he would give support by saying "We can't say everything, you say it." Now he said about the three

arrows on the seminar invitation (which we had no intention behind) “I hope there’s no ideological aspect to this”… Çevikçe told Fuat Atalay “Don’t go after Cem but criticize fiercely and bring a new text by the congress.” That’s what we’ll do.

May 19 / No word from Baykal. I wonder how he received Ahmet Taner Kışlalı’s article published in *Cumhuriyet* on May 16, which contained harsh criticism directed at me? Is he signaling that I should leave now by not calling me? Maybe… I talked to Hasan Cemal. He said İsmail Cem was playing for Baykal’s position. He thinks I need to be patient for a few more months… Adnan Keskin also told Atalay that after the March elections both Günay and Cem would rise up against Baykal. If even Talay can openly tell me that Baykal is a handicap…

May 21-25 / I was in Istanbul. At Taha Akyol’s suggestion I called Yalçın Doğan, *Milliyet*’s editor-in-chief. “Actually when I heard you had gone to Ankara, I thought this wouldn’t work out… In July we’ll move to the new building. New personnel, new publications will come up. Call me after the holiday,” he said… I stopped by Alaton’s. We reviewed the list of TESEV founders. Only 10 out of 23 people might support me for the general secretaryship… No response yet from the project we submitted to Satel.

May 25 / Baykal called Fuat today, but he didn’t call me… In the evening I had dinner with Rıza Türmen. “I had sensed that this job of yours couldn’t be permanent,” he said… Yet he had received it very positively at the beginning… A heavy defeat is expected for the center-left in the elections… What I want most right now is to somehow make it to Milliyet…

May 26 / The day began with a surprise visit from Ankara provincial chairman Nail Gürman. He started by asking whether the texts from the economics seminar would be printed. He said if the CHP Research Center name would be on it, the CHP’s economic views should be expressed. He said Yahya Tezel’s speech had generated backlash. I said there were also many who spoke in favor, and that I looked at whether the speakers were experts on the subject…

In the afternoon a tall, very attractive woman came from the US Embassy; she asked me to explain the CHP Research Center. She said she couldn’t understand the reasons for the CHP group being against Operation Provide Comfort. I said I shared the same view… Then Fuat came. He had met with Baykal, who had spoken about us as if he supported us. “He might be disappointed if he heard what we think about him,” he said.

May 27 / It was an important day. Baykal came to the Cinnah office at 5:30 PM and stayed for about four hours. Fuat was also there. I told Baykal openly: “The idea that I’m not useful to the CHP, that I’m even harmful, is spreading. The program draft with six new principles generated backlash in the Commission. Cem is trying to impose his own extremely inadequate program draft by saying ‘Şahin Alpay isn’t even a commission member anyway.’ Hayrettin Uysal, Algan Hacaloğlu are hurling threats like ‘Don’t insist too much, you’ll split the party, you’ll scatter the group.’ Do you also think I’m harming the party? This is the first time we’re meeting one-on-one since I came to Ankara. You haven’t commented on almost any of the reports I’ve written. On January 18 we agreed that I would come to the CHP. On January 24 Uğur Mumcu was killed. On April 17 Özal

died, Demirel became President. You concluded that the leadership of the opposition would fall to us without us doing anything. I've come to think there's no need for me here…"

Fuat Atalay took the floor. He said a radical program was needed, that Baykal was acting without courage on this matter, that he didn't want to take risks, that he couldn't manage the party well, that we had come to a breaking point. Baykal responded as follows: "A radical program would isolate us. We're playing for the leadership of the left bloc. I share your ideas, but we must proceed step by step. I find your work very useful. Şahin's coming brought many points to the party. It never crossed my mind that you were harmful; otherwise I would have made it clear."

"I Don't Believe in a Radical Move"

I also said: "We should play not for the leadership of the left bloc but of society. Society can only be mobilized around new ideas. A vanguard and cadre to represent new ideas is needed. One man doesn't provide credibility. A balance policy brings the danger of alienating both conservatives and reformists." Baykal responded: "I don't believe in a radical move. I share your ideas, but we can get them accepted over time. Be compromising enough not to put me in a difficult position and support me. Don't worry, the CHP is receiving great interest from society…"

We agreed that I would report to him once a week; that I would organize meetings with experts and intellectuals; that I would write the local governance report as soon as possible, etc. Meanwhile he asked me to bring Cem Boyner to the party "acting as if the proposal was coming from me"… After Baykal left, Fuat said he wasn't satisfied, that Baykal thought he could gain support with cosmetic measures like bringing Rüştü Saracoğlu and Cem Boyner to the party, that he even saw me as a cosmetic element, but that given the support he had shown, it wouldn't be good for me to just leave, and that I needed to stay in the party for at least 6 more months… In the evening I told Fatma on the phone: I'll continue working at the CHP until I get a better job offer, but I don't believe I'll be permanent.

May 28 / I met Hurşit Güneş for lunch. He said: "Until 4-5 months ago Baykal looked like he would succeed, but he didn't… Despite having a better cadre he won't be able to pull it off, because he causes an allergic reaction…"

While I was away Erol Çevikçe had come to the office; he told Fuat, "Baykal was very affected by what you said." But he repeated the impression that things weren't going well; apparently he doesn't want to be seen around…

I talked to Ömer: Although the American editors really liked our program proposal, no result came from the meeting with Satel. They said we'll call you after the holiday… When they hear the fee we're asking they won't accept… I told Ömer, "Anyway Fatma also wants me to commit myself to the CHP now, or at least see this attempt through to the end."

June 14 / After the holiday break and a herniated disc crisis during the holiday, I could only return to Ankara today. At 3 PM we went to Baykal's room at headquarters. Baykal wanted Sencer Ayata to attend the meeting alongside Haluk, Yahya, and Fuat. Çevikçe was also there. Sencer explained his thesis that the CHP would need to win over former leftists, even revolutionaries in small towns in the coming three months; I explained my thesis that the CHP should work on the liberal social democratic views I proposed. I said the general chairman and the MKYK needed to decide on one of these two theses, otherwise I and those who think like me would break from the CHP. Yahya, Fuat, Haluk all opposed Sencer. Baykal said he didn't see a contradiction between the two theses…

June 15 / Yalçın Doğan called. Saying we'd talk about "the other matter" (my moving to *Milliyet*) later, he asked for information on how privatizations were done in Spain. I found texts on this subject at the American Library and sent them.

June 17 / Ömer and Refik this time talked to Satel's American news editor. He liked our proposal but asked us to turn it into a weekly news program. Our side requested 3,500 dollars per person per month for this. They said they would respond within two weeks.

June 18 / Today I met with Murat Karayalçın. He said he wouldn't run for SHP chairman without getting 60 percent support, and if he did he would announce a social democratic platform. I said of course that a liberal social democratic platform was needed. He had heard from Hasan Cemal that I was having trouble at the CHP. I said I wanted to return to the press. He said he would tell Yalçın Doğan that he supported me.

June 20 / At Yahya's house, Haluk, Fuat, and I prepared the critique of the government program. Baykal's lack of courage, disorganization, irritability came up. None of them finds my idea of leaving unjustified anymore.

"How Do We Raise the Organization's Morale?"

June 21 / In the morning I talked to Baykal. He was pleased with our preparation on the government program. Meanwhile he had also talked to Fuat; he said "Talk to Şahin too, what can we do to raise the organization's morale"… Well, let's hope for the best…

June 24 / Fuat is very upset. Baykal and his colleagues are apparently preparing to oppose Tansu Çiller's privatizations. We stopped by Ertuğrul Günay's. I had read in Derya Sazak's article that morning that he too said they would wage an ideological war against privatization. I told Günay that the CHP couldn't get anywhere with a schizophrenic identity. In response he said things meaning "The CHP isn't a new party, we must take Kemalist sensitivities into account…" Meanwhile he criticized my not having CHP spokespersons speak at the economics seminar I organized. I said it would be very wrong if they opposed privatization in principle.

June 25 / I talked to Hasan Cemal on the phone. I said again that I was looking for work; I mentioned the Satel and *Milliyet* possibilities. I asked if he had any contact with Aydın Doğan. He said he could talk to Altan Öymen. They had offered him the Show TV general manager position at double the salary, but he had turned it down. "Otherwise I would have called you to my side right away…" he said. But he wasn't going to manage

anymore, he was comfortable… “Remind me that you’re looking for work…” he said. Typical HC!

June 26 / Today first the Ayatas then Çevikçe came to the office. There were long debates again. Sencer and Ayşe said Baykal lost by leaning toward liberalism. I said he lost because he didn’t know what he wanted to do. I feel the time has come to leave the CHP… I’ll probably leave as of July 15 even if I can’t find a job. I feel like the happiest person in the world because I’m still Fatma’s beloved. I’ll find a job somehow.

June 27 / I talked on the phone with Refik. When I said “I can’t stand it anymore, I might leave Ankara even if I can’t find a job…” Refik’s response was, “If you panic you’ll end up in a job beneath you; you’ll also upset Ömer and me because of the CHP people and the project we’re waiting for a response on… At least keep quiet until the end of August, get your money, take your vacation…”

June 28 / We delivered the notes to Baykal for his speech in the confidence vote on the government. We also suggested he condemn the US bombing of Baghdad. After dinner I went to Müfit’s (Özdeş). A likeable person despite all his nationalism. İlber (Ortaylı) also came. Tansu Çiller had offered him a history advisor position. For some reason İlber doesn’t like anything or anyone, but he likes and appreciates me…

June 29 / Baykal said he would use the note about the bombing of Baghdad in his group speech.

July 2 / I attended the Program Commission meeting. Now Hacaloğlu is guiding the work instead of Cem… In the late afternoon Fatma and Acar came to Ankara. We stayed at Mola Hotel. At night the news came that the Sivas Madımak Hotel had been burned, 35 people killed… We were deeply shaken!

July 3 / Fuat and I went to the TBMM for the confidence vote debates. Baykal’s speech was generally good. He took a populist stance by defending agricultural subsidies, but it was positive that he said he wasn’t against privatizations and that he advocated local governance as a solution to the Southeast problem. His polemic against Çiller was a bit fierce but well done.

July 5 / Baykal called. He thanked us for the notes we prepared. He said he couldn’t use them much but they helped him find his footing. I also congratulated him on the speech he gave… In the afternoon I stopped by Ahmet Evin’s (my classmate from Robert College who at the time was heading the Ankara office of the American tobacco company Philip Morris). Susan Kemper (headhunter) who had found him his current job was in Istanbul; she wanted to meet with me… I called İlkay Sunar and said I was interested in teaching a course on “Scandinavian Politics” at Boğaziçi… Erdal Yavuz also said I could teach a course on “History of Social Democracy” at METU. Let’s see where my next stop will be?

“This Woman Won’t Be Able to Handle This”

July 6 / The atmosphere in Turkey is changing. The judgment “She turned out hollow… This woman won’t be able to handle this…” is spreading about Tansu Çiller. Yesterday,

receiving the generals, she announced that she was delegating the matter to the army by saying “We will stand by the TSK (Turkish Armed Forces) in its struggle against the PKK.” At the Sivas funerals Erdal İnönü was booed along with the ministers accompanying him. The SHP is cracking; its withdrawal from the coalition is on the agenda. The news that SHP Chairman Aydın Güven Gürkan requested a meeting with Baykal led to interpretations that he would run for chairman in September with a “uniting the parties” initiative… I told Haluk I would leave the CHP at the first opportunity.

July 7 / I didn’t go to the PM meeting. Çevikçe also called the meeting “a waste of time”… My dear Fatma apparently wants me to stay in Ankara… At least until I find a new job. But I’ve completely lost interest now… In the evening I went to the cinema. I don’t want to sit in the Mülkiye Association garden; it’s full of people I don’t want to see.

July 11 / After his meeting with Çiller we talked with Baykal. Çiller’s feeling him out without coming with a concrete proposal had infuriated Baykal. “Either she doesn’t know what she’s going to do or she does whatever the Americans say,” he said. We presented him our five-page ‘Solution to the Kurdish problem’ report. We advocated TRT broadcasting in Kurdish, Kurdish classes being given in state schools. When I said the duty of defending the country’s unity had fallen to him after Özal’s death, Baykal’s response was, “The state shouldn’t have a responsibility like developing Kurdish identity.” He said he opposed Operation Provide Comfort because of “national feelings” (integrity), but he wasn’t opposed to a Kurdish state in Northern Iraq. We revised the report according to his wishes.

July 12 / Taha Akyol talked to Yalçın Doğan about me; “He’s leaving the CHP, *Sabah* or *Hürriyet* might grab him, let’s take him,” he said. Yalçın also said “I knew he couldn’t make it at the CHP… We’ll take care of that in August”… In the evening I went to visit İlber; we chatted.

July 13 / Tomorrow I’m going to Ayvalık for fifteen days. I hope these are finally my last days in Ankara. It would be good to end this well… Judging from the news in the papers, it’s clear that Baykal was inspired by our text in his Van speech. I wonder how the bigots in the party are receiving it? The SHP and CHP support Çiller’s proposal for Kurdish classes and broadcasts, but Demirel came out strongly saying “it will lead to division.” Çiller will probably back down.

July 14 / Çevikçe returned from Van. The text we prepared was reworked through the night and given to the press. Today the newspapers wrote that Baykal said “end to the assimilation policy.” Bravo, he spoke quite courageously…

I constantly think about the meaninglessness of living separately from Fatma. If I left without waiting to find a new job, if I spent the summer with Fatma in Ayvalık… I also think about the failures in my life. I’ve reached this age and couldn’t amount to anything… This is perhaps the result of my taking on every task only half-heartedly. Most likely so…

“What Will Be Written on My Tombstone”

August 1 / My elder brother’s daughter Ümit and her fiancé Cem Boyner came to Ayvalık. Cem mentioned his intention to establish a new party that would bring together a sensible left, Kurds, and the religious. He said he was working on this with Zülfü Dicleli, Asaf Savaş, and Hüseyin Ergün. I said our struggles to fix the left hadn’t worked, that this had led us too to the idea of a new party, though we thought this wouldn’t be easy at all, and I congratulated him for showing this courage. He said in fifteen days he would be able to tell me more satisfying things. “What will be written on my tombstone, that’s what matters to me…” he said. He said the success he had achieved in business didn’t satisfy him. He implied that he wanted me to be part of the party they would establish.

August 2 / I’m in Istanbul. Among the important developments of the last twenty days is Satel firing the British editors. Zafer Mutlu and Ercan Arıklı have been brought in their place. In my opinion this is the end of our flirtation with television… Ömer, however, maintains hope because of Arıklı’s admiration for him… Starting tomorrow I’ll launch a job search offensive. I’ve completely broken from the CHP “morally,” especially after hearing about Boyner’s new party idea. Cem and I chatted: While explaining the reasons for his entering politics, he said the trajectory on the Kurdish issue was toward a military regime, in which case the only opposition would be religious opposition, and something needed to be done against this. But he couldn’t help saying that sometimes he thought about spending his life “growing cucumbers”… Last night Aylin Livaneli’s wedding was full of pleasant coincidences: I chatted with Arne Ruth (Dagens Nyheter editor) for a significant portion of the evening. Ataman Onar said Fatma was “as beautiful as Catherine Deneuve.” (In my opinion she’s even more beautiful…) Baykal told Fatma that “they were sharing me among themselves.” Alaton told Fatma that I was more important than both Baykal and Karayalçın… Tuba’s drunken dance with Çetin Altan was a masterpiece.

August 3 / After about 20 days I’m in Ankara again. I talked to Taha Akyol on the phone. Yalçın Doğan really wanted to hire me at *Milliyet*, but this could only come up after the newspaper moved on August 15. When I called Yalçın and couldn’t reach him I left a note. He didn’t call back. Ömer and I agreed that he would talk directly to Ercan Arıklı about the television program.

August 4 / I spent last night in a nightmare of anxiety about the future. I woke up at 4 in the morning and was lost in thought for a long time… When morning came I consoled myself like this: “You’d better stay at the CHP until the retirement issue is resolved.. What’s important anyway is health, the rest will work out…” It wasn’t ineffective.

Three phone conversations I had today suddenly changed the picture: I called Zülfü (Livaneli); I mentioned the television program Ömer, Refik, and I had prepared. He said after the British editors left, he too was in management alongside Zafer Mutlu and Ercan Arıklı, I should send him the project, he would look into it. When he said he would also be making a program, I said I could be editor for his program. “Look, that’s a good idea!” he responded. He said he would think about these matters and call me…

I called Necla Zarakol. “It must be telepathy, I was going to call you too,” she said. She was also part of the group Boyner mentioned. I said Cem had told me about his preparations too, that I was hesitant about forming a party, and that a manifesto similar to *YÖN* could be good. She said she was about to leave her current job. We talked about how we could do good work together… Later I talked to Nur Çekirge. She said she was going to Istanbul for the company whose founding she was participating in, and would call soon to give detailed information. These contacts lifted my spirits; I became hopeful that new job opportunities would emerge. I called Fatma in this good mood… I hope one of the emerging options materializes…

August 5 / Yalçın Doğan called and said my *Milliyet* job unfortunately couldn’t happen… I was quite upset. I’m approaching 50 and facing the anxiety of unemployment. This saddens me greatly… In the afternoon at the CHP Research Center Conferences we organized, Fuat’s friend Osman Coşkunoğlu from the University of Illinois spoke. Then we went together to Baykal’s room. Baykal talked at length. Although he wasn’t opposed to privatization, he said opposing it would put wind in the CHP’s sails… This isn’t a policy I approve of. Not being able to speak openly bothers me. I can carry on this job until September 15 at most.

“I Hear You’re Leaving the CHP…”

August 6 / On the way to Istanbul on Varan I ran into Rıza Türmen; we sat next to each other. “I hear you’re leaving the CHP…” he said; Erol Çevikçe had told Murat Katoğlu… I felt as if boiling water had been poured over my head. Apparently my complaints reached their ears and they wrote me off… Yet yesterday Baykal had shared some information about those who would join the CHP…

In Istanbul, Fatma, Ömer, Oğuz (Öztuzcu), and I assessed the situation. I decided to inform Baykal that I was leaving when I returned to Ankara. I felt relieved… The worst thing is indecision. Besides, nothing can be achieved without taking risks. I told Fatma, “The time to give up the luxury of working for the country and nation and at a job I love, and to get a paying job, has come and is passing.” I announced my decision to Fuat Atalay; he wasn’t surprised at all. Maybe he’s calculating to take my place. I told Haluk my decision too.

August 7 / Elem, the young woman who was my secretary at the Cinnah office, left a letter when she quit. She wrote: “Mr. Şahin, something came up and I had to go to my hometown Gümüşhacıköy tomorrow Sunday. I came here on Saturday to say goodbye to you. But I couldn’t find you. Thank you for everything. When necessary you were my boss, when necessary you were a father to me. You made me love working life. If it weren’t for you I probably would have left this job much earlier. I thank you again for everything. Love and greetings to Mrs. Fatma, Mr. Fuat and his wife.” I was moved…

August 9 / I called Ms. Nesrin (Baytok) and requested an appointment with Baykal. We were able to meet at headquarters between 7:45 and 8:15 PM. I told Baykal: “With my family in Istanbul I’m living a very difficult life. Half of the money I earn goes to travel and hotels…” In response, he said “Move the house; your place is Ankara..” When I said “I can’t decide…” he said “Oh no, I think you have some ideas that aren’t good…” I said:

“The party didn’t receive me well; I came across as too liberal in views. The Research Center couldn’t be properly established. Contacting you wasn’t easy. I personally want to support you but I no longer want to work for the party, because I don’t feel I’m being useful. I can’t establish dialogue with anyone in the party other than you…”

He responded as follows: “You will become a politician. You’re right in your unease; I too encountered the same attitudes when I was an advisor. Despite all the difficulties, liberalizing the left is easier than the right. We will get you into politics. There are developments toward SHP-CHP integration. Now is not the time to leave. Tell me what you need, I’ll try to meet it. I was also at fault. Let’s move your office to headquarters. Go, take a vacation for a while…” In short he didn’t let me go… He spoke so beautifully that there’s no need to rush to leave. He showed such respect and goodwill that I can’t dismiss it out of hand. If a good job opportunity comes up in the meantime, great… For now I continue working. It probably would have been better if he had said goodbye, but he didn’t… I went to dinner at the Özdalgas’. As we discussed there, the CHP needs “revolutionary” (paradigm- changing) politics, but Baykal is a “normal” (even overly normal) politician; too cautious and calculating.

August 10 / Today I told Fuat: We lost the ideological struggle in the Program Commission. Let’s continue by organizing conferences and seminars. Let’s shift our projects from future-oriented to opposition-function oriented. If we did this, I said, we could “coexist” with Baykal. I said I would take the proposal to Baykal that he have equal status with me and receive a professional salary.

August 13-16 / I was in Ayvalık for the long weekend. On the morning of the 14th Cem Boyner called; he praised to the skies my article titled “The need for reform and the left,” a copy of which I had also sent him. “Can I share it with my colleagues?” he asked. He said it had been proposed that they take over the DP (Democrat Party). I wished him well.

August 17 / I talked with Hasan Cemal; I conveyed the negative response from Yalçın Doğan. “Apparently there’s no place for me in the Turkish press,” I said…. Then I talked to Ömer; he too is about to give up hope on the Satel job.

August 18 / Today, a friend of mine who works in the construction industry told me that Çiller was siphoning money into her own pocket from a DYP contractor, and that Demirel, who had noticed the situation, was very angry about it.

August 20 / The appointment with Baykal from two days ago finally happened today. Again he did most of the talking. From now on, the party will cover my travel and hotel expenses. The office will continue. We’ll discuss the cadre issue “later” again. I conveyed my discomfort at appearing to work at two separate full-time jobs. “The Group advisorship is not a problem; don’t mind such things,” he said. We finally delivered the local governance reform project… I need to find a proper job as soon as possible…

August 24 / This morning I returned from Ayvalık where I spent the weekend. According to the poll *Hürriyet* had conducted, SHP 11%, CHP 10%, DP 7%… There seems to be a shift from SHP to CHP. Hasan Cemal called; apparently Güneri Cıvaoğlu was going to

offer me editorship on a television program he would do; he had asked what I was getting from the CHP… I said I wasn't thinking of being Cıvaoğlu's assistant; I didn't like him at all. "You're right, you can't work with that man, but still don't be harsh if an offer comes," he said. I also said if he made an offer I would politely decline. Shortly after, I was told Cıvaoğlu was calling and Zülfü came on the line and conveyed the offer from Cıvaoğlu who was apparently sitting next to him. I said we were insistent on the program proposal we made to ATV, and that I couldn't work with Cıvaoğlu… I explained the situation to Fatma. Her reaction was "Zülfü is trying to prepare an opportunity for you, and you're refusing…" When I said "Leaving my post as Baykal's advisor to become Cıvaoğlu's assistant would be a big loss of prestige" she had to agree… When I talked to Zülfü the situation became clear: He had been forced to make this call. While arguing that news needed to be presented accurately and reliably, when he said "For example Şahin used to do this at *Cumhuriyet*" Cıvaoğlu jumped on it and said he wanted exactly me as editor… I told Zülfü about my recent agreement with Baykal, but said I could still be research editor for a program he would do, and that I could explain the situation to Baykal. "I'll think about it and call you," he said.

"The De-personalization of the Turkish Left"

August 25 / Mümtaz Soysal wrote the following lines in his column in *Milliyet* today, implying me without naming me: "…What has happened is that left parties coming from the Kemalist tradition have, as if all this were a bad dream that should be forgotten, at times come under the influence of a circle called the Second Republicans. This influence, which has seeped into the management of foundations close to the parties, into ministry and general chairmanship advisorships, even into the preparation rooms of leadership races, played an important role in the de-personalization of the Turkish left, in its becoming colorless and integrating with the established order."

September 1 / I was in Ayvalık between August 28-31. This was the closing of the 1993 season… Today the CHP Kırkpınar district chairman visited me along with his entourage. In summary: He said the CHP executives couldn't give the party a spirit, and the party could find this spirit in Kemalism. This was supposedly the spirit of national liberation, resistance to Sèvres, revolt against imperialism… The biggest reason for the CHP's growing in Kırkpınar was MHP (Nationalist Movement Party) youth joining the party; because they had decided that the real nationalist leader was Baykal… Nothing surprising!!!

September 2 / I visited Nur Çekirge at the office of the Alo Bilgi company where she had started working. I met Sedat Örsel, one of the former TRT deputy general managers, who was her boss. The company they founded called Aktif TV was producing contract programs for ATV. He half-heartedly suggested I also make a program… Then I stopped by Ahmet Evin's (Philip Morris office). "Headhunter" Susan Kemper was coming to Ankara in 15 days. We would have dinner together.

September 3 / Today we suggested to Baykal that he announce before or immediately after the SHP congress, at the merger congress of the two parties, that he wouldn't run for chairman… I talked to Nebil İlseven: Apparently he's eager to leave Satel. Meanwhile

I talked to Nilüfer Kuyaş; she said she could only stand Satel for two weeks… Cem Boyner called and invited me to the meeting they would hold at The Marmara on September 9 where they would announce a manifesto. He said the Democrat Party founded in November 1992 had made a merger proposal, and they would respond within a week. “You carry great weight, I’m worried it would be squandered in a merger,” I said. “I talked to ANAP and DYP people, you can’t do business with them,” he said. I agreed. His colleagues in the New Democracy Movement had really liked my article; they asked “Did he give this article to that moron?” I said Baykal wasn’t a moron, but unfortunately he was doing “normal politics.”

September 4 / On the occasion of the Sivas Congress anniversary I went to the rally the CHP held in Sivas and to the Party Assembly meeting. If Fuat Atalay and Nur hadn’t come the 6-hour round trip would have been unbearable. Sivas is just another Central Anatolian city; maybe the number of round-bearded men is a bit higher. Baykal was met by a convoy of 500 vehicles also coming from Antep and Istanbul. Çiller was leaving as we were entering the city. Like Çiller’s rally, Baykal’s also gathered at most 2-3 thousand people. When I returned to Ankara at night I had severe diarrhea.

September 7 / Fatma said don’t listen to Seyfettin and Fuat who were against me attending Cem Boyner’s meeting on the grounds that it would cause gossip. I still called Seyfettin. When he advised me to consult, I called Baykal: He said I should attend the meeting and suggest to Boyner that they join the CHP as a team. The conflict between the respect I feel for Baykal’s virtues and my reaction to the CHP’s conservatism is wearing me down… Today Fatma said, “This can’t go on like this, come to Istanbul already.”

“The Need for Reform and the Left”

I was in Istanbul between September 7-13. / On September 9 I attended the meeting at The Marmara of Boyner and his colleagues (Asaf Savaş Akat, Mehmet Altan, Hüseyin Ergün, Cengiz Çandar, etc.). In Cem’s words, they announced a text significantly inspired by my article titled “The need for reform and the left.” Proposals were made to establish an association, foundation, party. İlhan Kesici advocated joining a party. I said the “message” was strong, what mattered was conveying this message most effectively, having it spread through an announcement like the *YÖN* manifesto, everyone working for the ideas in this text where they were, for example there was a large segment in the CHP too that embraced these ideas. I explained that I was afraid this message would be marginalized and wasted if it became a party. Maybe I didn’t express myself well enough… I couldn’t attend the dinner because I went to the CHP’s 70th anniversary cocktail at Pera Palas. It was a terrible crowd: provincial and old… I was angered when I heard that Ahmet Taner Kışlalı, who had attacked me, was a panelist together with İsmail Cem and Elisabeth Özdalga. Nebil İlseven and I left; we talked about starting a political consulting company. Of course in vain…

September 10 / In the morning I went to the “Chinese House” where Boyner lived in Ortaköy. I said if they established a party, the energy created by the message would go to waste, that even the DYP’s offer of Istanbul Mayor to him seemed more reasonable to

me. I mentioned the dangers of setting out with intellectuals. He talked about the difficulty of continuing the battle of ideas with existing parties. When I conveyed Baykal's proposal that he join the CHP, he said "I'm touched and honored but I haven't decided what to do yet, when I do I'll also meet with Baykal." I said the idea of change still found greater support in left parties. (Really?..) He suggested I join his political movement. I said this wasn't possible because I worked professionally at the CHP, but I could participate in their intellectual work. We talked about the tension between public and private lives. He said he might not stay in politics for very long. (Interestingly: Indeed, that would be the case.)

September 11 / In the morning I met with Necla Zarakol and we agreed on establishing a political consulting company. If necessary we'll take a wealthy friend of hers as a partner. The timing looks like it will be around November-December. In the evening it was announced that Murat Karayalçın had won the SHP general chairmanship.

September 12 / Ufuk Güldemir called, and I went to his house in Ulus. He said he had received a general manager offer from Show TV and wanted to know what I thought about it. I enthusiastically supported it. When I said we could work together, he said "that would be amazing."

September 13 / In Ankara at Yahya's (Tezel) house we watched the debate on television between Karayalçın and Baykal about uniting the parties. Baykal appeared quite uncompromising. However, the next morning we read in *Milliyet* that he had proposed merging the parties rather than cooperating in opposition. It seems that, having failed to develop an independent political line or to show any difference from the SHP, he has reached the "throwing in the towel" stage.

September 14 / I conveyed to Baykal what Boyner had said.

"He Made a Mess of It"

September 15 / In his opening speech at the Party Assembly meeting Baykal brushed off the merger issue by saying "under the CHP roof and on an opposition platform." Then the discussion moved to the program written by Cem and Hacaloğlu, full of repetitions and vague expressions, which lagged behind even the SHP's. Besim Üstünel gave a speech in favor of making all kinds of concessions for the merger. It seems Baykal has no choice but to merge with the SHP since he couldn't create a different party. He couldn't give a clear message either: He tells others "let's unite in opposition"; but told *Milliyet* "it could be in government too." In Sedat Ergin's words, "he made a mess of it." It was announced that Ahmet Yücekök and Uğur Alacakaptan would join the party as advisors to the general chairman. I could hand over the job to Yücekök and leave, and indeed I should; but it's hard without finding a job.

September 16 / In Istanbul I ran into Üstünel at the Japanese Consulate General's cocktail. He said Alacakaptan was mediating between Baykal and Karayalçın… I talked to Alaton. He said it had been decided that the Strategic Research Foundation would be established under the Boğaziçi University Foundation, that Üstün Ergüder also supported me for the directorship, and that he was waiting for me to return to Istanbul.

September 17 / I visited Ergüder: He said I was always among those mentioned on the list, that he believed I would do this job well, and that we could start as soon as money was collected.

September 19 / I spoke at the joint panel of TÜSES-TDV-SİSAV on “Press and Democracy Culture.” When Taha Akyol didn’t come I was left alone with Altemur Kılıç and Oktay Ekşi… In the evening Yavuz Baydar stopped by; from him I learned that Ufuk Güldemir’s appointment as Show TV editor-in-chief had been finalized. I called, he wasn’t home; I talked to his wife Cumhur. She was very happy.

September 20 / As soon as I returned to Ankara and entered the office Alaton called. I conveyed my conversation with Ergüder. He said he would do his best but there might be obstacles he couldn’t overcome… I called Ufuk and congratulated him. If you think of me, I’m in, I said. “I’m not thinking of anyone else… Let’s bring it up after I start work,” he said. “That would be good, because there are other job possibilities too…” I said. Fuat, Haluk, and I assessed the situation at the CHP. I said: Baykal is under pressure on one hand for merger at any cost, on the other for no merger, that’s why he appears inconsistent.

September 21 / Today Fuat and I prepared a proposal for Baykal that in summary contained a call “The SHP is finished, social democrats to the CHP”… In the afternoon İlter Turan called and suggested I teach a course on “Turkey’s social structure” at the Istanbul University SBF starting October 4. I asked for a day or two to think, but I probably won’t be able to accept. There’s too little time to prepare.

September 23 - October 3 / I stayed nine days in Istanbul with Fatma and the children.

October 1 / Together with Fuat and Seyfettin, I wrote a report for Baykal containing concrete proposals for merger with the SHP. BBC Turkish asked me for commentary on the merger; I didn’t want to speak because I don’t have a political identity… Celal (Üster) said Alp Orçun was preparing an economics newspaper with Aydın Doğan’s support, and he would do the arts pages. Since he didn’t mention me, Alp must not have me in mind… Hadi Uluengin came to breakfast; he said “You’re one of Turkey’s 4-5 intellectuals in the Western sense, decide what you want to do already”… As if there were fifty jobs if I just waved my hand… 9 days in Istanbul did me a lot of good. It would be great if a job came up in Istanbul now and I could finish this Ankara business.

October 4 / Today Karayalçın came to visit Baykal, but it seems he’s not very enthusiastic about the merger. Yet the merger is an opportunity for him.

October 5 / I’ve had it up to here with Ankara now. If I had a little courage, or rather financial strength, I would run away from here tomorrow. But I have to hold on at least until I get my pension from the SGK (Social Security Institution). I called General Manager Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu by phone; he said he would help, bless him.

October 7 / I talked to Baykal on the phone. He had told Karayalçın “Either we’ll establish a new party together or one of us will join the other…” and requested unconditional talks; Karayalçın said he would think it over. The point Baykal has reached is interesting; this is called throwing in the towel… I said I didn’t have much work, I was

writing a report on Black Sea Economic Cooperation. “Also look into that water issue…” he said and gave a lecture on the topic. He already knows the subject but I was glad I got a “job.” These two reports, plus preparing a proposal on the election law will keep me busy for a while… Fuat and I went to see Erol Çevikçe: He mentioned the possibility of Ecevit proposing an alliance to Karayalçın; he told Fuat he could propose the chairmanship of the merged party to Aydın Güven Gürkan. Fuat will convey it.

“Intellectual Perspective” on the Horizon

October 10 / I’m in Istanbul to follow up on my retirement paperwork. Zülfü called; “A page called ‘Intellectual Perspective’ is being prepared at Sabah newspaper, would you take on the editorship?” he asked. “Of course!…” I said. I’m over the moon… Is the opportunity I’ve been waiting for emerging?!.. In the evening I went to Zülfü’s; we exchanged views on details. Initially it was thought that Can Ataklı and Murat Birsel would edit the page, which was to be called “Intellectual.” But Zülfü persuaded Mutlu by saying “Şahin Alpay does this job best, and he’s looking for an opportunity to return to the press. It would also be more appropriate if the page’s name were a bit less pretentious, Intellectual Perspective…” That night when I got home I excitedly put into writing the page proposal I would present to Zafer Mutlu.

October 11 / I met with Mutlu at *Sabah*; we discussed the proposal I had prepared for the page; he liked it. He offered to pay me the same salary as managing editor Okay Gönensin; I immediately accepted. This was the highest salary I had received up to that point. He also accepted my wish to hire a qualified assistant for the daily page. Was my luck turning?.. I was very happy. Most importantly, Fatma was also pleased with the news.

October 12 / I went to Ankara and met with Baykal. I explained that I was leaving and returning to the press, that I would do a daily opinion page at *Sabah*. He received it with more understanding than I had ever expected. He probably thought my job would be over if the merger happened. He had me do something I hadn’t done in eight months, asking me to work all night on the proposal document to be given to the SHP. I worked with pleasure. Thus another page in my life, the CHP page, was closing.

As for what I did during the 8 months I worked at the CHP, the main reports, some of which I prepared together with Haluk Özdalga and/or Fuat Atalay and gave to the general chairman, all written with a liberal left understanding, were as follows:

- Global Trends and Turkey

- What Does the CHP Want in Education

- What Is Contemporary Social Democracy?

- The Need for Reform and the Left in Turkey (The text that Boyner, not Baykal, spoke of with praise.)

- Turkish Democracy Toward the 21st Century

- Democracy Culture and the Press in Turkey

- Democracies and Political Research Foundations

- Clean Society Project (Alpay - Atalay)

- Local Governance Reform (Alpay - Atalay)

- On the Kurdish Question (Alpay - Atalay)

- CHP - SHP Merger Scenario (Alpay - Atalay)

- The CHP's Fundamental Goals (Alpay - Özdalga - Atalay)

- Report to the Party Assembly (Alpay - Özdalga - Atalay)

- A Proposal for the CHP Program (Alpay - Özdalga - Atalay)

What happened at the CHP after I left Ankara? The CHP and SHP merged in 1995 under the CHP's roof and under Baykal's leadership. The CHP barely passed the 10% national threshold in the 1995 general elections; in the 1999 elections it couldn't pass the threshold and remained outside parliament. In the 2002 general elections when Ecevit's DSP was routed with 1% of the vote, the CHP rose to the position of main opposition party with 19% of the vote; in the 2007 elections it also raised its vote share to 21%. Baykal resigned from the CHP general chairmanship in May 2010 following a conspiracy against him (the release of a tape about a secret meeting with his secretary Nesrin Baytok). At the extraordinary congress held after Baykal's resignation, Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu would be elected general chairman. Despite all Kılıçdaroğlu's efforts to distance the party from its statist-centralist-laicist (favoring authoritarian secularism) discourse and give it a freedom-oriented discourse, the CHP's vote remained around 25-26%. I won't claim that if Baykal had adopted the views I proposed in 1993, the CHP could have become a more influential actor in Turkish politics… But the party's inability to intellectually renew itself must have played a role in this stagnation.

Was It "Not About the CHP's 'Genes'"?

Looking back after so many years have passed, what can I say about my CHP experience? When I couldn't find the opportunity to continue my academic career after returning from Sweden and started working at *Cumhuriyet* newspaper, the understanding that gave meaning to my life was that I could contribute to the country's intellectual life and liberation with my liberal left views. However, the reaction of *Cumhuriyet*'s older generation of writers who had an authoritarian left understanding resulted in my having to leave the newspaper. The motivation that led me to work first at TÜSES for about a year after *Cumhuriyet*, and then at the CHP for about eight months, was also the search to inoculate circles that defined themselves as social democratic-democratic left with the modernity of the liberal left views I had acquired in Sweden. However, this search of mine also resulted in a failure similar to what I had experienced at *Cumhuriyet* newspaper.

In the article I wrote years later titled “It’s Not About the CHP’s ‘Genes’,” I tried to explain the reasons for this failure as follows:

“I met Deniz Baykal at Ankara University SBF in the mid-1960s. I was a student, he was an assistant with a doctorate, then became an associate professor. For me and my friends, although Baykal wasn’t left enough, he was a respected faculty member we found warm and friendly, in short our ‘Deniz Abi.’ About ten years later, I visited Deniz Baykal, who had just left the Ministry of Finance at the time, to ask for his help. I had returned home from Sweden with the political amnesty issued in 1974, and did my military service as a short-term reserve officer in 1975. But because I wasn’t given a passport, I couldn’t return to Stockholm University where I was continuing my doctoral studies. In the end, through his influence I was able to get a passport, return to Stockholm and complete my doctorate. In this regard, I owe him a debt of gratitude I will never forget.

My re-encounter with Baykal was in the late 1980s when he was SHP General Secretary. At that time, while I was working at *Cumhuriyet*, I was also writing for the magazine called *Sosyal Demokrat*, which I published together with friends like Ercan Karakaş, Asaf Savaş Akat, and Seyfettin Gürsel. After leaving *Cumhuriyet* I had also taken on the directorship of the TÜSES Foundation (which I joined at the late Erdal İnönü’s invitation). The question in my mind in those years was this: Could there be a truly social democratic current, a party in Turkey, of the kind I knew in Sweden? When Deniz Baykal and İsmail Cem published the book titled *New Left* in 1992, I saw this as a ray of hope in that direction.

On September 9, 1992, with some curiosity and some excitement, I went to Ankara to watch the CHP’s reopening congress. At that congress Baykal gave a speech that still seems ‘magnificent’ to me today. He was saying: ‘We will redefine the CHP… The goal is not to make poverty an ideology, but to create a welfare society… From here I address all the people: There is no longer a Kurd-Turk, Alevi-Sunni fight. From now on there is peace. The CHP is coming to realize this great claim. It is coming to reconcile labor and capital. It is coming to reconcile Eastern and Western cultures. We are coming to embrace both the young person who attends İmam Hatip (religious vocational) school and the young person who goes to the disco… The CHP should no longer be understood as a state party, but as a society and people’s party…’

A few days later I called Baykal and invited him to give a speech at the Pera Palas meetings (of which I was among the organizers at the time). The Pera speech seemed even more magnificent… I was saying to myself ‘Here is Turkey’s liberal social democratic leader being born…’ I told him: ‘Deniz Abi, if you walk on this path that Turkey so desperately needs, tomorrow you will be Turkey’s prime minister… You should establish a team of young and knowledgeable advisors to support you on this path. Look, at least two prime ministers emerged from the brain trust of Sweden’s legendary 1950s Prime Minister Tage Erlander. You too should build a strong political cadre that will serve Turkey…’

Despite my objections that I wasn’t young enough for this job, Baykal invited me to the CHP to build this cadre. On February 15, 1993, I started work as advisor to the CHP

General Chairman and the Group, and as Research Center director. But my job had ended before it began, for after my late friend Uğur Mumcu's despicable murder on January 24, 1993, Baykal, looking at the mass reactions to this murder, had decided that the CHP didn't need to renew itself.

I stayed in Ankara for about eight months. During this time Baykal and I met three or four times, for 15-20 minutes at a time. He didn't even want to be seen with me. Together with my like-minded friends Haluk Özdalga and Fuat Atalay, I joined the Program Commission. Faced with the reactions our proposals to redefine the six arrows generated, I saw that staying at the CHP was meaningless. I asked Baykal for permission and returned to Istanbul, to the press. After that we never met again.

If Baykal had believed in the power of ideas whose time had come, if he had stuck to his discourse at the 1992 congress, the CHP could long since have been in power, and Turkey could be a completely different place. In my opinion it's not about the CHP's 'genes.'" (*Zaman*, April 26, 2008)

I am writing these lines in 2022. Looking at the fact that the struggle that broke out at *Cumhuriyet* newspaper in the 1980s between the left Kemalist (i.e., statist, nationalist, laicist) mentality and the social democratic/liberal left understanding continues within the CHP even today, it is also possible to conclude that the problem does stem from the genes.

CHAPTER IX / "INTELLECTUAL PERSPECTIVE"

On October 13, 1993, I made my permanent return from Ankara to Istanbul, and my first task was to call Nilüfer Kuyaş to offer her a position working together at *Sabah*. After graduating from Robert College, Nilüfer had completed her undergraduate degree in philosophy at Wellesley College, one of America's prestigious universities, and had also earned a master's degree in social psychology from Boğaziçi University. Between 1982 and 1993, while pursuing her philosophy doctorate at the University of London, she had worked as a programmer at the BBC Turkish Service together with her husband Tayfun Ertan, and that year they had made their permanent return to Turkey. We had known each other since 1982, when she translated Thomas Kuhn's "The Structure of Scientific Revolutions," one of the masterworks of the history of philosophy of science, into Turkish, and I had started editing the book page at Cumhuriyet. Her acceptance of my proposal and taking on the assistant editorship of the page that would be published seven days a week was an extraordinary stroke of luck for me; because Nilüfer was not just a friend I loved and admired—I could not have found another work partner with her qualifications.

On October 14, my old friend Nebil İlseven, who was then serving as a consultant to Dinç Bilgin, the owner of the *Sabah* group, picked me up from home and took me to the newspaper building in İki Telli. The next day Nilüfer also came, spoke with Mutlu, and started work. On October 16, we published the first issue of "Intellectual Perspective." The page's headline article was devoted to introducing Huntington's "Clash of Civilizations" thesis, which had appeared in his article in the Summer 1993 issue of

Foreign Affairs magazine and attracted great interest, under the title “Famous American political scientist Huntington claims: Civilizations will clash in the new world.” The rest of the page featured an article introducing the New Democracy Movement under the title “An intellectuals’ initiative against the political class: New world, new Turkey, new democracy,” alongside a piece on British historian Paul Kennedy’s book *Preparing for the Twenty-First Century*, which was gaining fame at the time.

In the introductory text titled “There is a need for Intellectual Perspective,” I wrote: “Whatever field we work in, we increasingly feel the need to have more and deeper knowledge… Our world and our society are changing at a dizzying pace. To keep up with this change, more or less all of us feel the need for the most important quality of an intellectual—being able to look critically at the society we live in and at ourselves. Different views and different approaches and perspectives now seem more interesting and important to us than before. It can be said that all of us need ‘Intellectual Perspective’ to some degree. For these reasons, on this page called ‘Intellectual Perspective,’ we hope to provide *Sabah* readers with clues to help them follow developments in the fields of knowledge and thought in the world and in our country, emerging trends, and erupting debates. We plan to spread across a wide area ranging from politics and economics to cultural subjects in the broadest sense, including science, art, music, architecture, environment, and sometimes sports.”

The page was published for a little over six months until April 25, 1994, and we remained committed to this perspective. Nilüfer Kuyaş generally took on the writing and editing of art and culture topics, while I handled politics and social science. Among those who immediately called to congratulate me upon my sudden departure from CHP and appearance at *Sabah*, I have recorded the names of İshak Alaton, Osman Kavala, Zülfü Dicleli, Hüseyin Ergün, Cem Boyner, Mehmet Kabasakal, Asaf Savaş Akat, Ferai Tınç, Yalçın Bayer, Adil Özkol, Uğur Alacakaptan, and Güngör Mengi from *Sabah*.

At *Sabah*, I was reunited with my close and former colleagues Hasan Cemal and Cengiz Çandar.

Hasan was pleased with my arrival. When he saw the first page of Intellectual Perspective (hereafter IP), he said, “This is exactly the page I was expecting!..” Cengiz, with his usual mischievous manner, teased me by referring to what we had experienced at *Cumhuriyet* in the 1980s: “Oh no, now that you’ve come, it looks like I’m on my way out…” he said. Okay Gönensin (may he rest in peace), who again appeared before me as managing editor, made it clear he was not pleased with my arrival at *Sabah*. I met Ergun Babahan, Can Ataklı, and Murat Birsel for the first time; they showed neither particular sympathy nor antipathy toward me. However, before my name came up, it had been planned for Ataklı and Birsel to create the page.

My first disappointment at *Sabah* was that, contrary to my expectations, we were not given an office. We were shown a place at one of the desks lined up in the hall where the reporters worked. My second disappointment was the attitude the owner took toward us. On one of my first days at the newspaper, Mutlu introduced me to Dinç Bilgin, who, as always, was playing backgammon with someone in a room. Bilgin neither asked how I was nor posed a question nor said anything; he just stared blankly. From then on,

whenever we crossed paths in the corridors, he pretended not to know me. (Zülfü tried to explain this with Bilgin's "shy temperament," but I was not convinced.) Thus I began to get acquainted with the culture of *Sabah* newspaper.

The caste system at *Sabah*

The culture of *Sabah* was quite different from *Cumhuriyet*. On the top floor of the newspaper's modern and ostentatious building was the restaurant where the owner and the "most privileged" writers and managers ate, on one of the middle floors the reporters ate, and on the lowest floor the ordinary employees ate. There was virtually a caste system. Everyone had internalized the rules of which floor they would work on, which restaurant they would eat in, which rooms they could enter and exit; no one made a mistake. The culture of the newspaper, which claimed to represent Turkey's "rising values" together with ANAP, in my view exactly reflected the mentality of the "nouveau riche," the new rich. I felt very alien to this "class-based" culture. At *Cumhuriyet* I had worked with a sense of exclusion; at *Sabah* I would work with a sense of being out of place.

What made me happy in my new job was Zafer Mutlu's weekly column published on November 29, 1993. After listing how *Sabah* was "the best" of the Turkish press in various respects, Mutlu said: "For those interested in the intellectual dimension of events, for those who want to follow our world from a more intellectual perspective alongside current affairs, *SABAH* is again the unrivaled daily newspaper. Because Çetin Altan, Zülfü Livaneli, and Mehmet Altan are all at *SABAH*. In addition, Turkey's only and first (I say first because I'm sure imitations will be made very soon) intellectual page is also at *SABAH*. The interest shown in this page of incredible quality, edited by Şahin Alpay, makes us very, very happy on behalf of our country. The interest this page has received is extremely encouraging for Turkey."

At that time in the Turkish media, the *Sabah* group owned by the Dinç Bilgin family and the Doğan group owned by the Aydın Doğan family were on the one hand forming a cartel among themselves and cooperating against employees, while on the other hand they were in fierce competition for circulation, advertising share, political influence, and obtaining advantages from the government. The *Sabah* group was close to DYP, and the Doğan group to ANAP. The competition between them had triggered an unprecedented promotion war with a wide variety of products ranging from dishes to dictionaries and encyclopedias given along with the newspaper to increase sales.

Although I was extremely uncomfortable with the culture and environment of *Sabah*, Nilüfer and I tried to do our job as well as we could. On the other hand, because it was the most prestigious and highest-paying job I had done until then, and because I believed we were providing an important service, I was generally pleased with my job at *Sabah*. In the IP pages, alongside my and Nilüfer's writings and interviews, contributions from some of Turkey's most distinguished signatures also appeared. We were pleased with the work we were doing… Nilüfer expressed it this way: "We like what we're doing, and that's enough for us!.." But unfortunately, my *Sabah* adventure, like my TÜSES and CHP adventures, was not long-lived.

My ATV adventure

The financial crisis that erupted in April 1994 brought the end of IP at *Sabah*. One day the newspaper went from 40 pages to 20; managing editor Gönensin announced with undisguised satisfaction that it had been decided to close IP. Zafer Mutlu said they had made this decision unwillingly, that I should wait a while, that the crisis would pass, but that they had to say goodbye to Nilüfer Kuyaş. The reason Mutlu suggested I wait was probably that he thought a place could be found for me at *Yeni Yüzyıl* newspaper, which the *Sabah* group would start publishing shortly.

At the beginning of May, I decided to resign from *Sabah*. Since the job I loved doing had ended and Nilüfer had also been let go, there was no point in sitting and waiting at a workplace I found not at all pleasant. I also thought new doors could open. I knew Umur Talu, *Milliyet*'s editor-in-chief, from *Cumhuriyet* where he had worked for a time. I had hope that I could find a place there. Ufuk Güldemir had been appointed editor-in-chief at Show TV. We were discussing among ourselves that we could make a program with political-intellectual content where I would edit and he would host. Ufuk had served as *Cumhuriyet*'s Washington DC correspondent and had returned to the country after his position was terminated following the split at the newspaper. I had strongly supported his acceptance of Show TV's offer.

Then, at the beginning of June 1994, *Sabah*'s senior columnist Güneri Cıvaoğlu (hereafter GC) called me on the phone. We met for lunch. In September he would start making a documentary program called "Red File" on ATV; he wanted me to do the research and editing, offering to pay the salary I had received from *Sabah*. I did not have great respect for Cıvaoğlu's journalism, but this was the only concrete job offer before me. Fatma was repeating her suggestion that I leave the media and that, after we spent the summer together, we open a bookstore and publishing house. She said she could work with me and that this business could also benefit the children. But when had I ever listened to her… I again went my own stubborn way. I not only accepted GC's offer but also proposed the topic for the first program: let's tell the story of the National Outlook movement under the title "Unknown Welfare." He accepted this proposal and my wish to work together with Tayfun Ertan. However, from our first meeting with him at his villa in Yeniköy, Tayfun and I had deep misgivings: how were we to work with someone who treated us like janitors rather than colleagues? We were right to be worried, but on the other hand the project was attractive and we had no better option at the time.

The story of the National Outlook

Despite the flare-up of my herniated disc pain that had started in the winter of 1986 and become chronic, I devoted almost all of the summer of 1994 to conducting about 50 interviews, shared between Tayfun and me, telling the story of the National Outlook. When Tayfun's radio journalism and my print media experience were combined with the knowledge we had gained from watching Western television, in our view a quite high-quality documentary would emerge.

I conducted long interviews on the occasion of this program with the founders of the National Outlook movement Ahmet Tevfik Paksu, Hasan Aksay, Gündüz Sevilgen (one of the leaders of the opposition to Erbakan at the MSP's 3rd Congress in 1976); Bahri Zengin, who got the RP to adopt the "legal pluralism" view; the RP's Islamist critics Hasan Mezarcı, Altan Tan, Ercüment Özkan and others. One of the most interesting interviews was with Ahmet Tevfik Paksu. Paksu, who was one of the leading representatives of the Nurcu community and had served as senator from the Justice Party and then as Minister of Labor from the MSP, described the role of Naqshbandi Sheikh Mehmet Zahit Kotku in the founding of the National Order Party, the first political party of the National Outlook movement, as follows:

"Together with Hasan Aksay (also one of the leading representatives of the Nurcu community, a member of parliament from the Justice Party, later deputy chairman and State Minister of the MSP), we were seeking to establish a party that would not look down on Muslims, would not oppress Muslims, and would express its views in its organization and in public squares even if it could not enter Parliament. We presented this idea to Erbakan. At first, Necmettin Bey neither rejected it nor said okay. He said, I have a teacher; the imam of İskenderpaşa Mosque, Mehmed Efendi. Let's go to him and discuss it, he said. We said okay. Necmettin Bey, Hasan Aksay, the late Arif Hikmet Güner and I got up and went to Hocaefendi. I explained the necessity of establishing a new organization in Turkey to the best of my ability. Arif Hikmet Bey was of a completely opposite opinion. He argued that establishing such an organization would harm Muslims; therefore it was better to work within existing parties. Necmettin Bey, as he had done with us before, stated the positive and negative aspects of this matter. Hasan Bey shared my opinion. In the end, Hocaefendi said to us—I'm saying the sentence exactly as it was, because this is a sentence that will go down in history—'Follow whatever Hacı Tevfik Bey says.' That is, he said he approved of our idea. Upon this, together with Necmettin Bey and other friends, we set about establishing this party organization." (See Şahin Alpay, *Milliyet*, November 11, 1995.)

The account of Paksu, who had parted ways with Erbakan and left the MSP in the late 1970s due to disagreements, bore witness to the alliance formed between the Naqshbandis and the Nurcus in the founding of the National Order Party. This alliance, which played a role in the MSP receiving 12 percent of the vote in the 1973 elections, broke down when Nurcu candidates were excluded in the 1977 elections, and the MSP's vote dropped to 8 percent.

"I must have been wrong"

One of the most interesting interviews we conducted for the "National Outlook" documentary in the summer of 1994 was undoubtedly the one I had with Recep Tayyip Erdoğan (future Prime Minister and President), who at the time was completing his third month as Mayor of Istanbul. In this interview, Erdoğan appeared to me as quite a liberal and pragmatic person by RP standards. I had thought that Erdoğan could make the RP a party acceptable to broader segments. The main views that made me think this way were:

“Our concern is not why this person covers her head, why that person goes uncovered. Our concern is neither beards nor beardlessness, neither mustaches nor mustachelessness, neither covering nor not covering… The RP is not a prosecutor or a judge. We have no right to judge anyone. Only God has the authority to judge whether a person is Muslim or infidel… We have no claim that RP equals Islam. Welfare is not a religion. It is a political party established within this system, according to the rules of this system… The RP is libertarian. Islam is the most libertarian religion. Of course there are limits to freedom. That is the freedom of others… We will solve problems with science, not with prayer. Islam does not deny science… Whether the person who comes to my door is Muslim, Christian, or Jewish, they receive equal treatment. My faith commands this…” (For the article where I reported these statements, see *Milliyet*, July 23, 1996.)

When I read Nilgün Cerrahoğlu’s interview with Erdoğan (Milliyet, July 14, 1996), I would be startled and write the following: “Erdoğan was using the ‘99 percent of us are Muslim’ rhetoric this time with a very different emphasis: ‘There are two types of people in Turkey. This is also our esteemed Teacher’s observation. Those who are Welfare supporters and those who are candidates to become Welfare supporters… We will see Nilgün Hanım in the RP soon.’ This statement was a clear expression of the mentality shared by many RP members that sees democracy only as majority rule (majority dictatorship), that rejects the fundamental rights and freedoms of those not included in the majority that cannot be violated by any majority, that rejects pluralism. So everyone would, willingly or unwillingly, become a Welfare supporter over time, would be forced to become a Welfare supporter.

“Erdoğan was also telling Cerrahoğlu a view he had never expressed before: ‘We say that democracy is not an end but a means…’ For ordinary citizens like me, this statement was the clearest and most concise expression of the understanding in RP ranks that sees democratic competition as merely a process of ‘conquering’ power. I also find Erdoğan’s recent statements about the media alarming. It’s not that the RP doesn’t have media; they have plenty of television stations, radios, newspapers. Why the anger reaching the point of saying ‘The dogs bark but the caravan moves on’ about the media just because the majority of the people prefer the opposition media rather than these?” (*Milliyet*, July 22, 1996).

In a later article I said: “Wasn’t it that the RP did not equal Islam? Is being against the RP contrary to Islam? Are those who don’t approve of the RP, as Erbakan says, ‘of the potato religion’?.. I had the impression that Tayyip Erdoğan was a representative of the RP’s more democratic face, respectful of freedoms and pluralism. I had thought he could be a leader candidate who could make the RP accepted by much broader segments than Erbakan had been able to achieve. I must have been wrong.” (*Milliyet*, July 25, 1996)

As I will relate later, I would be wrong about Erdoğan not once but several times…

The end of the adventure

The documentary we prepared was quite high quality in our view (that is, Tayfun Ertan’s and mine); however, GC did not like the script, which in his words “resembled a doctoral

thesis," and decided that the work needed to pass through the hands of "a professional screenwriter"; for this he made an agreement with writer and former ANAP parliamentarian Yılmaz Karakoyunlu. Karakoyunlu ruined our documentary, which we had designed to be broadcast over two weeks with each part being two hours, by turning it into something to be broadcast in one go in 90 minutes and making various interventions. When GC also devoted most of the time to his interview with Erbakan, the work ceased to be our work. (We had thought that interviewing Erbakan, who spoke every day, wouldn't be meaningful…) We were greatly disappointed. In September 1994 I left GC, and shortly after Tayfun did too. When I informed him of my decision to leave, GC pretended to be surprised and asked "Why?.." In response, I simply said, "You are intelligent enough to know the answer to that…" (Even while leaving, I still did GC a favor; I recommended my friend Koray Düzgören from the Faculty of Political Science to replace me. He would work with Koray for quite a long time.)

Going to Stockholm for an academic meeting right after leaving ATV did me good. On one of the days I was there, "Unknown Welfare" was broadcast in Karakoyunlu's version. I was invited to dinner at the home of one of my Turkish friends; I asked them to turn on ATV at broadcast time. The documentary we had put so much work into had become so unrecognizable and meaningless that after watching for a while I asked my friends to turn off the television. Not mentioning our contributions at all was disrespectful to our labor, but fortunately they had done so; because the documentary had become a caricature of what we had designed.

Unfortunately, that was not the end of what happened to the National Outlook documentary. A few months after we left the job, when İkitelli creek overflowed due to heavy rainfall, sewage water flooded the archive section in the basement of the ATV building, and all our work literally went to "shit." Tayfun and I deeply regretted not having kept copies of the interviews for ourselves. Worse still, while writing these lines I couldn't even find a copy of the script we wrote for the documentary in my archive. This too must be a reflection of my *alaturka* ways—my haphazard Turkish-style disorganization.

Ufuk Güldemir at *Milliyet*

My hope of finding a place for myself at *Milliyet* continued. After returning from Stockholm, I made an agreement with Umur Talu and wrote a series about the evolution social democracy had undergone in Sweden, gradually becoming more liberal and starting to view EU membership favorably (Sweden would become a member in 1995). The series was published in *Milliyet* some time later, somewhat shortened. On the phone, Umur was saying they would soon invite me to work at *Milliyet*, but I sensed something strange in his voice. The reason became clear some time later. When Ufuk Güldemir called one late afternoon, I thought we would discuss the program we would do together at Show TV, but that wasn't the topic. He was delivering bombshell news: he had become editor-in-chief of *Milliyet*. What's more, he wanted me to bring the "Intellectual Perspective" page to *Milliyet*. Furthermore, I would be able to bring Nilüfer Kuyaş with me. Furthermore, I would be able to write a column three days a week on the page that would be published six days a week… What more could I ask for?!?!…

I had entered *Cumhuriyet* through Hasan Cemal, *Sabah* through Zülfü Livaneli; I was getting into *Milliyet* thanks to my friendship with Ufuk Güldemir. (My adventure should be considered a good example of how hiring works in the Turkish media.)

Nilüfer and I started doing Intellectual Perspective at *Milliyet* in the last days of November 1994. Ahmet Altan, Can Dündar, and Nilgün Cerrahoğlu also joined the *Milliyet* staff around that time. I would receive a salary that couldn't be compared to the amounts paid to other columnists, but was satisfying for me. Again I didn't have my own office, but a spacious corner where Nilüfer and I would sit together had been allocated to us; soon we would also have a secretary. Best of all, I would be able to go home and back with the newspaper's vehicles. Yes, Ufuk hadn't been able to get the appointment he wanted to introduce us to the owner, but what more could I ask for? For the first time, I held such a privileged position in the media. According to Taha Akyol, who was writing at *Milliyet* at the time and with whom my friendship would progressively deepen, most writers at newspapers only had a column; I, on the other hand, had a page on top of that, in a way rarely seen in Bab-ı Ali (Istanbul's old press district)… The page brought us quite a lot of readers and garnered quite a lot of praise. The signatures of many people who later became well-known commentators appeared for the first time on the page I edited at *Milliyet*, as they had at *Cumhuriyet* and *Sabah*.

One, two, or three "l"s?

As at *Sabah*, a debate arose at *Milliyet* about how the page's name should be spelled. I described this debate, which took quite an interesting turn, in a column: "When we started at *Sabah*, Can Ataklı had conveyed that there was some hesitation about the spelling of 'Entellektüel,' that some said it should be written as 'Entelektüel.' Then all hell broke loose: The Turkish Language Association dictionary supposedly spelled it 'entelektüel,' and the duty of an intellectual was supposedly to show society the truth about everything, and so on… Letters, phone calls, fax messages… Zülfü Livaneli came to the rescue; he wrote 'The correct form is entellektüel.' This time the debate was settled amicably with jokes that lightweight intellectuals wrote it with 'one l' while heavyweights wrote it with 'two l's.' Hıncal Uluç wrote 'The number of L's can even go up to three if necessary.'

We started receiving warnings that it was mandatory to spell it 'Entelektüel.' A well-known writer of ours said he didn't read the page because it was written with two "l"s. One of our readers gave an ultimatum: 'By such and such date, the two l's will be reduced to one!' My dear friend Zülfü Livaneli, with whom by a twist of fate we had reunited under the same roof, again came to our rescue. Again with a fine article he reminded us that the correct form was 'entellektüel,' but that the real issue was tied up in the meaning of the word. This time he too started receiving letters full of advice and Zülfü got fed up…" ("Entellektüel," *Milliyet*, December 27, 1994)

Since Ufuk wanted me to attend the morning editorial meetings in addition to making the page and, as I had done at *Cumhuriyet*, to offer suggestions and criticisms, I was staying at the newspaper six days a week from early morning until the late hours when page preparation was completed. Again I couldn't devote enough time to my family.

Fatma was living her own life as always, but because both my spirits and my earnings were good, perhaps for the first time we were both content with our situation. Our daughter Elvan had married and left home two years earlier, becoming a painter who would gradually gain fame. Our son Acar was attending Işık High School.

At *Milliyet*, everything went well for the first few months. However, the newspaper's departure from its traditional seriousness in its headlines was causing discomfort among both readers and the owner. Ufuk thought he could increase circulation by bringing to *Milliyet*'s headlines the habit of "adding color" to articles that he had acquired at *Cumhuriyet*. When I mildly criticized this, I remember him saying, "If we don't put some blood on the front page, how can we connect with the citizen on the street?.. Those looking for seriousness can read your page…" The real crisis erupted in April 1995 over Ahmet Altan's column titled "Atakürt" (Ata-Kurd), one of his masterpieces. Aydın Doğan, saying he was under intense pressure from readers, demanded that Ahmet Altan leave the newspaper. When Ahmet left, Can Dündar also resigned in solidarity with him. He called me on the phone to probe whether I would join him. I had no doubt that owner interference in a writer's articles was in no way acceptable, but I didn't see myself as strong enough to make a heroic gesture by resigning. I now had a job I loved doing, and I was determined to protect this job as long as I could. Unfortunately, after Ahmet and Can, Ufuk also had to resign.

Shortly before Ufuk's resignation was announced, Aydın Doğan, with Ufuk's participation, hosted a dinner somewhere on the Bosphorus for the writers Ufuk had brought to *Milliyet*. His purpose became clear later: Ufuk is leaving but you can stay, he was saying. At the dinner, I was seated (as the most senior writer) across from the owner (whom I was meeting for the first time); on either side of me were Nilüfer and Nilgün Cerrahoğlu. In response to the owner's words explaining why he had asked Ahmet Altan to leave, I said approximately or exactly the following: "Aydın Bey, while we were struggling for the establishment of freedom of expression in Turkey, you stabbed us in the back by removing Ahmet from the newspaper…" The owner's response was exactly this: "I have no such cause as defending freedom of expression; I want to publish a social democratic newspaper…" (The owner was indicating that what he meant by "social democracy" was Kemalism.) I'll never forget, Fatma was surprised at how the owner hadn't immediately fired me because of these words. Aydın Doğan didn't fire me immediately after these events in 1995, but (as I will tell the story) he would do so later, and in quite an ugly manner.

After Ufuk's resignation, Derya Sazak was brought in as *Milliyet*'s editor-in-chief. Both Nilüfer and I were very happy that Derya was appointed rather than someone else. Derya was Nilüfer's friend. When he was Ankara bureau chief and I was working at CHP, we had become close. At that time he had mentioned the possibility of being appointed editor-in-chief and had given me hope that perhaps he would also bring me to *Milliyet*. Derya, bless him, treated us in a friendly manner as long as he remained in the position; under his management we felt secure. Our close friends Edip Öymen and Yavuz Baydar also worked with us for periods.

The political landscape in the mid-1990s

A brand new page was opening in my journalism career. While IP was being published six days a week, I was also writing a column titled “3rd Eye” three days a week on this page. What course should I follow in my columns and in preparing the IP page? My answer to this question was based on the following observations:

1) Liberal democracy (that is, majority rule limited by citizens’ fundamental rights and freedoms), despite its various problems, was the best form of governance that could be found, beneficial both for individuals and for societies. 2) Within a liberal democratic regime, securing both individual freedoms and social justice could only be possible through liberal social democratic policies (that is, the synthesis of market economy and welfare state), not statist ones. 3) If liberal democracy was to take root in Turkey, this could only be possible by integrating Islamists and the Kurdish political movement (their non-radical, non-authoritarian interpretations) into the system.

After I started writing at *Cumhuriyet* newspaper, I had engaged in an intellectual struggle for the goals I listed above, together with a rather limited number of liberal-minded people like myself. By the time I started writing at Milliyet in the 1990s, the Turkish political landscape in my mind had become quite clear. There were three basic political currents competing to determine the country’s future.

1) Kemalists: They were divided into three main wings: a) Those who were secularist (that is, authoritarian secularism) but also pro-democracy (majority rule) and pro-integration with the West, generally gathered in the CHP. b) Radical Kemalists who were secularist-statist-nationalist, essentially represented in the vein of *Cumhuriyet* newspaper and its circle. c) Turkish-Islam synthesizers who were proponents of authoritarian identity politics verging on racism (“we are all Turks”) but kept their distance from authoritarian secularism and generally gathered in the MHP.

2) Muslims and Islamists:

It was necessary to distinguish Muslims, who embraced the Islamic faith in its different interpretations, from Islamists, who produced a political ideology from the Islamic religion. Muslims, who constituted the vast majority of Turkey’s population, consisted of orthodox (that is, pure in their beliefs) Sunnis and heterodox (that is, harboring a synthesis of different elements in their beliefs) Alevis. Although the minority Alevis had suffered repression reaching the level of massacre in Tunceli/Dersim through the impositions of Kemalism’s uniform identity policies (saying “we are all of the Diyanet religion”), they mostly supported the Kemalist party CHP out of concern that it would provide them protection against the Sunni majority. Sunnis, on the other hand, were roughly divided into three segments: a) Those attached to State Islam, that is, the “Diyanet religion” represented by the Directorate of Religious Affairs. The political preferences of this majority segment could be directed toward various parties. b) Those attached to Folk Islam, that is, the interpretations of Islam represented by tarikat orders and religious communities.

Although tarikat orders and religious communities had been banned since 1925 due to authoritarian secularism policies (and perhaps encouraged by this), they maintained their vitality. Traditional tarikat orders, whose roots extended to the 12th and 13th centuries, were organized in the form of sheikh-disciple relationships and consisted mainly of the Naqshbandi, Qadiri, Rufai, Halveti, Melami, and (having a special identity) Mevlevi orders. The most dominant segment, the Naqshbandis, were mainly divided into the İskenderpaşa, İsmail Ağa, Menzil, and Erenköy congregations.

Unlike the tarikat orders, the religious communities, which were a product of the 20th century, of the modern era, consisted of a spiritual guide (mürşit) who guided believers and his followers, and were mainly divided into groups known as Nurcus, Süleymancıs, and Işıkçıs (all of Naqshbandi origin). The Nurcus, followers of the teachings of Said Nursi, had over time split into more than 40 branches, the largest being the Fethullah Gülen community.

The Islamists, on the other hand, overwhelmingly consisted of those gathered in the ranks of the National Outlook movement; a segment we could generally call moderate, embracing peaceful, legal struggle rather than violence. (Islamists favoring the use of violence were not making their presence felt.) The İskenderpaşa lodge of the Naqshbandi order, whose sheikh was Mehmet Zahit Kotku, was particularly interested in politics and had played an important role in the emergence of the National Outlook movement. Necmettin Erbakan, Turgut Özal, Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, and most famous politicians belonging to the National Outlook movement were of Naqshbandi origin.

3) The Kurdish political movement: The bans imposed on the expression of Kurdish language and identity with the proclamation of the Republic had led to increasingly strong reactions. By the mid-1990s, it was observed that Turkey's Kurds were roughly divided into a segment that prioritized religious identity and supported Islamist parties, and those who prioritized ethnic identity and supported the Kurdish nationalist movement. The Kurdish nationalist movement was roughly divided into three wings: a) The current represented by the PKK that was based on armed struggle, aiming for autonomy or independence. b) The current represented by legal parties that started with HEP in 1991 and were successively closed down on grounds of separatism, gradually growing to reach HDP today (the third largest party), proposing a peaceful-democratic solution within Turkey's integrity to the problem arising from policies based on the denial of Kurdish identity. c) Liberal-minded independent Kurdish intellectuals, not very numerous, who thought that the PKK's armed struggle was playing into the hands of state policies and causing great harm to Kurds.

Of course, there was also a Marxist or Communist current on the scene. Although banned since the first years of the Republic, they had begun to make their presence felt in Turkish politics in the 1960s, splitting among dozens of factions, some of which favored armed struggle. However, the communist current suffered a great defeat after the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991 and Eastern Europe's liberation from the Soviet yoke, and had gradually become marginalized. My own political views had moved away from the Kemalism instilled by my family, turning to Marxism in the 1960s when I was at university, and gradually to its Maoist interpretation. However, while doing my doctorate

at Stockholm University in Sweden where I had taken refuge in the early 1970s, the Marxist paradigm in my mind gradually eroded and collapsed, and I had begun to see Marxism as the opposite of liberal democracy. Upon returning to the country, inspired especially by Karl Popper's views, I had written articles criticizing Marxism; I had not hesitated to say that "I was proud of my apostasy."

In the 1980s, my articles defending liberal social democracy at *Cumhuriyet* newspaper had met with strong opposition from the secularist-statist-nationalist writers and their supporters who dominated the paper. The split that occurred at the newspaper in the early 1990s, roughly between the wing represented by İlhan Selçuk and the cadre represented by Hasan Cemal, was essentially the product of the conflict between Kemalism's secularist-tutelary interpretation and its social democratic interpretation. Just as Marxism in history had given rise to communism on the one hand and social democracy on the other, I had thought that social democratic interpretations could also emerge from within the Kemalist current, and with this thought I had briefly pinned my hopes on Ecevit's ("respectful of religion") DSP. However, when it was soon seen that the DSP was a personality party with little connection to either democracy or the left, my hopes turned to Deniz Baykal's CHP; with this hope I had worked at the CHP for a short time, but there too I had been disappointed.

The path I should follow

When I started writing at *Milliyet*, the path I should follow as a commentator who idealized the establishment of liberal democracy seemed quite clear to me: I would defend pluralist and liberal democracy, and criticize political views incompatible with liberal democracy. Looking at Turkey's Islamic geography, it seemed essential to distinguish Islamists from Muslims. Kemalism's repressive secularism policies had caused justified reactions among Muslims; some of these reactions had fed the Islamist current. However, like believers of all other religious faiths, Muslims could also embrace democracy. Indeed, Turkey's practice after 1950 seemed to support this.

Islamism, on the other hand, was in principle incompatible with liberal and pluralist democracy. However, it was also necessary to distinguish moderate Islamists who opposed violence from radical Islamists who favored violence. The former could be integrated into the democratic regime; those who really needed to be criticized were the latter. With this fundamental perspective, in my writings and speeches I criticized authoritarian secularism policies; I advocated the lifting of bans on tarikat orders and religious communities, the end of the headscarf ban and other restrictions on religious freedoms, the separation of religion and state, and the transformation of the Directorate of Religious Affairs into an autonomous structure.

The political parties belonging to the National Outlook movement, which represented moderate Islamism, had many elements in their agendas that contradicted liberal democracy: They embraced democratic elections as the path to power, but they did not inspire confidence and raised doubts about whether they would be respectful of the rule of law and pluralism once in power. In my writings, I would call on the moderate Islamists

represented in the RP not only to be committed to majority rule but also to be respectful of citizens' fundamental rights and freedoms. And that is what I would do.

"Religion and politics"

Around this time, also under the influence of what we had learned from the documentary we made for ATV, my understanding of the distinction in Turkey between *Official Islam* (represented by the Directorate of Religious Affairs), *Political Islam* (of which the Welfare Party represented a non-violent type), and *Folk Islam* (divided into tarikat orders and religious communities) had begun to settle firmly into place. I had begun to see that the most important distinction in the context of Folk Islam was between the Naqshbandis and the Nurcus, mainly between the İskenderpaşa lodge and the Fethullah Gülen community (or the Hizmet Movement, as it wished to be called). My article titled "Religion and Politics" published in *Milliyet* reflected where my understanding of Islam in Turkey had arrived. I was writing:

"A generation of intellectuals, including myself, had difficulty in their youth understanding the place of religion in the lives of individuals and societies. Especially those like me who for a while thought Marxism was the key to building paradise on earth believed that the formula 'Religion is the opium of the people' explained everything right there. Everything was determined (even if 'in the last instance') by the 'base,' that is, production and property relations; the rest was nonsense. First, we began to understand that this was not so; that people's needs were not limited to eating, drinking, and reproducing; that their needs related to meaning and the world of culture were at least as important; that religion had the function of being a cultural code that held societies together. When we opened our eyes a bit more, we began to understand the impossibility of understanding society without understanding the 'superstructure' called culture, including religion.

"Social scientists such as the late Sabri Ülgener and Şerif Mardin, whom I remember with deep respect, made a great contribution to opening our eyes to the world of meaning and culture. Especially Şerif Mardin's works helped us see the void that single-party rule had created in the cultural world. Then we discovered the impossibility of analyzing politics in Turkey without taking into account the tarikat orders and religious communities that officially did not exist but in reality maintained and developed their vitality. We understood that in Turkey, where modern institutionalization and organization lagged behind, one of the basic forms of social organization continued to be these religious brotherhood and solidarity organizations.

"When we delved a bit deeper, we learned that the National Order Party, founded in 1970, was essentially based on an alliance between the Nurcus, disciples of Bediüzzaman Said Nursi, and the disciples of Naqshbandi Sheikh Mehmet Zahit Kotku; that the foundations of the National Outlook movement were laid in this way. We learned that as a result of the struggles that erupted within the National Salvation Party in the second half of the 1970s, the Naqshbandis had largely purged the Nurcus; that the Nurcus, as they had always done, essentially turned to center-right parties. Also that Kotku died in 1980, at a time when he was very unhappy with the attitude of Necmettin Erbakan and the MSP… Meanwhile, it became understood that Süleyman Demirel's

influence in the DP-AP tradition was significantly based on Nurcu support, and the late Turgut Özal's power within ANAP was significantly based on Naqshbandi support. Another consequence of our eyes opening was understanding the impossibility of explaining how the CHP-SHP tradition could get votes from society without understanding Alevism in Turkey.

"In the early 1990s, we witnessed the strong opposition of Esad Coşan, the theology professor and son-in-law who succeeded Kotku, against Necmettin Hoca, and his talk of founding a new party. Nowadays, we are witnessing the Nurcu supporters of Fethullah Gülen clustered around *Zaman* taking, against the interpretation represented by the Welfare Party, a stance that appears more moderate, more 'tolerant,' seeming to emphasize cultural Islam rather than the politicization of Islam.

"Religion is one of the most powerful elements of people's world of meaning and culture. Attempting to abolish religion is, as many experiences have shown, a futile and backfiring endeavor. Religion is not the 'opium' of society but perhaps its mortar. Modernization may not eliminate religion but on the contrary may strengthen it. Making religion an instrument of politics is as dangerous as abolishing it. Political religion, in our country political Islam, which divides the people into believers and non-believers, into different belief groups, can plant dynamite at the foundations of society. Just as we must treat cultural Islam with respect, opposing the exploitation of the Islamic religion for political purposes should be the duty of all Muslims as much as all democrats." (*Milliyet*, February 18, 1995)

Islamic currents were not limited to the National Outlook movement. I had come to the conclusion that the current represented by Fethullah Gülen and his community, which had become increasingly visible in public opinion from the mid-1990s, represented an interpretation of Islam compatible with liberal democracy. Gülen advocated pluralism, secularism respectful of beliefs, mutual tolerance, the separation of religion and politics, EU membership, and the market economy, and opposed the RP's majoritarian views. In those years, except for radical secularism supporters, there was a positive atmosphere toward the Gülen community in society. Bülent Ecevit, who claimed to be "democratic left" advocating "secularism respectful of religion," was among those who viewed the Gülen movement positively. The "Tolerance and dialogue awards" ceremony organized by the Journalists and Writers Foundation, of which Gülen was honorary president, at Çırağan Palace on the evening of January 4, 1996, would be attended by Ankara Metropolitan Mayor Melih Gökçek, Istanbul Metropolitan Mayor Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, former Environment Minister Rıza Akçalı, Abdülkadir Aksu, Muhsin Yazıcıoğlu, Mehmet Aydın, Ali Coşkun, and many other politicians.

Among the participants at the meeting were CHP politician Ertuğrul Günay, Journalists' Association President Nail Güreli, journalists Hasan Cemal, Mehmet Altan, Zeynep Göğüş, and others. That evening, the media/TV programmer award went to Abdurrahman Dilipak and Toktamış Ateş, the columnist award to Cengiz Çandar and Taha Akyol, the sports award to Fatih Terim, the art award to Barış Manço, the nature and environment award to Hayrettin Karaca, and the family award to Perihan Savaş. The award for helping the disabled was shared by Recep Tayyip Erdoğan and Müjdat

Gezen. Among the many politicians from the right and left to whom the Journalists and Writers Foundation gave awards at various events organized until 1997 were President Süleyman Demirel, Parliament Speaker Hikmet Çetin, Deputy Prime Minister Bülent Ecevit, and (later prime minister) Tansu Çiller, as well as names like Yıldırım Akbulut, Bülent Akarcalı, Cemil Çiçek, Ertuğrul Günay, Işılay Saygın, İlhan Kesici, Mustafa Kalemli, Namık Kemal Zeybek, Nevzat Yalçıntaş, Vehbi Dinçerler, and Muhsin Yazıcıoğlu.

"Respect for Hocaefendi"

The fact that my article titled "Respect for Hocaefendi," in which I emphasized the importance of the Gülen movement that I saw as a representative of cultural Islam as opposed to political Islam, could be published in *Milliyet* was an indication of how different the atmosphere was in those days compared to today. As far as I remember, only one columnist among *Milliyet* employees reacted harshly, claiming that this article was "an attack on the foundations of the newspaper." The majority either found the article reasonable or remained silent, because it was consistent with the view that was prevalent in public opinion at the time. I was saying:

"It must be acknowledged that even today, the late nineteenth-century Young Turk movement has left a significant mark on how some of our intellectuals view religion in general and Islam in particular. We know that the thinkers and leaders of the Young Turk movement, which later organized as the Committee of Union and Progress, such as Ahmet Rıza and Abdullah Cevdet, held religion in general and Islam in particular responsible for the decline of the Ottoman State. The Young Turk leaders advocated that Ottoman elites adopt the Positivist philosophy that 'replaced religion with science' (developed by Auguste Comte and his followers in France) in order for the state to modernize. According to them, for modernization and Westernization to succeed, the people also needed to be educated with a kind of 'true Islam' that presented these as Islamic concepts…

"Of course, it is not possible to say that the positivist ideology of the Young Turks is still the dominant ideology among our intellectuals today. But there is no doubt that remnants of this worldview still circulate among us. These remnants, in my view, still manifest themselves in holding religion responsible for our social backwardness, viewing religion and science as rivals, denying the social role of religion and its important place in individuals' world of meaning, perceiving almost every manifestation of religion, such as the headscarf, as an instance of reaction and a threat to the secular regime, and in other ways.

"With such a perspective, it is certainly not possible to distinguish, analyze, and understand the diversity of Islam in Turkey and the different forms it takes; to put religion and politics in their proper places. Thankfully, with the help of whatever freedom and democracy we have, and with the pressures of society, we are slowly overcoming these shallow understandings. In this context, it is impossible not to see the benefits and contributions of Fethullah Gülen Hocaefendi's initiatives in recent times. Hocaefendi is the current leading representative of the community founded by Bediüzzaman Said

Nursi, a distinctive Islamic thinker and leader of twentieth-century Turkey who was a different kind of Young Turk in his effort to reconcile Islam with modernity and science.

“As far as I can see, Hocaefendi opposes the use of Islam as a political ideology, a party philosophy, and the division of society into two poles of believers and non-believers. He advocates for those with different beliefs and different thoughts to be respectful and tolerant of each other, and for peace and reconciliation in society. In my view, Hocaefendi’s efforts can help us put religion in its proper place… I perceive Hocaefendi as a religious leader who separates religion from politics, opposes the culture of enmity that could divide the people into camps, and contributes to the development of a tolerant understanding of Islam. What Hocaefendi has done should be respected.” (*Milliyet*, July 29, 1995)

Upon the publication of this article in *Milliyet*, two representatives from the Journalists and Writers Foundation, which Gülen had initiated, came to visit me at the newspaper with flowers in their hands; they conveyed that they wanted to give me one of the “Tolerance Awards” that the foundation was distributing at the time. I declined the award with thanks, but said that I was curious about the schools the movement had opened in Central Asian countries, and that if they invited me along with a group of journalists to see these schools, I would be very pleased. I made the same suggestion to Hüseyin Gülerce, who was then the editor-in-chief of *Zaman*.

This suggestion of mine was realized: Together with a group of colleagues including Ali Bayramoğlu, Ali Bulaç, Mustafa Özel, Atılgan Bayar, and others, between October 20-28, 1996, we visited the schools the movement had opened in Uzbekistan’s Tashkent, Jizzakh, Samarkand, and Bukhara; and Turkmenistan’s Ashgabat and Charjew. We spoke with the Turkish, Uzbek, and Turkmen administrators, teachers, and students of the schools.

The series of articles I wrote upon my return from the visit was published in *Milliyet* under the title *“Fethullah Gülen Hoca’s community’s ‘Schools Empire’ spreading around the world - Turkey’s trump card in Central Asia is education”* on November 1-5, 1996. My impression of the schools was quite positive. These schools, which constituted one dimension of Turkey’s opening to the world in the post-Cold War era, were providing modern and scientific education in two Central Asian countries governed by authoritarian secular and nationalist regimes, under joint management with local authorities, were among the most prestigious educational institutions in these countries, and were training the leaders of the future.

My impression of the movement’s schools in Central Asia was quite positive. In the Turkey of those days, in an effort to distinguish between interpretations of the Islamic movement that were compatible and incompatible with democracy, I wrote articles that viewed the Gülen movement favorably while looking at the Welfare Party quite critically. Circles favoring radical secularism were furious about my articles on the Gülen community. This was probably the main development that led me to start writing for the community’s newspaper *Zaman* some time after my job at *Milliyet* was terminated in 2001. (In 2004, the Journalists and Writers Foundation would compile the articles I had

written about the community during my time at *Milliyet* and my first two years at *Zaman* in a booklet titled *Gülen's Contribution*.)

Marxism held minds captive

Another result of the publication of my article titled "Respect for Hocaefendi" in *Milliyet* was that Eyüp Can from the community's newspaper *Zaman* conducted an extensive interview with me. In the interview titled "Marxism held minds captive" that I gave to Can, who would later join the *Hürriyet* group and also serve as editor-in-chief at *Radikal*, I was saying:

"In my youth, those who read, wrote, and were interested in events were mostly Marxist intellectuals. As such, we found ourselves within the Marxist current. But my ardent Marxist period was short; about 4-5 years. It didn't take me long to discover the disconnect between what the theory said and reality… Looking back today, I see all of this as experience. I say that perhaps the mistakes we made then were necessary for us to arrive at a more realistic understanding today… Marxist thought unfortunately caused many people's minds to be held captive in Turkey… Of course, there are still lingering residues. For example, there may be the influence of positivism and the Marxist approach in general on the attitude of some Turkish intellectuals toward religion. There may still be those who think they can explain religion with the opium analogy.

"Yet this way, let alone religion, we cannot even fully understand Marx. It is not possible to explain everything through matter. People have a spiritual world that gives meaning to their lives, and religion responds to needs in this area. A human being is not a machine. There are also moral rules and social values. Answers have always been sought to all of these throughout human history and will continue to be sought; religion is one of the fundamental sources to turn to in this area. This is true both sociologically and philosophically… On the other hand, it is very wrong to see religion and science as rivals. Both have an area that corresponds to something in human beings. One concerns reason, the other concerns faith." (*Milliyet*, January 7, 1996)

I think there were not many people in Turkey at that time who came from the Left and arrived at such a liberal understanding on the subject of religion.

"Huntington is talking nonsense"

The person who expressed the views most contrary to my own in the interviews I conducted for *Milliyet* was certainly the American international relations professor, the world-famous Samuel P. Huntington. My interview with Huntington was published in *Milliyet* on September 9, 1996, and my column about it came out the very next day. I was saying:

"Huntington is a famous American political scientist. He had long been known in the academic world, but he made the news three years ago. In his article titled 'The Clash of Civilizations?' published in the Summer 1993 issue of *Foreign Affairs*, he was saying: 'In the post-Cold War world, conflict will primarily occur between Western, Confucian, Japanese, Islamic, Hindu, Slavic, Orthodox, Latin American, and (possibly) African

civilizations; it will focus among states belonging to Western, Islamic, and Confucian civilizations.'

Huntington's thesis drew a storm of criticism. When I asked the famous historian Paul Kennedy, also from Harvard, who was visiting Turkey at the time, what he thought, he said: 'This article appealed to crude and narrow-minded views about the Islamic and Hindu worlds. I find the article generally negative. The danger it presents is that it becomes self-fulfilling and self-justifying.' (*Sabah*, November 24, 1993).

"I listened to Huntington's speech in Istanbul last week. Afterwards, I conducted an interview with him. As can be seen in the interview published on our page yesterday, Huntington put forward a new thesis in Istanbul: 'Turkey should become the leader of Islamic civilization!' When asked how it could achieve this leadership, given that three years ago he wrote that Turkey was a country 'torn' between Islamic and Western civilizations, his answer was essentially this: 'Being a bridge is not a very good thing. You don't belong to either side and people walk all over you. Since the West doesn't want you, take the lead of the Islamic world; let the dire leaderlessness there come to an end as well.' Even if we accept as true that the West doesn't want Turkey, how realistic is it that Islamic states, almost all of which are at each other's throats, would want to see Turkey as their leader? About as realistic as Erbakan's 'Islamic Union' dream…

"Huntington's views that would greatly please our Islamists were not limited to this. His deeming Turkey worthy of a 'non-secular, Islamic type' democracy even exceeded the expectations of the Welfare Party. That a political scientist of Huntington's caliber would consider a democracy 'respectful of fundamental rights but not secular' as possible was truly incomprehensible. Especially the connection he drew between liberal democracy and Christianity revealed his terrible prejudices… Huntington also has an idea that some of our Islamists would not like at all (reasonable, but completely inconsistent with his other views): He approves of the 'Pinochet option,' that is, the armed forces' duty to protect the constitution, against governments that do not respect fundamental rights. Listening to Huntington, I concluded that his knowledge about Turkey was quite inadequate and that he was generally talking nonsense." ("Huntington Is Talking Nonsense," *Milliyet*, September 10, 1996.)

My friendship with Şerafettin Elçi

Starting from my years working at *Cumhuriyet*, in my articles on the Kurdish issue, while strongly opposing the PKK's totalitarian ideology and politics of violence, I took a stance in favor of the democratic rights of Kurds and advocated that parties defending these rights find a place in the multi-party system. I wrote that the preservation of the country's integrity could be achieved not through violence and military methods, but through the recognition of the language and identity rights of Kurdish citizens and meeting demands for regional autonomy. Because of these views, while I encountered hostility from PKK supporters, I earned respect from liberal-minded Kurdish intellectuals. I had a special friendship with the late Şerafettin Elçi (1938-2012), who was foremost among them.

The late Elçi waged a noteworthy struggle for the democratic rights of Kurds. He was elected as a Mardin member of parliament from the Justice Party in 1977; he served as

Minister of Public Works (1978-79) in the coalition government that the CHP formed with JP deputies who had resigned to become independents. During his ministry, he was sentenced to 2 years and 3 months in prison by the martial law court for saying “There are Kurds in Turkey, and I am a Kurd”; he was also tried at the Supreme Court on charges of “hiring some Kurds” and was additionally sentenced to 2 years and 4 months in prison; due to these convictions, he spent more than 30 months in prison. In 1992, together with 98 Kurdish intellectuals, he founded the Kurdish Rights and Freedoms Foundation; after a long legal struggle, he managed to register the foundation under the name Kurdish Culture and Research Foundation, thus for the first time in the history of the Republic, an institution gained the opportunity to use the name “Kurdish.” In 1994, together with a group of friends, he pioneered the establishment of the Kurdish Democratic Platform; he assumed the General Chairmanship of the Democratic Mass Party founded in January 1997. When the party was closed down by the Constitutional Court on charges of separatism on February 26, 1999, Elçi spearheaded the establishment of the Participatory Democracy Party in December 2006 and was elected as the party’s general chairman.

I met Elçi in 1992 when he was serving as the founding chairman of the Kurdish Rights and Freedoms Foundation. Our views on the Kurdish issue, which almost completely overlapped, formed the basis of our friendship. On almost every trip I made to Ankara, I would meet with him and exchange views. In the long interview I conducted with him in February 1997, when he was chairman of the Democratic Mass Party, he was saying “I look to the future with hope.” When I asked “What is your proposal for a solution?” he was saying:

“At the founding stage of the Republic, it was promised that the state would be the state of the Kurds as well. In the Amasya protocol, which we can call the social contract upon which the state was founded, it was promised that all kinds of rights of the Kurds would be protected. Kurds participated in the first assembly as Kurdistan deputies. Kurds joined this state with the hope that their rights would be protected. But unfortunately, after things settled down, after Lausanne was signed, all promises were pushed aside. Kurds were assumed not to exist. The destruction of the thousands-of-years-old identity of the Kurds became the fundamental policy. It was not possible for a dignified society to endure this. Rebellions and conflicts arose for this reason. And it has continued until today. That is why we say that the injustices done to the Kurds must be corrected. As Mr. President (Süleyman Demirel) stated in 1992, the ‘Kurdish reality’ must be recognized. The acceptance that Kurds are also one of the essential elements of this society, and its legal guarantee, is necessary. The state must abandon the understanding that everyone living in this country is a Turk…”

Elçi also explained the difference between his party and HADEP as follows: “What is truly important is our ideological difference. We are not inspired by the Marxist tradition. We do not base our politics on class. We are a mass party… We consider intra-party democracy as important as democracy in the country. The party should be of a nature that can act entirely of its own will… Also, style in politics, the method of struggle, is very important. We believe that styles that increase harshness and escalate tension in society will not contribute to solving problems… We need to move politics away from

conflict. One of our fundamental principles is respect for the country's integrity. Since we will solve problems within this country, an atmosphere of friendship and trust must be created among everyone living in this country." (*Milliyet*, February 10, 1997)

I would meet with Elçi for the last time, about a year before his death, in Diyarbakır during the 2011 election campaign in which he participated as an independent candidate supported by the BDP. He said that his entering the election on the list of a political movement that he had criticized heavily until that day and viewed as PKK-controlled "should be understood as a sign of how hopeful he was about the resolution of the problem and the guns falling silent, and his desire to contribute to this." He expressed his belief that the AKP, CHP, and BDP could reach an agreement to solve the problem by negotiating among themselves. He emphasized that this opportunity should not be missed. ("There are Kurds in Turkey too," *Zaman*, June 4, 2011) Unfortunately, the opportunities were missed. Another ten years passed. In the last ten years, some steps have been taken toward granting freedom for the expression of Kurdish identity, but a democratic solution to the problem, with the guns falling completely silent, has still not appeared on the horizon at the time these lines are being written.

Elçi passed away on December 25, 2012, while undergoing cancer treatment in Ankara. His body was first taken to Diyarbakır, then he was buried in his hometown Cizre in a ceremony attended by approximately 100,000 people. His name was given to the Şırnak airport, which was inaugurated by Prime Minister Recep Tayyip Erdoğan in July 2013.

A fair criticism

Throughout my journalism career, I conducted interviews with renowned academics, politicians, and journalists at the newspapers *Cumhuriyet*, *Sabah*, and *Milliyet*. Among those from Turkey, I can mention my interviews with professors Sabri Ülgener, Şerif Mardin, Nur Yalman, Şükrü Hanioğlu, Dani Rodrik, Ayşe Buğra, Bülent Tanör, Asım Erdilek, Ziya Öniş, Gürol Irzık, Ümit Cizre, Kemal Karpat, Ergun Özbudun, politicians Korkut Özal, Rauf Denktaş, Mehmet Ali Talat, and European Court of Human Rights judge Rıza Türmen. These and others were collected in a book titled *Turkey's Witnesses: Those Who Look from Within*. (Timaş, Istanbul 2003)

Among the world-renowned social scientists I spoke with, I can primarily mention Paul Kennedy, Ernst Gellner, Dankwart A. Rustow, Abdülkerim Soruş, Martin van Bruinessen, Samuel P. Huntington, Sadık Celal El Azm, Francis Fukuyama, Leonard Binder, Hassan Hanefi, Jeffrey Sachs, Bernard Lewis, Richard Clogg, and Norman Stone. Among others were Danish Social Democratic Party Chairman Svend Auken, French Minister of Education (later prime minister) Lionel R. Jospin, Swedish Foreign Minister Anna Lindh, President of the European Court of Human Rights Luzius Wildhaber, and German Foreign Minister Joschka Fischer. These interviews were also collected in another book titled *Turkey's Witnesses: Those Who Look from Outside*. (Timaş, Istanbul 2002)

These books received fair criticism. İlhan Kesici, who would later serve as a member of parliament from ANAP and CHP after serving as undersecretary of the State Planning Organization, said he did not find the interviews satisfying; that it was not good that I included them in the books in their abbreviated forms as published in newspapers rather

than in their entirety. He was right. I should mention a serious weakness of mine on this occasion. Yes, in the 1960s and 1970s, during my period when I was intellectually Marxist, communist, even Maoist, I may have refrained from collecting the articles published in magazines and newspapers in books (on the grounds that they no longer represented me). But I regret not turning into books the articles I published during my liberal social democratic period after the 1980s, when I advocated for libertarian and pluralist democracy, despite receiving offers from some publishers. The main reason for this may be my nature that always prefers to look forward. The other reason why there are very few books bearing my signature is that I could not find the time to conduct studies that I would believe were worth publishing.

Among the famous politicians I met, I remember Anna Lindh with great sadness. I conducted two interviews with her: The first was during her first visit to Istanbul when she was still the leader of the Swedish Social Democratic Youth Organization (*Cumhuriyet*, January 7, 1990), the second was when she came as Swedish Foreign Minister (*Milliyet*, February 22, 2000). At the time, it was believed that Lindh would be Sweden's next prime minister, but unfortunately, on September 11, 2003, like Prime Minister Olof Palme in 1986, she fell victim to a senseless assassination. Afterwards, I wrote: "I will not remember Anna Lindh only as one of the brightest politicians Sweden has produced. Anna Lindh had a special interest in and sympathy for Turkey. (Had she not died, she was coming to our country next month for a vacation with her family.) In our last meeting, she had also emphasized that a Turkey meeting the Copenhagen political criteria could not be excluded from the EU, that there was no turning back from the process that began with Helsinki (See *Zaman*, February 11, 2003)… Prime Minister Göran Persson said the following after Anna Lindh's death: 'Social democracy has lost one of its most skillful politicians. The Swedish government has lost one of its most talented ministers and colleagues; Sweden has lost its face to the world.' Turkey also lost a friend." (*Zaman*, September 13, 2003)

"The Martin Luther of Islam"

One of the thinkers who influenced me considerably was Abdülkerim Soruş, the Iranian theologian and philosopher of science who is also known as "the Martin Luther of Islam" and is a leading representative of the reform in Islam or Islamic liberalism movement. My first interview with him was published under the title "Rights come before belief" (*Milliyet*, August 14, 1995). Eleven years later, in 2006, I had the opportunity to meet with him again and had written the following about him:

"We know that all religions, including Islam, have both fundamentalist and reformist interpretations. It can be said that fundamentalist interpretations adhere to the letter, that is, the word, of sacred texts; while reformist interpretations take the spirit, that is, the meaning, of sacred texts as their basis. Dr. Abdülkerim Soruş, the Iranian theologian and philosopher of Islam and science, rejects the views that he is the 'intellectual father' of the 'reformist' inclined clergy in his country; but there is no doubt that he is the leading representative of libertarian, liberal Islamic thought.

"It is possible to summarize Soruş's fundamental ideas in the following points: Islam and democracy are not only compatible, but Islam cannot exist where there is no democracy.

Efforts to produce totalitarian political ideologies from religion are contrary to Islam. Because there is no compulsion in religion; belief based on coercion is not true belief. To be a believer, one must first have the right to believe, have human rights. For an individual to truly believe, they must be free to adopt the faith and, if they wish, to abandon it. For this, religion and state must be separated; neither religion should interfere with the state, nor the state with religion. Secularism in the political sense is not a rival or enemy of religion, but its complement. Sacred texts are divine and unchanging, but their interpretation belongs to human beings and changes. Therefore, there is no interpretation of Islam valid for every place and time; interpretations change over time. Islam does not grant any group, including clergy, the authority to monopolize the interpretation of religion.

“All believers have the right to interpret their beliefs as they wish. Clergy can have no privilege compared to other citizens. In order to free themselves from being spokespersons for official or popular views, they must receive salaries from neither the state nor the people, but earn their living by working. In the West, religion and science clashed, and finally declared a ceasefire; but both benefited from this conflict and learned to be more humble. The interpretations of religion should not contradict science. If a particular interpretation of religion is an obstacle to progress, progress can be encouraged by changing the interpretation. The secret of progress lies in rationalism and the ability to self-criticize.

“Appointed by Khomeini to the Cultural Revolution Council tasked with reorganizing university education programs after the 1979 Islamic Revolution, Soruş resigned from the council in 1983 due to disagreements with the regime and began publishing *Kiyan*, which became the magazine of religious intellectuals in the 1990s. The magazine was closed by the regime in 1998. Soruş not only lost his job at Tehran University, but his lectures also began to be targeted by attacks from regime supporters.

“In response to the pressures he faced, Soruş said ‘Has this country become a place where a professor must risk his life to teach a class or give a lecture? Do we need Galileos and Brunos?’ and left Iran in 2000. He gave lectures at Harvard, Yale, and Princeton universities in the USA, then at Wissenschaftskolleg in Berlin. He is currently a visiting professor at the University of Amsterdam… According to him: The vast majority of the people are content with their situation because they receive a share of the increased oil revenues in recent years. The regime has complete control in the political, economic, and cultural spheres. The differences among political power holders do not carry significant importance. No change should be expected in the established order in Iran for at least the next twenty years.” (“Abdülkerim Soruş and Islamic liberalism,” *Zaman*, December 26, 2006.)

“Erbakan should be tried for racism”

In my articles, I advocated that secularism requires the separation of religion and state, and that for Turkey to be a secular country, the Directorate of Religious Affairs (DİB) should be made autonomous even if not abolished. While supporting the understanding of cultural Islam that respects differences, as represented by the Gülen movement, I

viewed quite critically the Islamist current represented by Necmettin Erbakan and the Welfare Party (RP), which excluded violence but represented a majoritarian understanding of democracy that could turn into majority dictatorship. In the article titled "Erbakan should be tried for racism," which contained my first harsh criticism of Erbakan, after first characterizing Erbakan—who some time earlier had had his bodyguards wash his feet at his summer house in Altınoluk—as "a vulgarized would-be Sultan," I expressed my main criticism as follows:

"His Excellency Necmettin Erbakan, the General Chairman of the Welfare Party, in a propaganda speech he delivered on Tuesday, May 21, on the occasion of the June 2 by-elections, after saying 'We'll be in power in a week, ten days,' decreed: 'If you vote for a party other than Welfare, you vote for the Jews. The martyrs and saints will strike that person!'… On Thursday evening, May 23, a television channel announced: His Excellency Erbakan, in that day's speech, this time decreed that 'those who vote for parties other than RP vote for Armenians, for Israelis.' If Turkey were a true democracy, a secular rule of law state, prosecutors should have immediately taken action to open an investigation against Erbakan under Article 312 of the Turkish Penal Code; the Grand National Assembly should have lifted Erbakan's immunity; courts should have convicted Erbakan for racism. But of course Turkey is neither a true democracy nor a true secular rule of law state. How tragic that the probability of Erbakan being tried for racism is zero… Because Turkey is such a country that, although the constitution, the European Convention on Human Rights which we accept as superior to it, and the laws consider it a crime, practicing racism is effectively legitimate and free. The anti-Semitism of RP spokespersons; their anti-Jewish, racist statements have become so blatant that even some Islamists themselves are disturbed by it; but neither an investigation nor a lawsuit has been opened against them…

"The probability of Erbakan and RP spokespersons being tried and convicted for racism is zero, because Turkey is such a country that the best characterization that this country's emergency governors can find to explain to the people what kind of a calamity the bloody terrorist organization PKK is, is to declare PKK members as 'Armenian'… Just as His Excellency Erbakan and various spokespersons of his party declare Jews as 'evil' as a race, a lineage, at every opportunity, targeting Turkey's citizens of the Jewish faith as enemies…" (*Milliyet*, May 25, 1996)



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Following this article, his lawyers filed a lawsuit against me on the grounds that I had "violated Erbakan's personal rights." As a result of the trial, I was sentenced to 3 months in prison in October 1998. The sentence was first converted to a fine of 2 million 900 thousand liras, and was later pardoned by an amnesty law. The interesting aspect of this incident is that this was the only article of mine that was made the subject of a lawsuit throughout my column-writing career that began in 1982 and ended in 2016.

"Erbakan after the truck"

With the Refahyol coalition government established between the Welfare Party and the True Path Party receiving a vote of confidence on July 8, 1996, Erbakan had assumed the prime ministership. On the evening of November 3, 1996, on the Balıkesir-Bursa highway near Susurluk, as a result of a Mercedes automobile crashing into a truck, police chief Hüseyin Kocadağ, organized crime leader and deep state agent Abdullah Çatlı carrying fake identification, and his girlfriend Gonca Us lost their lives; DYP Şanlıurfa member of parliament Sedat Edip Bucak survived with injuries. The accident exposed the dark relationships in the state-politics-mafia triangle. The public demanded that the dark relationships be illuminated through a civil society action called "One Minute of Darkness for Continuous Light" and with the support of the media. Erbakan, however, chose not to pursue the matter, dismissing it as "nonsense." In my commentary on this subject, I was saying:

"'After the truck,' the most important opportunity that Erbakan captured on paper was, of course, to assume the leadership of the 'clean society, clean politics' demand rising from society; to open a comprehensive investigation aimed at exposing the criminal gangs nested within the state and those who protect them, with all their connections. By doing so, Erbakan could have gained the support of segments whose votes he could never otherwise obtain, and could have opened the door to a vote share of a height he couldn't even dream of in an election whose date he would determine himself. However, 'after the truck,' Erbakan started off by saying 'Nonsense.' Nowadays he is doing everything he can to change the agenda. It is clear that he has no intention of taking advantage of this opportunity that has come before him. He probably sees his main interest in 'burying' the matter." (*Milliyet*, December 17, 1996)

The public outrage at the deep state's cooperation with gangs would eventually pave the way to Erbakan's loss of power and the closure of his party. In light of the facts revealed by the "Susurluk scandal," in the commentary titled *"The state's gangs"* that I would write about two years later, I would write the following:

"Although it is difficult to predict where the 'Susurluk process' will lead, we must stop at this point as a society and make an assessment: As it has emerged, the relationship between the state and the gangs was established by assigning certain outlaw bandits to fight 'communist, ASALA, or Kurdish enemies of the state' through illegal means, through extrajudicial executions. The bandits who were asked to kill for the state soon began killing for their personal interests (in drug-arms smuggling and other sectors) and eventually reached the point of 'rebellion against the state' (in the words of the report

given to Prime Minister Mesut Yılmaz by Prime Ministry Inspection Board Chairman Kutlu Savaş)…

“At this point, the state faced the necessity of bringing under control the ‘monster’ it had itself created. Even if we forget for a moment that fighting ‘enemies of the state’ through illegal means is contrary to morality, the rule of law, and democracy, and evaluate this method only by the measure of ‘effectiveness - achieving the goal,’ the result is a disaster: Is it the ‘enemies of the state’ who suffered the most from this method, or is it the state itself, whose reputation, prestige, and credibility have been shaken, stained by ‘the disgrace of our history’? Who will clean this stain, and how?” (*Milliyet*, August 27, 1998)

At the European Court of Human Rights

One of the most meaningful things I did at *Milliyet* was my articles introducing the European Court of Human Rights. During my first visit to Strasbourg in January 1997, the European Commission of Human Rights and the Court had not yet merged—as they would on January 1, 1998, pursuant to Article 11 of the European Convention on Human Rights—to take the name European Court of Human Rights. Prof. Dr. Şeref Gözübüyük from Ankara University Faculty of Law was a member of the Commission, and Prof. Dr. Feyyaz Gölcüklü from Ankara University Faculty of Political Sciences, who was also my professor, was a member of the Court.

In Strasbourg, I also conducted an interview with Commission Chairman Stephen Trechsel, who was expected to come to Ankara on February 17-18 at the invitation of Welfare Party Justice Minister Şevket Kazan. (During this first visit to Strasbourg, it never crossed my mind that one day I too would have to argue before the European Court of Human Rights that my rights had been violated; but that happened too. You will read the story later.) Trechsel was explaining Turkey’s position before the Commission as follows:

“The countries with the most applications to the Commission are Italy, Poland, and Turkey. Applications from these 3 countries currently constitute approximately half of the total 2500 applications before the Commission. Most applications from Italy are related to the length of trial proceedings. Examinations related to these do not take long. Most applications from Poland are also related to property rights and 80 percent of them are not found admissible… I cannot hide that applications against Turkey have distinctive characteristics. One group of applications belongs to those claiming their relatives were killed by security forces. Some are applications from those claiming they were subjected to ill-treatment or torture by security forces. There are applications related to restrictions on freedom of expression. Of course, there are also complaints of a lighter nature related to non-payment of expropriation compensation.” (*Milliyet*, January 27, 1997)

In the commentary titled “The rule of law is *our* cause” published on the last day of the three-day series of articles, I was saying: “The idea that Turkey could withdraw from the human rights oversight mechanism in the face of adverse decisions by the European Court of Human Rights was first put forward by Prof. Dr. Bakır Çağlar, Turkey’s former lawyer at Strasbourg (in the interview Yavuz Baydar conducted with him and published

on this page)… It cannot be considered possible that any government could take such a step that would mean Turkey completely giving up EU membership; and, much more importantly, turning its back on the 200-year struggle for modernization and democratization…

"Instead of making threats to withdraw from European human rights oversight, Turkey should aim to conform to the European Convention on Human Rights, which it made part of its domestic law by ratifying it as early as 1954, to the protocols attached to it, and to other human rights conventions signed within the framework of the Council of Europe. For this, it should make the necessary changes in its laws and constitution. The existence of the European human rights oversight mechanism should be seen not as a burden for us, but as a blessing that supports our establishment of the rule of law… What befits Turkey is to make the European Convention on Human Rights, the fundamental document of contemporary democracy, dominant in its law." (*Milliyet*, January 29, 1997)

Although Turkey accepted in 1987 the right of its citizens claiming their human rights were violated to apply to the Commission, and in 1990 the jurisdiction of the Court, judicial organs can still act as if ECHR decisions do not exist even in 2021 when these lines are being written; the President can also say that ECHR decisions are not binding. Rıza Türmen, who served as a judge of the European Court of Human Rights from 1998 to 2008, wrote the following exactly 24 years after I penned the series of articles I referred to above: "Those who argue that ECHR decisions are not binding are not only saying they will not comply with the rules of the game, they also want the rules of the game to be adjusted to their views…" ("Are ECHR decisions binding?," *T24*, January 1, 2021) These lines are extremely instructive in showing that Turkey is progressively regressing in the field of human rights.

Post-modern coup

With the Refahyol coalition government established between the Welfare Party and the True Path Party receiving a vote of confidence on July 8, 1996, Necmettin Erbakan had assumed the prime ministership. However, the military-dominated National Security Council soon, with its decisions on February 28, 1997, forced the government to resign on the grounds that it had practices against secularism. The military's interventions in the political process on May 27, 1960, March 12, 1972, and September 12, 1980 were "modern" in nature, meaning that, albeit in different ways, they overthrew the government in power and installed new ones in its place. The decisions taken by the National Security Council on February 28, 1997, however, were 'post-modern' in nature (in Cengiz Çandar's expression), because they merely forced the government to resign. Prime Minister Erbakan would not be able to withstand the military's pressure and would submit his resignation on June 18, 1997.

Despite my principled opposition to military interference in politics, following the National Security Council's February 28 decisions, I was writing the following in the article titled "Erbakan and democracy":

“Prime Minister Erbakan explained his understanding of democracy at the last RP parliamentary group meeting: ‘What is democracy? First, sovereignty belongs unconditionally and without reservation to the nation. No one can stand before the nation and impose conditions or reservations. They will respect the nation’s decision… Second, the essential thing is the nation, not the state. The state exists to serve the nation. Third, we will believe in the principle that large majorities do not unite in error…’ It is clear that this definition does not conform to the liberal (that is, freedom-oriented and pluralist) understanding of democracy that is valid in contemporary democracies, that is, in countries that are members of the Council of Europe, NATO, and the European Union… In liberal democracies, there are ‘conditions and reservations’ on sovereignty. The right to govern / power belongs to the party or parties that receive the majority vote. On the other hand, individuals / citizens have fundamental rights and freedoms that cannot be violated by any government, by any majority no matter how large. Liberal democracy is majority rule limited by human rights…

“It is clear that Erbakan’s definition of democracy accepts the principle of ‘majority rule’ but excludes the principle of ‘fundamental rights and freedoms that cannot be violated by any majority.’ It is obvious that such a definition is prone to the mentality of ‘majority dictatorship,’ where ‘a government that has the support of the majority can do whatever it wants’… However, we cannot hold only Erbakan and the movement he belongs to responsible for the insufficient development in our country of the awareness that contemporary democracy also has the principle of ‘fundamental rights and freedoms’ equivalent to the principle of ‘majority rule.’ In light of recent events, it is seen that the struggle to establish a contemporary democratic order in Turkey continues not only on the ‘freedoms’ front but also on the ‘majority rule’ front.

“Nevertheless, we can say that a consensus on ‘majority rule’ has been established among Turkey’s civilian-military ruling elites. (Since the transition to the multi-party system, those who lost elections transferred power to those who won; the military, which seized power directly or indirectly three times, transferred governance to civilians after a relatively short period.) Our main problem in the field of democratization (which also prevents the full establishment of the principle of ‘majority rule’) is that the awareness of the individual’s fundamental rights and freedoms has not taken sufficient root… Why could what is called ‘the essence of liberalism,’ that is, the awareness of the individual’s fundamental rights and freedoms, not fully take hold? Probably one important reason… The Turkish Enlightenment movement’s neglect of adopting the doctrine of human rights from the Enlightenment Movement in the West.” (*Milliyet*, March 4, 1997)

In short, I was not saying an unconditional “no” to the February 28 intervention.

Is Blair imitating Erbakan

In another article where I attacked Erbakan, I was making the following commentary reflecting my understanding of the religion-politics relationship:

“Prime Minister Erbakan reportedly said: ‘Look at what Blair says: I am committed to religious beliefs… Everything comes from love and faith, never mind leftism… They are imitating RP.’ There is no doubt that RP leader Erbakan has cracked another one of his

jokes that make us all laugh. But his words, frankly, also have a serious side. That is Blair's commitment to religious beliefs. The socialism adopted by the British prime minister is (unlike the Marxists' understanding of"scientific" socialism) an ethical socialism; one of the sources of this ethics is also religion. Blair, of course, is not the first social democrat to say this. The Socialist International's Declaration of 1951, about half a century ago, also said this.

"But is Blair imitating Erbakan, or should Erbakan take as an example Blair (who in no way makes his religious beliefs material for political struggle)? This question brings us to one of the topics we have been intensely discussing recently, the religion-politics relationship. It can be said that we have reached clarity that secularism means the separation of religion and state, freedom of belief, and the state being equidistant from all beliefs (and non-believers); and that secularism is a necessary but not sufficient condition for democracy. But there is no clarity on the separation of religion and politics. My view is as follows: A politician should be moral. One of the most important sources of morality (though not the only one) is the values that religion instills, such as respect for creation, for life, 'sin and merit,' love, solidarity, acting justly, honesty, not lying… Could there be anything more desirable than politicians being committed to these values?

"But, if a politician declares those who don't vote for his party as 'infidels / irreligious'… If he denigrates and demeans citizens of other faiths (for example Jews and Armenians)… If he presents religion as if it were the 'property' of his party… If he turns faith into ideology… If his statements are inconsistent with each other… If he does not act honestly… If he uses religious feelings for 'vote hunting' and does the exact opposite of what religion instills… That politician is exploiting religion. For these reasons, in the eyes of many of us, Erbakan is an 'exploiter of religion'; a politician who harms both politics and religion…

"His 'supplications, ritual prayers, pilgrimages to Mecca' hold no value in the eyes of many of us beyond being 'political shows.' Another point we have not clarified in the context of religion and politics is the claim put forward mostly by those among us who adhere to positivist philosophy, that 'religious belief, thought, and education lead to an authoritarian mindset'… When we remember that various authoritarian and totalitarian ideologies, primarily communism and racism, were based entirely on secular belief, thought, and education, there is nothing in this claim to be taken seriously.

"To attempt to identify the religion of Islam with Islamism because of the efforts of Islamist currents that strengthened in the 1980s to interpret Islamic faith (just like communism and racism) as an absolutist political ideology is, to put it mildly, nonsense. Marxists and other types of positivists may see religion, including Islam, as 'the opium of the people'; they may find Islam as religion and culture 'much more dangerous' than political Islam (which is ultimately worldly). This view should be met with respect, like all views. However, with such an understanding, it is not possible to explain the contrast between Islam as a religion and political Islam. Nor to understand what is happening in society…" ("Blair and Erbakan," May 8, 1997)

Closing the RP would be wrong

I was not saying an unconditional “no” to February 28, but I was taking a stance against the closure of RP and listing its “drawbacks” as follows: “1) It could play into the Islamists’ hands. Voters who see that the other parties have made no progress toward solving fundamental problems may, in order to punish them, turn in greater numbers to the party that will replace RP. 2) It will not help voters who put their hopes in it understand RP’s opportunist and demagogic identity and its lack of any solution for Turkey’s problems; the exposure of RP’s true colors will be postponed. 3) Suppression may lead some Islamists who have until now been moderate to radicalization. For these reasons, closing RP would be wrong. RP is actually a moderate party that rejects violence. Like all movements that exclude violence, Islamists should also have freedom of expression and organization. Those within this movement who advocate violence and undemocratic methods should not be left unpunished. However, Islamists should be given the opportunity to ‘democratize by living democracy.’” (*Milliyet*, December 18, 1997)

In the article I wrote upon the closure of RP by the Constitutional Court on January 18, 1998, I was also making the following commentary: “I have long thought as follows: The political current represented by RP cannot be excluded from democracy. The anti-democratic tendencies of this current can only be remedied through being ‘disciplined’ within democracy, over time. In democracies, freedom of organization is certainly not unlimited. Parties that do not play the game according to the rules can be closed. However, it cannot be said that RP generally ‘does not play the game according to the rules.’ It is clear that RP has members who ‘do not play the game according to the rules.’ The main ones among these are the RP members of parliament whose parliamentary memberships the Constitutional Court decided to revoke. These members, even if they are the party’s general chairman, should be held accountable before the judiciary for their statements and behaviors that violate the rules of the game… The collective punishment of the party is controversial in terms of legal principles and is politically objectionable because it does not benefit the establishment and strengthening of democracy in Turkey.” (*Milliyet*, January 20, 1998)

“Sèvres Syndrome”

On April 27, 1997, I participated in an international conference at Oxford University’s St. Antony’s College on the topic “Which way Turkey now?” and gave a talk titled “Turkey’s European vocation: Elite and mass perceptions.” In this talk, I focused on a book published by the General Staff with the note “The views contained in this work are entirely the personal views of the author and do not reflect the views of the TAF that published the work,” but with the recommendation that it “be utilized as a reference document and auxiliary source.” The book in question, titled “The Middle East in the Light of International Relations: Lands Sought to Be Partitioned and People Exploited,” written by a colonel, was a sharp example of the belief, quite widespread among Turkey’s military-civilian elites, that Western states are constantly conspiring to divide and partition Turkey, also known as the “Sèvres Syndrome.” In the article I wrote upon returning home from the conference, I was saying:

“I am sure that the views expressed (in this book) do not dominate the TAF. Nevertheless, it is noteworthy that views reflecting deep suspicion and distrust toward Western allies come from within the institution believed to be the most ‘Westernist’ of a country that has been a NATO member for about 50 years. But it is not at all surprising. Because we frequently hear these views or similar ones from various party spokespersons, primarily RP, DSP, and MHP, from ministers, from former presidents and chiefs of general staff, and we frequently read them in newspaper columns. President Süleyman Demirel, whom leftists in the 1960s and 1970s nicknamed ‘Morrison Süleyman’ because they found him too close to the USA, also expressed similar views in May 1995. He said: The West wants to divide Turkey, to bring back Sèvres… (At the conference in Oxford) In my talk on the psychological dimension of Turkey-West relations, I emphasized the above point. My purpose was to remind our Western friends that Turkey cannot be regarded as ‘in the bag.’” (*Milliyet*, May 9, 1996)

If we look at where Turkey-West relations have arrived today, about a quarter century after this article was published, it can be said that this reminder was quite apt. In January 2021, when these lines were being written, not only had Turkey’s hope for EU membership virtually disappeared, but the USA’s new secretary of state, Blinken, was also referring to Turkey as a “so-called ally.” (Newspapers, January 20, 2021)

Military solution

One of the most exciting events of my journalism career was the trip I participated in between November 17-20, 1997, at the invitation of the General Staff’s Press-Publication-Public Relations and Promotion Department, covering the bases of soldiers fighting against the PKK in the Southeast. We, the nearly 30 journalists participating in the trip, flew on a military plane from Ankara to Van. From there, by helicopter, we flew to Dağlıca, Köprülü, Mezraa, Gürvil Mountain, Şenoba, Siyahkaya, Çalışkan, Şırnak, Namaz Mountain, Siirt, Doğanköy, Okçular, over Lice to Diyarbakır, and then returned to Ankara by plane. According to information provided by the General Staff, we flew a total of 9 hours and 45 minutes on this trip and covered 2,205 km. I would also express my observations and impressions about the trip in a series of articles.

In the article I sent from Şırnak, I was saying: “As far as I can see, the main message that the commanders conducting the fight against separatist terrorism want conveyed to the public is this: The armed forces have achieved significant success in the fight against terrorism at the cost of great material and moral sacrifice; terrorism has essentially been brought under control. However, for the success to be permanent and for the swamp that breeds terrorism to be drained, it is now time for socio-economic measures that need to be taken without delay. What is meant by this is essentially the provision of job opportunities that will pave the way for the welfare of the region’s people. In short, the soldiers are saying, ‘We have largely implemented what is called the “military solution.” Now it’s time for the civilian solution…’” (*Milliyet*, November 21, 1997)

In the article I sent from Köprülü near Hakkari, I was also writing the following:

“Brigadier General Fikri Gönültaş, commander of the 1st Commando Brigade stationed in Çukurca, is giving a briefing to journalists participating in the press tour organized by the General Staff about the fight against the PKK. At one point he says: ‘We are aware that whoever wins the people will succeed…’ Here is the most concise expression of what we call the civilian solution: Winning the people… If macroeconomic stability is achieved, if obstacles to investments are removed, if the country becomes attractive for both domestic and foreign investors… If the economic incentives promised to the Southeast and East are fully and expansively implemented… If progress is made in the GAP project… Then we can achieve the development drive that will eliminate the swamp that breeds terrorism, that is, unemployment and poverty. This would be a very important breakthrough toward the civilian solution, that is, winning the people.

“However, economic development is not enough to solve the Kurdish problem underlying the ‘PKK problem,’ that is, to ‘win the people.’ I do not think those governing Turkey have yet grasped that the problem has a psychological dimension in addition to its military and socio-economic dimensions. Because we have been able to go little beyond words in recognizing Kurdish identity, we are unfortunately far from being able to say that the region’s people have been psychologically won. Without resolving the Kurdish problem, that is, without recognizing the right of Kurds to freely develop their language and culture; without opening the opportunity for Kurdish nationalists who reject violence to freely participate in democratic competition, we cannot win the people, we cannot fully solve the PKK problem. The problem is, of course, not one that can be solved immediately tomorrow. It is long-term and multi-faceted. We have come a long way on the military front. It is time for progress on the other fronts as well. This is the task not of the army, but of the civilian administration.” (*Milliyet*, November 22, 1997)

Civilian solution

In the general assessment I wrote after returning to Istanbul from the trip, I was drawing attention to the following points: “It was understood that the Southeast Anatolia Press Tour organized by the General Staff had two main purposes: to convey to the public in the most effective way 1) that the security forces, primarily the TAF, have managed to bring separatist terrorism under control to a certain level after a 13-year struggle with a very high moral and material cost; and 2) that military measures alone, the ‘military solution,’ are not sufficient to completely overcome separatist terrorism; that the fight against terrorism also requires a multi-dimensional, multi-fronted ‘civilian solution’… Regardless of what they mean by ‘civilian solution,’ the fact that the military no longer insists on the idea that ‘military solution’ is the sole and sufficient solution is, undoubtedly, a new stage on the way toward solving Turkey’s main problem. Unfortunately, we lack a civilian administration that would take the soldiers’ message and act on it, a strong and stable government…

“The soldiers have largely accomplished the task that fell to them and brought separatist terrorism under control to a certain level. But have the region’s people been won? Or, as some claim, is the PKK retreating militarily while advancing politically? The visible economic revival I encountered when I stopped in Diyarbakır on the way back from the ‘Press Tour’ was hopeful. Learning that MED-TV, the mouthpiece of separatist terrorism,

was the most-watched television station in the region was like a cold shower. Why do the state and the region's people still not have television and radio stations that broadcast in Kurdish and thus can address the entire population of the region? Why can Kurdish music be played on local television channels but Kurdish cannot be spoken? Why does the PKK's propaganda go unanswered? Is there any way to explain this?" ("Winning the People," *Milliyet*, November 27, 1997)

"On Life's Path"

During the Southeast press tour, I had the opportunity to meet and chat with many officers and soldiers. One of them was an officer who at the time held the rank of Gendarmerie Staff Captain. In the letter he later sent me, he was saying: "Dear professor, I have just returned to Diyarbakır from duty and I am reading your article titled 'On Life's Path.' It is impossible not to agree with you. Hopefully, we will learn to tolerate each other, to discuss like human beings, to look at each other with tolerance. But I think we are slowly learning. Because in this country, there is both a spouse and bread for all of us. We need only one thing: Good administrators who can put the country's interests ahead of their own interests. My hope is that young people who understand your and Professor Taha's thoughts will be raised soon. Respectfully, Y.K."

In my article triggered by this letter that pleased me, I was referring to Taha Akyol's latest book with the same title (Milliyet Publications, November 1997) and saying: "*On Life's Path* is Taha Akyol's book consisting of articles discussing the experiences he wants to share with young people and the lessons he has drawn from them. With these articles, Akyol, based on his own personal experiences, those of our generation, and those of other domestic and foreign generations, calls on young people who have been captivated by the 'spell of ideology' (Islamist, Revolutionary, Idealist, Ummahist, Communist, Turkist, or Kurdist) to break the spell and take the path of critical reason; to live for ideals instead of dying for ideology. He also tries to explain to society and the state the importance of approaching young people 'with understanding' and giving them the opportunity to free themselves from the spell (which they have been captivated by partly due to their psychology).

"Akyol and I are two members of the same generation who, after having been at the far extremes of the right and left ideological wings, drew similar conclusions from our experiences. The point where we met after drawing these conclusions was liberal democratic values. Perhaps he remained somewhat attached to local and conservative sensibilities; perhaps I preserved to some extent universal and reformist sensibilities. But we both abandoned dogmas and settled on critical rationalism…

"I completely agree with Akyol. Unfortunately, despite all the local and universal experience; despite the years, lives, generations spent on this path, we have not been able to establish in our country the understanding that human beings are 'fallible,' that what we think is right today may turn out to be wrong tomorrow; the questioning, skeptical, critical, rational, that is, scientific mentality. As a society, we still have not understood that perhaps the essential measure of contemporary civilization is being able

to criticize oneself; that freedom-oriented democracy is above all ‘the regime that makes it possible to turn back from mistakes, to correct wrongs.’

“Some still prefer ‘dying rather than turning back’ from mistakes; those who consider changing one’s mind as immorality, those who say ‘Shoot those who abandon the Cause!’ can still gain respect. Unfortunately, we have still not been able to establish in Turkey respect for the individual, for the rights and freedoms of the individual. We have not grasped that the subject of freedom can be none other than the individual. We have not transcended the discourse of the ‘freedom’ of the class, the people, the nation, the ummah, the community, identities, etc. The only thing we can take consolation in is that dogmatism and the ‘spell of ideology’ have perhaps retreated a little more today compared to the days when we were young.” (*Milliyet*, December 27, 1997)

A few weeks after returning from the Southeast Press Tour, a kilim sent as a gift from the Gendarmerie Public Order Command arrived at my address by cargo. With the following note: “Dear Şahin Alpay, the motifs on this kilim woven by the beautiful people of the Southeast are the most original symbols of our unity and integrity woven with love. With our wishes that it reminds you of the region’s beauty that lives on despite everything, and of those who have ‘sworn an oath’ to protect it at the cost of their lives. Respectfully. Lieutenant General Çetin Doğan.” (The same Çetin Doğan was promoted to full General in 1999 and appointed to the Aegean Army Command. Later, while he was the 1st Army Commander, it was claimed that he had prepared the “Sledgehammer coup plan”; he was also retired in 2003. On August 19, 2021, he was arrested as one of 14 officers who received life sentences in the February 28 trial in which he was prosecuted.)

At Princeton University

When I returned to the country after completing my doctorate at Stockholm University, I had not been able to find an opportunity to continue my academic career and had to take refuge in the press. Continuing an academic career must have remained an unfulfilled aspiration within me, because at the suggestion and encouragement of my late friend Mustafa Gürsel, I taught an elective course on “Opinion Writing” at Anadolu University Faculty of Communication in the fall semester of 1987. When I left *Cumhuriyet* in 1992, again with Gürsel’s encouragement, I had applied for the one-year fellowship that the Nieman Foundation of Harvard University offers to journalists for their professional renewal, but I was quite disappointed to receive a negative response.

In the spring semester of 1994, at the suggestion and encouragement of Prof. Binnaz Toprak, who was then the department chair, I taught an elective course on “Politics in Scandinavia” at Boğaziçi University’s Department of Political Science. This was a kind of consolation gift that Binnaz offered me to remedy the “defeat” I had suffered in the associate professorship examination that I had entered at Hikmet Özdemir’s encouragement despite being completely unprepared. The most valuable of the opportunities my friends provided for returning to academia was the invitation by Prof. Şükrü Hanioğlu, the chairman of the Department of Near Eastern Studies at Princeton University, one of America’s leading universities, to teach an elective course on politics in Turkey to graduate students in the spring semester of 1998.

I first disclosed the invitation from Hanioğlu to Derya Sazak. Derya said let me raise the matter with the boss (Aydın Doğan); then he told me to see the boss. I called his secretary; after being made to wait for a few days, I was granted an audience. He treated me with his usual distance, but he responded quite positively to the invitation I had received. He even said "We'll announce with fanfare that you're going to Princeton." I was pleased. Indeed, Derya Sazak announced that I was going with a short news item he put on the front page. We agreed with Derya that I would continue writing my column three days a week and leave the editorship of the page to Nilüfer, with Naki Özkan assisting her. At the beginning of February, Fatma and I went to Princeton, and in the spring semester that lasted until June, I taught a course on "Politics in Turkey in the Multi-party Period."

What made it possible for me to go to Princeton was the financial support provided by the foundation established with the donation made by brothers Ahmet and Nasuhi Ertegün to Princeton University's Near Eastern Studies Department in order to perpetuate the name of their late father Münir Ertegün (one of the former ambassadors to Washington). The Münir Ertegün Foundation, established in 1994 to encourage Turkey studies, was managed by a committee. At that time, the chairman of the committee was Şükrü Hanioğlu, and its members were the famous historian Bernard Lewis and Abraham Udovitch. The foundation organized conferences and panels each academic year; provided financial support to researchers; and occasionally invited academics or experts to Princeton for one or two semesters to teach.

(A piece of information I want to share about Princeton University is this: With a decision taken in June 2020, the university's board of trustees removed Woodrow Wilson's name from one of its faculties because of his "racist views and policies." Yet Wilson was someone who served as president of Princeton University from 1902 to 1910, as President of the United States from 1912 to 1920, and received the Nobel Peace Prize in 1919 for the principles he announced before the USA entered World War I…)

In Princeton, we settled into one of the residences rented to university employees. Although Fatma was a bit bored in the first days, she later got used to the environment; she was quite happy with the visits first of our daughter Elvan and our then one-year-old granddaughter Defne, and later of our relatives including my elder sister Olcay and my brother-in-law Ünal. In Princeton, we formed lasting friendships with Ali and Nazlı Karaosmanoğlu and the couple Heath and Demet Lowry. Lowry, whom I had met during his teaching at Boğaziçi University, was teaching Turkish political life courses at Princeton. Karaosmanoğlu, whom I had met during his teaching at Bilkent, was conducting research at Princeton's Woodrow Wilson School of Public and International Affairs.

The Near Eastern Studies department where I was a guest was located in Princeton's building called Jones Hall. The small office assigned to me here had an interesting history: Albert Einstein, one of the pioneers in natural sciences, had used this office for a short time during his faculty position at Princeton in the 1930s.

The six months I spent at Princeton contributed significantly to my getting to know the university, academics, society, and politics in the USA. Only five students, one American

and the others Turkish, attended my course, which I gave in the form of seminars lasting several hours once a week. There was nothing surprising about this, because most graduate courses were conducted with a small number of students. This experience would be good preparation for the Turkish Political Life course I would begin teaching at Bahçeşehir University a few years later.

Meeting Bernard Lewis

During the time I spent at Princeton, I had the opportunity to meet some world-renowned American academics. The most famous of these was certainly the Near Eastern historian Bernard Lewis (1916-2018), who taught at Princeton from 1972 to 1986. Lewis was known in Turkey primarily as the author of the book *The Emergence of Modern Turkey*, which is the basic reference work for Turkey's modernization history courses, and as the famous historian who rejected the "Armenian genocide" thesis. The fact that Lewis characterized what happened to Ottoman Armenians in 1915-1916 as "terrible holocaust" in the 1961 and 1968 first editions of his book on Turkey, and as "terrible slaughter" in later editions, had been quite controversial; it was alleged that he engaged in "historical revisionism" for his political and personal interests. Palestinian-American social scientist Edward Said had also characterized Lewis's works as leading examples of "Orientalism" (that is, Western experts looking at Middle Eastern peoples with a gaze that distorts their reality and others them). Lewis would also be a historian debated internationally as one of the mentors who encouraged US President George W. Bush's attack on Iraq in 2003.

During the months I was at Princeton, I met with Lewis several times. In one of these meetings, Lewis told me that he had written an article that he never intended to publish in response to the criticisms directed at him by Armenian circles in the USA, and that he wanted to show it to me, but unfortunately he did not keep this promise. In the interview I conducted with him, published in *Milliyet* under the title "Building democracy is not easy," he was saying: "Although Turkey has suffered many difficulties, it has established a functioning democracy. It hasn't solved all its problems yet, but it is quite successful compared to other Muslim countries in the region… I believe Islam is compatible with liberal democracy. But this is a theoretical, not a historical proposition. Today, only one of the 56 members of the Organization of the Islamic Conference, Turkey, is a democracy." (*Milliyet*, May 4-5, 1998.) At the time I conducted this interview, Lewis was 82 years old and his mind was working brilliantly. I had also heard that he was living with a woman about 40 years younger than himself. He would live another 20 years until he died at the age of 102.

One of the famous figures I met and became somewhat acquainted with at Princeton was Professor Norman Itzkowitz. Itzkowitz was best known for the book "Immortal Atatürk" (1984) that he co-authored with Vamık Volkan. About the book, he was saying: "Unfortunately, history is written without any reference to psychology. Yet we all know that individual psychology plays a major role in our lives. What we did in this book was to approach Atatürk as a human being…" Itzkowitz and Volkan would later publish another book called *Turks and Greeks: Neighbours in Conflict* (1994).

Professor Abraham Udovitch, an expert on Near Eastern Jewish history, was one of the department members who showed me warmth and with whom I conversed. I also met his wife Lucette F. Valensi at a dinner. Tunisian-born Valensi was at that time a faculty member at École des Hautes Études en Sciences Sociales, one of France's leading schools, and the author of many works on "Islam in the Mediterranean." Her works "Venice and the Sublime Porte" and "Islam in Revolt" had also been translated into Turkish.

"Greece should advocate for Turkey's EU membership"

At Princeton, lunch breaks were not wasted; meetings were held during almost every lunch break where a speaker was invited and refreshments were served to participants. The subject of one of the meetings I attended was "US Policy toward Turkey, Greece, and Cyprus," and the speaker was Monteagle Stearns, one of the USA's former ambassadors to Athens. Among those who came to attend the meeting was also Mrs. Margarita Papandreou, the American-born former wife of Greece's late prime minister Andreas Papandreou. I was quite surprised when Mrs. Papandreou took the floor during discussions and said, "For the resolution of the problems between them, Greece should be the leading advocate of Turkey's EU membership."

Following the brief chat I had with her after the meeting, I would write as follows: "Mrs. Papandreou complains that Greek politicians cannot see that if Greece takes the lead in Turkey's accession to the EU, the resolution of Turkish-Greek problems would be facilitated. Mrs. Papandreou, who plays an important role in the Greek women's movement, is determined to work for Turkish-Greek rapprochement. We may see the first examples of this in the coming days. As is known, Margarita Papandreou is the mother of Greece's alternate foreign minister George Papandreou." (*Milliyet*, February 24, 1998)

I had the opportunity to listen to many famous speakers at conferences organized at Princeton. One of them was the late Prof. Dr. Halil İnalcık, one of the greatest of our Ottoman historians. I would convey an anecdote from his speech as follows: "İnalcık stated that in today's Turkey it is not possible to write an objective, scientific work on either Fatih (Sultan Mehmed the Conqueror) or Atatürk. I couldn't help but ask: 'Why is that?!' The Professor's answer was good: 'As you know, these days it is said that freedom of expression is restricted in Turkey…' Perhaps the most important of the points the Professor emphasized was this: Turkey suffers greatly from two types of bigotry. The first of these is 'revolutionary' bigotry. This bigotry misunderstands Islam and Turkish society. It assumes that the masses attached to their traditions and beliefs do not exist. Because of the mistakes of such bigots, the great mass is being pushed toward the sphere of influence of the second type of bigots, the 'Sharia advocates.'" (*Milliyet*, May 17, 1998)

Visiting the New York Times

Princeton was quite close to New York City; it was possible to reach it in less than an hour by train. Fatma and I made this trip quite frequently. On one of these trips, I visited *The New York Times* and met two of the newspaper's unsigned editorial writers, that is,

two of its “anonymous heroes.” The subject they were most curious about was how relations between the Islamists and the military, the guardian of the official ideology, would proceed after the closure of RP and its replacement by the Virtue Party. After noting that there were optimists who believed the Islamists had learned their lesson from February 28 and pessimists who did not believe so, I conveyed what I had said in my *Milliyet* column as follows:

“I find the pessimists too pessimistic and the optimists too optimistic. Virtue’s future will probably be somewhere between the two. But still, we should continue to remind the Islamists of the lessons to be learned from their experiences and their responsibilities. FP can certainly continue to criticize interpretations that turn secularism into ‘hostility to religion,’ as well as ‘imitation of the West’ and policies indexed to the West. It can continue to defend our history and our distinctive identity. But FP should reject RP’s bad legacy. It should bury in history the nonsense of ‘multiple legal systems’ and ‘just economic order.’ It should adopt secularism, which means the state being equidistant from all religions and beliefs and freedom for all beliefs. It should abandon racism and anti-Semitism. It should give up wanting freedom only for itself. It should internalize liberal democracy based on human rights and freedoms, including secularism. It should not harbor those who do not adopt these principles. Then FP can see that it is playing a beneficial role not only in Turkey but in the entire Islamic world.” (*Milliyet*, March 12, 1998)

Busy agenda

During my time at Princeton, I was very pleased to receive invitations from many universities to speak on Turkey’s domestic and foreign policy. April was particularly busy. First, I gave two talks to faculty members and students at Princeton’s Near Eastern Studies department. Then I was a guest of the Turkish Student Association at Rutgers University, also in New Jersey. Later I went to the capital Washington DC and spoke successively at the United States Institute of Peace, Johns Hopkins University, George Washington University, and (at the invitation of my friend Prof. Sabri Sayarı) the Foreign Service Institute, the center for training diplomats.

In May, at the invitation of the late Prof. Kemal Karpat, I gave a talk at the University of Wisconsin’s Madison campus. It was a pleasant surprise that our famous surgeon Prof. Münci Kalayoğlu was among the audience. From there I went to Boston and gave a talk at Harvard University’s Kennedy School of Government at the invitation of the renowned Ottoman historian Cemal Kafadar. My last stop was New York. There, I spoke at the Association of Turkish Architects, Engineers, and Scientists. At the meetings I briefly mentioned above, I had very instructive dialogues with both American and Turkish students and faculty members.

Los Alamos

After the seminar I taught at Princeton ended, Fatma and I set out on an approximately ten-day West Coast trip. At our first stop, we visited my sister Jackie from the Wilson family, in whose home I had spent the 1961-62 academic year as an AFS scholarship

student, and her husband Bob MacFarlane at their home in the famous city of Los Alamos in the state of New Mexico. I would write the following about this visit:

“The mystery and secrecy of Los Alamos from the years when the first atomic bombs were made and tested is, of course, gone now. Nevertheless, Jackie’s physicist husband Bob could not obtain the necessary permission for me to tour the laboratories where he had been working for years. Because the work at Los Alamos laboratories is still 60-70 percent ‘for military purposes,’ that is, related to the development of nuclear weapons. (According to what Bob told me, the USA’s signing of the treaty banning tests was creating great ‘distress’ in these circles. Because bomb producers could not find the opportunity to test their products.)…

“Maybe it seemed so to me, but it was as if Los Alamos was still in a state of ‘remorse.’ In the brochure distributed at the Science Museum in the city, which was frequently the scene of demonstrations by Americans opposed to nuclear weapons, it said, ‘We had to use the atomic bomb because the Japanese were the attacking side; they were not willing to surrender; thousands of people were dying every day as long as the war continued; the bomb saved the lives of many more people than it killed.’ When I browsed through the notebook where museum visitors noted their impressions, I encountered the same arguments. I learned there that the scientists of Jewish origin who developed the atomic bomb were opposed to its use against the Japanese after Germany surrendered.” (*Milliyet*, May 26, 1998)

From there we flew to California. First we went to Big Bear Lake and spent two nights with Mollie Wilson, the Wilsons’ mother who always showed me great affection. Then we moved to the Los Angeles coast and met with the eldest son Gordon Wilson and his wife Evie, who lived in Newport Beach. It was interesting that Fatma, like me, found Los Angeles and its surroundings to be the most livable place in the USA. Then we flew to Las Vegas. The young American servicewoman I chatted with during the flight inspired me to write the article titled “Women in America.” I was saying:

Judie and Jackie

“She boarded the plane going from Los Angeles to Las Vegas at 9 pm at the last minute. She was slim, blonde, blue-eyed, quite attractive, and a bit flustered. ‘You were hoping I wouldn’t come, but here I am!…’ she said and sat down next to us, in the window seat. She immediately began to tell her story: When she missed the plane she was supposed to board from Ontario, her friends had rushed her to Los Angeles airport, but they had almost gotten lost on Los Angeles freeways and she had almost missed the plane. When she learned that my wife and I were speaking Turkish between ourselves, she said, ‘I’m learning German, but I wish I were learning Turkish…’ After asking what we were doing in the USA, she told everything about herself: No, she wasn’t going to Las Vegas and had never been there. She would fly to St. Louis on the plane departing from there at midnight; then continue by car, and by dawn arrive at the house where her mother, father, and 5 siblings all younger than her lived; she would spend her fifteen-day leave with them.

“Judie was 18 years old. She belonged to the US Navy’s special forces, the Marines. She had completed her military training and in a month would be sent to the US naval base on Japan’s Okinawa island. No, she didn’t want to spend her life as a marine. She would serve for four years, and during this time would complete the higher education program provided by the Navy through ‘flying professors’ and the internet. This was actually the most important reason for her being a marine. After leaving the Navy, her intention was to find a job at the FBI (the USA’s intelligence organization responsible for internal security). For a woman, being a marine was not difficult at all. Perhaps the hardest part of the job was that there were only 3,000 female marines compared to 176,000 male marines in the Navy…

“The story of the young American woman we met on a plane trip, who came from a small town in the American Midwest and a low-income family, became a marine, and thereby planned to get a higher education and work at the FBI, made one think about the place and role of women in American society. The story of my ‘American sister’ Jackie, whom I visited in Los Alamos, New Mexico, was no less thought-provoking. Jackie grew up in an affluent family in southern California. She studied mathematics at the University of Pittsburgh. In Los Alamos, to which she had become deeply attached after marrying her physicist husband Bob and settling there, she has been teaching mathematics to eighth-grade students for years. In this city at an altitude of about 2,500 meters above sea level, she runs for at least an hour and swims for at least an hour every morning before going to work. In the evenings, she plays the violin in one of the classical music orchestras, as she has done with great pleasure since her youth.

“Jackie has three sons. One is doing a doctorate in philosophy, another in medicine; the youngest is studying economics. All three are competitive swimmers. Jackie doesn’t hide that when they were young, she would get her sons out of bed at 4:30 in the morning and take them to inter-school swimming competitions held at 6:30 in the state capital Albuquerque. Although it may seem like ‘torture’ to some, according to Jackie, this was an important part of her children’s education. And so it must have been… The secret of how the eldest son John, in the years he began studying philosophy at Harvard, could come to Turkey and traverse the Turkish mountains from the Aladağlar to the Kaçkars (by trekking) probably lay here.

“Of course, not all women in the USA are like Judie and Jackie. But one of the most important forces that make the USA what it is, is undoubtedly women like them who contribute to social life in every field. Isn’t one of our greatest hopes for Turkey’s future also the increasing number of women who contribute to social life in every field?” (*Milliyet*, May 29, 1998)

Like everyone who goes there, we had a good time in Las Vegas. I won’t forget the elderly couple we encountered at a casino, who believed that they owed the money pouring out like rain from the slot machine they were playing to the luck we had brought them when we appeared there, and who cheered for us because of it… The night shows at the MGM hotel where we stayed were also as entertaining as only the USA can offer. We had quite a good time here. Then we flew to San Francisco. We stayed three nights

and met with Turkish acquaintances there. The dinners we had at Fisherman's Wharf were perhaps the most enjoyable part of this trip.

In our last weeks at Princeton, our son Acar, who was studying at Bilkent, came to visit us. Following very poor advice, we went with him to Disneyland in Orlando, Florida, and stayed two nights — an unfortunate visit. Orlando was unfortunately unbearable in the June heat. The New York visit I made with Acar, however, was unforgettable. When we went to the very top of one of the World Trade Center buildings that were destroyed by Al-Qaeda attacks on September 11, 2001, I remember how we trembled inside thinking about what could happen if a plane were to hit these tall buildings.

In my article titled "Farewell to Princeton" that appeared after I returned to Turkey, I was saying: "In the articles I sent from Princeton, I wrote more about what was happening in the USA and the world; trying to draw some lessons for Turkey from them… I believe the time I spent here, the experience I gained, made a great contribution to my getting to know American society and politics, and to my quest for approaching events with a global and comparative perspective. During this time, in both the courses I taught and the talks I gave at various distinguished institutions, I tried to reflect the complex reality of Turkey in various aspects and to contribute as much as I could to the establishment of a balanced perspective on Turkey. I did not only talk about Turkey's problems; I also emphasized its great achievements." (*Milliyet*, June 16, 1998)

The articles I wrote from the USA were worth collecting in a book. Why didn't I do so? This must be another manifestation of my habit of not being able to look back.

Milliyet is being sold

We returned home from the USA on June 15, 1998; shortly after, a series of events that would result in the sale of *Milliyet* began to unfold. At the beginning of August, the tender privatizing the public bank called Türkbank was broadcast live on television. The next day, we learned that someone named Korkmaz Yiğit (hereafter KY) had acquired the bank. I had never heard this name. I went to the newspaper's economics desk trying to find out who he was.

The economics desk chief Murat Sabuncu (whom I would meet years later in Silivri prison) said, as if saying something very ordinary, "He's Alaaddin Çakıcı's partner, bro…" That day and the next, I searched for information about who he was in the newspapers; there wasn't any. Someone said he was a rich contractor. Then news about Korkmaz Yiğit also buying E-TV, Kanal D, and Genç TV appeared one after another in the press. When I asked Murat Sabuncu, "Hey Murat, why aren't you doing a story about who this man is?" he said, "Come on bro, maybe 'those above us' (meaning the boss) have some business with him; do you want me to create trouble for us?"…

On the evening of September 12, I was invited to dinner at the home of Stephen Kinzer, the Istanbul bureau chief of the New York Times (NYT). I jokingly said to Kinzer, "Why don't you do a story about who this KY is so we can learn…" When he asked why *Milliyet* wasn't doing it, I conveyed what I had heard from Sabuncu. A few days later,

curious about what reaction I would get, I told Derya Sazak about what I had discussed with Kinzer. He merely said, “Well said, bro!” (!)

Then it was announced that Yiğit had also acquired the newspaper *Yeni Yüzyıl*; rumors spread that he would also buy *Radikal*. I called İsmet Berkan, the Ankara representative who was my friend from *Cumhuriyet*. Berkan said “it would be more reasonable for him to buy *Milliyet* instead of *Radikal* which has no printing press or building”… Then word began to spread that KY was holding talks to buy *Milliyet*. Derya was confirming the rumor but insistently saying he didn’t think it would happen. When I returned from an overseas trip I made between September 16-27, 1998, I would learn that the sale of *Milliyet* to KY had been formalized in a protocol and that the transfer of the newspaper would take place on October 8. Fatma told me that Güneri Cıvaoğlu had called while I was abroad, but I hadn’t paid attention. As I later learned, Cıvaoğlu had been calling *Milliyet* writers saying things like “Don’t worry, everything is under my control…” The general atmosphere among newspaper employees was that they were trying to get used to the new boss. This is how they were talking: KY was said to have a relationship with Alaaddin Çakıcı, but what was wrong with that? He was a rich man… He was giving tremendous raises to salaries… Besides, breaking the cartel wouldn’t be so bad…

The announcement that appeared in the newspaper on October 8, 1998, stated that the process of “transferring the shares of *Milliyet* Gazetecilik A.Ş. and AD Yayıncılık A.Ş., which publishes the magazines of the *Milliyet* Group, to the Korkmaz Yiğit Group” would be completed soon; it was stated that “the total shares of the companies in question were valued at 310 million US dollars and that a preliminary agreement had been reached on the sale of the majority shares based on this price.” On the same day, Aydın Doğan’s farewell article to the effect that “I sold the newspaper because of cartel accusations” was also published in the newspaper. In the following days, Güneri Cıvaoğlu’s column where he wrote “Korkmaz Yiğit used to sell newspapers when he was little” would be followed by articles themed “Welcome Korkmaz Yiğit” by Hasan Pulur, Doğan Heper, Derya Sazak, Yalçın Doğan, and Umur Talu.

On the evening of October 8, the handover ceremony of the newspaper was held. I learned that such a ceremony would be held from the drivers when I was leaving the newspaper in the afternoon. Thinking that I had no business there since I had not been invited, I went home. Yet the ceremony had been held open to all employees on the floor where the restaurants were… As I later learned from Osman Ulagay, who was present at the ceremony, Aydın Doğan had looked sad; KY was so excited that he couldn’t read the text in his hand properly. According to the rumors I heard, after the ceremony, celebrations were held on the top floor occupied by the bosses, with managers and writers attending and champagne corks popping. Cıvaoğlu had played the leading role in the celebrations. When the waiters recounted to him what had happened, Aydın Doğan was terribly resentful…

***Milliyet* is not being sold**

Due to my work, I went to Ayvalık between October 11-13. When I returned to Istanbul on the evening of October 13, something inside nudged me, and instead of going straight home, I stopped by the newspaper to pick up incoming mail. I encountered

people with sullen faces in the newsroom and around it. That day, CHP deputy Fikri Sağlar had released at a press conference in the Grand National Assembly the recording of the telephone conversation (sent to him by mail) between mafia leader Alaaddin Çakıcı and Korkmaz Yiğit. According to the recording, Yiğit, who said he wanted to acquire Türkbank, was asking Çakıcı to eliminate the other bidders from the process… KY's relationship with the mafia had been clearly exposed. What would happen now?.. I immediately went to see Derya Sazak. Derya said, "Of course we will publish the news; tomorrow we'll also get together as writers and decide what to do."

On the morning of October 14, Derya called the newspaper's writers to a meeting in Aydın Doğan's office. I went together with Nilüfer Kuyaş. Also there was a person named Yaşar Eroğul, who was said to have brokered the sale of *Milliyet* from Aydın Doğan to Korkmaz Yiğit, just as he had previously brokered the sale of *Hürriyet* from Erol Simavi to Aydın Doğan. Taha Akyol immediately sidled up to me and advised me not to open my mouth because Aydın Doğan was going to take the newspaper back. I was happy about this news, for after hearing Fikri Sağlar's disclosure, I had decided not to work at a *Milliyet* whose boss was KY.

At the writers' meeting, Derya conveyed that they had gathered to discuss what should be done following Fikri Sağlar's disclosures, that he had met with Aydın Doğan that morning, and that the boss had asked for two days to make a decision. Hasan Pulur and Meral Tamer thanked Derya for publishing the phone recording news as a headline in the newspaper; they asked what Yaşar Eroğul, who had left the room at that moment, was doing at the meeting. Eroğul returned shortly; he said that KY had no concern other than *Milliyet*'s prestige and that he was ready to return the newspaper to Doğan if terms were agreed upon. When Nilüfer asked, "If the newspaper is taken back, are we going to continue as if nothing happened?!", Abbas Güçlü said, "What, are you tired of Aydın Doğan?" The meeting dispersed to wait for the two-day period.

I spoke with Zülfü, who was in Germany. "I've submitted my resignation," he said. He had agreed with Zafer Mutlu to return to *Sabah*. Nilüfer Kuyaş and Nilgün Cerrahoğlu were inclined to resign; I told them I was in favor of waiting. Meanwhile, it was learned that Ali Sirmen and Oktay Akbal would return to *Cumhuriyet*. According to the gossip that reached Derya's ear, Sirmen had said at a meeting that *Milliyet* writers 'wiped their behinds with dollars.' Derya was very angry about this: he spoke of how Sirmen was one of those who drew the most money from the newspaper and spent a significant part of the year in Paris.

Finally, on October 20, it was announced that an agreement had been reached between AD and KY for the return of the newspaper to AD. When Hugh Pope in the *Wall Street Journal* wrote that part of the 310 million dollar sale price had not been returned, AD denied this; Pope then corrected the story. Doğan returned to the newspaper on October 21 with a grand welcome. Almost all employees had gathered at the door. I contented myself with watching the event from my office window. On the evening of October 23, AD gave a "hello again" dinner for the writers. I was in Antalya with the late Sami Kohen for an EU-Turkey journalists' meeting; Sami Bey immediately returned to Istanbul, while I stayed.

A week after the announcement that *Milliyet* would be sold, I had published an article expressing my reaction to this. In the article titled “Milliyet is important,” which summarized my views on the function of media in democracies and the state of media in Turkey, I was saying:

“Freedom of the press and independent and respected media organizations and institutions that exercise this freedom are one of the ‘sine qua non’ conditions of democracy. Because: Citizens receive news about national and world events and the commentary that enables them to make sense of these from the media. It is natural that a democracy can only function well to the extent that citizens are informed, knowledgeable, and have the opportunity to see the truth behind events.

“The media’s ability to properly fulfill the democratic functions mentioned above depends on three main conditions: 1) The constitution and laws must guarantee freedom of the press. 2) The press business is not just any economic enterprise, any money-making pursuit. Media owners are responsible not only for ensuring that their organizations are financially healthy, but also for fulfilling the functions they assume in a democratic society. For journalists, acting in accordance with professional principles carries perhaps even greater importance than it does for other professional groups. The main task of professional organizations is to defend these principles. 3) The media must have institutions that are independent from the state, strong, competing with each other, and have traditions built on professional principles…

“It is clear as day that various practices in Turkish media are incompatible with a pluralist and competitive structure; that not all journalists in Turkey act in accordance with professional principles and ethics. However, despite all these limitations, we know that the media in Turkey plays an even greater role than parliament in monitoring whether political and economic power holders are acting in accordance with laws and ethics, and that the media is perhaps the most important force of democracy in Turkey. The media’s ability to fulfill its functions is the most important guarantee for the future of democracy in our country. The media’s ability to fulfill its democratic functions is possible with strong, reliable, respected media organizations and institutions. *Milliyet* newspaper, as old as our democracy, is undoubtedly one of the foremost of these organizations and institutions. To protect and develop these qualities of *Milliyet* is perhaps the duty of us, its employees, more than of anyone else.” (*Milliyet*, October 15, 1998)

I have thought that the above article of mine played a role in my employment at *Milliyet* being terminated in a rather ugly manner, in less than three years.

“The Türkbank Scandal”

What would come to be known as the “Türkbank scandal”—a series of events that exposed the “politics-business-media-mafia” relationships in Turkey—would eventually result in former Prime Minister Mesut Yılmaz and former State Minister Güneş Taner being tried before the Supreme Court (Yüce Divan, the Constitutional Court sitting as a high tribunal for trying ministers). The indictment would allege that the defendants “carried out all the arrangements to establish a media order under their control by

committing fraud in the conduct and price formation of the Türkbank tender" and would seek a prison sentence of no less than 10 years.

When I arrived at the newspaper on the morning of December 19, 1998, I learned that Derya Sazak had resigned from his position as editor-in-chief and that Yalçın Doğan had been appointed in his place; Umur Talu would become the publication coordinator. I went to Yalçın and said, "If you want, let's close 'Intellectual Perspective.'" His response—"No, Intellectual Perspective is this newspaper's pride"—both surprised and pleased me. Two days later, he gave a wonderful speech to the newspaper staff: "We will set the bar high; we will make *Milliyet* a quality newspaper committed to professional principles," he said. My relationship with Yalçın had completely improved…

However, a few days later, one morning when I saw that Intellectual Perspective had been replaced by Süleyman Demirel's draft constitutional amendment, the blood rushed to my head. I went to Yalçın in anger and asked what this meant. He said it was just a one-day intervention, but that he might occasionally want to use the page. A few days later, I also saw that the headline I had put on the page had been changed without my knowledge. It was clear that Yalçın wanted to remind me that he was the one running the newspaper; that I didn't have a feudal fiefdom within the paper. I would either herd this camel or leave this land… Where could I go anyway? I chose the former.

My "Brilliant" Year in Journalism: 1999

1999 was a year full of events both for Turkey and for me personally. The year began with Fatma and me going to the Turkish Republic of Northern Cyprus from January 19-22. We met with my old friend Ahmet Aker and his new wife Şule in Kyrenia. Ahmet was serving as Denktaş's advisor at the time. Through an appointment he arranged, on January 21 Fatma and I were invited to lunch with President Rauf Denktaş and his wife. According to Ahmet, this was "a great honor" shown to me. It truly was; until that day, no important politician had ever invited me to a meal. At the lunch, where Ahmet and Şule were also present, Denktaş shared a Demirel anecdote on condition it wouldn't be written. (I think there's no harm in writing it now; neither of them is alive.) Demirel had once told him, "There are people working for the CIA even in our Foreign Ministry, even in the General Staff. So don't believe anything unless you hear it from me…" This was an anecdote consistent with Denktaş's staunch nationalist stance.

My interview with Denktaş was published on January 25-26 with the headline "TRNC President Rauf Denktaş ready for EU membership on condition of confederation." In the interview, Denktaş said: "We are ready to negotiate EU membership on the condition that we enter as a confederation and that they accept us on equal terms with the Greek Cypriots. At the very least, they must acknowledge that the Greek Cypriots do not represent all of Cyprus… Turkey does not need to be an EU member for the TRNC to join the EU."

My interview was also covered in the Wall Street Journal, but unfortunately opportunities continued to be missed in Cyprus. UN Secretary-General Kofi Annan's unification plan for the island was rejected by the Greek Cypriot side in a referendum held in April 2004. The Greek Cypriot Administration, which rejected unification, was made an EU member

on May 1, 2004, representing the entire island no less; Greece's threat to veto EU enlargement if Cyprus was not included paved the way for the island's permanent division.

At the Peak of My Reporting Career

At the suggestion of German Ambassador Joachim Vergau, who served in Ankara from 1995 to 2000, I went to Germany as an invited guest in the first week of February 1999. The necessary appointments had been arranged for me to conduct various interviews. The most important of these was with Foreign Minister Joschka Fischer. In the interview published in *Milliyet* with the headline "For us, Turkey is a candidate," Fischer said: "Turkey is a very important partner for Europe. From our perspective, it is a candidate for EU membership. However, we have problems. We want to develop relations, and a positive approach from Turkey would make us very happy."

The interview with Fischer was one of my most successful works in the context of "news journalism." Indeed, Yağmur Atsız, who was living in Germany at the time, would write in his column in *Milliyet*: "Şahin Alpay's interview with German Foreign Minister Joschka Fischer in *Milliyet* dated February 3, 1999 unfortunately did not receive the attention it deserved from the public. Yet this was a text carrying important messages beyond any ordinary exclusive interview, one that needed to be carefully analyzed… Germany's first 'Green' Foreign Minister Fischer's interview should be evaluated in connection with the following sentence he said during a speech in parliament shortly before: Germany has acted wrongly in EU-Turkey relations!" (*Milliyet*, February 10, 1999)

Fischer's words were truly important; they signaled the process that would begin at the end of that year with Turkey being declared an EU candidate at the EU's Helsinki summit in December 1999. Meeting him had been a happy occasion for me. I would write the following about Fischer, who belonged to the same generation as me (the '68 generation):

"One of the foreign ministry officials I spoke with in Bonn interpreted the results of the 1998 elections as 'Germany catching up with the 1989 revolution.' One-third of the federal parliament had been renewed; a new and young generation of politicians had taken over the country's governance. National interests hadn't changed, but new ideas about how to serve them had come into play. As the official was explaining these things (as you might guess), I couldn't help thinking about how desperately we needed such changes as Turkey: A young generation of politicians with new ideas that would enable us to adapt to the post-Cold War world; that would better serve our unchanging national interests. Unfortunately, it seems we will have to wait quite a while longer for these innovations to arrive." (*Milliyet*, February 4, 1999)

On February 10, German Ambassador Vergau called; he said Fischer was very pleased with the interview I had conducted. Fischer had also agreed with my view that "conditions are always imposed on Turkey, but there is never any encouragement." I was pleased.

When I returned from Germany, I learned that Nilüfer had left *Milliyet* and would start making programs at NTV. I was naturally upset; she was a colleague I had worked with at *Sabah* and then at *Milliyet*, above all an old friend. I immediately called her. “I’m sorry, I couldn’t wait for you. The new management was treating me very badly, I couldn’t take it anymore…” she said. She was right too. My morale was shattered. How would I continue?.. I thought about giving up my page. My friends I consulted—Ayşe Buğra, Şirin Tekeli, Güven Nil, Meral Tamer—said “don’t you dare”… Taha Akyol insisted, “Don’t close the page; that’s where your power comes from. You’re the only writer in the press who has not just a column but a whole page. Leaving would also be a blow to Yalçın Doğan…” I decided to continue. But I complained to Yalçın Doğan about my low salary. He confirmed that I was one of the lowest-paid writers (probably the lowest-paid writer); he promised to add a bonus. He said I had done good work in Germany, but added that he couldn’t see any “local colour” (?!) in my writings.

“Abdullah Öcalan Is in Turkey”

The first major event of 1999 was the capture of PKK leader Abdullah Öcalan in Kenya with US assistance and his extradition to Turkey. Prime Minister Bülent Ecevit announced this on February 16 with his statement “Abdullah Öcalan is in Turkey.” Öcalan, who was sentenced to death on June 29, 1999 for “founding and leading an armed terrorist organization,” had his sentence commuted to aggravated life imprisonment in accordance with EU harmonization laws. He has been imprisoned in İmralı Prison since that day. In my article titled “Historic Opportunity” that I wrote upon Öcalan’s capture, summarizing my views on the PKK and the Kurdish issue, I said the following:

“The capture and neutralization of Öcalan undoubtedly dealt the heaviest blow to the gang that sought to establish a so-called Marxist dictatorship over part of Turkey’s territory. However, Turkey should also see this success as an opportunity for resolving the issue that this armed gang—which has spared no effort for years to incite fraternal strife in the country—has exploited and manipulated: namely the Kurdish issue, and for establishing democracy with all its rules and institutions. Otherwise, our country cannot escape the damage caused by Kurdish racist nationalism that obstructs progress toward development and democratization, and the Turkish racist nationalism it has provoked. Great progress has been made in resolving the PKK problem. Now it’s time to solve the Kurdish issue. Let us determine the content of the ‘political solution’ ourselves. Without being subjected to the increasing pressure from Western allies in this area, as a country ‘determined to take its rightful place in European integration,’ let us take the steps we should have taken long ago.

“President (at that time Prime Minister) Süleyman Demirel declared 8 years ago, in 1991, that we recognized Kurdish identity. It’s time to act on this: Let us grant our citizens of Kurdish origin who so wish the right to freely use their language and culture. If they have certain demands different from the rest of society, let us open opportunities for them to freely express these and to engage in political struggle for them on legal, peaceful, democratic grounds. At the same time, let us accelerate the economic incentives necessary for the development of the Southeast.

If we are to progress on the path of modernization, civilization, and democratization, if we are to base our national unity on voluntary foundations, if we are to become a truly free country rather than partially free, taking these steps is inevitable. The earlier we take them, the more we gain. This truth doesn't change." (*Milliyet*, February 18, 1999)

At the European Court of Human Rights

I went to Ankara on February 22 after being invited to Nazlı Ilıcak's program "The Essence of the Matter" on a television channel. Among the participants were Abdullah Gül and Cemil Çiçek, heavyweights of the Virtue Party. Both showered my writings with compliments. Their saying "Continue to criticize us" was noteworthy; it seemed like a harbinger of a split in the FP.

1999 would also be a year when I "saw the stork in flight" [a Turkish idiom: seeing the stork on the wing augurs a year full of travel]. I spent the first week of March in Strasbourg, France. My friend Rıza Türmen, whose path had crossed mine at various periods of my life, had been elected as a judge at the European Court of Human Rights (ECHR) in 1998 and would serve in this position for ten years. Taking advantage of this, I convinced Yalçın Doğan that a visit to Strasbourg would be beneficial. Turkey had accepted its citizens' right to individual application to the ECHR in 1987 and compulsory jurisdiction in 1990. (Of course, it never crossed my mind that about 20 years later, I would be one of the Turkish citizens exercising the right of individual application in a case where I was tried on charges of being a member of "FETÖ, the Fethullahist Terrorist Organization," and would be the subject of an ECHR ruling ordering the termination of my detention on the grounds that my rights had been violated.)

The best work I did in Strasbourg was an interview with the ECHR's new Swiss president Luzius Wildhaber. In the interview published with the headline "Don't leave matters to Strasbourg," Wildhaber said: "If Turkish courts apply the Convention [the European Convention on Human Rights] on their own initiative, there would be no need for these cases to come to Strasbourg. It would also prevent the impression that the Court in Strasbourg is interfering in Turkey's affairs…" (March 9, 1999)

The Constitutional Court would express the legal changes that occurred after this interview was published on its website in 2012 as follows: "The Republic of Turkey became a party to the European Convention on Human Rights in 1954; it accepted the right of individual application to the European Court of Human Rights in 1987 and compulsory jurisdiction in 1990. With the constitutional amendment made in 2004, international conventions on fundamental rights and freedoms to which Turkey is a party, particularly the European Convention on Human Rights, were given a value above laws. The final link in the amendments referring to 'universal standards' regarding fundamental rights was the opening of the individual application path to the Constitutional Court with the constitutional amendment made in 2010. With the implementation of individual application, constitutional judicial review against violations of rights caused by persons and institutions exercising public power was initiated as of September 23, 2012. Accordingly, as of September 23, 2012, everyone can apply to the Constitutional Court claiming that any of the fundamental rights and freedoms guaranteed in our Constitution

and within the scope of the European Convention on Human Rights has been violated by public power."

Unfortunately, despite all the legal changes made, today, in 2022, the Turkish government still does not implement the ECHR rulings regarding Osman Kavala and Selahattin Demirtaş that call for their "immediate and unconditional release."

A Night in Jerusalem

At the beginning of March 1999, I received a surprise invitation from Israel's Consulate General in Istanbul to visit Israel. I had seen Israel from the outside in the summer of 1971, looking from the camp of the Democratic Front for the Liberation of Palestine in the village of Jaba near Syria's occupied city of Quneitra. In those years, I viewed Israel as an occupying state that should be thrown into the sea. Much time had passed, and my view of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict had changed. It had become more or less understood that throwing Israel into the sea was neither possible nor right. The 1993-1995 Oslo peace accords had resulted in Israel's recognition of the Palestine Liberation Organization; hope for a two-state solution had emerged. Turkey-Israel relations were experiencing a honeymoon. (Unfortunately, in 2022, as I write these lines, the two-state solution has never been so far away.)

In that environment, I saw no moral problem in going to Israel with a group that included Culture Minister İstemihan Talay (my colleague on the SBF Student Association Board that I chaired in the 1966-67 academic year) and journalist colleagues Doğan Hızlan and Murat Bardakçı among others, and spending two nights and three days there. Our hosts showed us around Jerusalem, Tel Aviv, the Dead Sea shore, and other places. Our Ambassador at the time, Ahmet Üzümcü, also hosted us for a dinner at the embassy in Tel Aviv. In the article I sent to the newspaper from Jerusalem, I wrote the following:

"The night of my first and only day in the holy city of Jerusalem. We're exhausted from rushing from visit to visit. I'm hoping to at least get to bed by midnight before waking at 4 a.m. to start the return journey. Just as I'm about to go up to my room, I notice: the sounds of a very cheerful celebration are rising from the hotel's ballroom floor. When I look down from the terrace and see the young girls in their long black skirts and white blouses and the young men with their hair in ringlets, I begin to understand…

"Then I run into Luiz Salgırtay, the charming Istanbul director of the Israeli airline El Al, one of our hosts. 'Yes, this is a Hasidic celebration,' she says, 'Come, let's go take a look. They'll probably let us in…' When we enter somewhat hesitantly, I'm faced with an incredible scene: The hall is divided in the middle by a wooden partition about 2 meters high; on this side of the partition the girls, on the other side the young men, are dancing the hora in ecstasy.

"I go to bed with the sweet happiness of having seen something the other journalists in the group didn't see. In the morning I learn that the devoutly religious Hasidic young men took our friends Culture Minister İstemihan Talay and Doğan Hızlan by the arms right into the celebration area and danced the hora together. Murat Bardakçı also recorded this historic moment with his video camera…"

I also added this to the article: “Foreign Minister Ariel Sharon received Talay and those accompanying him… We had the opportunity to ask Sharon a few questions. On questions about the PKK, Sharon said, in summary: ‘As a country that has suffered greatly from terrorism, we view terrorism as a great danger and are determined to fight all forms of it. It is well known that we have traditionally good relations with the Kurds in Iraq, especially the Barzanis, but we have no relationship with the PKK…’

“Israeli officials, following their statements that they had no role in the capture of PKK leader Abdullah Öcalan, also categorically denied reports that they had indirect relations with the PKK. However, to date, no Israeli official has characterized the PKK as a terrorist organization. Apparently, Turkey is not insisting on this either.” (*Milliyet*, March 18, 1999)

New China

The summer of 1999 also witnessed a visit that was meaningful for my autobiography. One day in early June, editor-in-chief Yalçın Doğan called. Our mutual friend Ambassador Daryal Batıbay (my friend from both Robert College and the Political Science Faculty) had called saying that the Chinese News Agency (Xinhua) wanted to invite a journalist from Turkey to China. Naturally, I—as a former Maoist—was the first to come to Yalçın’s mind… When he asked me “Would you like to go to China?”, I nearly jumped to the ceiling with joy.

I immediately contacted Daryal and our ambassador to Mongolia, Nuri Yıldırım (also my friend from both Robert College and the Political Science Faculty). Fatma and I agreed to make this trip together. That’s how the journey to China and then Mongolia began that month. Our trip covered Beijing, Shanghai, and Xi’an in China, then we flew to Ulaanbaatar. From June 8 to 22, 1999, I never missed my column. The four-day series titled “New China” that I wrote upon returning home was also published over four days from June 29 to July 2.

What the “Maoist” Şahin Alpay of the late 1960s and early 1970s wrote from and about China in 1999 could naturally be of interest to my friends and readers who knew me. In this context, I wrote the following:

“My first day in Beijing was a special day in terms of my life story. About 30 years ago, for 2-3 years I had fallen under the illusion that Mao Zedong’s interpretation of socialism could be a remedy for Turkey’s troubles. It was impossible not to reflect on the changes that I and of course China had undergone in the intervening time. I remembered those years, frankly, with pain. How I could have been swept up in such impossible ideas—even though I wasn’t alone, even though I had conformed to the ‘intellectual climate’ of the day—was a painful question. My awakening from the fantasy, or rather the nightmare, had been relatively quick. My sorrow for those who couldn’t wake up for a long time never subsided. My only consolation for myself and my generation is that perhaps without living through this experience, it would not have been possible to understand the value of freedom to our very bones. From this, I can also draw consolation for Turkey’s present: Looking at our experiences, we have still come a long way as a society. Without painful experiences, the value of freedom and democracy

cannot be appreciated. Thirty years ago, no one around me believed in democracy. Today, that is the fundamental belief."

About China I said: "China too has left the Mao Zedong era far behind. With the reforms initiated in 1978 by the 'Second Man' Deng Xiaoping, who fell from power and returned several times, China is now a completely different country. The symbolic expression of this is that nothing remains of Mao except his portrait hanging in Tiananmen Square. It is very striking that the single party he founded, which still governs the country, has reached the judgment that the 'worshipped man' of about 20 years ago 'did 40 percent right and 60 percent wrong.' Beijing, where 74 five-star hotels have risen, clearly shows in every way that China has made considerable progress in establishing a competitive market economy—or in their own terms, 'socialism with Chinese characteristics'—under Communist Party rule.

"With the reforms initiated by Deng, in the last 20 years incomes in rural China have increased 3-fold and in cities 5-fold. China's GNP increased 20-fold, from 44 billion dollars to 904 billion dollars. The average growth rate for the period was 10 percent! (The world average was 3.3%). Foreign trade volume jumped 15-fold from 20 billion dollars to 325 billion dollars. China rose from 27th to 10th place in world trade. Today, China is the world's 2nd largest economy after the US based on purchasing power parity calculations…" (*Milliyet*, June 8, 1999)

Tonyukuk and Bayınmunk

Our visit to Mongolia, which came about because my friend Nuri Yıldırım, from both Robert College and the Political Science Faculty, was our ambassador there, was also extremely interesting. In the column I sent to the newspaper from Ulaanbaatar, I wrote: "Mongolia, which until just ten years ago was one of the most closed countries in the world, is now not only a Central Asian country considered fully 'free' (according to the New York-based organization Freedom House), but is also rapidly opening up to the world… Nambaryn Enkhbayar, the leader of the Revolutionary People's Party (former communists), who is very likely to assume the prime ministership after the next elections, said they were pleased with the cultural enrichment brought by opening up, but that the missionary activities of Christian sects were an exception to this…

"I want to immediately share a very interesting memory of Enkhbayar's: As the general secretary of the Mongolian Writers' Union at the time, he had hosted the late Aziz Nesin who visited Ulaanbaatar in 1980, and personally took him to the Tonyukuk inscriptions. The master became very emotional when he reached the inscriptions left by our Göktürk ancestors, and he hugged them and wept. I couldn't help saying, 'The late Aziz Bey was never known as a Turkish ethnic nationalist!'

"We too were fortunate to see the Tonyukuk inscriptions. What excited me more than the inscriptions was the boundless Mongolian steppes on which they stood, lush green in June. 'Our ancestors must have gained the horizon (vision) that took them to the gates of Vienna from these steppes,' I thought. The Mongolian government has surrounded the inscriptions—erected between 720 and 725 in the name of Tonyukuk, who was the vizier and father-in-law of the Göktürk Khagan Bilge Kagan, and which are among the

first written examples of Turkish—with a 1-meter-high iron fence to protect them. The Turkish government has also built a dig house (newly completed construction, still empty inside) to be used in future archaeological work. The Tonyukuk inscriptions also have a guard paid for by the Turkish government. His name is Bayınmunk. Bayınmunk is a very likeable 23-year-old Mongolian youth living in his ger (Mongolian tent) set up in the middle of the steppe with his motorcycle, bicycle, and his dog Harszık." (*Milliyet*, June 12, 1999)

"Gülen's Cassettes"

At the beginning of the "February 28 process" that led to Erbakan's resignation and the dissolution of the Refahyol government, the Ankara Police Directorate had prepared a report on Fethullah Gülen and his community. According to the report, Gülen was an organization leader and the organization's members were infiltrating police units. Three days after this report reached the General Directorate of Security, on March 21, 1999, Gülen flew to the United States citing health reasons and began residing in Pennsylvania. When I returned from the China-Mongolia trip, I learned that during the days I was out of the country, some video cassettes had been broadcast on television channels leading to accusations that Gülen was "inciting his followers to infiltrate the state in order to overthrow the secular order and establish a sharia state." Thereupon, I made the following comment in my article titled "Gülen's Cassettes":

"I have no way of knowing whether the claims that Fethullah Gülen established relations with the Taliban 'to seize the state and establish a sharia state,' that he worked in the service of both the KGB and the CIA, that he has 3,000 suicide commandos and 2,000 teachers with US diplomatic passports, are true or not. However, I imagine my readers are curious about how I, as a writer who has expressed positive views about him, interpret Gülen's 'cassettes.'

"Gülen came before the public in 1995 with a call for tolerance and dialogue. As someone who thought that various polarizations were hindering Turkey's efforts to become a strong market democracy, I found what he said very noteworthy: 'There will be no return from democracy. Bigotry, intolerance must be abandoned. Turks have developed a tolerant, non-bigoted understanding of Islam. Religion cannot be made a subject of politics. Unfortunately, we are experiencing the harms of this in Turkey. The broadest freedom of worship for Muslims exists in Turkey because there is democracy. Faith is not in the headscarf but in the heart. Belief must be based on reason, on science. We cannot neglect reason, rationalism, because it is the foundation of science…' These were extraordinarily positive views for Turkey, especially coming from a religious leader of a community. While some politicians, even official voices, made statements inciting hatred and animosity against citizens belonging to minority religions, Gülen's words and actions promoting brotherhood among religions were highly commendable.

"At the invitation of the Journalists and Writers Foundation, in the autumn of 1996 I toured the community's schools in Uzbekistan and Turkmenistan along with other colleagues. The schools operated under the support and supervision of the governments

in these countries (which were even more strictly secular than Turkey's). They were doing important work in bringing Turkish, and even world culture to these places. Their activities were not outside the knowledge and supervision of the Turkish state. The hosts were pleased with the schools. (I heard the same satisfaction from Mongolian state officials two weeks ago.) I came to the conclusion that through the schools, media organizations, companies, etc. he had established, Gülen was transforming his religious tradition-based 'community' into 'society'; that is, into modern-based relationships. I listened to Gülen himself twice along with other colleagues; I did not sense any falseness in what he said. I attributed the community's eagerness to involve others in their activities and the meaningless awards they distributed to a concern for 'protection' in a country where religious orders and communities are legally banned.

"As for the cassettes: There is no doubt that they will spread the conviction that Gülen acted hypocritically, that he practiced 'taqiyya'; that they will shake the value of his words. But I don't think they are enough to prove that he was preparing an uprising to establish a religious state. Why were they held back and released now? Why were they delivered to the media rather than to the authorities authorized to initiate prosecution? Is the 'reactionary threat' being exploited? These are not questions I can answer… The aspect of the campaign against Gülen that targets almost the entire political class, including the President who received an award from him and the Prime Minister and former Prime Minister who accorded him respect, is extremely worrying for civilian governance." (June 24, 1999)

After the videos were broadcast, in August 2000 the Ankara State Security Court Chief Public Prosecutor's Office filed a case against Gülen claiming he planned to "*use the youth whose brains he washed in his schools and the society he would form with them to end the Republic of Turkey, which is a secular, democratic, and social state of law, and to establish in its place an Islamic state ruled by sharia law.*" Gülen defended himself against the charges by saying: "*A member of a nation does not infiltrate the institutions that exist for his nation; it is his right to enter there; he enters the civil administration, enters the judiciary, enters intelligence, enters foreign affairs…*" In March 2007, the Ankara 11th Heavy Penal Court concluded that no crime had been committed in light of the *Anti-Terror Law* and acquitted Gülen; the General Assembly of the Court of Cassation unanimously upheld the decision in June 2008.

Earthquake Grandpa

The 7.5 Richter scale earthquake centered in Kocaeli/Gölcük that occurred around 3 a.m. on the morning of August 17, 1999 shook the country. According to official data, around 17,500 citizens lost their lives and nearly 24,000 were injured; according to unofficial data, the number of dead reached 50,000 and the number of injured 100,000. The fact that the earthquake occurred in one of the important industrial regions also dealt a major blow to the country's economy.

Following the tragedy, I toured the Kocaeli/Gölcük region that was hit hardest by the earthquake. What surprised me most was that buildings that remained standing solid were right next to buildings that had been reduced to rubble. What I saw was like

concrete proof of the saying that has now become a proverb: “It’s not the earthquake that kills, it’s the building”… I conducted two interviews about the earthquake. The first was with the late Prof. Dr. Ahmet Mete Işıkara (1941-2013), director of the Boğaziçi University Kandilli Observatory and Earthquake Research Institute, who would frequently appear in the media after that date and earn the nickname “Earthquake Grandpa.” The words of Işıkara that I made into a headline were: “The big earthquake has passed; a new one may come after many years.”

Işıkara gave the following answer to my question “Could there be another big earthquake soon?”: “A very long process is needed for another earthquake of this intensity, that is, magnitude 7.4, to occur. No, the big earthquake happened, it’s done… Such a 7.4 magnitude earthquake doesn’t just happen. It prepares itself. And it takes a very long time to be ready.” (*Milliyet*, August 19, 1999) Considering that the expected big earthquake in Istanbul was still being awaited in 2021, Işıkara was not wrong.

I conducted the second interview with ITU’s world-renowned geologist, member of the European Academy, Prof. Dr. Celal Şengör. In the interview published with the headline “You can’t escape an earthquake, but you can take precautions,” Şengör said that the next earthquake could occur when the fault line south of the Istanbul islands ruptures, that it could be 6-plus on the Richter scale, and that it should be expected “within 10-12 years maximum.” According to Şengör, his professor from ITU, Prof. Dr. İhsan Ketin, had submitted a report to the authorities advising against building the TÜPRAŞ refinery in İzmit, but it had been ignored. When I asked “Why?”, Şengör’s answer was: “Our esteemed Speaker of Parliament reflects the same mentality when he says ‘Kurdish is a dialect.’ The mentality of ‘Science is outside us, we live differently.’” (*Milliyet*, August 20, 1999)

The parliament speaker Şengör was referring to was Yıldırım Akbulut. Ten days earlier, Akbulut had announced to journalists that “henceforth, some deputies will not be allowed to write Kurdish in the foreign language section of the parliament album,” saying: “We are learning the languages that deputies know in order to use them in inter-state relations. Kurdish is not a language, it’s a dialect. Let this no longer be dragged into different dimensions…” (Newspapers, August 10, 1999)

The interview occasioned by a very sad event led to my meeting Şengör and becoming friends with him for a while. We agreed that Karl Popper was a great philosopher of science. (I think for this reason Şengör even told me that I was “Turkey’s greatest social scientist.”) However, I could not understand how Şengör could reconcile Popper’s political philosophy with the militarist views he himself advocated (the kind that holds ‘soldiers know best’). Nevertheless, we could still have enjoyable discussions. In this context, I would like to share my article summarizing my conclusions about the relationship between religion and science, inspired by my discussions with Şengör:

“Professor Celal Şengör, in Greenland where he went last August to study the oldest known section of the earth’s crust, found himself without food and fuel for about a week. A storm had blocked the supply routes. He became anxious that he might not see his beloved wife and son again. In this mental state, he discovered that in addition to

religion's 'explanatory' and 'regulatory' functions, it also has a 'psychological' function: 'Religious belief is a support against humanity's sense of loneliness,' he thought.

"When he told me these things, I reminded Şengör of religion's 'sociological' function, the role of religious teachings in shaping people's values and behaviors. He asked this question: Without falling into relativism on one hand (not in the physics sense, but in the philosophical sense—that is, without denying that there is objective truth and rules binding for everyone), and without falling into scientism on the other hand (that is, the fallacy that science is a body of eternally proven, infallible truths and is omnipotent), how can religion and science be compatible?"

In response, I said: "The answer to this difficult question that can fit in this short article might be this: Religious explanations that contradict the findings of science are invalid. For example, the theory of evolution does not invalidate the doctrine of creation; but a religious teaching that insists humans were created in their present maturity cannot be credible. The claims of religious teachings such as 'Jesus Christ is the son of God' or 'Israel was promised to the Jews by God' and similar ones are of course incompatible with reason. Religious law loses its validity to the extent that it contradicts human rights and freedoms, which are the common heritage of humanity. Religious obligations that prescribe treating women as 'second-class humans' or recommend 'killing non-believers' are unacceptable. A religious teaching that insists on these will lose its credibility.

"Science, which appeals to reason, can never (except perhaps for a very small minority) eliminate humanity's sense of loneliness, uncertainty, and meaninglessness in the universe, the need to 'take refuge in God.' Only religious teachings that appeal to emotions can respond to this psychological need of humans. Science can never answer the question of whether there is a creator. The massacres caused by doctrines like 'scientific' socialism, which set out to create paradise on earth supposedly 'using science,' or 'national' socialism, which aimed to create a superior race, have surpassed the murders committed, for example, by the Inquisition in the name of protecting religion (actually the church). The sociological functions of religion cannot be ignored. The precepts about what is a good deed and what is a sin have extremely important effects —preventing crime, providing social solidarity and integration, hindering or encouraging socio-economic development, and others." (*Milliyet*, December 28, 2000)

Interestingly, Şengör, with whom we had interesting discussions and socialized as families, would completely cut off relations with me after I was arrested and thrown into Silivri prison in the days following the July 15 coup attempt (just like another professor friend of mine, Şükrü Hanioğlu).

"The Earthquake Was No Coincidence"

The earthquake of August 17, 1999, which had the most devastating consequences in our recent history, had also given rise to religiously-flavored interpretations. Regarding these interpretations, I wrote the following:

"Recently a guest from England came to visit *Milliyet*. While discussing what was happening in Turkey, I conveyed one of the most heated debate topics of recent days.

One of the headscarved students who was not admitted to university had unfurled a banner saying ‘7.4 wasn’t enough?!’; then a religious community leader had stepped forward and said ‘The earthquake was no coincidence, it was God’s punishment for those who made the February 28 decisions’; similar interpretations were frequently made in the Islamist press. My professor friend also told me this: About ten years ago, lightning struck the cathedral in York, England, starting a fire. Thereupon some Christian fundamentalists claimed that God had sent the lightning as punishment for the York bishop, known for his liberal views…

“Yes, attributing natural events to supernatural forces, to God, is not peculiar to Turkey and some Muslims, but is a universally observed tendency. Perhaps what is peculiar to us about this tendency—which grants no autonomy (will) to nature or humanity, which are God’s creations; which bypasses the question of why humans were created with reason and will; and which reflects an extremely primitive understanding of religion—is the exploitation of religious beliefs for political purposes. My readers know that I am not in favor of immediately seizing and imprisoning those who exploit religious beliefs for political purposes, and that I see benefit in all views being freely expressed except calls to violence and racism. I think the best attitude to adopt toward these people is to expose their nonsense and drivel.

“I don’t find the exploitation of religion in Islamist newspapers surprising, but that Mehmet Kutlular—a community leader who had opposed Islamists’ exploitation of religion—was engaging in religious exploitation himself truly astonished me. The response of another Nurcu community leader, Fethullah Gülen, to Kutlular was also interesting from a theological standpoint: ‘If a religious reason is to be sought for such disasters, it should be considered that it may be related to general errors, and everyone should first examine themselves…’ Apparently Gülen also shared the view that ‘the earthquake was a divine warning,’ but was saying that ‘we are all targets of the warning.’

“All of this surprised me, because I thought Said-i Nursi argued that ‘Islamic faith can only be strengthened through interpretations compatible with political freedom and modern science; that religion and science occupy separate domains.’ Of course, I (as an outsider) may be mistaken about Said-i Nursi’s message. But another serious (and more grave) possibility is that both Kutlular and Gülen are badly mistaken in their understanding of Said-i Nursi’s message. Fortunately, the sensible majority of society knows how to separate the domains of religion and science.” (*Milliyet*, October 19, 1999)

I had met Mehmet Kutlular (1938-2021) mentioned in the article. The followers of Said Nursi, known as the “Nur community,” were divided into ten branches; one of the main ones was the community gathered around the *Yeni Asya* newspaper and known as the Yeni Asya group. Kutlular, the owner and editor-in-chief of *Yeni Asya*, while making detailed statements that the earthquake was a “divine warning,” was saying that this warning “could be related to the oppression during the February 28 process,” and that it could not be a coincidence that the earthquake’s epicenter was the Gölcük Naval Base where the February 28 plans were made.

The same Kutlular, impressed by my articles defending freedom of belief, had called me and invited me to his newspaper. During our meeting, Kutlular said they were greatly

disappointed by Şerif Mardin's book titled *The Bediüzzaman Said Nursi Phenomenon* (İletişim Publishers, 1989). He added that they would be very pleased if I wrote a book on Nursi and his thought; that they were ready to provide any sources I might need on this subject. Frankly, the topic was quite appealing to me in terms of efforts to understand religion in Turkey; however, I was managing the opinion page at *Milliyet* six days a week and writing a column three days a week; unfortunately I didn't have the time to do this work properly.

"CNN Türk Desk"

In September 1999, it was announced that the Doğan media group had reached an agreement with CNN, that a news channel called CNN-Türk was being established, and that Taha Akyol would manage the channel. Some time later, Akyol called me and said they wanted me to do a talk show on the new channel. Of course, I received this with pleasure but also with some hesitation, as I had no screen experience until then. According to the concrete proposal, I would host "CNN Türk Desk," to be broadcast in the 9-10 PM slot, every Tuesday evening with a guest. Mehmet Ali Birand, who took on the position of programs director, said he was surprised when he learned I would be among the presenters, that I was "a person whose opinion should be sought, not one who conducts interviews." But then, perhaps to mollify me, I remember him coming during the test recordings and calling out "A local Larry King is being born!"

Birand was advising me to invite guests from almost every field, from politics and economics to sports, cinema, and entertainment, on the program I would do. Unfortunately, the right to select guests was left to me, and by choosing them only from the worlds of politics and academia, I perhaps caused the program to fall out of favor shortly after. CNN-Türk began broadcasting on October 11, 1999; the first program I did was also broadcast on October 12. My first guest was our famous novelist Orhan Pamuk. The announcement that appeared in *Milliyet* that day said: "The famous writer, who until now has been in the spotlight with his novels and is a favorite of literary circles, will for the first time discuss and comment on politics in this program." That evening Pamuk was at least as excited as I was. Indeed, I remember him trying to calm down in the makeup room by drinking whiskey from a small bottle he took out of his pocket.

My program on CNN Türk Desk was short-lived. The interviews I conducted began to be broadcast once a week at noon under the name "Intellectual Perspective" starting from January 2000. Among those I hosted in this program, which lasted about a year and a half, were: Academics Sami Selçuk, Ayşe Buğra, Ergun Özbudun, Ersin Kalaycıoğlu, Nevra Necipoğlu, Ali Yaşar Sarıbay, Celal Şengör, Kemal Kirişçi, Fahrettin Yağcı, Burhan Şenatalar, Faruk Birtek, Çağlar Keyder, İzzettin Doğan, Seyfettin Gürsel, İlter Turan, Emin Yaşar Demirci; novelist Nedim Gürsel; writers Ali Bulaç and Mustafa Çalık; BJK President Serdar Bilgili; businessman İshak Alaton; journalist Hasan Cemal; Istanbul Bar Association President Yücel Sayman; politicians Sami Uslu, Sema Pişkinsüt, Mehmet Ali Talat, Bülent Arınç.

The program, whose viewership remained limited outside academic circles, was ended in April 2002. A bad memory related to my CNN Türk days was this: In some programs, I

had to strain to keep myself from yawning, to keep my eyes from closing. Meanwhile, Fatma was also becoming alarmed noticing that I frequently stopped breathing while sleeping at night. When I went to my high school classmate and friend Sedat Tavşanoğlu, who was then a cardiology professor at Cerrahpaşa Medical Faculty, with complaints of high blood pressure, he suspected I might be suffering from sleep apnea. I spent two nights in Cerrahpaşa's sleep laboratory; the severity of my apnea (my breath-skipping affliction) was measured with the primitive equipment of those days. As a result, I started using a device called CPAP that pumps air into my nose, and I will use it until I die. If I hadn't been diagnosed and started CPAP, I might have long since died like many others who lack the necessary precaution. CPAP became a device that extended the lives of many people I know as well.

Helsinki in Thessaloniki

During the days of the Helsinki Summit (December 10-11, 1999), where Turkey's candidacy for the European Union (EU) was declared, I was in Thessaloniki. Haluk Şahin, one of my senior friends, had arranged for me to be invited to the Balkan Journalists Conference to be held in Thessaloniki, of which he was one of the organizers. It was my first opportunity to visit Greece. Thessaloniki, where my maternal grandfather Halit Remzi Bey, originally from Skopje, had lived for many years, was only 80 km from Serres, where my paternal ancestors originated. On this short visit, touring Thessaloniki's "Turkish quarter" and listening to Rebetika songs of Izmir origin in the tavernas at night made me very happy. The main reason for my happiness in Thessaloniki, however, was the news that broke that day of Turkey being declared an EU candidate. For years, I had ardently advocated Turkey's EU membership, believing it would help purify the pluralist democratic regime of its deficiencies and flaws and "anchor it firmly." In my commentary on the Helsinki decisions that I wrote upon returning to Istanbul, I said:

"During the Helsinki days, I was in Thessaloniki for a conference. Along with the announcement of the decisions, the first news from the Greek agencies was government spokesman Dimitris Reppas's statement: 'We got three out of three!' Reppas was saying that all three of Greece's conditions had been adopted when Turkey's candidacy was accepted. The point that the Greek colleagues I spoke with emphasized, however, was that Athens had opened the EU path for Turkey by not using its veto right.

"We reached a consensus on this point: A unity of will had emerged between the two countries for resolving disputes within the EU framework. The Helsinki decisions had been given a form that (so to speak) both sides could 'sell' to their publics. Reppas's 'three out of three' could be read very differently. Namely: 1) The solution of the Cyprus problem would not be a precondition for the Greek Cypriot Administration's EU membership, but the EU Council would decide whether the GCA could become an EU member, taking into account 'all relevant factors.'

"2) If all candidates cannot resolve their disputes through peaceful means, they are expected to take them to the International Court of Justice 'within a reasonable time.' The EU Council will review unresolved issues by the end of 2004. However, there is no

time constraint for going to the Court. (How can this be made a condition for Turkey when France does not accept the Court's jurisdiction?) On the other hand, didn't Turkey just confirm last week that it could go to the Court if necessary? Greece says it can only discuss the continental shelf issue. Yet the Helsinki decisions speak of 'problems.'

"3) The letter from Finnish President Lipponen, holder of the term presidency, confirms that no condition other than fulfilling the Copenhagen political criteria has been imposed on Turkey for starting membership negotiations. Since Turkey has already accepted this, the condition that Athens had inserted into the Helsinki decisions regarding progress in democracy and human rights has almost no meaning.

"The Greek opposition's reaction to the Helsinki decisions indicates that it is even possible to read Reppas's 'three out of three' as 'zero out of three': According to New Democracy Party leader Kostas Karamanlis, the Simitis government's stance was 'A very dangerous departure from traditional foreign policy…' According to the conservative newspaper *Eleftheros Typos*: 'The Simitis government shared the responsibility of issuing Turkey an EU ticket. Turkey's demands from Greece became official; it erased its aggressive and expansionist past from the records.' According to Greek Communist Party leader Aleka Papariga: 'Greece made new concessions from its sovereign rights…'

"However, the Greek people in general (just like the Turkish people) are pleased with the Helsinki decisions. Perhaps the most direct expression of this is that the Athens stock exchange index recorded a 2.4 percent increase following the announcement of the decisions. (The increase in the ISE index was historic: 14.2 percent!) Commentators agree that Simitis has increased his chances of winning the elections expected to be held on March 26. In short, those who are not pleased with Helsinki are a minority who, by virtue of their ideologies, positions, and interests, favor Turkey remaining outside the EU and Turkish-Greek disputes continuing forever." (*Milliyet*, December 14, 1999)

Unfortunately, the Helsinki Summit could not open the EU path for Turkey; more than twenty years later, Turkey's EU membership today remains nothing but a dream.

"Turkish Occupation" in Athens

I also participated in and gave a speech at the Turkish-Greek media conference held in Athens on February 5-6, 2000, at the initiative of the Press Council of which I was a member, or officially the "1st Mass Communication Conference." Regarding this speech, I wrote the following in my column in the newspaper:

"In the words of the *Kathimerini* newspaper, last week the Greek capital witnessed giant steps toward the desired Greece in the Greeks' three greatest obsessions: politics, relations with Turkey, and Athens traffic. The Athens metro went into service. The Turkish foreign minister officially visited Athens for the first time in 40 years. Prime Minister Simitis announced early elections on April 9. Another important event of the week was the Turkish-Greek Media Conference held on February 5-6. On this occasion, the arrival of about 40 Turkish journalists and media executives in Athens was

announced by the weekly English newspaper *The Hellenic Star* (humorously) with the headline ‘Turkish occupation.’

“Prime Minister Simitis’s statement at the reception held for Turkish journalists at his residence on February 4—that journalists bear as much responsibility as politicians in resolving problems—attracted great interest. I think this was also the most important question discussed at the conference: Can journalists play as important a role as politicians in improving relations and resolving problems? Some colleagues objected to Simitis. According to some, his words reflected an attitude of ‘dumping responsibility on journalists.’ According to others, the journalist’s duty was limited to reporting news and criticizing policies. I completely agree with the Greek Prime Minister. In the speech I gave at the conference, I essentially tried to explain why Simitis was right.

“Yes, journalists’ responsibility in improving Turkish-Greek relations is no less than that of politicians. Why? The media, with its provocative attitude and broadcasts during the Kardak-Imia crisis in the winter of 1996, nearly dragged the two countries into war. In the summer of 1999, the same media used the earthquake disasters as an occasion to pave the way for politicians’ efforts to improve relations. Yes, if it does its job properly, the media can make a great contribution to realizing the peace that both peoples desire. The media doing its job properly means, of course, above all presenting news as accurately and objectively/impartially as possible (that is, without filtering and distorting it through prejudices).

“Of course, journalism is not limited to reporting news; interpreting events from different angles is as much the journalist’s duty as reporting news accurately. Today, the media is perhaps a more important factor than family and school in acquiring political attitudes and values. The greatest influence on the formation of public opinion is again the media’s. Of course, any commentator will interpret events as they wish. However, if issues are interpreted freely and independently rather than through the eyes of Ankara or Athens; if interpretations oriented toward resolving problems find as much space as interpretations that would prevent this, the peace that both peoples desire can be realized much more easily.

“At the media conference, it appeared that a fairly strong unity of will had formed on both sides regarding eliminating their deep ignorance about each other; reporting news accurately and without distortion; avoiding hostile provocations; and not tagging along behind state policies. The issue is to implement this will and make it permanent. That’s no small matter either, but one has to start somewhere, I suppose.” (*Milliyet*, February 8, 2000)

Yannis Atmazoğlu

This was my second visit to Greece and my first to Athens. I wrote about my Athens impressions as follows: “On the occasion of the Turkish-Greek Media Conference, I went to Athens for the first time last weekend. At the first opportunity I found from the program prepared by the Greek colleagues who showed warm hospitality, I wanted to go to the seaside. I asked the hotel receptionist: Where should I go? ‘To Pashalimani…’ I asked him to write down on a piece of paper where I should go so I could tell the taxi driver.

When the taxi driver looked at the paper and muttered to himself in Turkish ‘What is this?!’, I thought he was someone who knew Turkish well, perhaps of Istanbul origin. No, he wasn’t. His parents from Isparta, who had migrated to Greece with the 1923 population exchange, had spoken only Turkish between themselves until they died.

“Yannis was born in Athens and had managed to learn a little Turkish in his childhood. We mostly communicated in English. He told me he would be going to Turkey and Isparta for the first time in his life in the coming summer months. He would definitely join the trip organized by the Isparta Immigrants Association headquartered in Athens. As soon as we set off, he put on a cassette. He had transferred the Turkish Rumelian folk songs from his father’s old ‘stone’ records to cassette and always listened to them. Listening to these songs whose words he didn’t fully understand was ‘something else’: ‘I’m being swept away, to the wind of my fate. Oh horizons, I say…’ I couldn’t help thinking about what Yannis’s mother and father must have felt when they left Isparta. Just as I thought about what my grandfather might have felt when he left Serres.

“When I asked what he thought about recent developments in Turkish-Greek relations, Yannis’s answer was: ‘Let the hostility end; we’re fed up…’ Did everyone want that? ‘No, but I think the majority does,’ he said. Of course, he would vote for Simitis. Partly for Turkish friendship. When parting, he gave me his card. He explained that his surname was actually Atmazoğlu, but he had changed it to a more native name. ‘But we’re still different,’ he said; ‘We’re unique.’

“The exchangees, their children, and grandchildren certainly have a different, unique identity of their own. Even though they are perhaps the ones who have suffered the most pain and endured the most torment from the hostilities, it is also certain that the ‘exchangees’ are one of the bridges of friendship between the two countries. The meeting organized last month in Istanbul by the Lausanne Exchangees Association that those who migrated from Greece to Turkey wanted to establish, which brought together exchangees from both sides, was perhaps the most concrete expression of this.

“Turkish-Greek peace won’t happen tomorrow. The difficulties are great. The two peoples defined their national identities in war against each other. Cyprus only knows its own story. There are tough issues in the Aegean. However, there are also elements that can make peace possible. Common interests are greater than national interests. Common geography, history, and culture unite. There have always been groups on both sides who sincerely believe in friendship. Since the earthquakes, there is a new mentality on both sides. But most importantly, Greek governments have abandoned policies of excluding Turkey. The more Athens opens Turkey’s EU path, the easier the resolution of problems will become. Of course, if Turkey is willing to progress on this path.” (*Milliyet*, February 10, 2000)

“Here Is the President!”

In May 2000, Süleyman Demirel’s seven-year term was coming to an end. A new president would be elected. With a joint motion from deputies belonging to the parties included in the ruling coalition government of the time (the Democratic Left Party, the Nationalist Movement Party, and the Motherland Party), as well as the Virtue Party and

the True Path Party, Constitutional Court President Ahmet Necdet Sezer was nominated for the presidency on April 25, 2000, and was elected the 10th President by securing the necessary majority in the final round of voting held on May 5; he assumed office from Demirel on May 16.

During his presidency of the Constitutional Court, Sezer was leaving a positive impression on the public with his views defending fundamental rights and freedoms and the rule of law, and with his modest persona. I also carried the same impression. I kept telling my friend Rıza Türmen, who was then a judge at the European Court of Human Rights, that it would be very appropriate for him to meet with Sezer when he came to Turkey. Indeed, Türmen had visited Sezer and he too had gained very positive impressions.

In the article I wrote upon Sezer's nomination for the presidency, titled "Here Is the President!", I said:

"… Both Prime Minister Bülent Ecevit and the other coalition leaders deserve congratulations; they found the unifying candidate. The Virtue Party leadership's unhesitating support for the candidacy of Sezer, who had signed the decision to close the Welfare Party, is enough to show the prestige this name carries. Mr. Sezer, in his speeches on the occasion of the Constitutional Court's founding anniversaries both last year and this year (even after it was announced that he would be nominated for the Presidency), emphasized the importance of human rights, fundamental rights and freedoms, and the rule of law, and repeated his call for a new, freedom-oriented, and pluralist constitution. Sezer's election would mean both that a person respected by the great majority would ascend to Çankaya; and that the demand shared by the great majority for 'an end to lawlessness and the rule of law to prevail' would be carried to the highest office." (*Milliyet*, April 27, 2000)

Shortly after being elected President, Sezer called me by phone and thanked me for the support I had given. Of course, I was extremely pleased; for the first time, I was being acknowledged by a president. For the first and last time in my entire professional life, I was invited to Çankaya that year for the October 29 Republic Day. My darling Fatma was also quite pleased about this. We would shake a president's hand for the first time and see what the Çankaya mansion was like. But it was not to be. On October 28, Fatma couldn't get out of bed due to severe pain in her joints. One of my closest and most loyal friends, my high school classmate Prof. Dr. Hasan Yazıcı, diagnosed Fatma with acute joint rheumatism. With the treatment Hasan recommended, Fatma was able to get back on her feet before long, but we couldn't go to Çankaya. After I left *Milliyet* some time later, Sezer never invited me again, so we never had the opportunity to see Çankaya.

"The Two Faces of the FP"

The congress of the Virtue Party, established to replace the Welfare Party after its closure by the Constitutional Court, held on May 14, 2000, became the scene of competition between the "Traditionalist" (pro-Erbakan) and "Reformist" (anti-Erbakan)

wings. In the days leading up to the congress, I was writing the following about this competition:

“I looked at my archive: My first article in *Milliyet* on the two different ‘faces’ of the Islamist movement in Turkey appeared on November 25, 1995, with the title ‘The Two Faces of Welfare.’ In that article, I wrote, in summary: On one face, the WP is an important element, a success of our democracy. If Turkey is the ‘star of Islam,’ one reason is its success in making the Islamist opposition part of the democratic process rather than pushing it underground. The WP’s other face is the doubts about its commitment to fundamental rights and freedoms. The WP’s division of society into Muslims and non-Muslims; its exploitation of religious feelings; its anti-Semitism and racism under the guise of anti-Zionism were worrying tendencies.

“Since I wrote those lines, much water has flowed under the bridge. The National View Movement today is, in no sense, at the point where it stood at the end of 1995. The principle that the only thing that doesn’t change is change naturally applied to this movement as well as others. The National View Movement has undergone continuous change over time. The NSP was different from the NOP; the WP from the NSP… But the biggest change in this political line undoubtedly occurred while it was sharing government responsibility during the Refahyol period. That experience benefited the WP greatly. The nonsense about the Just Economic Order and the freedom to choose one’s law was abandoned. No one talked anymore about leaving NATO or tearing up the Customs Union. In short, the WP moved toward a reasonable line.

“According to some: If the WP hadn’t been closed, if Erbakan hadn’t been banned, the leap the National View Movement made with the FP couldn’t have happened; the new discourse emphasizing the need for compromise and dialogue, human rights, and fundamental freedoms adopted under Recai Kutan’s leadership couldn’t have developed easily. I don’t know. But what is certain is that the FP doesn’t resemble the WP either. Perhaps the most important indicator of this dissimilarity is that the ‘two faces’ of the moderate Islamist movement in Turkey are openly competing for power within the FP for the first time. In my view, if the Reformist wing, which appears to have adopted the goal of making the FP a party ‘as committed to the fundamental principles of freedom-oriented and pluralist democracy as it is to Islamic values,’ wins this competition, not only the FP but all of Turkey will benefit.

“The Reformist wing can make the FP the Muslim Democrat Party that Turkey yearns for. In that case, the FP could assume a prominent role in favor of liberalization and democratization in Turkey’s political life. It seems to me that even if the Reformist wing cannot win this first congress to be held on May 14, it can win the next congress. Some friends remind me that today’s ‘reformists’ in the FP were yesterday’s ‘radicals.’ I tell them this: It is normal for yesterday’s ‘radicals’ to become today’s ‘advocates of freedom’ who have learned the value of freedom through experience, by living.” (*Milliyet*, May 11, 2000)

The Hürriyet newspaper reported the FP’s congress result as follows: “Kutan, who entered the election with Necmettin Erbakan’s support behind him, could only get 633 votes out of the FP’s 1,238 delegates. Abdullah Gül, the Reformist wing’s candidate,

caused a big surprise by receiving 521 votes, while 43 delegates did not participate in the voting… The result Gül achieved, which Erbakan tried with all his might to prevent, was interpreted in FP circles as: Kutan was re-elected General Chairman, but looking at the result, the winner was Gül; and the only loser of the congress was Erbakan." (May 15, 2000)

For some time I had been following the statements of the leading spokespeople of the "Reformist" wing, especially Abdullah Gül, and I had become hopeful that the Islamist movement could gradually embrace fundamental rights and freedoms. Following his success at the congress, I called Gül and conveyed that I wanted to meet with him. When he invited me to lunch, I went to Ankara. This first and last private meeting between us was very sincere. I was quite pleased when Gül said that my articles in *Milliyet* criticizing both the authoritarian secularism practices inherited from the single-party era and the majoritarian understanding of democracy disrespectful of fundamental rights and freedoms prevalent in the Islamist movement had been very influential; that he and his "Reformist" friends had reproduced these articles and discussed them among themselves. I fell under the illusion that my commentaries were having an impact. From that date on, I also began to expect Gül to become more influential in Turkish politics.

"Thank You, Alpay"

It was becoming clear that my criticisms of authoritarian secularism practices were not only influencing the "Reformists" of the Islamist movement. The radical Islamists' newspaper *Akit*, in its November 26, 2000 issue, under the headline "Hypocritical EU," referenced my article published the day before and said "The EU's hypocritical attitude was raised for the first time yesterday by Şahin Alpay, a former Marxist." The eight-column headline of *Akit*'s "Mediacritique" page was also "Thank You, Alpay." Below it said:

"… But he is now a liberal. He rejects both Marxism and Marxist terror. He works in the cartel. He both writes and makes television programs. In doing so, he doesn't share some people's nature. He doesn't join in 'reactionary hysteria' just to protect his position. He doesn't send 'I'm one of you' messages to power centers by insidiously attacking Muslims and their sacred values. The article below, like many before it, is proof of this. Moreover, it's a document defending the rights of the oppressed on an issue that many Muslims either couldn't notice or couldn't reconcile noticing with their 'EU advocacy.' Thank you, Şahin Alpay…"

And *Akit* quoted my article titled "Religious freedom" in full without any abridgement: "The EU Commission's 'Progress Report 2000' on Turkey's candidacy, announced on November 8, says in the section on religious freedom: 'No change is seen in the official attitude toward Alevis. The compulsory religion classes in schools and their textbooks not including Alevi identity, and the state providing financial support only to Sunni mosques and foundations are the main complaints of Alevis.' In the first 'Progress Report' on Turkey two years ago, the Commission noted that 'officially recognized religious minorities are free to practice their religion…' but that 'beliefs other than (Sunni) Islam face many bureaucratic obstacles,' after which it was underlined that the clergy of

Alevis, ‘whose numbers are estimated to be at least around 12 million,’ did not receive salaries from the state.

“Considering that they were not mentioned at all in the 1999 Report, it can be said that Alevis’ problems found the widest coverage in the latest report… This may partly be due to some Alevi community leaders having conveyed their complaints to the Commission’s Ankara Representation. The latest ‘Progress Report,’ while referring to the problems of Alevis, also notes that ‘some signs are seen that tolerance toward non-Muslim minorities has increased.’ However, the noteworthy point is that not a single word is mentioned about the continuing bans and pressures on religious orders and communities, which are folk interpretations of Sunni Islam.

“It is not at all a harsh judgment to interpret this as a result of the EU Commission’s deep ignorance and prejudices regarding Islam. The fact that EU reports never in any way mention the headscarf ban in universities, which means not only the restriction of freedom of belief but also of educational freedom and discrimination against women, makes this interpretation even more justified. Whether the EU Commission sees it or not, ending the headscarf ban for university students is one of Turkey’s democracy issues. Members of religious orders and communities and headscarved students must respect the rule of law based on human rights. Those who don’t will of course face bans and penalties. But for those who do show respect to also face bans and penalties is incompatible with democracy. Presumably someone needs to explain this to the EU Commission as well.” (*Milliyet*, November 25, 2000)

It was understandable that this article of mine would increase my prestige in religious circles. In secular, especially secularist (pro-authoritarian secularism) circles, however, my prestige was gradually decreasing.

Virtue Is Also Being Closed

On May 7, 1999, the Chief Public Prosecutor’s Office applied to the Constitutional Court for the closure of the Virtue Party (FP), on the grounds that, just like the previous NOP, NSP, and WP, it had become “a center of activities contrary to secularism.” I expressed my view on this in an article titled “The Venice Commission”:

“From the perspective of European and Turkish political party law principles, the closure of the FP would be very surprising. Of course, if Turkey is a state of law that has been a member of the Council of Europe for about half a century and is an EU candidate… When looking at the issue from a political angle, the question that always nags at my mind is this: Would it have been very good if the NOP-NSP-WP-FP had never been allowed, if all those representing the political views and demands of Islamist and religious circles had been forced (to go underground and multiply there, just like the religious orders)? I am surprised that some ‘responsible’ persons appear to be unaware of this question.” (*Milliyet*, January 29, 2000)

The Constitutional Court decided to close the FP on June 22, 2001. The FP applied to the European Court of Human Rights against the closure decision. However, it later withdrew its application on the grounds that the Court “applied double standards to

Muslims." The deputies of the FP called "Traditionalists" joined the Felicity Party under Recai Kutan's leadership, while those called "Reformists" would gather in the yet-to-be-established Justice and Development Party, which would elect Recep Tayyip Erdoğan as its leader.

The Partnership of Radicals

In the days when the decision to close the Virtue Party had not yet been announced, a topic that was becoming increasingly clear in my mind was the common aspects of Kemalist and Islamist radicals. I addressed this topic in an article titled "Kemalism 2000": "Britain's weekly politics and economics magazine *The Economist*, read all over the world, in its first issue right after the EU's Helsinki Summit (December 18, 1999), quoted the words of a European diplomat stationed in Ankara: 'Many Turks see EU candidacy as an end in itself. But few are aware of what will come after candidacy, what complying with golf club rules might mean.' The magazine then turned to Daniel Cohn-Bendit, the head of the European wing of the Turkey-EU Joint Parliamentary Commission: Following one of his visits to Ankara, Cohn-Bendit had argued that EU membership would 'mean the end of Kemalism in Turkey.'

"In this article titled 'Farewell to Atatürk?', *The Economist*, proceeding from Cohn-Bendit's words, wrote that EU membership posed a dilemma even for 'the most pro-Western Turks' and added this comment: 'Even the most pro-Western Turks, while on the one hand thinking that EU membership would prevent radical Islamists from coming to power, on the other hand question whether giving up the guarantee the army provides in this regard is a wise thing to do…'

"Let's start with Cohn-Bendit. Frankly, I couldn't understand why EU membership would mean 'the end of Kemalism (and farewell to Atatürk).' If Kemalism meant, as some try to load onto it, 'Turkish ethnic nationalism, rigid secularism, statism in the economy and politics, authoritarian centralism, militarism, anti-Westernism, etc.,' Turkey could never have become what it is today: a market economy that, despite all its constraints, has 50 years of democracy experience and is increasingly opening up and integrating with the EU. The intellectual legacy of the founder of the Republic of Turkey rests on two fundamental principles: 1) Catching up with contemporary civilization. 2) And for this, remaining committed to Enlightenment Thought (symbolized by the saying 'My spiritual legacy is science and reason'), that is, to critical rationalism. These are the Atatürk principles that Kemalists should embrace in the year 2000.

"Viewed this way, Turkey's EU membership would mean nothing other than Kemalism's reaching its ultimate victory, and when this happens, the value of Kemalism as an intellectual force contributing to Europe's integration on the basis of universal values can be fully understood. Because the EU is the idea of Europe's integration on precisely these principles (Enlightenment Thought, not Christianity). A type of 'Kemalism' that obstructs Turkey's catching up with contemporary civilization, meaning freedom-oriented and pluralist democracy based on human rights, is surely contrary to the essence of Kemalism. As for some 'most pro-Western Turks': *The Economist*'s correspondent probably hasn't lived in Turkey long enough to know these people. Otherwise, he could

have added to his commentary that these people are no less intolerant of difference than radical Islamists; that they cannot seem to grasp that the more authoritarian the regime, the greater the radical Islamist threat will grow." (*Milliyet*, April 25, 2000)

As can be seen, this must be the column where I looked at Kemalism with the most benevolent eye.

"Earthquake in the Cartel"

The political crisis that began when President Ahmet Necdet Sezer threw the constitution booklet in Prime Minister Bülent Ecevit's face at the meeting held on February 19, 2001 ("Black Wednesday") had turned into an economic crisis. Large-scale layoffs began in the media, especially in the Doğan and Sabah groups, which were referred to as the "cartel" because they both competed for influence and circulation and showed solidarity against their employees. I didn't expect to be one of the victims of the "earthquake" that the *Akit* newspaper announced with the headline "Earthquake in the Cartel," but I was.

I had joined *Milliyet* in 1994 when Ufuk Güldemir became editor-in-chief. After his departure in 1996, Derya Sazak continued in the position until 1999, then the duo of Umur Talu and Yalçın Doğan took over. I had worked in harmony with all these managers. In December 2000, Mehmet Y. Yılmaz, who had until then been editor-in-chief of *Radikal*, was brought in to manage. For the first time, someone I wasn't friends with would be running the newspaper. Naturally, I became a bit uneasy. I did what I had to do; I went and wished Yılmaz success. I even noted that I said, "I see your appointment as an opportunity for *Milliyet* to return to the Abdi İpekçi tradition." In response, Yılmaz said, "The boss wants us to make the newspaper more popular. There's no longer a possibility of being a reference newspaper, but we will continue the tradition of being a newspaper of ideas. We will expand your page to two pages by adding other writers…"

Before long, the first crisis arose between me and Yılmaz; the interview I did with painter İpek Aksüğür-Duben disappeared from the page. After waiting two days, I asked Yılmaz why. His answer was, "There was a communication failure… I didn't know it was your interview." A few days later, Melda Türker's piece on "F-Type prisons" flew off the page. There was no longer any need to talk to him… A few days later, the page secretary also conveyed that Yılmaz found my column pieces (2,700-2,800 characters) too long. When I ran into him in the corridor, I asked the reason for his complaint. He actually said, "Şahin Bey, I used to write 1,400 characters at *Radikal*… If you get down to 1,500 characters, you'll be Turkey's best writer!.."

A few days later, the page's name became "Entelektüel Bakış" (spelled with a single "l"). And finally, on January 4, the page completely disappeared without my knowledge. It had become quite clear that Yılmaz didn't want me. I went and told him I could also stop writing the column. In response, he said the page had been temporarily closed due to the economic crisis and would be published again in the future. It wasn't convincing at all. I began to think I might be on my way out.

The Death of Güven Nil

In this troubled environment, I was shaken by the death of one of my closest friends, Güven Nil, at the age of 57 from a heart attack while playing basketball. I wrote the following in my column: “The Turkish business community has lost one of its most distinguished members. Güven Nil, co-chairman of the TÜSİAD Agriculture Working Group and member of the Foreign Relations Commission, passed away on Sunday, February 18. I met Güven Nil exactly 40 years ago, on a journey. He was a student at the Austrian High School, I was at Robert College. We were going to study in the USA for a year on a scholarship. On our return, he transferred to our school to complete his senior year. Throughout that year, we were inseparable. Many from our generation will remember the folk music trio he formed with Münir and Mürüvvet. We were together in the theater club. When Shakespeare’s ‘Julius Caesar’ was staged, he was Caesar, I was Brutus.

“Then our paths diverged. I decided to go to the Political Science Faculty intending to become a diplomat, he continued to the upper division of the College to become an engineer… He worked as an engineer and administrator for a while, but he wanted to do bigger things. He found his real excitement in trade, opening up abroad, investment, and globalization. He started from scratch in business and was very successful. We always ran on different paths in life, but even when long years came between us, our friendship continued where we left off. For the last 20 years, we were always in a close and intense relationship.

“We looked at life from very different positions. Partly because of this, I learned a lot from him. His most distinctive characteristics were his brilliant intelligence, his determination to create from nothing, his foresight, and his unshakeable optimism. Even in our last phone conversation a few days before his death, he was advising me not to fall into pessimism looking at today’s temporary troubles, that Turkey was a society strong enough to overcome all difficulties, to look at events with a long-term rather than short-term view, to try to see the forest rather than the trees. I will follow this advice.

“I had mentioned him in an article published in August 1999. I had written: ‘Three friends who shared the same room while boarding at the College met in Çanakkale 36 years later. Ahmet (Kutman), if left to his own devices, might have become a famous theoretical physicist. He studied chemistry, took over the family business, and became one of Turkey’s leading wine producers. Güven, if left to his own devices, might have become a great musician. But life made him one of Turkey’s most creative, most entrepreneurial businessmen. His great curiosity about the history of the Gallipoli War eventually led him to buy the Sarafin Farm and to produce some of the country’s highest quality wines together with Ahmet.’

“Güven did what very few people in Turkey do: He invested the money he earned in agriculture. Books never left his hand. There was no place left he hadn’t gone to see. He bought his last guitar a few days ago. He was one of the founding partners of Açık Radyo. He prepared and presented ‘Wine Conversations with Music.’ His heart stopped

while playing basketball, as he did every Sunday. He had much more to do." (*Milliyet*, February 20, 2001)

Güven used to say he was ready to invest quite a bit of money in a film that would tell my life story. Unfortunately, he would not be able to see what I experienced after that day.

"Sweeping Operation"

Then news began to appear on internet platforms that a "sweeping operation" would be conducted at *Milliyet* and that I would be among those to be fired. I asked Hasan Cemal, who had transferred from *Sabah* to *Milliyet* two years earlier and who was also close to the boss, to investigate whether the news was true. The fact that there was no word from Hasan despite considerable time passing was not a good sign.

My last article in *Milliyet* was published on February 27, 2001. I was fired the next day. I was at CNN-Türk to do a program. My friend Naki Özkan, who had taken over as my assistant on the page after Nilüfer Kuyaş transferred to NTV about two years earlier and who started working in the editorial department when the page closed, called. He informed me that at the editorial meeting he attended, it was announced that about ten writers had been terminated, and I was one of them. The others whose employment was terminated were Doğan Heper, Yalçın Doğan, Umur Talu, Nilgün Cerrahoğlu, Yalım Eralp, Zeynep Oral, Duygu Asena, Turhan Selçuk, and Bedri Koraman. Among these, the ones I was most surprised to see let go were the last two names, two monuments of Turkish cartooning. (That summer I ran into Bedri Koraman on the Bandırma-Istanbul ferry. When the new editor-in-chief took office, he had told Aydın Doğan, "I can leave now if you want"; the boss's answer had been "Don't even think about it.")

Despite everything, and strangely enough, I was surprised to be suddenly fired. Apparently, I didn't expect such an ugly end to a job I believed I was doing well and for which I received praise. It couldn't have been my generally liberal views that criticized Kemalist, authoritarian secularism practices and looked favorably on the Gülen movement and the "Reformist" wing of the Virtue Party that caused this. Because my views on these issues were not much different from those of Taha Akyol, who was also writing at *Milliyet* at the time like me. This must have been the decision not of the boss but of Mehmet Y. Yılmaz, who apparently wanted to renew the newspaper, I thought. I called Taha and asked if I would continue with the CNN-Türk program. "I haven't received any notification to the contrary," he said. After congratulating me on my last interview with Yeşim Arat some time later, he confirmed that my job at CNN-Türk would continue; he added that he would do whatever he could if he could help in any other way. (Taha Akyol would always show that he was a true friend.)

Of course, I first informed Fatma that I had been fired. My dear immediately consoled me, saying "Don't worry, you'll find a job anyway…" When the news of my dismissal from the newspaper was heard, many people, especially close friends, called to express their sorrow. Among those who called, I noted the names of retired ambassadors İlter Türkmen, Şükrü Elekdağ, Oktay İşcen; politicians Ertuğrul Günay, Abdullah Gül, Mehmet Ali İrtemçelik, Sema Pişkinsüt, Salim Uslu; businessmen İshak Alaton, Murtaza Çelikel;

(Court of Cassation President) Sami Selçuk; from the press Mehmet Ali Birand, Ahmet Sever, Güneri Cıvaoğlu, Nazlı Ilıcak, Ali Bulaç, as well as diplomats Swedish Ambassador Henrik Liljegren and Istanbul Consul General Sture Theolin and EU Representative Karen Fogg. I was both surprised and pleased that TBMM Speaker Ömer İzgi, of MHP origin, called and spoke in praise of my writings and expressed his sorrow. I would also be surprised by the commiseration calls from Hasan Pulur and (my friend from the Ankara years) Melih Aşık, *Milliyet* colleagues with whom my views seldom coincided.

When Orhan Pamuk called, he said, “I used to buy Milliyet because you wrote there, I won’t buy it anymore.” Retired Ambassador Ümit Pamir called and said “I was reading all your articles. This country has no gratitude…” Social scientists Andrew Mango, Philip Robins, and Jan Erik Zürcher from abroad showed the kindness of calling. A message that made me happy was an unsigned note that one of our neighbors wrote on a mail envelope addressed to me: “My dear, can a valuable writer like you be fired? This is the state of our country!..” I was also pleased in the following days when Güler Sabancı, whom I met at my daughter Elvan’s art exhibition, said “I can’t say ‘my commiserations,’ because it’s a disgrace…”

Messages expressing solidarity continued for a while. I was pleased by the message from Bülent Gültekin, one of the former governors of the Central Bank, who was then a professor at the University of Pennsylvania’s Wharton School: “Dear Şahin Alpay, I am sorry that you have left *Milliyet* newspaper, or rather that you have been fired. I am not surprised. And I think this is the right outcome. It was not right for you to remain in these now completely corrupted institutions. You were giving them unnecessary legitimacy. I hope this unjust action spurs you on and provides an occasion for you to use your talents in better places. May you be together with your readers in more pleasant environments. If there is anything I can do during this transition period, please don’t hesitate to call. I can be considered experienced in resignations and departures. Much love.” (March 30, 2001)

My friend Zülfü Livaneli would also write the following in his column: “Şahin Alpay is my friend of 30 years. Recently we met for dinner with our esteemed history professor at Princeton University, Şükrü Hanioğlu. Şahin had also taught at Princeton as a visiting professor for a period. The conversation turned to the media and Hanioğlu told an interesting thing: The professors at Princeton occasionally ask what Şahin Alpay is doing. I tell them that he had to leave the newspaper he was working for, that is, he was fired. Then they are astonished and say ‘So the level of journalism in Turkey must be very high, even Princeton professors are not considered worthy of writing in newspapers’…” (*Sabah*, April 29, 2001)

“The Fish Rots from the Head”

A few months after I was dismissed from *Milliyet*, I ran into İsmet Berkan, my friend from *Cumhuriyet* who had taken over as editor-in-chief of Radikal in place of Mehmet Y. Yılmaz, on an Ankara flight. İsmet described the “sweeping operation” at *Milliyet* as follows: One day Aydın Doğan, Mehmet Yılmaz, and İsmet gathered. Yılmaz said he

wanted to change the newspaper's columnists, but that the boss needed to decide who would go. Thereupon Doğan, without thinking much, wrote the names he saw fit to send off one by one on a piece of paper… The proverb "The fish rots from the head" was apt; I had been wrong to hold Mehmet Y. Yılmaz responsible for my dismissal. Moreover, I knew that Doğan didn't like me at all. I was also aware that one of my last articles at *Milliyet*, titled "Quality in the Media," would not please him at all if he read it. In the article, I said:

"What has been happening in the media recently has been a good occasion for remembering the profession, principles, ethics, and ideals of journalism. I can touch on the main ones as follows: Under today's conditions, media owners cannot be expected to invest only in this sector. But we can hope that during the membership process, we will bring the principles that media owners will follow when entering public tenders, and the standards regarding the shares newspaper owners can have in other media, into line with EU norms.

"The problems of the media sector other than those related to ownership can only be solved by establishing professional principles and ethics. The foremost of these principles is that media owners and journalists avoid 'conflict of interest.' Today, with its increasing importance as a source of news, commentary, and information, the media has assumed a function even more significant than family and school in shaping citizens' values and behaviors, that is, their general and political culture. It has become all the more important for media owners to act with awareness that the media is not just any investment field.

"Media bosses should be meticulous about leaving the journalistic activities of the organizations they own entirely to journalists and not interfering with the journalistic aspect of the work. The prestige that media organizations operating according to professional principles will bring to their owners is too valuable to be measured by financial gain. The situation of those who don't think this way is instructive. As for journalists: Using one's profession as a tool for personal gain is both the greatest immorality and a crime. But there are other things journalists must avoid. A journalist cannot undertake work incompatible with the profession: cannot be both a journalist and a parliamentarian, politician, or member of intelligence organizations. They avoid establishing cozy relationships with political and economic power holders. There are drawbacks to being a journalist on one hand and a financial-administrative manager on the other, because the interests of the workplace can conflict with the interests of journalism (and thus the public).

"The distinction between news and commentary in journalism is as important as the separation of religion and state in politics. This does not only command that commentary not be made in news. It requires that the executives responsible for news and those responsible for commentary be different people. It is natural for journalists' salaries to be proportional to their skills and their contribution to the organization they work for: Some will earn less; some will earn more. However, if some journalists' salaries are higher than those of their colleagues in similar positions in the richest countries, the existence of a

‘media aristocracy’ attached to their high salaries rather than professional principles will be suspected.

“As journalists, we have a responsibility to keep quality high. A quality newspaper is not, as was claimed in Turkey until very recently, ‘a newspaper printed with the newest equipment, on the best paper, with the best ink,’ but a newspaper that strictly applies professional principles. In a country without quality media, neither press freedom nor democracy can function fully.” (October 31, 2000)

Interestingly, on the morning this article was published, Hakkı Devrim, a writer for Radikal newspaper who was one of the columnists Aydın Doğan respected most, called me by phone and congratulated me on this “courageous” article, greatly surprising me. The late Devrim also called when he learned I had been dismissed from *Milliyet*, said he was sorry; he described what was done as “rudeness.” I think he was right.

Looking for Work Again

When it was heard that I had been dismissed from *Milliyet*, the most valuable job offer I received came from “Açık Radyo.” Dear Meral (Madra) called and said, half-jokingly, that Açık Radyo could also pay me what I was getting from *Milliyet*, that they could support me for at least a year, and therefore not to rush to find a job. It was wonderful that Ömer also called and said, “Don’t you dare find a new job and leave Açık Radyo out.” In the mid-1990s, Ömer had said “Enough of being at the mercy of media bosses!” and decided to establish a free and independent radio station. I was, of course, one of the first people he shared this idea with. Açık Radyo (now 95.0) began broadcasting on November 13, 1995; Ömer had achieved the independent media he longed for.

From the early days of Açık Radyo (1995-1996; then between 1999-2004), I was a guest on Ömer’s “Açık Gazete” program and made political commentary. I have an interesting memory related to this (in the context of the power of radio in general and Açık Radyo in particular): One day in the late 1990s, I was traveling by bus from Ayvalık to Bandırma to catch the Istanbul ferry. The young man sitting next to me and I hadn’t talked at all during the trip. As we approached Bandırma, I happened to ask him something. When he heard me, his eyes lit up; “Are you Şahin Alpay?!” he asked. He had recognized me by my voice. He lived in Germany. He had never read any of my articles, had never seen me on screen, but he constantly listened to Açık Radyo… (You can imagine how happy Ömer was when I told him this anecdote.)

I would once again not listen to my wife Fatma, who had long been suggesting I start a publishing house and choose freedom, and would continue to be at the mercy of media bosses… One day, Ali Bulaç, one of the writers I had traveled to Central Asia with, called and invited me to write at *Zaman* newspaper. I didn’t give an immediate positive answer, because it hadn’t yet occurred to me that I would be left without options, and I wasn’t thinking of writing at a newspaper supported by a religious community… A job offer also came from Swedish Consul General Sture Theolin. After telling me that his wife Marit was very upset by my being fired from *Milliyet*, that her eyes had teared up, he suggested I work as a consultant for him. I was very touched, but I said I would primarily look for work in the media or universities. I was also pleased that Arne Ruth, one of

Sweden's well-known journalists and now retired editor-in-chief of Dagens Nyheter, called to offer his commiserations. My late friend Ufuk (Güldemir) also called and suggested I write for *Habertürk* newspaper, of which he was editor-in-chief. I said I would think about it.

NTV was on my mind. I gathered the courage and called Cem Aydın (a former "Aydınlıkçı"), who was then Editor-in-Chief. "Brother, we need you, come let's meet one day…" he said. When I called a few days later to make an appointment, he said, "Unfortunately, we can't do anything in the next month or two; if you're in a tight spot, you can do a radio program for us." It was apparent that he couldn't get approval from his boss regarding me…

Then Nebil İlseven, whom I had known since childhood and who was at the time on the Board of Trustees of Bilgi University, conveyed that the university's founder Oğuz Özerden wanted to meet with me. When we met, Özerden, who pleased me by saying he constantly followed my newspaper articles and my commentary on Açık Radyo, had in mind that I would turn "Medyakronik," a publication of the university, into what he called an outlet "that intellectuals follow," and also that I would manage the university's EU Studies Institute. When I said I would prefer to teach, he said he would need to discuss that matter with rector İlter Turan, who was abroad. Later he would convey that Turan had told him "they didn't need Şahin Alpay," and that he was very sorry about this.

CHAPTER X / AT BAHÇEŞEHİR UNIVERSITY

At the beginning of the 21st century, I was living through a very happy period in my family life. There was no deterioration in the health of my beloved wife Fatma. The liver failure diagnosed in 1987 generally left her tired and weak, but it did not pose a life-threatening danger. Our daughter Elvan, who graduated from the Fine Arts Faculty of Marmara University after finishing Galatasaray Lycée, was rapidly advancing toward becoming a painter whose original works garnered admiration. From her 1994 marriage to businessman Altan Güler, a daughter — my beloved granddaughter Defne — was born in 1997. (Sadly, this marriage, which did not bring happiness, would end about ten years later.) Our son Acar would go on to study graphic design at the Fine Arts Faculty of Bilkent University after graduating from Işık Lycée. After completing his short-term military service in Sivas in 2004, he began working in his profession. The arrival of our second grandchild Leyla, born in 2014 from his marriage in 2009 to our much-loved daughter-in-law Gökçe (Özkaya), would be the pinnacle of our family happiness. I want to emphasize that not being able to devote enough time to my grandchildren, just as with my children, due to my demanding professional life, has remained a lasting regret.

Before long, a period of stability would open up in my professional life as well. An important pillar of this would be Bahçeşehir University (henceforth by its abbreviated name, BAU), where I would work full-time for fourteen years. One day in early March 2001, Prof. Dr. Süheyl Batum — whom I had met in the days of TÜSES (the Turkish Social, Economic and Political Research Foundation) and who had transferred from Galatasaray University to BAU to assume the deanship of the Law Faculty — called me.

He suggested I teach at BAU, “at least until you find another job in the media…” In truth, I had not even been aware of BAU’s existence until Dr. Ahmet Sözen (now a professor at Eastern Mediterranean University in Cyprus), who was teaching there and had taken an interest in my writings, came to visit me at *Milliyet* to make my acquaintance. I hesitated. The person who convinced me to work at BAU was Prof. Dr. Eser Karakaş, whom I had met at New Democracy Movement gatherings and who was then the dean of BAU’s Business Faculty. Karakaş — whom I ran into at a conference on March 16 and who would gradually become one of my closest friends — said, “Şahin Bey, we want you to work for us full-time.” When Rector Halil Güven, whom he introduced me to at the same meeting, repeated the same proposal, my future was settled.

Karakaş and I agreed and shook hands on my going to Bahçeşehir three days a week to give a total of nine hours of political science lectures, as well as on the salary and other matters. However, when I pointed out that I did not even have a driver’s license, let alone a car, and asked how I would get back and forth from Akatlar where I lived to Bahçeşehir, Eser’s face fell completely. “From now on, the first thing I’ll ask the people I offer jobs to is whether they have a driver’s license,” he exclaimed! We burst out laughing… (Poor Eser would pick me up from my home and drive me to Bahçeşehir and back for months, sometimes with a driver, sometimes without.)

A few days later, I met the university’s founder, Enver Yücel. After graduating from the Mathematics Department of İstanbul Atatürk Education Institute, Yücel had taught for a while in his hometown of Giresun, then entered the business world and over time established the Uğur Preparatory Schools, then the Bahçeşehir Colleges, and finally BAU (reportedly “so his daughter could study there”). As would become clearer with time, he was a very energetic, intelligent, and shrewd businessman. After obtaining his approval as well, I started work at BAU as a lecturer on April 1, 2001; I taught for approximately fourteen years until February 2015 (with the status of Assistant Professor between 2005 and 2011).

In the days when I joined the faculty, BAU was operating out of an old high school building in the Bahçeşehir neighborhood from which it took its name, along with a few villas nearby. There was talk of building a campus on a large plot of land in the vicinity. But the institution grew rapidly and in 2004 would move to its current buildings in Beşiktaş, gradually spreading into the surrounding area. This move was a great blessing for me, living as I did in Akatlar. More importantly, the university’s teaching staff kept expanding and became a circle of friends for me. My senior colleagues Seyfettin Gürsel from Galatasaray University and İlkay Sunar and Binnaz Toprak from Boğaziçi University, along with economist Nuri Yıldırım (my friend from the Ideas Club at SBF, the Faculty of Political Sciences), joined us at my urging. First İlkay, then Binnaz served as chair of the Political Science and International Relations department. I would also become friends there with Murat Çizakça, who joined us shortly after me. Among us, Gürsel would be the most enduring presence at BAU. As of 2022, when these lines were written, he was continuing his professorship while also serving as director of BETAM (Bahçeşehir University Center for Economic and Social Research), which he had steadily developed.

Over fourteen years, I taught various courses in undergraduate and graduate programs. The principal ones were required courses such as Introduction to Political Science, Introduction to Turkish Political Life, Comparative Politics, and Turkish Foreign Policy, along with an elective course on Religion and Politics. I must confess that I prepared seriously for every course I taught, and I reaped great benefit from this in terms of expanding my knowledge. In particular, the reading I did in preparation for the Religion and Politics course — which I would teach from 2003 until my departure in 2015 — would profoundly influence my thinking on the place of religion in society and politics. Both the rise to power of the AKP (Justice and Development Party), a party with Islamist roots, in 2002, and my beginning to write for the newspaper *Zaman* — published by a religious community — around the same time had certainly been strong incentives for me to take on the Religion and Politics course, which I knew was widely taught at Western universities.

I was happy working at BAU. The boss, Enver Yücel, treated me with particular respect during the 2002–2011 period when my columns took a favorable view of the AKP government. The esteem I enjoyed from him during this period would peak at a meeting attended by nearly all the faculty, when he declared, “Wherever Şahin Hoca is, that’s where I’ll be…” My standing would last until November 2013. Enver Bey would call to congratulate me on the column I wrote (titled “No tolerance for civil society”) about the AKP government’s decision to shut down preparatory schools, saying, “You’ve captured the essence of the matter.” Yet from that point on, as I began writing increasingly harsh columns critical of the AKP government, our relationship would gradually cool, and — as I will recount later — in February 2015 he would decline to renew my contract (while implying that he did so unwillingly).

At BAU, the rectors, the deans, and the department chairs — most of whom were my friends — all treated me well. Unlike the media world, I was happy to be among highly educated colleagues. It was very gratifying to be ranked among the most popular professors in student evaluations. The fact that young women made up the large majority of my successful students was one of the things that made me optimistic about Turkey’s future.

This may not be the place, but I cannot help touching on a subject that I never addressed in any column during my time at BAU. My command of English had also played a role in my finding a job at BAU, since BAU was one of the institutions of higher education where the language of instruction was English. I have no objection to the opening of private universities — provided they do not compromise on quality — nor to instruction in a foreign language in higher education. However, while everyone knows that foreign language education at the secondary level is virtually nonexistent (excluding foreign schools), it is equally certain that one year of intensive language instruction in higher education cannot suffice. For this reason, English-medium instruction at BAU — as at other English-medium institutions of higher education — sadly remained largely nominal. My conviction, therefore, is that instruction in a foreign language has become one of the obstacles to receiving a proper higher education in Turkey! To overcome the problem, like many other faculty members, I limited the English requirement to the

assigned readings for courses, and conducted both lectures and examinations in Turkish. No one was in a position to object.

My eye still on the media

When I began working at BAU in April 2001, I was still doing the “Intellectual Perspective” program on CNN Türk. One day, at the Hürriyet / CNN Türk building in İkitelli where I had gone to record the program, I ran into Hasan Cemal. He asked how I was. I told him I was content with my life, that although I missed newspaper writing, I was not too unhappy with my situation since I was freed from the stress of producing columns on deadline. I also asked the question I had been wanting to ask: “Did it never occur to you to ask the boss why he fired Şahin from *Milliyet*?” He said it hadn’t, because being let go was a perfectly ordinary thing in the Turkish press… “So Hasan Cemal saw nothing unusual about my being fired!” I thought, and felt somewhat resentful. But I reminded myself of what I often said to him: “Nobody’s perfect…”

Then something interesting happened. While trying to call my Mülkiye friend Prof. Dr. Nuri Yıldırım, I accidentally dialed Nuri Çolakoğlu, one of my oldest friends. When Çolakoğlu asked what I was up to, I told him I was working as a lecturer at BAU and that I “hadn’t been fired yet” from CNN Türk. Nuri surprised me by saying, “Why would they fire you? You lend them prestige…” A few days later, in early October, when it was announced that Taha Akyol had handed over the post of editor-in-chief of CNN Türk to Nuri Çolakoğlu, I called to congratulate him and naturally asked whether the program I was doing could continue; I asked him to tell me personally if the boss should want my employment ended. “The program will of course continue, but let’s think about a new format together,” he said, and asked me to consult him about which guests I would have on. He cautioned me that “a global February 28 had begun” and that I should steer clear of names like Şerafettin Elçi or Mehmet Şevket Eygi.

Naturally, I continued doing the program as I saw fit. (As is well known, I was committed in principle to “editorial independence”…) I don’t know whether it was for this reason, but some time later, in March 2002 — just as at *Milliyet* in February 2001 — my employment at CNN Türk was terminated one day abruptly and rather shabbily. When I went to the channel for a recording, a third-tier manager informed me that the program had been cancelled and there would be no taping. I was forced to call and apologize to that day’s scheduled guest, the late Professor Dr. Nur Vergin.

Being fired from CNN Türk in such a similar fashion after *Milliyet* had been quite hard to take. Unfortunately, this was the “culture” of the media owned by Aydın Doğan. (How could I have known that the group would later pass into far “worse” hands?!) Because of this incident, I was deeply resentful toward Nuri and cut off all contact. Yet when he called Fatma following my imprisonment in the summer of 2016, and then called me after my release, our old friendship was revived. He would tell me that he had no hand in the cancellation of my program at CNN Türk, that it had been done without his knowledge.

I was content with my job at BAU, but partly because I wanted to share my ideas by writing in newspapers as I had grown accustomed to over the years, and partly because

I needed supplementary income, I began searching for a writing position. When my program at CNN Türk was cancelled in March 2002, my search became more urgent. Shortly after I had started working at BAU, the late Kürşat Bumin had called and told me that, from what he had heard, the newspaper *Zaman* wanted to add me to its staff, and that Ali Bulaç had even gone to the United States to discuss the matter personally with Fethullah Gülen. Kürşat would call again a few days later to say that word had reached him that *Zaman*'s management would offer Etyen Mahçupyan and me positions writing columns five days a week.

Sure enough, Bulaç called and asked whether I would agree in principle to write for *Zaman*. I merely said, "Let's talk…" since it was certain that Fatma would not approve. Word must have gotten out that *Zaman* was interested in me, because at a dinner that EU Representative Karen Fogg hosted for Istanbul journalists, Cüneyt Ülsever — then a columnist at *Hürriyet* — while heaping praise on my writing, spoke warmly in support of my writing for *Zaman*… Yet for a long time, no concrete offer would come from *Zaman*.

A journey to origins

In October 2001, I was in Athens for the Turkish-Greek-Cypriot journalists' forum that the German Friedrich Ebert Foundation (FES) had been organizing for years. On October 20, my Greek colleague Michalis Moronis did me the kindness of driving me to Serres, where my father was born. I saw that only two mosques from the Ottoman-Turkish era remained in Serres — one restored, the other under restoration — and that a surviving bedesten building had been converted into a Greek historical museum. I was overjoyed to find in a bookshop a photographic history of Serres. The photographs bore witness to the classical Ottoman architecture (based on wooden buildings) and the hundreds of minarets rising across a city that, until the Balkan Wars (1910–1912), had been predominantly Muslim — two-thirds of the population, according to Mark Mazower. I could not help reflecting on how ruthlessly both sides had turned their backs on their histories.

After returning from Serres, when I visited my paternal relative Yahya Alantar in Adapazarı, he told me something I had never heard before: my paternal grandmother's (Mukaddes Hanım's) maternal great-grandfather was "the conqueror of Crimea, Ömer Lütfi Pasha, of Hungarian origin," and his wife was Maria, the daughter of a Serbian prince. I found the story of Ömer Lütfi Pasha (1806–1871) in the Encyclopedia of Islam. He was described as being of Hungarian origin, but was born in Croatia. In pursuit of the family tree, I visited Zehra Abla, the daughter of my father's maternal aunt. She told me that Kadı Osman Bey — the father of my father's maternal grandmother Güllü Hanım and the son of Ömer Lütfi Pasha — had come from Crimea and settled in Serres. Could Agâh Efendi, the Mevlevi Sheikh of Serres, have been Osman Bey's son? I was unable to confirm it. If everything I learned was true, our origins and lineage were quite mixed; apparently there was Croatian, Serbian, and Crimean (Tatar?) ancestry as well.

Karen Fogg's "secret organization"

The magazine *Aydınlık*, whose editor-in-chief was Workers' Party Chairman Doğu Perinçek, proclaimed on the cover of its February 10, 2002 issue: "We have obtained Karen Fogg's secret correspondence: How to bring the Turkish state to heel…" The internet correspondence that *Aydınlık* had "managed to obtain" proved (!) that Fogg, the EU's representative in Ankara, was scheming to "bring the Turkish state to heel."

The cover story was remarkable in two respects: it showed how deep-seated hostility toward the EU and the West in general was in Turkey, and what conspiracy theories — in other words, the invention of theories bearing no relation whatsoever to the facts — were capable of. The article stated the following: EU Representative Karen Fogg had established a special organization. This Special Organization operated under EU Commissioner for Enlargement Verheugen… Fogg's Special Organization in Turkey included government officials, top-level state administrators, certain trade union leaders, "civil society" leaders, certain retired generals linked to the Çevik Bir junta, certain academics, and certain agent-journalists… In her correspondence, Fogg explicitly stated the aim of bringing the Turkish state to heel… On this basis, the magazine demanded that Fogg be "immediately expelled from the country."

Yes, you guessed it: according to *Aydınlık*, I was one of the "agent-journalists" who belonged to Fogg's "organization" and corresponded with her by email (along with Mehmet Ali Birand, Sami Kohen, Semih İdiz, Cengiz Çandar, Lale Sarıibrahimoğlu, Metin Münir, Ferai Tınç, and Zeynep Göğüş). After reproducing the brief message I had sent Fogg saying I wanted to introduce her to Eser Karakaş, *Aydınlık* included these amusing lines about me: "We leave it to our magazine's expert on turncoats, Hasan Yalçın, to evaluate the meaning of the warmth in the correspondence that begins with the salutations 'Dear Karen' and 'Dear Şahin' and in which they even share their sleeping hours, and to assess the state of mind of Fogg's 'chat buddy' Şahin Alpay, who once championed proletarian revolution against the Karen Foggs of the world and now, together with her, tries to rouse 'sleeping beauties' against the Turkish nation-state…"

As can be seen, the magazine's claims extended from the fact that we addressed each other as "Dear" in a few email exchanges — as is customary in English — all the way to the insinuation that Fogg and I had a "warm relationship." The reality was this: EU Representative Fogg would come to Istanbul on several occasions and host columnists who took an interest in Turkey-EU relations for an exchange of views. I was one of those invited. My being among those whom *Aydınlık* magazine accused of being "agent-journalists" was interesting in the following respect: *Aydınlık*'s editor-in-chief Doğu Perinçek, who had been my "comrade in the cause" between 1968 and 1971, and I had parted ways never to cross paths again. Over time, we had both abandoned communism; he chose an increasingly hardline Turkish ethnic nationalism, while I chose liberal social democracy. (Perinçek would say in 2021, the year these lines were written, "It is an honor to lead the MHP [Nationalist Movement Party].") Just as I had completely cut off contact with him after our last meeting in 1971 and avoided so much as uttering his name, I did not see the need to respond to his declaring me an "EU agent"; I left it to the public's judgment. I mention the incident here because the Doğu Perinçek / Şahin

Alpay comparison must be a striking example of how members of the ’68 generation could diverge onto such different paths.

Following the interception and publication of Fogg’s emails, European Commission President Romano Prodi called Prime Minister Bülent Ecevit to express his displeasure at the incident and requested that the communication security of EU representatives be ensured. The Commission spokesperson denied claims that Fogg would be recalled and said there had been no such demand from Turkey either. (NTVMSNBC, February 20, 2002) Nevertheless, Fogg — perhaps at Brussels’ urging — left her position at the Commission. In July 2002, shortly before departing Turkey where she had served for four years, she would answer the questions of *A Haber* magazine as follows:

“*Are you angry about the uproar over the emails?* — I’m not, but the reaction of the Turkish authorities was disappointing. I was surprised that an injunction could not be issued against the illegal distribution… It was a great misfortune, because it was grossly misinterpreted, distorted, and exploited by people with questionable political ideologies. Turkey was harmed by this at least as much as I was.

“*What was the biggest distortion?* — I don’t waste my time with what Perinçek thinks I said, but the most ridiculous distortion was about HOR. Incredible! Even after I denied it, there were those who insisted that by HOR I meant the President of the Republic (Head of the Republic) and that I was attacking him. Anyone with even the slightest knowledge of the EU Commission would have understood that HOR stood for Head of Representation — that is, me!”

Toward *Zaman*

Autumn 2002 had arrived and I had begun my second academic year at BAU. One day, Eyüp Can (Sağlık) — who had also conducted interviews with me for *Zaman* — came to visit me and conveyed *Zaman*’s offer of a column. None of my searches at other newspapers had borne fruit; I said I could consider writing for *Zaman*. Some time later he called again and informed me that a meeting had been arranged for me with the editor-in-chief Ekrem Dumanlı. At the time, familiar figures such as Hilmi Yavuz, Etyen Mahçupyan, Nuriye Akman, and even Cem Behar from Boğaziçi University were writing columns for *Zaman*. Even the late Sami Kohen — my office neighbor who had come to my room on the day I was fired from *Milliyet* to express his regret — had said, “You could write for *Zaman*… It’s a serious newspaper, it would suit you…”

On the day and at the time Eyüp Can had indicated, I went to *Zaman*’s old administrative headquarters in Yeni Bosna. Mehmet Gündem and Zafer Özcan, newspaper staff whom I had known for some time, greeted me. Eyüp unfortunately had not been able to come because something had come up. Dumanlı and I were introduced. After some pleasantries, I told him I could write a column three days a week for *Zaman*. In response, he actually said they had no need for a new writer!!! I could not believe my ears… What had I been reduced to!.. I was furious at Eyüp Can, and even more so at myself…

A few days passed; Eyüp Can came again. He apologized profusely for what had happened, implying that Dumanlı had not known what he was doing. He said they wanted me to start writing two days a week, and that in time I could write three times a week like the other columnists… It was plainly obvious that there was an authority above Dumanlı at the newspaper *Zaman*, and that this authority was none other than Fethullah Gülen himself. I told Eyüp Can that to give him a positive answer, I needed to obtain approval from BAU's administration. The proposal made sense to me, but how was I going to convince Fatma?!

I first broached the subject with Eser Karakaş. Eser was positive; he said that if the boss gave permission, he too would like to write once a week for *Zaman*. The next day, he came with the news that Enver Bey had said "that would be fine" for both of us. The boss had said, "They want to use you, but you can use them too…" The boss had probably caught the scent that the Justice and Development Party, which *Zaman* was close to at the time, would soon come to power.

Now came the main issue: obtaining Fatma's approval. She was telling me to focus on the university, that we had no need for me to wear myself out for extra income… İshak Alaton came to my rescue. When I mentioned in a phone conversation that I had received an offer to write for *Zaman*, he gave his enthusiastic support. When I told him that Fatma viewed it negatively, he took the phone and explained to her at length that *Zaman* was a very important newspaper, both for its Muslim identity and its affinity for liberal (freedom-loving and pluralist) views, and yes, he convinced Fatma. Thus Sami Kohen, the distinguished representative of the Jewish minority in the media, had convinced me, while İshak Alaton, the distinguished representative in the business world, had convinced my wife to accept my writing for *Zaman*… I called Eyüp Can and gave him my positive answer. I said they could also invite Eser Karakaş to write. And so, from November 2002 onward, I began writing twice a week, soon three times a week, and Eser once a week for *Zaman*. (May he rest in peace, Alaton passed away in 2017, while I was imprisoned in Silivri. When he heard of my arrest, he had told someone close to him that he deeply regretted having encouraged me to write for *Zaman*; "We got the boy into trouble…" he had said.)

When I went this time to discuss the details, Dumanlı was somewhat sheepish. Etyen Mahçupyan — whom I had known since the 1990s and who had contributed to "Intellectual Perspective" at both *Sabah* and *Milliyet* — was also in his office. When we left the newspaper together, Etyen told me that it was he who had suggested they invite me to write for the paper. Bless him, years later (while I was residing in Silivri prison), he would write the following about my relationship with *Zaman*:

"I wrote a column for *Zaman* newspaper for nearly ten years, leaving aside the intervening *Agos* and *Taraf* period. I was probably the first writer to come from the secular camp… After a while they wanted to bring on Şahin Alpay as well, and Editor-in-Chief Ekrem Dumanlı asked me to speak with him. Şahin thought about it for a long time, remained undecided, and resisted this transition, which in his world meant a 'major' change. His entire family, friends, and companions were secular leftists… But after a while he moved away from viewing the Islamic sector through a secularist lens and

began writing for *Zaman* newspaper. Those were the years when there was a nearly organic closeness between the AK Party and the Gülen community, and when the secularist/statist status quo was trying by every means to halt the wave of Islamic conservative power coming from the periphery. Şahin, insofar as he was someone who could channel his militant left-wing past into a freedom-loving mold and increasingly embraced pure liberalism, supported the positive work the Gülen community was doing at the societal level. He found the criticisms directed at the community's political aims to be speculative. But he was never part of the Gülen movement or a political sympathizer." ("What had Şahin Alpay done?", *Karar*, October 29, 2017)

"In my youth I was an atheist, now I'm an inconsistent deist"

Two days before my first column appeared in *Zaman*, on November 3, 2002, Nuriye Akman's interview introducing me to the newspaper's readers was published. I reproduce below in its entirety the interview, which ran under the headline "Şahin Alpay: I am philosophically a turncoat, and I am proud of it."

Dear Şahin Alpay, welcome to our newspaper. I am extremely pleased to meet with you here. I think the most straightforward way to introduce you to our readers is for you to tell your life story. Because this story will also give us all the opportunity to do a media analysis. If you like, let's begin from February 2001, when you were 'fired' from Milliyet, *where you had worked for nearly seven years.*

Ten writers and cartoonists were let go along with me. Although this purge was explained by the economic crisis, many new writers were hired shortly afterward. Clearly a staff change was what they wanted. No one can object to that, of course. What offended me was that our dismissal from the newspaper was not even communicated to us personally by the paper's owner or editor-in-chief. We had deserved at least a letter or phone call of thanks.

It's a pattern of gracelessness. For instance, I left Sabah *without even being able to collect my retirement bonus. They still haven't paid it. When I ran into Zafer Mutlu by chance at the airport and asked, he said to me, "I've built a wall, nobody can get past that wall." I understand very well how your heart was broken…*

Last July, it fell to Nuri Çolakoğlu — my friend of forty years, with whom I had spent ten years of my life — to end my program at CNN Türk. He too ended my employment in the manner of *Milliyet* Editor-in-Chief Mehmet Yılmaz, someone I barely knew. He did not even deign to make a phone call. I think these are not things that befit colleagues.

Perhaps there was no need for the kind of program you were doing.

Perhaps, but my objection is to colleagues not treating each other as colleagues. Only journalists themselves can protect the principles, ethics, and freedom of the press. If we don't stand up for the dignity of our own profession and our colleagues, if we allow the owners to push us around, things get completely out of hand, as they have in Turkey.

Why did it turn out this way?

The owners used the media as an instrument for their non-media interests and made undeservedly vast sums of money. By paying certain executives and columnists salaries and providing perks unseen anywhere else in the world, they created a media aristocracy. Because these people owed their income levels to the owners, they became "their masters' voice." Whether professional principles were being trampled or not was no longer their concern. During the debates over the RTÜK (Radio and Television Supreme Council) Law, the media aristocracy was so blatantly exposed… Even writers who presented themselves as paragons of democracy either defended this law — which was contrary to the constitutional amendments and the EU's Copenhagen criteria, and which trampled on press freedom — or fell silent, because their owners wanted them to. The owners also eliminated unionization in the press. The disorganization and fragmentation among journalists, as a serious obstacle to press freedom, even made it into EU progress reports.

Why couldn't you become part of the media aristocracy?

I always earned less than I deserved in the media. Some of my colleagues, upon hearing my salary, could not restrain themselves from saying "that's a disgrace"… I received a good upbringing. Just as I always knew my place, I never groveled before anyone for the sake of money.

If Aydın Doğan were to invite you back, despite everything, wouldn't you go?

No, never… The money they earned thoroughly spoiled the media aristocracy. They committed every manner of vulgarity. At a panel on quality in the press, some editors-in-chief of major newspapers said: "Our newspapers are very high quality. Because they use the finest ink, the best quality paper, and are printed on the most modern presses…" I remember the audience bursting into laughter.

What did you see that was different at Zaman *that made you come?*

As soon as I left *Milliyet*, they said "Come right away" from *Zaman*. But I had started teaching political science courses at Bahçeşehir University… As you know, I am primarily a political scientist. I did my doctorate in Sweden, at Stockholm University. Because of the September 12 coup, I had been unable to return to academia… On the other hand, I had decided to continue with the program at CNN Türk. I thought you can't carry three watermelons under one arm. But once my job at CNN Türk ended, I knocked on the doors of the newspapers.

Including Cumhuriyet and Star?

Not quite. *Cumhuriyet* was out of the question, because I had resigned from there in 1992. Honestly, I never even considered *Star*. There was no response from the other papers. *Zaman*, on the other hand, renewed its invitation. I owe *Zaman* a sincere debt of gratitude for giving me the opportunity to write again. For now, I'll write two days a week. We may increase it to three later on. Of course, having received an invitation was not the only reason I accepted *Zaman*'s offer.

I think the real reason is your desire to strengthen the existence of a "gray" area in this polarized, "black or white" media.

Correct… I received a good education. I have had rich experiences in life. I want to share my knowledge and accumulated insight. For me to find fulfillment as an intellectual, I need to be able to say what I think and to make my analysis heard. Unfortunately, the prevailing view in our country equates journalism with news reporting. Perhaps partly because of this, nearly all columns have become news-writing spaces, while news stories are filled with commentary. Yet journalism has two branches: commentary and reporting. Unfortunately, in our country they are conflated, whether consciously or not.

Ah! You've come to just the right place. Zaman *is perhaps the only newspaper that is aware of this distinction.*

Yes, that's right. So first of all, I'm at *Zaman* because they wanted me. Second, for the past year there has been an effort at *Zaman* toward professionalization — toward putting out a serious newspaper that applies professional principles. A serious newspaper where everyone can read accurate news and different, high-quality commentary…

There was a similar situation at Cumhuriyet *in the early 1980s, I believe.*

You can think of *Cumhuriyet* in those days as a secular, left-wing community. In those days, I was part of a young cadre who were themselves leftists but had renewed their views and begun to value freedom, and who believed Turkey needed a serious newspaper that applied professional standards. The community's mostly elderly leaders reacted strongly against this cadre's effort to professionalize the paper. They panicked: "We are defending an ideology that's a mix of Kemalism and Marxism here… These people are going to turn this newspaper into a liberal paper that anyone can read…"

And they won, not you.

Yes, after ten years of wrangling it became clear this marriage could not work. We, the younger generation, left *Cumhuriyet* and scattered across the entire media. Now at *Zaman* there is also a young cadre. They too say, "We are journalists, and we should make *Zaman* a real newspaper." I don't know how the people running the paper will take this. But the young ones tell me, "We're only getting encouragement."

And from what I understand, you are saying, "If there's a group trying to liberalize, I'll put my shoulder to the wheel."

I too want to lend my support to this effort. There is yet another reason I write for *Zaman*: the polarization you just mentioned… I know that the overwhelming majority of Turkish society does not approve of the religionist-secularist polarization. I see that the middle ground — which opposes both kinds of bigotry — needs to be strengthened. I am as much against the suppression of religion and belief in the name of secularism as I am against the suppression of freedoms in the name of religion, and I will never compromise

on this stance in any way. As long as *Zaman* newspaper continues to publish my columns, I will write them. One reason I was let go from *Milliyet* may well have been my opposition to secularist bigotries.

Have you come to terms with your Maoist past?

In the 1960s I was a leftist who became progressively radicalized. It began with sympathy for Mehmet A. Aybar's Workers' Party of Turkey. It went as far as believing that the truest path was the one shown by Mao… Actually, it started like this: in 1961–62, on an AFS (American Field Service) scholarship, I went to attend senior year at one of California's most famous high schools. When I returned, the question in my mind was, "Why is Turkey so poor and why are these Americans so rich?"

And the Workers' Party of Turkey offered you an answer: Because of imperialism…

Yes, I got caught in that chain. And my search ultimately led me to Mao. Let's not forget that in those years, the West was experiencing the '68 Revolution and the East the Cultural Revolution. It was a period when critiques of capitalism had become very radical. My ideas radicalized to a degree that exceeded even my own nature. In truth, I am a thoroughly conventional person, deeply devoted to family life. But intellectually I was a revolutionary. Intellectual inquiry and experience eventually showed me that the things done in the name of leftism were producing results exactly opposite to what was intended. I began to be horrified by the things we had done. But for a while, of course, it was not possible to — how shall I put it — tarnish one's own valor. In the end, though, God helped me and I freed myself from those errors.

Really? Are you a religious person?

I am definitely not devout. But I am culturally Muslim. I think a creator may exist. In my youth I was an atheist. My current position could be defined as deism. Over time, I came to appreciate the meaning and importance that religion holds for people. I reached the conclusion that religious beliefs must be respected and that religious faith is as valuable as intellectual conviction.

So how did God help?

After the March 12 intervention, I was a wanted man. The reason was the articles I had written in left-wing magazines. I fled Turkey. I spent nine months in the ranks of the Palestine Liberation Organization. Then I returned to Turkey. The movement fell apart. With the help of my family — especially my late older brother — I escaped to Sweden. I put my life in order. I began doctoral studies at Stockholm University. But I was never involved in any armed action.

In those days you were together with Doğu Perinçek. What is your relationship like today?

After 1971, I think we met only once. He keeps having things written about me in his magazines calling me a "turncoat." But I am philosophically a turncoat, and I am proud of

it. If a person decides he is intellectually on the wrong path, he should correct himself. The greatest virtue of democracy, after all, is that it gives both societies and individuals the opportunity to turn back from their mistakes. Democracy is an educator. It makes radicals moderate.

You also taught for a period at Princeton University, didn't you?

During the years 1982–2001, when I was primarily working as a journalist, I also found opportunities to make use of my academic side. While at *Cumhuriyet*, I taught opinion writing at Anadolu University's Faculty of Communication; in the 1994–95 academic year, I gave courses on Scandinavian Political Life at Boğaziçi University. At Princeton University, I taught a seminar on Turkish Political Life in the spring semester of 1998.

Have you ever given thought to metaphysical questions?

No. Definitely don't look for a spiritualist side in me. I grew up in a secular family. My mother's father was an atheist member of the Committee of Union and Progress, while my maternal grandmother was an extremely devout lady. But they were so in love with each other that a year after my grandfather's death, my grandmother too died of grief. On both my father's maternal and paternal sides, they were Mevlevi sheikhs. They came from Serres, which was a Muslim city until 1913. My mother's side, on the other hand, was from Midilli (Lesbos). In the family I grew up in, religion had become an entirely personal matter. No one interfered with anyone else's beliefs. My late mother, between her own mother and father, took a somewhat agnostic, skeptical stance. My father never discussed religious matters. Both of them, like all immigrants from Rumelia, were deeply devoted to Mustafa Kemal.

So there is a very strong secular vein in your upbringing.

Yes. But we need to distinguish between secularism and secularist ideology. Secularism also entails full respect for religion. It does not mean the suppression of religion. I believe that social problems stem not from a conflict between believers and non-believers, but from the contradiction between the poor and the destitute, between those who can exercise their rights and those whose rights are denied. I used to think that Proudhon's famous dictum — that property is theft — was the absolute truth. But the conclusion I reached over time was this: Property is liberty…

Let's talk a bit about your family too…

I have a very happy marriage. My wife Fatma is my youthful sweetheart… She was studying pedagogy at Istanbul University. She dropped out of her studies and came to Ankara because I was going to finish Mülkiye and join the Foreign Service… We were separated between 1971 and 1974. She played a great part in my finding the path of reason… I am proud of the achievements of my daughter Elvan, who is a painter. My son Acar is a graphic designer, a recent graduate of Bilkent University. That our children became artists is a great source of happiness for us."

Perhaps the most notable question in this interview was the one about my religious beliefs. In my youth, I had been an atheist until my thirties; when I felt the need to pray

during the very difficult times I lived through (even if in my mother tongue), I began, out of honesty, to describe myself as a deist. I may have been the first person in Turkey to openly describe himself as a deist. I should note on this occasion that there was a serious inconsistency in my deism. For deists — the most famous of whom were America's founding fathers — believe that a creator, having created the universe, does not intervene in its workings. I, on the other hand, was the kind of deist who prayed and thereby invited the creator to intervene in my fate — an inconsistent deist, in other words. I would become increasingly conscious of this inconsistency.

CHAPTER XI / 14 YEARS AT ZAMAN

Zaman was the newspaper I wrote for the longest. For approximately 14 years, I wrote a column three days a week for *Zaman*. My first article was published on November 5, 2002; my last on February 27, 2016. I also wrote a weekly column for *Today's Zaman*, the English-language newspaper that the Zaman group began publishing in November 2007. On March 4, 2016, both newspapers were seized by court order and a trustee was appointed. Following this, some Zaman employees started publishing two newspapers on March 6. I wrote for one of them, *Yarina Bakis* (Looking to Tomorrow). My last article opposing calls for military intervention against the AKP government was published on July 14, 2016, one day before the coup attempt of July 15. The weekly commentary program called "Akil Defteri" (Notebook of Reason), which I did together with Mehmet Altan and Eser Karakas on Mehtap TV, one of the Zaman group's television channels, and which attracted considerable attention, would also be broadcast for ten years between 2006 and 2016.

When I started writing for *Zaman* in 2002, I certainly knew that it was the media organ of the religious community led by Fethullah Gulen, or as they called themselves, the Hizmet (Service) Movement. I saw no problem in writing there. My view of religion had changed over time. People had not only material but also spiritual needs; religious beliefs maintained their power in almost all societies. On the other hand, if the liberal and pluralist democracy I advocated was to take root in Turkey, there was a great need for an interpretation of Islam compatible with it. I thought Gulen represented such an interpretation of Islam. By writing for *Zaman*, I could continue to defend liberal democracy as I had done before at *Cumhuriyet*, *Sabah*, and *Milliyet*, and in this way I could also influence the views of Gulen community members. As an intellectual, I was burning with the desire to write for newspapers and share my ideas with society as I had been doing since the 1980s. Moreover, my monthly salary from the university was insufficient for my living expenses; I also needed additional income. Only *Zaman* in the Turkish press was giving me the opportunity to write.

What Kind of Community?

By writing for their newspapers, speaking on their television channels, and visiting the schools they opened both domestically and abroad, I had the opportunity to get to know the Gulen community, or as they called themselves, the Hizmet Movement, to some extent. *To some extent*, because my views and impressions about the community were

limited in several ways: First of all, I was working full-time at the university. I knew the community primarily through my contacts with media organizations, mainly with *Zaman* employees. My contact with the newspaper was also limited to writer meetings held a few times a year, and largely to my dialogue with opinion page editors. In short, I was looking at the community "from the outside"; I was not familiar with its non-transparent aspects or internal workings.

As I explained above, I viewed the Community positively, with "benevolence," on the grounds that it represented a liberal interpretation of Islam. The modern building in Yeni Bosna, where the newspaper would move shortly after I started writing, resembled a beehive. A quiet but intense work routine was in place that I had not seen in any other newspaper I had worked for. I explained this with the work ethic expressed by the concept of "Hizmet" (Service), working for the benefit of society with religious motivation. I would see the same work routine and ethics in other workplaces of the Community. Yes, I was aware that there was a "closed" or, as its opponents put it, "non-transparent" quality in the Community's operations. However, I did not find the criticisms in this direction important, considering that all of the community's activities directed at society were in public view. I attributed this introversion, this lack of transparency, essentially to the pressures that the Kemalist state imposed on religious movements making it necessary. In 2004, in the second year of my writing for *Zaman*, I would explain my views about the Community as follows:

"About ten years ago, I wrote in an article titled 'Respect for Hocaefendi' published in *Milliyet* newspaper: 'As far as I can see, Hocaefendi opposes the use of Islam as a political ideology, as a party philosophy; the division of society into two poles as believers and non-believers. He advocates that those who believe differently and think differently should be respectful and tolerant of each other; peace and reconciliation in society… I perceive Hocaefendi as a religious figure who separates religion and politics, opposes the culture of enmity that could divide people into camps, and contributes to the development of a tolerant understanding of Islam. Hocaefendi's work should be respected.' (*Milliyet*, July 29, 1995) In the ten years that have passed, my conviction about Gulen's contribution has not changed, it has grown stronger.

"Today too, I think Gulen represents an interpretation of Islam suited to the requirements of our age, of a world that is increasingly modernizing, individualizing, democratizing, and globalizing. I believe that Gulen's contribution has value and meaning on a global scale: If the many and very different interpretations of Islam existing in the world today can be compared, it can be said that Wahhabism is at one end and Gulen's interpretation is at the other.

"If, since the 1980s, the idea has taken root to some extent in Turkish society that problems can be solved not through fighting and violence, but only by respecting different beliefs, views, and understandings; through dialogue, talking, and reconciliation, I have no doubt that Gulen's advice has made an important contribution to this. I also think that Gulen's advice has had an indirect but important share in the fact that the political cadre that emerged from the Milli Gorus (National Vision) Movement, Turkey's own unique Islamist movement, founded the Justice and Development Party in

2001, came to power in 2002, and over time reached a consensus on European-standard democracy and secularism for Turkey. The fact that a significant portion of society is still unaware of this is an important deficiency of ours." (Sahin Alpay, Gulen's Contribution, Journalists and Writers Foundation, Istanbul, June 2004.)

Except for the last 4-5 months of the approximately 14 years I was a columnist at *Zaman*, the newspaper's constant editor-in-chief was Ekrem Dumanli. Dumanli graduated from Istanbul University's Faculty of Literature in 1987, started working as a reporter at *Zaman* in 1993, went to the US in 1997 to pursue a master's degree at Emerson College in Boston, and upon his return to the country in 2001, took over as *Zaman*'s editor-in-chief. Reportedly, he was one of a group of young people sent to the US for education at Gulen's instruction.

I first met him briefly in 1998 on the occasion of a speech I gave at Harvard University at the invitation of Cemal Kafadar. Our first proper meeting, as I described above, was during a visit when I went to meet him with the expectation of writing for *Zaman*, but received a negative response. After I started writing for *Zaman*, our relationship always continued within a framework of mutual respect. I think our good relationship peaked in July 2006. During a visit to the newspaper, he said that they greatly appreciated me, that they would do everything they could to make me happy, that if I had to leave the university I could do additional work for the newspaper, and thus compensate for my income loss.

Censorship at *Zaman*

My articles at *Zaman* were very rarely interfered with. In this respect, I was perhaps the writer who was "given the most latitude" at the newspaper. As a general form of censorship, at the beginning of my time writing for the newspaper, I was asked not to write critical articles about Central Asian dictators. Concerns were expressed that the Hizmet schools in these countries could face the risk of being closed. I received this with understanding, decided not to touch on those subjects, and did not. At a time when the intensity of my criticism of the AKP government was increasing, I had to change the last paragraph of an article titled "The Prime Minister Must Change."

The original version of the paragraph was: "If the Prime Minister cannot be persuaded to change, then it can be concluded that he has become extremely tired as a result of the intense work he has carried out for approximately eleven years, or that his health condition does not allow him to continue at this pace, and the mechanism of the parliamentary system that enables the renewal of the executive when necessary can come into play. The AKP group, if necessary alone, can vote no confidence in the current government and ensure continuation with a new prime minister. This is in the interest of Turkey, the AKP, and its members of parliament."

Dumanli called me on the phone and said, "I agree with you, but they will assume that we made you write these lines and will create an incident…" and asked me to soften the paragraph. I did my best and revised the paragraph as follows: "If the Prime Minister cannot be persuaded to change, then I personally will conclude that he has become extremely tired after the intense work he has carried out for approximately eleven years,

or that his health condition does not allow him to continue in office. Then the responsibility to find a solution will fall to the people." (*Zaman*, June 6, 2013)

Dumanli was not satisfied with this version of the article either, but he did not push further. Some time later, he told another *Zaman* writer what had happened: Prime Minister Erdogan, having read the softened version of the article, had called him furiously, saying "Throw this man out of the newspaper…"; Dumanli's response had been "We don't have a practice of removing writers." When I learned this, I was truly startled. Even though I had always given due credit for his services, the Prime Minister's intolerance toward me had surprised me.

My article titled "Why Hagia Sophia Should Remain a Museum," which was supposed to be published on December 7, 2013, was censored and completely eliminated. The page editor called me on the phone to say that the newspaper management agreed with the content of my article, but that, due to the increasing tension between the community and the government, there was concern it could cause conflict among Muslims and demonstrations in front of the newspaper. Sometime later, another *Zaman* writer would explain to me exactly where the concern originated: Said Nursi had sent a letter to Prime Minister Adnan Menderes requesting "the opening of Hagia Sophia for worship." In other words, the Community could have no objection to opening Hagia Sophia for worship (!)

The Huseyin Gulerce Case

One of the first people I met at *Zaman* was Huseyin Gulerce, the institutional director who had served as the newspaper's editor-in-chief until Dumanli was appointed. Gulerce, who also served as president of the Journalists and Writers Foundation established by the Community for a time, showed me great warmth. I was a guest on his weekly program on the Samanyolu television channel several times. I had formed a very positive impression of him. I can say that he was one of the people under the *Zaman* umbrella with whom my views most aligned.

Gulerce ended his columns at *Zaman* and his program on Samanyolu channel some time after the judicial investigations launched against some ministers on December 17/25, 2013. I would hear that when leaving Samanyolu, he had warned employees there, "they will lock all of you up." Gulerce, who was said to be one of Gulen's closest associates, and was even known for a time as "the spokesperson of the Community," would surprise everyone by making statements against the "Fethullahist Terror Organization, FETO" after cutting ties with the Community.

(In its decision overturning the 8-year 9-month prison sentence given by Istanbul 13th Heavy Penal Court in July 2018 on the grounds that "I was a member of the Fethullahist Terror Organization," the Court of Cassation requested that Huseyin Gulerce be heard as a witness about me. At the hearing held on January 11, 2022, Gulerce said the following: "I know Sahin Alpay closely. I don't think he has any connection with FETO at all. He was writing for the newspaper. He wasn't even someone who came to the newspaper often. I think Mr. Sahin made a choice between the government and the community through his articles, but I don't think he was affiliated with FETO or that he received instructions. What I said about Mr. Sahin also applies to the other four friends

(tried in this case). I knew these friends as people who did not abandon the honor of the pen. I don't think they wrote articles on instructions. Because they are people who are closed to suggestion. I haven't even heard rumors of such a thing.")

Bilici: The AKP Government Proved the Kemalists Right

Abdulhamit Bilici, a graduate of Bogazici University's Political Science and International Relations Department who took over this position following Dumanli's resignation as editor-in-chief in October 2015, was also one of the people with whom I had the closest dialogue at the newspaper. What Bilici, who continued as editor-in-chief until March 4, 2016, when the newspaper's management was transferred to a trustee by court order, said in our last meeting was very striking: The AKP government's practices had proven the Kemalists right. The practices of Islamists in Muslim-majority countries had caused great disappointment in him. He no longer found my objections convincing that authoritarian secularism policies had made Islamists a problem everywhere, including Turkey. As far as I know, Bilici settled in the US some time after the newspaper was transferred to a trustee.

I also had good relations with Bulent Kenes, the editor-in-chief of the English-language *Today's Zaman* newspaper, published between 2007 and 2015, to which I contributed by writing a weekly column. Kenes, who like Bilici was a graduate of Bogazici University's Political Science and International Relations Department, and who had previously served as editorial coordinator of *Turkish Daily News* and bureau chief of Anadolu Agency in New York, also left the country after the newspaper was transferred to a trustee; he sought asylum in Sweden. As far as I know, in 2019 he made an announcement that he had left the "Hizmet Movement."

The *Zaman* employees with whom I had the closest contact were, of course, the page editors responsible for the columns I sent three times a week. (In order: Ahmet Turan Ayhan, who left the newspaper in 2007 to become an advisor to a ministry and then a program maker at TRT; Levent Kenez, Yavuz Altun, and Buket Davulcu, all of whom emigrated abroad after July 15.) The writers with whom I became friendly during my time writing for *Zaman*, and with whom I grew closer as pressures on the newspaper increased, were Ali Bulac, Ahmet Turan Alkan, Mumtaz'er Turkone, Nuriye Akman, and Lale Kemal. After July 15, we would meet with them in detention, in prison, and in courtrooms.

My view of the AKP government in my columns at *Zaman* can be roughly divided into three periods. The first period covers the time from their coming to power in 2002 until 2011, during which I generally viewed them positively. The second is the period extending from 2011 to the end of 2013, when I called on the AKP government to return to its early days. The third period is from early 2014 to March 2016, when my articles ended with the appointment of a trustee to the newspaper, during which I harshly criticized the AKP government. My harsh criticisms would continue in the daily newspaper called *Yarina Bakis* (Looking to Tomorrow), which *Zaman* employees began publishing on March 6, 2016, and which was shut down by the government after the July 15 coup attempt.

Nowadays, it is not possible to access my articles published in both *Zaman* and *Yarina Bakis* between 2002 and 2016. This is because, similar to how the communist regime that was in power in Russia between 1917 and 1992 erased facts it wanted forgotten from historical records, the AKP government has also completely erased from the internet the archives of *Zaman*, *Yarina Bakis*, and all publications belonging to the Gulen community. For this reason, I will include some short and some long excerpts from articles I consider important below.

"Victory of Democracy"

In 2001-2002, three events that would deeply affect my intellectual world came roughly one after another: I had started teaching political science full-time at BAU. This was followed by my starting to write a column three days a week for *Zaman* newspaper, published by a religious community. And in the days when I started writing for *Zaman*, the Justice and Development Party, which had its roots in Turkey's own unique Islamist movement and now declared itself "Conservative Democrat," came to power. My first article in *Zaman* was published two days after the election with the title "Victory of Democracy." I wrote:

"The election resulted in a victory for democracy. In several respects. First of all, the election was held in great calm, with fairly high participation and with almost no incidents. (…) Second, despite perhaps the world's worst electoral system (neither providing stable government nor ensuring fair representation), democracy worked. The coalition parties that had dragged the country into crisis were removed from power, suffering a heavy defeat at the ballot box. (…) Third, partly perhaps thanks to the world's worst electoral system, Turkey purged a political cadre whose failures had been proven time and again, who were deeply involved in corruption, and whose time had long passed. (…)

"Unfortunately, this victory for democracy is overshadowed by perhaps the world's worst electoral system. A very large portion of voters, approximately 45 percent, will not be represented in parliament. Despite all the warnings made over the years, the election law was not changed; even the 10 percent threshold was not reduced to a normal level. In the end, those who did not do this fell into the pit they dug for others. So much so that no one may have the nerve to argue about legitimacy.

"The great winners of the elections are undoubtedly Recep Tayyip Erdogan and the AKP. There are many factors that explain this success. First, the AKP is undoubtedly not a 'fifteen-month-old party.' It is the heir to a great political movement that has been organized step by step since the early 1990s, the movement that makes the AKP Turkey's own unique and only mass party. Second, AKP leaders carried out a great ideological transformation from Islamist discourse toward a discourse of human rights, freedom, European-standard democracy and economy. Seeing that the overwhelming majority of the Turkish people are as committed to secularism and democracy as they are to religious values, they pulled the party to the center. On this path, they did not miss the opportunity to shake off the burden of Erbakan and the cadre around him whose time had long passed. With its current discourse, the AKP can only be characterized as

a Muslim democratic or conservative party. Now it has the opportunity to show those who have doubts about this whether its essence matches its words.

“Actually, the AKP is also a victory for Turkish democracy. A young cadre that entered the political scene with a radical Islamist stance, under the conditions forced by democratic competition and gradually understanding that freedom is necessary for everyone, adopted a moderate and reasonable center-right line. The greatest virtue of democracy is that it gives political movements, as well as societies and individuals, the opportunity to correct their mistakes. Democracy educates; it makes radicals moderate. We can be proud of our democracy, even as it is.

“There is also a message to the world from these elections: Islam absolutely does not mean terrorism, fundamentalism, bigotry, or backwardness. Islam, like all religions, is open to all kinds of interpretation. In a Muslim country, both secularism and democracy can function perfectly. Turkey has shown this once again with its recent election. The AKP is undertaking a very difficult task. To succeed, it must gain everyone’s support. And everyone should help. Because success is in all our interest.” (*Zaman*, November 5, 2002)

(This article was an expression of how much goodwill I viewed the AKP and its government with in 2002, and how much credit I extended to them. Unfortunately, the hopes that the AKP raised in me and many others for Turkey and the world would not be realized; before ten years had passed, it would be seen that AKP leader Erdogan’s “essence and words” were gradually moving apart from each other; the attributed title of “Muslim Democrat” would gradually give way to “Islamist populist.”)

Just as I characterized the AKP coming to power on its own as a victory for democracy, I also advocated that its leader Erdogan, who could not run for parliament because his political ban was still in effect, should assume the prime ministership. I wrote: “The President has tasked AKP deputy chairman Abdullah Gul with forming the 58th government. We wish Mr. Gul success. Gul is the AKP’s second man, Tayyip Erdogan’s closest associate; with his always reasonable and moderate line, he is also an acceptable figure among those who did not vote for the AKP. But he is not the AKP’s chairman. For this reason, Gul’s prime ministership can only be for a temporary period. It would be beneficial for this period to be as short as possible.” Indeed, with the support of the CHP under Deniz Baykal’s leadership, the TBMM lifted Erdogan’s political ban. Erdogan entered parliament as a deputy for Siirt following the by-election held on March 9, 2003, and with Gul submitting his resignation, he assumed the prime ministership on March 14, 2003.

“We Have No Business in Iraq?”

In early 2003, Turkey witnessed one of the most important foreign policy crises of its recent history. US President George W. Bush decided to intervene militarily in Iraq on the grounds that Saddam Hussein’s regime had developed nuclear and biological weapons and had ties to Al Qaeda, thus becoming a major threat to the US and the world. He asked Ankara for permission to station 62,000 troops in Turkey for 6 months in preparation for an invasion from the north. The prime ministry motion submitted to the

TBMM on February 25 by the AKP government to be authorized on this matter caused controversy. When the AKP group split, the motion was rejected in the vote held in the general assembly on March 1, 2003, with the votes of the CHP and AKP dissidents. The rejection of the motion caused great disappointment in the US administration.

The invasion, which all NATO allies except Britain opposed, resulted in the overthrow of Saddam Hussein's regime. The intervention, which resulted in the deaths of nearly three hundred thousand people, both civilian and military, caused great destruction in the country. Perhaps the most important consequence for Turkey was that the Kurdistan region in northern Iraq, neighboring Turkey, gained an autonomy close to independence. After the war, it would emerge that both of the justifications used by the Bush administration for the invasion were inconsistent with reality.

Perhaps for the first time in my writing career, I hesitated on whether to say "yes" or "no" to the motion. This hesitation was expressed in my article titled "Between 'Yes' and 'No'": "Washington is expecting the 59th government, to be formed under the leadership of AKP General Chairman Recep T. Erdogan, who was elected deputy from Siirt, to resubmit the motion rejected on March 1 to the TBMM. During this waiting period, Turkey continues to debate whether to say 'yes' or 'no' to the motion. (…) The scenario that the 'yes' camp hopes for is that the Bush administration will be proven right, that is, that the intervention will be successful in a very short time and without much harm to the people. That the Americans will immediately establish order and bring democracy to Iraq whose integrity is preserved, then turn to resolving the Palestinian issue, opening an era of peace and democracy in the region.

"The scenario that the 'no' camp fears is exactly the opposite: The US wins the war but cannot win the peace; the state collapses in Iraq, civil war breaks out between ethnic groups, Turkey, along with other neighboring countries, is drawn into this war, the region begins to burn. It is because they are caught between the logic of 'yes' and 'no' that the calendar of those governing Turkey does not match Bush's calendar. (…) If Ankara finally says 'yes,' it should still act according to the logic of 'no': Above all, it should definitely avoid standing in the way of the democratic aspirations of the people of Northern Iraq, the ethnic kin of our brothers…" (March 11, 2003)

Shortly after, I changed my view and took a determined stance against getting involved in Iraq in my subsequent articles. In the article titled "Address to the TBMM," I called on the parliament to stand by the March 1 decision and wrote: "Distinguished deputies seated in the TBMM… Regardless of which party you belong to, stand up for the authority and dignity of the TBMM, which achieved Turkey's independence, founded the Republic of Turkey, and is the main pillar of our democracy. No other authority besides the TBMM can decide on the stationing of foreign soldiers in Turkey or the sending of Turkish soldiers to foreign countries…" (March 15, 2003)

I explained why I was against intervention in Iraq in an article titled "We Have No Business in Iraq": "… If we think long-term rather than short-term, we did the right thing by staying as far away and outside as possible from the war that the US started in accordance with the Bush-Sharon doctrine. Maintaining this position is a requirement of our national interests. This is so in several respects. Let's start with the Kurdish

separatism issue: There can be no doubt that the division of Turkey would be a disaster. But how will we preserve national unity?

“If we think long-term, this cannot be achieved through pressure, bans, or force of ‘arms.’ We can only preserve national unity by ensuring and reinforcing the voluntary loyalty of our Kurdish-origin citizens to Turkey. For this, we must remove without further delay the obstacles to their freely expressing their culture and identity, and seeking solutions to their troubles and problems within the democratic system. As long as Turkey’s Kurds can benefit from the blessings of Turkish democracy, as long as Turkey is a strong democracy and economy advancing on the path to EU membership, our unity will not be harmed.

“Preserving Iraq’s integrity is certainly our fundamental preference in terms of preventing the region from being dragged into great instability. But preserving Iraq’s integrity is not the task of the TSK (Turkish Armed Forces). If we had passed the motion and sent 40,000 of our soldiers to Iraq along with the Americans, even the smallest provocation could have put the TSK in the position of Israel in Palestinian territories, of the US in Iraqi territories, that is, in the position of occupier. We must be extremely vigilant because this danger is still at our doorstep. (…)

“The Republic of Turkey is not a racial state. All of our people from different origins are first-class citizens. We are related to all neighboring peoples. We must certainly use all our means to defend the rights of Arabs, Kurds, and Turkmens in Iraq, and support them in healing the wounds caused by Saddam’s dictatorship and the war. But the Turkish army should not become a force that occupies its neighbor. We must preserve our reputation in the eyes of all the people of Iraq. In the long run, this is our greatest capital.

“Let us also know this: In the end, the people of Iraq will decide Iraq’s future. If Iraqi Kurds want to be autonomous within Iraq or to be independent, Turkey should not be the one standing in their way. Iraqi Kurds are the ethnic kin of our brothers. We have all kinds of means and reasons to win their friendship and trust. We can continue the policy of friendship we have pursued since 1991, and we can act together against the PKK and the like. The closest friend of Iraqi Kurds should not be the US, but Turkey.” (*Zaman*, April 15, 2003)

This article also reflected the essence of my views on what Turkey’s Kurdish policy should be; how we should view our own Kurds and Kurds in neighboring countries.

“Gulen and Secularization”

One of the fundamental views I advocated with my new “social liberal or social democratic” identity after returning to the country from Sweden in the early 1980s was this: Turkey’s problems can only be solved through liberal, that is, libertarian and pluralist democracy. The establishment of liberal democracy can only be possible through this regime’s reconciliation with Islam, the belief of the majority, through secularism gaining a democratic interpretation, that is, through the separation of religion and state. The Justice and Development Party government with its “Muslim Democrat”

identity could provide this interpretation, and thus reconciliation. The Gulen community, or as they called themselves, the “Hizmet movement,” could also contribute to this.

This was also one of the reasons I agreed to write for *Zaman* newspaper. The first of my articles about the community in *Zaman* was published with the title “Gulen and Secularization.” In this article, I was referring to the articles of a sociologist, METU faculty member Elisabeth Ozdalga, who supported my expectation that the community would contribute to secularization.

” ‘One of the most powerful–and controversial–Islamic movements in Turkey is the Gulen community, gathered around the charismatic leader Fethullah Gulen. There is no other religious figure against whom circles strictly committed to secularism have shown such a reaction. Considering that Gulen’s supporters are modest people who avoid coming to the fore, this becomes even more difficult to understand. Gulen’s opponents attribute to him great, secret powers that could even challenge political authority. This fantasy is fed by a fear of ’reaction’ reaching panic proportions and ignorance about the Gulen community. This ignorance stems partly from the community’s attitude and partly from indifference to reaching a healthy understanding about this movement. The result is the development of the darkest kind of prejudices about the community.’

“Elisabeth Ozdalga’s article titled ‘Secularizing Trends in Fethullah Gulen’s Movement’ published in the Spring 2003 issue of the academic journal *Critique: Critical Middle Eastern Studies* begins with the observation I quoted above. In her first article on the Gulen community, titled ‘Worldly Asceticism in Islamic Casting’ published in the Autumn 2000 issue of the same journal, Ozdalga had analyzed Fethullah Gulen’s worldview. In that article, she concluded that rather than pursuing political ambitions, Gulen was trying to develop an ethical understanding directed toward the rationalization of social relations (very close to Max Weber’s concept of ‘worldly asceticism’ that he developed while studying Protestant ethics), that is, basing them on reason.

“In her newly published article, Ozdalga goes a step further, arguing that despite its strong religious appeal, the Gulen movement is actually leading the community toward secularization. According to Ozdalga, there are striking similarities between the activities of the Gulen community and Christian missionaries, especially 19th-century Protestant missionaries. The Gulen community carries an educational mission just like the 19th-century Protestant missionaries. Robert College, which is today a national, secular, expensive, and prestigious high school in Istanbul, was founded in the 19th century by Protestant missionaries who came from the US and dedicated their lives to this work. All schools established by Protestant organizations in the US and abroad in the 19th century, while initially strongly committed to Christian values, gradually transformed into truly secular institutions over time. Schools opened by Protestant missionaries initially devoted great space to religious subjects and practices. This was not the case in Gulen schools. Although teachers embraced their work with religious faith, the curricula under the supervision of the Ministry of National Education never focused on religious education.

“According to Ozdalga, there are the following similarities between the behaviors of the Gulen community and Protestant missionaries: Although the driving force in the work of

both movements is religious faith, their mission or cause is not to spread religion. They are guided by more general or universal values than those belonging to a particular faith. Members of both movements share these characteristics: Leading a pious and self-sacrificing life; a deep interest in acquiring knowledge, especially in natural sciences; the desire to convey acquired knowledge to others through various educational institutions; an entrepreneurial spirit; providing useful services to society and the desire to transcend national boundaries and reach other countries of the world.

“Ozdalga’s conclusion is this: Community members may be highly devout people, but their formulating their mission as a humanitarian project weakens their religious foundations. The sociological paradox here is that even the most vibrant Islamic renewal movements can be carriers of modernization… What if the MGK (National Security Council) also read and examined Elisabeth Ozdalga’s (and of course other academics’) ‘reports’ about the Gulen community?” (*Zaman*, April 29, 2003)

“Where Are We in ‘Taqiyya’?”

The first of the commentaries I would write in *Zaman* about the nature of the AKP was titled “Where Are We in ‘Taqiyya’?” I wrote: “How the AKP, which has its roots in Turkey’s own unique Islamist movement, and the political cadre at its head, which was not distinguished by liberal qualities, has come to bear the standard for the country becoming a democracy at EU standards today, may not be easy to understand for many inside and outside the country. (…) Two main (non-mutually exclusive) ‘theories’ are being put forward to explain the change in the AKP. According to the ‘stick’ theory, we owe this change to the ‘state’s,’ that is, the military-civilian bureaucracy embodied as the MGK and the Constitutional Court’s, non-liberal interventions in the democratic process.

“According to the other, ‘carrot’ theory, we owe this change to Turkey having adopted the process of democratic political competition since the 1950s. That a political movement that does not respect the people’s fundamental preferences (democratic and secular order as well as Islamic values) can neither come to power nor maintain power was gradually understood, step by step, from the MNP to the AKP. According to this second theory, which I most fervently advocate, what happened in Turkey’s own unique Islamist movement is meaningful evidence on a global scale of democracy’s educating, democratizing quality.

“There are also those who take the change in the AKP too far. According to them, the AKP is on the way to rapidly ‘assimilating’ into the system, that is, fully conforming to the status quo, becoming indistinguishable from other parties; its only concern is actually ‘rent-seeking.’ My theory is that the AKP is in ‘cohabitation,’ living together with the system, and that its ammunition to reform the system in the direction supported by the majority has not yet run out.” (*Zaman*, May 24, 2003)

AKP or “Ak Party”

In all my articles, I referred to the Justice and Development Party by the abbreviation AKP; I refused to use the “Ak Party” abbreviation that the party itself preferred. I

explained my reasoning as follows, when the AKP government was still in its tenth month:

“The other day I watched almost from start to finish the speech Prime Minister Recep T. Erdogan gave at an AKP provincial congress. The Prime Minister again devoted a large portion of his speech to the subject that the abbreviated name of the Justice and Development Party is not AKP but ‘Ak Parti.’ He also explained his reasoning as follows: 1) The party’s abbreviated name is registered that way. Just as the Motherland Party is called ANAP by its registered short name rather than AP, the Justice and Development Party should also be called ‘Ak Parti.’ 2) Just as the concept of ‘Justice’ in the party’s name represents the party’s ideal of ensuring justice in the country, and the concept of ‘Development’ represents achieving development, its abbreviated name also symbolizes this party’s goal of ending corruption in the country.

“I find both the Prime Minister and other Justice and Development Party officials who devote their valuable time to this claim rather strange. For the following reasons: 1) The reason the Motherland Party is commonly referred to as ANAP in the media and public opinion is presumably not because the party’s registered short name is so, but to avoid confusion with AP, the abbreviated name of the Justice Party. Moreover, the ANAP abbreviation is not loaded with meaning like the ‘Ak Parti’ (meaning ‘White/Clean Party’) abbreviation. 2) Everyone can see that there is a somewhat crude ‘image game’ behind the ‘Ak Parti’ abbreviation. This is why very few people outside party members have adopted this abbreviation. 3) Although the Justice and Development Party’s claims that it will end corruption and that it itself will first be a ‘clean party’ are as noble and commendable as its promise to achieve justice and development, they are doomed to remain mere words unless proven over time. For this reason, instead of preemptively declaring itself ‘Ak’ (‘Clean’), it would be much more convincing if the AKP waited for the people to give it this title.” (*Zaman*, July 17, 2003)

Let me confess that when I was writing the lines I quoted above, it did not occur to me how much my arguments in the article would be vindicated over time. But now, the reality that is clearly evident in 2021, when these lines are being written, is that the AKP represents not only the most unjust, most oppressive, but also the most degenerate, most corruption-tainted government in Turkey’s multi-party history; the gains it has made in the area of development are also rapidly declining; as the regime becomes increasingly authoritarian, the country is becoming increasingly impoverished.

“The Future of Political Islam”

My beginning to think that political Islam could become increasingly liberal was largely based on the impressions and hopes raised by the Gulen movement and the AKP government in Turkey. What made me think that similar developments could occur in the rest of the Islamic world were the analyses put forward in books and articles by Graham E Fuller, an American political scientist who had held important positions in the US intelligence agency CIA for a time. I wrote the following about Fuller’s book *The Future of Political Islam* (Palgrave, 2003):

“Let me say at the beginning what should perhaps be said at the end: I cannot claim to be familiar with the entire literature on political Islam, but as far as I know, Fuller’s latest work is perhaps the book most worth reading on this subject. What is political Islam or Islamism? What is its relationship to the religion of Islam? What kind of ideology is it? What forms does it take? What kind of evolution is it going through? What should the West’s attitude toward Islamism be? I hope that this newest book in this field, which in my opinion gives the most satisfying answers to these and similar questions, will be translated into Turkish without delay… Fuller’s advantage is combining his academic personality with the knowledge and experiences he gained during his tenure as deputy chairman of the CIA’s National Intelligence Council in the 1980s and during the fourteen years he spent in Islamic countries (including Turkey).

“Fuller’s most important theses are these: The religion of Islam, like all other religions, is concerned with spiritual and moral issues. Islamism is the result of efforts to produce a political ideology from the religion of Islam; it is a product not of the religion of Islam, but of the troubles experienced by Muslim societies. Islam will live on as a spiritual and moral force, but the fate of Islamism is uncertain. To understand Islamism, one must examine not the religion of Islam but the problems of Muslim societies, the demands and needs of Muslims. (Isn’t this the fundamental truth that some in Turkey cannot or do not want to understand?) Islamism should be understood not as a rigid ideology, but as a political program for expressing the social and political needs of Muslims. Islamism, which is rapidly growing, evolving, and diversifying, is today the most

powerful movement aimed at political change in the Islamic world.

“Muslim societies had previously tried secular nationalism and socialism to find a cure for their troubles, and Islamism rose as a result of the disappointments caused by these experiments. Islamism takes on many different forms ranging from Radical Islamism at one end, which wants to establish a totalitarian regime based on so-called religious principles using violence, to Liberal Islamism at the other end, which makes a synthesis of Islamic values with libertarian principles and institutions. Radical Islamism has been tried so far in three countries (Iran, Sudan, and Afghanistan) with very different practices, and has failed in each. Liberal Islamism is not the dominant trend today, but it is a rising trend, also thanks to the failures of radical Islamism and the reactions it has aroused. Radical forms of Islamism should be fought, but the way should be opened for the diversification of other interpretations; the development of liberal and pluralist Islamism should be encouraged.

“According to Fuller, the country where Liberal Islamism has gone furthest is Turkey… ‘A candidate to be the first country to succeed in making a true synthesis of Islamist and Western liberal democratic traditions.’ One disagreement I have with Fuller is whether the AKP can be characterized as liberal Islamist. I am of the opinion that because it has broken from its Islamist roots and characterizes itself as ‘Conservative Democrat,’ the AKP cannot be called Islamist. Fuller, on the other hand, finds it correct to characterize the AKP as Islamist, as a successful example of the liberal interpretation.

“Fuller also writes this about himself:”The years I spent as a CIA member, especially in the developing world, lead many people to think about me, even though I left official duty fifteen years ago, that once an intelligence officer, always

an intelligence officer.” Moreover, many foreigners believe that my views represent the *CIA* or the US government. I wish they did.” (*Zaman*, August 12, 2003)

“In Memory of Anna Lindh”

I certainly have a special affinity for Sweden, which opened its arms to me during the most difficult period of my life; which I see as the world’s relatively most civilized, most just, and freest society; whose state and society stood by me when I was accused of terrorism and would be imprisoned in Silivri. Throughout my life, I have known many Swedes from all professions. Among them, one of those who impressed me most was Foreign Minister Anna Lindh, who fell victim to murder. Lindh appeared to me as a summary of Sweden’s virtues. In the article I wrote upon her death, which I quote in full below, I tried to explain this.

“I was acquainted with Swedish Foreign Minister Anna Lindh, who died as a result of a stabbing attack. I first met her in Istanbul in January 1990, when she came to participate in a conference on social democracy. At that time, she was still the president of the Swedish Social Democratic Workers’ Party’s youth organization, SSU. On this occasion, I had a long interview with her about the ‘Swedish Model’ and social democratic youth

organizations (*Cumhuriyet*,

January 7, 1990).

“After she became Foreign Minister in 1998, I had the opportunity to meet with her every time she came to Turkey as well

. As a knowledgeable, intelligent, skilled, and moreover charming and humble politician, she always impressed me. The last time we had a chance to chat, although briefly, was at the beginning of February this year during the conference on ‘Women in Turkey and Sweden’ organized by the Swedish consulate general. When she was leaving the consulate building in her official car, with Turkish police guards in front and behind, she saw me and waved warmly. That scene will probably never

leave my memory.

“Unfortunately, because Anna Lindh could not be protected in her own country, she was stabbed to death one September day, in broad daylight, in the center of Stockholm, in the middle of Sweden’s most prestigious store. Very similar to the way Prime Minister Olof Palme was killed seventeen years ago… I will not remember Anna Lindh only as one of the most brilliant politicians Sweden has produced. Lindh had a special interest in and sympathy for Turkey. If she had not died, she had been due to come to our country next month for a holiday with her family. She had also emphasized in our last meeting that a Turkey that meets the Copenhagen Political Criteria cannot be excluded from the

EU, and that there can be no turning back from the process that began with Helsinki. (*Zaman*, February 11, 2003).

“There is nothing to take seriously in the claims of some of Turkey’s filthy newspapers and filthy writers: Anna Lindh was a person who sympathized with neither separatism nor

terrorism in Turkey. During an interview, she had answered my question on this subject as follows: ’We believe it is very important to grant everyone the right to speak their mother

tongues and develop their own cultures as individual rights or minority rights. However, we also very clearly state that the Kurdish problem must be solved within Turkey’s existing borders. We have never been on the side of separatism anywhere in Europe up to now. We have always explicitly condemned terrorism, including the PKK.’ (*Milliyet*, February 22, 2000)

“Anna Lindh was of the opinion that whatever rights those of Kurdish origin in Sweden have,

those of Kurdish origin in Turkey should also have the same rights. Just like democrats who believe in freedom everywhere in the world… Prime Minister Goran Persson said the following after Anna Lindh’s death: ‘Social democracy has lost one of its most masterful politicians. The Swedish government has lost one of its most talented ministers and colleagues; Sweden has lost its face to the world…’ Turkey too has lost a friend.” (*Zaman*, September 13, 2003)

“The Impasse of Turkish-Style Secularism”

One of the topics I frequently addressed in my columns at *Zaman* was the critique of Turkey’s own unique, authoritarian secularism practices. In these articles, I advocated the need for ‘secularization of secularism’ in Turkey; that is, for state control over religion to give way to separation of religion and state, for restrictions on religious beliefs that are incompatible with the democratic order to be lifted. The lines I quote below reflected the essence of this view of mine:

“…It is certain that Turkish-style (alaturka) secularism is in crisis. This crisis stems, at its most fundamental level, from the conflicting aims of official identity and secularism policies. While undergoing changes over time, the identity policies of the Republic of Turkey essentially aimed to create from the Muslim population of the Ottoman Empire, which spoke many different languages and was attached to very different interpretations of Islam, a homogeneous Turkish nation that spoke Turkish, shared Turkish culture, and was attached to the state-approved (Sunni-Hanafi) interpretation of Islam. The religion of Islam was accepted as an inseparable part of Turkish identity. This is why non-Muslim citizens were never seen as part of the national community; most state positions, especially military officership, were kept closed to them.

“The secularism policy pursued by the Republic of Turkey charged the state with secularizing society, that is, with religious institutions and ideas losing their influence,

with religion being removed from social life and limited to people's inner worlds and mosques, to belief and worship. This policy was the product of the positivist philosophy that deeply influenced Ottoman-Turkish reformers: For social progress and development to be achieved, religious thought had to give way to scientific-rational thought. For this reason, Turkish-style secularism (which we can characterize as positive, militant, radical secularism or laicism) was based not on the separation of religion and state but on the state keeping religion under control. While the state supported the official interpretation of Islam with all its means through the Directorate of Religious Affairs established based on the Byzantine-Ottoman tradition, it imposed various bans and restrictions on other beliefs, on Alevism, on the Islamic interpretations of religious orders and communities, and on non-Muslim religious groups. Secularism remained limited to secular laws.

"It can be said that the Turkish-style secularism regime is caught between promoting a certain interpretation of Islamic faith on the one hand as a requirement of identity policies, and practices aimed at excluding religion from social life on the other. No one is satisfied with this type of secularism: Right-wingers and left-wingers, conservatives and liberals,

Islamists and Kemalists, Alevis and Sunnis, Muslims and Christians,

everyone is complaining. Neither policies that define national identity with Islamic faith nor policies based on the state controlling religion and restricting religious freedoms are compatible with the requirements of liberal and pluralist democracy. As long as identity policies that define Turkishness not by language, culture, or belief but by citizenship are not adopted; as long as a genuinely secular order is not established in which religion is left to society, the state stands at equal distance from all beliefs, and all restrictions on freedom of belief are lifted, complaints will not end. It is certain that we need reform not in religion but in secularism.

"However, we are still very far from this point, because clearly Turkish-style secularism serves the interests of both parties to today's conflicts to some extent: One side believes that with this method the state somehow controls religion, and the other side believes that with this method their religion somehow uses the state. That is why the headscarf ban,

the admission of imam-hatip high school graduates to university is being discussed, but why non-Muslim communities cannot open seminaries, why they cannot build places of worship, why changing religion is seen as a threat, etc. is not being discussed. And of course the fundamental question is not being asked: In a regime that separates religion and state, can there be

a Directorate of Religious Affairs, mosques, religious officials, imam-hatip high schools, and mandatory religion classes financed by all citizens' taxes?" (*Zaman*, October 28, 2003)

I don't think I need to explain how much further we have moved away from genuine secularism as I advocated by 2022. Under AKP rule, we have witnessed the state

gradually moving away from controlling religion, and religion increasingly deeply penetrating the state.

“Goodbye Ecevit”

Prime Minister Bulent Ecevit had been one of the leaders at the focal point of my interest in politics. From the 1960s onwards, I had closely followed his discourse and behavior; for a brief period I had hoped (or deluded myself) that the DSP he founded in the 1980s would contribute to the liberalization and democratization of the country. The vote share of his party, which had carried Ecevit to the prime ministership by collecting 22.19% of the vote in the 1999 general elections, dropped to 1.22% in the general elections held three years later in 2002. Thereupon, at the DSP’s 6th Ordinary Congress held on July 25, 2004, Ecevit bid farewell to the party he founded and to politics. In the article commenting on his farewell to politics, I wrote:

“At the DSP’s 6th Ordinary Congress, Bulent Ecevit implemented a rather delayed decision: He bid farewell to the party chairmanship and to a fifty-year political life, together with his closest colleague and wife, Mrs. Rahsan. I wish Mr. Ecevit health and wellness in his years outside politics. Ecevit has a special place in the lives of my generation, to which I also belong, who attended university in the mid-1960s. The main reason for this is that no other leader has been

on the stage, part of our lives, for this long. Those of my generation who share similar

perspectives with me see three separate periods of Ecevit.

“In the first period extending to the March 12, 1971 military intervention, Turkey

‘s Workers’ Party sympathizers like me, who adopted increasingly radical forms of socialism, saw Ecevit as a bourgeois politician trying to keep

a dying collaborationist capitalism alive by making some improvements in favor of the working masses. Still, on the grounds that he represented a more democratic

form of capitalism and that it would be easier to spread socialism in a more democratic capitalism, we preferred him to other “bourgeois politicians” and trusted that he would end military rule. And so it happened.

“The period extending from the 1973 elections when the CHP became the first party to 1979 when Ecevit resigned from the prime ministership is the 2nd Ecevit period. In this period, for those who had gradually moved away from radical interpretations of socialism and reached a consensus that the issue was not overthrowing democracy and capitalism but establishing a more democratic and just society, now ‘Ecevit is our hope.’ He promised a Turkey as prosperous, just, and independent as the Scandinavian countries

. He would end the war between the extreme right and

extreme left armed gangs that caused the country to bleed internally, he would bring peace and tranquility

to the country…

“These hopes peaked in the 1977 elections when the CHP succeeded in getting more than 41 percent of the vote for the first time in its history

. However, shortly after, hopes gave way to disappointment. The government that Ecevit formed in 1978 together with independents

and that could not cure any ill, I remember together with the prime minister’s increasingly prolonged and increasingly distressing empty speeches, and when he resigned

with the “Ohhh…” our whole family breathed. This period is the first experience of the Turkish people placing great hopes in Ecevit and very soon being deeply disappointed.

“For those like me who, from the 1980s onwards, came to the increasingly firm conviction that a Western-type social democratic party was Turkey’s greatest need, Ecevit’s third period began with the DSP (founded in 1985). We were thinking: Was Ecevit, when founding the DSP, aiming to purge himself of the mistakes of the pre-1980 CHP? Would the DSP become the longed-for modern social democratic party in its ideology and organization? Was it bringing a liberal nationalism respectful of our cultural differences, a”secularism respectful of religion”? Hopes flared up and died out like a straw fire.

“It was soon understood that the DSP was neither democratic, nor left-wing, nor a party; it could best be characterized as a one-person or ‘husband and wife’ party. The DSP, while representing an ethnic nationalism competing with the MHP and undiluted laicism, became the number one example of the phenomenon called ‘leader’s dominance’ in Turkish politics. If the DSP succeeded in becoming the first party with 22 percent of the vote in the 1999 elections, it was due to the Turkish people’s reaction to corruption and decay in politics and their delusion that Ecevit had captured Abdullah Ocalan. However, with the financial crisis of February 2001, the Turkish people woke up to the realities of Ecevit and his party and gave him the vote he deserved in the November 2002 elections. The fact that the CHP leader has taken Bulent Ecevit as his ‘model’ shows that even if Ecevit leaves politics and the DSP closes, the style of politics he represented will continue to live for some time.” (*Zaman*, July 29, 2004)

Farewell to Ecevit

I bid farewell to Ecevit with the article I wrote upon his death on November 6, 2006:

“Bulent Ecevit, one of the figures who left his mark on Turkey’s political life for the last 40 years, has passed away. Among adults living today, those who did not at some point in their lives place hope in Ecevit are, I think,

in the minority. For those like me who opened their eyes to politics in the 1960s, Ecevit has meant something different in every period. One reason for this is that my generation’s

values and views have changed over time, and of course the other

reason is the changes in Ecevit's attitudes and behaviors. Since we're talking about at least 40 years, what could be more natural?

"Throughout my entire journalism career, I met with Ecevit twice. Once, together with my friend Seyfettin Gursel, for the long interview we conducted at his home in Oran (which we later included in a book). (This interview appeared in the book as if it was done with Rahsan Ecevit, who was then the DSP's proxy founding president. But as everyone understood, it was Bulent Ecevit who was speaking.) Another time, at the request of my friend Haluk Ozdalga, who was then DSP Deputy Chairman, we met at the Istanbul Provincial Chairmanship. The problems of

Turkish immigrants in Europe were to be discussed. I too was invited as someone knowledgeable. But no one asked my opinion.

"As will be understood, I had no close relationship with Ecevit. I always stayed away from political or other power holders anyway. This was partly because of my nature that does not enjoy power holders, and partly because I believed excessively that keeping distance between oneself and power holders is a principle of the profession that journalists, especially commentators, must observe.

"I had no close relationship with Ecevit, but I have intense memories of him. When Ecevit was beginning to emerge on the political scene, I was a university student deeply sympathetic to the TIP. I saw the 'Left of Center' movement he led as an operation to block the rise of

the TIP, which I thought was destined to rise. The March 12

memorandum being given against him was a claim I could not make sense of at the time, but later I understood that this was Ecevit's message of commitment to civilian rule and of his candidacy for the CHP General Chairmanship. When he became CHP General Chairman in 1972 despite Inonu, I remember being very happy about it.

"Now 'Ecevit was our hope.' When he, as Prime Minister, paved the way for the 1974 political amnesty, opening before me the possibility of ceasing to be a political refugee in Sweden and returning to the country

, as a now convinced social liberal, I felt great affinity with Ecevit's democratic left discourse. I could not vote in the 1977 elections; but I was among those who wholeheartedly celebrated the victory in front of the CHP's general headquarters. 'Karaoglan' was going to take us to 'Bright Days'… That day, my wife and I decided to return to the country from Sweden, and we returned the following year.

"In the period before September 12, I remember Ecevit as a Prime Minister who gave long and empty speeches. I too, like everyone else, saw that together with Demirel they were fueling political polarization and leading the country toward a military coup. And I was very resentful of Ecevit. His resignation from the General Chairmanship of the CHP, which had been closed by the September 12 administration, initially seemed rather

meaningless to me. Later I would come to believe that ‘this could be a message to start an alternative political movement to the CHP, which could not put a wall between itself and the communist left.’

“I looked positively at the DSP initiative. I became hopeful about him again, thinking perhaps Ecevit had become a sincere social democrat just like me. I found Ecevit’s discourse of ‘secularism respectful of religion’ particularly apt. (The Merve Kavakci incident would cast a very heavy shadow on his sincerity on this matter.) Close friends like Ozdalga and Gursel decided to enter politics in DSP ranks. But unfortunately

it soon became apparent in all its nakedness that the DSP was neither left-wing, nor democratic, nor a party. A good assessment of Bulent Ecevit’s political legacy can be found

in Haluk Ozdalga’s book titled ‘Badly Governed Turkey: The DSP Example.’ I offer my condolences to all who loved him. May God have mercy on him. (*Zaman*, November 7, 2006)

“The EU Is Not a ‘Christian Club’”

I saw Turkey’s gradually approaching and eventually becoming a member of the EU as the greatest hope for the establishment of liberal and pluralist democracy in Turkey. The EU’s decision in December 2004 to begin membership negotiations, after declaring Turkey a candidate for membership at the Helsinki summit in December 1999, had strengthened this hope. However, I was also aware of the obstacles to its realization. I wrote:

“What does the decision taken by the EU Council on December 17 to begin accession negotiations with Turkey on October 3, 2005 mean? In my view, it means above all this: The EU is not a ‘Christian club’ but a project of lasting peace and democracy in Europe. This project cannot be completed without Turkey joining the EU; Turkey cannot be without the EU. Nor can the EU without Turkey. The second meaning of the December 17 decision is this: Turkey’s march toward catching up with ‘contemporary civilization,’ the modern civilization pointed out by Mustafa Kemal Ataturk, the founder of our Republic, has entered a new phase. The EU leaders on December 17, in the words of the Dutch Prime Minister Jan Peter Balkenende, truly ‘made history.’

“Turkey’s membership in the EU will take at least ten years, yes. Because due to public opinions that do not look favorably on it, the EU is subjectively not yet ready for Turkey. Turkey, objectively, is not yet ready for the EU because it is far from fulfilling all the Copenhagen Criteria. But if Turkey shows in fulfilling the political criteria

the same determination in fulfilling all the Copenhagen Criteria, what Giscard d’Estaing fears could happen: In 2015, Turkey could very well become the EU’s largest and therefore most influential country. We should never lose sight of this goal.

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“Yes, the decision taken by the EU Council envisages an accession process for Turkey that includes conditions different from those applied to other candidate states. However,

we must also accept that Turkey is in a different category from the states that have been (and will be) candidates for the EU to date: Almost as populous as the total of the 10 countries that joined the EU last May, with a per capita income level reaching only one-third of the EU average, with agriculture still having a considerable share in the economy

, with great income imbalance between regions, and moreover a country whose membership EU public opinions have not yet accepted. For these reasons, while it may not be desirable that the accession conditions foreseen for Turkey are different, it should be considered reasonable.

“It is stated that the negotiations will be ‘an open-ended process whose outcome cannot be guaranteed in advance’

. Yes, after the negotiations are completed, just as any member country can say ‘no’ to Turkey’s membership, Turkey, having brought its democracy

and economy into line with EU norms, can very well give up being a member in the end. Just as Norway did… Turkey’s being

strongly tied to EU structures is foreseen in case it cannot fulfill all the obligations of membership. Whether to fulfill the obligations

or not is in its own hands, so it definitely cannot be said that there is a cause for concern here regarding the future of Turkey-EU relations. The provision for suspending negotiations in case of serious and continuous violation of the principles of freedom and democracy is a provision in Turkey’s favor that ensures the continuation of the reform process

. Unlike the method followed until now, it is not sufficient for the acquis to be accepted by the candidate country on paper

, but also requiring its implementation, which can help Turkey’s economy achieve EU norms.

“Everyone knows that the expressions in the decision about ‘permanent restrictions being conceivable’ are aimed at calming European public opinions where unemployment is widespread.

Finally, for negotiations to begin, Turkey is required to sign the protocol regarding the adaptation of the 1963 Ankara Agreement with the ten new members. Ankara recorded during the summit that signing this protocol, which would bring Turkey into a customs union with the 10 new members, would not mean officially recognizing the Greek Cypriot Administration; it will also record this with a reservation when it signs the protocol. Therefore, signing the protocol is not an issue. (See Prof. Ali Karaosmanoglu’s commentary in yesterday’s *Zaman*.) The issue is the reality that Turkey cannot become a member of the EU

without the Cyprus problem being solved. Therefore, it is inevitable that new initiatives will be launched to solve the problem." (*Zaman*, December 21, 2004)

Yes, these were my hopes in 2004. Unfortunately, in 2021 when these lines are being written, almost no one is left who believes that Turkey could one day become an EU member. This is partly the result of developments in the EU that have distanced the union from digesting Turkey, but more so the result of Turkey, especially since 2011, coming under an authoritarian one-man rule and moving away from the goal of membership.

"Presidential System Does Not Suit Us"

The proposal for Turkey to abandon the parliamentary system and switch to a type of presidential system was seriously brought to the agenda for the first time by President Turgut Ozal. The proposal came up again in the early years of the AKP government. I took a stance against this idea from the days it was first proposed. In the article I wrote on the occasion of the AKP government beginning to flirt with this idea, I wrote:

"…Since the late President Ozal, proposals for Turkey to abandon the parliamentary system, which is its traditional regime, and adopt a type of presidential system instead have come up from time to time. Now the AKP is also seen to want to open this proposal for discussion. I do not know whether what the AKP administration has in mind is an American-style presidential system or a French-style semi-presidential system (which is a mixture of presidential and parliamentary systems). However, neither from the first

nor from the second am I certain that any good will come to Turkey.

"The drawbacks of the presidential system are well known. The first of these is: In case the president and the majority in parliament are from different parties, there is a danger of the system locking up or becoming paralyzed. Because in this case there is no institutional method to resolve the disagreement between the two organs. (In the semi-

presidential system, the difficulty known as cohabitation arises in case the president and prime minister belong to different parties.) Whereas the vote of confidence mechanism in the parliamentary system easily resolves disagreements between the two organs.

"The second important drawback of the presidential system is that in this system politics tends toward polarization because a single candidate and a single party win and all other candidates and parties lose. (In the semi-presidential system, this drawback is mitigated.) Presidential and semi-presidential systems may suit societies where the tendency of the leader who holds executive power to slide into authoritarianism (sultanism) is weak and the culture of compromise among politicians is strong, due to the basic drawbacks listed above, but they do not suit us.

"As far as I can see, the two basic justifications behind proposing a presidential or semi-presidential system for Turkey are: 1) Resolving the elected-appointed conflict in governance and fully establishing the authority of the former over the latter. 2) Giving long-term stability to the executive. Presidential or semi-presidential systems that tend to create polarization in politics

one does not need to be a political scientist to foresee that they could yield results completely opposite to these goals in a country with Turkey's conditions.

"On the other hand, to achieve these goals, there is no need to change the parliamentary system to which Turkey has adhered for about a hundred years. What really needs to be done is: 1) Removing the powers granted to the president by the 1982 Constitution that are incompatible with the parliamentary system and thus ending the

dual leadership in the executive, that is, establishing a pure parliamentary system. 2) Abandoning the proportional representation system that leads to unstable coalition governments and

adopting a two-round, single-member constituency majority system of the type applied in France. On this matter, we can finally say this: Since the probability of obtaining a majority in parliament sufficient for switching to a presidential or semi-presidential system is remote, it will be difficult for Turkey to be dragged into such an adventure.

"I am of the opinion that Recep Tayyip Erdogan ascending to Cankaya in 2007 within the existing system would not be auspicious for either his party or the country. The damage that Ozal's and Demirel's ascent to Cankaya caused to ANAP and DYP due to the leadership struggle that erupted should not be overlooked." (*Zaman*, December 23, 2004)

The above article was one of the signs that I was rowing against the current in my commentary on Turkish politics. As is known, a presidential system of the "alaturka" type was accepted by referendum on April 16, 2017 (in which I, imprisoned in Silivri prison, voted "no") and began to be implemented as of July 9, 2018. Turkey's regime turned toward "sultanism." It has become apparent that the drawbacks of the "alaturka" presidential system are even worse than the general drawbacks of presidential systems. Today, in 2023, opposition parties are busy with preparations to return to the parliamentary system.

"Long Live Turkey on the Path to the EU!"

I welcomed with great happiness the EU Council's decision on October 3, 2005 to begin membership negotiations with Turkey. I wrote: "*Zaman*'s headline summed up the situation well: 'Turkey's European march continues…' I agree with Prime Minister Erdogan's words: Every negotiation is open-ended. The goal is full membership. Whether it will reach this goal and how long it will take is now largely in Turkey's own hands. Perhaps any government in Turkey would have made this effort; but the determination and success the AKP government has shown on the EU path is commendable…" (*Zaman*, October 6, 2005)

Now, looking back from 2021, the excessive optimism I see in these lines reminds me once again how far I could be from foresight when commenting on politics.

“Re-establishing Turkish-Armenian Friendship”

A product of the AKP government’s and especially Foreign Minister Abdullah Gul’s search for normalizing relations with Armenia was the conference “Ottoman Armenians in the Final Period of the Empire: Issues of Scholarly Responsibility and Democracy.” I also participated in the conference, which was planned to be held at Bogazici University in May but after various obstacles were overcome could only take place on September 24-25, 2005 at Bilgi University under the shadow of protests, at the invitation of Halil Berktay on behalf of the organizing committee. On the second day of the conference, at a panel chaired by Murat Belge, I spoke alongside Ali Bayramoglu, Etyen Mancupyan, Ahmet Insel, Murat Paker, and (may he rest in peace) Hrant Dink. The column summarizing my speech, titled “Re-establishing Turkish-Armenian Friendship,” reflected my view on the Armenian issue. I wrote:

“I am not a historian. As a political scientist and commentator, I am primarily concerned with the current problems of Turkish political life. I find the overcoming of what we call the ‘Armenian Question’ necessary for the establishment of liberal and pluralist democracy in Turkey and for a culture of peace to prevail. Therefore, I am concerned with the future rather than the past. My question is: What can be done for the re-establishment of Turkish-Armenian friendship?

“There are certainly those among both Turks and Armenians who want to reach a reconciliation and overcome the problem. Reconciliation advocates are in the minority today, but tomorrow they could constitute the large majority. For this, solution advocates must reach consensus on some

fundamental findings. The event is this: What happened at the end of the 19th century and the beginning of the 20th century is the story of the multi-religious, multi-ethnic Ottoman Empire falling apart through the conflict of ethnic and religious nationalisms supported by imperialist European states. Ethnic-religious

cleansing, expulsion from homelands, massacre of millions - this is their story.

“Almost all ethnic and religious groups that constituted the Ottoman Empire have taken their share from this tragedy to one degree or another. The Committee of Union and Progress decided to have absolute dominance over Anatolia and to purge it of religious and ethnic elements whose loyalty it did not trust. In 1915-16, the Unionists, with the aim of

punishing the separatists who collaborated with the Russians and sought to establish an independent Armenia, subjected Armenians from almost everywhere in the country to forced migration to Syria (the province of Zor), and as a result, Armenians endured the worst of the suffering experienced during the dissolution of the Ottoman Empire.

“Not only Armenians in the war zone but Armenians from everywhere in the country except Istanbul and Izmir were subjected to the Deportation; during the forced migration, hundreds of thousands were killed or perished from hunger and disease. Some escaped the deportation by adopting Islam, some were

saved by Muslims and then managed to survive by converting. Some of those who could reach Syria without dying settled there, many

migrated to France and the USA. The Turkish people have very little information about this tragedy experienced by Ottoman Armenians, and without having sufficient information

, there is absolutely no possibility of overcoming the problem. On the other hand, reaching a consensus on the claim that Armenians were subjected to genocide is out of the question. Some will insist on this claim; some will never accept it.

“But it is an indisputable fact that this claim prevents Turkey from freely discussing what happened in history. Holding all Turks of yesterday and today responsible for the crimes committed by the Unionist administration, using the genocide claim to generally

incite racist hatred and enmity against Turks is unacceptable. If a consensus can be reached on these fundamental findings, progress can be made toward a solution. As reconciliation and solution advocates in Turkey

, our duties are clear: First, we must work for our Armenian citizens to enjoy equal citizenship rights and for minority rights to be secured. Historians should, with courage and determination, accelerate research that will shed light on what happened and who was responsible. We must build public opinion for the establishment of diplomatic relations between Turkey and Armenia and the opening of borders between the two countries.

“Ankara can thereby also contribute to peace between Azerbaijan and Armenia. We must multiply and strengthen contacts

and dialogue between the civil societies of Turkey and Armenia. If we can do all this, the day will come when it will be possible to erect a monument

in Anatolia in memory of the great suffering of Ottoman Armenians.” (*Zaman*, September 29, 2005)

Unfortunately, hopes for Turkish-Armenian, Turkey-Armenia reconciliation could not advance. Only 17 years after the publication of the above article, in early 2022, a new step (with uncertain outcome) toward Turkish-Armenian reconciliation could come on the agenda: On January 14, 2022, representatives of Turkey and Armenia meeting in Moscow announced that negotiations had begun aimed at achieving unconditional normalization between the two countries, without bringing the Armenian Genocide and Nagorno-Karabakh issues to the table.

“Not the Parliamentary System But the Electoral System Should Change”

One of the views I advocated throughout my column-writing career and which largely failed in foreseeing the direction the country would take was that we needed to change the electoral system, not the parliamentary system. In an article on this subject, I wrote:

“There is no doubt that Suleyman Demirel, who served as prime minister seven times between 1965 and 1993, was removed from his seat twice through military interventions during this time, and served as president between 1993 and 2000, is Turkey’s most experienced politician. It is also well known that the most experienced politician is distinguished by frequently changing his views without seeing the need to explain his reasons, with his famous logic of ‘yesterday is yesterday, today is today.’ However, Mr. Demirel has been advocating, without changing his mind on this matter for at least ten years, the transition to a presidential system. In his statement to Murat Yetkin from *Radikal* newspaper the other day, he also said that a system should be adopted where the President is elected by the people in a two-round election (May 15). He said very confidently, ‘Eventually, both Europe and Turkey will switch to the presidential system!’…

“I have long been one of those who think that changing the parliamentary system, which is Turkey’s traditional regime, will not only be of no benefit but will create new and bigger problems. There is a very rich political science literature on the political deadlocks and polarizations that arise in presidential systems when different parties dominate the executive and legislature, and in semi-presidential systems when the president and prime minister come from different parties. Moreover, it is known that these systems can function effectively only in environments where there is a strong culture of compromise (which we do not have). What needs to be done in Turkey is to make the parliamentary system a true parliamentary system…

“However, I have long wholeheartedly supported Mr. Demirel’s proposals that the electoral system should be fundamentally changed from proportional representation to a majority system, and that candidates should be determined by primaries rather than by party leaders. The current system turns elections into a gamble. It can lead to great injustice in representation due to the 10 percent threshold. The unfair distribution of electoral districts does not give equal weight to every citizen’s vote. Because it leaves the door open for candidates to be determined by central nomination, it alienates deputies from voters and reinforces leader dominance in parties.

“In my opinion, the best solution was proposed by Prof. Dr. Seyfettin Gursel in research he did for TUSIAD years ago: A proportionally supplemented, single-member district, two-round majority system (See *Milliyet*, Intellectual View, November 14, 1998). A TBMM consisting of 450 (in my opinion 550 or 650) deputies elected in two rounds from small districts and 100 deputies elected through a proportional representation system with a maximum 1% threshold could provide an effective answer to our search for stability in government and justice in representation.” (*Zaman*, May 18, 2006)

“Freedom of Expression, the Essence of Civilization”

There were also views I advocated throughout my column-writing career that I never thought I was wrong about. One of them was my belief that freedom of expression is the essence of civilization. This was the view I held firmly after abandoning Marxism, one that never wavered. Unfortunately, under AKP rule, Turkey would increasingly move away from civilization. According to the European Court of Human Rights report, Turkey was the European country where freedom of expression and thought was most violated

in 2020 as in 2019. Signals that this would be the case began to come in the early years of AKP rule. In 2006 I wrote:

“The fact that in Turkey, which is a member of the Council of Europe, NATO, OSCE and has begun membership negotiations with the EU, in the year 2006, people who neither praise nor call for the use of violence are still being tried in courts and sentenced to prison is, in my opinion, the clearest indication of how far the Republic of Turkey still is from the ‘contemporary civilization’ it is trying to achieve. Because ‘contemporary civilization’ is essentially nothing other than an environment in which ideas, thoughts, views, and theories can be freely expressed, respectfully listened to, freely debated, and criticized.

“The only thought that should be banned and punished is the call for and praise of suppressing thought, expression, that is, violence, that is, barbarism. It has been said and written I don’t know how many times before and will be said and written I don’t know how many more times: Human beings’ needs do not consist only of material needs, that is, needs like eating, drinking, shelter, and reproduction. Human beings also have spiritual needs. If human beings do not have the opportunity to freely express their ideas, beliefs, and identity without any sanction, they cannot be happy.

“The spiritual needs of human beings are sometimes stronger than their material needs. That is why many people can face all kinds of difficulties and even give up their lives for the sake of expressing their ideas, beliefs, and identity. Societies where people do not have the freedom to freely express their ideas, beliefs, and identities, that is, their personalities, cannot overcome the problems they face. That is why societies that did not allow freedom of expression withered and collapsed, while societies where freedom of expression existed advanced. That is why the fundamental struggle being waged everywhere in the world today is between those who advocate the free expression of ideas, beliefs, and identities and those who want to suppress this, that is, between those for and against civilization.

“Turkey is a society with many problems but also with tremendous potential. Turkey’s progress and rise in every respect can only be possible if it succeeds in freely discussing its problems and producing civilized solutions. It is not possible for Turkey to become a country that develops and progresses in peace unless both its appointed and elected officials fully realize this. This is the essential issue. Whether the European Union grows or falls apart, whether Turkey is admitted to the European Union or not, this truth does not change.” (*Zaman*, June 8, 2006)

“Why Is the World More Religious?”

One of the views reinforced by the readings I did for the “Religion and Politics” course I began teaching at Bahcesehir University was the invalidity of the theory, generally advocated by positivist thinkers, that societies would move away from religion with modernization. In one of my articles, I explained this view based on the theses of American sociologist of religion Peter L. Berger, whose work I was considerably influenced by:

“Nineteenth-century social scientists, especially August Comte, Karl Marx, Emile Durkheim, and Max Weber, argued that religious beliefs would gradually weaken with industrialization and modernization; that religious thought would give way to ‘rational and scientific’ thought. This was also the dominant approach in social scientists’ view of religion until the late 20th century: It was believed that as modernization progressed, societies would move away from religion, religious beliefs would have no social role, and religion would at best be confined to individuals’ private worlds.

“Those who understood secularism in Turkey not as the separation of religion and state, the state keeping equal distance from all beliefs, a political arrangement where freedom of belief including non-belief is secure, but rather as scientific thought replacing religious thought, religion being excluded from social life and confined to individuals’ consciences, the state helping this by controlling religion and restricting religious freedoms, that is, ‘secularists,’ must have thought that science was on their side. However, faced with the rise of Evangelical Protestantism in the USA, Latin America, South Korea, and elsewhere, new types of religious movements developing in Western Europe, the revival in Islamist movements, and similar developments, social scientists abandoned the theory that modernization would bring secularization in the sense of moving away from religion from the mid-1990s onward. That is, science is no longer on the side of ‘secularists.’

“It can be said that the person who best reflects the changing views of contemporary social scientists on modernization and secularization is American sociologist of religion Peter L. Berger. According to Berger, who completely abandoned his old views, the theory that rational scientific thought would become dominant with modernization (Weber), that religion would lose its social function (Durkheim), and that its influence would gradually be confined to individuals’ consciences, does not fit the realities of the world we live in; because ‘Today the world is as religious as it has been at any time in the past and in some places more intensely religious than ever in history.’ The understanding currently dominant among contemporary sociologists of religion is that as long as humans exist (even if religious institutions decline or take on new forms), religious beliefs will continue to exist. Berger expresses this view as follows: ‘The religious impulse, the quest for meaning that transcends the restricted space of empirical existence in this world, has been a perennial feature of humanity… To extinguish this impulse would require something like a mutation of the species.’ (Secularism in Retreat, 1996.)” (*Zaman*, October 24, 2006)

“Religious Orders from a Scientific Perspective”

In addition to Berger, the questioning by some contemporary sociologists of religion like Thomas Luckmann and Grace Davie of positivist theories that modernization would lead to societies moving away from religion also shed light, in my view, on the question of why religion, religious orders, and communities in Turkey maintained their vitality. I wrote:

“President Ahmet Necdet Sezer touched on the subject of religious orders in his press statement on the occasion of Republic Day on October 29. He said they were

‘formations that should be closed down’ and characterized ‘their presentation as civil society organizations as initiatives lacking good faith.’ The President’s statements made me think quite a bit as someone involved in social sciences. As follows: Religious orders are Sufi, mystical interpretations of Islam whose roots go back at least a thousand years. Their main purpose is the spiritual and moral training of believers (disciples) under the guidance of a sheikh (teacher). They were banned in 1925 because they were seen as a threat to Republican rule, and the ban continues today. Religious orders, which display great plurality, maintain their existence and vitality despite the ban. In 20th-century Turkey, religious communities and groups that gathered around charismatic religious figures (different from religious orders because there is no sheikh-disciple relationship) also emerged and spread.

“What is the reason for religious groups such as religious orders and communities maintaining their vitality despite prohibition and pressure? People’s needs are not limited to eating, drinking, sheltering, and reproducing; they also have spiritual needs belonging to their inner worlds. Religious groups respond to these needs as well as taking on social and economic functions. Organizations aimed at social solidarity that rush to help citizens in the grip of poverty and unemployment are organized to a very large extent by religious groups. Schools opened by religious groups have made a great contribution to meeting educational needs. A concept that greatly helps us understand the importance of religious groups for society is the concept of ‘social capital’ developed by social scientists. Social capital can be defined most simply as people cooperating on the basis of mutual trust developed in the context of face-to-face relationships.

“Since the 1980s, religious leaders’ encouraging teachings to their members to work, earn, and transform earnings into investments have played an important role behind the economic development experienced especially in Anatolian cities, behind the ‘Anatolian Tigers.’ This is what lies behind the entrepreneurial groups that some local politicians call ‘Green Capital’ and some foreign researchers call ‘Islamic Calvinists.’ The social capital provided by religious groups has had a considerable share in Turkey’s development.

“It cannot be ignored that religious groups have played a notable role in preserving social unity in an environment where the democratic rule of law has not developed, and in softening ethnic conflicts. It has also been seen that these groups have pioneered the establishment of legitimate political parties to expand the rights and freedoms of believers. It is certainly possible to characterize religious groups, as voluntary associations independent of the state, as part of civil society in Turkey as everywhere in the world.

“However, all this does not mean that there are no opportunists, moral degenerates, and religion exploiters in Turkey who exploit religious order and community solidarity and gain economic and political advantage from it. There have certainly been swindlers who, by collecting the savings of religious people who consider interest forbidden with promises of ‘profit partnership / profit share’ payments, established pyramid schemes as in the examples of the 1980s ‘bankers’ and the 2000s ‘Titans.’ Just as there have been those who derived political terror organizations from religious groups. The effective way

to prevent the exploitation and misuse of religious beliefs in various ways is not prohibition and pressure policies, but transparency and the democratic oversight mechanisms it will make possible. The continued validity of bans placed on religious orders eighty years ago, in accordance with the needs of that day, in 21st-century Turkey, which is moving toward liberal and pluralist democracy, is literally anachronistic." (*Zaman*, November 21, 2006)

AKP as a Sunni Party

While taking a stance against all forms of bigotry, religious dogmatism, and the exploitation of religious beliefs for various purposes in my articles at *Zaman*, I also advocated for respect for religious beliefs. In this context, I harshly criticized the AKP government's attitude toward the Alevis, the country's largest religious minority. I wrote:

"The Istanbul 5th Administrative Court, in its decision dated October 12 and reported in the press on November 23, ruled that compulsory religion courses were contrary to freedom of belief. In the case filed by Alevi Bektashi Federation Vice President Ali Kenanoglu, the court concluded that children of parents who think that the content of the religious culture and ethics course is not compatible with their religious and philosophical beliefs should be exempted from this course…

"The decision of the 5th Administrative Court, from one perspective, in Turkey's primary and secondary education

means the certification that compulsory religion courses are implemented in the form of teaching students the official, state-approved interpretation of Sunnism. From another perspective, it means the determination that in Turkey, which claims to have a secular regime, religious education is kept under state monopoly contrary to secularism in the sense of separation of religion and state, and that the beliefs and worship of a particular sect are being compulsorily taught to all students in public schools financed by all citizens' taxes.

"One of the conditions for the secularization of Turkish-style secularism, that is, for the transition to a system where neither the state interferes with religion nor religion interferes with the state, is certainly the removal of religious education from being a duty of the state. Since we are far from the necessary consensus for this, shouldn't the minimum conditions of religious freedom, one of the basic conditions of democracy, be ensured? Wouldn't the path shown by the 5th Administrative Court be appropriate for this, that is, exempting children from compulsory religion courses if their families so wish? This

exemption, which was previously possible, is also possible within the framework of the 1982 Constitution…

"Alevi parents' request for their children to be exempted from compulsory religion courses does not make Alevis a 'minority' according to either Lausanne or any other legal acquis. That Alevis are the largest religious minority in Turkey in the sociological sense is also scientifically indisputable. As for the debate about whether Alevism is a

part of Islam, a sect: The head of the Directorate of Religious Affairs, the representative of the official interpretation of Sunnism, saying ‘Discussing whether Alevis are Muslim or not is an insult to Islam,’ and the Minister of National Education’s statement that ‘No one has the luxury of saying I am not taking this course’

alongside some leading representatives of the Alevi community themselves accusing those Alevis who view Alevism as outside Islam of ‘divisiveness, reducing Alevis to minority status, atheism, communism, etc.,’ are worrying examples of religious intolerance in Turkey.

“Are these statements not contrary to freedom of religion as well as to the Islamic belief that says ‘There is no compulsion in religion’? In democracies, citizens are free to choose their beliefs, including unbelief, and to interpret them as they wish. Only Alevis themselves can answer the question ‘Are Alevis Muslim or not?’ It is true that the vast majority of Alevis see themselves within Islam. But the claim that those who do not think so cannot be considered Alevi is not reasonable.

The insensitivity of AKP spokespersons, who rightly complain about restrictions on the religious freedoms of the Sunni majority, regarding the freedoms of Alevis is certainly the most obvious example of this party’s double standard in defending religious freedoms. The attitude of AKP spokespersons, who claim to represent the entire nation, reducing Alevism to ‘a culture within Islam’ and the AKP’s doors being kept closed to Alevi citizens is, unfortunately, the clearest indication that this party discriminates among citizens based on religion, that it is a Sunni party.” (*Zaman*, December 7, 2006)

“The Gold Medal of the Literary Olympics”

One of the events that made me happiest during the years I wrote for *Zaman* was Orhan Pamuk winning the Nobel Prize in Literature. On the occasion of the award ceremony, I went to Stockholm, where I had lived for nearly ten years in the 1970s, and sent the following article from there, mixed with my Swedish memories:

“Stockholm, the city where I lived the longest after Istanbul, has an important place in my life. Every place is full of memories. Since my permanent return to the homeland twenty-five years ago, I come to Stockholm once a year, sometimes once every 2-3 years. For the first time, I came with such great happiness and excitement. After settling into the hotel, I immediately headed to Stockholm University to see an old friend. When I entered the metro station, I encountered a huge sign. It said: ‘Dear Orhan Pamuk, we wish you a good time in Stockholm! Since you’ve come this far, wouldn’t you consider a more permanent solution? As an expression of our respect for you, we have opened a page at www.pamukforpresident.se. Was that too much? Then what do you say to <www.iwonthenobelprize.se>? In any case, we would be very pleased to host you.’ The city of Stockholm was advertising itself in this way with Orhan Pamuk, who had arrived here the day before.

“On my way back, I stopped by the university’s bookstore. A special corner had been prepared for the 2006 Nobel Prize in Literature. All of Orhan’s novels stood before me with their Swedish and English translations… When I arrived at the hotel, I reviewed the

newspapers dated December 6. Sweden's number one newspaper Dagens Nyheter, in its news with the headline 'Nobel Prize in Literature winner arrives in Stockholm,' wrote that Swedish Academy Secretary General Horace Engdahl greeted Orhan at the door of the plane and took him to the city in a limousine. When I turned on the television before going to bed at night, with the magnificent views of Istanbul in the background, I listened to what Orhan had said to the world media at the press conference he held that morning.

"When I picked up Dagens Nyheter the next morning, I saw that the editorial was devoted to Orhan Pamuk. The editorial, which began 'This year's Nobel Prize in Literature winner Orhan Pamuk strongly supports Turkey's EU membership. Pamuk has as multifaceted an authorship as the European integration project…' was about the importance of Turkey's EU membership for Europe and the world. It seemed to me that Stockholm and the world through Stockholm went to sleep and woke up with Orhan Pamuk.

"I attended the luncheon given by our Stockholm Ambassador Mr. Necip Eguz and his wife Mrs. Senay in honor of Orhan Pamuk. After he won the Nobel, I found the opportunity to embrace Orhan there for the first time to congratulate him, and to thank him for the joy and pride he gave us. At this age, I have not experienced another event that made me as happy as a Turk as Orhan Pamuk winning the Nobel. I asked the Ambassador what Orhan's success meant for Turkey's image and prestige. Raising his hand toward the ceiling, he said in a single word, 'Tremendous!' He told how Swedes who recognized him from photographs in newspapers stopped him on the street and said, 'You are the Turkish ambassador, aren't you? I heartily congratulate you on the Nobel Prize.'

"December 7, 2006, Thursday, the biggest event in Stockholm was, of course, Orhan Pamuk's Nobel Prize acceptance speech at the Swedish Academy's historic and magnificent building in the old city. Although it was announced that he would give his speech in Turkish, tickets had sold out days in advance, and the hall was packed full. The large majority in the hall would follow the speech from the distributed Swedish and English texts. When Orhan entered the hall together with Engdahl

hundreds of people stood up and applauded our great writer for minutes. The whole world listened in 'Turkish.' His speech titled 'My Father's Suitcase' was about the story of Orhan Pamuk's authorship and his father's role in this story. He told how his late father, when he read his first novel, embraced Orhan and said, 'My son, you will win the Nobel one day.'

"When he ended his emotional speech, listened to in complete silence, with 'Distinguished members of the Swedish Academy who gave me this great award, this honor, distinguished guests, I very much wish my father were among us today…' many of our eyes had welled up with tears… After leaving the Swedish Academy, I returned to the hotel with a long walk. Along the way, I thought about how much I envied Orhan, and how I had never envied anyone else in life. Years ago I had told him too: How much I envied him for giving his entire life only to literature and for never doing anything other than writing…

“My early youth ideal was also to become a literary figure, to write novels; but my path was drawn more by fate than by myself. Yet that evening my heart was laden not with envy, but with pride… Yes, Orhan Pamuk received the gold medal of the literary Olympics; he brought great reputation and prestige to Turkey. He succeeded in reaching humanity in 49 languages, including most recently Vietnamese, Bengali, and Basque, which only a few hundred thousand people can read and write. He alone carried Turkey to the world. No matter how much we take pride in him, it is not enough.” (*Zaman*, December 9, 2006)

Is Islamic Liberalism Possible?

During the years I wrote for *Zaman*, I had the belief that not only dogmatic-totalitarian but also liberal, libertarian interpretations of Islam and Islamism were possible, and the expectation that such interpretations would gradually become dominant. One source of encouragement for this was certainly the Iranian Islamic (not Islamist) thinker Abdulkerim Sorush, whom I met in Istanbul in the mid-1990s and whose writings I continuously followed afterward. I wrote the following about Sorush and political liberalism:

“We know that all religions, including Islam, have both fundamentalist and reformist interpretations. It can be said that fundamentalist interpretations adhere to the letter, that is, the word of sacred texts; while reformist interpretations take as their basis the spirit, that is, the meaning of sacred texts. Iranian theologian, philosopher of Islam and science Dr. Abdulkerim Sorush rejects views that he is the ‘father of ideas’ for ‘reformist’-inclined clerics in his country; but there is no doubt that he is a leading representative of libertarian, liberal Islamic thought. It is possible to summarize Sorush’s basic ideas as follows:

“Islam is not only compatible with democracy, but Islam cannot exist where there is no democracy. Efforts to produce totalitarian political ideologies from religion are contrary to Islam. Because there is no compulsion in religion; belief based on coercion is not real belief. To be a believer, one must first have the right to believe, human rights. For an individual to truly believe, they must be free to adopt faith and to abandon it if they wish. For this, religion and state must be separated, neither religion should interfere with the state nor the state with religion. Secularism in the political sense is not the rival or

enemy of religion, but its complement.

“Sacred texts are divine and do not change, but their interpretation belongs to humans and changes. Therefore, there is no interpretation of Islam valid for every place and time; interpretations change over time. Islam does not grant any group, including clerics, the authority to monopolize the interpretation of religion. All believers have the right to interpret their beliefs as they wish. Clerics can have no privileges over other citizens. In order to free themselves from being spokespersons for official or popular views, they should receive salaries from neither the state nor the people, and should earn their

living by working. In the West, religion and science clashed, and finally declared a ceasefire; but both benefited from this conflict and learned to be more humble. The interpretations of religion should not conflict with science. If a particular interpretation of

religion is an obstacle to progress, progress can be encouraged by changing the interpretation. The secret of progress lies in rationalism and the ability to criticize oneself.

“Sorush, who was appointed by Khomeini to the Cultural Revolution Council tasked with reorganizing university education programs after the 1979 Islamic Revolution, resigned from the council in 1983 due to disagreements. In the 1990s, his relationship with the regime grew increasingly strained; he began publishing”Kiyan,” which became a magazine for religious intellectuals. The magazine was closed by the regime in 1998. Sorush not only lost his job at Tehran University, but his lectures also began to be targeted by attacks from regime supporters. Saying in response to the pressures he faced, “Has this country become a place where a professor must risk his life to give a lecture or conference? Do we need Galileos and Brunos?” Sorush left Iran in 2000. He gave lectures at Harvard, Yale, and Princeton universities in the USA, then at the Wissenschaftskolleg in Berlin. He is currently a visiting professor at the University of Amsterdam.

“The interview I conducted with him (*Milliyet*, August 14, 1995) had contributed to Sorush becoming known in Turkey as well. After an approximately 11-year hiatus, I found the opportunity to be together again and chat with Sorush, who visited Turkey last week. Naturally, we also talked about what the results of the local council and Assembly of Experts elections held on December 15 in Iran meant. Sorush does not see the election results, which Nesrin Alavi characterized as the end of Mahmoud Ahmadinejad’s rise (*Open Democracy*, December 19), as harbingers of major political changes in Iran. According to him: The vast majority of the people are satisfied with their situation because they are receiving a share of the increased oil revenues in recent years. The regime has complete control in the political, economic, and cultural spheres. The differences among the holders of political power do not carry significant importance. No change should be expected in Iran’s established order for at least the next twenty years.” (“Abdulkerim Sorush and Islamic Liberalism,” *Zaman*, December 26, 2006)

Today, as I write my memoirs in 2021, I can say that there is no trace left in my mind of the expectation that liberal interpretations of Islam could gradually become dominant, and that I am completely disappointed on this matter. It was also understood that Sorush was not wrong in his pessimism regarding Iran.

In Memory of Hrant Dink

Agos, the newspaper of the Armenian community in Turkey, published mainly in Turkish and Armenian, began publication in 1996. I appreciated the efforts of Hrant Dink, the newspaper’s editor-in-chief and writer, both to have Turkish society face the great catastrophe that befell Ottoman Armenians and to bring about rapprochement between Turkey and Armenia. When I visited the *Agos* office, which was then in Beyoglu, to meet him in the early 2000s, the warmth he showed me made me very happy. We had come together on various occasions and had spoken on the same panel at the Ottoman Armenians conference held at Bilgi University in 2005.

Hrant's falling victim to a shadowy assassination in front of the *Agos* office in Osmanbey on January 19, 2007 had deeply shaken me. In the article I wrote in great sorrow upon the sad news and sent to the newspaper, after making references to Hrant's last article published on January 10, I wrote:

"Hrant Dink was a friend of mine. He was a person with a warm heart and a lion-like character. His conscience was free, his mind was free. He was a first-class intellectual who did not hesitate to say what he believed was right. He was as much a Turk as he was an Armenian. He had put his life on the line to re-establish Turkish-Armenian friendship and gave his life for this cause. I feel great shame and great pain in the name of Turkey, Turkishness, and humanity…

"Those who killed Hrant dealt a very heavy blow to Turkey, Turkishness, and humanity. Those who killed Hrant truly degraded Turkey and Turkishness… There could be no greater insult to Turkey and Turkishness… No heavier blow could be dealt to Turkish democracy and Turkey's prestige and reputation in the world… Unfortunately, the cost of this crime committed by the real enemies of Turkishness will be very heavy for Turkey. Hrant Dink died physically. But he will live forever with the great contribution he made to Turkey's cause of freedom and democracy." ("Hrant Dink (1954 - 2007): Here is your price…," *Zaman*, January 20, 2007)

I would also write the following after Hrant's funeral:

"The great reaction shown to the savage and treacherous murder of Hrant Dink, who was targeted through a hate campaign conducted by racist circles, was a strong sign that humanity and civilization will sooner or later prevail over barbarism and brutality in Turkey. Tens of thousands of Istanbulites marching behind Hrant Dink's coffin with slogans of 'We are all Hrant… We are all Armenian' were only saying 'We are all human!'… More than a hundred thousand Istanbulites from all walks of life and all origins marching in silent rebellion behind Hrant's coffin gave a lesson in humanity. But the real lesson in humanity was given by his wife Rakel Dink with her dignified stance that day. In her speech that touched hearts, she said, 'Whatever their age, 17 or 27, whoever the killer is, I know they were once babies. Nothing can be done without questioning the darkness that creates a killer from a baby, my brothers…'" ("Lessons in Humanity," *Zaman*, February 15, 2007)

The 367 Crisis

As the term of the 10th President Ahmet N. Sezer approached its end in May 2007, the debate over who would replace him had become one of the main items on the political agenda. Representatives of the authoritarian secularism understanding that restricted religious freedoms launched a campaign against the possibility of Prime Minister Erdogan being elected President. *Cumhuriyet* newspaper came out with the headline "Are you aware of the danger?" CHP chairman Deniz Baykal threatened Erdogan, "Don't you dare be a candidate!" In this environment, after intra-party negotiations, Erdogan announced (even though perhaps he himself actually wanted the position) that the AKP's presidential candidate was Foreign Minister Abdullah Gul.

Threats aimed at preventing Gul's election peaked with the statement published by the General Staff at midnight on April 27. However, the AKP government, trusting the strong voter support behind it, reacted harshly to the General Staff's memorandum for the first time in Turkish history. Government spokesman Cemil Cicek made a statement emphasizing that the TSK was attached to the Prime Ministry and responsible to the Prime Minister. Following this, Chief Public Prosecutor of the Court of Cassation Sabih Kanadoglu distorted the rule that according to the constitution, two-thirds of TBMM members, that is, 367 deputies, must vote for the President to be elected in the first round, with a scandalous interpretation, putting forward the condition that 367 deputies must be present in the General Assembly in the first round for the election. When none of the opposition parties participated in the first round, the Constitutional Court (following Kanadoglu) annulled the election. Thereupon Gul withdrew his candidacy; the AKP decided to hold early elections on July 22.

In the articles I wrote during the 2007 presidential election process, I advocated that Erdogan continue as prime minister, Gul as foreign minister, and that an AKP member who the opposition could also support be elected to the Presidency. I first explained my opinion on this matter in an article titled "Erdogan should remain prime minister" as follows:

"Last week I met with the 9th President Suleyman Demirel in a television program. Of course, we asked him what he thought about the presidential debates. Mr. Demirel implied that Prime Minister Erdogan's election as President was inevitable, saying that the answer to this question was given on November 3, 2002… However, I have not yet lost hope: I think Erdogan has services to render to Turkey as Prime Minister and I am expecting an announcement that another respected AKP member is a candidate for the Presidency." (*Zaman*, April 17, 2007)

The television program I mentioned above had been the occasion for my first and last meeting with the late Demirel. At that time, I was one of the regular guests of "High Politics," the program of my friend from the AFS years Haluk Sahin, broadcast on TV8. Meeting Demirel through the program would be a valuable opportunity for me. When Mr. Demirel came to the studio, Haluk and I greeted him together. Thinking that he might not know me, I introduced myself somewhat embarrassed, saying "Mr. President, I am Sahin Alpay. I am a faculty member at Bahcesehir University, and I also write a column for *Zaman* newspaper…" Demirel looked at me with a mocking air and said, "I was prime minister seven times and president for seven years in this country; I know who Sahin Alpay is…" I had wanted to sink into the ground… It was known that Demirel had an extraordinary memory. Certainly, during the years he was in office, MIT files about me must have come before him, he must have come across my newspaper columns and the television programs I participated in. The late Demirel (1924 - 2015), whose policies often saddened me and sometimes gave me hope, had left me no choice but to apologize.

CHAPTER XII / BOTH SUPPORT AND OPPOSITION TO THE AKP

In its early years, I viewed the AKP government quite positively and with hope. However, starting from 2007, I began to voice my objections to their policies while maintaining what I considered a balanced perspective—supporting them on one hand while not withholding criticism on the other. In one of the first articles I wrote from this angle, I said:

“First of all, I must state that I greatly appreciate the role played by the AKP under the leadership of Recep T. Erdoğan, Abdullah Gül, and (yes) Bülent Arınç in transcending the National Vision Movement and in committing Turkey’s distinctive Islamist movement to democratic and secular principles. The AKP’s performance in power was even more successful than I expected. The AKP government made a very important contribution to raising democratic standards in Turkey, especially in the context of EU reforms,

and by ensuring macroeconomic stability, it achieved a significant development push.

“Our not getting entangled in the Iraq quagmire until now was perhaps a matter of luck. But with its foreign policy bearing the signatures of Abdullah Gül and Ahmet Davutoğlu, which was based on diplomacy and dialogue, Ankara increased its prestige across almost the entire world—from the USA to Israel, from the EU to the Islamic world, from Africa to India and China. The AKP became synonymous with change and progress in Turkey. In the upcoming elections, the Turkish people will appreciate these services.

“What we have experienced since the April 27 memorandum shows that the gains Turkey achieved under AKP rule are unfortunately at risk due to the AKP administration’s own mistakes. I hope Turkey succeeds in overcoming the crisis we are going through and continues and strengthens the democratic process. But if the AKP leadership is to continue leading change in Turkey, it must once again succeed in learning from its mistakes and purging itself of errors. To help with this, I want to list what I consider the AKP’s most important mistakes and errors.

“It is quite obvious that the AKP made a complete mess of the presidential election. The AKP administration, by treating this issue as an internal party matter, as ‘capturing another position while the opportunity arose,’ paved the way for the April 27 military intervention. However, an AKP member whom the opposition could also accept could have been elected president, and this crisis might not have occurred. The elimination of the bureaucratic tutelage regime established through military interventions requires a patient, long-term struggle to be won step by step. I hope the AKP administration immediately abandons its enthusiasm for transitioning to a semi-presidential system ‘while taking advantage of the opportunity’ and aims to strengthen the parliamentary system.

“The AKP must take seriously the widespread doubts and fears about its commitment to secularism and its respect for different lifestyles and beliefs, and do what is necessary to address them. Those who want respect for their own lifestyles and beliefs must be

respectful of others' lifestyles and beliefs. This principle applies to everyone. The AKP must use every opportunity to show the nation that it is committed to this principle. In this context, the primary problem it must immediately overcome is to cease being a 'Sunni party' and to ensure that Alevi and non-Muslim citizens are represented at all levels of the party. Without achieving this, the AKP can neither convince society of its commitment to secularism nor become a center party, a party of the entire nation, as it claims. The most justified objection directed at AKP rule is the criticism of 'cadre-building.' The impression has taken hold that loyalty, not merit, is the basis for almost every appointment. In its second term in power, the AKP must completely erase this impression. Autonomous boards must be 'autonomous in substance, not just in name.' It must be understood that this is in the interest of all governments and the country.

"The claim of being 'Ak (meaning Clean) Party' requires proof. Unfortunately, the experiences of 4.5 years of AKP rule (despite the main taps being turned off) are not of a nature to convince anyone that corruption is behind us. The impression that corruption has grown along with the economy is widespread. Finally, the AKP should devote its greatest effort to making the Copenhagen Criteria the Ankara Criteria, to fulfilling these standards. The most crucial task here is establishing the rule of law. The rule of law cannot be established unless political murders are fully brought to light. Those who do not do everything possible to establish the rule of law will themselves become victims of lawlessness." ("My Objections to the AKP," *Zaman*, 24.5.2007)

"Abdullah Gül should remain as foreign minister"

In the general election held on July 22, 2007, the AKP received 47% of the vote and maintained power much more strongly; the MHP, which had remained outside parliament in the 2002 elections, also passed the threshold and entered parliament. When the AKP won 341 and the MHP won 70 parliamentary seats, the 367 requirement was easily surpassed, and Gül was elected the 11th President on August 28, 2007. Despite the great electoral victory it won, I insisted on the idea that the AKP should elect the new president by reaching consensus with the opposition, because I believed it would be the right thing to do, even though I did not think it likely. I wrote:

"Judging by the interview he gave to Hasan Cemal, Foreign Minister Abdullah Gül appears to have decided to run for President again. (*Milliyet*, July 26) I have not been warm to this idea since the day his candidacy was mentioned. The July 22 election results did not change my mind either… My final word on this matter is: I see it as being in the country's interest for Mr. Erdoğan to continue as prime minister and Mr. Gül to continue as foreign minister for at least one more term." In the same article, I said I would consider Gül's presidency a "waste of talent." (*Zaman*, 28.7.2007)

However, in light of the electoral victory it achieved despite the April 27 memorandum, the AKP administration did not give up on Gül's candidacy, and Gül was elected the 11th President of the Republic of Turkey on August 28, 2007, receiving 339 votes in the third round of the presidential election held in the Grand National Assembly. Upon it becoming clear that he would be elected, I wrote the following:

“As a commentator who believes that Foreign Minister Abdullah Gül assuming the presidency is a waste of talent, I must first state this: I wish Mr. Gül success in his new position. Everyone must show absolute respect for the decision of the Grand National Assembly, the most fundamental institution of our democracy. However, there is benefit in examining what Gül’s presidency means for Turkish political life. The fundamental goal is for Turkey to be a free and prosperous country in every sense. For reforms toward the establishment of democracy and modernization of the economy to continue, bureaucratic tutelage must end. There is complete consensus on these matters among those who believe in freedom and democracy. However, opinions differ on how the bureaucratic tutelage regime can be liquidated.

“The view that dominated the AKP leadership until last April was this: Erdoğan would ascend to Çankaya, thus the Presidency, the fortress of the tutelage regime, would also pass to the AKP. After the general election, the constitution would be changed and a semi-presidential system would be established. Erdoğan and Gül would govern the country together. However, this scenario was abandoned at the last moment partly due to strong objections from the tutelage front to Erdoğan’s ascent to Çankaya, and partly due to concerns that power could be lost if he left the party leadership; Gül was declared as a candidate instead of Erdoğan.

“When the Constitutional Court’s invention of ‘367’ made the presidential election impossible, an early election became necessary. In light of the discussions conducted in public opinion and the experiences gained, Erdoğan changed his view on two important matters: 1) He saw that breaking bureaucratic tutelage could be possible through patient, step-by-step struggle, and decided that at this stage it would be more appropriate for a low-profile AKP member to ascend to Çankaya. 2) He abandoned the semi-presidential system. He tasked an expert committee headed by Prof. Dr. Ergun Özbudun with preparing a democratic constitution draft that would strengthen the parliamentary system and grant only symbolic powers to the president.

“The elections resulted in AKP’s victory. Bülent Arınç, saying that the architect of this was Erdoğan and therefore everyone should accept the positions he deemed appropriate, did not run again for Speaker of the Grand National Assembly. A low-profile AKP member, Köksal Toptan, was elected to this position with very broad consensus. Erdoğan emphasized that he wanted ‘work, not crisis’ in the new term; he said he would go to the opposition parties with a candidate list; he gave all the signs that he preferred Gül to withdraw his candidacy. But he also emphasized that ‘the decision and responsibility’ belonged to Gül. When Gül insisted on his candidacy, Erdoğan had nothing left to say. Since the MHP announced that it would take the victimhood card from the AKP’s hands, Gül’s ascent to Çankaya as the 11th President on August 28 was certain. (…)

“So, what does Gül’s ascent to Çankaya bring? It is clear from day one that a suitable ground for the opposition’s tactics of putting the government in conflict with the military and civilian bureaucracy will emerge. How will this affect the political and economic stability that we have greatly benefited from? Will the AKP government be strengthened or weakened in dealing with the tough domestic and foreign problems before it? Will we

face a ‘two-headed’ AKP in the coming period? Will the constitution that would grant only symbolic powers to the president

be shelved? It is certain that uncertainties have increased.” (“Everyone Must Respect the Decision of the Grand National Assembly,” *Zaman*, 16.8.2007)

“Congratulations”

It quickly became apparent that my suggestion on who should be president, like my suggestions on other matters, was extremely idealistic. When it became clear that Erdoğan would remain prime minister and Foreign Minister Abdullah Gül would be brought to the presidency, I found myself having to say “Congratulations”:

“Because of his conciliatory and reconciling character, it is understood that Mr. Gül’s presidency is approved even by segments that are not fanatically opposed to the AKP. There is no reason why Mr. Gül should not show the same success in the presidency that he showed in the Foreign Ministry. Perhaps most importantly, Mr. Gül’s words about what kind of president he would be if elected: ‘I know Turkey’s sensitivities. I am also aware of the problems Turkey faces. From today, I am determined to work in harmony with all institutions and civil society. I will try to put myself in everyone’s place and think that way. I will embrace everyone.’ If Gül remains true to these words, the presidency can become an office that solves problems rather than creates them. Congratulations on the presidential election.” (*Zaman*, 26.4.2007)

Interestingly, my advocacy for Abdullah Gül to remain as foreign minister would also have a ‘cost’ for me. During the presidency of Gül, who had made me happy in 2001 when we met by saying that my writings had contributed to the formation of the ‘Reformist’ movement that brought the AKP to power, I was not invited to any reception at Çankaya. Whether not having been invited to Çankaya throughout my column-writing career can be considered a deficiency from my standpoint, I do not know.

My AKP optimism at its peak

In the days leading up to the July 22, 2007 elections, Haluk Özdalga called: Prime Minister Erdoğan had proposed parliamentary candidacy to two former CHP members, himself and Ertuğrul Günay; he was asking how I would react to his becoming a candidate from the AKP. I told him to definitely accept. This would be a contribution to keeping the AKP on the right track. When he asked “what would you do if you received such an offer,” I got the impression he was sounding me out. I replied, “I’m not thinking about politics; I’m happy with what I’m doing, I want to maintain my independence…” When their candidacies were announced, I called both to congratulate them. Günay said, “The boss had mentioned that he would also propose candidacy to you, but for some reason he changed his mind…” If I had received such an offer from Erdoğan, would I have accepted? I don’t think so.

I interpreted the great success the AKP achieved in the 2007 general elections as a new victory for democracy. I wrote: “My first column in *Zaman* newspaper, published two days after the November 3, 2002 elections, was titled ‘Victory of Democracy.’ The July

22, 2007 elections also resulted in a new victory for democracy. Mainly for these reasons: The Turkish people conducted the 15th general elections since the transition to a multi-party system with great maturity, with high turnout (around 85%), and without any noteworthy incident. The efforts of gangs to sabotage democracy, the speculations that some excuse would be found to prevent the elections, proved futile, and the bomb plots in this direction failed.

“The Turkish people gave clear and explicit support to the single-party rule of the last five years; they said ‘continue on the path’ to the Justice and Development Party (AKP) government. Despite perhaps the world’s worst electoral system (proportional representation with a 10% threshold), the situation that emerged in the last election was not repeated, no ‘shadow’ fell on democracy: The proportion of votes that would not be represented in parliament fell to an acceptable level (around 13%). The ruling party will have fewer seats in parliament, but will form a stronger government with much greater legitimacy and authority (because no ‘shadow’ of inadequate representation fell on parliament). At the same time, it will be monitored by a stronger opposition consisting of at least three parties. It is hoped that, as indicated by the signals given in the Prime Minister’s thank-you speech, greater attention will be paid to the need for consensus with both parliamentary and extra-parliamentary opposition on fundamental decisions.

“The biggest message these elections gave is that voters definitely do not approve of polarizing attitudes. As a reformist party in favor of open society and competitive economy, the AKP was registered as the dominant, center party of the system. Despite perhaps the world’s worst electoral system, the political party that claims to represent primarily the concerns and demands of our citizens of Kurdish origin, the DTP, entered parliament through independent candidates. This is a very important opportunity to exclude violence and weapons from Turkish politics, if all politicians act responsibly. That this opportunity not be wasted is perhaps the greatest hope born of these elections.

“With the July 22 elections, the AKP received the authority to govern the country alone for another five years. Approximately half of the voters from every background, belief, and class and from all regions of the country said ‘Yes!’ to the AKP. The AKP became the party that increased its vote share the most while in power in the history of Turkish democracy. How can this great electoral victory be explained? The main reasons can be listed as follows: The AKP government (following the ‘roadmap’ drawn by the EU) stabilized the economy in Turkey, average income increased by more than double; a relative improvement in income distribution was achieved. Despite ongoing problems with fundamental rights (thanks to EU reforms), Turkey became a country where freedoms expanded compared to pre-2002, where fundamental rights were more respected, and where improvements in the human rights field were experienced. The vast majority of voters did not give credence to claims that secularism was in danger or that the ruling party was responsible for the surge in terrorism.

“The fact that the opposition parties were run by a tested cadre whose failures were established, who lacked credibility, and who were quarrelsome worked very much in the AKP’s favor. Another factor explaining the AKP’s electoral victory is undoubtedly Prime Minister Recep Tayyip Erdoğan’s having support even higher than his party. ‘Charismatic

authority' is effective on a significant portion of Turkish voters. On the other hand, it is clear that many CHP voters either voted for another party or did not go to the polls because of the party's 'repellent' leader. It is difficult to estimate what contribution the anti-democratic interventions by the military and civilian bureaucracy in the presidential election process made to the support given to the AKP. According to KONDA researchers who successfully predicted the election results, the AKP's vote appeared to be above 45% since September 2006. Certainly today Turkey looks to its tomorrow with greater confidence and optimism." ("The New Victory of Turkish Democracy," *Zaman*, 24.7.2007)

Problems cannot be solved if ideas are not free

In my articles in *Zaman*, I explained the most fundamental principle I adhered to:

"I have forty years of experience in expressing my thoughts in writing and orally in public. During these forty years, my ideas have changed and evolved considerably depending on what I learned by reading, living, and discussing. During these forty years, while expressing my thoughts, I had to struggle on the one hand with the restrictions and bans imposed by the state, and on the other hand with the prejudices of the society and environment I was in (if you will, 'neighborhood pressure'), and I still struggle. Looking at the fact that the limits of freedom of expression are gradually expanding and that 'neighborhood pressure' on those who think differently is gradually easing, I still maintain my optimism for the future.

"When faced with a question like 'What is the most fundamental lesson given by forty years of experience?' my unhesitating answer is this: There can be nothing that gives greater happiness to a thinking person than saying what they think, and nothing that causes greater torment than not being able to say what they think… For a society to overcome the problems it faces, there is no more effective way than acquiring all the information it can reach about the facts that give rise to the problems and conducting the broadest discussion about how they can be solved… The advancement of science is also only possible where there is freedom to question and criticize… For this reason, no limit should be placed on expression other than calls for and praise of violence, incitement of hatred and enmity, and insult, and people should be encouraged to say what they think… This is the strongest, the most indispensable of the ideas and principles I adhere to.

"Because this idea and principle, unfortunately, is still far from being established in our society, like others I often feel the need to voice it. These days we are living through times when the negatives arising from Turkey's two fundamental problems, the 'Kurdish problem' and the 'Armenian problem,' not having been overcome are piling up. It is certain that both problems have very complex aspects and that there are no easy solutions. But the fundamental truth behind these problems with about a century of history still occupying and distressing us today is that Turkish society has been prevented from acquiring all the available information about the facts that gave rise to them and from conducting the broadest discussion about how they can be overcome. The primary instrument of this prevention is, no doubt, the cover called 'official history'

that the state has been trying to spread over historical facts for years using laws, the education system, the media, and other means, and which has only begun to be torn in recent years.

“Perhaps the best indicator of this dire situation is the point reached in the ‘Armenian problem.’ This problem is essentially the inability to freely discuss the questions of ‘What happened to the Ottoman Armenians in 1915-16?.. Are there responsibilities that these events impose on the Republic of Turkey?..’ The imposition of ‘official history,’ that is, the state’s view on this matter, on society, the punishment of those who think differently, and their exposure to the harshest insults and the harshest ‘neighborhood pressure.’ Was not our valued colleague Hrant Dink, who made great efforts to achieve Turkish-Armenian reconciliation and to free relations from being a subject of confrontation fueled by ethnic nationalists on both sides, made the target of a campaign of hatred and enmity for expressing his ideas?

“Was he not, in a great injustice, sentenced to prison under Article 301 of the Turkish Penal Code for allegedly ‘insulting Turkishness’? Did it not become plainly clear that despite reports that he would be killed, the necessary measures for his protection were not taken? Even after he was killed, was his trial not continued, and this time was not his son Arat Dink also convicted? Are not those who (rightly) oppose the criminalization of saying ‘there was no genocide’ in Switzerland and France also defending the criminalization of saying ‘there was genocide’ in Turkey? Is not this the fundamental reason behind the resistance to changing or abolishing Article 301 of the Turkish Penal Code? Is the number of those prosecuted under Article 301 not increasing every day? As long as we cannot fully establish freedom of expression, as long as a ‘culture of fear’ dominates even our universities, we cannot overcome any problem.” (*Zaman*, 18.10.2007)

Opportunity in the Kurdish problem

I thought that the AKP’s emerging from the July 22, 2007 elections with its power strengthened created an opportunity for the Kurdish problem to enter a path to solution:

“After the July 22 elections, an opportunity arose to solve the Kurdish problem and end PKK terrorism. Not only the domestic but also the external conjuncture became perhaps more favorable than ever. Why? It is certain that after entering the EU accession process, the world’s perception of Turkey changed. Because after the 2001-2004 EU reforms with the de facto recognition of Kurdish identity, some steps being taken to remove the obstacles to citizens who consider themselves Kurdish freely living their language and culture, and the expansion of freedom of expression, there remained no justifiable aspect to the armed uprising.

“Even those who saw the PKK as ‘freedom fighters’ began to understand that it was a genuinely terrorist organization that applied the harshest terror mainly to Kurds and its own members. Perhaps the clearest sign that the external conjuncture had changed was both the USA and the EU placing the PKK on their lists of terrorist organizations in 2002. The PKK, which serves an unclear purpose and unclear masters, panicked about losing

its influence among Turkey's Kurds after the July 22 elections. It escalated provocative attacks aimed at drawing Ankara into

a Turkish-Kurdish war encompassing the entire region by occupying Northern Iraq. The EU strongly condemned the attacks and stood by Turkey. The US administration also finally understood that the PKK was also seeking to destabilize Northern Iraq… At the point reached today, it can be seen that both the USA and the KRG want the liquidation of the PKK, which is a festering sore that damages their relations with Turkey.

"In light of the experiences since 1984 when the PKK launched its armed uprising, what needs to be done is clear: First of all, the obstacles to citizens who consider themselves Kurdish freely living their language and culture and freely expressing their particular concerns should be removed step by step. The government should determine the steps to be taken in this direction through dialogue with Kurdish politicians inside and outside parliament who are against violence. Amnesty is an indispensable tool in the fight against terrorism. For the PKK to be neutralized, its ordinary militants must be pardoned with an appropriate formula and the way must be opened for them to return to normal life. For the amnesty to produce results, thought must also be given to how the young people who escape from the PKK's grip will earn their living.

"If Ankara truly wants the PKK to be finished, it should also not object to PKK ringleaders seeking asylum in third countries on condition that they abandon terrorism. One of the most important tools in solving the problem is, without doubt, the elimination of unemployment and poverty in the Kurdish-majority region. Finally, dialogue must definitely be established with the Kurdish Regional Government in Iraq. Ankara should respect the KRG's autonomy in return for it never allowing its territory to be used by the terrorist organization and pursuing a policy of friendship, and should deepen economic interdependence with the region…" ("What needs to be done on the Kurdish problem is clear," *Zaman*, 12.1.2008)

"Is the AKP abandoning the EU?"

Starting from early 2008, I began to question the AKP government's foreign policy. In this context, one of my first articles was titled "Is the AKP abandoning the EU?" In those years when I was careful to distinguish between the positive and negative aspects of AKP rule, I wrote:

"It is certain that AKP rule has brought positive innovations to Turkish foreign policy. Looking at the statements of foreign policy advisor Prof. Dr. Ahmet Davutoğlu and the declarations and practices of the government, I had been convinced that, at least until the end of 2005, the AKP's foreign policy was essentially guided by the following principles: The fundamental foreign policy goal is EU membership. However, multidimensionality will be given to foreign relations. The multidimensional foreign policy to be conducted with self-confident diplomacy will not only reduce problems with neighbors to zero, but will also make Turkey

a 'central country' with a say in both regional and world politics (including international organizations).

“Post-September 11 world conditions give Muslim-majority Turkey the opportunity to be not just a bridge between the West and Islamic countries, but a ‘model’ for the Islamic world with the strong economy and democracy it will build. There is not conflict but rather complementarity between EU membership and multidimensional foreign policy goals. Because gaining effectiveness and prestige in its region and especially over Islamic countries will increase Turkey’s value to the EU. How can recent foreign policy developments be evaluated from the perspective of the above paradigm?

“Kostas Karamanlis being the first Greek Prime Minister to come to Turkey in 49 years is, no doubt, a result of the AKP government’s policy of improving relations with neighbors. The disputes between Turkey and Greece have not been resolved, but there is visible rapprochement in relations between societies and even between armed forces. The probability of a war breaking out between Turkey and Greece is close to zero. The AKP government did not damage relations with Israel, but rather developed them. But Prime Minister Erdoğan is just as right in showing a strong reaction to the policy of collectively punishing the Palestinians in Gaza by blockading and bombarding them today as he was right in accusing Israel of being a ‘terrorist state’ yesterday.

“The AKP government was also doing the right thing by inviting Hamas representative Khaled Meshaal to Ankara in February 2006. Israeli-Palestinian peace can never be achieved by excluding Hamas. However, neither can Sudan be equated with Palestine, nor can Hassan al-Bashir be equated with Khaled Meshaal. Hamas, which Khaled Meshaal represents, is the legitimate, elected representative of a people under occupation and subjugation, the Palestinians; Hassan al-Bashir is a dictator who seized power through a military coup and oppresses the religious and ethnic minorities in his country. How can the crimes against humanity committed by the al-Bashir government against non-Arab Muslims in Darfur, which caused the deaths of more than 200,000 and made more than 2 million refugees, and which outraged the civilized world including the UN, be ignored?

“Prime Minister Erdoğan’s participation in the Arab League meeting in Khartoum in April 2006 and his claim that ‘assimilation and genocide’ could not happen in Darfur because Islam rejected ‘tribalism and racism’ had nothing humane about it. Looking at the increasingly frequent visits and closer relations with Sudan, what can you say to those who say Ankara is now pursuing a policy of ‘Islamic, Sunni solidarity’? Turkey will of course establish and develop relations with countries with different regimes in line with national interests. But there is certainly a moral limit to this. It was absolutely unnecessary to invite someone like al-Bashir to Ankara.

“I wonder: How can a Turkey that is close to Sudan, which has not signed the UN’s Kyoto Protocol, is not a party to the UN International Criminal Court, and does not implement UN decisions, contemplate being elected to the Security Council, how can it be considered European? I ask: Is the AKP abandoning EU membership? How else can the fact that relations with the EU are not mentioned with a single word in the 60th Government Action Plan be explained?

Is the meeting with Sarkozy and Merkel a move to trip up Turkey's supporters in the EU, a preparation for 'privileged partnership'?" ("Is the AKP abandoning the EU?" *Zaman*, 26.1.2008)

"Why I am not just a 'democrat'"

Yes, I was advocating liberal democracy. But was there not a tension between citizens' fundamental rights and freedoms and democracy in the narrow sense, that is, majority rule? I often felt the need to explain this. As follows:

"In an article I wrote recently, I referred to my political identity as 'liberal social democrat.' Some of my readers said they knew me as a 'social democrat' and asked why I felt the need to add the adjective 'liberal.' The reason is this: As I have stated in many of my articles, I am not just a 'democrat,' but both a 'liberal' and a 'social' democrat. I am a 'liberal democrat' because I believe in democracy limited by individuals' fundamental rights and freedoms as much as in government by the consent of the people, in a libertarian and pluralist society. I am a 'social democrat' because the market economy based on private property, which has great superiority in creating wealth, when left to itself both produces great injustices and causes great damage to the natural environment.

"That is why I am in favor of a 'social market' economy of the kind where equality of opportunity and social justice are ensured and nature is protected through laws enacted by parliament. Undoubtedly, one reason for calling myself a 'liberal social democrat' is also that the term 'social democrat' has been ruined in Turkey, that is, it has come to be used as a label also by those holding Kemalist, secularist-nationalist, and nationalist (national) socialist ideas.

"Some of my friends also ask why I did not sign the statement of academics supporting the constitutional amendment proposal that would allow headscarves at universities. The reason is definitely not that the statement was prepared by 'those close to the AKP.' The removal of other legislation restricting freedoms is of course as important to me as the removal of the headscarf ban at universities. But it is not realistic to expect all steps toward freedom to be taken at the same time. Yes, this constitutional amendment may be a legitimate source of concern in terms of delaying a new and civilian constitution, but there may also be benefit in discussing the new constitution independently of the 'turban issue.' I do not understand at all what harm there could be in the MHP also supporting the constitutional amendment. Every step toward freedom can be taken with different alliances in parliament.

"I did not sign the statement, because my views are not unknown. For years, both in my writings and in the television programs I participate in, I have been saying that the headscarf ban as implemented in Turkey is compatible with neither human rights nor secularism. Secondly, I am not in complete agreement with the text of the statement, because I do not advocate unlimited 'dress freedom' at universities. I do not accept the headscarf-turban distinction; I do not believe that either 'under the chin' or 'GATA bow' is a solution. But it cannot be reasonable to allow attending classes in a black chador that

leaves only the eyes visible, or in a ‘burqa’ that also covers the eyes, or in a bikini or shorts.

“I am neither the kind of ‘democrat’ who advocates that covering should be unconditionally free (because the majority wants it so), nor do I approve of the ‘secularists’ who want covering to be unconditionally banned on the claim that it is contrary to gender equality. Just as I am against the headscarf ban being applied to university students, I also do not approve of it being applied to people’s representatives in parliament and to those receiving public services in public buildings. But I believe that public officials representing the secular state, which does not discriminate between beliefs, and those providing public services wearing religious symbols is incompatible with secularism.

“I approve of the headscarf ban being applied to minor students attending publicly owned primary and secondary schools financed by the taxes of all citizens. However, I have no objection to the ban being lifted from private schools in terms of recognizing freedom of choice. Finally, the protection of the freedom of female students who do not consider covering a religious obligation is as valuable to me as the freedom of those who consider it a religious obligation. In short: I am not just a ‘democrat,’ because ‘democracy’ alone can turn into a dictatorship of the majority; it can result in the stifling of both freedom and secularism.” (*Zaman*, 07.02.2008)

The headscarf ban is a human rights issue

From when I began writing in newspapers, I opposed the headscarf ban applied in schools and public service as a requirement of the Kemalist authoritarian secularism regime. By 2008, I was writing:

“*Radikal* newspaper headlined the result of a TESEV study: ‘If the goal is girls’ education, the turban is really trivial’ (February 7). According to the study, among the factors preventing female students from continuing to university, the headscarf ban comes last and concerned only 1%. That is: If the headscarf ban violates girls’ right to education, this is true for only 1% of them, therefore it is not worth dwelling on… Then *Zaman* newspaper headlined the result of a survey conducted by the Ankethane Research Company: ‘80 percent of society wants the ban lifted’ (February 9). That is: If 80% wants the ban lifted, it should be lifted…

“The message from both headlines misses the essence of the debate about the headscarf ban. Neither supporting the continuation of the headscarf ban because it takes away the right to education of only 1%, nor advocating its lifting because 80% wants it, is compatible with the logic of the libertarian order we want to establish. The question to be asked of those who think like Radikal’s headline is: The penal articles that restrict freedom of thought and expression in Turkey in a way that touches the essence of the right, primarily Article 301 of the Turkish Penal Code, do not concern more than 1% of society. So should these bans continue? The question to be asked of those who think like Zaman’s headline is: The vast majority of society is in favor of the death penalty. Should the death penalty, which violates the most fundamental right, the right to life, be reinstated just because that is the case? Even if the headscarf ban at universities

concerns only 1%, even if 80% is in favor of the ban continuing, it should be lifted, because it violates the fundamental right to education and the fundamental freedom of expression. This ban must end, because it is contrary to human rights.

“Much can be said about the way the lifting of the ban, which has been a major subject of debate for at least ten years, came onto the agenda. It can be said that because the AKP government did not see the strength in itself to lift the headscarf ban in its first term, it had said through Deputy Prime Minister Mehmet Ali Şahin: ‘The number of those who consider it a problem is 1.5 percent. We as the government focused on the problems that the people want to be solved first… Our priority is not the turban but unemployment.’ (NTV, May 23, 2006) For the same reason, Prime Minister Tayyip Erdoğan had also made this comment on a question about Şahin’s statement: ’Let us think of the forest, not a few trees there. If we act based on a few trees, we will make a mistake. Indeed, the results of public opinion surveys are very clear and evident. That is, if we make evaluations looking at these, Turkey will win, not lose…

“It can also be said that the AKP government, which emerged considerably strengthened from the July 22 elections, was preparing to bring the issue onto the agenda with a new constitution. However, the process that began with the Prime Minister’s answer (without thinking where it would lead) to a journalist’s question in Madrid, ‘Even if it were a political symbol…’, gave the MHP the opportunity to wear down the government and do ‘vote harvesting’ in its own way. It can also be said that the poor management of the issue made its resolution difficult; baseless concerns that the AKP government is leading Turkey toward a religious state are being made subjects of political exploitation; the Prime Minister, instead of answering criticisms coolly, is shouting and yelling and thus abetting this exploitation…

“All of this may be true. But just because all of this is true, can the continuation of the ban

be defended? What falls to those who are in favor of freedom is to support the implementation of the constitutional amendment and leaving the ban behind. Encouraging the AKP government to make other reforms in the direction of expanding freedoms and deepening democracy; advancing the struggle for the rights of religious and ethnic minorities and other minority rights (which do not concern more than 1 percent of society) can only be possible in this way. The logic of either all freedoms immediately or none is not logical.” (“The headscarf ban is a human rights issue,” *Zaman*, 16.2.2008)

Fortunately, as a result of libertarian writers preparing public opinion, the CHP also gradually abandoning its strict secularist stance, but above all the AKP government’s determination on this issue, the headscarf ban was gradually lifted. First in 2007 at universities with the instruction sent by the Presidency of YÖK (the Council of Higher Education) to rectorates; it ended in public workplaces in 2013 with the change of the dress code regulation in the public sector. Shortly after this, female AKP deputies began entering the Grand National Assembly with their headscarves. Thankfully, such a ban does not exist today.

“Liberals” and the AKP

In late 2007 and early 2008, commentaries began appearing in the media about the alliance between the AKP and liberal-minded intellectuals breaking down. In those years when I had not yet lost my hope that AKP rule would serve liberalization in Turkey, I explained my view on this matter:

“Haluk Şahin first put forward these views: Liberals in Turkey helped the neo-Islamist AKP express its actually ‘reactionary and archaic’ goals in terms of concepts like democracy, freedom, human rights. They ‘entered into ideological struggle with segments sensitive about secularism and battered them’ and paved the way for the AKP. Thus they gave the AKP, which they enabled to be known in a very different way than it actually is, ‘legitimacy and modernity’ in domestic and foreign public opinion (*Radikal*, September 22-23, 2007). Then, in a long interview based on these theses, he developed his analyses on Turkey’s intellectual and political climate and collected them in a book worth reading and thinking about titled ‘Liberals, Nationalists, Islamists and Others’ (Istanbul: Say Publications, 2008).

“What both this book and recent discussions themed around ‘Liberal-AKP alliance and its breakdown’ made me think can be listed as follows: Some intellectuals who were in authoritarian or totalitarian socialist, nationalist, Islamist, etc. movements in the period between 1960-80, drawing lessons from what was experienced in Turkey and the world, reached the following conclusions: Turkey is an illiberal type of democracy under bureaucratic tutelage. There is no separation of state and religion; secularism is limited to secular laws. Political freedoms, particularly freedom of expression and association, are restricted.

“The state’s official ideology, referred to as ‘Kemalism,’ covers up the country’s historical realities and cultural differences. State-dominated economic policies closed to competition are preventing the country from becoming prosperous. It is not possible for Turkey to cope with its differences and become a rich and just society without establishing a libertarian and pluralist democracy and transitioning to a competition-based market economy. Intellectuals (‘Liberals’) who adopted to some degree the liberal-critical discourse I have briefly summarized from the 1990s onwards, ardently advocated the EU accession process, which they saw as strong external support for liberalization and democratization.

“The said discourse that emerged from the accounting of painful events that have been and are being experienced affected almost all political currents in Turkey to some degree. Turkey’s distinctive Islamist movement, the National Vision Movement, was no exception to this. The influence of liberal-critical discourse also played a major role among the various factors that led to the transition from RP to FP and then the transformation into AKP. So much so that the AKP, while culturally its ‘conservative’ qualities predominated, signed on to a program and practice that was liberal and libertarian in both political and economic terms (at least to a degree Turkey had not seen until now). Not to see the evolution that the Islamist movement has undergone in Turkey,

to declare the AKP 'Islamist with a hidden agenda,' one must either be blind or (like the CHP) hope to reap political gain from it.

"'Liberals' supported all the steps the AKP took toward liberalization, democratization, and prosperity in the context of EU reforms (while also criticizing their inadequacies and contradictions). The bureaucratic, secularist-nationalist, nationalist, and Islamist opposition that rose in parallel with the decline in societal support for the EU, which began to wane with the negative signals coming from the EU from 2005 onwards, undoubtedly weakened the AKP's reformist will and strengthened its tendency to compromise with the established order. As the AKP distances itself from reforms and thus from the EU agenda, it becomes a target of some 'liberals'' critical discourse.

"After the EU largely lost its 'soft power' over Turkey,

and after the political opposition increasingly lost its credibility, the only force that can (unfortunately) encourage the AKP toward reforms is these 'liberals.' But, of course, 'liberals' can have very different perspectives among themselves (on various issues, including the AKP). So much so that some 'liberals' (somehow) equate liberalism with secularism, uniformity, monoculturalism, in short Kemalism, and can declare themselves only 'democrat.'" ("In my view 'Liberals' and the AKP," *Zaman*, 23.2.2008)

Islamism and the AKP

Whether the AKP's ideology was Islamist, and whether it would be more accurate to characterize it as "conservative democrat," was also a subject of debate among political scientists. In an article I wrote directly on this subject, I said:

"We know that circles who want democracy to be destroyed and Turkey to sever its ties with the EU characterize the AKP as 'Islamist,' even 'Islamofascist,' and we laugh it off. However, even in the Western media, which could be expected to be more faithful to reality, those who speak of the AKP as 'Islamist' (even if the adjectives 'moderate, modernist and liberal' are put before it) are still widespread. So what does 'Islamism' mean? Can the AKP be called Islamist? There is benefit in addressing these questions.

"Political Islam or Islamism, by its academic definition, is a modern political ideology produced from Islamic belief that claims to be an alternative to capitalism, communism, and socialism. For example, according to the well-known French expert Olivier Roy, Islamism is 'a political ideology that envisages Islam dominating every aspect of society (politics, law, economy, social justice, foreign policy, etc.).' According to him, the minimum common point of Islamist movements is their desire for religious rules to dominate at least in the field of private law. American expert Graham E. Fuller, in his book titled 'The Future of Political Islam,' has made the broadest definition of Islamism. According to him, Islamists are 'those in the contemporary Islamic world who believe that Islam as a faith has something important to say about how politics and society should be ordered and who seek to implement this idea in some form.'

"If we look from the perspective of definitions, it can be said that the Welfare Party, which was closed in 1998, was a 'moderate Islamist' party because, at least until the

Refahyol government was formed, it advocated the 'Just Economic Order' supposedly as a system different from 'capitalism and socialism'; freedom to be subject to Islamic law (at least in the private sphere) for those who wish; and Islamic unity. The closure of the RP, despite having no connection to violence except for the statements of a few members, was not a situation that could be explained by democratic standards. But RP members did not resort to other means against the decision about them; they appealed to the European Court of Human Rights (ECHR). The ECHR, with a highly debatable decision, approved the party's closure.

"It is quite clear that the AKP cannot be considered Islamist even by the broadest definition. The party program closest to liberal views in Turkey is the AKP's program. Being devout also never means being Islamist. The AKP has both devout and non-devout members. The AKP receives votes from every region of the country and every segment of society. It has never proposed the adoption of Islamic law, even in the private sphere. The AKP has not imposed a covering requirement on anyone; it made the constitutional amendment toward lifting the headscarf ban in universities that was contrary to human rights, with the encouragement and support of the MHP. It wants an end to discrimination not only against graduates of imam-hatip schools (opened and supervised by the state) but against all vocational high school graduates in university admission. Although not always consistent on this matter, it advocates that the state treat all religious beliefs equally.

"AKP governments have been in favor of close political and economic relations not only with Islamic countries but with all countries, specifically with Western countries, including the USA and Israel, and have made reforms that opened the way for Turkey to join the EU. The points that those who claim the AKP is 'Islamist' fail to understand are these: The cadres who founded the AKP abandoned Islamism, because they saw that Islamism would never be adopted by the majority of the Turkish people and that it was not a way out for Turkey either.

"The pressures they were subjected to taught them not to hide their agenda, but the importance of political freedom. That is why the AKP, compared to other parties, has a more libertarian, more democratic, and more secular identity. Turkey's flawed democracy has made it possible for the Islamist movement to gradually moderate and finally transcend Islamism. Turkey is the star of the Islamic world essentially in this sense. It is not possible to understand Turkey without understanding these things." (*Zaman*, 5.4.2008)

After the years that have passed, when I ask whether this assessment still holds, my answer is roughly this: By Olivier Roy's narrow definition, calling the AKP Islamist still does not capture reality in my opinion. But if we define Islamism very broadly like Graham E. Fuller, calling the AKP Islamist is possible. My preferred characterization for the AKP today would be 'Islamic populist.'

"What is being done to the AKP fits neither law nor ethics"

Court of Cassation Chief Public Prosecutor Abdurrahman Yalçınkaya applied to the Constitutional Court on March 14, 2008, requesting the closure of the AKP on the

grounds that it had “become a center of actions contrary to secularism” and a 5-year ban from politics for 71 party members including Prime Minister Recep Tayyip Erdoğan and President Abdullah Gül. The Constitutional Court accepted the said indictment on March 31, 2008. Turkey was referred to as a “graveyard of parties” due to the multitude of closed parties, but this was the first time a closure case was opened against a party in power, one that had received approximately half of the voters’ votes. I strongly opposed the attempt to close the AKP. The article I will quote below, after listing the practices of AKP rule that I found positive and negative, reflected my view that the former considerably outweighed the latter.

“I did not vote for the Justice and Development Party (AKP) in either the 2002 or 2007 elections. I will not call it ‘AK Party’ without being convinced that it is truly a ‘clean party’ and not tainted by corruption. There are many aspects of AKP rule that I do not approve of and criticize. I see its inability to escape its identity as a ‘Sunni Party’ as its biggest mistake. I find its constant zigzagging on the Kurdish issue, its taking a stance sometimes for freedom, sometimes for bans and oppression, grave.

I find its almost complete lack of sensitivity on environmental issues shameful. I see the AKP as tending to capture the established order rather than change it. In this context, I think it is doing very wrong by bringing its own members or close associates to important public positions (including the Presidency) instead of people the whole society can trust. (…)

“However, despite all my criticisms, I see the AKP as a great success of our flawed democracy. The AKP is an example that where political competition is legitimate, an Islamist movement can transform into a center party committed to democracy and secularism. The AKP’s leading cadre, by drawing lessons from experiences and seeing that Islamism was not a way out, succeeded in renewing itself. That is why I have great admiration for this cadre (to whom I personally have no closeness). AKP rule, by adhering to the IMF-supported economic stability program and the route drawn by the EU accession process, achieved a ‘silent revolution’ in both the economy and democracy, at least until 2005.

“I have not the slightest doubt that today’s Turkey is a more prosperous and freer country than pre-AKP. That is why the AKP managed to increase its vote from 34% in 2002 to 40% in 2004 and to 47% in 2007. Today the AKP is the center party that has the trust of the vast majority of the Turkish people including Kurds and is the guarantor of the country’s integrity. What is being done to this AKP fits neither law nor political ethics. The clique at the head of the CHP, by spreading delusions that secularism is being lost, is calculating to come to power at the cost of crushing democracy. (…)

“In 2003 and 2004, two military coup attempts were made. In 2006, they tried to place the responsibility for the Council of State attack in which a judge was killed on the government. Last April, the people were provoked against the government with rallies organized by coup supporters. On April 27, 2007, the Constitutional Court was put under pressure by posting a statement on the General Staff’s website meaning ‘If Gül’s election as President is not prevented, there will be a military coup.’ Now, with an indictment that has no legal merit, they want to close the AKP… The only hope is that

the Constitutional Court, saving its own and the country's reputation, puts a stop to this." (*Zaman*, 15.4.2008)

As is known, the Constitutional Court, in its decision announced on July 30, 2008, reached by a margin of one vote, would rule not for the closure of the AKP but for halving the treasury aid it would receive.

"The '68 generation forty years later"

The 40th anniversary of the '68 events had also been an occasion for me to look back at my own past. I wrote:

"It was not easy in Turkey's busy agenda, but from what was written and said about the '68 generation, from television series and debates, I finally realized that exactly forty years have passed since 1968, the year of 'youth uprisings' all over the world… I am also from the '68 generation. I contributed more to the discourse than to the actions of that generation. I either knew or was friends with almost all of the youth leaders belonging to the '68 generation. I always remember with respect and sorrow those who are no longer among us because they were killed.

"Were there not among us police agents from the beginning or later, mentally ill people

or those lacking character? Today we can identify them better… But the overwhelming majority of us, with great moral idealism, had committed to a political ideal: We believed that we could turn Turkey into paradise with a 'revolution' that would happen one way or another. Unfortunately, we were not aware that the authoritarian and totalitarian ideologies that set us against each other, the paths we took, those who wanted to use us in the power struggle, were taking us in the exact opposite direction of the ideals of equality and freedom we shared. Unfortunately, the power holders of the established order were also too bigoted and ruthless to see that we were young and in need of understanding.

"The vast majority of those from the '68 generation who managed to survive and look critically at what happened, some after a short time, some after a long time but definitely, saw the wrongness of the ideas they had committed to and the paths they had taken. If I can find time from my work and my life allows, I want to write the view of the '68 generation from my own window… To be honest, until now, few of those who should really write have written about the experiences of the period that ended with the 1971 military intervention. The most important of what has been written is undoubtedly Hasan Cemal's book, which tells the story of the March 9 junta attempt (for some reason ignored in March 12 documentaries and in television series about March 12) by those seeking to bring Turkey a Baath

(Iraq, Syria)-type regime. *I Wrote Myself, Let No One Be Angry* (1999) also sheds light on understanding the anti-democracy putschist tradition that has made itself felt again in recent years.

"One of my contributions to understanding the 'youth uprising' that occurred in Turkey in 1968 is the article titled 'An Essay on the '68 Generation' published in issue 41 of

Toplum ve Bilim journal twenty years ago, on the twentieth anniversary. When I read this article today, twenty years later, which I later learned caused a storm in the journal's editorial board between those who wanted it published and those who wanted it rejected, I see that some of the findings here no longer have much validity. My main concern when writing this article in 1988 was, as someone who (unfortunately) contributed to the spread of these views in Turkey 20 years ago, to settle accounts with Marxism and Marxism-Leninism and to explain why I completely abandoned these views. Since what happened in both the world and Turkey in the years after this article was written has made both Marxism-Leninism and Marxism museum pieces, what I said in this context may no longer have much value.

"But there are findings in the article that I think are still meaningful. The conclusion reached in this context is noteworthy: 'In my opinion, what has been experienced in the last twenty years has taught the '68 generation the indispensable value of fundamental rights and freedoms, individual rights, especially freedom of thought. The '68 generation had turned its back on pluralist democracy that guarantees the individual's fundamental rights and freedoms in 1968. Today, however, those most wholeheartedly committed to fundamental rights and freedoms are in my opinion largely them.' Looking at what happened in China governed by Deng Xiaoping, in the Soviet Union led by Mikhail Gorbachev, and throughout the world, the article may also be found noteworthy in terms of predicting the dissolution and collapse of 'real socialism' that would begin just one year later, in 1989." (*Zaman*, 12.4.2008)

"Kemalism must be reinterpreted"

One of the themes I frequently addressed in my writings and speeches was that Kemalism needed to be reinterpreted. I grounded this claim as follows:

"(…) It must now be understood: The oppressive understanding of secularism developed approximately a hundred years ago, under an authoritarian single-party rule, in accordance with the understanding of modernity of that time, definitely contradicts the needs of Turkey at the beginning of the 21st century, which is socio-economically much more developed, much more differentiated, has nearly 60 years of democratic experience behind it (albeit frequently interrupted by military interventions, incomplete and flawed), and is conducting EU accession negotiations.

"The oppressive understanding of secularism aimed at imprisoning religious beliefs in consciences cannot be sustained in today's Turkey, let alone within democracy, even under a military dictatorship. Religious beliefs do not disappear with modernization; they continue to exist in harmony with modernity. Therefore, the liberalization of oppressive secularism; the removal of restrictions on the freedom of belief of Sunnis, Alevis, non-Muslims, those who believe in no religion, everyone, is now on Turkey's agenda. Those who cannot see this and insist on the oppressive understanding of secularism are causing very, very great harm to Turkey by leading society toward polarization.

"The Islamist movement in Turkey succeeded in leaving Islamism behind and reconciling with both democracy and secularism. For democracy to be established in Turkey, radical secularists must also reinterpret Kemalism according to Atatürk's legacy pointing to

contemporary civilization and the needs of contemporary Turkey, thus reconciling with democracy and tearing down the walls between them and the people." (*Zaman*, 17.6.2008)

"Why shouldn't the military interfere in politics?"

From the late 1990s onwards, the existence of a secret armed organization called Ergenekon was claimed in Turkey. Prosecutors alleged that this organization (the "deep state"), organized within the state's security forces and consisting of soldiers, police, journalists, and academics, made plans to overthrow the AKP government in 2003-2004; that it organized the Council of State attack in 2006 in which a high judge was killed, and the Zirve Publishing House attack in Malatya in 2007 in which three Christians were killed. However, in the Ergenekon case with 235 defendants, all defendants were acquitted of charges of 'establishing an armed organization, managing it, membership, aiding and abetting' by the Court of Cassation's decision on April 21, 2016… In the early days when the Ergenekon investigations first came to the agenda, I interpreted the subject as follows:

"What we have experienced in recent weeks—reports leaked to the press about how the military would shape politics in Turkey and other matters, court decisions, some trampling the rule of law and others raising hope for its establishment, progress made in the Ergenekon gang investigation, and other signs—raise this question in our minds: Is there perhaps a struggle within state institutions in Turkey between those who support democracy and the rule of law and those who oppose it? I do not possess information to answer this question. But if this is the case, I certainly hope that democracy and the rule of law emerge victorious from this struggle.

"What I know is this: Since April 27, 2007, we have entered a very concerning political struggle. In this process, the Turkish Armed Forces, the guarantor of Turkey's internal and external security, unfortunately appears as a party to the political struggle, almost like a political party. In the 8th year of the 21st century, unfortunately there is no consensus in Turkey—neither among elites nor in public opinion—that problems can only be solved within a democratic order based on the rule of law, and that keeping the military out of politics is one of the most fundamental conditions of this order. In this environment, we must persistently continue to explain that secularism and national unity can only be secured in a state based on human rights and the rule of law, and that military involvement in politics, even for these purposes, carries great dangers.

"All human experience shows that only countries with liberal democratic regimes can succeed in diagnosing and solving their problems; can earn the loyalty of their citizens; can have stronger economies and therefore stronger armies and security. Is the Soviet Union not the greatest example of this? Did it not turn out that the USSR, considered a superpower throughout the Cold War, was ultimately a 'paper tiger'? Because there was no freedom, it could neither develop economically nor escape disintegration despite its enormous military power.

"Strong armies, like strong societies and economies, can only exist in democratic regimes… One of the most fundamental principles of democratic societies is the

separation of the military from politics… Armies are built on principles of hierarchy, discipline, and absolute obedience due to the nature of their duties—that is, on principles that are the exact opposite of democracy. The principles and requirements of military service are incompatible with the principles and requirements of democratic society… If the army becomes a party to politics, it cannot properly fulfill its duties, and the country's internal and external security weakens… If it takes sides in politics, it becomes inevitable that the army will be used by politicians against each other, that its reputation and prestige in the eyes of the people will be eroded, and much worse, that it will become a scene of internal divisions and conflicts… We are one of the societies that has best seen and experienced the consequences of this for national security.

"For soldiers to properly fulfill their duties in democratic societies: 1) The army must be subject to the authority of civilian administrators who are democratically elected and accountable to the people. 2) Even defense policies must be determined by civilians. The authority of soldiers even in this area is limited to making recommendations and taking responsibility for implementation. 3) Regardless of which party is in power, the army must be loyally bound to the government that comes to power through elections, by the people's vote. 4) Like all citizens, soldiers must also receive education in liberal and pluralist democracy in their schools. We must establish these fundamental principles of democratic society irreversibly." (*Zaman*, 3.7.2008)

"Is the AKP government at the beginning of the end?"

It was in late 2008 that I first began questioning in my own mind where the AKP government was taking Turkey. After examining how Turkey-EU relations had evolved in recent years, I was trying to answer the question 'Is the AKP government at the beginning of the end?':

"Is the AKP government at the beginning of the end?.. Recently I have been frequently confronted with this question, especially from foreign colleagues. I tell them that to answer this question, one must compare the conjuncture of the 2002-2004 period, when the AKP government led reforms referred to as a 'Silent Revolution,' with what came after. In the 2002-2004 period, the main opposition party CHP was saying 'yes' to EU harmonization laws. The majority of the media, including the Doğan Group, and the educated classes approved of the reforms. Public support for EU membership was reaching 75 percent. The Chief of General Staff was Hilmi Özkök, who viewed the reforms favorably. Those seeking a coup could not find the support they sought in the army. The PKK was maintaining the ceasefire it declared in 1999. The EU, including France and Germany, was encouraging the reforms.

"In May 2004, ten new members join the EU, including the Greek Cypriot Administration (which had said 'no' to the Annan Plan for a solution on the island a month earlier). In the summer months, the PKK ends the ceasefire. During the referendums on the EU constitution draft in the summer of 2005, voices begin to rise in Europe against enlargement in general and Turkey's membership in particular. Angela Merkel, who will assume the German chancellorship in November, is proposing 'privileged partnership' to Turkey. Nicolas Sarkozy, who will be elected president in France in May 2007, is saying

‘there is no place for Turkey in the EU.’ Nevertheless, in October 2005, the decision to begin accession negotiations comes from the EU. However, the adopted Negotiating Framework does not guarantee membership even if negotiations are successfully completed. The AKP government’s enthusiasm is dampened.

“From the beginning of 2006, public support for EU membership in Turkey begins to decline and gradually falls below 50 percent. After the Council of State attack in May 2006, the political atmosphere becomes murky. The struggle for the presidential election has begun. In April 2007, ‘Republic rallies’ are organized against Abdullah Gül’s candidacy (by defendants in the Ergenekon case). The CHP virtually declares the AKP an ‘enemy,’ opposing Gül’s election and all reforms. The General Staff publishes a ‘memorandum’ against Gül’s candidacy on its website. The Constitutional Court blocks Gül’s election. The AKP calls early general elections, wins by a wide margin, and elects Gül as President. Tension between state elites and the AKP continues.

“The Doğan Group goes into opposition, claiming that secularism is being violated (or for other reasons). The MHP begins to apply tactics to pit the government against state elites. The PKK escalates its attacks. The DTP increasingly follows in the PKK’s footsteps. The Bush administration does not lift a finger against the PKK until November 2007. The neoconservative gang in Washington intensifies its campaign against the AKP. Sarkozy adds 4 more chapters to the 8 chapters suspended due to Ankara’s not including Southern Cyprus in the customs union. Negotiations proceed at a snail’s pace. The Ergenekon gang’s preparations for a coup against the government in 2009 are revealed. The Chief Prosecutor files a closure case against the AKP. The AKP narrowly escapes being closed, but the Constitutional Court declares juristocracy (rule by judges). The CHP expands corruption allegations against the AKP. Economic crisis is at the door.

“The AKP has received the votes of half of the electorate, but it is besieged from within and without. Under these conditions, there are essentially two paths it can take: to embrace reforms by trusting the voters and its supporters in the EU, or to surrender to the status quo and continue to benefit from the advantages of power. Because the first is very risky, it chooses the second. This time, it also alienates the circles that supported the AKP as long as it was making reforms. Let’s say this much is understandable… But how can we explain AKP spokespeople, especially Erdoğan, increasingly embracing MHP rhetoric? Perhaps with the calculation that this will win votes… In my view, a wrong calculation. If it persists in this attitude, if it avoids reforms, the AKP government may be at the beginning of the end.” (*Zaman*, 18.11.2008)

Yes, a political observer can only be this wrong!.. Fifteen years after these lines were written, the AKP was still in power and when it would leave was still unknown.

“Why am I ‘apologizing’?”

In mid-December 2008, a declaration stating *“My conscience does not accept the insensitivity to the Great Catastrophe that Ottoman Armenians were subjected to in 1915, or its denial. I reject this injustice, and for my part, I share the feelings and pain of my Armenian brothers and sisters, and I apologize to them”* was announced to the public

with numerous signatures. I was one of the first to sign the declaration. I explained my reasoning as follows:

“I avoid signing texts written by others, because as a commentator, I have the opportunity to express my views on subjects I consider myself competent in. But I signed this text without deliberating over its wording. Why? Why am I apologizing to our Armenian brothers and sisters? During the dissolution of the Ottoman Empire, all the peoples involved faced great tragedies. Among these, what happened to the Armenians has a special place. I do not think that the catastrophe that befell the Ottoman Armenians in 1915 was a genocide of the kind claimed by some Armenian nationalists, comparable to what Jews were subjected to in Germany. Armenian nationalists collaborated with Russia to separate from the Ottoman Empire and establish an independent Armenian state, engaged in terrorist acts, and killed many Turks and Muslims. In response, the Ottoman government, or rather an inner clique within it led by Talat Pasha, decided and implemented the deportation of all Armenians living mainly outside Istanbul and Izmir to the Syrian desert, that is, their forced migration.

“Approximately half of the roughly 1.5 million Ottoman Armenians subjected to deportation lost their lives during the migration—some from attacks by members of security forces and bandits who coveted their property, some from epidemic diseases and starvation. Some survived by being protected by Turks and Muslims and converting to Islam. The rest migrated to the West, primarily to France and the USA. Armenians who served in the Ottoman army found upon returning from the war that no one from their families and communities remained, and that their property had been confiscated.

“Armenian nationalists claim that the Ottoman government’s intention with the deportation was the wholesale destruction of Armenians, similar to what the Nazis did to the Jews. This claim has not been proven. Respected non-Turkish Ottoman historians do not support this claim either. However, there is no debate about the fact that the Ottoman government collectively punished all Armenians for the crimes committed by Armenian nationalists. Today in Turkey, we have knowledge about all the tragedies that occurred during the dissolution of the Ottoman Empire. The catastrophes that befell Turks and Muslims who were expelled from the Balkans and massacred, who were killed by Armenian insurgents in the northeastern provinces, and Muslims who were expelled from Russia in the mid-19th century are all known and freely discussed. But the tragedy that befell the Ottoman Armenians is covered up and cannot be freely discussed. The responsibility for this tragedy lies neither with the Turks nor with the governments of the Turkish Republic; it lies with the Committee of Union and Progress dictators who led the Ottoman state to ruin.

“Of course, I have no personal responsibility for what happened to the Ottoman Armenians. But as a human being and a Turk, I feel great sorrow for a tragedy that occurred in my homeland and has been covered up and made taboo by the state. The primary reason for signing the declaration is a moral obligation arising from this. Secondly, I want Turkey to strengthen its democracy, and for no subject to remain undiscussed and unilluminated so that evils are not repeated. Thirdly, as Turks and Armenians who lived in friendship for centuries until the age of nationalisms, I value the

re-establishment of friendship between Turkey and Armenia. I believe that as Turkey confronts its history, Armenia and the Armenian diaspora will also confront theirs. The signs are already visible: voices are rising saying 'We cannot debate as freely as Turkey… We too should apologize for the killed Turks and Muslims… Let Armenian archives be opened…'" (*Zaman*, 23.12.2008)

"Science is science, and faith is faith"

In the days following UNESCO's declaration of 2009 as Darwin Year, the "turmoil" that occurred at the *TÜBİTAK* magazine provided an occasion to express my views on the relationship between science and religion. I wrote as follows:

"Reports in some newspapers about the March issue of the 'Science and Technology' magazine published by the Scientific and Technological Research Council of Turkey (TÜBİTAK) were as follows: Because 2009 was declared 'Darwin Year' by UNESCO, the magazine first made Charles Darwin and the theory of evolution its cover story. But at the last moment, with an intervention from senior management, the cover story was changed, a 16-page dossier was removed from the magazine, and editor Dr. Çiğdem Atakuman was dismissed. State Minister Prof. Dr. Mehmet Aydın, responsible for TÜBİTAK, said the following in response to these reports: 'TÜBİTAK exists to open all doors to science, not to censor science… No one's purpose can be to approach science from an ideological perspective or to approach science from a religious perspective. Science is science, faith is faith. As long as these proceed in their own lanes, they are beneficial to each other.' (…)

"Minister Mehmet Aydın has essentially said what needed to be said about the incident. Nevertheless, there are two aspects of the incident that need to be addressed. The first is that disrespect and intolerance toward different ideas, understandings, and beliefs—regardless of the justification (except for those advocating violence)—is in no way acceptable. The second is the importance of the incident in terms of properly understanding the relationship between religion and science, and criticizing the bigotries that view religion as hostile to science and science as hostile to religion. On this occasion, both religious bigots and science bigots should be reminded of the following:

"The domains of religion and science are different. Religion is a body of beliefs that responds to the spiritual and moral needs of human beings. Science, on the other hand, is the effort to understand and explain oneself and the universe one lives in, based on human reason and logic. Viewing religion and science as rivals, and efforts to substitute one for the other, have caused great disasters for humanity. The Inquisition, Communism, and Nazism are just the best-known examples of this. Civilization, on the other hand, has developed through religion and science showing respect to each other.

According to the understanding of science that prevails among scientists today, science consists of theories that are valid until proven otherwise; it advances by replacing theories shown to be wrong with new theories; and as science advances, it becomes apparent how little we know about the universe.

“Ideas that science is capable of explaining everything, that science will replace religion, are not accepted. On the other hand, dogmatic interpretations claiming that religion is capable of explaining everything are also becoming increasingly marginalized. Interpretations of religions that are at peace with values and institutions developed and adopted as a product of humanity’s centuries of experience (human rights, democracy, separation of religion and state, rule of law, science) and compatible with modern life maintain their vitality; fundamentalist interpretations are increasingly standing against civilization. It is also certain that the majority of scientists do not see a contradiction between religion and science; they both pray and continue their research. Just like other people who both pray and do not neglect to go to the doctor when fighting disease.” (*Zaman*, 14.3.2009)

“Time to abandon weapons”

By 2009, I thought an opportunity had been seized to solve the Kurdish problem. That this was another of my errors would soon become apparent, but the arguments I relied on were as follows:

“In some of my writings and speeches, I put forward this view: If the PKK had not appeared on the scene or if the path of armed struggle had not been taken, Turkey’s Kurdish problem could have been solved without so much bloodshed and without so much suffering. The two basic assumptions underlying this view are as follows:

Firstly, despite all its deficiencies and flaws and being under bureaucratic tutelage, the existing democracy in Turkey would have made it possible to seek rights without resorting to violence. Indeed, during periods when PKK attacks stopped, democratic openings on the Kurdish issue became possible. Secondly, the PKK’s policy of violence laid the groundwork for demands related to Kurdish identity to be identified with violence and suppressed with violence. This is the main reason why many Kurdish politicians and intellectuals believe that the PKK was used by the state to delegitimize the Kurds’ rightful struggle, and even that the PKK is a curse brought upon us by the ‘deep state.’

“The opposing view, as is known, is that the PKK put the Kurdish problem on Turkey’s agenda, and that without the PKK, there would have been no awareness of the problem. Then the question to ask becomes this: To advocate that Kurds also live in Turkey and have the right to freely live their language and culture, one would certainly have had to take some risks, but would the bloodshed and suffering have been this great? Such a debate may have no meaning in retrospect. But it has meaning for the future. Namely:

“At the point reached today, neither the PKK nor the state is in the position it was at the beginning of the 1980s. The PKK has moved far from its original goal when it emerged—an independent Marxist-Leninist Kurdish state that would gather all Kurds under a single flag. It has abandoned Marxism-Leninism as well as the goal of an independent state. Unlike some other Kurdish parties, it is not pursuing federalism either. It is quite clear that the PKK has become aware that there can be no solution through arms. What Murat Karayılan told Hasan Cemal is very clear: Kurds freely living their language and culture, and strengthening local governments not only for the Kurdish-majority region but nationwide. For this to happen, weapons must first be silenced and then abandoned. For

this, the government must talk with the DTP, or if not, with 'wise men.' Turkey is also not the Turkey of September 12.

"Despite many obstacles and restrictions in practice, the ban on Kurdish was lifted in 1991. Kurdish newspapers, magazines, and books became free. Between 2002-2004, Kurdish names, learning Kurdish, and radio-television broadcasting in Kurdish became free. Since 1991, parties began to be established that put the Kurdish issue at the center of their program. Although they were closed one by one, they began to come to power in local governments from 1999 and entered parliament in 2007. Even the military is declaring that it is not against identity rights at the individual level and is giving the green light to amnesty for PKK militants.

"What has essentially changed is the world: In the world and Turkey of the 1960s and 70s, the idea that Marxism-Leninism was the guide to building a free and just world, and that armed revolution was the only method, was widespread. Since then, it was first understood that Marxism-Leninism promised nothing but a totalitarian dictatorship. Then it was gradually understood that violence is barbarism; that it breeds violence; that it is impossible to get anywhere with violence; and the ideals of freedom, human rights, democracy, and peace became dominant.

"For all these reasons, there is a real opportunity to remove violence from Turkey's agenda. To do this, one must of course talk with the legitimate representatives of Turkey's Kurds, with Kurdish MPs from the DTP and other parties in parliament. All democratic countries that have had to deal with separatist movements resorting to terrorism—Spain, Britain, France—have succeeded in at least marginalizing separatism and violence by expanding democracy and freedoms. Turkey can succeed too. Because it is time to abandon weapons." (*Zaman*, 14.5.2009)

"Action Plan to Combat Reactionism"

The *Taraf* newspaper, in its headline story on June 12, 2009, wrote that a "briefing document" allegedly prepared by the Information Support Department of the Turkish Armed Forces General Staff, signed by Colonel Dursun Çiçek, contained plans aimed at destroying the AKP and the Fethullah Gülen community. For this purpose, an "Anti-Reactionism Unit" had been established within the General Staff. Following *Taraf*'s report, the General Staff ordered an investigation of the matter. The military prosecutor's office, in the investigation it launched the same day, announced that "when the evidence obtained so far is evaluated, an opinion has been reached that the document alleged to have been seized was not prepared in any unit of the General Staff" and decided there were no grounds for prosecution.

However, a debate had begun about whether there was an organization within the TAF referred to as the "Ergenekon Terror Organization" preparing a coup against the elected government. When writing about this in 2009, in light of what I knew about the history of civil-military relations in Turkey, I said:

"With the legislative changes adopted by the Grand National Assembly and approved by President Abdullah Gül, Turkey accepted the principle that civilians be tried in civilian

courts under all circumstances, and that soldiers who commit civilian crimes also be tried in civilian courts.

Thus, another step was taken toward normalizing civil-military relations.

The CHP, which is becoming increasingly determined in favor of the continuation of bureaucratic-military tutelage over democracy, is taking the legislative changes to the Constitutional Court. It is likely that the Constitutional Court will annul the legislative changes, finding them contrary to Article 145 of the Constitution. On the other hand, it is certain that the legal changes needed to establish civilian democratic oversight of the military do not end here, and that a fundamental change in mentality is needed among both soldiers and civilians to make the military subordinate to civilian authority.

“Nevertheless, with the ongoing Ergenekon Terror Organization case, in which those accused of creating conditions for a military coup against the legitimate government have reached the 3rd indictment stage regarding coup plots, with more than a dozen active-duty officers detained within the scope of this case, and with civilian prosecutors continuing to investigate the ‘Action Plan to Combat Reactionism,’ it can be said that expectations for democratic principles to prevail in civil-military relations in Turkey are strengthening.

“In the summer of 2009, it can be said that there are two basic theories about the future of civil-military relations in Turkey. According to the pessimistic theory, as long as the mentality that the soldier is the owner of the state and the country remains widespread among bureaucratic elites and a considerable portion of voters share this view, the political role of the military will continue. Indeed, according to a recent public opinion survey, the proportion of voters who agree with the view that ‘country problems should sometimes be solved by a military regime instead of elected politicians’ is not less than about a quarter. (See: *Understanding the New Turkey*, Konda, November 2007).

“According to the optimistic theory, the idea that the military’s involvement in politics has resulted in neglecting its primary duties and that problems have become completely intractable is spreading not only among civilians but also among soldiers. The Ergenekon case indicates that the TAF will no longer turn a blind eye to coup plotters within its ranks. Chief of General Staff İlker Başbuğ’s statements on various occasions that ‘personnel who are not committed to the principles of democracy and the rule of law cannot remain in the TAF’ is also an expression of this.

“One of the main references for those closer to the second theory is certainly the words of General Hilmi Özkök, one of the former Chiefs of General Staff, who is also known to have supported EU reforms in the 2003-2004 period and prevented coup attempts: ‘The intellectual level achieved by TAF personnel, the evolution in communication technology, the stage reached in democracy, developments in political, economic, and other national power elements, the Republic of Turkey’s increasing participation in international institutions and organizations, the increase and development in civil society organizations and other civilian power elements, and developments in techniques for drawing lessons from previous events have closed the era of coups. In the near future,

Turkey will be a country where every job is done by those who should do it. In my opinion, the people have proven their maturity.' (*Hürriyet*, March 21, 2009)

"It can be said that the truth lies somewhere between these two theories. The era of interventions of the 1960, 1971, 1980, or even 1997 type may have ended. The TAF may henceforth purge 'personnel who are not committed to the principles of democracy and the rule of law' from its ranks. It may even be that only Chiefs of General Staff can serve as the military's spokesperson from now on. But as long as the military believes it represents the national interest and continues to protect its privileges, the end of the military's political role should not be expected." ("Coups and the military's political role," *Zaman*, July 14, 2009)

What the AKP is and is not

In the debates over whether the AKP—in its eighth year since its founding and seventh year in power—was Islamist, conservative democrat, or what kind of party it was, the view that I also shared at the time (quoted above) was most competently presented in the book titled *Islamism, Democracy and Liberalism in Turkey: The Case of the AKP* (*Routledge, 2009)*, co-authored by the distinguished constitutional law scholar Ergun Özbudun and William Hale, one of the leading political historians of Turkey. (Turkish translation: *Türkiye'de İslamcılık, Demokrasi ve Liberalizm: AKP Olayı / Doğan Kitap, 2010)* I made the following assessment about the book, which I had the opportunity to read before its publication:

"The Justice and Development Party (AKP) celebrated its 8th founding anniversary on August 14. In terms of coming to power the year after its founding and spending seven of its eight years in power, the AKP is probably a party with a world record. In one sense, the AKP is of course not just eight years old; as one of the parties born of the National Vision Movement, it has a history of about 40 years. But in another sense, the AKP is really eight years old, because it has little resemblance to the National Vision parties that came before it.

"There is various hearsay about the nature of the AKP. It defines itself as 'Conservative Democrat.' But if you ask not only authoritarian secularists in Turkey, but also analysts working at research institutions closely connected with neocons in the US (and therefore the Israel lobby), and even Northern European 'Kemalists,' the AKP is an Islamist party that is Iranizing or Malaysianizing Turkey. According to AKP opponents who find this excessive and want to appear more reasonable, Erdoğan is the 'Turkish Putin' and the AKP is taking Turkey toward a Russia-type democracy. Of course, there are also those who think the exact opposite. According to them, Erdoğan is the greatest reformer after Atatürk and Özal; the AKP is taking Turkey toward a European-standard democracy and economy, even if it is not ultimately admitted to the EU.

"Academic studies as well as junk and propaganda books about the AKP are proliferating. The most noteworthy of these studies, in my opinion, is being published on September 17 by Britain's Routledge Publishers. Its authors are two professors well known to the public. One is Ergun Özbudun, the dean of Turkey's constitutional law and political science fields. The other is William Hale, known for his publications on the

military and foreign policy in Turkey. I think the identity of the authors is sufficient guarantee of the book's quality. The main conclusions of the book, whose writing was completed at the beginning of the year and which I had the privilege of reading before publication, are as follows:

"'It is possible to characterize the AKP as the Muslim equivalent of conservative parties in Western democracies. While adopting faith-based values on social, cultural, and perhaps economic issues, it rejects the idea of establishing an Islamic state whose laws and processes are incompatible with basic democratic values… In his approach to the Kurdish issue, Tayyip Erdoğan made some important goodwill gestures that went far beyond previous governments in officially recognizing Kurdish identity. However, the AKP failed to produce and pursue a consistent policy that would protect the country's territorial integrity while meeting the legitimate demands of the Kurds. Similarly, in its stance toward the modest demands of Turkish Alevis, the AKP government preferred to implement an 'avoidance policy' rather than taking concrete measures…

"The AKP made other mistakes in public policy, but none of them have anything to do with Islamism… The claim that the AKP government has a secret plan to destroy democratic governance and establish an Islamic state in its place is not convincing… Far from undermining democracy, the AKP has worked harder to expand fundamental rights and freedoms than all the governments established since 1960… It is observed that economic factors are much more important than religious factors in explaining the votes it receives…

"At the beginning of 2009, after 6 years in power, it appears that the AKP is being forced to choose between continuing to act as a liberal and reformist force and making peace with conservative state elites. Although concerns that it will turn Turkey into an Islamist autocracy are still widespread among members of the CHP, the TAF, and the judiciary, the possibility that the AKP, by reaching a compromise with its opponents to avoid being subjected to a closure case again, like the center-right parties before it, will not slide toward authoritarianism and inward-looking nationalist attitudes seems more realistic.' Don't the developments since Özbudun and Hale put the finishing touches on their book give the impression that the AKP has not exhausted its reformist energy?" (*Zaman*, 25.08.2009)

It is clearly visible that when I wrote these lines I was unfortunately badly mistaken, and had no concern that the AKP government could slide into Islamist populist authoritarianism.

"Conspiracy theories are poisoning minds"

Since the years when I started writing for *Cumhuriyet*, one topic I occasionally had to address in my writings was the prevalence of conspiracy theories that poison people's minds in Turkey. The *National Unity and Brotherhood Project* that the AKP government launched in 2009 to solve the Kurdish problem was also met with conspiracy theories. I, on the other hand, saw this as an opportunity to end the Kurdish rebellion. As follows:

“The leaders of the MHP and CHP say that the ‘democratization/Kurdish opening’ that the government says it will lead and has been making contacts about is an evil that will lead the people to division and the country to partition, and that behind this evil (‘treason plan’) is the US and the EU. According to the leader of the closed RP, Necmettin Erbakan, the initiative is part of the ‘Haim Nahum Doctrine,’ that is, the Zionists’ plan to ‘make Turkey a province of Israel.’ MHP Deputy Group Chairman Mehmet Şandır also wholeheartedly agrees with this interpretation. There is common ground that brings together the CHP, MHP, and former RP leaders. This ground is that their minds operate not from the analysis of objective facts, but from conspiracy theories, which Karl Popper described as ‘secularized forms of religious superstition.’ The diagnosis and exposure of conspiracy theories is of vital importance for establishing scientific thinking habits in our country.

“Seventeen years ago, based on MÇP leader Alparslan Türkeş’s statement that ‘The events happening in our homeland are monstrous activities organized by imperialism. Terrorists are the lackeys of imperialism…,’ I wrote: ‘Behind the understanding that explains everything with imperialism lies the ’theory’ that philosopher Karl Popper called ‘the conspiracy theory of society.’ According to this theory, widely believed in our country and other countries where scientific thought is not well developed, social events are the work of some powerful centers that benefit from them… According to some, it is the work of imperialists or communists, according to others, Zionists or missionaries. Hasn’t the time come to set aside these superstitions that are completely irrational and unscientific?’ (*Cumhuriyet*, 15.02.1992)

“Apparently not… Today the same minds are trying to present the government’s search for a solution to the Kurdish problem as the US’s, EU’s, Israel’s plan/conspiracy to divide and partition Turkey. Let us no longer deceive ourselves: The Kurdish problem was not created by imperialists, Zionists, or others; we created it ourselves by ignoring the Kurds with an outdated understanding of modernity and attempting to Turkify them. Because we insisted on this wrong policy, some Kurds rebelled; the PKK rebellion is the latest of these. And yes, now there is an opportunity to end this rebellion.

“Because: 1) The militarists on both sides have understood that they cannot solve the problem with violence. 2) The government in Ankara has grasped that identity policies that ignore the Kurds are unsustainable. 3) Iraqi Kurds no longer see Turkey as a threat, they see that they need rapprochement with Turkey more than ever, and they want to help eliminate the PKK, which is the main obstacle to this. 4) The EU has been repeating for more than a decade that a civilian and political solution to the Kurdish problem must be found for Turkey to meet the membership conditions.

“The US, since the beginning of the Cold War, and especially in the post-9/11 world, places great importance on stability in Turkey, its most reliable ally and partner in the Islamic world. The US under the presidency of Barack Obama is giving great support to the establishment of democracy in Turkey to a degree that no other American administration has done. The Kurdish opening is not an evil imposed by some foreign power to divide the people and partition the country; on the contrary, it is a necessity dictated by reason and conscience to preserve the integrity of the country and the unity

of the people, which Turkey has become aware of through debates made possible by its flawed democracy after immeasurably great moral and material losses caused by an internal conflict lasting 25 years. If vote calculations prevent what reason and conscience dictate from being done, one's eyes must be blinded by superstition not to see that the danger of division-partition will only then become serious." (*Zaman*, 5.09.2009)

"Prime Minister Erdoğan should receive the Nobel Peace Prize"

One of the most important reasons for my positive view of the AKP government was the "zero problems with neighbors" policy whose architect was Foreign Minister Ahmet Davutoğlu. My nomination of Prime Minister Erdoğan for the Nobel Peace Prize due to the policies pursued in this context probably constituted the peak of my support for the AKP government in my writings. I wrote as follows:

"In recent weeks, we are witnessing extraordinary activity in foreign policy. Last month, a *High-Level Strategic Cooperation Agreement* was signed with Syria; the visa requirement between the two countries was mutually lifted. The rapprochement with Syria, with which we have various problems and from which we were on the brink of war just ten years ago because it harbored PKK leader Öcalan, is undoubtedly one of the most important achievements in the AKP government's 'zero problems with neighbors' policy.

"Last weekend, President Gül made an official visit to Paris on the occasion of *Turkey-France Year* events. French President Sarkozy did not mention 'privileged partnership' to Gül; he emphasized that differences of opinion on EU membership should not affect bilateral relations and did not refrain from showing his interest in tenders in Turkey. Of course, the most noteworthy thing in the context of France is that French officials declared to Chief Negotiator Egemen Bağış during his visit last month that they were in favor of continuing negotiations with Turkey.

"Something unexpected also happened last weekend. Greece's brand-new Prime Minister Yorgo Papandreou made his first foreign visit to Turkey on his fifth day in power. While Papandreou was in Istanbul, I also went to Athens for a meeting and had the opportunity to talk with Greek colleagues about the meaning of this visit. According to the general opinion, Papandreou's coming to Istanbul to meet with Prime Minister Erdoğan and Foreign Minister Davutoğlu before his visit to Cyprus on October 19, despite the strong reactions in Greek public opinion to Turkish warplanes flying over inhabited Greek islands, is a sign that the coming months are pregnant with new initiatives in Turkish-Greek relations.

"Perhaps the most important foreign policy development not only of the past weekend but of recent years is, of course, Turkey and Armenia officially signing on October 10 in the Swiss city of Zurich the protocols providing for the normalization of relations between them, which they had previously agreed upon. It appears that Ankara is making rapprochement with Armenia contingent on Azerbaijan-Armenia normalization. Prime Minister Erdoğan is repeating that without progress on this second front, there is no question of the protocols passing through parliament and the borders opening. There is

no doubt that this is a requirement for achieving peace and stability in the South Caucasus. Ankara is doing the right thing.

“Another very noteworthy foreign policy development of the past week was the cancellation of the joint air exercise in Konya that Israeli warplanes were also to participate in. It appears that the policies pursued by Israel are causing great disappointment not only to the government but also to the TAF. What is disturbing Ankara is apparently not only Israel’s Gaza attack earlier this year, but perhaps even more so, the new Israeli government under Netanyahu setting aside all commitments and continuing to expand Jewish settlements on Palestinian territories, thereby derailing peace negotiations with the Palestinians.

“I came across the most meaningful commentary of recent days in the editorial of Israel’s *Haaretz* newspaper: ‘Turkish Prime Minister Erdoğan, showing impressive wisdom, is leading reconciliation with Armenia while also working on a solution in Cyprus by improving relations with Greece… The peace agreement between Turkey and Armenia is also a fascinating lesson for Israel and the Palestinians… The Turks, whose ancestors were the Ottomans who ruled our region for centuries, have opened a door of hope for us too.’ (October 12)

“The AKP government is pursuing a policy, of which Mr. Davutoğlu is the architect, that is exemplary for the whole world (including Obama) in solving problems through diplomacy and negotiation. I hope Prime Minister Erdoğan succeeds in all his domestic and foreign policy openings and wins the Nobel Peace Prize.” (*Zaman*, 13.10.2009)

Considering the points mentioned in the above article, it must be admitted that by late 2009 there were valid reasons to think that the AKP government was pursuing a peaceful foreign policy (one compatible with Turkey’s interests).

The Sledgehammer mentality is doomed to defeat

The *Taraf* newspaper, in its headline story on January 20, 2010, wrote that at a plan seminar held at the 1st Army headquarters on March 5-7, 2003 under the leadership of Gen. Çetin Doğan, a military coup plan called “Sledgehammer” was made with the aim of overthrowing the Turkish government. My comment on *Taraf*’s report was as follows:

“When I read the ‘Sledgehammer coup plan’ news published in *Taraf* on Wednesday morning, January 20, I had not the slightest doubt about its accuracy. Because for almost as long as I can remember, that is, for about the last fifty years, I have been living in a country where military coup

plots are made and carried out. However, some of the people I encountered throughout the day viewed the news with suspicion, saying it could be ‘disinformation.’ At first I was surprised… Then, once again, I thought about how dependent our perceptions are on the values and ideas in our minds. I do not know what these people think after the details of the coup plan published in *Taraf*, and after the General Staff’s statement essentially confirming the report. But their skeptical approach to news of the various

exposed coup attempts and to the Ergenekon case must be related to their concern about the end of the bureaucratic tutelage regime prevailing in Turkey.

“For a moment, let us assume that there is a serious side to these concerns. Let us say that if the bureaucratic tutelage over it ends, democracy in Turkey will face the danger of turning into a majority dictatorship. Because what has provided balance in the regime and prevented power from being concentrated in one hand until now has been

bureaucratic tutelage. Well, how valid is this claim? Certainly, liberal, in other words libertarian and pluralist democracy, is not just about power being determined by election, that is, majority rule.

The fundamental rights and freedoms of citizens (primarily freedom of expression, organization, and belief) being under constitutional guarantee; the legislature and executive being subject to judicial

oversight; the existence of a strong civil society composed of voluntary organizations independent of the state, a competitive market economy—these are the other indispensable elements of democracy.

“However, the problem Turkey faces today has not the slightest connection with the elimination of fundamental rights and freedoms, with democracy turning into a majority dictatorship. Today in Turkey, neither the principle of majority rule

is valid, nor are fundamental rights and freedoms secure… The administration that comes to power through the people’s vote is under the tutelage of bureaucratic elites who are committed not to liberal democratic principles but to an authoritarian interpretation of Kemalism (or nationalism and secularism)

as it is under tutelage; fundamental rights and freedoms are also restricted by this interpretation. In Turkey today, on one hand the struggle to establish popular sovereignty, on the other hand the struggle to remove the restrictions on fundamental rights and freedoms

is being waged. Turkey today is going through a transition from a kind of democracy that is under the tutelage of a bureaucracy committed to the authoritarian interpretation of Kemalism to a liberal, that is, European-standard democracy.

“This process can succeed, because the ‘Sledgehammer mentality’ is a retreating mentality doomed to defeat. Not only in parliament but in almost every segment, the preference for democracy prevails. It is for this reason that military coup plans are being exposed and failing. The Ergenekon investigation and case became possible because of this. In both the judiciary and the media, the ranks of liberal democracy are getting stronger. Among businessmen as well… On January 21, the election of Ümit Boyner, who comes from the New Democracy Movement, to the TÜSİAD Presidency—

isn’t it a sign of this?

“It is certain that we need external support to establish liberal democracy. Yes, Western allies, especially the US, do not ignore the nature of the regime in Turkey as long as it

remains committed to the alliance, as in the Cold War years. But the greatest opportunity we have is the EU membership perspective. The AKP government should once again show the determination and energy of the 2002-2005 period to overcome all the obstacles and make all the reforms necessary for EU membership. If it cannot completely renew the constitution, it should make changes in the constitution and basic laws in the direction of democratization and civilianization without delay. All forces in favor of democracy should also mobilize to give support." (*Zaman*, 23.1.2010)

The 'Sledgehammer coup plan' disclosed by the *Taraf* newspaper became the subject of a judicial investigation. The case opened as a result of the investigation began on June 19, 2010 at the Istanbul 10th High Criminal Court. On September 21, 2012, the court sentenced 325 of the 365 defendants, including retired generals Çetin Doğan, Özden Örnek, and İbrahim Fırtına, to aggravated life imprisonment for 'overthrowing the council of ministers of the Republic of Turkey or forcibly preventing it from performing its duties'; however, it applied various sentence reductions due to "incomplete attempt."

In the continuation of the case, the Istanbul 4th High Criminal Court on June 19, 2014 unanimously ruled that 234 officers be released and retried and that all arrest warrants at the prosecutor's office be lifted. In the "Sledgehammer Plan" case, which was retried following the Constitutional Court's decision of "rights violation," the Anadolu 4th High Criminal Court on March 31, 2015 decided to acquit 236 defendants as it was not established that they committed the crime charged. However, the prosecution appealed to the Court of Cassation against the acquittal decision regarding defendants Çetin Doğan and 6 other defendants. The 16th Criminal Division of the Court of Cassation on June 14, 2021 unanimously ruled that the crime of "conspiracy to commit a crime" had been committed and overturned the acquittal decision regarding 7 defendants. The case will be retried.

Was the "Sledgehammer coup plan" real, or was it a plot against the military?.. When I wrote the article I quoted above, I had no doubt that the "Sledgehammer coup plan" was real. Years later, writing these lines, I can dwell on two points: 1) As seen in other examples in our history, many years must pass and governments must change for questions related to military coup attempts to be fully clarified. 2) The AKP government experience should have shown that military tutelage does not provide a guarantee against authoritarian civilian rule, and that this can only be achieved by embedding liberal democratic institutions in people's consciousness and strengthening them.

"Baykal's resignation should not have been like this"

In the news announced by the Hürriyet newspaper on May 8, 2010 with the headline "Tape blow to Baykal," it was said that "the hidden camera footage placed on internet sites, allegedly belonging to CHP leader Baykal and CHP MP Nesrin Baytok, created an earthquake effect in politics…" Following this news, Baykal resigned from the CHP leadership. My comment on the incident was as follows:

"When I read the news, I thought the tape was a 'product of montage' and an instrument of a vile conspiracy. It is not certain whether the tape is a 'product of montage' or not, but there really is a vile conspiracy at hand. Baykal's resignation should not have been like

this. My acquaintance with him goes back a long way… Had Mr. Baykal remained faithful to the libertarian discourse he adopted when the CHP, which the September 12 coup had closed, was reopened in September 1992, he would have become prime minister and could have gone down in Turkish history as a leader who served democracy. But, unfortunately, he headed in the opposite direction; he increasingly settled on guarding the bureaucratic tutelage order, and even worse, on serving as a lawyer for those who attack democracy.

“For these reasons, as someone who voted for the CHP in almost every general election except 2007, I was against the ideas Mr. Baykal defended and the political attitude he adopted, especially from 2005 onward. But I was saddened that Baykal was forced to resign through such a vile conspiracy. I would have wanted him to be held accountable for his wrong policies at the ballot box. Being forced to resign in this way, I’m afraid, will not help the CHP correct itself and review its policies.

“Baykal, while resigning, claims he was subjected to a conspiracy orchestrated by the ruling party, the government. I find this not at all convincing. I don’t think it will be found convincing in public opinion either. Because from the AKP’s perspective, there could not have been a more acceptable chief opposition leader than Baykal. While there were clearly many aspects of the AKP government to criticize, by taking on the role of advocate for those who opposed the government through illegitimate means and those who damaged democratic principles and institutions, he distanced the CHP from being an alternative to power in the eyes of the people. He was supported only ‘reluctantly’ even by die-hard CHP voters.

“For this reason, I find the *Taraf* newspaper’s headline diagnosis of ‘His supporters struck…’ (May 9) apt. Indeed, the fact that those who thought he could no longer successfully serve their cause were fervently calling on Baykal to resign also pointed to this. That circles which failed to remove the AKP from power through illegitimate means are seeking to equip the CHP with a leader who could block the constitutional changes in the upcoming referendum and win the next elections seems to me to be the strongest ‘theory’ explaining the tape.

“There are also points about the ‘tape blow to Baykal’ that need to be dwelt upon from a media perspective. The first of these is this: Of course, newspapers may have different understandings about to what extent this carries news value. They can view the event as ‘big’ or ‘small’ if they wish. But there could not be the slightest hesitation that the event carried news value and deserved to be commented upon. The second point is this: The secret recording of the tape and giving it to the media is of course a crime; those who did this must definitely be found and punished. The Prime Minister’s instruction to the National Intelligence Organization (MİT) to find the culprits is very appropriate in this regard.

“However, once the ‘tape’ reached the media, it was out of the question not to make it a subject of news and commentary. It should not be forgotten that in democracies, the most important (fourth estate) function of the media is to monitor whether holders of political, administrative, economic, and cultural power are acting contrary not only to democracy and laws but also to moral principles. Holders of power are not ordinary

citizens; what they say and do concerns not only themselves but the whole society. Therefore, they do not have 'private lives' like ordinary citizens." (*Zaman*, 11.05.2010)

The two faces of the CHP

While commenting on the arguments in the article titled "Sex tape opens the door to a bright future for Turkey" by *New York Times* Istanbul bureau chief Stephen Kinzer, I also wrote:

"For years, I have been arguing that the other face of the CHP tradition should not be neglected. Yes, on one face, the CHP is the state party, the guardian of the bureaucratic tutelage order. But the same CHP, on its other face, is also the heir of a tradition that opened the door to democratization, even if under tutelage, in the 1940s, that brought the concepts of fundamental rights and freedoms to this country in the 1950s, social rights in the 1960s and 1970s, and cultural rights in the 1980s and 1990s. If the CHP had been able to rebuild itself along the lines of this tradition when it was reopened in 1992, democracy would have long been established in Turkey.

"The National Vision tradition, by learning from mistakes, succeeded in abandoning Islamism and rebuilding itself as 'Conservative Democracy.' With a determined leadership cadre, the CHP could very well have abandoned an authoritarian understanding of Kemalism and rebuilt itself as a social democratic party in the European sense. This was the (unfortunately unfulfilled) expectation of myself and many of my friends when the CHP was reopened. Is the door to rebirth now opening for the CHP? I am not optimistic about this. But I agree with Kinzer on this point: Behind Turkey's successes has always been its ability to renew itself." (*Zaman*, 15.05.2010)

After Baykal's resignation, I welcomed Kılıçdaroğlu's announcement of his candidacy for the CHP leadership. I wrote as follows:

"Kılıçdaroğlu can pull the CHP onto the democracy mat, that is, he can turn it into a serious opposition party that opposes through legitimate means, directs legitimate criticisms at the government, and therefore an alternative to power, instead of hoping for help from military and judicial coups and playing 'Ergenekon lawyer.' He can make a civilized political style that appeals to minds prevail instead of a shouting, polarizing style. Both our democracy and the CHP would greatly benefit from this. I think this is the hope that Kılıçdaroğlu has aroused in public opinion." ("The hope aroused by Kılıçdaroğlu," *Zaman*, 20.05.2010)

More than ten years have passed since then. Despite the great difficulties Kılıçdaroğlu faces, I believe he has played an important role in steering the CHP, which during the Baykal era was dominated by an authoritarian understanding of Kemalism, toward a liberal understanding of democracy.

Militarism befits neither Ortaylı nor the MHP

As the first decade of the 21st century was coming to a close, as intellectuals who had embraced liberal views since the 1980s, we believed that the main reason Turkey could not establish liberal democracy was the military-bureaucratic tutelage over democracy

(majority rule), upon which the frequently recurring military interventions were based. It never occurred to us that majority rule unconstrained by fundamental rights and freedoms could lead to majority dictatorship—to one-man rule, as would be seen under the Erdoğan government. In an article where I criticized militarism, I wrote:

“Prof. Dr. İlber Ortaylı has been a friend I’ve known since our years studying at Ankara University’s Faculty of Political Science. He graduated two years after me, in 1969. He stayed away from the student movements of those days and devoted himself to his education. He learned many languages and became a good historian of the late Ottoman period. I believe the first articles he published in the press appeared on the book page I edited in *Cumhuriyet* in the 1980s. His book titled *The Longest Century of the Empire* is a valuable work. It is perhaps the book that best explains that the Tanzimat reforms were a turning point in Turkey’s modernization, not in its semi-colonization. Through this book and other works, he has gained increasing prestige.

“As far as I know, İlber has developed a habit as he ages of viewing almost every notable idea and person negatively, of not approving of anyone. (According to some friends, when this habit combined with the increasing attention he received from society, it led him to a kind of megalomania.) As far as I can follow, in recent years İlber has shown particular hostility toward ideas and people who approach late Ottoman and Republican history with a humane and libertarian perspective. The views he expressed at a Nationalist Movement Party meeting on February 6 are the latest manifestations (perhaps excessive) of this reaction.

“With a charitable reading, some valid points can be found in Ortaylı’s views. Mümtaz’er Türköne addressed some of these on this page (February 9). However, the proper response must surely be given to Ortaylı presenting the scourge called militarism—one of the primary characteristics of fascism—as if it were a virtue. Based on the claim that ‘the primary characteristic of Turks is being a soldier nation,’ Ortaylı argues that ‘in recent years in Turkey a feeling of shame about one’s nationality and a drift toward an anti-militarist, soldier-hating society have been stoked’… He asks what harm Europe could suffer from ‘Turkish society being militarist.’

“Ortaylı cannot be speaking without knowing what militarism means. Militarism means arguing that political problems can best be solved by military methods, that is, by force of arms; wanting the principle of absolute obedience peculiar to armies to dominate all of society; believing that the country can best be governed not by those who come to power through elections but by soldiers, and supporting this. Militarism is not synonymous with soldiering, and it is definitely not a mentality or ideology peculiar to soldiers. Today in Turkey, militarism is unfortunately more prevalent among civilians than soldiers, and we are having great difficulty freeing ourselves from it. Opposing militarism is definitely not being hostile to soldiers. As long as there is a need for defense, there will be armies, soldiers, and weapons. And Turkey also needs an army that does its job properly.

“Turkey has suffered greatly from militarism. The damage inflicted on the country over the last quarter century by the mindset of violent, forceful solutions prevalent among both Turks and Kurds is evident. Ortaylı complains about ‘not having become France in

the last 30 years'… If we haven't, the main culprit is militarism. The militarist mentality is doing great harm to both the army and soldiers in Turkey. Because involvement in politics has resulted in the TAF's inability to perform its duties properly, and unfortunately is also eroding its prestige.

"Europeans also suffered greatly from militarism. To escape from it, they founded the European Union; they turned to solving problems by talking rather than fighting, to establishing democracy, that is, to making civilization dominant. As Turkey, with our great majority, we also want to be part of the EU for this reason. Yes, joining the EU would for this reason be 'bliss' (which Ortaylı doesn't like)… If European states are inciting us against militarism, good for them… There is much to say about Ortaylı's other claims too. But let me conclude like this: Militarism befits neither İlber Ortaylı nor the MHP that hosted him." (*Zaman*, February 13, 2010)

Upon the publication of this article, the congratulatory messages I received from some of Ortaylı's historian colleagues were surprisingly numerous. I should also note that İlber, a very old friend of mine, received this criticism of mine with maturity.

Hey soldier, don't meddle in politics!

The article I wrote about Hasan Cemal's book titled *Turkey's Soldier Problem* also well reflected the view, shared by many liberal-minded intellectuals, that the main problem of democracy in Turkey stemmed from being under military tutelage. I said:

"… It can be said that the 'soldier problem' is Turkey's number one problem today, because the insolubility of all other problems stems from it. Well, why does Turkey have a 'soldier problem'? Because the role soldiers play in Turkey is incompatible with the liberal democratic order we want to establish. In liberal democracies, there is a clear distinction between the roles of politicians and soldiers. This distinction rests on three pillars. First, soldiers do not interfere in politics and are absolutely subordinate to the elected government. Second, even in matters related to military affairs and defense, it is the elected officials who determine policies. Soldiers may offer advice on these matters, but they are obligated to implement the policies determined by the government. Third, soldiers are absolutely impartial politically; that is, regardless of which party is in power, they must faithfully implement the policies pursued by governments. Turkey has a soldier problem because since the transition to the multi-party system, soldiers have intervened in politics through direct and indirect means, have interfered in the affairs of elected officials on every matter, and have not been politically impartial.

"Well, where does the 'soldier problem' originate? It can be said that at the source of the problem is the fact that a significant portion of officers, due to the political culture they acquire in military schools, are committed not to liberal democracy (which makes the West the West and constitutes the fundamental philosophy of the European Union) but to the 'Atatürkist Thought System' or to the prohibitionist and authoritarian interpretation of Kemalism. The fact that politicians in Turkey have not been able to reach an agreement among themselves to establish civilian authority over the military (what Hasan Cemal calls the 'civilian problem') is also the second, auxiliary reason why the soldier problem still cannot be solved. Hasan Cemal's latest book is a great service to

the struggle to establish democracy because it tells the story of the soldier (and civilian) problem experienced since the 1980s and what this has cost Turkey, with all its important details.

“On the one hand, signs that commitment to the democratic rule of law is increasing among soldiers, and on the other hand, that the Republican People’s Party may henceforth throw its weight behind ending the political role of the military, are giving rise to hope that in the coming years we may achieve, in the words of former Chief of General Staff General Hilmi Özkök, ‘a Turkey where everyone does their own job.’” (*Zaman*, May 22, 2010)

The experiences we gained in the years after these lines were written revealed that to establish liberal democracy, not only soldiers but also civilians must show loyalty to the fundamental principles of this regime. The AKP government gradually ended military tutelage and built in its place a one-man regime that we can characterize as a majority dictatorship. We will only see over time whether our lived experiences have helped establish the principles that liberal democracy includes not only majority rule but also respect for the fundamental rights and freedoms of individuals, no matter how much they remain in the minority.

“We solve by talking, not by fighting”

In July 2010, upon Prime Minister Erdoğan’s announcement during his contacts with opposition leaders that preparations were nearing completion for a professional security unit whose sole task would be to combat the PKK, and that it had not yet been decided whether the unit would be attached to the TAF or to the Police, I wrote the following:

“… It is not possible to underestimate or belittle the necessity and importance of military measures in the fight against the PKK. However, on condition that we do not forget even for a moment that the fight against the PKK cannot be won through military methods alone… It cannot be forgotten for a moment that to win this fight, what essentially needs to be done is to solve the Kurdish problem by resolutely continuing the ‘democratic opening.’ To solve the Kurdish problem, as we have repeatedly stated without tiring, means first of all removing all obstacles to the free expression of Kurdish identity in Turkey, ensuring that Kurdish citizens can freely express their unique concerns, in short, fulfilling the democratic demands of Turkey’s Kurds. Solving the Kurdish problem also means making Turkey a democratic country that all Kurds respect and trust, no matter what country or continent they live in. Only when full respect is shown to Kurdish identity can the environment that feeds the PKK insurgency and drives Kurdish youth to the mountains come to an end. And Turkey can achieve this.

“To solve the PKK problem, which is a product of the Kurdish problem and which has gained aspects independent of the Kurdish problem after a 26-year struggle, what needs to be done above all is to talk with whoever needs to be talked to (the Peace and Democracy Party represented in the parliament, or failing that the PKK leaders in Kandil, or failing that Abdullah Öcalan in İmralı), through whatever direct or indirect channel is necessary; to open the way for PKK militants to engage in politics through legitimate means rather than with weapons.

“If the special units to be deployed on the borders cause even the slightest neglect of the political measures that must be taken as the primary focus, causing attention to once again focus on military methods doomed to fail, let us recognize from now that this will not serve in the slightest the outcome desired by the overwhelming majority of the Turkish and Kurdish people, namely peace and stability prevailing in the country, the ideal of a Turkey growing freer and more prosperous together.” (*Zaman*, July 17, 2010)

A thousand times yes

The constitutional amendments proposed by the AKP government to break bureaucratic tutelage over governments based on majority vote were announced to the public on May 12, 2010; the referendum on them was held on September 12, 2010. I had explained in an article dated July 10 that I would say “Not enough but yes” to the constitutional amendments. In my article that came out a few days before the vote, I said:

“Now I feel the need to say ‘A thousand times yes!’ because what was said and seen during the referendum campaign allows me to see better that the acceptance of this package is of vital importance for the normalization of democracy in Turkey; and that if ‘no’ comes out of the ballot box, the forces struggling for bureaucratic tutelage over democracy to continue and for the coup plotters to be acquitted could seize the initiative.

“As I have written before: Of course, I have respect for those who will say ‘no’ to the constitutional amendments or those who will boycott the vote (for one reason or another). After all, democracy means freedom of expression as much as majority rule. However, there is a very fundamental disagreement between those who will say ‘yes’ and the others. Those who will say ‘yes’ prefer Turkey to achieve a democracy at EU standards, while the others prefer it to remain under bureaucratic-military tutelage. According to the others, secularism in its current form (meaning the state controlling religion and restricting religious freedoms) is more important than democracy. For them, the principles to be followed are not those of liberal democracy but of an authoritarian interpretation of Kemalism. Unfortunately, in Turkey there is no consensus on the liberal and pluralist democratic regime that generally prevails in EU countries.

“I say ‘A thousand times yes!’ I can list the basic reasons for this as follows: A ‘yes’ result from the referendum will show that there is a majority in Turkey in favor of a new, civilian, and democratic constitution; from the morning of September 13, a campaign will begin for a new constitution that will secure the free expression and practice of religious and ethnic identities alongside individual freedoms. I believe that the adoption of the constitutional amendments will also help the main opposition party CHP to get its act together and break its ties with the tutelage system. In that case, Turkey will have a stronger will to solve its fundamental problems, primarily the Kurdish problem and subordinating the military to civilian authority. (…) I say ‘A thousand times yes!’ because if the constitutional amendments are adopted, the pressure from society on the ruling AKP government to solve the Kurdish problem by negotiating with the Peace and Democracy Party, to end PKK violence, and thus to make Turkey a free, prosperous country that is an example to its entire region, will increase greatly.” (*Zaman*, August 31, 2010)

Looking back from today, from 2021, what is now patently obvious is how naively optimistic I was in those days; that it never even occurred to me that ending military tutelage could open the door to majority dictatorship.

Presidentialism is bad, the parliamentary system is good

Prime Minister Erdoğan, immediately after the referendum held on September 12, 2010, repeated the view he had first touched upon in April of that year; he spoke of abandoning the parliamentary system and switching to a presidential system with new constitutional amendments to be made. Upon this, I wrote the following:

"… As is known, there can be essentially three types of government systems in democracies: The parliamentary system (cradle: Britain), the presidential system (cradle: USA), and the semi-presidential system, which is a hybrid of the two (cradle: France). Therefore, a claim that presidential or semi-presidential systems are incompatible with democracy certainly cannot be made. However, like the great majority of our political scientists, I also think that presidential systems are particularly unsuitable for Turkey. I can list the main reasons for this as follows:

"I see great benefit in the head of state (that is, the President) only representing the state and nation, being in a supra-partisan position that all citizens can trust. In the parliamentary system, the President, who is generally elected by parliament through inter-party consensus, can easily play the role of a supra-partisan, unifying statesman. However, in both the presidential and semi-presidential systems, because the president is also the head of the executive branch, it becomes impossible for them to play this supra-partisan, unifying statesman role.

"Turkey needs reforms and therefore a strong executive branch. Only a parliamentary system can provide this. In a parliamentary system, because the Prime Minister, who is the head of the executive branch, comes from parliament, there is no incompatibility between the executive and legislative branches. However, in presidential systems, if the president and the legislature are from different parties, there are major problems in governance. And problems can only be overcome with a culture of compromise (which we don't really have). The difficulties experienced by the AKP government and Prime Minister Erdoğan during President Ahmet Necdet Sezer's term were definitely not caused by the parliamentary system, but by the powers granted to the presidency as a tutelage institution by the 1982 constitution, which were incompatible with the parliamentary system and resembled those in semi-presidential systems. In other words, Turkey in a sense experienced the disadvantages of the semi-presidential system.

"Turkey's need for decentralized restructuring of the state in no way necessitates a switch to a presidential or semi-presidential system. The parliamentary government system is compatible with a federal state structure (as in India); with a structure based on devolution or transfer of powers to regions (as in Britain and Spain); with a unitary structure where all powers except those related to the state's basic functions (namely defense, security, economy, foreign policy, justice) are transferred to municipalities and local governments (as in Sweden); and even with a unitary structure where governors are elected by general vote (as in Japan).

“The (in my opinion) problematic and therefore undesirable aspect of the parliamentary system is related to its also leaving the door open to coalition governments. But the parliamentary system definitely does not necessitate coalition governments. What leads to incompatible, internally quarreling coalition governments is the proportional representation electoral system. We have learned from experience that even a 10% threshold in the proportional representation system is not enough to prevent coalitions. Coalition governments are (in my opinion) bad, but the remedy is definitely not presidential systems, but the majoritarian electoral system.” (*Zaman*, October 7, 2010)

In light of the experiences we have gained over the years, I should note that my views on coalition governments and the proportional representation electoral system have changed: Today, I think not that the majoritarian electoral system is more democratic than the proportional representation system, or that single-party governments are more democratic than coalition governments, but quite the opposite…

The two faces of enlightenment

Enlightenment, light, intellectual… These were concepts frequently used in Turkey’s left (both Kemalist and communist) tradition, drawing their source from the intellectual movement that emerged in Western countries in the 17th and 18th centuries, from positivist philosophy. In one of my articles, I was trying to draw attention to the shallowness and superficiality in the use of these concepts in Turkey:

“Yesterday we celebrated the 87th founding anniversary of the Republic of Turkey. If, like me, you live within the boundaries of a municipality governed by the CHP, you frequently encountered posters containing slogans like ‘The Republic enlightens… Toward brighter tomorrows…’ and similar ones on this occasion. Especially if you are a reader of the *Cumhuriyet* newspaper, ‘Enlightenment’ will perhaps be one of the concepts you encounter most often. I thought it might be a good idea to write about this concept on the occasion of Republic Day.

“In the history of Western thought, the 18th century is referred to as the Age of Enlightenment. In this era, a series of thinkers, in light of the findings of developing science, subjected traditional institutions, traditions, and morality, and in this context religious beliefs and the authority of the church (in short, the status quo), to critical questioning. The values related to using the findings of reason and science to question the established order, the status quo, the dominant institutions and ideas (ideology) (if you will, critical rationalism), are certainly a legacy of the Age of Enlightenment.

“But this is not the only legacy of ‘Enlightenment.’ The Age of Enlightenment is also the source of the idea that humanity, using its reason, science accepted as a body of absolute and indisputable truths, and the technologies that are its products, can make the world an increasingly better, more advanced, more civilized place by shaping nature and society according to its own preferences (let us call it social engineering). It can be said that what characterized the Modern Age, extending from the Middle Ages to the 20th century, was essentially these two legacies of the Age of Enlightenment.

“The ‘wholesale’ (if you will, revolutionary) interpretations of what we might roughly call ‘social engineering,’ the second legacy of the Age of Enlightenment, yielded disastrous results. Some of these are the disasters caused by the totalitarian regimes (communism) established under the leadership of Marxist-Leninist parties that claimed to be ‘midwifing history’ based on the idea that Karl Marx discovered the laws of society’s development. Another part consists of the disasters caused by Nazism, fascism, and similar totalitarian and authoritarian regimes based on the idea, again using science, of making the superior race/nation dominant. It can be said that the ambition to dominate nature and exploit it for its own purposes using science-technology has also come to threaten life on earth in the 21st century with global warming and climate change.

“The leaving behind of the disasters that Enlightenment’s second legacy (wholesale social engineering) brought upon humanity was made possible largely thanks to Enlightenment’s first legacy (critical rationalism). Critical rationalism not only enabled the mistakes made to be seen; by questioning the idea that all societies would necessarily follow the same path, it opened the door to the transition to the Postmodern, or Post-Modernity, Age. If the dominant ideology of the traditional (pre-modern) age extending to the 17th century was religion, the dominant ideology of the modern age extending to the 20th century was science. Just as in the 18th century religion and religious institutions were subjected to critical questioning, in the 20th century the established (positivist, absolute, infallible) understanding of science was also subjected to critical questioning. As a result of this questioning, it was understood that science consists only of theories valid until proven otherwise, and that as our knowledge of the universe advances, it becomes apparent how little we actually know. The Postmodern Age thus entered suggests that religion and science have separate domains; that religion must approach science with respect, and science must approach religion with respect.

“I am aware of the problems that come with reducing complex matters to simplicity. But at the very least, one must be conscious that ‘Enlightenment’ does not have a single legacy, that it has at least two faces. The legacy of ‘Enlightenment’ that must be embraced is critical rationalism. But unfortunately, the circles in our country that constantly trumpet ‘Enlightenment’ are turning their backs on critical and questioning reason.” (*Zaman*, October 30, 2010)

The two different faces of the ’68 generation

At the end of 2010, when Prof. Dr. Burhan Kuzu, Chairman of the Constitutional Commission of the Turkish Grand National Assembly, was pelted with eggs at Ankara University’s Faculty of Political Science and not allowed to speak, his statement that “The ’68 generation has been a curse on this country…” inflamed debates about the ’68 generation. While following these debates, I concluded that there were still some reminders I could make in addition to what I had previously written and said. And I wrote the following:

“First: What do we mean by ‘the ’68 generation’? We are talking about young people who, while studying at universities in Ankara and Istanbul in the late 1960s, engaged in intense questioning and debate about the fundamental political problems of the world

and Turkey, and who eventually took action with a great sense of social responsibility and idealism, guided by certain ideas, to fundamentally change the country. When evaluating the ’68 generation, as with almost every subject, it is necessary to consider it in light of the conditions of its time, with its different aspects and the evolution it has undergone.

“Those were Cold War years. The Western and Eastern blocs were competing for influence over Turkey. The young people were under the influence of the world: they were under a bombardment of ideas from the West about criticisms of capitalist democracies and from the East about criticisms of established communist regimes. On the other hand, internally, they were under the influence of the political environment determined by the May 27, 1960 military coup and the 1961 constitution adopted afterwards. The most influential intellectual movement on the ‘68 generation was undoubtedly Marxist socialism with its different interpretations (which has also become quite marginalized in the world today). The answer to the question of why there was such an oppressive regime and such an unjust social order in Turkey was quickly found: The culprits were imperialism and capitalism; the remedy was revolution and socialism. There were different prescriptions for how the revolution would take place: Some were convinced of top-down approaches (coup-making) for the revolution, while others adopted armed revolution models from Latin America or China learned from books. With increasing fanaticism, a race over ’who is more revolutionary’ began.

“These were years when development policies based on import substitution were still producing quite successful results, when the economy was growing, real wages were rising, and villagers were getting richer. The young people received no support from society; the state, for its part, approached them with its usual unsympathetic, merciless attitude of punishing in the harshest manner. Some of the young people were executed, some were killed extrajudicially; the great majority served years in prison. This treatment they received encouraged many to persist in the path they had taken. While many over time gave up socialism and turned to nationalism, some became outright fascists.

“But among the members of the ’68 generation, most of those who were able to find the opportunity to reflect on what was happening in the world and in Turkey reached a different conclusion: They understood (some at an earlier stage, some later) that freedom of expression, individual autonomy, human rights, the rule of law, and democracy are indispensable for a society’s liberation and attainment of prosperity and justice. (This understanding also applied to a significant portion of those among the young people studying at universities in the late 1960s who were captivated not only by Marxist ideology but also by other authoritarian and totalitarian ideologies of a nationalist or Islamist nature.)

“Consequently, a portion of the ’68 generation, coming from painful but rich experiences, today ranks among the leading advocates of freedom and pluralist democracy in Turkey. (I have never doubted that most of those who were executed or killed extrajudicially would also be in the democracy camp today if they had survived.) If Turkey is today progressing from democracy under tutelage toward a normal democracy (in this context, if the party to which Burhan Kuzu belongs has been able to take off the National Vision

shirt), this has been made possible to some extent thanks to the effective criticisms that intellectuals belonging to the ’68 generation directed at the tutelage order and the national security state established in the 1980s…” (*Zaman,* December 16, 2010)

Years later, now reading these lines, I say: What great naivety it was to think in those days that Turkey was progressing “from democracy under tutelage toward a normal democracy”… Indeed, the signals that I would begin to awaken from this dream would not be delayed…

CHAPTER XIII / DOES ERDOĞAN WANT TO BE PUTIN?

It could be said that the first sign that my commentary on the AKP government, and specifically on Prime Minister Erdoğan, would shift from a benevolent to a critical perspective was the article I wrote in early 2011, expressing my own suspicions that Erdoğan wanted to become Putin. Some opponents were saying that the AKP wanted to turn Turkey not into Iran but into Russia, and I agreed with this diagnosis. Here it is:

“The opposition has for some time abandoned the claim that the AKP would turn Turkey into Iran, instead saying it would turn it into Russia, that Erdoğan wants to be Putin… I have difficulty understanding the Prime Minister’s citing France and (yes!) Russia (the semi-presidential system where almost all powers are concentrated in the president’s hands) as examples. Because as we head to elections in June, polarizing the country, alienating some AKP supporters, and reducing the government’s votes is highly likely; I don’t find it compatible with reason and logic to bring up a proposal that has very little chance of being adopted.

“When it doesn’t accord with reason and logic, psychological explanations come to mind. It is claimed that the Prime Minister wants to be the next President and then to be as powerful a president as possible. It’s also difficult to explain how Erdoğan, who when addressing the Egyptian dictator Mubarak could say ‘We are mortal, we are not permanent. As Muslims, the place we will all end up is a pit two meters deep…’, who surely knows that democracy is the rule of rules not persons, could think this way, but I don’t see any other acceptable explanation…

“It’s very clear that presidential or semi-presidential government systems are not suited to Turkey’s makeup. Because unfortunately, both consensus on democracy and the culture of compromise are quite weak in our country. If we take the last referendum as a measure, at least 42% of the people are in favor of continuing the bureaucratic tutelage system. Almost every issue can become an occasion for polarization. In our society, besides political differences of opinion, there are divisions along religious-secular, Sunni-Alevi, Turkish-Kurdish axes. What we really need is to save both the government and the electoral system from being a monstrosity…” (*Zaman*, 8.2.2011)

Unfortunately, developments went in exactly the opposite direction of my hopes and expectations. Prime Minister Erdoğan gradually achieved his goal of “becoming Putin.”

The 2007 referendum established the rule that the President would be elected by popular vote; Erdoğan became President on August 28, 2014. With the referendum held on April 16, 2017, Turkey moved from its own peculiar parliamentary system to its own peculiar presidential system; Erdoğan's one-man rule as both AKP leader and President became institutionalized.

"We are learning the value of the rule of law"

However, I maintained my optimism about the future of democracy in Turkey. The European Council on Foreign Relations (ECFR) prepared a report titled "What does Turkey think?" after similar reports on China and Russia. In the study conducted jointly with the Centre for Economics and Foreign Policy Studies (EDAM), ECFR-affiliated researchers held a roundtable meeting with academics and journalists from Turkey in Istanbul at the end of February 2011. In my speech at this meeting, I said that Turkey was learning democracy and the rule of law through experience. I explained my view as follows:

"The history of the Republic in the first half of the 20th century is a period of building a secular Turkish nation under authoritarian single-party rule. The second period roughly covers the second half of the 20th century. During this period, Turkey experienced the establishment and operation of a type of democracy under the tutelage of the military-civilian bureaucracy (state elites), where democratic rights and freedoms were quite restricted. Since roughly the beginning of the 21st century, we have been in a struggle to establish a normal democracy. By normal democracy, I mean a democracy in which the country is governed by the party or parties that win elections, but where the rights and freedoms of minorities (in every sense—political, religious, ethnic) are guaranteed by the rule of law (that is, laws and practices that respect human rights).

"We hope that this struggle will be completed after this year's elections with the discussion and adoption of a new, civilian, and democratic constitution. There are both major obstacles ahead of this struggle and factors that could secure its success. The most important obstacle is that a significant portion of political, bureaucratic, economic, and cultural elites and civil society take a stance in favor of the continuation of the 'old regime,' that is, bureaucratic tutelage. The front opposing the transition to normal democracy is also quite broad: it includes not only the kind of Kemalists who yearn for 1930s Turkey but also (for different reasons) portions of Islamists, Turkish and Kurdish nationalists, extending into the ruling party and the government itself.

"Among the factors that give hope that the struggle can succeed is that the great majority of the people, as well as Western allies after the Cold War, take a stance in favor of a normal democracy in Turkey. The factor I particularly want to emphasize is that Turkey is learning through experience that democracy does not just mean majority rule, but also a state of law that respects individual and minority rights.

"In recent days, Turkey is seeing and learning that rights and law are valuable not just for themselves but for everyone. Until recently, the common understanding among officers was that democracy could be destroyed and the law trampled underfoot for the state's interests. Active and retired soldiers being tried in the Sledgehammer and

Ergenekon cases have seen the value of the rule of law and begun speaking of rights and law in their defenses. Some civilians who until yesterday worked for Turkey to come under military rule are now speaking of rights and law." (*Zaman*, 5.3.2011)

Ten years later, what I said in the above article seems noteworthy to me in this respect: how I had substituted my expectations and hopes for reality when I said "Turkey is learning through experience that democracy does not just mean majority rule, but also means a state of law that respects individual and minority rights…"

"The Imam's Army"

At this time, allegations that the Gülen community had taken over the police, prosecutors, and judiciary in Turkey had spread everywhere. Regarding these allegations, I wrote the following:

"You can guess that I was also confronted with questions about the Fethullah Gülen movement from EU parliamentarians and officials I met in Brussels last week: 'What did I think about the allegations that the Gülen movement had taken over the police, prosecutors, and judiciary in Turkey? Was the Ergenekon case a fabricated case by Gülen supporters in the police and judiciary to silence opposition to the AKP government? Was Ahmet Şık arrested because he wrote the book *The Imam's Army* revealing these truths, and was the book banned before printing for this reason?' I want to share with readers the answers I gave to these questions.

"One: I have been writing for *Zaman* for more than eight years. This newspaper is published with the support of the Gülen movement. Since I am not in the habit of hiding my views, I first expressed my opinion about Gülen in 1995, in an article titled 'Respect for Hocaefendi' published in *Milliyet* newspaper. My views have not changed; they have strengthened.

"Two: Islamophobia (fear of Islam) may not be as widespread in Turkey as in Europe, but it is quite strong in certain segments. According to the understanding that has dominated a segment of the elites since the founding of the Republic, especially the military and civilian bureaucracy, if Islam is not kept under state monopoly and control, if religious freedoms are not restricted, if religious movements are not kept under pressure, Turkey could become like Saudi Arabia or Iran. For this reason, Sufi orders, which are popular interpretations of Islam, have been banned since 1925; Alevism is not officially recognized; religious communities are not allowed to gain legal personality. Yet Turkey is predominantly a religious society. Despite all prohibitions and pressures, Sufi orders, the communities deriving from them, and faith-based social movements, most adapting to modernization, maintain their vitality. The prevalence of the Gülen movement, a faith-based social movement, frightens positivist and Islamophobic elites.

"Three: In Turkey, where scientific thinking has not developed, conspiracy theories—the belief that behind every event there is an omnipotent actor—are very common. This actor can be imperialism, communists, Zionists, and so on. Turkey today is experiencing the pains of transition from a kind of democracy under military-bureaucratic tutelage to a democracy at European standards. Society is polarized between those who want

democracy and the tutelage advocates. Among the former, there is a widespread tendency to see the ‘deep state’ or the Ergenekon organization under every rock; among the latter, there is a tendency to see the Gülen movement, which they try to demean, as they imagine, by calling its members ‘Fethullahists.’

“Four: Gülen is a religious scholar who supports modernization, meaning democracy, secularism in the sense of freedom of belief, fundamental rights and freedoms, respect for different beliefs and lifestyles, and development based on a market economy; who sees religion and science as complementary to each other; who emphasizes the spiritual and social aspects of Islam. He encourages his followers to serve the people and humanity by organizing companies, schools, hospitals, and aid organizations. He has always advocated adherence to laws and legitimacy. These are the reasons why he has gained great respect in Turkish society during the modernization process. But positivist and Islamophobic minds, because they can never accept that religion can play a positive role, hold the Gülen movement responsible for almost every evil.

“Five: The Ergenekon case is absolutely not a case fabricated to silence opposition to the AKP government. The emergence of practices contradicting the rule of law in its conduct does not even slightly overshadow the fact that this case is of great importance as it is the first time in the country’s history that coup instigators and perpetrators are being held accountable. As in every segment of society, there may be those who respect Gülen among the police, prosecutors, and judges involved in this investigation. But the claim that all of them take orders from Gülen or his movement neither accords with logic nor serves any purpose other than sabotaging the case.” (7.4.2011)

As can be understood from the above article, I was explaining the allegations about the Gülen community essentially as conspiracy theories arising from secularist, positivist prejudices. My extremely well-intentioned, naive perspective toward this community would unfortunately continue until the coup attempt on July 15, 2016—that is, until it became clear that community members in the armed forces played an important role in this attempt.

“A solution is possible, the opportunity should not be missed”

Yes, by 2011, I maintained views that I now, looking back, characterize as completely disconnected from reality—that Turkey would gradually establish liberal democracy over time and achieve a regime respectful of freedom of belief and ethnic identities. I was not at all alone in these views. After a visit to Diyarbakır in June 2011, I reflected the views expressed in the region as follows:

“The two days I spent in Diyarbakır reinforced my belief: Turkey, having left denial behind, can advance toward recognizing Kurdish identity. There is an opportunity that must not be missed. The cornerstones of this opportunity are these: The overwhelming majority of Kurds are committed to the country’s unity. The ruling party AKP, despite its vacillations, retains the trust of at least half of the Kurds. It is aware that, in order not to lose this trust, the new constitution must respond to Kurds’ common demands. That’s why the Prime Minister, in Diyarbakır, which gave him a great morale boost, did not content himself with emphasizing unity of faith and history; he promised ‘a constitution

that both the person from Diyarbakır and the person from Istanbul can call my constitution.' An extremely important intellectual transformation is taking place in the main opposition CHP. Chairman Kılıçdaroğlu is aware that not only the country's but also the party's interests require winning the trust of the Kurds. That's why after 9 years he goes to Diyarbakır and says: 'Yes, there is a Kurdish problem and your brother Kemal will solve it… Whatever the cost, we will bring peace…'

"Well, what does the BDP say? Since undoubtedly the KCK/PKK cannot speak with a single voice, the BDP also does not speak with a single voice. I think one of the most noteworthy voices rising from the BDP is Abdullah Demirbaş, mayor of Diyarbakır's Sur district, who opened the door for municipalities in the Southeast to provide multilingual services and who is being tried in more cases than he can count. The main points of what Mr. Demirbaş, who could say about my criticisms of the BDP 'Everyone needs criticism…', told me are as follows:

"Don't look at the increasingly tense atmosphere between parties during the election campaign. On June 13, the atmosphere will normalize, Turkey will seek the path of reconciliation. 75 percent of Kurds are in favor of the country's unity. A constitution reconciling Turkish sensitivities with Kurdish demands can be made. There have been three great alliances between Turks and Kurds until today. The first was the joint conquest of Anatolia in 1071, the second was the war of liberation between 1919-1925. Now it's time for the third alliance; the constitution that will democratize the Republic. We have two basic expectations from this constitution: Either it should make no reference to ethnic identities, or it should stipulate that all ethnic and religious groups are equal, free citizens. It should restructure the administration in 20-25 regions in a way that makes the principle of bottom-up local governance dominant. A statement from the Prime Minister on June 13 that such a constitution will be made will, I am sure, start the process of silencing the guns once and for all.

"In Diyarbakır, I also met with Mr. Şerafettin Elçi, one of the BDP-supported independent candidates. He said that his being an independent candidate from the BDP, which he had criticized much until now, should be understood as a sign of how hopeful he was about the resolution of the problem and the silencing of guns, and his desire to contribute to this. He expressed his belief that AKP, CHP, and BDP could reach a consensus to solve the problem by negotiating among themselves. He emphasized that this opportunity should not be missed. (…)

"Let us hope that his commitment to the vision of Turkey in 2023 as one of the world's strongest, most respected countries, receiving the respect of all Kurds and being the guarantor of stability in its region, will push Prime Minister Erdoğan to act decisively on the path to resolution." (*Zaman*, 4.6.2011)

Why is my vote going to the Has Party?

I explained whom I would vote for in the general elections held on June 12, 2011 as follows:

“Since 1994, when I started regular column writing, I have written in every election which party I would vote for. As columnists, we comment on almost every political issue and share our opinions with readers. I consider declaring whom I will vote for as a requirement of commentary. I had mentioned recently the reasons why I was undecided for the first time in this election. But in the end, I decided to vote for Has Party. Why?

“I have not the slightest doubt that the Justice and Development Party government is Turkey’s most successful government since the transition to the multi-party system. For this reason, the AKP is coming to power for a third term in the June 12 elections. It doesn’t need my vote for that. But the Prime Minister, who has turned the government and the AKP into a party of ‘yes-men,’ will need warnings and criticisms very much in the coming period. One of the issues the AKP government most needs to be warned and criticized about is its view of development as an end rather than a means. With the mentality of ‘development at any cost,’ we should not allow the destruction and plunder of our country’s nature, its most precious asset, or the disregard of human health.

“Turkey’s need for a strong Green Party that above all defends nature and wildlife is growing. The Turkey Greens Party, founded in 2008, co-chaired by Ümit Şahin and Yüksel Selek, unfortunately cannot participate in the election because it has not yet managed to organize in enough provinces. Among the parties participating in the election, the party whose views are close to mine on environmental issues as well as many other issues is the People’s Voice Party (Has Party), founded last November under the chairmanship of Mr. Numan Kurtulmuş. While ruling party spokespersons, despite the Fukushima disaster, speak like lobbyists for the nuclear industry with great obliviousness and indifference, what Has Party says seems particularly commendable to me. Has Party says exactly this in its June 12, 2011 Election Manifesto:

“‘The depletion of oil and natural gas reserves and the gradual increase in their prices, as well as the allocation of water resources for human use, has directed the whole world toward nuclear energy. However, the magnitude of the risks is causing people to hesitate. Today, many countries in the world, especially developed countries, meet their energy needs with nuclear power plants. We know that the history of nuclear power plants is full of accidents threatening the existence of humans and even all living beings. Most recently, the radioactive danger spreading from the Fukushima nuclear power plant damaged by the earthquake in Japan still threatens a large part of the world. Not only accidents but also the dangerous radioactive wastes produced by nuclear power plants continue to pose a threat to living beings. Has Party is a political party that puts humans and humanity first. Our party is against nuclear power plants, which pose a great threat to humanity. Because the essence of nuclear technology is not peaceful but warlike. A technology whose “margin of error” is mass deaths and permanent diseases is unacceptable. No nuclear power plant will be built in Turkey during our government. In addition, our party will show solidarity with nuclear energy opponents around the world and work for the closure of nuclear power plants and the elimination of nuclear weapons numbering in the tens of thousands.’ (p. 49)

“This is why my vote goes to Has Party…” (*Zaman*, 7.6.2011)

“I take back my vote”

My announcement and act of voting for HAS Party in the 2011 general elections was rightfully regarded as “comical” by some friends and, worse, by my wife Fatma Alpay. No positive (or negative) reaction had come from HAS Party members either. The People’s Voice Party, HAS Party, founded on November 1, 2010, dissolved itself on September 19, 2012 and joined the AKP with most of its members; thus completely abandoning its criticisms of the government. Numan Kurtulmuş, who entered politics with the Virtue Party, joined the Felicity Party during the process in which the Virtue Party split into the Felicity Party and the AKP, and then left the Felicity Party to found HAS Party, interpreted the invitation they received to join the AKP by saying “it is because of the value of HAS Party’s word, the reputation of its word.” It cannot be said that Kurtulmuş, who continued as AKP Deputy Chairman in 2023 and became one of Erdoğan’s closest supporters in the process of moving toward authoritarian one-man rule, has had an unusual political career by Turkish standards. About a year later, I would feel the need to take back my vote for Has Party and write as follows:

“In the first election I participated in after my final return in 1981 from Sweden, where I had taken refuge as a victim of the March 12 coup, I voted for the Motherland Party newly founded by Turgut Özal, believing he would civilianize the administration. I never regretted it. But from 1987 to 2002, I voted for CHP in all general elections (not for any other reason but lack of alternatives). I regretted most of them. In the 2007 elections, I voted for my friend Baskın Oran, who was an independent candidate from my electoral district. Baskın was not elected, but he said what needed to be said. Well done…

”In last year’s elections, I voted for HAS Party led by Numan Kurtulmuş. The parting of ways of Kurtulmuş and his friends with the Felicity Party had made a positive impression on me. But the reason for my voting for HAS Party was single and simple: It was the one and only party whose program opposed the construction of nuclear power plants. To underline how much I valued this stance against the AKP government, which with complete obliviousness had set out to bring the curse of nuclear energy upon the country regardless of the majority of the people being against it, I voted for HAS Party. You can guess the thoughts aroused in me by the same HAS Party now deciding to join the AKP… What can I say to not say something harsher?.. I take back my vote.

“Kurtulmuş, who accused Erdoğan of ‘becoming a pharaoh’ and the AKP of ‘becoming like Croesus,’ who left nothing unsaid about the AKP including that it was ‘a friend of Israel’ and ‘a political structure at the IMF’s service,’ has now decided to join the AKP, probably providing the freshest example of doing politics for seats rather than ideas and ideals in Turkey. I don’t know what the participation of Kurtulmuş and his party, whose reputation has been severely damaged, will bring to the AKP, but the purpose of Erdoğan’s invitation and the tactic he follows is very clear: To make the AKP the only alternative for voters in the same lane…” (*Zaman*, 21.07.2012)

“Liberal and pluralist democracy is being established”

In the general elections held on June 12, 2011, the AKP won 50% of the votes and 327 seats in parliament. I saw the election result as positive for the future of democracy and commented as follows:

“The June 12 election results are a new victory for democracy in Turkey. The first democratic victory on the path to liberation from military-bureaucratic tutelage occurred on November 3, 2002. In my first article titled ‘Victory of Democracy’ published in this newspaper (November 5, 2002), I said in summary: Despite perhaps the world’s worst electoral system, Turkey wiped from parliament the coalition parties that had dragged the country into the worst economic crisis in its history; it gave power to the cadre that had achieved a great intellectual transformation from the anti-EU National View to the pro-EU Conservative Democracy. In my article titled ‘New Victory of Turkish Democracy’ published after the July 22 elections (July 24, 2007), I expressed in summary: The achievements in both economy and democracy were rewarded; Turkey said ‘continue on’ to the AKP government under Prime Minister Erdoğan’s leadership.

“The June 12 elections also confirm Turkey’s progress toward establishing liberal and pluralist democracy. No record was broken in voter turnout, but the highest rate of recent years was reached. The rate rose from 79% in 2002 to 85% in 2007, and to 87% now. Voting took place with great maturity; no serious incident was encountered. Voters showed great care in concentrating their votes on parties or independent candidates they believed could enter parliament: Despite the 10% threshold, the rate of wasted votes dropped from 45% in 2002 to 15% in 2007, and to 5% this time. The 24th Term Turkish Grand National Assembly has no representation weakness; 95% of the votes are represented. The number of female deputies rose from 50 to 77; nearly one-third of the target has been reached.

“The AKP government received the reward for its services to the country in economy, democracy, and foreign policy. It raised its vote share from 34% in 2002 to 47% in 2007, and to 50% this time. It was seen that those who work in democracy win. This is a great success that should be celebrated for the AKP, especially for Prime Minister Erdoğan, its architect. The AKP not only received one out of every two votes but also strengthened its standing as the party of all of Turkey, of all regions. With this democratic victory, Turkey shines a light on the entire region, on the entire world. The people of Turkey gave the AKP government strong authority to govern the country for another 4 years, but did not give it the authority to draft alone the new, civilian, and democratic constitution it expected. The AKP’s number of deputies dropped (from 341) to 326. All political and civil society will prepare the new constitution through dialogue and consensus.

“The CHP received only half as many votes as the AKP, but increased its vote share from 20% in 2007 to 26%, and its number of deputies from 112 to 135. It became the party that increased its vote share and number of deputies the most. Kılıçdaroğlu’s policy of removing the CHP from being the party of the military-bureaucratic tutelage regime found serious support. The CHP could have been even more successful if it had not included Sledgehammer and Ergenekon defendants, some hardened

representatives of the tutelage order, in its candidate lists. The MHP, despite all the efforts Prime Minister Erdoğan made to push it below the threshold, despite the ugly tape scandals (it is still unclear who orchestrated them), did not fall below the threshold. I attribute the decrease of its vote share by only one point (from 14% to 13%) to its having become a victim and thus winning the votes of some voters who would not normally vote for the MHP.

“With its ‘Labor, Democracy, Freedom Bloc’ policy, the BDP, which nominated socialist Turks as well as conservative, religious Kurds, managed to increase its number of representatives in the Turkish Grand National Assembly from 20 in 2007 to 31. The Kurdish-majority region strongly showed its support for democratic struggle, not violence. Let us hope that the BDP taking an important role in drafting a constitution that will also respond to Kurds’ demands will be a major step toward defeating the war lobbies and Turkey solving its problems in a civilized manner, through dialogue and consensus. The overwhelming majority of Turkey approves of Prime Minister Erdoğan’s ‘balcony speech’ on the evening of June 12 and expects him to remain committed to the promises made there.” (*Zaman*, 14.6.2011)

Erdoğan can achieve peace and go down in history

It could be said that after the June 12, 2011 elections, my suspicions that Erdoğan “might want to be Putin” had dissipated, and my optimism about our future as a country had peaked. I wrote:

“The Justice and Development Party under Prime Minister Erdoğan’s leadership won a historic electoral victory on June 12. It became the first party in the history of our multi-party system to win an election by increasing its votes for the third time. The Prime Minister built his election campaign on the slogan ‘Turkey is ready, target 2023.’ He set himself the goal of making Turkey one of the world’s most advanced democracies and one of the ten most developed economies on the Republic’s 100th anniversary. This goal can definitely be achieved, but unfortunately Turkey is not yet ready for it, because its fundamental problem, the Kurdish problem, awaits a solution. Yes, the denial of Kurds has ended; but neither have the democratic demands of Kurds been met, nor has the PKK laid down arms. Without achieving these, Turkey can never reach the goals Mr. Prime Minister has set his heart on.

”On June 12, the people of Turkey from almost every segment gave Prime Minister Erdoğan and the AKP government very strong support—seldom given to any government in democracies—to achieve the 2023 goals. Now they expect something in return. There is a historic opportunity before the Prime Minister: The people of Turkey in this election said ‘Absolutely no!’ to the military-bureaucratic tutelage that would tie the government’s hands and trip it up, to authoritarian Kemalism. But the overwhelming majority is ready to support a new Republic faithful to what Mr. Prime Minister said in his ‘balcony speech’ on the night of June 12—the ‘founding philosophy of the Republic’ followed by ‘Gazi Mustafa Kemal and his friends’ between 1919-1923. As clearly seen in this election, both Turkish nationalists who reject coexistence and want to forcibly impose Turkish identity on Kurds, and Kurdish nationalists who seek a separate state,

are only a very small portion of Turkey's society. The overwhelming majority of the people of Turkey are in favor of becoming free and prosperous in peace.

"The cadre under Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu's leadership is working for the main opposition party CHP to be freed from military-bureaucratic tutelage and to commit to the principles of liberal and pluralist democracy. Mr. Kılıçdaroğlu said in Diyarbakır, 'There is a Kurdish problem and your brother Kemal will solve this problem… Whatever the cost, we will bring peace…' He even mentioned the declaration of a general political amnesty in exchange for the PKK laying down arms. He proposed the establishment of a commission in the new Turkish Grand National Assembly composed of wise men from all parties who would not make the issue a matter of political contention, and that this commission should talk with Abdullah Öcalan if needed. Despite making such a great intellectual renewal, the CHP under Kılıçdaroğlu's leadership received approval from voters and increased its votes. Kılıçdaroğlu is ready for 'reconciliation' after the election; he tells the Prime Minister 'my door is open.' Had he not made the mistake of nominating Ergenekon defendants, perhaps he would have received even more votes.

"Former BDP chairman Selahattin Demirtaş said the following on June 13: 'Now we can open the paths to peace. For this, in all constitutional discussions, in all solutions, we are the interlocutors, the elected politicians… For this war to stop, negotiations with Mr. Öcalan must continue, direct talks must be held with the PKK, which is one side of this war. The government should not avoid this. We politicians are also ready to support this.' (*Zaman*, June 14) PKK leader Abdullah Öcalan attributes the Kurdish problem to 'departing from the founding philosophy at the beginning of the Republic.' 'The constitution of the Republic of Turkey accepts the democratic existence and expression of all cultures… Let them put this sentence in the constitution, and within two months the PKK will lay down arms,' he says. (See Yıldıray Oğur, *Taraf*, June 14.)

"There is a historic opportunity before Prime Minister Erdoğan: By talking and reaching consensus with all parties, by making the constitution of 'Turk, Kurd, Zaza, Arab, Circassian, Roma, Alevi, Sunni, minorities, that is, 74 million' that he promised from the balcony on June 12, he can go down in history as the leader who brought Turkey to peace and tranquility." (*Zaman*, 16.6.2011)

What is happening in Turkish foreign policy?

By 2011, I also maintained optimism about the foreign policy pursued by the AKP, whose architect was Ahmet Davutoğlu. With these arguments:

"Recently I've been inundated with foreign visitors. Just last week, the common question of academics, analysts, and diplomats from Spain, the USA, Greece, Japan, and even Australia was: What is happening in Turkish foreign policy? My readers might be curious about my answer to them. In summary: Throughout the Cold War, Turkey's foreign policy was almost entirely indexed to the West; it was based on the principles of commitment to the NATO alliance and the goal of integration with Europe. With the end of the Cold War, the perception that its value to the Western alliance had diminished, the beginning of questioning its human rights and democracy performance by allies, and falling far

behind in the queue for EU membership led to a period of confusion in Ankara that would last about ten years. This was overcome with the AKP government. The ‘zero problems with neighbors’ policy, designed by Ahmet Davutoğlu and envisaging adaptation to post-Cold War regional and global conditions, was adopted.

”The ‘zero problems’ policy, based on the liberal principles of solving problems through dialogue and increasing mutual economic dependence, had two main goals: to support growth by increasing political and economic relations with regional countries, and to strengthen democracy at home and national security abroad. With these two main objectives, Ankara either resolved or put on the negotiating table its problems with all its neighbors; on the other hand, it tried to help dialogue between problematic parties to reduce the risk of conflict and war in the region. This policy was also inspired by the EU’s ‘neighborhood policy’ and helped Turkey get closer to the EU in every respect: The economy grew, democracy advanced, Turkey became a source of inspiration for its region.

“The ‘zero problems’ policy included rapprochement not only between governments but also between peoples. Through trade, tourism, cultural exchange, television series, and so on, societies drew closer to each other. Everywhere, but especially in the Arab World, Turkey’s image changed fundamentally. The image of a Turkey whose economy and democracy were strengthening under a Muslim Democrat government, which did not turn its back on the Islamic world, which started accession negotiations with the EU, which could say no to the USA, which had the courage to remind Israel of its mistakes, turned positive in the Arab street. Turkey as a source of inspiration has a ‘contribution’ to the Arab Spring.

”However, the Arab Spring (the collapse of authoritarian regimes in Tunisia, Egypt, Libya, and the appearance that others’ turn would come) is reshuffling the cards in the region. It could be said that the Arab Spring is causing as fundamental a change in environment/context for Turkish foreign policy as the end of the Cold War. In this new period, Ankara is turning to emphasize the role of ‘Turkey as a focus of democracy and secularism in the Middle East,’ which Prime Minister Erdoğan signaled in his visits to Arab Spring countries. However, to play this role, it must solve the Kurdish-PKK problem; it must implement the state that stands equidistant from all beliefs, including atheists, which it proposes to Arab Spring countries.

“I don’t think Ankara’s foreign policy disturbs sensible Western governments. Is Ankara doing wrong as the only member of the Western alliance keeping dialogue channels with Tehran open? Do you think Washington is not in some way pleased that it is the only member of the Western alliance that finds the courage to remind the Israeli government of its mistakes? Would you prefer the Arab Street to respect Tehran or Ankara? If Muammar Gaddafi and Bashar Assad didn’t listen, was it wrong for Ankara to invite them to reason? If Turkey establishes a ‘democracy axis’ with emerging Arab democracies, will this be to the detriment of Western allies? Finally, if there is a deadlock in Turkey-EU relations today, is Ankara mainly responsible for this, or is it Mr. Sarkozy, Ms. Merkel, and the Southern Cyprus governments who rely on them?” (*Zaman*, 3.11.2011)

Should the government return to its ‘apprenticeship’ period?

It could be said that during roughly the first ten years of its rule, I had given substantial support to the AKP government with the hope that it would lead Turkey to liberal and pluralist democracy and eventually EU membership, and my criticisms had been limited to its policies on issues such as media, environment, and energy. From the end of 2011, however, I began to criticize the AKP government in my writings with increasing intensity, out of concern that it was taking the country toward one-man rule. In the article titled “Should the government return to its apprenticeship period,” I said:

“Politicians not keeping their word, displaying inconsistencies, falling short of expectations is probably not a situation unique to Turkey. Of course, they cannot be expected to act like intellectuals, to follow the rule of saying and doing what they believe to be right. Politicians have vote calculations to come to power and stay there. This is also in the nature of democracy. All this is true, but in Turkey, politicians’ failure to keep their word, their inconsistencies, their falling short of expectations are exceeding reasonable limits. This, unfortunately, casts a shadow over the respectability of the institution of politics (which actually increased with the AKP government). What has happened since the June 12 elections is in this direction.

“The most striking example is the AKP government’s attitude of leaving the new constitution to ‘another spring’ after entering the last elections with the promise of a civilian and democratic constitution and receiving half of the votes. Another example is the parliament’s inertia on issues concerning the majority of society, especially democratization reforms, while achieving unanimity around common interests (such as changing the match-fixing law, doubling retired deputies’ salaries).

“In his speech on behalf of the government at the end of the budget discussions last week, Deputy Prime Minister Bülent Arınç made a hopeful statement for those who want liberal and pluralist democracy. He said, ‘The existence of Kurds has been a fact for at least a thousand years. You cannot deny this. We will give to a person who says I am Kurdish all the rights to life, knowledge, education, language, culture, identity—as much as all of us, at least as much as all of us in this country…’ However, unfortunately, this statement was perceived by many not as a sign of the government’s serious intention, but as Arınç’s announcement of his candidacy for the party leadership once Erdoğan was elected president. The MHP spokespersons’ remarks accusing Arınç of ‘negligence and treason’ reminded us how empty the claim of making a constitution with full consensus is.

“Last week, Deputy Prime Minister Beşir Atalay also made a hopeful statement for those who want liberal and pluralist democracy. While answering the press’s questions before the Counter-Terrorism session organized at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, he said the government was working on legal changes that would ensure the free expression of non-violent views. Before the ‘ink of Atalay’s words had dried,’ Interior Minister İdris Naim Şahin came out and, as if the breadth of the terror definition in the laws were not the most important problem of freedom of expression in Turkey, brought a definition of terror so broad that it could lead to any view and even activity being accused of

terrorism, the kind of breadth seen only in police states: ‘There is psychological terror, there is scientific terror, there is a backyard feeding terror… How does one give (support to terror)? Perhaps by painting, reflecting it on canvas; by writing poetry, reflecting it in their poetry; by writing daily articles, columns, writing and drawing things there…’ And more such appalling words. (Please see: *Radikal*, December 26) I wonder how much longer a person who can say these words will be kept in that position.

“The most noteworthy development of last week was the statements of Ayhan Çarkın, convicted in the Susurluk case. Çarkın, who had been making statements for some time about murders committed by the gang within the state, said in his meeting with Hüseyin Aygün, the CHP member of the Turkish Grand National Assembly Human Rights Commission (who said Dersim was ‘not a rebellion but a massacre’), that ‘prime ministers, high-ranking figures’ whose names he gave were aware of the Susurluk gang’s extrajudicial executions; that a team of 150 people is still on duty in the Police Special Operations Branch, not just carrying out executions. (*Taraf*, December 28) Prime Minister Erdoğan promised on various occasions that the fight against gangs within the state would be carried out to the end. For this promise and the ones related to reforms to be fulfilled, should Erdoğan and the AKP government perhaps abandon mastery and return to the apprenticeship period? This is the question being asked more and more.” (*Zaman*, 29.12.2011)

Party of the arrogant, not the aggrieved

On the night of December 28, 2011, in the village of Ortasu (Kurdish: Roboski) in the Uludere district of Şırnak, 34 civilians, 28 from the same family, were killed as a result of bombardment by the Turkish Air Force. Official authorities announced that the dead were a smuggler convoy of Kurdish citizens bringing diesel and cigarettes from Iraq to Turkey. The General Staff announced after the incident that it had been decided to strike the identified group because it was using routes used by the PKK. In the article I wrote about the incident, I said:

“It is true that the tragedy in Uludere unfortunately divided the country in terms of mood. Not a trace of the solidarity shown in the Van earthquake was seen. If this were a civilized country or a country with emotional unity between its west and east, where Kurds were not discriminated against, mourning could have been declared. Not only was that not the case, but the government did not even apologize to the families of the dead, let alone the people. Most of the media (presumably in light of instructions given from the Prime Minister to the ‘shop owners’) delayed reporting the incident and tried to minimize it. The (absolutely inexcusable) attack on the district governor was found almost more important than 35 young people being killed by bombing. The MHP leader went so far as to say, ‘The state did what was necessary…’

”You might say that the PKK on one hand, and the state on the other, disregarding human life for years; killing by shooting, by bombing, has numbed feelings against killing. You might say that the bombing of smuggler villagers, mistaken for PKK militants preparing to attack soldiers, was seen as somewhat forgivable. But as a society, will we surrender to re-escalating violence, will we again forget humanity? If those who died had

been PKK militants rather than villagers, would there have been celebrations? If bandits kill one, must the state kill five? Is the main thing for a democratic government not to ensure that people live? Wasn't the state supposedly no longer killing ruthlessly, approaching even militants with compassion? Morally, what is the difference between PKK terrorists saying 'we thought they were police' after shooting young girls and the state saying 'we thought they were terrorists' after bombing young men?

"Perhaps the most serious aspect of the Uludere tragedy is the deep shaking of trust in the Prime Minister and government among citizens committed to liberal and humane values, who had hoped they would go down in history by solving the Kurdish problem and ending violence. When AKP Diyarbakır Deputy Galip Ensarioğlu said, 'We have responsibility for every drop of blood shed here. If this is not stopping, it is because of our incompetence… The Prime Minister cannot go up to the Presidential Palace and be at peace before this is finished. Going to the Palace will have no meaning either…' (*Taraf*, January 2), is he not expressing the crisis of confidence the Prime Minister and government have created in their own party? Do the words of some AKP members, 'we have become the party of the arrogant, not the aggrieved…,' not reflect the same crisis of confidence?

"Look at what Ümit Fırat, a Kurdish intellectual committed to liberal and humane values, says: 'It would be bad if this incident is blamed on the AK Party. People will say, what is the difference from Tansu Çiller's government in 1993. They must not cover up the incident, but find those responsible and ensure they are punished. This is now a test. They must take actions that will make amends to society. Even if they cannot completely erase the traces of this incident, at least they can convince society that today is not like the past. Otherwise, it would be a pity. Because there is no other party in Turkey that gives hope to people, to society…' (*Star*, January 2) Don't Fırat's words reflect the great disappointment experienced in society?

"Prime Minister Tayyip Erdoğan is a leader to whom at least half of society, both Turkish and Kurdish, pins its hopes. This hope must not be broken. A 'Blair syndrome' should not be experienced. Prof. Dr. Erhun Kula, faculty member at Bahçeşehir University, recalled the possibility of it happening in an article (*Taraf*, December 19) as follows: 'I liken Prime Minister Erdoğan to former British Prime Minister Tony Blair. Both are highly eloquent, religious, and charismatic figures. Both rendered great services to their countries. Blair modernized the Labour Party, which had become a dinosaur. For the first time in the party's history, he won elections three times in a row. The economy grew unprecedentedly. Unemployment decreased greatly. Perhaps most importantly, Blair resolved the Northern Ireland problem. But Blair made one mistake: following George W. Bush, he dragged Britain into the Iraq war and eventually had to leave both the prime ministership and politics with a great loss of reputation.' Yes, is there anyone left today who remembers Blair's achievements?" ("Let there not be a Blair syndrome," *Zaman*, 5.1.2012)

Are only soldiers responsible for coups?

Since 2008, cases have been opened against hundreds of officers on charges of attempted coups. In an article I wrote on this subject, I felt the need to remind readers that not only soldiers but also their civilian supporters were responsible for coup attempts, and that none of us had a clean record in terms of commitment to liberal democracy:

“Since 2008, hundreds of active and retired officers, including a former chief of general staff and two former force commanders, are being tried in cases opened on charges of coup attempts, primarily Ergenekon, Sledgehammer, and Internet Memorandum. Last week, those who actually carried out a coup were added to these—retired generals Kenan Evren and Tahsin Şahinkaya, the main responsible parties for the September 12 coup. If cases are soon opened against retired generals responsible for the February 28, 1997 post-modern coup and the April 27, 2007 e-memorandum, no one will be surprised.

“That soldiers who carried out coups or allegedly attempted coups by violating the constitution and laws are finally being held accountable is certainly an important stage in the liquidation of the military tutelage system. In this context, we often repeat that the military tutelage system can only end with the liquidation of tutelage powers granted to soldiers in the constitution and laws, and with the restructuring of the regime on the foundations of liberal and pluralist democracy instead of the principles of Kemalism, which means authoritarian secular nationalism. There is no doubt that for these crimes not to be repeated, coup makers and soldiers alleged to have attempted coups must be tried and, if found guilty, sentenced to the punishments they deserve. However, while these trials continue, there are some facts that must not be forgotten. I can list the main ones as follows:

“First, yes, soldiers planned the coups that were successful or remained at the attempt stage until today; therefore, soldiers are primarily responsible for these. However, almost all of them received encouragement and support from civilians. Soldiers were not solely responsible for the coups. Second, both the soldiers who planned coups and coup attempts and the civilians who provided encouragement and support for them did this (yes, partly to protect and develop their privileges, but) essentially for ideological reasons, because of their commitment to Kemalism and militarism.

“Kemalism is essentially based on the belief that the people do not have the maturity for self-governance; that a modern society can only be a mono-cultural society (speaking the same language, attached to the same culture, sharing the same religious beliefs) where religion is confined to consciences. Militarism believes that the country can best be governed by soldiers and that problems can only be solved by force. It is certain that Kemalist militarists (whose numbers we hope are now decreasing) are as prevalent among civilians as among soldiers in Turkey. Until secularist-nationalist militarism is marginalized (as hoped) especially among soldiers, but also among civilians, Turkey cannot be a normal democracy. (I think it is also clear enough that the PKK represents secularist-nationalist militarism among Kurds.)

“Third, until they got slapped by September 12, until the Cold War ended, the great majority of intellectuals in Turkey believed not in liberal and pluralist democracy but in various authoritarian and totalitarian ideologies, in top-down coups or bottom-up revolutions (force and violence). Politicians representing society against the state represented by the military-civilian bureaucracy also essentially understood democracy as ‘national will,’ that is, majority rule. Politicians who believed that democracy means not only majority rule but also that citizens (of all political, ethnic, and religious identities) have fundamental rights and freedoms that cannot be violated by any majority were few enough to count on one’s fingers. In short, perhaps until the 21st century, Turkey was a democracy with very few democrats. In light of what I have listed above, the fourth fact that must not be forgotten is this: As people of Turkey [Türkiyeliler], we are a society that has been learning liberal and pluralist democracy through experience over the last 60 years. When looked at from the perspective of commitment to liberal and pluralist democracy, almost none of us has a clean record.” (*Zaman*, January 21, 2012)

Is the AKP ‘Islamic Kemalist’?

In articles I wrote in early 2012, while I continued to support the AKP government because of practices I found positive, on the other hand, my criticisms of its increasing negative practices were growing more intense:

“I received the following message from one of my foreign readers who follows my English commentary in *Today’s Zaman* from abroad: ‘I am still trying to understand why the situation in Turkey has come to this. Can you understand why the AKP is acting so slowly in changing Kemalist laws and structures? Yet it has been in power long enough to do this. Should we conclude that AKP members are ’Islamic Kemalists’; that because their brains were washed by the ‘strong state’ for a long time, they don’t know how to govern any other way?’

“The answers I gave are briefly as follows: The AKP is a mass party that brings together people of quite different mindsets. But of course, it can be said that the party’s founding and leading cadre has a common mindset. Looking from this cadre’s perspective, the AKP certainly has Islamic sensitivities. Well, can the AKP be called ‘Kemalist’? In most respects no, in some respects yes. From a cultural perspective: The AKP is definitely not Kemalist. Kemalists think religion is an obstacle to development and therefore should be confined to consciences. AKP members, on the other hand, are religious Sunnis and represent some victims of the authoritarian secularist order. However, although Prime Minister Erdoğan defined secularism as the state standing equidistant from all beliefs including atheists during his North Africa trip last September, the AKP government has been able to make very few changes to the Kemalist authoritarian secularist order.

“From an economic perspective: Although Kemalists have moved away from this understanding somewhat, they are essentially statist. The AKP government, however, represents the most liberal economic policies Turkey has seen. In addition, it has also taken some social welfare measures in health and education. This is the main explanation for the AKP’s electoral victories. From a political perspective: Kemalists in principle do not believe in democracy. Forced by circumstances, they at most accepted

democracy under military-bureaucratic tutelage. It is certain that the AKP, like all peripheral parties before it, is committed to democracy in the sense of 'national will,' that is, majority rule. It cannot be denied that the AKP government has made some improvements in both the fundamental rights and freedoms of individuals and the rights of minorities (Kurds and non-Muslims) within the framework of the EU accession process. It can also be said that a significant portion of society (also influenced by opposition parties not inspiring any confidence) still sees the AKP as the only hope for democratization.

"On the other hand, despite ten years of AKP rule, the fact that 'Kemalist laws and structures' largely remain in place can indeed be explained to some extent by 'not knowing how to govern any other way because their brains were washed by the 'strong state' for a long time.' If we start with the Unionists who dominated the late Ottoman period, Turkey underwent nearly a hundred years of statist-secularist-nationalist indoctrination, brainwashing. As a result, Unionist-Kemalist values left deep marks on Turkey's elites. It is possible to see these marks in Turkey's socialists, liberals, Islamists, even Kurdish nationalists, alongside the AKP members I characterize as Muslim Democrats. While it cannot be said that the AKP is statist or secularist, it is true that it has an (Islamic, with a drop of liberalism) nationalist identity.

"Of course, there are also other reasons why 'Kemalist laws and structures' largely remain in place. In this context, rather than the weakening resistance of the bureaucratic tutelage order, what can be underlined is that the AKP has come to believe it has sufficiently adapted the old order to itself to maintain its power—in other words, that it has fallen into the complacency of power. However, I don't think society in Turkey will accept this complacency. If the AKP cannot respond to the quite strong expectation of democratization in society, it will gradually lose power. I don't think an AKP that is becoming Kemalist, that is, becoming authoritarian, can stay in power." (*Zaman*, January 26, 2012)

When I read this article ten years later, it did cross my mind that I might have been right.

Religious freedom and the "transparency" issue

In my article commenting on the US Congress report stating that religious freedoms were being systematically and visibly violated in Turkey, I drew attention to how authoritarian secularism practices and restrictions on freedom of belief were driving religious communities to avoid transparency. This article was an indirect response to the criticism of "lacking transparency" directed at the Gülen community, which published the *Zaman* newspaper. I said:

"The United States Commission on International Religious Freedom counted Turkey among the 16 'countries of particular concern' in its 2012 report on the grounds that it violated religious freedoms 'systematically and visibly.' Yet in the Commission's 2008 report, Turkey was in the 'under review' category, and in 2009 in the 'monitored' category. Yet Turkey had been praised in the US State Department's religious freedom report published last year 'for the steps it took to develop an environment of religious tolerance.' The Turkish Foreign Ministry reacted harshly to the report: 'This report, which

deliberately ignores the steps taken forward in recent times and the political will that forms the basis of the reforms made… is null and void for us,' it said. Meanwhile, it also emerged that although 5 of the Commission's 9 members voted against, and Turkey should have been removed from the 'countries of particular concern' category when one of them changed their opinion, the report was published in its original form.

"Does Turkey have a place among the 16 'countries of particular concern'; frankly, I don't have the comparative knowledge to decide on this. It is true that there have been some improvements in the rights granted to non-Muslims in the last few years. However, like everyone else, I know that restrictions on religious freedoms that are absolutely incompatible with democratic order continue in Turkey. If you like, let me remind you again of just the main ones. According to Kemalism's authoritarian understanding of secularism, which considers religion, especially Islam, as 'reactionism,' there is no separation of religion and state in Turkey; there is a state monopoly and control over religion.

"Citizens of all faiths must finance the Directorate of Religious Affairs, which represents official Sunni-Hanafi Islam, with the taxes they pay. Advocating taking the Directorate outside the administration is grounds for closure for political parties. The Directorate controls all mosques; it sends Friday sermons from the center. Other belief groups receive not a penny of help from the state. Alevis have only been able to open their places of worship, the cemevis, for the last twenty years; however, their ability to obtain permits is still subject to municipalities' arbitrary permission. Like Alevis, Apostolic, Catholic and Protestant Armenian, Greek Orthodox, Syriac, Catholic and Protestant churches, Jews, Bahai, Yazidi, Shia, Jafari and other religious groups also have no legal guarantees; they are all subject to arbitrary practices of the state and politics.

"Although the vast majority of Sunnis believe in Sufi Islam and belong to Sufi orders and the communities that evolved from them over time and new religious movements, Sufi orders have been legally banned since 1925; threats and pressures on believers continue. The headscarf is banned not only in all public buildings including parliament but in all schools; it has only been effectively free in universities for a year or two. According to the 'Unification of Education' Law, religious education (including of clergy) is a state monopoly. Contrary to the European Convention on Human Rights, families are not granted the right to ensure their children receive the kind of religious education they wish. The justification for almost all the military coups carried out or attempted since 1960 has been the fight against 'separatism' (meaning the expression of Kurdish identity) and 'reactionism' (meaning the expression of Islamic identity). Parties with no connection to violence and racism but with Islamic sensitivities were closed; in this context, even the ruling party AKP, which received half of the people's votes, was left under threat of closure.

"Just as religious freedoms are restricted, due to pressures and threats, citizens still hesitate to reveal their religious identities. Alevis hid their beliefs until the last twenty years. Those who discover they are originally Armenian are only recently showing the courage to be baptized and join a church. Forget Alevis and non-Muslims, there are Sunnis who feel the need to hide which religious community they belong to. Setting

aside that religious freedom is not secure, I just laugh at the secularists who keep demanding ‘be transparent!’ of religious communities.” (March 29, 2012)

It is certain that the AKP government took some steps toward removing restrictions on religious freedoms. Fortunately, in 2022 when these lines are being written, such an absurdity as the “headscarf ban” in schools and parliament no longer exists in majority Sunni Muslim Turkey. Alevis have also made some progress in opening their cemevis. But there is still a long way to go for religious freedom to be established and for the regime to become secular.

Democracy is not just “national will”

The AKP government’s democracy report card was getting worse and worse. How could this be explained? On this subject, I wrote the following:

“… I expressed in many articles the AKP government’s contributions to the economy, democracy, and the country’s respectability. These services were possible thanks to a single-party government that could be established after the coalition governments of the 1990s that had sunk the country in every field by squabbling with each other, and a prime minister at its head who had more support than even his party. However, in its tenth year, the reforms that brought the AKP government its successes almost completely stopped, and its democracy report card began to deteriorate.

”How can this be explained? According to one theory, Prime Minister Erdoğan focused on the goal of being elected President in 2014; for this, he built his game plan on maintaining the balances as they were. According to another theory, because the AKP government could not manage to bring the military-civilian bureaucracy under its control, it turned to reconciling with it (without taking into account that the tutelage advocates’ audacity could increase); it gradually ‘became Kemalist.’ According to yet another theory, the weaknesses in the AKP government’s understanding of democracy began to show themselves.

“The last of these theories, all of which could be valid together, is worth dwelling on. The cornerstone of the weaknesses in the AKP government’s understanding of democracy is the mentality that sees democracy as identical only to ‘national will,’ to majority rule—a mentality also seen in all previous ruling parties (DP, AP, ANAP) that claimed to represent popular sovereignty against the bureaucracy’s tutelage. Yet democracy is the regime in which the right to govern belongs to the party or parties that have the majority’s vote, but also in which governments are checked and balanced by the opposition so they don’t make mistakes; in which citizens have fundamental rights and freedoms that cannot be violated by any majority.

”One of the recent examples displaying the weakness in the AKP’s understanding of democracy is the education reform proposal. A reform of this scale should have been brought to Parliament after consulting all relevant parties, and it should have been possible for the opposition to criticize it using all means in Parliament. Another example

is the destruction caused by the insistence that Newroz celebrations must be held on March 21.

“Democracy cannot function without a media that reports and comments freely. One of the AKP government’s most fundamental mistakes is its policy of bringing the media under control through ‘shop owners’ instead of passing laws that would secure the independence of journalism from the state, government, and bosses. Yes, like people from all professions, journalists can also commit crimes, and there may be journalists in Turkey who have become involved with terrorist organizations and coup attempts. But if laws that provide for the prosecution and punishment of individuals as if they were members of illegal organizations even though they are not remain in place, one cannot speak of the rule of law. This government rendered a very great service to this country by ending the denial of Kurdish identity. But reforms toward recognizing Kurdish identity stopped; it started negotiations with the PKK to ensure it lays down arms, but signals that it was again leaning toward a ‘military solution’ intensified.

”Yes, even in its strongest period, the AKP government’s mistakes are increasing. Hopes now rest on what Amberin Zaman reminded us of: ‘Still, I keep my hope. Because one of the characteristics that makes Prime Minister Erdoğan and the AK Party strong is their ability to turn around very quickly and make radical decisions. They took steps that no government dared; they can take them again. They must. After all, everyone with reason and conscience knows that Turkey can neither achieve real democracy nor peace without solving the Kurdish problem.’ ” (*Zaman*, 22.3.2012)

Prolonged power exhausts, wears down

Following Prime Minister Erdoğan’s launch of the “Let’s switch to a presidential system” campaign, I had started writing articles reminding readers of the problems this could cause for the country. In an article that ended with “Prime Minister Erdoğan has rendered very great services to this country. But apparently, prolonged power exhausts, wears down leaders…,” I said:

“The ‘Let’s switch to a presidential system’ campaign that started with Prime Minister Erdoğan’s encouragement is spreading. Deputy Prime Minister Bekir Bozdağ, who took over the standard-bearing from Constitutional Commission Chairman Burhan Kuzu, has already declared that Turkey will ‘inevitably’ switch to an (American-type) presidential system… However, opposition parties are against the presidential system. Since it is certain that a significant portion of the AKP group will also oppose this in a secret ballot, this campaign may be, as CHP chairman Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu said, an ‘artificial agenda.’ But since the Prime Minister wants it, of course it should be discussed.

“There are essentially three types of government system: the parliamentary system that developed in Britain through an evolution whose roots go back to the Magna Carta of 1215; the presidential system established by the USA, which gained independence from Britain in 1776; and the semi-presidential system invented by France in 1958 (which is a mixture of the first two). It is quite possible to access information on the principles, advantages, and disadvantages of these systems. Undoubtedly, every country adopts a

system according to its needs; if it doesn't work, it changes it. What must not be forgotten is that the governance system is determined not only by the government system but also by the electoral system (proportional representation, majority system, or mixed).

"In our country, a truly 'monstrous' system that mixes the parliamentary system with the semi-presidential system—brought by the September 12 military administration with the aim of reinforcing the military-bureaucratic tutelage order—and on top of that places a proportional representation system with a 10 percent threshold, has been in effect since 1982. With the AKP government's constitutional amendment in 2007 introducing the principle of electing the president by popular vote, the system became even more monstrous. However, switching to a semi-presidential or presidential system on the grounds that the system should be freed from monstrousness probably cannot be meaningful.

"What is meaningful is not Prime Minister Erdoğan's remaining in power until 2024 with a new constitution, but diagnosing and establishing the government and electoral system that will secure democracy in Turkey. My view, which I have expressed in countless articles regarding this debate that has been going on for at least thirty years, is clear: The system suitable for Turkey, where the culture of compromise is weak and political, religious, and ethnic divisions are numerous, is the parliamentary system where the executive emerges from the legislature. In presidential systems, if the popularly elected president and the parliamentary majority belong to different parties, governance can face serious deadlocks, it can become unable to make decisions. (Just imagine what could happen to us in an environment where the president is from the AKP and parliament has an opposition majority…) Another drawback of presidential systems that we cannot ignore is the tendency to divide society in two and polarize it.

"Yes, there is a need for a strong executive in Turkey. For the reasons mentioned above, a strong executive exists not in presidential systems but in the parliamentary system. (The solution of the Kurdish problem also depends not on the government system but on whether there is political will on this matter.) Yes, besides political stability, achieving justice in representation and freeing parties from leader domination are important needs of ours. The way to this is to adopt a two-round majority system where a single candidate is elected from each single-member district. We have really suffered much from proportional representation that gives birth to coalition governments.

"Presidential systems do not serve our democratization. Don't Prime Minister Erdoğan's recent attitudes also show this? The Prime Minister has begun to see the people of Turkey as a flock in need of herding and himself as their shepherd. For this, he has begun to intervene in every issue that doesn't concern him, from art to sports, from theater to abortion, to what the media should or shouldn't write. Finally, his saying that Turkey faces international conspiracies from Uludere to births has come to resemble 'old Turkey's' discourse of blaming 'internal-external enemies' for problems. Prime Minister Erdoğan has rendered very great services to this country. But apparently, prolonged power exhausts, wears down leaders." ("Why presidentialism doesn't suit us," *Zaman*, 22.03.2012)

The partnership between Kemalists and Islamists

As the AKP's authoritarian tendency advanced, I was finding common aspects uniting Kemalists and Islamists that were much more interesting and in need of explanation than the well-known 'tension' between them.

"… Former NSC Secretary General and Ergenekon case defendant retired Gen. Tuncer Kılınç was saying: 'May God have abundant mercy on him, Erbakan was a nationalist leader. We couldn't understand him correctly, soldiers didn't understand Erbakan correctly.' (*Yeni Akit*, April 1) Retired Maj. Gen. Osman Özbek, who had openly cursed Prime Minister Erbakan, repented and spoke thus: 'If only we had understood the National View. If only those days had never happened. I really value the National View's fight against imperialism and its upright stance.' (*Samanyolu Haber*, March 23)

"… The most important indicator of the partnership between positivist and secularist Kemalists and a certain understanding of Islam is undoubtedly that the Republic, which claims to have separated religion and state, actually has an unofficial religion, and this is represented by the Directorate of Religious Affairs, which monopolizes and controls Islam with the task of 'ensuring national unity.' The question of why most religious Muslims in Turkey are nationalist and statist, why they share with Kemalists the view on the Kurdish issue, the Armenian issue, and other matters, may have roots extending to Ottoman and even pre-Islamic Turkish history. It is possible to find the analysis of this in the extraordinarily important study of our teacher Prof. Dr. Şerif Mardin, who sheds light on many issues related to religion in Turkey, titled 'Turkish Islamic Exceptionalism Yesterday and Today: Continuity, Rupture and Reconstruction in Operational Codes' (*Turkish Studies*, Vol. 6, No. 2, June 2005, pp. 145-165)…

"Mardin says that the characteristics of Islam in Turkey derive from the interaction between the positivist modernism of the Ottoman-Republican bureaucracy and the innovative Islamic interpretation of the Naqshbandi order. In an interview he gave on this analysis, he underlines the following points: Throughout its history, the Ottoman Empire was careful not to keep religion away from the state. For Arabs, religion comes before the state. For Turks, however, the state has been more important than religion since the pre-Islamic period. 'When I say the Turkish exception, this is what I mean.' (*Asharq Alawsat*, December 12, 2007)

"It can be said that the transformation of the tension between Kemalists and religious Muslims in Turkey into a partnership in statism and nationalism finds its best expression in the Turkish-Islamic synthesis ideology, which is also the ideology of the September 12 regime…" ("Where are the roots of Islamic Kemalism?" *Zaman*, 19.4.2012)

"Where is the AKP government going?"

By the middle of 2012, I no longer had any doubt that the AKP government was taking Turkey toward authoritarian one-man rule. However, I maintained my optimism and thought Erdoğan would not succeed in realizing his ambitions. I wrote:

“The Justice and Development Party (AKP) government is the most successful of the governments established in the multi-party period. It performed great services in ten years. It at least doubled the average income. It pushed back military-bureaucratic tutelage. It ended the denial of Kurdish identity. It sought to end PKK violence through dialogue. It started membership negotiations with the EU. It made Turkey a country cited as an example in many respects in the international community. The two most important factors that brought these successes were: The ‘Reformist’ cadre within the Welfare Party (RP), headed by Tayyip Erdoğan, learned from criticisms. When founding the AKP, they took off their ‘Islamist shirt’ and acquired a Conservative Democrat identity (similar to Christian Democrats). They listened to the people’s demands for freedom and democracy; they charted their course accordingly. Thus, they came to power with 34%, gradually climbing to 50%.

“Their military-bureaucratic tutelage-supporting opponents resorted to every means to bring down the AKP from power. They claimed it would turn Turkey into Iran, and when that wasn’t convincing, into Russia. They attempted coups. When that failed, they tried to have the party closed by the Constitutional Court. When Turkey-Israel relations deteriorated after the Mavi Marmara, the Israel lobby also threw its weight everywhere behind efforts to distort the reality of the AKP. Despite all these attempts to trip it up, the support it received from freedom and democracy supporters played a major role in the AKP government’s success. The exposure and bringing to trial of coup attempts was possible thanks to the media with editorial independence, primarily the *Taraf* newspaper.

“However, since the last general elections held last June, since the announcement that it had entered the ‘Mastery’ period, the AKP government step by step took on an unrecognizable identity. Prime Minister Erdoğan’s discourse roughly became: ‘The national will, the nation is me… The people don’t know their interest, I know. I decide who gets contracts, what the media writes… I know football, art, theater, religion, abortion, cesarean section best… Criticizing a government that received half the people’s votes means not wanting Turkey’s development, falling for foreigners’ game, it is treason…’ With this discourse, expected reforms toward democratization completely stopped. It began to be said, ‘Denial is over, assimilation is also over. There is no Kurdish problem, there is a PKK problem…’ Instead of ending PKK violence through dialogue, there began to be talk of ‘minimizing’ it. Journalists writing critical articles began to be fired through Erdoğan’s ‘shop owners.’ The Interior Minister, speaking like the MHP, declared the victims of the Uludere bombing guilty. The question of whether Erdoğan wanted a new constitution that wouldn’t bring some kind of presidential system made it doubtful whether a democratic constitution would be made.

“Where might this reversal, this authoritarian tendency observed in Prime Minister Erdoğan and the AKP government stem from? Various theories are being put forward in this context: 1) Erdoğan now says ‘I am the state… Anyone who criticizes me is Turkey’s enemy…’ because he dominates the military-civilian bureaucracy and has consolidated his power. 2) He absolutely wants to be elected president. For this, he wants to win MHP votes with a nationalist-conservative cooperation strategy. 3) He abandoned his democratism and embraced conservatism; he is returning to RP Islamism. 4) Inflated

self-confidence, insistence on one-man rule, the sycophants around him have gone to his head. 5) His physical and mental health is not in order.

“Well, where does this course take the AKP? In my opinion, if Erdoğan doesn’t learn from criticisms and put himself and his circle in order, this course will sooner or later bring down the AKP from power. Even Erdoğan’s election as president would be endangered. Well, where does Turkey go? With its economy and civil society growing stronger through Erdoğan’s achievements; with its media that doesn’t hold back from criticism; with its people who increasingly know the world and demand freedom and democracy, Turkey will not tolerate authoritarianism. Even a portion of the AKP will not accept this.” (*Zaman*, June 5, 2012)

What an illusion I was living in… At least until 2022, when these lines are being written, society in Turkey tolerated authoritarianism perfectly well: The majority of society didn’t care about authoritarianism as long as the economic situation was going well. It was seen that if the AKP were to lose power, it would lose because of bankrupt economic policies that raised inflation to at least 70% in 2022.

Government - Community fight?

In my first commentary written on allegations that there was a fight between the AKP government and the Gülen Community, I said:

“Let me come to the claims that the Specially Authorized Courts (ÖYM) debate reflects ‘the latest stage of the fight between the government and the community’—claims adopted even by people whose logic I trusted until recently. The claim is in summary: The ‘Fethullah Gülen community’ has taken over the police and judiciary. All or most of the ÖYM prosecutors and judges belong to this community and act on instructions they receive, with evidence produced by police belonging to the community. The Ergenekon and Sledgehammer prosecutions are based on fake evidence fabricated by community members. The government has also begun to be disturbed by the ÖYMs. Even the MIT Undersecretary, whom it trusted greatly, being summoned to testify as a suspect increased the Prime Minister’s anger.

“When those who say the evidence in the Ergenekon and Sledgehammer cases is fabricated are asked for evidence for their claims about the community, their answer is: Well, the ‘community media’ defends the ÖYMs… Well, is it only the ‘community media’ that finds these cases credible? Is it only the ‘community media’ that opposes the abolition of the ÖYMs? Can’t those who write in the ‘community media’ be concerned that the abolition of ÖYMs could lead to coup attempters escaping justice? Does the claim that all or most of the ÖYM prosecutors and judges belong to the ‘community’ and act on instructions accord with reason and logic? Isn’t this disrespect for the personalities of the said prosecutors and judges? Isn’t it logical to look for the source of the justified complaints caused by ÖYMs in the authoritarian judicial culture that prioritizes the state’s interests over citizens’ fundamental rights?

“When I ask these questions, I conclude that the claims of ‘government - community fight’ carry no meaning beyond being another manifestation of the secularist mentality. I

am not a legal scholar, but I am a social scientist. I have been following the Gülen movement, a faith-based civil society movement, for years. I am committed to the values of freedom and democracy. This is the conclusion I have reached." (*Zaman*, 14.06.2012)

As can be understood from this commentary, I was striving to defend the Community against any and all criticism, on the grounds that it was being unjustly accused by "secularists." After years have passed, after what has befallen us, I must confess today that I had fallen quite far from objectivity on this matter. Probably for this reason: I thought that if there really was a Government - Community fight, I should take the Community's side. Because the AKP government was taking the country toward an authoritarian regime; if the Community was opposing it, it was playing a positive role.

Erdoğan and Gül should switch places

How could Prime Minister Erdoğan's taking the country toward an authoritarian regime be prevented?.. I had a proposal completely detached from reality: I was proposing that Erdoğan become President and leave the prime ministership to Abdullah Gül. As follows:

"Ankara seems focused on the presidential election to be held two years from now. According to what I hear from my Ankara friends, in the AKP it is viewed as certain that the Prime Minister will be elected president in two years. When he goes up to Çankaya, the question of who will head the AKP, who will be prime minister, who will go where in the new administration has become a more important issue than all of Turkey's other problems. And while urgent reforms are needed in every field, Turkey is wasting precious time. The Prime Minister may think he will secure his ascent to Çankaya by preserving the status quo as is. Yet wasn't it being the leader who changed the status quo and pioneered renewal that got him the votes of half the people, including Kurds? If he loses this identity and holds back from reforms, as I have written before, he may not be elected President in two years. Don't trust polls. This people can change its preference quickly…

"I'm thinking, the Constitutional Court, by interpreting Abdullah Gül's term as 7 years, made a decision that was wrong legally and negative politically. If it had made the correct interpretation, we would have elected a new President this summer. Erdoğan and Gül could have agreed between themselves; Erdoğan could have gone up to Çankaya, Gül could have been elected deputy in a by-election and become prime minister. This opportunity was missed. What a pity. Gül's election as president was in a way a waste of talent; the government weakened. But Gül won the trust of people from all segments at Çankaya. Finding a way for Erdoğan and Gül to switch places, and without delay, would be very auspicious." (13.9.2012)

Looking back, I think that yes, I fell very far from reality, but I wasn't wrong at all. If Gül had become Prime Minister while Erdoğan went up to Çankaya, what befell us might not have happened.

Does Putinism fit Turkey?

In the face of Erdoğan's increasing turn toward Putinism, I was asking 'Does Putinism fit Turkey?'

"Domestic and foreign opponents put forward the claim that when Erdoğan and the AKP first came to power, they were practicing 'taqiyya,' that they were secret Islamists who wanted to make Turkey like Iran. When the absurdity of this claim became apparent, they developed a different claim: Erdoğan wanted to be Putin, to take Turkey toward an authoritarian regime similar to Russia's. When I encountered these claims at home and abroad, I stated that the first was too wrong to be taken seriously, and that I was not at all convinced by the second. However, about two years ago, doubt began to gnaw at me. I expressed this in my article titled 'Does Erdoğan want to be Putin?' (February 8, 2011).

"But when Prime Minister Erdoğan's conservative populist discourse that has been rising since last May—'Let abortion be banned… Let the death penalty return… I will build a mosque in Çamlıca, in Taksim… I will close prep schools… This Süleyman doesn't represent my ancestors…' and so on—was added to the 'Turkish-style presidential' system proposal the AKP submitted to the Turkish Grand National Assembly Constitutional Reconciliation Commission, I no longer had any doubt: I don't think the AKP wants to take Turkey to an authoritarian regime; but Prime Minister Erdoğan wants to be Turkey's Putin.

"The essentials of the 'Turkish-type presidential system' produced by Constitutional Commission Chairman Burhan Kuzu at the Prime Minister's directive are as follows: There will be a single chamber; the president will be responsible only to the people, not to the assembly; there will be no vote of confidence or motion of censure for the president; the president will choose his cabinet from outside parliament; senior state officials will be appointed by the president without requiring the assembly's approval; the president will issue decrees with the force of law when needed (not subject to assembly oversight); the president will dissolve parliament when deemed necessary, and so on. Our leading constitutional law scholar Prof. Dr. Ergun Özbudun is of course quite right in saying that this system is called 'decretismo' (rule by decree) in Latin America and means 'the concentration of power in a single person.' (*Akşam*, November 29, 2012)

"'Turkish-type presidentialism' may be inspired by Latin America. But, (according to its inventor Burhan Kuzu) the rule-by-decree system that will save the president from 'crying day and night, begging parliament' is also applied in Russia. The regime in Russia is called not liberal democracy but 'managed democracy,' 'sovereign democracy,' or in short 'Putinism.' It can be said that Erdoğan finds his role model in Putinism, in the sense of the regime being shaped by a single person's personality and political power. A Russia expert defines Putinism briefly as follows: 'The concentration of political and economic power in one center, the emasculation of parliament, the silencing of the media, a return to Great Russian nationalist rhetoric, and bullying interference in the affairs of neighboring countries…' (Daniel Beer,"Russia's Managed Democracy," History

Today, Volume: 59, Issue: 5, 2009.) Putin's supporters value the strong state, economic growth, and security much more than human rights or democracy.

"The resemblance between Erdoğan and Putin must be so palpable that even Fehmi Koru recently wrote that Erdoğan is 'a stern father who sees the people as his children whom he tries to make good people' (*Star*, December 2). I had previously written that the Prime Minister 'has begun to see the people of Turkey as a flock in need of herding and himself as their shepherd.' (*Zaman*, May 29) Will Putinism take hold in Turkey? Yes, Erdoğan may want to become a Putin, but I don't think the people of Turkey, the Turkish Grand National Assembly, or above all the AKP will allow this. Why? The subject of another article." (4.12.2012)

I explained why Putinism would not take hold in Turkey, or so I imagined, as follows:

Putinism won't take hold in Turkey

"…Still, I don't think 'Putinism' can be implemented in Turkey. First of all, because Turkey is not Russia. Turkey has at least 60 years of democratic experience, however deficient and flawed. The people of Turkey have a democratic maturity; it has been seen that they know how to reward politicians for their successes and punish them for their mistakes. Turkey is a long-standing member of the Western alliance. Its frame of reference is Western democracies. The underground (oil, natural gas) riches that enable Putin to maintain his authoritarian regime do not exist in Turkey. Many Russian intellectuals go abroad, but the intellectuals of Turkey cannot be expected to flee the struggle for democracy. It is not possible for an administration that antagonizes intellectuals to stay standing for long. On the other hand, it should not be forgotten that popular opposition to Putinism in Russia is growing step by step.

"It has become clear that Erdoğan's 'Turkish-type presidential' system proposal, which would mean governing the country by decree, cannot be accepted by the Turkish Grand National Assembly; finding the three-fifths majority to take it to referendum also seems very difficult. In a secret vote, the AKP group cannot be expected to act like a herd. Let's say the Prime Minister managed to take the proposal to referendum. In this case too, its rejection by the people is very likely. Because it takes no prophet to say that a significant portion of the electorate that has supported the AKP government until now—primarily the religious segment demanding a democratic constitution and rejecting arbitrary rule, and Kurds—will not approve one-person rule. In my opinion, if Erdoğan continues the Putin-like line he has held since the last elections, he faces the risk of losing the presidential election to be held by popular vote in 2014, for the reasons I listed above, and being left out of politics.

"If my assumptions are correct, the auspicious choice for himself, his party, and certainly Turkey is for Mr. Prime Minister to correct his line and accept the presidency with its existing powers; to hand over the prime ministership to Abdullah Gül, who seems to be the only person who can hold the party together." (20.12.2012)

I think an observer of politics in Turkey could only be as wrong as I was in the articles above… Developments would go in exactly the opposite direction of what I thought, and

Erdoğan would succeed perfectly well in becoming Turkey's Putin and remaining so for a long time.

Unity cannot be preserved by dying, by killing

I was once again grounding the claim that Turkey "cannot preserve its unity by dying, by killing" as follows:

"Last week the Turkish Grand National Assembly Human Rights Investigation Commission announced: The TSK has lost 818 martyrs in the fight against the PKK in the last ten years, while 934 privates and noncommissioned officers under arms have committed suicide. I couldn't believe my eyes when I read it! I knew suicides were common in the army; I also knew that suspicions that some of them were actually killed by their superiors were widespread. But I didn't think the numbers could be this high. Could there be stronger evidence than this for the claims that the TSK doesn't value the lives of our young people doing mandatory military service? The commission chairman says, 'This is unacceptable…' Then do what is necessary as the Turkish Grand National Assembly!

"The event of last week that completely darkened my soul was some media announcing, as if a great victory had been won, that 1,176 PKK militants had been killed in the first 11 months of this year. As if even Kurdish citizens who don't embrace the PKK in the slightest don't have their attachment to this country and this state diminish a little more with every Kurdish youth killed! According to the media, the number of young martyrs we lost in the first 6 months of this year is 117. At this rate, 2012 is heading toward being the year we lost the most martyrs in the last ten years. It's very clear: The party mainly responsible for the deaths that distance us from each other is the political power. The truth cannot be covered up forever. It must be accepted that two peoples with different languages and cultures live in this country, and the government must finish what it started. The legitimate, democratic demands of our Kurdish citizens must be met; by negotiating with the PKK, their leaders should go to other countries, and their ordinary militants should return to their homes with a general amnesty. We cannot preserve our unity by dying, by killing. Listen to what Lawyer Muhammed Akar, from one of Diyarbakır's prominent families and an AKP supreme board delegate, said in his letter:" after which I left the rest of the article to Akar:

"Military operations, detentions and arrests, the dead bodies of young people and mothers' tears have replaced the democratic opening that led everyone to great hope. While soldier funerals in western provinces feed social anger, militant funerals in eastern provinces bring people to the streets. The greatest danger for a country is the formation of two separate worlds blind and deaf to each other. The extinction of the sense of empathy. The loss of a common moral and conscientious stance. More importantly, the shaking of trust in justice.

"Unfortunately, we have sacrificed the principle of justice to nationalist reflexes. Kurdish society demands justice, law, freedom, and equality from the state. Can an understanding that discriminates between the languages its citizens speak, that finds mother-tongue education dangerous, that has children say 'How happy is the one who

says I am a Turk' every morning be just? People are happy if they are free, if their stomachs are full, if they can look to tomorrow with hope. Not because they are Turkish or Kurdish. In the provinces where Kurds live, a quarter of the people are at the hunger line, half at the poverty line.

"Now we are also tense with the lifting of immunities of BDP deputies. A few years ago, we had brought those with weapons down from the mountains and entered political negotiations. Now we are showing politicians the path to the mountains. The more the BDP is targeted, the more its votes increase. Its mistakes become invisible. Even conservative Kurds who vote for the AK Party have begun to turn to the BDP. Because the current perception is 'The AK Party is arrogant, the BDP is aggrieved…' In this region, the aggrieved always wins. Military operations, detentions, arrests, road checks, highland bans have always won the PKK a base. For 87 years, names, parties, governments change but the Kurdish problem continues to grow. It depletes our resources, impoverishes us. More importantly, it takes our children from us never to return." (7.12.2012)

Lawyer Muhammed Akar, whose words I quoted above, would continue as AKP Diyarbakır Provincial Chairman until November 2017.

CHAPTER XIV / FROM ERDOGAN I TO II

How could the difference between Erdogan's first term, defined by policies aimed at establishing democracy, and his second term oriented toward establishing authoritarianism, be explained?.. I wrote:

"The other day I was chatting with a young academic friend. The conversation kept circling back to how Prime Minister Erdogan's political profile had changed so fundamentally since the last general elections. How is it that Erdogan I, who contributed so greatly not only to the country's prosperity but also to its democratization, was replaced by Erdogan II, who puts the brakes on democratization reforms and increasingly shows clear signs of arbitrariness and Putinization. In short: How can the transition from Erdogan I to II be explained?

"In response to this question, my friend put forward a 'theory' I had not heard before. According to this, Prime Minister Erdogan does not feel secure and therefore increasingly compromises with the status quo / established order, 'becoming one with the state.' After listing various signs of this, my friend drew attention to the Prime Minister's statement in a television interview the other day that 'the deep structure in the state has not been completely cleaned,' and to his sharing with the public, for the first time, the bugs planted in his offices.

"Interestingly, the Prime Minister elaborated on this last topic at his press conference the other day: 'We completely erased, finished, destroyed this—it's impossible for me to make such a claim. Because as a politician, I don't believe that any country or state in the world has finished or cleaned out its deep state. Every country has its deep state within it; they cannot reach a point of scraping it out and cleaning it. It's like a virus. The

moment it finds the right opportunity, the right ground, that virus emerges and tries to do what it wants to do.'

"The theory my young academic friend put forward was the exact opposite of the theory I had credited until now—that the 180-degree change in the Prime Minister stemmed from excessive, inflated self-confidence; that after believing he had established his authority, he fell under the delusion that he could turn to arbitrariness: in other words, the issue is not 'self-confidence' but 'insecurity.' I objected to my friend with the following reasoning: Let's say the Prime Minister doesn't feel secure (against 'deep structures'); shouldn't he rationally work to expand his social support as much as possible? But it appears that, following a line completely contrary to expectations, he is polarizing society and alienating at least some of the conservative-religious segments, Kurds, and freedom-loving intellectuals who had strongly supported him until now. (…)

"In the end, my friend and I agreed that the line the Prime Minister had been following since the last general elections was not rational. I concluded the conversation as follows: I now better understand why the U.S. Constitution allows presidents to be elected only twice at most. And why Tony Blair, who rendered great services to his party and country in Britain, had to resign before completing his third term as prime minister… Carrying such heavy responsibilities is not easy and is exhausting. I understand this, but we don't have to bear the consequences." (*Zaman*, 27.12.2012)

No to the AKP's presidential proposal!

In opposing Erdogan's proposal for transitioning to a presidential system, I put forward the following arguments:

"The judicial arrangements of the Erdogan-style presidential system proposal that the Justice and Development Party submitted to the Constitutional Reconciliation Commission have also been revealed. Thus, the government system proposed by the AKP has become somewhat more concrete. This system gives the President: 1) authority to dissolve Parliament, 2) authority to rule the country by decree, 3) authority to appoint high-level public officials, ambassadors, and some judges without parliamentary approval.

"According to the judiciary-related arrangements, the President will: 1) appoint one-quarter of the members of the Court of Appeals to be established (the rest to be chosen by the HSYK, the High Council of Judges and Prosecutors), 2) appoint 7 members of the HSYK (only 6 of the total 22 members will be elected by judges), 3) appoint 8 members of the Constitutional Court (the rest of the 17 members will also be elected by the parliamentary majority). That is, the Constitutional Court will not be able to review presidential decrees. Annulment cases at the Constitutional Court can only be filed by the President or 110 deputies, and most members of judicial bodies will be determined not by judicial members but by the political authority.

"It is quite obvious that this presidential system, which in the words of Prof. Dr. Ergun Ozbudun is 'a peculiar absurdity of our own,' responds to the needs not of Turkey but of Prime Minister Erdogan. It may be argued that this system is a reaction to the

bureaucratic tutelage system over democracy that came with the 1961 Constitution and was reinforced by the 1982 Constitution. However, if adopted, it is inevitable that this system will bring the domination of the elected majority instead of the tutelage of the appointed. Liberal democracy in the sense of libertarian and pluralist democracy may not be a perfect regime, but it is certainly the best form of government found so far.

“The regime that came to Turkey with the 1961 and 1982 constitutions and placed ‘national will’ under the tutelage of the military-civilian bureaucracy loyal to Kemalist ideology was one of the main obstacles to establishing democracy. But liberal democracy is not just ‘national will’ or majority rule. It is equally a regime where ‘national will’ is limited by citizens’ fundamental rights and freedoms; checked and balanced by the rule of law, separation of powers, independent judiciary, freedom of the press, and civil society organizations. Democracy can only be established on these two legs. The Erdogan-style presidential system proposal, which contradicts both the parliamentary system envisioned in the AKP’s 2007 election manifesto and the constitutional amendments made by referendum in 2010, will not bring stability; on the contrary, it is inevitable that it will be a source of instability by reinforcing personal rule, and therefore must be rejected.

“It seems impossible for the AKP’s constitutional draft to pass through Parliament today. However, Prime Minister Erdogan, who says ‘We don’t have the numbers to make constitutional changes with the BDP (Peace and Democracy Party). But if we can agree on a referendum, we can take joint steps with them…,’ is apparently calculating to win the BDP’s support by adding articles they would accept to this draft; to take it to a referendum with this support and have it approved by the people. We will see whether he succeeds in this calculation.

“I find it difficult to understand how Prime Minister Erdogan, who has truly rendered great services to this country in various fields, can so set aside the fact that democracy is governance by rules not persons, and that Turkey will be governed after him as well. I do not find his obsession that Turkey can only be best governed by himself, with unlimited power, compatible with the Islamic moral principles he claims to follow, such as staying away from arrogance and not abandoning humility.” (*Zaman*, 9.2.2013)

The meaning of being liberal in Turkey

While writing in the *Zaman* newspaper published by the religious community formed under the guidance of Fethullah Gulen, a cleric, and as a commentator defending liberal democracy, I occasionally felt the need to explain what I meant by being liberal in Turkey, and wrote as follows:

“What does it mean to be ‘liberal’ in today’s Turkey? In my view, it essentially means adopting the following ideas: People are of equal worth from birth. For this reason, all citizens should be equal in rights and before the law, regardless of gender, race, ethnic identity, or religious belief. However, people being of equal worth does not mean they do not have different abilities. The effort to make people equal in economic conditions rather than in rights has resulted in the suffocation of freedoms, as shown by totalitarian socialist practices.

“Like people, the identities, nations, religions, and cultures they belong to are also of equal worth and deserve equal respect; no hierarchy of superiority can be made among them. Conflicts can only be resolved through dialogue and compromise, not through violence and imposition. Authority in society should be based on voluntary acceptance, relationships between people on agreement, and governance on the consent of the governed.

“In the 19th century, liberals believed in governance limited by fundamental rights and freedoms, but they did not believe in governance by elected governments, that is, in political democracy. But over time they adopted the principle of ‘one person, one vote’; this principle was established in the West through the joint struggles of liberal and democratic socialist parties. Today, anyone who does not believe in political democracy and governance limited by human rights is not a liberal. Political democracy requires strong checks and balances to prevent the abuse of power, regardless of the form of government. A judiciary and media independent of the government, and academic freedom in universities, are among the indispensable conditions of political democracy.

“State and religion should be separated, and the state should maintain equal distance from all beliefs and non-believers. Until the second half of the last century, liberals argued that only individuals could be subjects of rights, and that the state should be ‘blind’ to ethnic-religious identity differences among citizens. But although the debate continues between monocultural and contemporary multicultural interpretations of liberalism, it is the latter that is increasingly prevailing through international group rights conventions.

“A free society can be pluralistic not only politically but also economically and culturally, meaning a society where decisions are made from multiple centers. A market economy based on private property is not a sufficient but a necessary condition of a democratic society.

“Through science based on reason, people can gain knowledge about the workings of nature and society. Through reforms based on this knowledge, they can build a freer, more just, and prosperous society. However, science consists only of theories that are valid until proven otherwise; it advances by replacing theories shown to be wrong with new ones. As science advances, it becomes clear how little we know. Therefore, science has its limits. At the source of moral values is not science but religions and philosophy. There is no single, absolute, infallible, unchanging truth or correctness. The domains of religion and science are separate; they should respect each other. All kinds of fanaticism, whether religious or scientific in origin, should be opposed.”

The final paragraph of the article can only be meaningful in showing how idealistic I was about Turkey’s political culture, substituting what I wanted to see for reality:

“Although those who adopt the label ‘liberal’ in Turkey today are limited to a rather narrow circle, the idea of governance by elected governments limited by citizens’ fundamental rights and freedoms, especially freedom of expression, organization, and belief—political liberalism—constitutes the common denominator of society. ‘Human

Rights,' which almost every segment wants to be respected, is a concept derived from liberalism." (*Zaman*, 06.04.2013)

Why is Fethullah Gulen so influential?

The article I will quote below well reflected that I valued Fethullah Gulen more than he deserved, and that perhaps I only considered the aspects of reality I wanted to see regarding his expressed views and the religious community he led.

"*Time* magazine in its April 29 - May 6, 2013 issue introduced, according to its own assessment, 'The 100 Most Influential People in the World.' One of them was Islamic scholar Fethullah Gulen. The short piece about Hocaefendi was written by Stephen Kinzer, bureau chief of *The New York Times* in Istanbul from 1996-2000 and author of the book 'Crescent and Star: Turkey Between Two Worlds' (2002).

"Kinzer wrote: 'From his secluded corner in Pennsylvania, his message of tolerance and respect for difference has won him admirers spread across the world. Schools opened by his followers have spread to about 140 countries… In his home country Turkey, through graduates of the schools he opened who have risen to high positions in government, judiciary, and police, he has enormous influence. This makes him look like a puppeteer operating in the shadows, and he has almost as many detractors as admirers. However, as the most powerful advocate of moderation in the Islamic world, he is waging a very urgent and important campaign.'

"After reading Kinzer's article, I thought. What makes Gulen one of the world's most influential thinkers? And why in Turkey does he have 'almost as many detractors as admirers'? For me, the answers to these questions are very clear. In Turkey and everywhere in the world, there are millions of Muslims who do not give credence to fundamentalist, fanatical interpretations of Islam, to efforts to produce a totalitarian ideology from Islam. These millions want to remain attached to the spiritual and social values their faith instills, while also living in a world where freedom of thought, belief, and enterprise is established; where different identities and beliefs are respected; where education replaces ignorance; where science is respected as much as religion; where working and earning is encouraged and appreciated. This is the primary factor that has made Gulen one of the world's most influential thinkers with his messages 'from his remote corner in Pennsylvania.'

"Another important factor, without doubt, is that Gulen is a thinker coming from within Turkey's Sufi, folk Islam tradition. In this tradition, if Said Nursi is the name who carried Sufi Islam to the modern age, Fethullah Gulen is the person who interprets it in light of today's increasingly liberalizing and globalizing world. If Nursi is the leader of a religious community, Gulen is the inspiration for a faith-based civil society movement, the 'Hizmet movement.' Today, the Hizmet movement, in line with the values Gulen instills, not only enables Turkey to build 'bridges of peace' with the world through schools spread across 140 countries that have earned societies' respect with the quality of education they provide. It also contributes to the establishment of a modern economy in Turkey and, with the values it represents, supports the establishment of libertarian and pluralist democracy.

“The secret behind the Hizmet movement’s successes is not Gulen’s orders from Pennsylvania or its centralized and hierarchical structure, but quite the opposite—its being based on principles of decentralization and voluntarism. Yes, among Turkey’s administrators, judicial members, and police today, there certainly are those who graduated from the Hizmet movement’s schools and respect Gulen’s guidance. But to assume that these people act on orders, to attribute Gulen’s influence to this, is nothing but a conspiracy theory.

“Yes, Gulen has ‘detractors’ who have forced him to live far from his homeland. These are essentially proponents of authoritarian secularism in its various shades, who see Islam as the chief enemy of modernization and believe it should be confined to consciences and completely excluded from social life. It is certain that Kemalism is still strong.” (*Zaman*, 07.05.2013)

Erdogan should return to pre-2011

In June 2013, with an understanding that substituted my own liberal preferences for society’s choices, I invited Prime Minister Erdogan to abandon the policies he had begun following after 2011 and return to the previous period. As follows:

“Turkey is a society with a plural structure in many respects—ethnic, religious, linguistic, cultural, ideological—with delicate balances. It contains many divisions within it, primarily Turkish and Kurdish, Sunni and Alevi, religious and non-religious, Muslim and non-Muslim, democrat and tutelage supporter, secular and secularist, libertarian and authoritarian. The government must take into account these divisions in society and the delicate balances between them. A society with a plural structure can never be governed with a majoritarian understanding (whoever has the majority’s support can do whatever they want). On the contrary, it requires a pluralist governance (seeing differences as richness, establishing mutual respect).

“Prime Minister Erdogan’s performance in the period up to the 2011 general elections followed a line that took into account the structure and delicate balances of society. This was one of the most important factors in his party collecting half of the votes. However, after receiving this 50 percent and succeeding in pushing back military tutelage, the Prime Minister adopted an attitude incompatible with libertarian democracy, assuming with inflated self-confidence that he could do whatever he wanted, didn’t have to listen to anyone, and only had to account from election to election. The point this attitude has brought him to (even if it is unclear with what purpose he said this) is the place Education Minister Nabi Avci described: succeeding in doing what the opposition could not have done in years of trying—uniting against the government groups that could not otherwise be imagined coming together…

“Finally, President Gul had to raise his voice: ‘Democracy is not just elections. The message has been received. What is necessary will be done…’ he said. The Prime Minister may not know or understand ‘what is behind this statement,’ but society understood very well what the President meant. Society hopes and expects that the President will not repeat mistakes like ‘Yavuz Sultan Selim’; that he will remain faithful to the pluralist, participatory democracy he says he supports. If the message was received,

what needs to be done first is for Istanbul's urban development to be taken out of the Prime Minister's hands and left to its municipality and people. The second is for the imposition of a presidential regime, 'Turkish-style' or not, to end.

"The fact that the President felt the need to intervene in the situation showed how vitally important a parliamentary system functioning with all its institutions and rules, not under tutelage, is for Turkey. I hope everyone saw that the distinction between the head of state representing the nation and the prime minister representing the majority in a parliamentary system is one of the safeguards against abuse of power. What I see is this: The Prime Minister must now change. He must be the Erdogan of before 2011. He must re-adopt an attitude respectful of the sensitivities of all segments of society. The President, taking with him the founders and prominent figures of the AKP who can see the gravity of the situation, should seriously warn the Prime Minister on this matter. For those who want to bring back military tutelage, revive the Turkish-Kurdish conflict, and destroy the good image the country has built with great difficulty and effort are right behind the door!

"If the Prime Minister cannot be persuaded to change, then I personally will conclude that he is extremely exhausted after the intense work he has been doing for about eleven years, or that his health condition does not allow him to continue in office. Then the responsibility for finding a remedy will fall to the people." ("The Prime Minister must change," 6.6.2013)

"Throw this man out of the newspaper"

While writing for *Zaman*, I very rarely encountered censorship. One example is this: I had to change the last paragraph of my article titled "The Prime Minister must change" that I quoted above. The original form of the paragraph was: "If the Prime Minister cannot be persuaded to change, then it may be concluded that he is extremely exhausted after the intense work he has been doing for about eleven years, or that his health condition does not allow him to continue at this pace, and the mechanism of the parliamentary system that allows for renewing the executive branch when necessary can come into play. The AKP group, if necessary on its own, can provide for continuing with a new prime minister by casting a vote of no confidence against the current government. This is in the interest of Turkey, the AKP, and its deputies."

When Editor-in-Chief Ekrem Dumanli saw this version of the article, he called and said, "I agree with you, but they will judge that we made you write these lines and will cause an incident…" and asked me to soften the last paragraph. Although I believed that no one had the power to make me write any line, I did my best and put the paragraph into the form I quoted above. Dumanli was not satisfied, but did not press the matter. Some time later he told another *Zaman* writer what had happened: Prime Minister Erdogan, reading the softened version of the article, had fumed and called Dumanli saying about me "Throw this man out of the newspaper…"; Dumanli's answer had been "We don't have a practice of dismissing writers." When I learned these things, I was truly startled. Although I had always given him due credit for the services he had rendered, I was surprised that the Prime Minister was so intolerant of me.

Another and more serious example in the context of censorship at *Zaman* was this: My article titled "Why Hagia Sophia should remain a museum," which was supposed to be published on December 7, 2013, was censored and completely disappeared. The page editor called me and said that the newspaper management agreed with the content of my article, but that due to the increasing tension between the community and the government, the article raised concerns that it might cause conflict among Muslims and demonstrations in front of the newspaper. Some time later, another *Zaman* writer would explain to me where the concern actually stemmed from: Apparently, in Said Nursi's time, he had sent a letter to Prime Minister Adnan Menderes requesting "the opening of Hagia Sophia for worship"…

Gezi Park: Democratic consciousness is strengthening

Following the forcible dispersal by security forces of the sit-in protest that began on May 28, 2013 to oppose the AKP government's plan to reconstruct the historic barracks building in place of Istanbul's Taksim Gezi Park, approximately 3.5 million people participated in mass demonstrations that spread across the country to protest the government's increasing authoritarianism and continued until late August. During the demonstrations, which were of a scale rarely seen in Turkish history, 11 people died, 8,000 were injured, and 3,000 were detained. I interpreted the Gezi Park demonstrations in the articles I will quote below as follows:

"About two years ago, in an article I wrote for a booklet titled 'What does Turkey think?' published by the European Council on Foreign Relations, I answered the editors' question 'Will Turkey without an EU anchor turn toward authoritarianism?'; I explained why the claim that 'the alliance between the AKP and various religious movements is taking Turkey toward elected authoritarianism…' which was ardently defended by authoritarian secularists at the time, was not at all convincing. (…) In Turkey, where under AKP rule the economy has strengthened, prosperity has increased, the middle class has expanded, it has opened to the world, pushed back military tutelage, broken taboos with expanding freedom of debate, ended the denial of Kurds, and started the peace process with the PKK, I have argued in various articles and speeches that the people will not accept or tolerate an authoritarian government. In my view, the main message of the demonstrations that began in Taksim Gezi Park on May 31 and have spread across Turkey is that democratic consciousness in Turkey is gradually strengthening.

"As for those who try to explain the protest movements that united very different segments against Prime Minister Erdogan's increasingly unacceptable imposition as the work of 'internal and external enemies': This is, as always, nothing but self-deception. These protests are the unintended consequences of the great services Erdogan and his government have rendered to Turkey. The AKP government made Turkey relatively richer and freer. In Turkey, which is richer and freer than yesterday, young generations have increasingly embraced the ideals of democracy and freedom, human rights and environmental sensitivity more deeply. *(Emphases added later.)*

“Today’s young generations are the products of the ‘new Turkey’ that AKP governments paved the way for; their values are fundamentally different from those of the generations of 30-40 years ago who pursued various authoritarian and totalitarian visions. The burning and destruction by ‘old Turkey’ remnants who use the nonviolent and creative reactions of these generations to the government’s authoritarianism, imposition, and police violence as an excuse to attack left and right should not prevent seeing the main character of the Gezi Park protest movement. (…)

“For many years Turkey struggled with the authoritarian secularist and monoculturalist military-bureaucratic tutelage over democracy; in the coming period it appears it will be the scene of struggles against the arbitrariness and authoritarianism of the elected government. In the end, we are learning democracy by living it, gradually maturing and establishing it.” (“Democratic consciousness is strengthening,” *Zaman*, 8.6.2013)

Lessons from Gezi Park

As can be seen, while interpreting the Gezi Park protests as signs of the strengthening of democratic consciousness in Turkey and the birth of “New Turkey,” I was also arguing that there were those who wanted to use the resistance to revive “Old Turkey” under military tutelage:

“The resistance movement against the construction of ‘Topcu Barracks’ in Taksim Gezi Park is full of lessons to be drawn for Turkey’s political life. As almost everyone, including the Prime Minister, acknowledges, the resistance began as a peaceful and democratic protest movement in which young people of very different political views participated. However, the movement took on a character that spread to all of Istanbul, and from there to all of Turkey, opposing the arbitrary and authoritarian governance style the Prime Minister has pursued since the 2011 elections, uniting very different segments who could not otherwise have come together.

“The pioneers of the movement were the young generations of New Turkey, largely the work of Prime Minister Erdogan and his government, who respect democracy, human rights, diversity, and the environment. Unfortunately, Old Turkey remnants who wanted to revive military tutelage, sabotage the peace process, and create chaos tried to hijack the movement. Militants who burned and destroyed businesses and attacked police with Molotov cocktails appeared on the scene.

“The Gezi Park resistance showed the Prime Minister that New Turkey will not accept arbitrary and authoritarian governance, whether military or civilian. The Prime Minister, who had previously given messages that ‘he wouldn’t listen to any supreme council,’ declared that he accepted the most fundamental requirement of the rule of law and would wait for the outcome of the judicial process for Gezi Park. By proposing a referendum, he also had to accept that the decision on whether to build Topcu Barracks should be left to Istanbulites.

“The Gezi Park resistance once again showed how centralized Turkey’s administrative structure is, and that this centralization is now concentrated in the hands of almost a single person (the prime minister). Mayor Kadir Topbas, who had rendered great

services to Istanbul, was almost erased from the scene. (In my opinion, he should have resigned to express his objection to the prime minister who ignored him.) Our need to strengthen local governments and local administration was once again seen.

“The Gezi Park resistance showed that ‘New Turkey’ will not accept a governance style that attempts to arrange everyone’s lifestyle according to its own preferences. But unfortunately, the Prime Minister continues to divide society into ‘those who are with us and those who are not’; to accuse ‘those who are not’ of treachery and baseness; to strain and polarize society by organizing rallies to intimidate those who don’t think like him. Instead of seeking the causes of what has happened in his own mistakes, he tries to explain it with the ostrich method of Old Turkey, with ‘conspiracies of internal and external enemies.’ He is practically inviting the destruction, within a few weeks, of the international reputation he personally earned for Turkey over ten years with great effort. Turkey’s identity that reconciles Islam with democracy and serves as an inspiration to all Islamic countries is suffering great damage. Perhaps worst of all, he is endangering the steps taken toward solving the Kurdish problem that has been bleeding Turkey for 30 years.

“There are also lessons to be underlined from the perspective of society. We must make public institutions respectable and strong. Of course we will criticize when the police use excessive force and act contrary to human rights, but as a society we can never forget that our security depends on the police force. Yes, democracy is not just elections. There is no democracy where there is no freedom of expression and organization. National will is not just the majority. Yes, we will criticize the elected government in the harshest terms when necessary for its practices incompatible with democracy, human rights, and the rule of law, but we cannot forget even for a moment that democracy means government by election.” (*Zaman*, 20.6.2013)

A sincere appeal to Prime Minister Erdogan

In 2010-2011, that is, in the early years of his turn toward authoritarianism, I was approaching Prime Minister Erdogan with more goodwill than he deserved; while directing my criticisms on one hand, on the other hand I was reiterating my appreciation for the services he rendered in the first half of his rule, calling on him to abandon the turn toward authoritarianism; as in the article I quote below:

“(…) The Prime Minister should be able to see that the New Turkey, which will never accept arbitrary and authoritarian governance, is largely the product of reforms that he himself pioneered, which made Turkey a richer, more democratic, and more open society. Brazil’s rulers say that the mass demonstrations that erupted over transportation fare increases and spread to 100 cities showed the whole world how democratic a society Brazil is, and that they are proud of these demonstrations. Surely, Turkey’s rulers, especially Prime Minister Erdogan, can see that the Gezi Park protests are not the results of ‘conspiracies of internal and external enemies’ but of the ideals of freedom and democracy taking root in society, and they can be proud of this.

“The opportunity has not been missed to reverse the negativities caused by the Gezi Park protests that harmed our democracy, economy, and international reputation; to

show the whole world that first-class democracy can be established in a Muslim-majority country. To seize this opportunity, it is enough for the Prime Minister to return to the attitude he followed for about ten years until the 2011 elections, which enabled him to overcome the great troubles he faced and elevate Turkey, which was respectful of the sensitivities of various segments of the people of Turkey, which united rather than polarized society, and to embrace the policy of governing the country in consultation with his government and people.

“As his past political career shows, the Prime Minister is a pragmatic, not ideological leader; one who knows how to learn from mistakes rather than insisting on them. These were the qualities that brought him his successes. His insistence on these qualities will save Turkey from increasing tension and polarization, and serve its progress on the path of democratization and peace. His insistence on these qualities will serve to emphasize —something we as the people of Turkey desperately need, and what will truly make us strong as Turkey—that we are one whole with all our differences, as Turks and Kurds, Sunnis and Alevis, Muslims and non-Muslims, religious and non-religious, and to establish mutual respect for each other’s opinions, language and culture, and way of life.

“There are great opportunities ahead of us. We have effectively left behind the era of military tutelage that made Turkey a semi-democracy. The Turkish Grand National Assembly can certainly find the necessary majority to make a constitution that will establish libertarian and pluralist democracy. We have the opportunity to end the armed uprising that has been bleeding and weakening our country for 30 years, that has crippled democracy and made our people unhappy. Prime Minister, you have largely created these opportunities; do not let these opportunities be wasted by straining and polarizing the country.

“With your encouragement as well, the PKK has embarked on the path of pursuing a responsible policy toward all of Turkey and all Kurds. It has finally seen that armed struggle has been harming the cause of equal citizenship for Kurds. It is giving signals that it will no longer resort to arms and will focus on political struggle. The time has come to advance to the second phase of the peace process. We must meet the common, legitimate, democratic demands of our Kurdish citizens. Democracy must now be established, violence must come to an end.” (*Zaman*, 22.6.2013)

Yes! But not enough…

In those years, a perspective that I would later almost completely abandon dominated my writings. I defined this perspective, which I called “strategic optimism,” as follows:

“I have an understanding that looks optimistically at the future of humanity and, as a part of it, Turkey in a strategic (long-term) sense. At the foundation of this optimism is my trust in critical reason, that is, in people’s ability to correct their mistakes using their minds. Looking at history, we see that it has never been easy for societies to reach conditions where critical (self-questioning) reason prevails. Establishing libertarian and pluralist democracy, the political order produced by critical reason, has required tough struggles everywhere; in much of the world it still awaits establishment.

“Even in countries with long histories in this field, various problems are experienced.

Although there is still a very long road ahead and sometimes setbacks occur, humanity is progressing toward a freer and more just future. Great disasters have been overcome. Humanity defeated Nazism, which stifled critical reason, and liquidated many fascist regimes. Communism was also defeated. The communist party itself led this in Russia and China. Yes, in Russia an authoritarian one-man regime replaced it, but Russians are freer today than yesterday and can look to the future with hope. Yes, in China the communist party monopoly continues, but the hope for prosperity and liberation is much further ahead today than yesterday.

“Yes, today humanity also faces great dangers, especially climate change. But it is not impossible for it to overcome this threat using critical reason. Yes, acts of violence have become much more visible today due to globalized communication, but statistics show that violence and the destructiveness of wars have decreased compared to the past. I believe that Turkey is also progressing toward a freer and more just society by using critical reason and learning from mistakes. In my youth, believers in critical reason and libertarian and pluralist democracy among intellectuals in Turkey were a very small minority; today, believers in dictatorship are a small minority. Today’s Turkey is much freer and more prosperous than the Turkey of my youth.

“It cannot be denied that Turkey, which set out on the path of the rule of law with the Tanzimat reforms and people-based governance with the Second Constitutional Era, is progressing toward establishing democracy that increasingly includes individual freedoms and group rights. No one can deny that through the efforts of both secular and Islamic modernization advocates, Turkey today holds an exceptional place among Muslim-majority countries in terms of democratization experience. In the process that began with the transition to a multi-party system in 1950 after an authoritarian modernization experience, Turkey witnessed the gradual expansion of freedoms despite all the setbacks brought by coups and efforts at violent suppression. Even today we are far from establishing libertarian and pluralist democracy, but as long as criticism is met with respect and lessons are learned from criticisms, we can look to the future with optimism.

“While listening to the Prime Minister yesterday, I was essentially thinking about these things. Definitely ‘Yes!’ to the democratization package he announced, but far from sufficient for Turkey to be a democracy by EU standards. The Prime Minister’s acknowledgment of this; his emphasis that progress cannot be achieved without strong support from society, despite the current opposition’s resistance, are the points I agreed with most in his speech. The Prime Minister’s return to a discourse embracing all of society is, in my opinion, the most gratifying aspect of the speech.” (*Zaman*, 1.10.2013)

The goal is to control civil society too

In one of the articles where I increased the dose of criticism against the increasingly evident authoritarianism of the Erdogan government, I said:

“(…) There is no field the Prime Minister has not touched in his effort to shape society according to his own preferences. First comes the media that shapes public opinion. Through large media owners who are dependent on him due to their commercial dealings, he has critical journalists fired. He holds decisions on which companies will benefit from which state opportunities and which tenders will be awarded to whom. He unleashes finance inspectors on companies whose attitude he doesn’t like. He violently suppresses demonstrations organized by opponents. Pointing to the attempt by opponents of democracy to hijack them, he explains the Gezi Park demonstrations, which were essentially led by those who want freedom and democracy to be established, as conspiracies of internal and external enemies who don’t want Turkey’s development. He threatens civil society saying ‘you’re either with me or against me… Those who are neutral will be eliminated…’ When a critical voice comes from the ranks of his party, he immediately warns ‘Don’t serve the enemy!’ and expels them.

“The latest link in Erdogan’s effort to bring civil society under control is the closure of private tutoring centers under the guise of ‘transforming them into private schools.’ The Prime Minister wants to suppress by law the demand for educational support that will continue to exist as long as the supply and quality of education are not increased. At this point, the Hizmet Movement, which represents not the entire sector but about a quarter of it, is rightfully reacting to the ‘closure by law’ effort that will also result in most of those working in their tutoring centers becoming unemployed, that is, to the initiative that disregards both society’s need for educational support and freedom of enterprise and contract. If there are problems in the tutoring sector and improvements are needed, reforms should be made in consultation with stakeholders, as in almost all matters. Imposition is not a method proper to democracy.” (*Zaman*, 23.11.2013)

This article of mine received unexpected but quite understandable support. Enver Yucel, founder of Bahcesehir University and one of the pioneers of tutoring centers preparing students for university entrance exams, who in this context was also a competitor of the Gulen movement, called and warmly congratulated me.

The partnership between the Kemalists and the AKP

The antipathy Kemalists and the AKP felt toward each other often hid their common aspects from view. In an article where I pointed out these commonalities, I said the following:

“(…) It is certain that there are some fundamental understandings that the Kemalists and the ‘conservative democrat’ AKP administration share. The foremost of these is that one represents authoritarianism of the top-down and minority-based kind, while the other represents authoritarianism of the elected and majority-based kind (not totalitarianism, of course). For this reason, both harbor vast intolerance toward voluntary organizations independent of the state, that is, toward civil society; for this reason they strive to keep civil society under tight control.

“Another common aspect of the mentality dominating both the Kemalists and the AKP administration is that both believe in keeping religion under state monopoly and that the state should decide which religious beliefs are correct/acceptable and which are wrong/

unacceptable. Their complete agreement on the indispensability of the Directorate of Religious Affairs is of course the clearest indicator of this. Kemalists cling tightly to the Directorate so that it doesn't bring Islamic interpretations contrary to their secularist (that is, understanding secularism as a lifestyle distant from religion) views and makes society homogeneous in terms of religion as well, not allowing differences. The AKP administration, on the other hand, holds the Directorate dear so that it serves their Sunni-Naqshbandi understanding of Islam. For this reason, neither of them has any liking for the understanding of Islam that embraces pluralist democracy, human rights, rule of law, respect for different ethnic and religious identities, and a competitive market economy that Fethullah Gulen represents today; they see it as a threat to themselves.

"Another common aspect of the mentality dominating both Kemalists and the AKP finds expression in the understanding of nation. According to both, the nation in Turkey consists of Turks and Muslims. What had the AKP's well-known Defense Minister Vecdi Gonul—on whose acceptability as a politician both sides displayed complete agreement—said on a national day like November 10 in 2008? 'If the deportation and population exchange had not happened, we would not have the national state we have today!'

"The Kemalists' understanding of nation has sometimes emphasized Turkishness in an ethnic (Central Asian origin) sense, sometimes in a cultural ('Happy is he who says I am a Turk') sense. The AKP's understanding of nation has almost always been based on the understanding of 'Islamic nation' consisting of Turks, Kurds, Laz, Circassians, and other 'anasir-i Islam,' that is, Muslim elements… Kemalists represent the secularist, the AKP administration represents the religious, but both largely agree both on statism (in the sense of 'the state is not at the service of the nation, the nation is at the service of the state') and on nationalism (based on the understanding of nation consisting of Turks and Muslims).

This is why neither can confront the deportation during World War I and the human tragedy it caused… This is why the Hrant Dink murder can never be solved." (*Zaman*, 30.11.2013)

Why the attitude against Hizmet?

The common aspects of Kemalists, the AKP, and Islamists in general also manifested themselves in the hostility both adopted toward the Gulen movement. However, the anti-Hizmet front was not limited to these two. I examined the anti-Hizmet front in the following article:

"The alliance formed against Fethullah Gulen Hocaefendi and the Hizmet Movement, a faith-based civil society movement formed under his guidance, which has been gradually expanding in recent days, interests me greatly. The locomotive of this front is certainly the hardline Kemalists who have not the slightest tolerance for civil society; for example, the generals who declared the Hizmet Movement very dangerous at the National Security Council (NSC) in 2004, wanted it placed under strict surveillance, and started the profiling. Ardent supporters of authoritarian secularism and military tutelage (or Nationalists) naturally follow these generals.

“Right beside them are intellectuals some of whom are referred to in public as ‘worried moderns’ and writers who can be characterized as ‘secularist democrats.’ At one end of this segment are those who believe that religious beliefs, especially Islam, can never be compatible with modernization and are considerably influenced by positivism and Orientalism. At the other end are those who accuse some members of the Hizmet Movement of being a hidden power nested within the state, an ‘autonomous power.’

“The ‘worried ones’ extend all the way to the USA. Those at this end long spread the theory that the Gulen Movement was on its way to making Turkey a Sunni Iran hand in hand with the AKP. These days they are working the claim that the ‘real big danger’ for Turkey is not the authoritarian AKP but the Gulen Movement. Those who harbor an animosity toward the Hizmet Movement bordering on enmity are the supporters of the KCK (Kurdistan Communities Union). Their concern is that Hizmet is taking Kurdish youth away from them by providing opportunities for education and social advancement.

“Recently, the anti-Hizmet front has been joined by the Prime Minister and his close circle, who are no less eager than the Kemalists in their quest to bring all of civil society under control; they speak of Hizmet as a ‘gang’ or ‘organization’ that has infiltrated the state. We have not been able to see evidence that they committed crimes, but public servants who are profiled on the allegation that they belong to Hizmet are being subjected to purges.

“Finally, in recent days some pure Islamists have also joined the front. When the AKP government attempted to close tutoring centers, some of which are operated by Hizmet, they too seized the opportunity and began raising their voices. According to one, for example, Hocaefendi represents the understanding of ‘moderate/light Islam without sharia, without fiqh, without jihad… that the USA, Israel, Evangelists, Crusaders, global capitalism and liberalism desire.’ Another recently wrote: ‘The movement actually resembles the headquarters of the “moderate Islam” project. It wants to advance not by confronting the USA, EU and Israel, but by having them alongside or behind it. Actually the project doesn’t concern only Turkey. Turkey is a pilot region. There is an effort to expand the workshop conducted here gradually toward other Islamic countries through education and media, business relations, in a way that will not pose a threat to Western values and interests, to the international order…’

“As you can see, the stance against Hizmet has now spread to quite a wide front. All the elements in this front have their own justifications, of course. Well, what could their common denominator be? In my view, all of them are very disturbed by Hocaefendi representing an alternative understanding of Islamic modernity that also appeals to the religious; that advocates democracy, rule of law, human rights, respect for differences, and integration with the EU; that encourages education and science; that embraces the whole world and all of humanity; that is libertarian and pluralist; and by his being a source of inspiration for alternative elites who are both religious and modernist.” (*Zaman*, 17.12.2013)

My benevolent view of the Gulen movement, which was shattered when its participation in the July 15 coup attempt was revealed, was perhaps best expressed in the article above.

Something is very rotten

The investigations initiated with a series of reports in September 2012 and February 2013, in which public officials including four ministers were accused of misconduct and bribery, became public on December 17, 2013 with the implementation of Public Prosecutor Celal Kara's detention orders and the related courts' search warrants. In the operation carried out by the Istanbul Police Department's Organized Crime and Financial Crimes units, an investigation was opened against persons including businessmen, bureaucrats, a bank manager, public officials of various levels, and four ministers and three ministers' children, on charges of "bribery, misconduct in office, bid rigging, and smuggling."

Prime Minister Recep Tayyip Erdogan claimed the investigation was a conspiracy set up by the Gulen Movement against the government. However, following the public disclosure of the investigations, Egemen Bagis was removed from his position as Minister for EU Affairs; Interior Minister Muammer Guler, Economy Minister Zafer Caglayan, and Environment and Urban Planning Minister Erdogan Bayraktar resigned from their positions; Bayraktar also resigned from his parliamentary seat. In the vote held in the Turkish Grand National Assembly on January 5, 2015, it would be decided not to send the former ministers to the Supreme Tribunal (Yuce Divan). I interpreted the investigations, which would be referred to in the media as the 'December 17-25, 2013 Corruption and Bribery Operation,' in the articles I will quote below as follows:

"One of the famous lines from William Shakespeare's play 'Hamlet' is, as you know: 'Something is rotten in the state of Denmark…' The operation called 'Big bribery,' initiated by the order of the Istanbul deputy chief prosecutor about which the public has very little information, and in which 52 people including ministers' sons, bureaucrats, and businessmen have been detained as of yesterday, unfortunately creates the impression that there is something very rotten in the Republic of Turkey. Those close to the government first of all, and generally the anti-Hizmet writers in the media, did not hesitate to cling to the cliche that this operation was a manifestation of the 'power struggle between the Government and the Community.' Some, after starting by admitting they knew nothing about the subject, were even able to claim that the operation was started by the Community on the instructions of the USA.

"I am not as certain as these people about how the operation should be interpreted. Moreover, I continue to be 'naive' enough to believe that there are still prosecutors and police officers in Turkey who are primarily committed to democracy, rule of law, and their duties, regardless of their political views or religious beliefs. What concerns me is that, whoever started it and for whatever motive, some rotten things in the Republic of Turkey are being uncovered through this and other investigations and the filth is being cleaned. What concerns me is what the government will do about the investigations that concern 3 ministers through their sons, and one minister directly.

"There appear to be different views within the ruling AKP party on this matter. AKP Deputy Chairman and party spokesman Huseyin Celik says, 'As the AK Party, we want everything that needs to be done for the truth to be revealed to be done completely…'

Isn't the foremost requirement for this that the relevant ministers step down? After all, didn't Finance Minister Mehmet Simsek say 'If such a thing happened to me, my choice would be to resign'?

However, it is sensed that the Prime Minister interprets the investigations as a 'trap' set by 'dirty alliances… gangs…' for the government and is determined not to give way.

"The Deputy Prime Minister also speaks of psychological warfare against the government, attempts to wear down the government, organizations nested within the state. After all, didn't one of the ministers the investigation concerned declare: 'Nothing will come of this investigation…' The appointment of new prosecutors to the investigation, the removal of some police branch directors from their duties on the allegation that they 'abused their office,' raises the suspicion that the government will try to interfere with the investigation. Will it succeed? I don't know. But I hope not. (…)" (*Zaman*, 19.12.2013)

Old – New Turkey struggle

"Whenever a crisis occurs, I devote more time to commentaries in the foreign press. Because some of them are illuminating, and most are entertaining.

The title of an article commenting on the bribery and corruption investigation involving 4 ministers of the so-called 'AK' Party government, a public bank general manager, and a mayor is 'Religious War…' Many people in Turkey think so too. But is it so?

"In my view, what is happening is this: All the struggles Turkey has witnessed in the 21st century are fundamentally the pains of the transition from the authoritarian modernization defined by Kemalism to liberal modernization that can be roughly defined by EU criteria. On one side there is Old Turkey with its regime that started as single-party rule and turned into military tutelage, with authoritarian secularism and single-identity policies imposed on society. On the other side there is New Turkey trying to establish democracy, human rights, rule of law, and respect for minorities.

"In roughly the first decade of the 21st century, the AKP government headed by Prime Minister Erdogan took the lead of New Turkey by placing EU accession at the center of its program and made considerable progress. Very different (political, economic, cultural) forces, primarily the victims of Old Turkey, each with their own characteristics and expectations, supported the struggle of Erdogan and his party. The New Turkey alliance found its broadest expression in the 2010 referendum (58% yes). This alliance extended from capital groups pleased not with the AKP's religiosity but with the liberalization of the economy, to soldiers who realized that their political role benefited neither the country nor the military.

"In the second decade of the 21st century, the agenda of not the entire AKP but of the Prime Minister ceased to be New Turkey. Erdogan, having received nearly 50% of the vote in the 2011 elections, and assuming that he had fended off coup attempts and that military tutelage had effectively ended, set about implementing his own agenda: to 'make Turkey one of the world's ten largest economies by 2023' he had to gather all

power in his own hands and be as powerful as Putin. The ‘Turkish-style presidential’ system that would not be hindered by separation of powers was the most concise expression of this quest. He began to think that he could be an authoritarian reformer in the tradition of Abdulhamid II and Ataturk, to say that democracy is only about elections. He tried to silence critical voices in the media. He set about repairing his ties with Old Turkey. He began to pretend to be solving the Kurdish problem. While taking on an Islamic Kemalist appearance on one face, on the other face he revived the National Vision Erdogan image; he increased the dose of Islamic populism.

“Erdogan’s third term as prime minister increasingly came to resemble Lord Acton’s words ‘Power corrupts, absolute power corrupts absolutely…’ In the end, it came to his close associates, who believed their power was unlimited, being neck-deep in corruption, as the latest scandal revealed. Erdogan’s performance caused divisions in almost every segment and polarization in society. Even his own party could no longer maintain its unity. The increasingly apparent differences of opinion with President Abdullah Gul, resignations from his party, and rising objections are signs of this.

“The first big sign that the longing for New Turkey would not surrender to Erdogan was last summer’s Gezi Park demonstrations. The second big signal is the current major bribery and corruption investigation initiated by duty-bound prosecutors and police. These developments are leading to the repositioning of the Old and New Turkey alliances and the sharpening of the struggle between the two. In other words, what is happening is not a religious war, but a struggle between Old and New Turkey.” (*Zaman*, 21.12.2013)

The ‘parallel state’ issue

I did not find the claims that the Gulen community had formed a “parallel state,” that is, a state within a state, convincing. For the following reasons:

“First, those convicted in the Balyoz and Ergenekon trials claimed that the accusations against them were based on evidence fabricated by a ‘Fethullahist, F-type’ (that is, related to the ‘community,’ to the Hizmet Movement) ‘secret organization, gang, junta, autonomous power, parallel state’ nested within the judiciary and police. Now the Prime Minister, whose four ministers are under suspicion in the ‘Big bribery and corruption’ investigation, is repeating the same claim. Most recently, the Fenerbahce club president convicted of match-fixing also demanded a retrial of his case with the same claim. It is also observed that there is a widening consensus in public opinion about the existence of a ‘Fethullahist parallel state.’

“I, probably with the information and perspective provided by being a political scientist who has been writing for 11 years in the Zaman newspaper founded by the ‘Community,’ who knows the ‘Community’ well through its media and schools, and who advocates libertarian and pluralist democracy, think that the ‘Parallel State’ claim has turned into a perfect conspiracy theory (in the sense Karl R. Popper explained) that people involved in various types of crimes use to clear themselves. It is also seen that those who harbor hostility toward the Hizmet Movement, of which the cleric Fethullah Gulen is the

inspiration (due to their authoritarian secularist or Islamist ideologies), wholeheartedly adopt and spread this conspiracy theory.

“The main thesis on which the perfect conspiracy theory is built is this: Students who studied (some on scholarship) at the Hizmet Movement’s tutoring centers and schools have gained important positions within the state’s judiciary and security apparatus. On instructions received not from their superiors but from Fethullah Gulen or the leaders of the Hizmet Movement, they trap those they consider enemies of the movement with fabricated evidence and send them to prison.

“This thesis has never seemed logical to me since it was put forward, and therefore not credible. Because: Yes, there are certainly people in the police and judiciary who have affinity with the Hizmet Movement. Turkey is a fairly plural society in terms of political views and religious beliefs, and it is highly likely that people of almost all these views and beliefs exist to one degree or another among police and judicial members. Therefore, it is incompatible with reason and judgment that all police and all judicial staff (including those who gave conviction verdicts in the Balyoz and Ergenekon trials) who played a role at key points of the relevant investigations and trials are ‘F-type.’ Moreover, for the thesis to be acceptable, it must be proven that all the police and judicial members who played a role at key points of the investigations and trials in question are ‘F-type,’ and also that they acted according to instructions received not from their superiors but from Fethullah Gulen and the Hizmet Movement administrators.

“No sane person can argue that there cannot be police and judicial members at the key points of the investigations and trials in question who are primarily loyal to the rule of law, regardless of their political views or religious beliefs. The claim that the investigations and trials in question are conducted by ‘F-type’ people unfortunately also damages the healthy conduct of the judicial process by casting suspicion on police and judicial members.

“It is now well known that pursuant to the decision taken at the NSC in 2004, public servants were profiled according to their religious beliefs and wave after wave of purges were carried out based on this profiling. Now too the Prime Minister is threatening ‘We will go into their dens… we will expose them… we will root them out’; hundreds of police officers are being removed from their duties. As the dismissals resemble a witch hunt, the suspicion in public opinion that the aim is to cover up the ‘Big bribery and corruption’ investigation is gradually strengthening. So much so that even those who have not the slightest sympathy for the Hizmet Movement have begun to say ‘Thank goodness there is a parallel state… They are the only element of checks and balances against authoritarianism and corruption…’

“In my view, if there is a real ‘parallel state’ in Turkey, it is the KCK-PKK with its hierarchy (whose reasons for existence are understandable), chain of command, armed forces, organization that collects taxes, dispenses justice, and tries to put Kurds under tutelage. Isn’t the ultimate aim of the solution, the peace process, to eliminate the reasons for that parallel state’s existence?” (Zaman, 26.12.2013)

The conflict between the AKP government and the Gulen Community or Hizmet Movement, as I mentioned above, started with the closure of the tutoring centers operated by Hizmet and escalated with the December 17-25, 2013 “Corruption and Bribery Operation.” Zaman newspaper editor-in-chief Ekrem Dumanli and Samanyolu broadcast group chairman Hidayet Karaca were detained on December 14, 2014. Karaca was arrested on charges of founding and running a terrorist organization (still in prison); Ekrem Dumanli was released with a travel ban. (It would later be understood that he had sought asylum in the USA.) In my last meeting with him in January 2015, Dumanli would tell me that Erdogan had wanted to make me an AKP parliamentary candidate in 2007; and that in 2013 he had said about me “Why are you still keeping this infidel in the newspaper.”

Conspiracy theory peaked

The claim that the “parallel state” formed by the Gulen Community or Hizmet Movement was responsible for all negative developments in society was spreading rapidly. Against this claim, which I found not at all convincing, I wrote a series of articles starting with the title “Conspiracy theory peaked.”

“In another article titled ‘Conspiracy theory and what we suffer from history,’ referring to Karl R. Popper, I tried to explain what conspiracy theory is as follows: ‘Conspiracy theories are a product of the secularization of religious beliefs. People first explained social events with God. Then natural laws took the place of God, then the laws of history. The most primitive form of secularization of religious beliefs is also conspiracy theories… Capitalists, imperialists, communists, fascists, masons, Zionists, etc. thus appeared on the scene as creators of social events. Yet the subject of social sciences, which try to understand and explain social events, is to examine the “unintended consequences of the intended actions” of the millions who are the actors of social actions. It’s not that conspiracies don’t happen, but conspiracies can only very rarely succeed.’ (*Sabah*, 6.12.1993)

“Frankly, it had never crossed my mind that after more than 30 years, I would witness a perfect conspiracy theory capturing not only everyone in Turkey from the most Islamist to the most secularist, but even people you would normally expect to think soundly. According to the ‘Fethullahist conspiracy, plot’ theory we go to bed and wake up with today: The ‘Fethullahists’ fabricated the Balyoz and Ergenekon trials… They had those tried for KCK-PKK membership imprisoned… They wanted to have the undersecretary of MIT (the National Intelligence Organization) arrested… They wiretapped tens of thousands of people’s phones… They exposed politicians with sex tapes… The club president convicted of match-fixing fell into their trap… The ‘Big bribery and corruption’ investigation is a trap against the AKP government, devised by the USA and Israel and implemented by them… They also killed the three PKK female activists murdered in Paris, they also wanted to search the truck bringing aid to Syrian Turkmens… They even committed the Uludere massacre!

“Many adopt this ‘theory’ with their secularist or Islamist prejudices. The aim of those marketing this is certainly to cover up the wrongdoings and crimes committed.” (*Zaman*, 7.1.2014)

It was supposedly a power struggle…

I answered the questions of readers writing from abroad about what I thought about the fight between the government and the Community as follows:

“… I give no credence to the claim of a ‘power struggle’ between the government and the community. On one side there is a government that is increasingly becoming authoritarian by integrating with the ‘state’; on the other side is a civil society movement that has no claim to power but supports the establishment of democracy… In my view, the ‘Fethullahist parallel state’ claim is a perfect conspiracy theory exploited by both secularists and Islamists, especially by the AKP government which once again confirms the maxim ‘power corrupts, absolute power corrupts absolutely.’

“*As in other places, there are certainly people in the judiciary and police who respect Gulen. This is their democratic right. But if there are among them those who violate laws, who commit crimes, they should of course be tried and punished*. *(Italics added later.)* Is the ‘Big bribery and corruption’ investigation a ‘Fethullahist conspiracy’ as Erdogan claims? I don’t think so. I tend to believe that the investigation was initiated by judicial and police members committed to the law.

“I understand the Gulen movement as a faith-based civil society movement that supports the establishment of democracy and thus the securing of religious freedoms that the Kemalist state kept under pressure. The Gulen movement did not feel affinity for Necmettin Erbakan, who had Islamist tendencies; it supported Erdogan as long as he served democratization; but it adopted a critical stance when he turned toward authoritarianism. Erdogan, as he became more authoritarian, set about suppressing the Gulen movement that he could not control.

“Finally, as for the claim that the Gulen movement is a more dangerous Islamist force than the AKP: The proponents of this claim are perhaps not aware that Turkey is already Muslim enough not to need Islamization. Due to their secularist prejudices, they may not be able to see that Gulen’s libertarian interpretation of Islam in the Sufi tradition is the most effective interpretation against Islamism.” (“It was supposedly a power struggle…” *Zaman*, 16.1.2014)

You can’t fool everyone all the time

I interpreted Prime Minister Erdogan’s claims that the corruption and bribery investigation against members of the government was “slander” as follows:

“As someone who has visited Hizmet’s schools in many countries for about twenty years and seen their cultural and commercial activities on the ground, I believe that the movement, in interaction with both Turkish society and the world, has now acquired a quality of serving not only our country but all of humanity. I find what some members say

about Hizmet noteworthy in terms of showing the point the panic in the government has reached. The Prime Minister is instructing ambassadors: 'Tell the world that the corruption investigation is slander, an attempted coup! Expose the organization! Ambassadors are responsible!..' I do not think that either sensible ambassadors or the governments they are addressing will pay attention to this fairy tale. What this government is doing brings to my mind an American saying: 'You can fool some of the people some of the time, but you can never fool all of the people all of the time.'" (*Zaman*, 18.1.2014)

The statements of some AKP spokespeople indicated that they too did not believe the claim that the corruption and bribery investigation was a conspiracy set up by the "Fethullahist parallel state" against the government. Upon this I wrote the following:

"The AKP administration is trying to suppress and cover up the biggest bribery and corruption investigation in the history of the Republic with the claim that it is a plot, a coup attempt, designed by the USA and Israel against the government and implemented by the 'Fethullahist parallel state,' that is, by judicial and police members who receive instructions from Fethullah Gulen. The effort is being continued on the one hand with the ugliest conceivable insults against Hocaefendi and the Hizmet movement, and on the other hand with the effort to put the judiciary under the command of the Minister of Justice.

"However, it is becoming increasingly clear that the 'parallel state' fairy tale is an excuse that everyone from bribers to real coup plotters, almost everyone convicted of various crimes, takes refuge in to be cleared. First it emerged that in a three-page report prepared on April 18, 2013, 8 months before the operation launched within the Istanbul Chief Public Prosecutor's Office on December 17, MIT, which the Prime Minister trusts greatly, focused on the relationship of the arrested businessman Reza Zarrab with some ministers, and in the conclusion section of the report, warned the Prime Minister personally that 'if the ministers' relationship with Zarrab is revealed, this situation could be used against the government.' (See: Arzu Yildiz, *T24*, January 5, 2014) (…)

"It appears that even government members themselves have difficulty believing the 'parallel state' fairy tale. Indeed, Customs and Trade Minister Hayati Yazici said that he 'did not find the parallel state claims very realistic… the claims need to be substantiated with evidence and documents.' I have the impression that Deputy Prime Minister Bulent Arinc is also not convinced by the 'parallel state' claim. Speaking to a local television station in Bursa, Arinc first said: 'We have nothing to say about the respected person said to be at the head of the community. We cannot even flick a finger at one of the people who have embraced the whole world…'

"If we are to believe these words, we must first judge that Arinc does not adopt the Prime Minister's words about Hocaefendi: 'False prophet, fake saint, hollow travesty of a scholar…' Arinc then implies that not the community but some of its members are trying to stage a coup against the government and addresses whoever they are: 'They should say we have no problem with this government. They haven't said so until now. We have no intention of overthrowing the government, wearing it down, or bringing someone else

in its place. If you say we are cutting ties with those among us who do wrong, this problem will end in a day…' (*Zaman*, January 26, 2014)

"I don't understand. According to the Prime Minister, aren't these people 'parallel state, crazed Hashashins, organization, gang…'? Didn't the Prime Minister say 'we will go into their dens, we will root them out, we will extinguish their hearths'? If there is such a 'parallel state,' isn't it imperative that they be caught and tried? How can the 'problem end in a day' if they say 'we have no problem with the government'? But I understand Mr. Arinc, in reality you too don't believe this hogwash. Yet I thought you had 'specific weight'; that you were your party's 'conscience.' I was wrong." (*Zaman*, 30.1.2014)

Yes, crime and punishment are personal

I wrote about the claim that the December 17-25 "corruption and bribery" investigation was a coup attempt by the Community against the AKP government as follows:

"Prime Minister Erdogan, in Germany, in response to the question 'Can the corruption investigation shake confidence in the economy?' said that there could be corruption by individuals, but the claim that the administration committed corruption was not true. The Prime Minister is right. In countries where the rule of law based on human rights applies, both crime and punishment are personal; that is, people can neither be collectively accused nor collectively punished.

"Furthermore, a person is presumed innocent until found guilty at the end of a trial. It is not the AKP government that is alleged to have committed corruption, but the members of this government against whom summaries of proceedings have been prepared. They are considered innocent until their crimes are established by a court. However, at the Prime Minister's request, they have resigned from their positions to make it possible for them to be tried fairly. Their immunity needs to be lifted.

"Yes, the Prime Minister is right. But it is quite clear that he does not believe even a bit of what he says. In the angry speeches he gives almost every day, he does not refrain from collectively accusing Fethullah Gulen Hocaefendi and the Hizmet Movement that he inspires, the 'community,' of being a 'parallel state, gang, organization, crazed Hashashins…' preparing a 'coup' against the AKP government with the bribery and corruption investigation.

"*These collective accusations are unjust and unlawful. Among judicial and police members, there may be and certainly are those who feel affinity with the Hizmet Movement, the 'community.' Feeling affinity with the Hizmet Movement is not a crime and cannot be. However, if among these people there are those who act on instructions received not from their superiors but from the Hizmet Movement, as claimed, they should of course be brought before the judiciary with evidence and documents; they should be removed from duty for a fair trial; and if the judiciary decides they are guilty, they should be sentenced to the punishments prescribed by law. (Italics added later.)*

"There is not the slightest hesitation about all this, but the Prime Minister and his close circle's collective accusation of the Hizmet Movement, launching a witch hunt based on

this accusation, displacing 5,000 police officers and hundreds of prosecutors is compatible neither with democratic morality nor with the concept of rule of law. In this context, on the one hand some circles (rightfully) demanding that ministers subject to corruption allegations be held accountable, and on the other hand the Prime Minister and his close circle constantly making the 'parallel state' accusation against the Hizmet Movement, virtually screaming 'Death to the Community!' is compatible neither with democratic morality, nor with secularism, nor with the concept of rule of law." (*Zaman*, 8.2.2014)

The essence of the matter is the struggle for freedom

In my article that came out two days after the article I quoted above, I also analyzed what had happened since the AKP came to power in 2002:

"The fact is that the Justice and Development Party (AKP), which came to power in 2002, took important steps toward adopting the Copenhagen criteria through constitutional and legal amendments, drawing on the support of Turkey's European Union accession process that began when it was accepted as a candidate for membership in 1999. These steps were reciprocated by the EU with the launch of accession negotiations. (One should doubt the intelligence of those who characterize intellectuals who supported the AKP government's reforms in this direction as 'useful idiots.')

"Supporters of military tutelage made direct military coup attempts to sabotage the reforms they found contrary to their authoritarian Kemalist principles and threatening to their privileges; they tried to have the AKP shut down through a judicial coup. The AKP government neutralized these threats with the support of the great majority who were in favor of establishing democracy, including soldiers who believed that the political role it played was damaging to the prestige and professional responsibilities of the Turkish Armed Forces. On one hand, the improvement in the average citizen's standard of living through economic growth, on the other hand, the de facto if not legal end of military tutelage, won the AKP approximately half the votes in the 2011 elections. The significance of the 2011 elections for democracy in Turkey was that it indicated that one of the two fundamental principles of libertarian and pluralist democracy, as expressed in EU criteria, namely the principle of governance by elected governments, was being established.

"However, the elected government quickly entered into a trend of arbitrariness and authoritarianism, the signs of which began to appear just before the 2011 elections. The top-down arbitrary and authoritarian governance based on the justification of defending 'Ataturk's principles and revolutions' was replaced by a form based on the 'national will.' Prime Minister Erdogan said, with the claim that he would 'make Turkey one of the world's 10 largest economies' by 2023, 'I want a Turkish-style presidential system where the legislature and executive don't get in my way.' He began to emulate Putin. (My article titled 'Does Erdogan Want to Be Putin?' was published in *Zaman* three years ago on February 8, 2011.)

“TRT became the government’s mouthpiece. Part of the private media came under the Prime Minister’s command through owners dependent on government contracts. Critical writers began to be fired from their jobs. The Prime Minister monopolized all decisions from what would or wouldn’t be written in media loyal to him to who would get which public contract. Court of Accounts audits were restricted. Finance inspectors began to be sent after businessmen who angered the Prime Minister. The Prime Minister increasingly adopted an attitude of seeing himself as a shepherd, the people as a flock, identifying himself with the state. Every day he would interfere in citizens’ lifestyles, including how many children they should have, scolding and threatening opponents.

“In the summer of 2013, mass demonstrations that began in Istanbul’s Taksim Gezi Park and spread across the country gave the first signs of rising opposition against the increasingly arbitrary and authoritarian AKP administration. The attempt to close prep schools was a sign of the AKP government’s search to suppress civil society as well. The major bribery and corruption investigation that began on December 17, 2013, containing allegations about at least 5 ministers, businessmen and bureaucrats close to the government, and the Prime Minister’s family members, revealed that the AKP government was not only becoming authoritarian but was also the government facing the most serious corruption charges in the history of the Republic.

“Since December 17, we have been witnessing the administrative and legal measures taken by the AKP government to cover up the corruption investigation, using the ‘parallel state’ lie as a pretext: These measures ranged from the transfer of hundreds of prosecutors, judges, and police officers from their posts to the Judicial Police Regulation, from changes to the HSYK Law to changes in internet legislation. These steps came to threaten not only to wipe out Turkey’s gains in the area of freedoms and rights over the past decade, but also democracy itself in the sense of governance by elected governments.

“*The essence of the matter is this: Just as Turkey was beginning to believe that it had left behind the military-bureaucratic tutelage regime and established democracy in the sense of governance by elected governments, it is faced with the elected government moving to stifle freedoms. (Italics added later.)* Now a struggle for freedom and rule of law is being waged against an increasingly arbitrary and authoritarian prime minister and a clique around him who have tied their political careers to him. Turkey cannot solve any fundamental problem, neither secularism nor the Kurdish issue, without establishing libertarian and pluralist democracy through this struggle. It is time for responsible members of the AKP to see this reality too, because the course is not good for the party any more than it is for the country.” (*Zaman*, 11.2.2014)

Disappointments: Gul and Arinc

I believed that Abdullah Gul and Bulent Arinc did not approve of the path Erdogan was taking. In time, this would also become apparent. However, I was also hoping that they would oppose Erdogan. I expressed my disappointment on this matter as follows:

“In the late 1990s, I found an opportunity to have a private conversation with each of Tayyip Erdogan, Abdullah Gul, and Bulent Arinc, who would later form the top leadership

of the AKP, only once. (In my effort to stay away from political, economic, administrative, and other power holders, the role of my personality that does not enjoy unequal relationships was greater than the journalism principle of not getting too close to news sources.) … I opposed Gul's ascent to Cankaya on the grounds that it would be a waste of talent, but I respectfully accepted it when the Grand National Assembly deemed it appropriate. I generally appreciated Gul's performance at Cankaya. Arinc, whom I believed played an important role in overcoming the mentality widespread in the Welfare Party that saw democracy as a 'Greek deception,' became a politician who succeeded in presenting himself to society as the voice of common sense and conscience in the AKP, despite his occasionally unbecoming statements.

"It appears that the arbitrary and authoritarian leadership that the Prime Minister has been pursuing since the last general elections has disturbed both of them. They expressed in various ways that they did not adopt Erdogan's harsh response to the Gezi Park demonstrations. Gul stated several times that democracy is not just about elections. It was heard that Arinc came to the brink of resignation in the face of Erdogan's bluster. He openly asked Erdogan to respect his 'specific gravity.' The attitudes of both toward the December 17 bribery and corruption investigation were also different from Erdogan's. It is obvious that they did not approve of the 'parallel state, gang, organization, crazed Hashashin' rhetoric that Erdogan used to cover up the investigation. Nor the hate speech directed at Fethullah Gulen Hocaefendi in the form of 'false prophet, fake saint, sham scholar'…

"Neither of them can fail to see that the Prime Minister is declaring almost everyone who does not think like him a traitor; polarizing society in a very dangerous way; destroying the rule of law to cover up corruption; in short, following a line incompatible with reason, prudence, and logic. It is plainly obvious that where the Prime Minister is leading will cause great harm to the country. The majority of society believes that these two leading politicians' loyalty to the country's interests is much stronger than what they feel for the Prime Minister; they expect them to put a stop to this course that will cause great harm to both the country and the party. President Gul should veto the laws that trample on freedoms and the rule of law that come before him. Otherwise, his respectability will be damaged." ("What is expected from Abdullah Gul and Bulent Arinc," *Zaman*, 13.2.2014)

When it became clear that neither Gul nor Arinc would do what was expected of them, I would write: "Unfortunately, Gul chose the path of being satisfied with partially correcting the laws leading the country to a police state, acting not as a president but as the former prime minister of the AKP. By acting this way, sadly, he continues to be worn down. As for Arinc, who is preparing to retire, it is obvious that he does not see in himself the 'specific gravity' to stop the disastrous course. Are there no AKP deputies with reason, prudence, and morality who are worried about the future of both the country and their party? Perhaps there are. Ultimately, the matter is left to the people. Fortunately, there are three elections ahead of us." (*Zaman*, 27.2.2014)

Unfortunately, the number of AKP deputies who were worried about the country's future did not exceed the fingers of one hand. Unfortunately, when the matter was left to the people, the AKP would win the elections.

The ultimate goal of the Hizmet Movement

In forming my conviction that the Gulen Community supported libertarian and pluralist democracy and the economy in Turkey, in addition to people I knew at the *Zaman* newspaper and what I saw in schools it opened domestically and abroad, the comments of some observers whose views I valued also played a role. One of the publications that supported this conviction was the articles in the book *Toward an Islamic Enlightenment: The Gulen Movement* (Oxford University Press, 2012) by Hakan Yavuz, a professor of political science at the University of Utah in the USA. I had written the following about the book:

"It certainly cannot be said that this study has the last word on both Gulen's views and the examination of the Hizmet Movement's evolution over time, that it is satisfying in every respect, and it has aspects open to criticism. It can be said that the author having made critical statements about the Gulen movement from time to time makes his study even more noteworthy. (…)

"I can summarize the most noteworthy argument, which also gives the book its title, as follows: There is no single interpretation of Islam. Like all other religions, the history of Islam is a history of different interpretations. The processes of modernization and globalization have essentially led to two different interpretations. Fundamentalists who reject modernization advocate a pure Islam based on the Quran and what the Prophet Muhammad said and did. Those who advocate Islam's compatibility with modernity (democracy, human rights, secularism as freedom of belief, respect for different identities, economic development, and science) have rescued Islam from its rigid and bigoted interpretations and reinterpreted it to meet the spiritual and material needs of Muslims. Enlightenment, in essence, is not the rejection of religion (as claimed by the prevalent shallow understanding in Turkey), but the use of critical reason and science in understanding society and the universe. In Turkey, Said Nursi and Fethullah Gulen are Islamic thinkers who apply reason and science to the interpretation of religion for social and cultural reforms aimed at building a more humane society.

"A question that is emphasized both in Turkey and in the outside world is what the 'ultimate goal' of Gulen and his movement is. Yavuz's answers are as follows: *'As this research reveals, the goal of the Gulen movement is neither to establish hegemony over society nor to seize control of the Turkish state. The goal is to reshape society and politics by strengthening the sense of morality and virtue among believers, in society, in the state, and in humanity… The movement's main political goal is to transform society by raising individuals' moral consciousness. By raising moral consciousness, the movement aims to cleanse the bureaucracy of widespread corruption, increase the effectiveness and transparency of state institutions, revive public work ethics to strengthen the state's legitimacy, and create areas of opportunity for the marginalized segments of the Anatolian people.' (Italics added later.)*" (*Zaman*, 22.2.2014)

After so many years and so much that has happened since then, I can say today that I have deep doubts about the judgment that "The movement's main political goal is to transform society by raising individuals' moral consciousness…"

How will this filth be cleaned up?

I thought that the “theory” that almost everyone who does wrong or commits a crime clings to, that unites secularists and Islamists, that all evils originate from the “parallel state, parallel structure, Fethullahist gang” was heading toward bankruptcy. However, in time the exact opposite would prove true, that is, the “theory” would unite secularists and Islamists. But I was writing that the steps of the “theory’s” bankruptcy were listed in the eleven questions that the leader of the main opposition party CHP, Kemal Kilicdaroglu, asked Tayyip Erdogan:

“Did the parallel state give the 700,000 lira watch to a minister? Did the parallel state put the 4.5 million dollars in the shoe box? Did the parallel state place seven safes, at least as tall as you, in the ministers’ children’s bedrooms? Did the parallel state place the millions of dollars, Euros, Turkish Liras in those safes? Did the parallel state place the money counting machines in the bedrooms? Did the parallel state take you as a family on Sarraf’s private plane to umrah? Four ministers resigned when their names were tainted by corruption. Did the parallel state make those four ministers resign?..

“You created a 630 million dollar pool, starting from 100 million dollars each, to create a partisan media for yourself. Did the parallel state create this pool? Your son Bilal Erdogan founded a foundation called TURGEV. Those who received contracts from the state paid bribes to that foundation. Did the parallel state have your son establish that foundation? When four ministers were resigning, did the parallel state ask you to have a declaration signed in your favor? You sold a governor for two villas. Did the parallel state advise you to sell a governor for two villas? And Kilicdaroglu asked the 12th and final question at the last CHP group meeting, in essence: On the morning of December 17, did the parallel state tell you to have your son Bilal immediately distribute the money in his house? (…)

“The main opposition leader says of the audio recording, ‘As real as Mount Ararat, as Mount Erciyes…’ Anyway, it is plainly obvious that the claim that the recording was ‘doctored’ has no meaning other than an effort to cover up the scandal. The real question that needs to be asked is this: How will this unbelievable corruption, this filth be cleaned up? The truth is, of course, as Kilicdaroglu said, that Erdogan should either resign or leave the country. I don’t consider these impossible. However, unfortunately the greater probability is that Erdogan, with an attitude incompatible with reason, prudence, and morality, will try to hold on tightly to power, not hesitating to drag the country into great turmoil for this purpose.” (*Zaman*, 27.2.2014)

In the time that has passed until the day these lines were written, the following was seen: Kilicdaroglu not only failed to get answers to the above questions but also gave up asking them. Erdogan not only did not resign or leave the country but also succeeded in gathering all power in his own hands. But I was not wrong on one point: This success of his was leading the country toward a major economic and political crisis.

This nation is not ‘blockheaded’

In those days, I was asking myself this question: “Can Erdogan and his clique stay in power, can they turn Turkey into a police state?” I was answering as follows:

“My answer is clear and open. No, never! Erdogan and his clique are covering up the biggest corruption investigation in history step by step, erasing its traces, making up lie after lie every day, and thus may think they will eventually escape being tried. But they have long been convicted in the conscience of the nation. A growing majority of the nation, (in Erdogan’s definition, the ‘national will’) is no longer behind this clique.

“The opposition parties, whose votes are steadily rising, have rendered their verdict on Erdogan and his clique. After the filth that has emerged, they are demanding that he resign and be tried. The CHP leader said, ‘A thief cannot be prime minister…’ The MHP chairman said, ‘The Prime Minister must account for his shamelessness in denying the theft…’ The BDP leader said, ‘Walking with this government has become impossible…’ It is becoming increasingly clear that this clique is also an obstacle to the resolution process. Increasingly broader segments of civil society want Erdogan and his clique to resign and be tried. The US administration is exposing the corruption scandal in Turkey and the human rights violations committed to cover it up. The EU has never come so close to suspending membership negotiations. Erdogan and his clique, unfortunately, are destroying our reputation in the eyes of the world.

“I’m sure the majority of the AKP group in Parliament, who don’t see their political fate tied to the clique, are anxiously thinking about how their party will survive this ordeal. A growing segment of our citizens who voted for the AKP is distancing themselves from Erdogan and his clique. An increasing portion of believing citizens are saying, ‘Islam is incompatible with corruption and lying…’

“A visible village needs no guide: Whatever he does, the end of Erdogan and his clique’s power is in sight. The people of Turkey, this nation is not ‘blockheaded’! The people of Turkey no longer want to be ruled by the military stick or the police stick; they are standing up for their rights and law. This people did not bring the AKP to power because they were ‘blockheaded’; because they are not ‘blockheaded,’ they will know how to end the power of Erdogan and his clique, and will not allow them to ‘screw the nation over.’” (*Zaman*, 01.03.2014)

After so much time has passed, perhaps I can say that this has been understood: A large segment of the people in Turkey may not have a demand for the establishment of freedom and democracy; they can only change their preferences when livelihood concerns come knocking at the door.

“Why should I criticize the Community”

In early 2014, I had begun to face questions about why I was not criticizing the Community. My answer to these questions summarized what I thought about the Community at that time:

“Some of my readers ask: ‘Why don’t you criticize the Community?!..’ Some are also surprised: ‘Why aren’t you neutral in the dispute between the government and the Community?!’ It is possible to find the answer to these questions in my writings over the past approximately 20 years. But, apparently, it is useful to give a collective answer to these questions in these days when Erdogan and his clique are showering Fethullah Gulen and the Hizmet Movement he inspires with baseless accusations, insults, and threats. Actually, my answer is essentially another question: Why should I criticize the Community?

“I call Gulen ‘Hocaefendi’ because he is a cleric I respect. Yes, I am not a religious person at all. But I am not at all someone (like Marxists and Kemalists) who wants religion to be excluded from the public sphere; who sees religious beliefs as an obstacle to modernization in the contemporary, liberal sense. Religious beliefs are as indispensable a need for people as bread and water. Religions have both bigoted, fundamentalist interpretations that reject modernization in the liberal sense, and interpretations that support and embrace it. In my view, Gulen is a religious scholar of worldwide value with his interpretation that reconciles liberal modernity with Islamic faith.

“I refer to the ‘Community’ as the Hizmet Movement, because I believe that characterizing it as a faith-based civil society movement is more accurate. I am not one of those who, like secularists (that is, authoritarian Kemalists or Marxists), adopt the claim that there cannot be a religion-based civil society movement. My view of religion is based on liberal principles that prioritize freedom of expression. There can certainly be a civil society movement based on religious belief that is independent of the state and advocates freedoms, and there are many examples of this in the world. The strongest example in Turkey is undoubtedly the Hizmet Movement. I see the Hizmet Movement as one of the most influential civil society forces providing unique support to Turkey’s development, solidarity, democratization, and integration with the world. Why should I criticize the Community?

“I give no credence whatsoever to the ‘Fethullahist state, structure, gang’ claims that almost everyone who commits crimes, most recently those caught in the largest bribery and corruption investigation in the history of the Republic, takes refuge in and uses to clear themselves. I see these claims as a full-blown conspiracy theory diametrically opposed to reason, logic, prudence, and scientific thought. Gulen is a human being, therefore of course he is not infallible. *The Hizmet Movement, consisting of institutions spread around the world in the fields of education, media, commerce, industry, and social solidarity, perhaps encompasses hundreds of thousands. Of course, wrongdoers and lawbreakers can emerge from within this movement.* But it is unacceptable to portray Gulen and the Hizmet Movement as ‘the gang at the source of all evil.’

“Let’s not get into the others. I was not convinced in the slightest that the *Sledgehammer, Ergenekon, and KCK cases, based on allegations of coup attempts and attempts to establish a real ‘parallel state,’ were ‘conspiracies produced to throw innocent people in prison.’ But I always wrote and said that unjust, unnecessary detentions were made in these cases, that detention was turned into punishment, that defense rights were violated, and that these wrongs needed to be corrected. I also*

argued that the release of those convicted in these cases through a general amnesty was a social necessity. *(Italics added later.)* I have always defended all fundamental rights and freedoms of citizens, including the right to a fair trial, and the democratic group rights of Kurds (including secession by referendum). I have always opposed the provisions of the Anti-Terror Law that are incompatible with freedom of expression. But I am equally opposed to the armed impositions of both military tutelage supporters and the PKK. It is certain that, due to my profession and expertise, I focused on the political rather than legal aspects of the above-mentioned cases.

"It is inconceivable that among police and judiciary members in Turkey there are not those who feel intellectual affinity with various parties, political and ethnic groups, sects, religious orders and communities, including the Hizmet Movement which provides great support for young people from poor families in Anatolia to study and acquire professions. If this is a more or less democracy rather than a Kemalist or Islamist dictatorship, it is the right of all these people to serve within the state bureaucracy; to act according to their knowledge, beliefs, and consciences. *If among these there are those who violate laws, who receive orders from outside rather than from their superiors, who do not comply with the requirements of the rule of law, they should of course be caught, brought before the judiciary, and punished. Within the Hizmet Movement, which encompasses hundreds of thousands, there may be lawbreakers as well as agents, informers, and turncoat witnesses (who, in line with Kemalist practices, kept files on and monitored religious citizens). (Italics added later.)*

"Both Gulen and the Journalists and Writers Foundation, which is the spokesperson for the Hizmet Movement, have repeatedly called for them to be caught and tried. If this is a state of law (if Soviet law does not apply here), it is probably not the movement's responsibility to prove that it is not 'a gang that sets traps for innocent people and throws them in prison.' It is also out of the question for me to criticize them by saying 'Why don't you prove to society that you did not set up a conspiracy…'

"It is said, 'The Community has transformed from a religious community into a political organization… Let them establish a party…' Truly, there cannot be a claim so contrary to the democratic order. In democracies, politics is never just the business of politicians and political parties. Politics is also the business of workers' and employers' organizations, associations, foundations, all civil society organizations, of course the media, and individual citizens.

"It may be said, 'Why don't you criticize this or that particular view of the Community?' What we are talking about is a very broad civil society movement. There are people with very different views and preferences within it. Very different ideas are also put forward in media close to the Community. In my commentaries, I defend libertarian and pluralist democracy and mainly criticize the statements and behaviors of politicians that contradict this ideal. When we speak of the Community's view, probably only the statements made by Gulen himself and the Journalists and Writers Foundation can be taken as a basis. If I have not encountered in these statements a matter that contradicts the libertarian and pluralist democracy I defend and that must be addressed and criticized, why should I criticize?

“It is said that it is not ‘transparent’… I don’t know how much more transparent and visible a social movement that spearheads the establishment of schools, universities, media organizations, foundations, associations, and companies can be in Turkey’s current conditions. Let’s say you want movement members to carry membership cards, to hang signs saying ‘This is a Hizmet Movement organization’ on their institutions. Then first, (as I and all freedom advocates do), advocate secularism in the true sense, that is, where the state maintains equal distance from all beliefs. Then fight for the establishment of a regime where freedom of religion and conscience is fully established and respected, where belief groups including non-believers can have legal personality, where they are not discriminated against in any way, where they are not kept under threat and pressure. How far we are from a true secular order is evident, isn’t it, from the uninterrupted profiling carried out for years on the orders of the National Security Council; from ‘plans to finish off the Community’ that envisage ‘secretly planting weapons and drugs in Community dormitories and trying their members on terrorist organization charges’?

“In short: The unjust, baseless accusations directed at the Community by radical secularists and Islamists; the heavy insults and threats showered upon it, deeply wound my sense of fairness. How can I be expected to remain neutral in the dispute between a government whose legitimacy has become questionable as the subject of the largest bribery and corruption investigation in the history of the Republic and the ‘Community’? In Turkey’s suffocating media environment, under pressure first from the military and bosses, then from the government and bosses, struggling with censorship and self-censorship, the media supported by the ‘Community’ gives a say to me and writers like me who defend libertarian and pluralist democracy (without touching a hair). Why should I criticize the Community?” (*Zaman*, 4.3.2014)

“Even the AKP cannot tolerate this Erdogan”

One of my subsequent articles also carried the errors I fell into in my observations and comments on Turkish politics to their peak. I wrote:

“Where did we start, where have we come? The AKP, headed by Tayyip Erdogan, came to power with the promise of saving Turkey from corruption and prohibitions. An increasing portion of our people supported this promise. In its first two terms, the AKP rendered great services to the country. However, at the point we have reached 12 years later, (thinking of those with sense, honesty, and conscience within it, I cannot bring myself to say AKP government), Erdogan and the clique consisting of certain ministers, bureaucrats, and businessmen gathered around him have shown what the pinnacle of corruption and the epitome of prohibitionism are.

“Some of my friends think that our situation at the point we have reached resembles the Sisyphus legend in ancient Greek mythology. Sisyphus is the king who was eternally condemned by the gods for his crimes of deceit to push a huge rock up to the top of the mountain, only to push it up again when it immediately rolls back down. According to some of my friends, like Sisyphus, we will never succeed in placing the rock at the top, that is, in establishing libertarian and pluralist democracy.

“I don’t think like them. As a member of a generation that in its youth (that is, in the 1960s and 70s) believed that democracy was identical to the dictatorship of the proletariat, I look differently at where we started and where we have come. In my view, we are learning by living and experiencing what libertarian and pluralist democracy is and is not, and progressing step by step toward establishing it. We need to be patient, thinking that what Western countries achieved through centuries of struggle cannot be expected to fit into our 60-70 years.

“Let’s take a look at the adventure of our democratization process that began with the transition to a multi-party system. We spent the second half of the 20th century with a kind of democracy under military tutelage. Soldiers, whose brains were washed in their schools in line with the Republic’s founding philosophy that they were the owners of the homeland and the nation, disrupted the functioning of the democratic process by staging coups four times and attempting coups. In the end, it was seen that military interventions created bigger problems than they solved; we made considerable progress toward establishing the principle of governance by elected, representative governments, one of the two fundamental principles of democracy. It was seen that military tutelage had ended de facto, if not in the constitution and laws. Among soldiers, the awareness spread that the political role they played was shaking the prestige of the Turkish Armed Forces and preventing them from fulfilling their professional duties.

“Then, we witnessed the elected government, which played a major role in ending military tutelage, emboldened by receiving nearly 50 percent of the vote in the last elections, escalate an authoritarianism and corruption that reduces democracy to elections. For the past three years, we have been learning by experience that democracy does not permit the shelving of the rule of law, the trampling of rights and freedoms underfoot. No matter what percentage of votes Erdogan and his clique receive in these elections, their end is in sight. Even the AKP cannot tolerate this Erdogan.” (*Zaman*, 22.3.2014)

“There is no room for pessimism”

With an understanding bordering on naivety in my effort to understand the ongoing process, I could even claim that there was no room for pessimism:

“According to documents published by the *Radikal* newspaper, the head of the Anti-Terror Department of the General Directorate of Security requested in a ‘secret’ letter sent to the security directorates of 30 provinces that it be determined ‘whether the Fethullah Gulen community has an armed force’… He was not satisfied with this; he also requested that the community’s ‘connection’ with the Aziz Santoro, Hrant Dink, Council of State, Zirve Publishing House, Necip Hablemitoglu, and Uzeyir Garih murders be investigated… (July 6)

“The *Taraf* newspaper, with its headline ‘Witch hunt dropped below age 18,’ reported that the same ‘secret’ letter gave instructions to ‘keep files on millions of students who attended Community prep schools and schools and stayed in their dormitories’ over the past ten years. (July 7) It announced that the ‘Cosmic Working Group’ formed within the General Directorate of Security kept files on 100,000 businesses large and small in 81

provinces, saying they ‘may be related to the Community,’ down to their customer profiles. (July 9)

“When I read these news reports that documented with evidence that the government, on Prime Minister Erdogan’s orders, had embarked on an effort to portray the Hizmet Movement as an armed organization, a terrorist organization trying to overthrow the government, and had launched an unprecedented witch hunt for this purpose; then that Erdogan had said at the previous day’s AKP group meeting that he would ‘hold accountable those who remain silent and unresponsive’ against the Hizmet Movement, I thought we were facing a surreal scene in Turkish politics that was impossible to explain with reason and logic, hard to believe was real. *Taraf* was absolutely right in its headline diagnosis of ‘The government has gone mad.’ (…)

“There is no room for pessimism. Turkey is not a society primitive enough to tolerate such an abnormality, such an absurdity for long, to put up with the injustices and evils being done. Sooner or later, but without fail, an accounting will be demanded for these lawless acts.” (“The government has really gone mad,” *Zaman*, 10.7.2014)

Toward a mukhabarat state

Yes, my prediction that Turkish society, including AKP members, would not tolerate Erdogan’s rule was unrealistic to the point of naivety. However, I was not very wrong in my observations about where the ongoing process was taking us:

“It is now clearly seen that the goal of the initiative launched by Prime Minister Erdogan with the claim that the major bribery and corruption investigation was a ‘coup attempt orchestrated by the USA and Israel and implemented by the Pennsylvania organization – parallel state’ was not limited to suppressing the investigation, but that the aim was to take the entire state and society under his control with this pretext. The handcuffed detentions of security personnel who conducted the bribery and corruption investigation on the morning of July 22 were the new step in the implementation of the mukhabarat state. The architect of the mukhabarat state had said, ‘We are developing a project. When it is finished, the process will accelerate. We will open thousands of cases…’ On July 22, in response to a question ‘Could the operation spread to other areas?’, he did not hesitate to express that he was personally running the ‘process’ by saying, ‘Of course, of course…’

“The concept of ‘mukhabarat state,’ which we will apparently use frequently in the coming period, can be defined as follows: The type of regime in which the state’s intelligence organization (including the armed forces) penetrates and controls all social institutions; is not accountable to anyone; holds very broad police powers; and becomes impossible to separate from the government. The concept entered our language because of the Assad dictatorship in Syria, but various examples of the regime in question, with its varying types, can be counted from the totalitarian Soviet Union to the authoritarian Russian Federation. Starting from the definition and examples, it can be said that the end of the road has not yet been reached in the construction of the mukhabarat state in Turkey.

“The Prime Minister, who is a presidential candidate, is justifying the move toward a mukhabarat state with national security threatened by Western allies. Most recently, in his speech at the iftar of Alevi associations in Ankara, he said, ‘Many countries in the Western world are doing everything to set us against each other…’

“Where did we start, where have we come? At least until the 2010 constitutional referendum, we believed that Turkey under AKP rule was progressing toward establishing democracy with reforms made in the EU accession process. Now, under the same government, we are witnessing progress toward a mukhabarat state with the ‘internal and external enemies’ rhetoric frequently used during the military tutelage period, declaring Western allies as enemies.

“Can we stop this course? Absolutely yes! Yes, we gained rich experience in the struggle against army-based authoritarianism, but our accumulated experience against authoritarianism that comes through elections is weak. In the coming period, as democrats who believe in freedom, we must develop this ability. The first step is to do everything we can to prevent Tayyip Erdogan from being elected president.” (*Zaman*, 24.7.2014)

No to Erdogan!

As Turkey was heading toward the presidential election on August 10, 2014, I was saying “No to Erdogan!” with all my might. As follows:

“With the operation launched on July 22, 115 security officers were detained, 31 of whom were arrested. On August 5, with the operation spreading to 14 provinces, 33 more security officers were detained. There is not the slightest doubt that these operations are links in the AKP government’s, primarily Prime Minister Erdogan’s, effort to take revenge on judicial and security personnel who served in the December 17-25 investigation, the largest bribery and corruption investigation in the history of the Republic.

“CHP leader Kilicdaroglu said, ‘This is a revenge operation against the police who exposed the bribery and corruption…’ MHP leader Devlet Bahceli said of the operation, ‘It is nothing but the thieves’ action to cover up the theft…’ HDP leader and presidential candidate Selahattin Demirtas said the operation was conducted ‘with a feeling of vengeance and revenge,’ and that ‘the order was given by the Prime Minister.’ The fact that the main opposition leaders are in full agreement on this matter gives sufficient idea of what the truth is.

“It is very clear that the law was trampled underfoot in the revenge operation. (See ‘9 articles of the European Convention on Human Rights were violated 11 times.’ *Zaman*, August 4, 2014.) The facts that emerged due to the operation showed that the prosecuted security officers, contrary to the claim that they constituted a ‘Fethullahist parallel state,’ had very different identities; that they acted on orders given by their superiors. (…)

“What Tayyip Erdogan said on the NTV - Star TV broadcast on the evening of August 5 gave a very noteworthy clue as to what kind of person we were about to elect as president. Erdogan, while explaining his words at a rally, ‘Kilicdaroglu, you are Alevi, I am Sunni. Say this. Demirtas, you are Zaza. Don’t be afraid to say this…’, uttered these shameful words implying a dark racist mentality: ‘What’s wrong with that? Either appear as you are or be as you appear. The things they said about me. One came out, the same mentality, and said he’s ’Georgian.’ Another came out and, excuse me, said with much uglier things that he’s Armenian…’

“What Devlet Bahceli said in his speech in Izmir on July 30 contained perhaps the most striking depiction of under what conditions the presidential election was being held: ‘Can a man who was caught while emptying the Treasury, while embezzling the state’s coffers, become president? Can someone who paves the way for bribe-takers, who shelters thieves, who stocks robbery money in villas become president? Can someone who releases the immoral people who hid millions of dollars in shoe boxes and bedrooms become president? Someone who calls a money launderer and gold smuggler charlatan a philanthropist, calls a box banker naive, calls pool businessmen the pride of Turkey, and brands those who pursue theft as traitors – he can be anything but one thing he will not be is president…’

“I fear he can be, and in that case very great troubles await Turkey. If you don’t want this, act with civic consciousness, go to the ballot box, and say ‘No to Erdogan!’” (*Zaman*, 7.8.2014)

The above lines also remind us how MHP Chairman Devlet Bahceli could transform from a harsh opponent of Erdogan to an uncompromising ally.

“Supreme leader Erdogan”

As expected, Erdogan won the presidential election held on August 10, 2014. But I persisted in my errors, not giving up the idea that not just Turkey, but even the AKP would not be able to tolerate Erdogan for long. I wrote:

“(…) I absolutely do not share the pessimistic views that the establishment of a kind of ‘one party, one man’ regime, an autocracy, could be possible in Turkey. As I have always written and said, the gains provided by the services the AKP itself rendered to the country in its first two terms of power, the spread of awareness of freedom and respect for difference, the globalization of the economy, the increasing integration with the democratic world do not allow for the revival of the ‘old old Turkey.’ Yes, even the AKP cannot tolerate this course for long.

“Are the signs of this not already visible? Are not some of its founders crying out that the path being followed will drag the country into troubles? Is the conflict within the party between the ‘newcomers’ and the ‘elders-veterans’ not an expression of this? Are not all the tricks to prevent Abdullah Gul from returning to politics, the smear campaign against him, signs of this? Is there not an expectation of ‘when will the uprising of the Guls come’?

“A question I wonder about is this: How is it that Tayyip Erdogan, who is certainly quite an intelligent person, cannot see the following? What made Erdogan successful were the liberating, democratizing reforms he pursued in his first two terms of power, the style that embraced the whole of society and aimed at adopting universal values. Mustafa Kemal Pasha also succeeded in liberating Turkey from occupation and subjugation and rebuilding it with his style and practices that embraced the whole society, respected all identities, and were liberating and democratizing. ‘Supreme leader Ataturk,’ who is identified with one-party, one-man rule, however, laid the foundations of the deep-rooted problems we still cannot leave behind today, namely authoritarianism, commandism, worship of power, militarism, intolerance of civil society, disrespect for difference, identities, and beliefs. ‘Supreme leader Erdogan’ can only cook up new troubles for us.” (*Zaman*, 30.8.2014)

Time to stand against authoritarianism

I was calling on society to resist the increasingly darkening one-man rule, authoritarianism:

“We are living in an international conjuncture where storms are blowing in our region, in both our northern and southern neighbors. We are in a period when there is the greatest need to protect domestic peace and stability by strengthening democracy, rule of law, human rights, and respect for minorities. Yet a narrow clique that has entrenched itself at the head of the ruling Justice and Development Party is leading the country toward a corrupt, arbitrary, and authoritarian one-man rule.

“The country’s fault lines are cracking. Mistakes that provoke Turkish-Kurdish, Sunni-Alevi, and all other social divisions are being persisted in, and even Sunnis and Kurds are being set against each other. Attempts are being made to suppress criticism. Attempts are being made to silence the opposition, which is indispensable to the democratic regime, with accusations of ‘Traitors, scoundrels, ingrates…’ and openly with the words ‘Shut up, we don’t need your ideas…’ What we are experiencing presents an almost surreal scene that evokes a feeling incompatible with Turkey’s level of development… We cannot allow the country to be taken back to the old days, to the painful days of the 1990s, with the nonsense of a New Turkey. Against the worrying course, we must voice our criticisms without bowing to pressure and threats…” (*Zaman*, 16.10.2014)

Due to my identity as an academic and commentator, I was one of those whose views foreign observers frequently consulted in those years. A conference I attended at the University of Macedonia in Thessaloniki, in neighboring Greece, in November 2014 provided a good example of what kind of questions I generally faced and the answers I gave to them. I leave it to readers to judge how accurate or inaccurate I was in my answers.

“*Where is the ‘resolution process’ going?* It is very clear that Turkey cannot find peace or maintain its integrity without making peace with the Kurds at home and abroad. The AKP administration’s main concern is to protect power; for this, not to lose half of the Kurdish votes. With this calculation, it is conducting the ‘resolution process’ with the logic of ‘the

process is everything, the result is nothing…' The PKK, on the other hand, is benefiting from the process to consolidate its forces. What the result will be is impossible to predict.

"*Is the AKP Islamist-Sunni?* The AKP government did not promise sharia, did not advocate turning its back on the West, and also made many reforms for EU membership. Its ideology is not Islamism but at most religious nationalism, but its main compass is to hold on to power and continue to benefit from its fruits; to do whatever is necessary for this. It engages in Islamic populism domestically, addressing the Sunni majority, but in foreign policy its dialogue with Shiite-majority Iran is good, whereas there is no dialogue left with Sunni-majority Egypt; now an enemy, but before 2011 it was hand in glove with Alawite Bashar al-Assad. (…)

"*How do you see the future of the AKP government?* As everywhere in the world, the economy is decisive in Turkey too. However, Turkey is not as primitive a society as the AKP administration thinks. In a country where the opposition and civil society are quite strong, the people cannot tolerate an arbitrary, authoritarian government tainted by corruption for long. The AKP may win the upcoming elections, but Erdogan's 'Turkish-style' presidency is now a pipe dream.

"*'What happened to the AKP-Gulen community alliance?'* We call the faith-based civil society movement formed by the counsel of religious scholar Fethullah Gulen the Hizmet Movement. Hizmet is not a politically-aimed movement, but it has an indirect influence on domestic and foreign policy through the foundations it established, media organizations, and schools spread around the world. Like everyone who wanted military tutelage to end in Turkey and libertarian democracy to be established, Hizmet also supported the AKP government in its first two terms of power when it acted in this direction. Many civil society organizations did the same. But there was no 'political alliance' between the AKP and Hizmet. If there were, presumably a considerable portion of the AKP's parliamentary group would consist of people close to Hizmet; these people would vote no confidence in the government when they deemed necessary. Nothing like this was seen. The AKP government is trampling the rule of law underfoot with the nonsense that a 'conspiracy' was set up against it through the December 17-25 corruption investigation, conducting a witch hunt against Hizmet." (*Zaman*, 25.11.2014)

The December 14 operation

On December 14, 2014, *Zaman*'s editor-in-chief Ekrem Dumanli and Samanyolu Broadcasting Group General Manager Hidayet Karaca were detained. Three days later, the court they were brought before decided on the arrest of Karaca along with three security officers, and on Dumanli's trial without detention. In the article I wrote in response, titled "*Zaman* is the bastion of the free press," I defended the Community media that opened its pages and screens to me as follows:

"The mere fact that this case, built on an absurd claim like 'establishing an armed terrorist organization to seize the sovereignty of the state' based on two columns and one news report, was even opened is perhaps the most striking expression to date that judicial independence and the rule of law are increasingly disappearing in Turkey, that the country is increasingly coming under an arbitrary and authoritarian one-man rule.

“It is certainly no coincidence that the one-man rule targets *Zaman* and STV first in the media. The truth indicated by the December 14 operation is that *Zaman* and STV are the leading bastions of the free press in Turkey. No one can deny that both *Zaman* and STV have been the media organizations that have shown the most determined stance against both the military tutelage regime and the one-man rule (which has now taken the tutelage supporters in tow) in Turkey. That *Zaman* and STV are bastions of the free press in Turkey certainly stems from the Hizmet Movement, which they receive support from, being one of the most important forces of civil society in Turkey.

“The December 14 operation may perhaps also help in understanding the following points, like the saying ‘there is good in every evil’: The editors and writers of *Zaman*, the editors and commentators of STV, do not write or speak on instructions received from Fethullah Gulen Hocaefendi, from the ‘Community’ as some claim. What guides them and the entire Hizmet Movement is yes, the understanding of Islam and worldview pioneered by Hocaefendi. The understanding they share is one where commitment to democracy, secularism as freedom of belief, the rule of law, universal human rights, and the principle of respect for difference, summarized in the principle of ‘accepting everyone as they are,’ is being internalized ever more deeply. *Zaman* Newspaper and Samanyolu Broadcasting Group are not, as some claim, only and solely the spokesperson of the Hizmet Movement. These media organizations have been open to all views that defend democracy, fundamental rights and freedoms, and human rights.

“Another result emerging from the December 14 operation is that the one-man rule is seeking to maintain its dominance by polarizing press members as well as the whole society through the ‘pool media’ it has established, using the state radio and television financed by all our taxes as its own mouthpiece. The fact that some media members almost celebrated their colleagues being detained on absurd claims reminded once again that democracy cannot be established in Turkey without professional ethics and principles being established in the media. The only consolation that can be felt in this context is that professional organizations and self-respecting names in the media have taken a determined stance against the operation.

“We are learning by living that rights and law are necessary for everyone. The December 14 operation also provided the occasion for *Zaman*’s managers and writers to show the virtue of self-criticism by accepting certain mistakes made in the past struggle against the military tutelage regime. None of us learned the value of democracy and the rule of law in our mother’s womb. We learn democracy by living it. The freedom struggle, just as it brought down the military tutelage regime, will also bring about the end of the one-man rule.” (*Zaman*, 20.12.2014)

My above article was met by some of my friends with the comment that I was “more Community-ist than the Community.” Subsequent developments showed they were right. However, in those days I saw defending the Community as a requirement of defending freedoms and democracy against authoritarianism.

What is the AKP, what is it not?

In my first article of 2015, I explained my view on where the AKP had come from and where it had arrived. As follows:

“The AKP defines itself as ‘conservative democrat.’ The most common definition among its opponents is that it is ‘Islamist.’ (Including so-called political scientists who use the concepts of devout Muslim and Islamist identically.) There are types of the Islamist definition. Those I have encountered: Secret, soft, radical, dissimulating Islamist, neo-Islamist, post-Islamist, Islamofascist, Muslim Brotherhood branch… There are also those like me who refer to the AKP as religious nationalist, Sunni nationalist, Islamic-Kemalist. And of course, there are the recently raised claims that the AKP is an ‘American or Israeli project.’ Thank goodness, there are more than enough people in our country looking for an ‘American, Zionist, mastermind’ finger under every stone. We can set aside such claims by those whose minds are poisoned by conspiracy theories. So, how can the AKP be defined at the point it has reached today? First, the following observations need to be made.

“The AKP is a product of the more or less multi-party system that has existed in Turkey for approximately 70 years, of the deficient-flawed democracy. It takes its roots from the National Outlook Movement (MGH) that emerged on the scene from the 1970s onward. The parties born of the MGH, up to the Welfare Party, deserve the Islamist characterization because they are against integration with the West, advocate Islamic unity, and at one point also took up the idea of ‘freedom to choose law, legal pluralism.’

“However, the MGH underwent a transformation that began with the traditionalists-innovators split that started in its ranks in the 1990s, continued with the U-turns during the Refahyol government, and became fully apparent with the Virtue Party experience. At the basis of this transformation lies the politicians belonging to the innovator wing seeing the impossibility of coming to power with an Islamist agenda in a country where the people demand freedom and prosperity and where the reins of power are in the hands of the Kemalist military-civilian bureaucracy. For this reason, the AKP declared it had ‘taken off its Islamist shirt’ and entered the political scene with the most liberal program in Turkish history, both politically and economically, with EU membership at its center.

“The AKP succeeded in coming to power as a result of tutelage parties dragging the country into the most severe financial crisis in its history. In its first term in power, it clung to the EU’s rope, embraced broad segments of society, and doubled its vote share. In its second term, it repelled military and judicial coup attempts with society’s support. When it collected half the votes in the 2011 elections, Tayyip Erdogan at the head of the party, judging that he had neutralized military tutelage and won the people behind him, decided together with the clique around him (who had tied their entire political careers to him) that he could govern the country as he wished; the Erdogan II period opened.

“How was the transition from Erdogan I to II made? Theories vary: According to Kemalist tutelage supporters, this was the inevitable result of the Islamist hidden agenda. According to freedom advocates, what is in question is the ‘power corrupts, absolute

power corrupts absolutely' syndrome. There are also those who resort to psychological analyses. (See Hadi Uluengin, 'Erdogan: A case of hubris,' *Taraf*, 18.10.2014.) What is certain is that, like every organism, the AKP also underwent an evolution. At the point it has reached today as a result of this evolution, it has become difficult to speak of the AKP's ideology, its ideas.

"If an ideology must be attributed, it can be said that the AKP carries Kemalist tendencies in the sense of authoritarianism, intolerance of civil society and opposition; that it resorts to Islamic populism (demagoguery) to maintain its power; and that it emulates Putinism with its desire to establish one-man, one-party rule. But what essentially defines the AKP now is that it has no aim, ideal, or quality left other than maintaining the power of a political and economic interest group; that it is an opportunist party of one person (Erdogan)." (*Zaman*, 6.1.2015)

Is the AKP cracking?

In February 2015, there were signs that some cracks had appeared in the AKP. I drew attention to these signs, which would lead nowhere, as follows:

"It appears that the differences of opinion in the AKP have gone beyond the party summit and spread to the ranks. The first sign of this was given by Davutoglu's chief advisor Etyen Mahcupyan: 'The corruption is not nonsense… Half of the AKP voters are not happy about this.' (November 23, 2014) A more distinct sign emerged when around 50 AKP deputies voted in favor of sending the 4 ministers who resigned over corruption allegations to the Supreme Tribunal. (January 20) The Prime Minister had asked the relevant ministers to go to the Supreme Tribunal on their own, but President Tayyip Erdogan had not allowed it.

"The rest of the signs were lined up as follows: Following Erdogan's warning that 'If you lower asset declaration to the level of provincial and district chairmen, you won't find anyone to take on duties…', Davutoglu withdrew the 'transparency' bill he said he attached great importance to. HDP Co-Chair Selahattin Demirtas said, 'Mr. Davutoglu would do well not to make such statements again without asking the President.' (February 6)

"None other than one of the founding fathers of the AKP and Deputy Prime Minister Bulent Arinc's words were heavy: 'Trust must be in its rightful place. It absolutely cannot be near this or that person, on their side, here or there. This is what destroyed ANAP, this is what destroyed DYP… We get 50 percent of the vote. But in the remaining 50 percent, it is turning into hate speech. We used to go out on the street, our supporters loved us very much. The opponents on the other side also showed respect. Now I sense a look of hatred. There is ossification, polarization. This won't prevent our 50 percent vote. But Turkey may cease to be a governable country.' (February 7)

"MIT Undersecretary Hakan Fidan resigned from his position to become an MP from the AKP, not complying with President Erdogan's wishes. (February 7) Erdogan said, 'he may have been made promises.' Davutoglu broke his silence on the 'Turkish-style' presidential system that Erdogan wanted; 'The issue is not concentrating power in one

person's hands within a non-libertarian constitutional system. Neither our President wants this, nor do I want it, nor does any sensible politician in Turkey envision something only for their own future…' he said. (February 5)

"However, the great majority in society agree that 'our President wants to concentrate power in one person's hands.' It is understood that most AKP members are not convinced about the presidential system. (*Taraf*, February 14) Deputy Prime Minister responsible for the economy Ali Babacan's response to Erdogan, who was pressuring the Central Bank to lower interest rates and questioning the bank's independence, was clear: 'The sole authority lies with the Central Bank. This should not be a daily matter of debate from the government's perspective… (Otherwise) the risk premium and interest rates will rise.' (February 14)

"Perhaps TBMM Speaker Cemil Cicek's statements can also be seen as a crack coming from the AKP: 'Due to our party's decision, I will not be able to be a deputy candidate this term. Turkey's perhaps biggest difficulty is here: In advanced democracies, maximum benefit is derived from those who have performed certain duties…' (February 15) It is certain that the real cracking will break out in the context of the candidate lists to be announced on April 24. As you know, whoever determines the candidates is also the owner of the party. It was reflected in the press that Erdogan said to Davutoglu, 'Let's give you Konya…' (*Taraf*, February 5)

"There is no room left for other signs of 'discord' in the AKP… I keep writing and saying: Turkey is not as primitive a society as Erdogan thinks; even the AKP cannot tolerate one-man rule… Perhaps I will be proven right." (*Zaman*, 17.2.2015)

In 2022 when I am writing these lines, that is, seven years after my above article, the probability of being proven right was increasing; the crack had grown, both Ahmet Davutoglu and Ali Babacan had long since left the AKP and established separate parties and were opposing with all their might.

Why 'Hizmet' is enduring

In early 2015, I grounded my view that the Hizmet Movement, whose founder is Fethullah Gulen, would be enduring in arguments inspired by the sociology of religion, as follows:

"As a reminder: All the founding fathers of social sciences who lived in the 19th and early 20th centuries shared the view that societies would move away from religion with modernization and that science would replace religion. Beginning from the end of the last century, social scientists saw that this theory did not accord with facts, that the world today is as religious as ever, if not more so. Some embarked on an effort to save the secularization theory; others turned to the social scientific explanation of why modernization did not result in moving away from religion. (…)

"In the context of the latter, one of the analyses that recently came to my attention was the article titled 'Beyond beliefs: Religions bind individuals into moral communities' by two social scientists from the renowned University of Virginia in the USA, named Jesse

Graham and Jonathan Haidt. (*Personality and Social Psychology Review*, Vol. 14: 1, 2010, pp. 140-150.) In this article, the authors explain (in their own words) 'three puzzles' based on research findings, namely why most people are religious, why religious people are happier than others, and why they are more charitable than others. The findings can be summarized as follows:

"The claim put forward by some (radical secularists almost everywhere) that religiosity is based on belief in God or the prophet and that people can abandon these beliefs if the scientific invalidity of religious beliefs is demonstrated, is not valid. Most people are religious because religious beliefs integrate people with spiritual-moral communities. Religious people are happier than others. There is truth in the view that religious beliefs protect people against the threats and uncertainties they are exposed to. But happiness among the religious stems not from a sense of protection, but essentially from the spirit of unity and solidarity provided by being part of a religious community. There is a strong relationship between religiosity and engaging in charitable works regardless of education, age, gender, income, and political preferences. Having common ideals appears to be the strongest explanation of why the religious are more charitable than others.

"The scientific findings I conveyed above may help those who have difficulty understanding how Hizmet, a faith-based civil society movement formed by the counsel of Fethullah Gulen Hocaefendi, was able to motivate thousands of volunteers to work selflessly in distant lands; its ability to create financial resources from the contributions of volunteers.

"How is it that Hizmet has been able to provide scholarships enabling many young people to study and acquire professions, to open schools throughout Turkey and in around 160 countries? How is it that the 'Kimse Yok Mu' (Is Anybody There) association has been able to deliver humanitarian aid throughout the country and to three continents? How is it that the Journalists and Writers Foundation has organized so many conferences and meetings domestically and abroad? How is it that *Zaman* has nearly a million paid subscribers? How is it that those devoted to Hizmet have stood by Bank Asya, the participation bank that the AKP government wanted to sink, by selling their goods and properties and forming long queues to deposit their money? And how is it that Hizmet not only remained standing despite the pressures and prosecutions of the 1980 and 1997 military coups, but found the opportunity to grow stronger?

"In its mortar there are certainly religious beliefs, respect for Hocaefendi's interpretation of Islam that reconciles Islam with modernity. But this mortar does not stem solely from belief. Commitment to the spiritual and moral values that Hizmet has developed, the interpersonal mutual trust and solidarity it provides also have an important share in this mortar. That is why, whatever those who try to eliminate it do, Hizmet is enduring." (Zaman, 21.2.2015)

In 2022 when I am writing these lines, the claim I put forward in the above article appeared quite open to debate. Namely, while pressures and arrests against the Community / Hizmet Movement continued domestically, it was seen that there were

cracks in its organization abroad, and dissidents were emerging from within the movement.

Presidential system would be a disaster

One of the rare subjects I was not wrong about in my political commentaries was that a presidential system, especially the kind that Erdogan wanted to bring, would be a disaster for Turkey. I explained this view as follows:

“Yes, the proposal to transition to some kind of presidential system was raised from time to time from the late 1970s onward. Prime Minister Turgut Ozal mentioned it in the late 1980s, and President Suleyman Demirel in the late 1990s. However, the proposal never came to the agenda as a government bill or election manifesto. Erdogan says he has been advocating this since his Istanbul mayorship, but such a proposal was not included in the AKP program. The AKP government he headed promised in its 2007 general election manifesto to establish the parliamentary system with all its institutions and rules through the new constitution to be drafted. The constitutional draft prepared by Professor Ergun Ozbudun and his team at Erdogan’s invitation, announced in September 2007, was based on this promise.

“However, Erdogan immediately shelved the draft. It can be said that from that date onward he turned to concentrating all power in his hands. In October 2007, he had the constitutional amendment providing for the president to be elected by the people for five-year terms, up to two times, adopted through a referendum. Thus, the unaccountable but empowered president envisaged by the 1982 military tutelage constitution came to be elected by the people. In December 2012, the AKP, knowing that opposition parties would oppose, ensured the dissolution of the parliamentary Constitutional Conciliation Commission by proposing a ‘Turkish-style presidential’ system to the commission. President Erdogan, who has taken an oath of impartiality according to the Constitution, is currently (judging by his latest statement) continuing a campaign to ask for votes for the AKP for a ‘Mexican-style’ presidency.

“The Mexican-style presidency that Erdogan apparently discovered during his Latin America visit really suits him. Because it gives unlimited power to a president who can be elected only once for 6 years, this system is called a ‘6-year monarchy.’ The president is at once head of state, head of government, and commander-in-chief (but not ‘head of the legislative body’ as Erdogan claims). He fully commands both the state and the party he is a member of. He has no deputy. He can appoint and dismiss ministers and the entire bureaucracy alone. There is a bicameral parliament, but it convenes only between November 1 - December 15 and April 15 - July 15; for the rest of the year, a mixed committee of 31 people from both chambers represents the parliament. Legislative, law-making authority is essentially in the hands of the president. The president even determines whom his party will nominate for the presidency after him. As you can understand, it has come close to Erdogan’s ideal presidential system.

“So, how does Erdogan defend the transition to a presidential system? As follows: While it is a fact that almost all developed countries are governed by a parliamentary system, he claims the opposite; (of Britain, which is the cradle of the parliamentary system) he

says ‘Even England is semi-presidential. The dominant element is the queen…’ He says that the USA, the cradle of the presidential system, ‘tried the parliamentary system for 20, 30, 40 years and then got stuck and transitioned to the presidential system.’ To these incredible, inconceivable words, the other day was added ‘actually the presidential system is in our genes.’ What he means is clear: We Turks were created to be ruled by a sultanate!

“In the presidential system debate, we are literally at the point where words fail. A presidential system can work in places where a high culture of consensus prevails among politicians. Even if copied from the USA, a presidential system would be a disaster for Turkey. Erdogan’s performance is more than enough to prove this: He brazenly tramples on the Constitution; he acts as the president not of all the people but of those who voted for him; he accuses all opposition of treason; he is polarizing society in an increasingly worrying manner. If tomorrow Erdogan (or someone else) confronts us with a presidential system of any kind, I don’t even want to imagine what could happen to us.” (*Zaman*, 26.2.2015)

“Alliance of thieves and coup plotters”

In early 2015, I assessed the political landscape in the country as follows:

“Why was Mehmet Baransu arrested and put in prison? Let me also explain: In March 2003, at the 1st Army Command located in Istanbul, under the guise of a ‘plan seminar,’ a coup aiming to overthrow the AKP government that had come to power a few months earlier was planned. Senkal Atasagun, who was the MIT undersecretary at the time, told *Cumhuriyet* newspaper executives Ilhan Selcuk, Ibrahim Yildiz, and Mustafa Balbay in May 2003, ‘Tip-off letters are coming from Istanbul and they are important. Everything is ready in the First Army, they are preparing for a coup…’ and suggested they meet with Chief of General Staff Hilmi Ozkok, who opposed the coup. This information was included in Mustafa Balbay’s (now CHP deputy) diaries.

“In the speeches recorded at the ‘plan seminar,’ what would be done if the coup succeeded was described as follows: ‘Units are ready. We are descending on Istanbul. We are seizing the administration. Mayors, public institution employees will be changed. They will be arrested. There will be harsh intervention. No mercy or anything, there is crushing…’ The coup attempt failed. In the following years, Chief of General Staff Hilmi Ozkok and the Land Forces Commander of the time Aytac Yalman quarreled over which of them had prevented the coup.

“Documents leaked from the TSK regarding the ‘Sledgehammer’ coup attempt were reported by Mehmet Baransu in the *Taraf* newspaper in January 2010. Copies of the documents submitted to the prosecutor’s office by Baransu were found in a secret compartment at the Golcuk Naval Command during a search conducted as part of another investigation in January 2011. The case that was opened concluded in September 2012. 361 defendants, primarily Cetin Dogan, were tried for ‘incomplete attempt to overthrow the government of the Republic of Turkey.’ 325 retired and active-duty officers found guilty were sentenced to prison terms ranging from 6 to 20 years. The Court of Cassation, finding sufficient the evidence deemed serious by the European

Court of Human Rights, confirmed the convictions of 237 defendants in September 2013.

“The Sledgehammer case defendants, their lawyers, and the front of military tutelage supporters claimed the evidence was fabricated. The case was subject to criticism due to the arrest of many relevant and irrelevant defendants, the conversion of long detention periods into punishment, and the violation of defense rights. Upon the defendants’ application, the Constitutional Court decided on retrial in June 2014; the convicts were released.

“Immediately after the major bribery and corruption investigation of December 17-25 (2013) became public, then Prime Minister Tayyip Erdogan’s Chief Advisor and AKP deputy Yalcin Akdogan, just like military tutelage supporters, raised the claim that a ‘conspiracy against the national army’ was set up through the Sledgehammer case. From that day to this, this claim has become the common discourse of the ruling party and military tutelage supporters. After the cover-up of the December 17-25 corruption investigation was completed, Mehmet Baransu was arrested for ‘disclosing state secrets’ by doing what journalism requires and reporting the Sledgehammer coup plan documents. Moreover, even though a decision of non-prosecution had been made in the investigation with the same accusation 5 years ago…

“So what is the meaning of all this? Ahmet Altan explained it best: ‘Since when are coup plans characterized as ’documents related to state security’ and ‘information that the state must keep secret’? Since when? *Since thieves and coup plotters linked arms to escape the law… (Italics added later.)* A government caught while stealing, when it started committing crimes greater than theft to save its skin, decided to go and take refuge with the coup plotters. The coup plotters, caught with their plans in hand, with their knees trembling from fear, shamelessly hid behind the men they clearly knew were thieves… Together they are trying to declare those who exposed their crimes as criminals.’ (*Cumhuriyet*, 03.03.2015)” (“Alliance of thieves and coup plotters,” 5.3.2015)

In 2022 when these lines are being written, Mehmet Baransu is unfortunately still in prison. Upon the Court of Cassation’s reversal decision regarding seven of the Sledgehammer coup plan defendants who were acquitted in June 2014, including former 1st Army Commander Gen. Cetin Dogan, the case began to be heard again on October 22, 2021. Meanwhile, on August 18, 2021, the Ankara 5th Heavy Penal Court issued an arrest warrant for 14 defendants, including Cevik Bir and Cetin Dogan, whose life sentences in the February 28 case in 2018 were confirmed by the Court of Cassation on July 9, 2021. In the face of these events, what else could be said but to ask, “has the alliance between thieves and coup plotters ended?”

CHAPTER XV / A DARK PERIOD

Upon the prosecutor’s invitation, on February 4, 2015, Ali Bulaç and I went to the Courthouse in Çağlayan. The subject of the invitation was the article dated November 23, 2014 by Etyen Mahçupyan, who had left *Zaman* and started writing for the *Akşam*

newspaper in June 2014. Mahçupyan had written the following about a meeting he attended earlier that year:

“The date is January 8, 2014, the place is Mabeyin Restaurant. The Journalists and Writers Foundation is holding its quarterly evaluation meeting. Along with me are *Zaman* newspaper writers Ali Bulaç, Mümtazer Türköne, and Şahin Alpay. Besides the foundation’s administrators, there are some guests I don’t know, as well as Ergun Özbudun, Fatih University Rector Şerif Ali Tekalan, and the newspaper’s former administrator Alaattin Kaya. We are roughly twenty people. Everyone has in mind what has been happening since December 17 and how events will develop. Before even getting into the topic, one of our journalist colleagues simply asks one of the Hizmet members ‘what’s happening?’ The answer is exactly this: ‘Nothing has changed for us… We’ll get results within a month.’ Since the conversation occurred during a quiet moment, everyone would have heard it. The moment of silence after the answer must be an indication that the audience understood very well what this answer meant.”

In response to this article, the Journalists and Writers Foundation had also made this statement: “If Mr. Mahçupyan had asked for confirmation from any of those he mentioned in his article who attended the meeting—Ali Bulaç, Mümtazer Türköne, Şahin Alpay, Ergun Özbudun, Şerif Ali Tekalan, Alaattin Kaya, or the Foundation administrators—before writing his article about this meeting that took place 10 months ago, he could have easily learned that such a conversation did not occur and would have understood that his memory had deceived him. Furthermore, Mr. Mahçupyan should clearly and explicitly state from whom he heard this statement. We call upon Mr. Mahçupyan, who has participated in such meetings of the Journalists and Writers Foundation for years, to prove his claim or apologize.”

The prosecutor, who treated Bulaç and me quite courteously, was asking whether the words “Nothing has changed for us… We’ll get results within a month…” quoted in this article were actually spoken. I had not heard such a thing. Neither had Bulaç. (Ergun Özbudun and Mümtazer Türköne, whom I had called and spoken with before going to the prosecutor’s office, had also said they hadn’t heard it.) We left after signing our statements. At that time, it hadn’t occurred to us that this would be only the first of our visits to Çağlayan, but we had become uneasy.

My last day at Bahçeşehir University—A sign that my future was darkening also came from the workplace where I had worked the longest in my career. I quote from my notes: “On January 22, 2015, around noon, when I received the news from Zekeriya (Tüzen, my student and later my assistant) that the make-up exam schedule was set, I went to school. Near the entrance, I encountered the owner Enver Yücel and his companions. We exchanged brief pleasantries. As he was leaving, he stroked my cheek. At that moment, I couldn’t make sense of it. I went up to my room; I wrote my article that would be published two days later. Then I prepared the syllabus for the *Media and Democracy* course I would teach again in the spring semester. I ran into Seyfettin (Gürsel) in the corridor; I told him we would go to Ayvalık on the 27th; ‘Maybe we’ll come too,’ he said. Then I stopped by Dean Necip Çakır; I told him I would go to Ayvalık for about ten days. He said okay.

I started preparing the questions for the make-up exams in my room. Then the phone rang. The assistant Hülya was saying that the rector wanted to have coffee with me. I immediately understood… I called Seyfettin and Necip to say 'the day of parting has arrived.' Neither of them was at their desks. I went up to the rector's floor. Hülya asked what she could offer me. I asked for plain coffee. Rector Şenay Yalçın, as if nothing extraordinary was happening, perhaps a bit nervous, first talked about BAU opening branches in Djibouti, Georgia, and Casablanca. I said I enthusiastically supported it. She asked about my health; she expressed her sorrow saying 'Look at what condition Yaşar Kemal is in…' She said she greatly admired me for standing firm against the government; 'The country needs intellectuals like you,' she said. I asked her to read my article that came out that day, in which I said 'Don't be surprised if Davutoğlu is also declared parallel…' She read it and said she liked it very much. Then she got to the point: a letter had come from YÖK (Council of Higher Education); apparently a certain maximum number of teaching staff was required for each department. Also, there was the budget issue, of course. Therefore, it was time to 'part ways' with me (unfortunately, although I was a lecturer, I was receiving a faculty member's salary).

I wasn't surprised at all. I said I owed gratitude to BAU; that I had worked here with pleasure for 14 years and was now leaving happily; that I would always consider myself a part of BAU; that I would be ready if there was any service I could provide in the future; and that I would donate some of my books to the university. 'You were already talking about leaving anyway…' she said. (Yes, it had occurred to me that my job might be terminated.) 'Am I leaving immediately from February 1?' I asked. She confirmed. She said my severance would be calculated and paid immediately after my approval. 'Please give my regards to Enver bey,' I said, and took my leave. 'He probably wants to have coffee with you too… We would also like to organize a farewell dinner for you,' she said. As I was leaving, her secretary Hülya said, 'Şahin bey, you didn't remember me; I was Zülfü Livaneli's assistant at Milliyet.' I had forgotten.

I thought: The owner had given me the first signal that my job would be terminated at a reception on the terrace at the end of that summer, early fall. On the day BAU received permission to open a branch in Washington DC, he had said 'Well professor, if you need to flee, you now know where to go…' He had given the real signal in October during a group dinner with department members: 'Professor Şahin, the other day I had dinner with your Ekrem Bey, and I told him to tell Professor Şahin to write a bit less harshly…' (When I asked Dumanlı months later, he confirmed this and said he had replied 'But Enver Bey, having Professor Şahin teach at your institution is a matter of prestige for you…')

I went to Dean Necip Çakır to say goodbye. He had heard that my job would be terminated. After the rector met with me, she had called and informed him. 'There is political pressure,' he said. He said my articles against military tutelage had created discomfort in the administration. They had been thinking about terminating my contract for some time. They had asked Eser to explain this to me; he had refused. 'We will organize a farewell party,' he said. (Indeed, on the afternoon of February 13, a farewell cocktail was held that almost all faculty members attended. It was a nice farewell.) I stopped by Seyfettin's. He said he was sorry that we wouldn't be able to see each other

as frequently anymore. While returning home after buying fish from Beşiktaş market, I decided it would be good to postpone the Ayvalık trip.

When I told my Fatma, who had been dealing with repair work at home with workers all day, that my job had been terminated, she said with her usual composure that she was very happy, that now we could stay in Ayvalık as long as we wanted, that we could do what we wanted, and that I would be less tired. She was genuinely pleased. She reminded me that we wouldn't have financial problems. I informed my daughter Elvan and my son Acar about the development. They just said congratulations. We postponed going to Ayvalık. I asked Fatma, 'I wonder if I should ask *Zaman* for a room and go there 2-3 days a week?' 'Don't rush; let's get through the summer and see what happens…' she said.

The next day I went to school and signed the contract termination document. I started sorting through books. I called the opinion page editor Abdullah Yavuz Altun from the newspaper. 'Talk to Ekrem bey. Maybe they'll give me a room; I'll put my books there and have my meetings there,' I said. I wasn't very sure it would be a good idea. Indeed, I gave up on this.

"Ten days that shook the AKP"

I had no job left other than *Zaman*. In one of my first articles to be published, I wrote that the alliance formed between the AKP government and its supporters and the military tutelage proponents—what Ahmet Altan aptly called "the alliance of thieves and coup plotters"—had the aim of "reversing Turkey's democratization history":

"The cover-up of the December 17/25, 2013 investigation—containing the largest bribery and corruption allegations in Republican history—by the AKP government not only initiated the process of destroying the rule of law in Turkey and dragging the country toward one-man, one-party rule, but also reversed the process of dismantling the military-bureaucratic tutelage system.

"The bribery and corruption allegations revealed in the investigation, which Istanbul prosecutors had conducted with great meticulousness since September 2012, not only covered four ministers, three of their sons, public officials, and businessmen, but also extended to the Prime Minister himself and his family members. Celal Kara, one of the prosecutors conducting the investigation, would express his opinion as follows: 'It is impossible and improbable that these affairs were conducted without the Prime Minister's knowledge, awareness, and permission. Looking at the phone conversations and the dialogues between them, you definitely say that it is the Prime Minister who allowed and permitted these affairs from behind the scenes.'

"The government headed by the Prime Minister of the time immediately took action to cover up the investigation. The fallacy was put forward that the evidence was 'doctored, dubbed, staged'; that the investigation was a 'plot' set up by 'foreign powers that cannot tolerate Turkey's strengthening and the Fethullah Gülen community' to overthrow the government. The detained suspects were released. A 'witch hunt' declared by the Prime Minister of the time was launched. Thousands of police officers and hundreds of

prosecutors and judges were reassigned; hundreds of police personnel were detained, some were arrested.

“In short, the ‘witch hunt’ was used to ensure the subordination of the entire state apparatus to one-man, one-party rule. By changing the HSYK (High Council of Judges and Prosecutors) law, the judiciary was tied to the executive. Not only was a decision of non-prosecution made for the four ministers who were forced to resign due to the gravity of the allegations, but the AKP majority in Parliament also prevented them from going to the Supreme Tribunal. Thus, the referral of the grave allegations to the judiciary was prevented (certainly for now).

“The other important result of suppressing the December 17/25 investigation was that the AKP government also put forward the fallacy that the Sledgehammer and Ergenekon cases were ‘plots against the national army’ set up by foreign powers that cannot tolerate Turkey’s strengthening through the ‘community,’ thus paving the way for covering up the coup attempt cases as well. Today we are facing an alliance between the AKP government and its supporters and military tutelage proponents, seemingly established with the aim of reversing the history of democratization in Turkey.” (*Zaman*, March 21, 2015)

“We will not let you become president”

In an article challenging Erdoğan’s leadership and his ambition to be elected president, I said:

“Last Saturday, while watching on screen the hundreds of thousands gathered at the Newroz celebrations in Diyarbakır to listen to the conditional peace message of Abdullah Öcalan, the natural leader of the PKK, my mind went back to old times. I remembered the first column article I had the opportunity to write in the press; I opened it and read it. In the article titled ‘Earthquake in Parliament’ I had written: ‘The other day I was casually watching the oath ceremony at the Turkish Grand National Assembly on television. Meanwhile, I followed the Leyla Zana incident almost entirely. It seemed to me that an earthquake was happening in parliament. It was as if old structures were creaking and new ones were emerging… Now there is a new demand at this “table”… The Kurds are voicing the new demand this clearly and strongly for the first time. They want to take their place in the Turkish Republic’s parliament by freely expressing their ethnic identity.’ (*Cumhuriyet*, November 9, 1991.)

“In the 34 years that have passed, unfortunately much blood was shed, much suffering was endured, but progress was also made in resolving the Kurdish issue. President Erdoğan is right: Denial policies have ended; most of the bans on the expression of Kurdish identity have been lifted; a search for a peaceful solution has begun… But the Kurdish issue has not disappeared. The truth, which even the State Security Courts accepted in the 1990s, is this: There are two peoples in Turkey. As long as this is not reflected in the Constitution, as long as the Kurdish mother tongue is not recognized as a regional official language, as long as the Kurdish-majority region does not gain a status of self-governance, the Kurdish issue will not end. So why is Erdoğan—the leader

who ended the denial of Kurdish identity, lifted the bans on its expression, and initiated the search for a peaceful solution—now saying again ‘There is no Kurdish issue…’?

“Because now we are facing a completely different Erdoğan than in the first two terms of power. Erdoğan, now consumed by the ambition to establish his ‘unchecked—unrestrained’ personal rule, needs to win the votes of Turkish nationalists and consolidate the alliance he has formed with the Turkish Armed Forces. Isn’t his statement the other day at the War Academies about the Sledgehammer and Ergenekon cases, of which he was once the ‘prosecutor’: ‘Through these operations, myself first and foremost, the entire country was misled, deceived…’ a clear expression of this? However, Erdoğan’s risk of ‘losing the bulgur at home while going to Damietta for rice’ is increasing. The possibility of Turkish nationalists’ votes that he has managed to win so far shifting to the MHP, and Kurdish nationalists’ votes shifting to the HDP is growing.

“I have always written: Turkey is not as primitive a society as Erdoğan thinks. No matter what he does, no matter what he says, the people will not follow him. Even the AKP cannot tolerate Erdoğan’s arbitrariness and authoritarianism. Indeed, the signs of this are increasing. Abdullah Gül says, ‘Democracy is not just about elections, Turkish-style presidency won’t work…’ Bülent Arınç warned that if Erdoğan continues to polarize society, the country will become ‘ungovernable’; he was forced to say ‘don’t forget, there is a government in this country…’ Ali Babacan constantly feels the need to say ‘There can be no development in a country without law…’ Even Prime Minister Ahmet Davutoğlu, who owes his seat and entire career to Erdoğan, didn’t he want to send the ministers accused of corruption and bribery to the Supreme Tribunal; didn’t he try to include Erdoğan’s ‘secret keeper’ in the government? He was even able to say ‘It is dangerous for a statesman to become arrogant…’

“At least half of society cannot tolerate Erdoğan, how can the Kurds tolerate him? Aren’t these reassuring words of HDP co-chair Selahattin Demirtaş an expression of the fact that an increasing portion of Kurds have also become unable to tolerate him?: ‘We are not a bargaining movement, a bargaining party. There was no dirty bargain between us and the AKP, there never will be… Mr. Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, as long as HDP members breathe on this land, you will not become president. We will not let you become president, we will not let you become president, we will not let you become president…’” (*Zaman*, March 24, 2015)

There is no alternative but HDP

In an article published as we were heading to the general elections to be held on June 7, 2015, after saying “I had written that I would unhesitatingly vote for CHP in this election too, but I no longer think so,” I listed the reasons why there was no alternative but to vote for HDP as follows:

“(…) One cannot vote for a CHP from whose candidate lists true social democrats—not demagogic ones—have been almost completely erased, and which has been filled with military tutelage supporters. The main reason is this: It has become completely clear, along with the candidate lists, that President Tayyip Erdoğan—who brazenly declared that he has put the Constitution in the waiting room and who already sees himself as

president—has fully established his hegemony over the AKP, and that almost no one from within the party will object to this in the foreseeable future. Restraining Erdoğan's ambition to destroy democracy and the rule of law under the name of 'Turkish-style presidency' has become Turkey's undisputed number one issue.

"Turkey went through very bad days during military coup periods. In those periods, we at least knew that military rule was temporary and that we could return to some form of democracy, however deficient and flawed, after a while. I don't even want to think about the damage Erdoğan—who, even now in a position where he has no authority, can declare everyone who opposes him as 'parallel, agent, traitor,' and who considers the nation as a flock and himself as the nation's shepherd—could do to the country if he somehow manages to become president. As Seyfettin Gürsel's analysis shows very convincingly, the only way to stop Erdoğan, the only solution, is for HDP to pass the threshold and be represented in Parliament. ('General election scenarios', *Zaman*, April 9.) In that case, even if AKP maintains power alone, it will become impossible for it to win the minimum 330 seats required to change the constitution.

"This will have other benefits too: First of all, a situation that would fundamentally wound representative democracy—such as HDP remaining outside Parliament—and push the Kurdish political movement to act outside Turkish politics will be prevented. The Kurdish nationalist movement will find the opportunity to abandon arms within Turkey and focus on political-democratic struggle. It will even benefit the AKP; even if it maintains power alone, it will not feel obligated to Erdoğan. Erdoğan, whose morale will inevitably drop, will be left face to face with the obligation to act within the framework of the current constitution.

"With HDP's candidate list aimed at winning the votes of conservative Kurds as well, it has become clear that the intention of the Kurdish political movement is not to remain outside Parliament. Yes, despite HDP Co-Chair Selahattin Demirtaş's repeated promise 'We will not let you become president!', there are those who think he might be forced to change his tune tomorrow, and that there is an implicit give-and-take agreement between the Palace and İmralı. The only way to test whether such an agreement really exists is for HDP to pass the threshold and enter Parliament. Let's say there is such an agreement. Even then, since HDP will have the ability to impose its own conditions, even if there is a presidency, it will not be the 'Turkish-style presidency' that Erdoğan wants.

"For all the above reasons, if you want to restrain Erdoğan's ambition, even if this doesn't sit well with you at all, the only solution is to vote for HDP. Yes, tactical votes may not be enough for HDP to pass the threshold; HDP mainly needs to win votes from Kurds who are AKP voters. For those who defend democracy, there is no alternative but HDP." (*Zaman*, April 11, 2015)

Why this hostility toward Hizmet?

In an effort to understand the AKP government's increasingly growing hostility toward the Gülen community or Hizmet movement, I wrote the following:

“If you asked what could be the reason for the Erdoğan government’s hostility toward the Hizmet movement, I think the average citizen in Turkey would answer as follows: ‘He believes that the December 17/25 investigation—the largest bribery and corruption investigation in Republican history—was conducted by judiciary and police members who feel close to Hizmet; that’s why he approaches Hizmet with great anger and a feeling of revenge.’ The questions that should be asked of the average citizen are these: Hasn’t it sufficiently emerged that the judiciary and police members who conducted the December 17/25 investigation had very different identities?

“Even if there are those among them who feel close to Hizmet, isn’t their common denominator being people who do what the law and morality dictate? Let us accept for a moment the fallacy, that is, that the December 17/25 investigation was conducted solely by judiciary and police members close to Hizmet, and moreover by the instruction of Fethullah Gülen Hocaefendi… Can this make it justified and logical to accuse the entire Hizmet movement collectively of being an ‘illegal terrorist organization’? It absolutely cannot.

“Then what is the logic behind the AKP government declaring the Hizmet movement an ‘illegal terrorist organization’? It is this: Democracy is not just elections. It also means the rule of law and that the fundamental rights and freedoms of citizens are secure. For this, courts independent of the government, independent media, and perhaps most importantly, a strong civil society composed of independent voluntary associations are needed. The common characteristic of power holders in authoritarian regimes is intolerance of strong civil society.

“Perhaps the strongest element of civil society in Turkey, with its scope extending to education, media, and social welfare institutions and economic enterprises, is the Hizmet movement. Hizmet not only took its roots from the tarikat (Sufi order) and community tradition, which are undoubtedly the most important civil society elements of our society; it evolved beyond the religious community shell toward a faith-based civil society movement; and from there, it has been moving toward acquiring the character of a global civil society movement addressing all humanity, based on universal values that all humanity shares.

“Religious or secular fundamentalists, authoritarian Islamists, Kemalists, and Marxists may not see this, may not comprehend it. This is why the Erdoğan government had no difficulty in gaining the support of all these circles in the war it waged against Hizmet, or at least in ensuring their silence. The real truth that those seeking an answer to the question of why Hizmet was left so alone cannot see, which will be understood in time, perhaps is already beginning to be understood, is this.”

The article ended with a self-criticism: I attributed my not being sufficiently critical of the AKP government until 2011 to my focus on defending fundamental rights and freedoms against military tutelage:

“Yes, the (insufficiently critical) support that the media, whose establishment Hizmet pioneered, gave to the AKP in the first two terms of power with the expectation that it would ‘defeat military tutelage, establish democracy and the rule of law, secure

fundamental rights and freedoms, and end the mistreatment of the religious' may have played a role in Hizmet being left alone. But didn't almost everyone who was committed to fundamental rights and freedoms in the struggle against military tutelage make this mistake?" (*Zaman*, May 26, 2015)

No to Erdoğan, yes to Demirtaş!

As we were heading to the June 7, 2015 elections, as had become my custom, I declared who I would vote for as follows:

"Next Sunday, the most vital election of multi-party life will be held in Turkey; the future of the regime will be determined. The proportional representation electoral system with a 10 percent threshold—the gift of the September 12 military dictatorship to the country—continues to make the country gamble. That is, if HDP passes the threshold and wins around 60 deputies as expected, President Erdoğan will have to bid farewell to his ambition to change the constitution and be elected president, to rule the country like a company (that is, his own property); there is a possibility that the AKP will not be able to govern alone. On the other hand, if HDP cannot pass the threshold, especially if Erdoğan's party AKP gets at least 330 seats in Parliament with the parliamentary seats it will steal from HDP, I don't even want to think about what could happen to the country.

"If you don't want the country to go in the direction President Erdoğan wants to take it, that is, you don't want press freedom—like the rule of law before it—and increasingly the opposition (already declared 'legal in appearance'), and therefore democracy, to be reduced to nothing; in short, if you say 'No to Erdoğan!', there is no alternative but to say 'Yes to Demirtaş!' The apparent truth is this: the biggest fear of Erdoğan and his supporters is HDP passing the threshold.

"That's why Erdoğan (as if his own government wasn't conducting peace negotiations with the PKK) says of HDP, which promises 'We will not stray from the path of peace!': 'The party backed by the terrorist organization is after blood and lives…' Even more interesting, Erdoğan and his supporters fear the strengthening of Demirtaş's position within the Kurdish political movement. For this reason, Bülent Arınç attacks Demirtaş saying 'You want to discredit Öcalan!..'; for this reason, Yalçın Akdoğan accuses Demirtaş of being 'a Brutus against İmralı…' (that is, a backstabber).

"Yes, if you want Erdoğan to retreat to his constitutional limits, the only solution is to vote for HDP. It is said, 'Yes, Demirtaş says "We will not let you become president; we will not support the AKP in any way…", but what if he doesn't keep his word? What if Öcalan or Kandil pushes him in another direction?..' We cannot know the answers to these questions without HDP entering Parliament. On the other hand, the cost to the country of acting on the assumption that Demirtaş will not keep his word is very great. It is also certain that the cost to Demirtaş of not keeping his word will be very great. Some say, 'Since it's a Kurdish party, let the Kurds vote for HDP…' Although HDP is a party supported by some Kurds, it is Turkey's party. Turks, Kurds, citizens of all identities, we are all in the same boat. The issue is Turkey's issue.

“It is also certain that the reasons for saying ‘yes to Demirtaş’ are not limited to saying ‘no to Erdoğan’. *HDP is striving to transcend the boundaries of the Kurdish political movement; to be a ‘Turkey party’ firmly committed to peace, democracy, and the rule of law. Shouldn’t those who want Turkey’s integrity to be preserved and politics to be cleansed of weapons support and encourage HDP, which emphasizes not Kurdishness but humanity, even if only for this reason? (Italics added later.)* Yalçın Akdoğan says ‘If HDP enters Parliament, AKP will lose power, the solution process will end…’, but the truth is the exact opposite! Peace cannot come to Turkey precisely in an environment where HDP is not represented in Parliament. On the other hand, the truth is that Selahattin Demirtaş, with his election manifesto, his peaceful and pro-freedom discourse, and his trust-inspiring personality, has succeeded in giving HDP a new identity; votes are rising because of this.

“*HDP passing the threshold is to the benefit not only of Turkey but also of the AKP. Thus, the AKP can be freed from one-man rule and find the opportunity to repair its increasingly worsening image, and perhaps even return to inclusive policies. HDP entering Parliament is also to the benefit of President Erdoğan. He can be saved from being destroyed by the ambition to become president and rule the country like a company, and at least complete his term in peace. He has been running around too much for years, sweating; he needs rest. (Italics added later)*” (*Zaman*, June 2, 2015)

The nightmare is over!

In the general elections held on June 7, 2015 to determine the 550 new members of the Turkish Grand National Assembly, no political party reached the 276 seats required for single-party government. The AKP, which had been in power since 2002, lost its parliamentary majority but emerged as the first party from the elections with 40.9% of the vote and 258 seats. The Republican People’s Party (CHP) obtained 132 seats with 25% of the vote and became the second party, but both its vote share and number of deputies declined compared to the 2011 general elections. The Nationalist Movement Party (MHP) won 80 deputies with 16.3% of the vote and increased its vote share by 3.28% and its number of deputies by 27 seats compared to the previous elections. The Peoples’ Democratic Party (HDP) won 80 parliamentary seats with 13.1% of the vote. I welcomed the AKP’s being reduced to a minority with great satisfaction, saying ‘The nightmare is over!’, with excessive optimism. But I could also see that the results could lead to a repeat of the elections. I wrote:

“The June 7, 2015 general elections went down in Turkish history as a new victory for democracy. In the first victory in 1950, the people said ‘Enough!’ to the single-party regime. The 1983 elections pushed aside the project of being governed through parties loyal to the military that the military wanted to impose. The 2002 elections opened the way to the liquidation of the bureaucratic tutelage regime. The 2015 elections put an end to authoritarianism fed by the ballot box. We are learning liberal democracy by living it, internalizing it by living it. From now on, neither military-based nor ballot box-based authoritarianism will work; democracy based on human rights, rule of law, and respect for minorities will gradually take hold.

“The June 7 elections showed that Turkey is not as primitive a society as President Erdoğan thinks; that the people will not accept being herded like a flock by a single man who thinks himself their guardian. In an election where the AKP used all state resources to maintain its power, where a President who had taken an oath of neutrality openly ran the ruling party’s campaign, the people went to the polls with a high turnout rate of 87 percent, took away the AKP’s ability to govern alone; they gave an unforgettable lesson to a government drowning in corruption and spreading hatred to society.

“In Turkey, which has at least 65 years of multi-party life experience, the electorate once again embraced freedoms; once again embarrassed those who do not trust the people’s collective wisdom and common sense, those who say ‘There can be no democracy in a Muslim society…’ This election showed that the saying ‘You can fool some of the people all of the time, and all of the people some of the time, but you cannot fool all of the people all of the time…’ is also valid for Turkey.

“The AKP government, which was becoming increasingly arbitrary, corrupt, and authoritarian, came out successfully from the March 2014 local elections and the August 2014 presidential election using the ‘parallel structure’ fallacy, but in this election it was defeated by the ‘national will’; Erdoğan’s ambitions to become a one-man ruler were destroyed at the root. Erdoğan, whose legitimacy is beginning to be questioned, if he wants to complete his term as president, must from now on stop polarizing the country and spreading hatred toward his opponents; he must learn to know his limits, that is, to act within the boundaries drawn by the constitution and his oath. The AKP too, if it wants to prevent its gradual shrinking, must find a way to free itself from Erdoğan’s tutelage and from those who have tied their political careers to Erdoğan (especially Ahmet Davutoğlu, who tries to present a heavy defeat as an election victory and speaks as if unaware of the election results).

“Yes, the results may make a repeat of the elections inevitable. However, the opposition parties must keep the promise they made to the voters and never cooperate with the AKP. Parties that attempt to enter a coalition with the AKP should not forget that they will be condemned to a heavy defeat in the next election. As I underlined in my previous article, the opposition parties need to be able to come together on minimum common grounds to repair the great damage to the rule of law, and to form an alliance for this.

“In this context, it is essential: that the suspects of the December 17/25 investigation—the largest bribery and corruption investigation in Republican history—be brought before the judiciary; that the judicial and police officials who conducted the investigation be reinstated; that the criminal peace judgeships be abolished and those unjustly arrested by these courts be immediately released; that judicial independence be secured through changes to the HSYK and Court of Cassation laws; that press freedom be strengthened; that the threshold be reduced to at most 5 percent. It is certain that Turkey cannot continue on its way without repairing the great damage to the rule of law. On the other hand, a valuable lesson to be drawn from the corruption and authoritarianism caused by one-man, one-party rule is that Turkey should get used to being governed by coalition governments and succeed in this.

“One of the most important results of the June 7 elections is undoubtedly HDP under Selahattin Demirtaş’s leadership shattering the 10 percent threshold. I believe that HDP’s success under Demirtaş’s leadership paves the way for the peaceful and democratic resolution of the Kurdish issue and for securing Turkey’s integrity. The experiences gained with the IRA in Ireland, ETA in Spain, and the ANC in South Africa showed that for armed resistance against injustice and oppression to be directed toward a peaceful channel, in addition to opening peaceful-political struggle paths, it depends on the internal balance in the resistance movement shifting in favor of the civilian-unarmed-political wing. From now on, the party to peace negotiations must be HDP in Parliament. The nightmare is over! After June 7, Turkey can look to the future with optimism.” (*Zaman*, June 9, 2015)

How wrong I was!

End to the ‘parallel’ fallacy

I also listed the lessons that should be drawn from the June 7 elections as follows:

“There are lessons that all parties should draw from the June 7 elections. At the head of these parties is undoubtedly the AKP. The electorate not only put an end to the ambition of President Tayyip Erdoğan—the de facto leader of the AKP—to become president and rule the country like a company; they also warned Erdoğan to know his limits, that is, not to exceed his constitutional powers. Prime Minister Ahmet Davutoğlu, who is legally the party chairman, himself admitted this: ‘We wanted to switch to a presidential system but the people did not give us the mandate…’ he said; referring to Erdoğan, he called on everyone to ‘do their duty within the scope of their powers and responsibilities.’

“The electorate not only said ‘no’ to Erdoğan; they also denied the AKP the possibility of governing alone. Within the AKP ranks, the debate ‘what did we do to lose power’ began. Davutoğlu expressed the extremely necessary need for debate by saying ‘We have to do our own internal reckoning…’ Many, including Abdullah Gül and Bülent Arınç among the party’s leading founders, are talking about the mistakes made. If this debate continues in a healthy way, that is, by facing the facts, both the AKP and the country will benefit from it.

“The first fact that AKP members must face is that their party completely turned its back in its third term in power on the policies of liberalization and democratization it had pursued in the first two terms. Can the AKP, which has become almost unrecognizable in terms of its cadres, give up turning its back on rights and freedoms? Can it give up covering up the December 17/25 investigation, which played a major role in its loss of power? It is difficult to give positive answers to these questions, but there is great benefit in AKP members, especially AKP voters, facing this fundamental truth.

“*That December 17/25 was a ‘coup’ attempt against the elected government is complete nonsense. It is an investigation that revealed, purely and simply, that the rule of law that the AKP strengthened in its first two terms of power was working, and that the AKP’s top cadres were involved in bribery and corruption up to their necks. (Italics added later.)* Gül (without answering the question of why he didn’t throw his weight in this direction at

the time) says if I were at the head of the party I would have sent the suspects to the Supreme Tribunal. Arınç (without answering the question of why he didn't express an opinion in this direction at the time) says the investigation can be reopened. If, as Gül and Arınç imply, there is 'corruption,' then 'coup' is a fallacy; the investigation should also be carried through to the end.

"A series of laws and regulations that devastated the rule of law, separation of powers, and judicial independence in Turkey were enacted to cover up the December 17/25 investigation—the largest bribery and corruption investigation in Republican history. Just as the claim that the investigation was a coup orchestrated by foreign powers who do not want Turkey to strengthen and implemented by the Hizmet Movement (smeared as 'parallel structure') is a complete fallacy, so is the claim that the Sledgehammer and Ergenekon cases were a 'plot against the national army' set up by the Hizmet Movement. Indeed, in the Sledgehammer coup attempt case, which was so obvious that it became the subject of a 'which of us suppressed it' debate between the Chief of General Staff and the Land Forces Commander of the time, the prosecution objected to the decision to acquit all defendants.

"The 'parallel structure' claim, produced to cover up the December 17/25 investigation and destroy the rule of law; used (in cooperation with the NSC) to revive February 28; put forward by almost all crime suspects to exonerate themselves, is nothing but a perception operation. There can certainly be those who have committed crimes within the Hizmet Movement. However, such claims cannot go beyond fallacy unless they are subject to a fair trial, not to courts established to declare them guilty. Leaving the entire Hizmet Movement under a vague accusation like 'parallel structure,' let alone a nonsensical accusation like 'terrorist organization,' is nothing other than the revival of the military tutelage supporters' clamor about 'religious reaction.'

"It is not possible to put the rule of law back on its feet as long as the 'parallel' fallacy does not end. This must be well understood not only by AKP members but by everyone, especially by those who claim to be committed to the rule of law." (*Zaman*, June 16, 2015)

"Farewell to Shepherd Sülü"

Süleyman Demirel, one of the most important political actors of the post-1960 period—that is, the period I witnessed—passed away on June 16, 2015. I wrote the following afterwards:

"It can be said that multi-party political life in Turkey is divided into four increasingly shorter phases. The first phase is the military tutelage period starting from the 1950 elections that ended single-party rule and extending to the end of the 20th century, to the 2002 elections. The second phase is the period of (effectively) leaving behind military tutelage, extending from 2002 to 2011; the third phase is the period of the elected government's increasing corruption, arbitrariness, and authoritarianism, extending from 2011 to the 2015 elections. It can be said that the fourth phase began with the 2015 elections, where we witnessed the birth pangs of leaving behind both military and civilian authoritarianism.

“The 9th President Süleyman Demirel, who passed away yesterday, was, together with Turgut Özal, one of the two most important politicians of the military tutelage period. He was one of the leading political representatives of the ‘periphery’ composed of civil society forces against the ‘center’ of the military-civilian bureaucracy that wanted to hold the reins of government with authoritarian Kemalism, that is, with an understanding of strict secularism and monoculturalism. As a pragmatic rather than ideological, conservative rather than reformist politician, Demirel’s main endeavor can be said to be keeping the military out of politics, sometimes through conflict and sometimes through compromise, and making civilian politics dominant. In this endeavor, he was sometimes successful and sometimes unsuccessful.

“Demirel had no sin in being forced to resign from the prime ministry on March 12, 1971. He was a victim of developments caused by a military coup attempt that would revive the single-party regime and remove Turkey from the alliance of Western democracies. His role in the execution of Deniz Gezmiş and his friends in 1972, however, will never be forgiven. His merit in recognizing that the import substitution development strategy that made the country ‘dependent on 70 cents’ had failed and pioneering the transition to an outward-oriented market economy with the January 24, 1980 decisions can be compared to his sin in paving the way for the September 12, 1980 military coup by rejecting Bülent Ecevit’s grand coalition proposal and insisting on early elections.

“If his opening the door to a peaceful solution by going to Diyarbakır and saying ‘We recognize the Kurdish reality’ upon his return to the prime ministry in 1991 can be written on the merit side, he committed a grave sin during his Presidency from 1993 to 2000 by supporting the deep state’s ‘solution through killing’ policies. His ensuring that Parliament remained open during the February 28 intervention can also be written on the merit side.

“His performance in the presidency can objectively be evaluated only by comparing it with Tayyip Erdoğan’s. The story of a peasant boy born in İslamköy, whose prime ministry began at age 41 and, with ups and downs, spanned 7 terms totaling 10 years, and then 7 years of presidency, is a success story of Demirel personally as well as of democracy in Turkey, with all its deficiencies and flaws.

“As I bid him farewell, I would like to share a memory of the late Demirel. Mainly due to my character, and partly because I pay attention to professional principles as a commentator, I have always stayed away from those holding political, administrative, and economic power. I met Demirel only once, in 2007, shortly after he left the presidency, on the occasion of a television program. Before the program, I went to him and introduced myself: ‘Mr. President, I am Şahin Alpay. I am a faculty member at such-and-such university, and I also write a column for such-and-such newspaper…’ I said. Demirel, with a rather mocking smile, said, ‘Mr. Alpay, I served as prime minister for ten years and president for 7 years in this country. I know who you are…’ He embarrassed me with his legendary memory.

“Like most of those, I think, who followed his long political career full of merits and sins, ups and downs, I too will remember Demirel as ‘Shepherd Sülü.’” (*Zaman*, June 18, 2015)

“Democracy is being murdered”

As a result of the June 7 elections, the expectation arose that CHP and MHP would form an HDP-supported coalition government and the AKP would fall from power. However, MHP leader Devlet Bahçeli had announced on the evening of June 7 that he would say “no” to all possible partnerships for a coalition and pointed to the need for new elections. Not only did he react against CHP leader Kılıçdaroğlu’s call of “*Let him be prime minister if he wants*,” he also opened the door for the AKP to elect the Speaker by refusing cooperation with opposition parties in the TBMM Speaker election. With this attitude, Bahçeli not only prevented the AKP from losing power but was also instrumental in its winning the repeat election to be held on November 1. President Erdoğan gave the task of forming a government to Davutoğlu, who was still serving as prime minister. No result came from Davutoğlu’s contacts. While no government could be formed, the country entered a rather dark period. This process developed step by step as follows:

- On July 15, the KCK announced that it had ended the resolution process, citing the construction of outposts and dams as justification.

- On July 20, in Suruç, ISIS carried out a suicide bomb attack against young people carrying toys for children in Kobani. 34 young people lost their lives.

- On July 22, two police officers stationed in Ceylanpınar were shot in the head and killed in their home. The PKK first claimed responsibility for the action, then announced it had no involvement. However, this incident, which still has not been fully clarified and in which all the names captured at the time were tried and acquitted, marked the end of the resolution process.

- On July 24, operations against the PKK and ISIS were launched on Prime Minister Davutoğlu’s orders. The operations meant that the “resolution process” had officially ended. On July 26, the PKK announced “The ceasefire has effectively ended.” On July 28, a major was martyred in a PKK attack; the next day, on July 29, President Erdoğan announced that the resolution process could no longer be carried out. With the start of PKK attacks, news of martyrs began coming from all directions. The TSK began bombing Kandil and its surroundings.

- On August 4, HDP Co-Chair Selahattin Demirtaş made a statement saying “The PKK should lay down arms, the government should end operations,” but his calls did not yield results. Demirtaş and HDP were accused of not openly taking a stance against the PKK.

- On August 12, a statement came from the KCK saying “*We have declared democratic autonomy*.” After this statement, “*democratic autonomy has begun*” announcements were made in many districts in the region. KCK groups that declared autonomy were arrested.

- When no result came from coalition negotiations, President Erdoğan did not assign anyone other than Davutoğlu the task of forming a government a second time and on August 26 decided that repeat elections should be held as required by the constitution.

- On September 7, 16 soldiers were martyred in a PKK attack in Dağlıca, and the next day 13 police officers were martyred in a PKK attack in Iğdır.

- On September 8, attacks were carried out against HDP buildings across the country. Davutoğlu's statement "*We are rising in the polls*" created great controversy.

- On October 10, ISIS attacked a peace rally held in Ankara with two suicide bombers. 102 people lost their lives in this attack in front of Ankara Train Station. After the largest terrorist attack in Republican history, Davutoğlu made a "*cocktail terrorism*" statement. Davutoğlu pointed to the PKK along with ISIS for the massacre.

- Davutoğlu's October 20 statement "*If AKP goes, white Toros cars will come*," referring to the unsolved murders of the 1990s, created great controversy.

- In the repeat election on November 1, the AKP received 49.5% of the vote and became the single-party government again with 317 deputies. HDP, which lost votes, narrowly passed the threshold with 10.8% of the vote. MHP also lost votes, falling to 11.9%. CHP's votes remained at 25%.

- The bloody process continued after the election as well. In January 2016, ISIS attacked foreign tourists in Sultanahmet. In February, the PKK carried out a bomb attack on shuttle vehicles carrying soldiers on Ankara's Merasim Street; in March, a bomb attack was carried out on bus stops in Kızılay. Also in March, ISIS carried out a bomb attack on İstiklal Avenue. This was followed by the ISIS attack in Bursa in April. In the latter part of 2016, the PKK's "trench operations" and security forces' operations against them were launched. Operations in residential areas, especially in Cizre, Sur, and Yüksekova, continued for nearly a year. (See Gökçer Tahincioğlu, "What happened between the June 7 and November 1 elections?" T24, August 24, 2019.)

I commented on the events between June 7 and November 1 and the November 1 election results in the articles I quote below as follows:

"(…) The truth that emerged with the latest Dağlıca attack is this: Although two years ago Abdullah Öcalan said the period of armed struggle had ended; although PKK spokespeople have stated various times that there can be no armed solution to the Kurdish issue; although since the June 7 elections HDP has had the opportunity to take the lead in Turkey's democratization; although HDP and all civil society organizations of the Kurdish-majority region, all tribal leaders have called on it to end its actions, the PKK does not hesitate in the slightest to support the murder of democracy in Turkey by escalating conflicts. President Erdoğan, who has effectively taken over the governance of the country, despite the increasing martyrs, despite the cries of families, can still say '…if a political party had reached a number that could get 400 deputies, the situation would be very different today…' He can openly say 'If you had made me president, all this suffering would not have happened'… By saying 'According to our religion, martyrs don't die, they continue to live…' he can ignore the pain of parents, spouses, children, siblings. The general picture is this: both the government headed by President Erdoğan and the PKK do not hesitate to pave the way that could ultimately lead to the destruction of democracy once again in Turkey, that could take the country to civil war and

disintegration. For the country's sensible people, reasonable people, there seems to be no other way but to cry out once again, as our years of experience, our consciences, our future dictate: 'Stop this violence; violence begets violence; problems can never be solved by killing, they can be solved by talking…' ("Democracy is being murdered," *Zaman*, September 8, 2015.)

"Who did this to us?"

"Last Saturday, the largest terrorist attack in Republican history took place in Ankara; 97 citizens were killed; 245 citizens, 65 of them in intensive care, are still being treated. Since the end of the 'resolution process,' the number of martyrs in clashes with the PKK has exceeded 150, hundreds of PKK militants have died, and the number of civilian deaths has reached 227. Turkey is bleeding internally. Starting with the Ankara massacre that brought the spiral of violence to its peak, we must ask the questions 'Who did this to us? How can we get out of this bloody pit we have fallen into?'

"For now, we do not know for certain who planned and carried out the Ankara massacre. We can list what we know through open intelligence, that is, through news reflected in the media, as follows:

1) The bombs used at the HDP rally in Diyarbakır on June 5, in Suruç on July 20, and in the Ankara massacre on Saturday are identical. Whose work the Diyarbakır and Suruç massacres were has not been clarified to date. However, initial findings indicate that the Ankara massacre, like the others, may be the work of ISIS.

2) This is a strong possibility. Because Turkey, as of late July, not only opened its bases including İncirlik to US warplanes against ISIS, but the TSK also began striking ISIS positions. The attacks we have been subjected to may serve the purpose of ISIS, which is fighting the Kurds in Syria and Iraq, both to punish Turkey and to provoke Turkish-Kurdish conflict in Turkey.

3) As in the others, it is seen that there was a security failure in the Ankara massacre and that not all measures necessary to prevent the attacks were taken. It is estimated that the intelligence officers purged in the witch hunt the AKP government launched in the police force in response to the December 17/25 investigation played a role in the emergence of this failure. MIT's success in ensuring the country's internal and external security, which is its main task, has been seriously questioned at least since it emerged that 34 citizens who were smuggling in Uludere/Roboski were bombed by warplanes based on MIT intelligence that they were "terrorists."

4) Information that the AKP government, until the last year, provided various forms of support to radical Islamist groups against the Bashar Assad regime, and at least turned a blind eye to their activities in Turkey, suggests that ISIS may have established a wide organizational network in Turkey.

5) Two AKP ministers and circles close to the government claimed that the Ankara massacre was carried out by the PKK for HDP to be successful in the election. It is not credible that the PKK, which generally attacks security forces, would target civilians,

mostly HDP supporters. Moreover, the Ankara attack occurred on the day the PKK announced that it would not take action unless forced to defend itself.

6) The AKP government, headed first by Prime Minister and then President Tayyip Erdoğan, since the December 17/25 bribery and corruption investigation, and mainly after losing single-party power on June 7, has polarized the country to an unprecedented degree in its history by viewing everyone who does not support it as an enemy; by declaring them traitors, terrorists, or terrorist supporters. This environment has made the country vulnerable to all kinds of provocation.

7) The Syria policy pursued by the AKP government has dragged the country into great international isolation. There are many state and non-state actors in the region that could carry out covert activities to stir up Turkey from within.

It is certain that we need a government that will move the country away from polarization, ensure internal peace, end security failures, and pursue a foreign policy that considers strategic interests. The November 1 elections are a great opportunity to establish a coalition government that will heal the wounds. If this opportunity is wasted in one way or another, I don't even want to think about what could happen to us." *(Zaman*, October 13, 2015)

Unfortunately, a coalition government that would heal the wounds could not be established, and elections were repeated on November 1, 2015. In the election, the AKP increased its vote by 9% to 49.5% and, winning 317 parliamentary seats, gained the possibility of being in power alone again. CHP's vote share and number of deputies remained stagnant at 25% and 134. The MHP, which had brought about the repeat election, saw its vote drop from 16% to 12% and its seats from 80 to 40. HDP's votes also dropped from 13% to 11%, and its seats from 80 to 59.

The November 1, 2015 disaster

I wrote two articles on the November 1 election results. In the first article I wrote:

"Undoubtedly, this is an electoral success for the AKP of a magnitude that neither party strategists nor public opinion pollsters could foresee. The voting, with participation reaching 85 percent and generally conducted with democratic maturity, is a satisfying situation both in terms of the people embracing their vote and in terms of the principle of government by election, one of the fundamental principles of democracy.

"However, it should now be better understood that democracy is not just about elections. Democracy is a regime where citizens' fundamental rights and freedoms are secured as much as it is about government by election. The naked truth is that in the November 1 elections, approximately half of the voters approved the continuation of a government that was becoming increasingly arbitrary, authoritarian, and steeped in corruption up to its neck. Looking at past experiences, I believed that governments that do not respect rights and freedoms eventually lose in Turkey. The June 7 elections had also reinforced this conviction. However, November 1 badly proved me wrong. If we are to establish democracy with all its principles and institutions, we must first understand well the

reasons for this unexpected result. In this context, the points that need to be underlined first are these:

“The polarization strategy pursued by the AKP government yielded results. The campaign of accusing the opposition of ‘treason, vileness, supporting terrorism, being an extension of terrorism, serving internal and external enemies’ played the leading role in consolidating voter support. The main implementers of this strategy were the judicial bodies placed under the government’s command and the pro-government media (‘pool media’) running a campaign of lies and slander. Public broadcasters TRT and AA functioned entirely as the government’s mouthpiece. Pressures intensifying during the election campaign on opposition media ranged from investigations, arrests, and censorship to the open seizure of İpek Media Group.

“It was also seen that the AKP administration was able to convince at least 8 percent of the electorate of its (completely unfounded) claim that stability could only be ensured by single-party government. The biggest role in this was played by the inability of the three opposition parties, which received 59 percent of citizens’ support in the June 7 elections, to come together and form a joint government, even for a short time, at least with the aim of repairing the damage done to the rule of law. The lion’s share of this failure certainly belongs to MHP, which treated HDP as ‘nonexistent’ and opened the way for repeat elections, virtually playing a buttress role for the government. Its loss of approximately 2 million votes on November 1 is clear evidence of this.

“On the other hand, it appears that the choices of Kurdish voters, who were caught between two fires (the state and the PKK) as the AKP government put the ‘resolution process’ in the ‘freezer’ and turned again to a military solution, and who were under the threat ‘if we go, white Toros cars (extrajudicial killings) will come,’ were somewhat affected by this situation. The fact that HDP, which could not even conduct a proper election campaign under pressure, still managed to pass the threshold and will maintain its place in Parliament with 59 deputies continues to be a source of hope for the resolution of the Kurdish issue. In this context, it should once again be seen that the PKK’s weapons are one of the most important obstacles to democratization in Turkey.

“As a result, yes, on November 1 the government problem was solved, but all the other problems of the country, especially authoritarianism, remain in place. Can Turkey, with a government that will effectively be run by President Erdoğan, overcome problems ranging from the Kurdish issue to judicial independence and freedom of expression, from economy to foreign policy? My answer in the next article.” (“Democracy is not just about elections,” *Zaman*, November 3, 2015)

Polarization at its peak

In my article two days later, I wrote:

“I can summarize the main factors that played a role in the great electoral success of the AKP, effectively headed by President Erdoğan, on November 1 with 49 percent of the vote and (in the final count) 317 deputies as follows: The government polarizing society by declaring opponents ‘traitors’; turning facts upside down with the media under its

command; with the help of the opposition, convincing a significant portion of the electorate that stability could only be ensured by single-party government; the MHP falling into the Bahçeli ‘trench,’ and the HDP into the PKK ‘trench.’

“Of course, in any country where government is determined by elections, for a party to collect around 49 percent of the vote is a great success. However, 49 or 59 percent of the vote alone cannot be a guarantee of either political or economic stability. Stability is possible only where citizens’ fundamental rights and freedoms are respected. Unfortunately, the main negative result of this election is that polarization in society has peaked with 49 percent approving authoritarianism. It is clear that the half of society that did not vote for the AKP feels a great reaction against Erdoğan’s administration, perhaps to a degree never seen in Republican history.

“Very different segments are extremely dissatisfied with the AKP government. No government that cannot win the hearts of the Kurds, who have resisted the denial of their identity since the founding of the Republic, can be long-lasting. Although the AKP government managed to regain the support of at least some Kurds, almost all of the Alevis, the country’s largest religious minority, have been very dissatisfied since at least the 1990s because their freedom of belief is restricted and they are being forced to adopt the Diyanet’s religion. The segment of society that perhaps constitutes Turkey’s largest minority in terms of lifestyle is extremely dissatisfied. Some devout Sunnis perceive the AKP government as a gang of interests that is an enemy of fundamental rights and freedoms, including freedom of belief, and that has turned its back on the most fundamental moral principles of Islam.

“Rising unemployment, inflation, declining exports, foreign and domestic investments, and declining economic growth rate are increasingly negatively affecting the living conditions of the segments of society that live by their labor. If the economic trend continues, an increase in dissatisfaction in this segment is inevitable. Under conditions where even the right to property is threatened, the segment of businessmen that does not receive the government’s support either remains silent for fear of facing wrath or grumbles silently. Not only are the dissatisfied spreading across a wide base, but groups from different political tendencies who had been opposed to each other until yesterday are tending to unite against the increasingly authoritarian government, setting aside their differences.

“In the face of the opposition parties’ powerlessness, the eyes of those hoping for the revival of the rule of law had turned to politicians within the AKP who seemed aware of the dangers of the direction of things, such as Abdullah Gül, Bülent Arınç, and Ali Babacan. Now the same eyes have turned to Prime Minister Davutoğlu because of his words in his ‘balcony’ speeches on the night of November 1 about being conciliatory and respecting rights and freedoms. (Arınç and Babacan, whom Erdoğan did not invite to the Palace on October 29, appeared right behind Davutoğlu on the ‘balcony.’)

“The point that seems to be being ignored is that both the AKP’s latest election victory and Davutoğlu himself are Erdoğan’s creation. The arrest of journalists the day after the election, ‘plot’ raids in 18 provinces, travel bans imposed on 54 judges and prosecutors, the Chief Prosecutor’s returning the Hrant Dink case indictment for the second time

(allegedly to remove certain names from among the suspects) remind us of the saying that should never be forgotten: 'A person's work is their mirror, not their words.' Another point that a narrower circle is trying to make us forget is that the 'parallel structure' fallacy is not being used to 'fight all kinds of illegal structures within the state through legal means,' but on the contrary, to demolish the rule of law.

"*My conclusion from November 1 is that Turkey has taken another big step toward an 'electoral autocracy.' The defeat of military-based authoritarianism took at least half a century. That the defeat of ballot box-based authoritarianism will not take that long is, I think, the most optimistic comment I can make."* (Italics added later.) (*Zaman*, November 5, 2015)

Many more years will probably need to pass for this rather dark period in Turkish history between the two elections to be illuminated. However, the following points emerged with the November 1 election results: 1) MHP helped the AKP maintain power by refusing to join the government after the June 7 elections and insisting on early elections. It itself became the biggest loser of the election. 2) Between the two elections, the PKK and ISIS, above all, escalated terrorist actions to an unprecedented degree. (The PKK's return to a low-intensity war strategy after several months of intense armed struggle raised questions.) 3) Voters frightened by the violence turned back to the AKP. The AKP increased its vote by approximately 9%, raising its number of deputies from 258 to 317 and regaining the possibility of governing alone.

Last trip to the USA: September 2015

When my job at Bahçeşehir University was terminated, although I didn't suddenly find myself "free as a bird," I had more free time than I had in a long time. I had no work left other than writing columns three days a week for *Zaman*, one day for *Today's Zaman*, and appearing one evening a week on the "Akıl Defteri" (Notebook of Wisdom) program on Mehtap TV. I had become able to take leave from my newspaper and television jobs and go on trips. At the invitation of *Zaman* representatives, in the last days of April I made a visit to Scandinavia (which would turn out to be the last). I spoke at meetings organized in Copenhagen, then in Gothenburg.

The Erdoğan government's attacks on the Gülen movement and therefore on *Zaman* were increasing, and the circle surrounding the group was narrowing. I had begun to feel that troubles could befall me in the not-too-distant future. My close American friend Tor Krieger had come to Turkey three times to see me in 1963, 2005, and 2007; I had not been able to make a return visit even once. These days might be my last chance. In September, I got permission from Fatma to go to Tor. In August, I wrote to Tor that an opportunity had arisen for me to visit him, and that this might be my last chance. His response, though delayed, was positive.

When Tor came from Santa Rosa in northern California, where he had lived for a long time, to New York in the spring of 1998 just to see me, I had met Shan, his second legally married wife among his many wives. Now he was with his third legally married wife, Danelle. When they met me at the San Francisco airport on September 8, I learned the reason for Tor's delayed response: considerable sorrow had been caused by the

suicide about two weeks earlier of Danelle's son from her first marriage, a very successful architect in his 30s (but whom Tor never liked because of his drug addiction). My coming to visit them provided an occasion for solace and was in a way good.

In the first five days of the visit, I stayed with Tor and Danelle. Our classmates from Webb School who lived nearby, Dick Power and John Trefethen, hosted us for dinners with their wives. Together with Tor, we toured the vineyards and wineries in the Napa Valley region, famous for northern California's wines. One day we took a trip to the coast. On the way, we stopped at Bodega Bay, where Alfred Hitchcock's famous 1963 film "Birds" was set. One evening, I gave a talk on political developments in Turkey and the world to a large group of friends at Tor's house. Shan, the mother of Tor's son Jess, also attended the meeting; we chatted briefly. I spoke by phone with my daughter Elvan and my granddaughter Defne, who were in Chicago at the time. This Santa Rosa visit, which I've described in some detail, took me out of the increasingly restrictive environment I was living in in Istanbul; it was good for me.

Before flying to San Francisco, I had contacted Hizmet's representatives; I had informed them that I wanted to see its schools in California and that I could give talks to Americans about what was happening in Turkey. In this context, on September 16, I gave a talk titled "What went wrong in Turkey" at the Center for Middle Eastern Studies at UC Berkeley, one of the leading universities in the United States (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TuO6yMUSc4U>).

Bilici instead of Dumanlı

When I returned to Turkey on September 18, the storm brewing around *Zaman* was growing.

The tension between the AKP government and the Gülen Community or Hizmet Movement, which began with the closure of the prep schools run by Hizmet, had greatly escalated with the December 17-25, 2013 "Corruption and Bribery Operation" in which public officials including four ministers were accused of abuse of office and bribery (allegedly initiated by prosecutors associated with Hizmet). *Zaman* newspaper editor-in-chief Ekrem Dumanlı and Samanyolu broadcasting group chairman Hidayet Karaca were detained on December 14, 2014; while Karaca was arrested on charges of establishing and running a terrorist organization (still in prison); Ekrem Dumanlı was released with a travel ban.

Dumanlı resigned on October 5, 2015 from the position he had held for 14 years. In his statement, he said, "I see that I cannot perform my duty as Editor-in-Chief due to the unlawful pressures applied to the press and to me personally in recent times." (On November 11, 2015, an arrest warrant would be issued for him; it would become clear that he had fled abroad.) Following Dumanlı's resignation, it was announced that Abdülhamit Bilici, the General Manager of Cihan News Agency, had been appointed to this position.

I had a more intimate relationship with Bilici than with Dumanlı. I was pleased that it was he, rather than someone else, who replaced Dumanlı. I visited him and wished him

success in his new position, which he had assumed in a very difficult period. During this visit, we had a very interesting conversation. Bilici said that looking at developments in the Middle East and in Turkey in recent years, the Kemalists had been proven right, and complained that Islamism had turned the region and the country into a hell of oppression and violence. I objected. I said it should not be forgotten that what brought Islamists to power in Turkey, though not in the Middle East, was the oppression exerted by Kemalists on Muslims. Interestingly, a similar debate would take place between Hilmi Yavuz and myself some time later at a meeting where *Zaman* writers gathered. I objected to "Brother Hilmi's" statement that Islam was incompatible with freedom and democracy. I argued that the problem stemmed not only from bigoted interpretations of Islam but also from imperialist and authoritarian pressures on Muslims. (As I write these lines, I think both factors need to be taken into account when trying to understand the Islamic world's lack of accommodation for individual freedom.)

Vietnam 50 years later

In mid-November, I went to Ankara at the invitation of Swedish Ambassador Lars Wahlund. I also visited the new and stylish building of *Zaman* and *Today's Zaman* (which would be seized by the government before a year had passed). I met with the bureau chiefs of the two newspapers, Mustafa Ünal and Abdullah Bozkurt. (I would meet Ünal next in Silivri. This would be my last meeting with Bozkurt; I would learn that he had taken refuge in Sweden after July 15.)

November 29, 2015 was Fatma's and my 50th wedding anniversary. When I suggested on this occasion that she could take a trip abroad of her choice, she chose a cruise to the Far East. With my elder sister Olcay and Fatma's cousin Emine also joining, we flew to Singapore via Dubai on November 30 and from there boarded the ship for a trip that would last until December 13. The trip took us to Brunei in the north of Borneo island, from there to the Vietnamese cities of Nha Trang and Ho Chi Minh (former Saigon), to Bangkok, the capital of Thailand, and Koh Samui island, then back to our departure point, Singapore.

The stop that interested me most on this trip was, of course, Vietnam. In the article titled "Vietnam 50 years later" that I wrote for *Zaman*, I wrote: "Frankly, it never occurred to me that there would be such a great contrast between the Vietnam that adorned the dreams of my youth and the Vietnam I saw with my own eyes 50 years later. Yes, Vietnam is still under the authoritarian single-party rule of the Communist Party. However, it seems the very symbol of the fact that the only thing that doesn't change in the world is change. (…)

Vietnam, which until that date had tried to establish a planned economy based on state ownership, seeing that this was not a way forward, from 1986 onwards (just like China) turned to establishing a (supposedly socialist) market economy based on private ownership under communist party rule." (*Zaman*, December 19, 2015)

On December 12, while we were preparing to leave the ship, Fatma fell ill; she became unable to walk. We immediately went to the ship's infirmary. The Australian doctor and nurses, bless them, showed warm concern. They said she was probably having a crisis

due to fatigue and would recover after the injection they gave her. Indeed, that's what happened. Perhaps because we disembarked late, the passport police delayed us for quite a while with questions. Skipping the Singapore city tour, we went straight to the airport. (If Fatma had had that crisis before leaving the ship, what would have become of us, which hospital would we have gone to, what would we have done if we had missed the plane? We were grateful for the timing of the crisis.) We returned to Istanbul via Dubai.

Neither law nor logic remains

The article titled "Neither law nor logic remains" that I wrote upon returning from the Far East trip, which began with "I don't remember an elected government in Turkey being as far from law and logic as it is today," and ended with the sentence "This Turkey has ceased to be the country I was born and raised in, the country I knew; it is experiencing a state of madness," in my opinion summarized well the point the country had reached at that time:

"I don't remember an elected government in Turkey being as far from law and logic as it is today. The AKP government, which with EU reforms brought the country closer to the rule of law than ever before until 2011, has zeroed out the rule of law with the steps it has taken since then. The same government that in its first term was moving the country toward becoming a fortress of peace internally and externally now leaves the country facing the threat of war internally and externally. I have never felt as much as I do today that the country is being governed by a cadre devoid of competence and prudence. Those who govern Turkey today recognize neither law nor logic; not only the country's law but also its accumulated wisdom and knowledge has been pushed aside.

"The most obvious, most painful proof of this is the conflicts growing in an increasingly alarming manner since the peace negotiations conducted with the PKK were unilaterally abandoned, saying 'Oh, HDP won't let me be elected president!' The historical experience that neither the Kurdish issue nor the PKK issue—its product—can be solved by killing people; that it can only be solved through negotiation, through talking, has been completely thrown aside. The President says, 'We must take the separatist terrorist organization out of action without showing the slightest tolerance…' The Prime Minister is so focused on solution through killing that he addresses AKP youth saying 'I see the love of martyrdom in your faces…'

"The Interior Minister proudly proclaims that 3,000 PKK members have been killed since the abandonment of the peace process; it is forgotten that dozens replace every PKK member killed. By subjecting the cities of the Kurdish region to an undeclared state of emergency, by imposing curfews, by forcing the population to migrate, by withdrawing public officials from the region, virtually everything necessary is being done to make the Kurds lose hope of living as equal citizens in Turkey. I don't know if even the soldiers are convinced by the logic of solution through killing.

"In foreign policy conducted with reactive steps, we are constantly being tossed about. The downing of the Russian warplane left Ankara, which has been pursuing regime change since 2011, with no ability to influence Syria's future. The no-fly zone it wanted

established against Bashar Assad's forces is now being implemented by Russia against Turkey. What Ankara feared is happening; Syrian Kurds, with Russia's support as well, are advancing toward autonomy in the region stretching along the Turkish border. Despite saying 'we won't withdraw,' Turkish soldiers in Iraq are being withdrawn at the demand of the Baghdad government, which is also supported by the US administration. The strained relations with Russia and the increasingly isolated situation in the region are forcing Ankara to get closer to the West, which it criticized saying 'They don't love us, they love our dead children,' and to reconcile with Israel, which it accused of 'committing genocide.'

"As for the internal situation: The revenge-motivated witch hunt conducted against the Hizmet movement on the claim that it was responsible for the December 17/25 bribery and corruption investigation has reached incredible dimensions. Perhaps all kinds of accusations can be made against its members, but neither sensible Turkey nor the world believes in the slightest the claim that Hizmet is an 'armed terrorist organization.' Efforts to pin all the dark murders committed in the country on the Hizmet movement in order to find support for this claim are the clearest evidence that the rule of law has been zeroed out.

"Just look at what happened in this last week: If an arrest warrant is issued for Cemal Uşak, Chairman of the Journalists and Writers Foundation, an intellectual who has earned almost everyone's respect, on the grounds that he is an 'armed terrorist'; if attempts are being made to link Police Chief Yakub Saygılı, who conducted the December 25 investigation, to the Zirve Publishing House massacre; if Hasan Cemal's books are being confiscated on the grounds of terrorist organization propaganda, then we are at the point where words fail. This Turkey has ceased to be the country I was born and raised in, the country I knew; it is experiencing a state of madness." ("Neither law nor logic remains," December 22, 2015)

Gül: If not now, when?

In an environment where the country was heading toward increasingly darker days internally and externally, I felt the need to address President Gül and Bülent Arınç, who had given hope that he would be the party's conscience. As follows:

"Exactly two years ago, I wrote an article titled 'What is expected of Abdullah Gül and Bülent Arınç.' The article ended as follows: 'Both of them cannot fail to see that the Prime Minister has declared almost everyone who does not think like him a traitor; that he is polarizing society in a very dangerous way; that he is destroying the rule of law to cover up corruption; in short, that he is following a line incompatible with reason, judgment, and logic. It is obvious that where the Prime Minister is taking things will cause great harm to the country. The majority of society believes that the loyalty of these two leading politicians to the country's interests is much stronger than what they feel toward the Prime Minister; they expect them to say stop to this direction that will cause great harm to both the country and the party.' (February 13, 2014)

"Where Tayyip Erdoğan, the Prime Minister of the time, has brought the country in the two years that have passed is obvious. After being elected President, he declared that

the constitution had been put in the ‘waiting room’ and that he was ‘effectively president.’ He ended the ‘resolution process.’ He turned to a military solution to the Kurdish issue, which cannot possibly yield results—to solution through killing. The PKK is gaining more and more supporters inside and more and more friends outside. The policy based on claiming to be a leader in the region has ultimately made Turkey completely ineffective in the region. While the country faces great dangers internally and externally, President Erdoğan is pursuing a ‘Turkish-style’ presidential regime by fueling polarization, as if all powers were not already in his hands, as if he couldn’t govern the country as he pleases, as if there were no other problems left. (…)

“Bülent Arınç has finally begun to raise his voice: ‘It won’t work with weapons, there must be a return to the resolution process; of course Erdoğan knew about the Dolmabahçe agreement with HDP,’ he said. ‘In the MIT trucks case, neither arrest nor conviction can be ordered,’ he said. ‘Such cases are being opened under the name of fighting the “parallel structure” that I want to take up lawyering again,’ he said. He didn’t heed the lynch campaign of ‘trolls and trollettes,’ he said ‘I stand by my words.’ Yes, he spoke ‘too late, too little,’ but he made us say ‘Better late than never…’ Former ministers Hüseyin Çelik, Sadullah Ergin, Suat Kılıç supported him. It seems others will too.

“And our 11th President Mr. Abdullah Gül? Although it was clear that he was not pleased with the situation internally and externally, he first signed all the laws that trampled on freedoms and the rule of law by acting like a ‘Çankaya notary’; then he remained completely silent, perhaps by putting party interests above everything, perhaps by saying ‘if there is a need my party will call me to duty…,’ perhaps with the expectation that ‘conditions will ripen.’ Yet if he shows the courage and determination to object to the bad direction, Gül could lead both the people and his party to put the country back on its feet. If nothing else, the respect he received from the majority of the people during his Presidency should encourage him to show this courage and determination.

“I wonder: If not now, when will Abdullah Gül say ‘Enough!’ and raise his voice against the country’s march toward chaos internally and externally?” (*Zaman*, February 6, 2016)

Not paranoia but fallacy

I felt the need to defend the community against the characterization of the Gülen community or Hizmet movement as a “legal-looking illegal structure”:

“Murat Tokay has prepared a wonderful dossier for the latest (February 22-28, 2016) issue of *Aksiyon* magazine; the title is ‘Parallel paranoia’ (pp. 42-44). An instructive dossier in terms of showing how far the ‘parallel structure’ claim extends. Let me quote a few selections: ‘Parallel’ is responsible for the contraction in tourism. It deceived farmers and seized their cows and presented them as calves. It wiretapped underwater fiber optic cables with a team of 60 people. It shot down the Russian plane. It caused someone being tried for fraud to hit a cow with his car. It victimized tradespeople by opening the Bolu tunnel. It caused a crime of passion. And more…

“The dossier is truly instructive, but the title is misleading. Which paranoia? Are those who try to pin the crimes they commit on the Hizmet Movement, which they label as

‘parallel structure,’ suffering from paranoia? As is known, paranoia is a mental illness, defining people who, completely disconnected from reality, imagine that traps are being set for them. Those who put forward the ‘parallel structure’ claims, or in its developed expression ‘legal-looking illegal structure,’ have not the slightest connection to any mental illness. It is wrong to establish a connection between them and mental illness; because it implies that they could be excused, that they could not be held responsible.

“It is certain that those who put forward the ‘parallel structure, Fethullahist Gang, etc.’ claims do so with their mental-psychological balance fully intact, knowingly and willingly. Yes, their purposes may differ: Some use it as a tool to cover up the crimes they commit, some to oppress, frighten, and intimidate society; some do it to ingratiate themselves with those making the claims, to fawn. What we are dealing with is certainly not paranoia, but, as Honorary President of the Court of Cassation Sami Selçuk accurately diagnosed, ‘fallacy.’

“The claim that they were ‘victims of the parallel structure’s plot’ was first put forward by the defendants of the Sledgehammer and Ergenekon coup attempt cases. They claimed that they had committed no crime, and that the allegations against them were ‘fabricated’ by judiciary and police members implementing Fethullah Gülen’s instructions. It is true that in these cases, far too many people, involved or not, were made defendants, that detention turned into punishment, and that defense rights were violated. But neither the ECHR nor the Court of Cassation believed that the cases were fabricated.

“The AKP government, subjected to the December 17/25 major bribery and corruption investigation, immediately clung to the theses of the Sledgehammer and Ergenekon case defendants to cover up the investigation. It didn’t stop there; it turned to using the ‘parallel’ claim as a tool to purge public administration of those who don’t think like them, to oppress civil society, and to silence the opposition. McCarthyism and witch hunting peaked in Turkey. The ‘parallel’ claim extended to the absurdity of claiming that the Hizmet Movement was an ‘armed terrorist organization’ (like DAESH, PKK, DHKP-C, etc.).

“I understand very well those who cling to the ‘parallel’ claim to be cleansed of crime. What I have difficulty understanding is those who think they are protecting themselves from the AKP government’s wrath by clinging to it. Because it is certain that these people are aware of the following points: Crime is personal. If there is a suspect, they should be tried fairly and receive the punishment they deserve. But bringing people before courts established not to try them fairly but to convict them, with fabricated allegations, their being oppressed, pushed around, means the end of the rule of law… That people who know these things very well see no problem in aiding the destruction of the rule of law is another manifestation of the state of madness we are living in…” (*Zaman*, February 27, 2016)

Last day at *Zaman*, last article

We did the last (477th) program of “Akıl Defteri,” which we had been conducting with Eser Karakaş and Mehmet Altan since 2006, on November 9, 2015. On November 15,

all radio and television stations belonging to the Samanyolu group, including Mehtap TV, were removed from Türksat. On February 29, 2016, the broadcasts of Kanaltürk, Bugün TV, *Bugün* and *Millet* newspapers, and Kanaltürk Radio, which were under trustee management, were ended. On March 4, 2016, a trustee was appointed to *Zaman*. Anadolu Agency would report that this decision was made on the grounds that 'there was strong evidence that the newspaper was being used within the scope of FETÖ/ Parallel State Structure's activities and in a way to support organizational activities.'

I convey the subsequent developments from my notes:

On the night of March 3, I was feeling tired. Without looking at the news, I watched Beşiktaş's 2-0 loss to Konya with annoyance and went to bed early. (Yet that day Cem Küçük and Abdurrahman Dilipak had written that *Zaman* would be seized.) On the morning of March 4, I woke up at 6 a.m. and until 8:30 a.m. reviewed the article titled 'The wisdom of Herkül Millas,' dealing with the issue of the Community's transparency, to be published the next day. When I looked at email messages, I saw the message from page editor Buket Davulcu calling me to the newspaper. Then I read the headline story in *Zaman* titled "Trustee threat." Around 9 a.m. Nazlı Ilıcak called, asking what was happening. I said I didn't know; I advised her to call Abdülhamit Bilici. As usual, I took the Metrobus; I reached the *Zaman* building around 10:30. Buket said a trustee decision had been made about the newspaper, and it was unknown when the trustees would arrive. Then I went up to Bilici's office: Mümtazer Türköne, Ahmet Turan Alkan, Bülent Keneş, Mehmet Kamış, Bülent Korucu, and, from *Bugün*, Nazlı Ilıcak and Turgay Oğur were there.

Morale was low. Bilici looked quite distressed. Alkan joked, "Now that Şahin Bey has come, the resistance is ready…" It was said the trustees might not come until their appointments appeared in the trade registry, and their arrival might be on Monday. I went downstairs and wrote a new article. I had managing editor Ali Akkuş read it: he said the sentence "President Erdoğan has become Turkey's most dangerous person" could be dangerous. Upon learning that the trustees could arrive at any moment, I put the title on what was clearly going to be my last article: "Words don't end." I wrote:

Words don't end

"I am writing this article in the hours when *Zaman* Newspaper, where I have worked for 14 years and which is the fortress of free press in Turkey, faces the threat of being placed under trustee management and destroyed, just as happened to *Bugün* Newspaper before. Unfortunately, our great Turkey, our country that I dreamed would be a country where freedom and democracy reign, is being taken step by step toward a third world dictatorship. This is hard to believe!

"Unfortunately, it is so! While the AKP signed off on many reforms toward making Turkey a free and democratic country in its first two terms in power, I gave considerable support to Prime Minister Tayyip Erdoğan with my writings. I cannot help but be astonished that Mr. Erdoğan, as president, is managing the process of ruling all of Turkey alone; Turkey, which has behind it approximately two hundred years of rule of law and at least half a century of democratic accumulation; of reducing democracy to just elections; of

destroying the rule of law at its root. However, if we close our eyes to the point Mr. Erdoğan has reached today and the impasse he has dragged the country into, we will have turned our backs on the principles and values we believe in.

“Mr. Erdoğan most recently says that the Constitutional Court violated the constitution by ruling that two journalists, Can Dündar and Erdem Gül, had suffered ‘rights violations.’ Admittedly, it is not an unseen thing in this country for the Constitutional Court to violate the constitution. My generation remembers as if it were yesterday that the Constitutional Court in this country bowed respectfully before the military administration that seized power through a coup. We also know that the current Constitutional Court played a role in the country reaching this point by approving the law concerning Criminal Peace Judgeships, which were established not to try fairly but to convict.

“However, I think that a legally compliant decision of the current Constitutional Court, which has no meaning beyond resulting in two journalists being tried without detention, being accused of ‘violating the constitution’ by a President who himself says ‘the constitution is on hold’ and that he is ‘effectively president’ rather than according to the constitution, is an event not encountered in any other country that could be considered a democracy to any degree. In a country claiming to be a democracy, the state’s seizure of the country’s best-selling, most-read newspaper, the fortress of freedom of expression, has never, ever been encountered.

“Unfortunately, Mr. President not only led the reversal of the gains of the first two terms of his government, but by excluding almost all of the founding cadres, he is transforming the AKP into a completely different party, the Tayyip Erdoğan Party. He turned his back on all the friendships he established while fighting against the enemies of democratization and won the friendship of his enemies. According to the constitution accepted by the people and the oath he took, the person who is supposed to represent all the people, who is expected to receive respect from everyone, viewing almost everyone who didn’t vote for him and who objects to the violation of law as an enemy, a traitor, must be one of the most dire situations that can befall a country. However, we are not at the point where words fail. We must say no to this direction that is taking our country toward the abyss. Turkey will not accept this direction.” (See: *T24*, March 5, 2016)

While we were waiting for the trustees, a crowd of readers and supporters, mostly community members, had begun to gather in the newspaper’s garden and in front. Administrators and writers were giving speeches to the crowd in the newspaper’s garden. I also got in line. Ali Bulaç addressed his former friends in the government, telling them to come to their senses; he warned supporters to conduct protests within the law. He spoke well. I also said in summary: “I am proud to have been writing for *Zaman* for 14 years. *Zaman* is the fortress of free press… In this country, we learn democracy and the value of freedoms by living them. We believed that the Erdoğan government would establish democracy in Turkey in its first two terms of power, and we supported it. The same government is taking the country toward a third world dictatorship. However, in a country at Turkey’s level of development, in Turkey which has 200 years of rule of law and 60-70 years of democracy experience, which is one of the oldest democracies

in the world, it is not possible to establish an authoritarian regime. Every darkness ends with light…" Ali Bulaç said, "you spoke well."

I went up to Bilici's office again. I asked if there was any preparation for what to do after the closure. People had come to show solidarity with the newspaper: Orhan Birgit and Pınar Türenç from the Association were there. Photos were taken. I gave statements to Cihan News Agency and Can Erzincan TV. As Pınar Türenç was leaving, I went over to see her off. "We said from the beginning that things would come to this, but we couldn't get through…" she said. She was implying that the support given to the AKP government was wrong. I didn't say anything.

Around 6:30 p.m., I said goodbye to Bilici before leaving the newspaper with Ali Bulaç and Ahmet Turan Alkan. "Let's not keep you any longer, brother," he said. "Do I look very disheveled?…" he asked. I consoled him. As I was leaving the newspaper, I ran into Mehmet Kamış (one of the oldest acquaintances from the newspaper) at the entrance. "Don't tell anyone, we have preparations for a new newspaper. This morning we talked with *Sözcü* and reached an agreement," he said. After coming home and eating dinner, I watched on Can Erzincan TV the arrival of 4 CHP deputies at *Zaman* in solidarity; the police dispersing the crowd that had gathered in front of the newspaper around 10 p.m. with water cannons, tear gas, and smoke bombs, then breaking down the door and entering the newspaper around midnight.

Euronews reported the news as follows: "Police raided the building of *Zaman* Newspaper, one of Turkey's leading media organizations. After the decision by Istanbul 6th Criminal Peace Judgeship to appoint a trustee to Feza Journalism, to which *Zaman* Newspaper belongs, riot police and police teams arrived in front of the newspaper building on Friday evening and clashed with newspaper employees and their relatives protesting the decision. Security forces, using pepper spray and water cannons to disperse the crowd, then broke through the chained doors and entered the building. Some journalists and photojournalists who resisted the police were removed.

"*Zaman* Newspaper Editor-in-Chief Abdülhamit Bilici is of the opinion that the decision is not legal but entirely political: 'Unfortunately, for the last 3-4 years, those who speak against the government's actions are either taken to court, imprisoned, or brought under government control. I think this is a dark process for our country and our democracy.' On the other hand, the UK National Union of Journalists (NUJ) announced that they were 'deeply concerned' about the implemented decision. *Zaman*, Turkey's best-selling newspaper with a circulation of 650,000, is known for its closeness to retired preacher Fethullah Gülen, founder of the Hizmet movement. It had been decided to appoint a trustee to Feza Journalism, which includes *Zaman* Newspaper, on the grounds that 'there was strong evidence that it was being used within the scope of the Fethullahist Terrorist Organization / Parallel State Structure's activities and in a way to support organizational activities.'"

CHAPTER XVI / AFTER ZAMAN

Amid all these dramatic developments, Fatma's health took a worrying turn. My beloved wife had been suffering from liver failure since 1986 and rheumatoid arthritis since 2000. After returning from our Far East trip, we began facing frequent episodes of her pulse racing. Several evenings we had to rush to Florence Nightingale Hospital, where medical interventions brought her pulse under control. When Fatma's heart palpitations recurred in Izmir, where we were for her nephew Cenk's wedding on March 18, we went to Alsancak State Hospital. Each time, injections would lower her pulse, but the episodes were becoming increasingly frequent.

When we returned to Istanbul, a friend strongly recommended that we consult Prof. Dr. Sabri Demircan from the Cardiovascular Diseases department at Florence Nightingale Hospital. Demircan had performed a procedure called ablation on our friend —entering the heart via catheter and burning specific tissues—achieving complete success in ending the palpitations. After examining Fatma, Demircan said he could succeed with 70 percent probability, not 100 percent, and Fatma decided without hesitation; she did not want to live with palpitations. On March 30, Fatma underwent the ablation procedure with very successful results. I was over the moon with happiness… I did not know how to thank Demircan enough…

We were leaving one problem behind only to face another. In early May 2016, we received news that Fatma's elder sister Ayşe—three years her senior and our childhood friend—had undergone surgery at a private hospital in Izmir following a severe herniated disc crisis, so we flew to Izmir to visit her in the hospital. Unfortunately, Ayşe contracted what is called a "hospital infection"—a great misfortune for her and a shameful situation for the private hospital where she was staying—and passed away on May 16. This was another blow to Fatma's morale.

"Why we could not establish democracy"

Starting from April 6, 2016, *Zaman* employees began publishing two daily newspapers, one named *Yarına Bakış* (Looking to Tomorrow) and the other *Yeni Hayat* (New Life). Upon invitation, I also began writing full-page articles once a week for *Yarına Bakış* starting April 21. Besides myself, *Zaman* writers such as Ali Bulaç, Hilmi Yavuz, Mümtazer Türköne, and Mustafa Ünal were contributing, along with renowned film critic Atilla Dorsay and constitutional law professor Levent Köker, who wrote for *Yarına Bakış* in solidarity with us.

In my first article titled "Why could we not establish democracy?"—a detailed analysis of the state the country had reached—I wrote:

"The Republic of Turkey transitioned to a multi-party system in 1950. It joined the Council of Europe in 1949 and NATO in 1952. It ratified the European Convention on Human Rights in 1954; in 1987 it recognized its citizens' right to individual petition to the European Court of Human Rights; in 1990 it accepted the compulsory jurisdiction of the ECtHR. It signed an association agreement with the EEC in 1963; became an EU

candidate in 1999; and began accession negotiations in 2005… Through this process that began at the end of World War II, under civilian governments ranging from the DP (Democrat Party) to the AKP (Justice and Development Party), Turkey became part of almost all international organizations formed by liberal democracies. Despite interruptions by military coups, we went through approximately 70 years of democratic experience during which restrictions on fundamental rights and freedoms gradually diminished.

“However, since the 2011 elections, Turkey has rapidly moved away from being a regime that could be called a democracy. It has become impossible to speak of rule of law, separation of powers, or judicial independence. All fundamental rights and freedoms—from freedom of expression, press, association, and belief to property and enterprise rights—are being trampled underfoot. Even elections have ceased to be fair. The ruling AKP is steering the country toward a one-man, one-party government with President Tayyip Erdoğan as its head. The country faces not only the danger of falling entirely under autocratic rule but also increasing instability and fragmentation.

“As citizens concerned about how we can stop this trajectory and get liberal and pluralist democracy back on track, we must reflect on these questions: Why could we not establish democracy and make it irreversible? How is it that despite all the democratization steps actually taken, we have arrived at where we are today? There are two main answers to these questions. One emphasizes ‘culture.’ According to nationalists (Ulusalcılar), socialists, and others who share an authoritarian understanding of secularism, the answer is roughly this: Religions in general, and Islam in particular, are incompatible with modernization, secularism (separation of religion and state), and democracy. This is because Islamic values do not instill respect for individual rights and diversity, which are necessary for democracy to take root. For this reason, democratic regimes that secure both elected government and fundamental rights and freedoms could not be established in Muslim-majority countries. In Turkey too, democracy essentially cannot take root for this reason.

“According to secular nationalists or Kemalists, without an authoritarian secularism of the kind envisioned by the Republic’s founding philosophy—where the state holds religion (Islam) under its monopoly and control and imposes restrictions on religious freedoms—neither secularism nor democracy can be institutionalized in Turkey. Only a democracy under the tutelage of military and civilian bureaucracy committed to Kemalism’s fundamental principles can survive. The ‘Islamist’ AKP boarded the democracy train in its first two terms to consolidate its power and push back the military tutelage it saw as an obstacle, but it got off the train when it judged that it had achieved its goal.

“The following main objections can be raised against the thesis summarized above—that democracy could not take root because of the people’s Islamic culture: No religion is compatible with secularism or democracy in theory, but interpretations compatible with both secularism and democracy in practice have been developed for all of them (including Islam). Except for fundamentalist Sunni Saudi Arabia and fundamentalist Shia Iran, the rest of the Muslim-majority states, including Turkey, were governed not by

Islamic but by secular nationalist authoritarian regimes. Islamists, who claimed to bring an order that would be an alternative to capitalism and communism, tried but could not come to power in any of them. The reason these countries could not establish democratic regimes should be sought not in religion but in the perception of democracy as a colonial imposition and in subsoil resources feeding autocratic regimes.

“The findings of the World Values Survey indicate that prevalent values in Muslim-majority countries (except for gender equality) are not different from those in Western countries. Turkey, which took steps toward the rule of law and constitutional government in the 19th century, certainly has a unique place among Muslim-majority countries. In Turkey, Sufi (flexible, popular) interpretations of Islam rather than Salafi (fundamentalist) interpretations maintain their prevalence. Whether the values related to disrespect for diversity observed in some studies originate from Islam or from secular nationalist ideology is also quite debatable. If we look at our multi-party history, we see that parties defending citizens’ fundamental rights and freedoms received great support, and when they turned their backs on these, they gradually disappeared.

“The main examples are Menderes’s DP, Demirel’s AP (Justice Party), Ecevit’s CHP (Republican People’s Party) and DSP (Democratic Left Party), and Özal’s ANAP (Motherland Party). All major ruling parties came to power with promises of rights and freedoms. The AKP also came to power not because it was Islamist or promised one-man rule, but because it promised to establish a liberal and pluralist democracy, to end the military tutelage system that suppressed fundamental rights and freedoms, and to achieve EU membership. It owes the preservation of its power today not to being Islamist but to the services it rendered in both the economy and democracy during its first two terms in power. It should not be forgotten that support for EU membership in Muslim-majority Turkey climbed to 70 percent during the 2004-2005 period.

“The other, much more convincing answer to the question of why we could not establish a democratic regime emphasizes ‘institutional structure.’ According to this perspective, mostly shared by liberals, the problems stem from the failure of institutions that secure the rule of law, human rights, respect for minorities, and market economy to achieve stability. The reason for this should be sought essentially in the insistence on the founding principles of the Republic, which were designed for an authoritarian regime. The authoritarian mentality that we see becoming dominant again today draws its source from the single-party era. The roots of the mindset that equates opposition with treason and fuels intolerance of civil society are there. The origin of the understanding that restricts freedom of belief (both believing and not believing) and places religion under the monopoly and control of the state (the Diyanet, the Directorate of Religious Affairs) is there. The origin of disrespect for different religious and ethnic identities, and of the policies still insisted upon today—Turkifying Kurds, Sunnifying Alevis, keeping Sufis (Sufi orders and communities) under pressure—is also there.

“These were also the fundamental principles on which the military tutelage order that persisted throughout the second half of the 20th century was based. The AKP government set out with the promise of establishing the (universal) Copenhagen criteria, but turned its back on these criteria essentially as a result of prolonged absolute power

corrupting absolutely. It is ultimately paying the price for this by surrendering to the 'national and domestic' Ankara criteria of the military-bureaucratic tutelage order. The discourse that the AKP is 'Islamist' is extremely misleading. The essential character of the AKP government is that it is nothing but a political and economic alliance of interests that, beneath a demagogic Islamic discourse on the surface, clings tightly to Kemalist policies at its core.

"Until now, no government that turned its back on citizens' fundamental rights and freedoms could stay standing. This is also true for the AKP government. The first signs of this were seen in the June 7, 2015 elections. However, the AKP managed to monopolize power again by embracing Kemalist nationalism and by leaving the people facing instability and security concerns. But power protected in this way has a limited lifespan. On the other hand, we must understand that in order to establish democracy with its universal standards, not only the military-bureaucratic tutelage based on a minority but also the majority dictatorship that comes to power through elections must be defeated at the ballot box, by the people's vote. This should be the next goal of struggle for those who believe in freedom." (April 21, 2016)

In my second article published in *Yarına Bakış*, I referenced the recently published articles by Prof. Dr. Kemal Gözler, one of our leading constitutional law scholars whom I greatly admire, which listed the constitutional violations by the AKP government that had turned Turkey into a country where rule of law and democracy could not be spoken of. ("How was the Constitution shelved?", April 28, 2016) The article by Gözler, a faculty member at Uludağ University, was so apt that I felt the need to get his phone number from his colleague and friend Prof. Ergun Özbudun to thank him. I called to congratulate him and said that it would be an honor for me to meet him. Gözler's reply—that he had been following my writings for years and that it would actually be his honor to meet me—greatly pleased me. Gözler's words were one of the most valuable rewards I received throughout my column-writing career.

He finished off the party, the state is next

I maintained optimism in my articles published in *Yarına Bakış*. In the article titled "He finished off the party, the state is next," I wrote: "Prime Minister Davutoğlu being forced to resign last week can be seen as the completion of Erdoğan's project to turn the AKP into an 'Erdoğan party' under his absolute dominion… Yes, the task of turning the AKP into an 'Erdoğan party' has been completed, but there is still a way to go in turning Turkey into an 'Erdoğan state.'" (May 12, 2016)

I also ended the article in which I asked "Why is the AKP still in power?" as follows: "The point where the AKP government is mistaken is this: 'You can fool some of the people all of the time, and all of the people some of the time; but you cannot fool all of the people all of the time…' It is not possible to keep the people asleep for long through brainwashing, or to hide the truth from the people for long. Governance by decrees coming from one person's lips is doomed to failure always and everywhere. In Turkey, the fraud of bad governance has always, sooner or later, been exposed. The

unsustainability of one-man rule will also be seen by the great majority sooner or later." (May 19, 2016)

In the next article titled "How will the one-man state be prevented?", I expressed the tough struggle that must be waged for Turkey to achieve liberal democracy: "Yes, the drift toward a one-man state is a great danger for what remains of democracy and for Turkey as we know it. We can only prevent this danger by mobilizing democratic means, by waging a struggle for democracy, and we must prevent it. Only when we defeat one-man rule—which is essentially a majority dictatorship—through the struggle for democracy, just as with the military tutelage regime—which is essentially a minority dictatorship—will it be possible to establish liberal and pluralist democracy." (May 26, 2016)

In my next article titled "Erdoğan's party and nation," I expressed my conclusion about the nature of the AKP: "No, do not deceive yourselves: The Erdoğan (or the Chief's) party, resembling neither the RP (Welfare Party) nor the AKP, having no goal other than preserving and perpetuating power, is not ideological but an opportunistic political and economic partnership of interests. It uses Islamist and Ottomanist discourse as seasoning, but it is not 'Islamist, Ottomanist.' If one insists on attributing an ideological quality to it, the Erdoğan party can be characterized as a 'Religious (Sunni) Nationalist' party. It embraces conservative Sunni Kurds but excludes other Kurds; it leaves Alevis out altogether. What the Erdoğan party calls 'the nation' consists only of those who vote for it." (July 7, 2016)

The one-man's guarantee, the opposition's wretchedness

In my final article titled "The one-man's guarantee, the opposition's wretchedness," published one day before the July 15 coup attempt, I wrote:

"Except for June 7, 2015, the Erdoğan party, the AKP, won all elections since November 2002. On November 1, 2015, it regained the single-party government it had lost on June 7, through tactics of lies and intimidation ('if I go, military tutelage will be resurrected; terror will increase, stability will be lost, there will be chaos'). If it dares, it will make the 'Turkish-style' presidential system (that is, one-man rule or autocracy) constitutional by renewing elections and/or through a referendum; if it does not dare, it will manage with the 'Suspended constitution + De facto Presidency' system. Indeed, one of the leading spokespeople of the one-man government declared: 'No elections until 2019…' It is being said that the possibility of changing government through elections has been reduced to zero. Not without justification, either…

"The one-man regime consolidated its alliance with the military tutelage advocates. (Doğu Perinçek declared the obvious: 'Erdoğan has been captured by patriotic forces… He has surrendered to Kemalism…') Nowadays, in accordance with its sole principle of 'preserving and perpetuating power,' it is putting new practices into effect. Some of these are: In the purging, under the 'parallel' nonsense, of public servants 'incompatible with the government,' the turn has now come to the TSK (Turkish Armed Forces). The judiciary is about to be made completely compatible with the government. According to the CHP leader, 'judges are being summoned to the Palace at 03:00 in the morning…'

There will be no way to distinguish anymore whether the alleged crimes are real or fabricated. The print and visual media, with very few exceptions, were under the government's control; now it is the turn of internet newspapers; they are being blacked out not by court decision but by prime ministry decree. (…)

"The factor that serves to keep the one-man regime standing, perhaps as effective as those listed above, is the wretchedness of the opposition. There are developments on that front as well. This wretchedness relates above all to the opposition parties' inability to come together, to unite their forces, even to defend democracy (which is also the guarantee of their own survival). The second dimension of the wretchedness is that each of them is afflicted with internal divisions that are difficult to heal.

"Let us start with the MHP (Nationalist Movement Party): The Devlet Bahçeli leadership, knowingly or unknowingly, had opened the way to power for the AKP in 2002. Since last year, it has virtually been functioning as the AKP's 'Trojan horse.' On June 7, it knowingly and willingly sabotaged the opportunity to get rid of one-man rule; on November 1, the party's number of deputies was halved. To maintain its dominance, it tried open cooperation with the AKP, coalition flirtation. Now that the party majority has revolted against the slide below the threshold, it is trying to intimidate its opponents with the now thoroughly vulgarized 'parallel' nonsense; it is preventing the party congress from meeting with the support of the 'compliant judiciary'; now the turn has come to expelling the dissidents.

"The revolt that broke out within the MHP, which until recently appeared to be Turkey's most one-man party, is undoubtedly a sign that politics in Turkey maintains its vitality despite everything. As long as it cannot escape from the leader's autocracy, the MHP will certainly continue to be one of the fundamental guarantees of Erdoğan's power. Otherwise, could the MHP escape from being condemned to its marginal role limited to ethnic Turkish nationalism, assume a conservative party identity that resolutely defends democracy and the rule of law, and take on a more effective role in politics? This is certainly one of the most noteworthy questions regarding the future of Turkish politics. *(Looking from today, it can be said that these lines foresaw the MHP - İyi Party split.)*

"Perhaps since the 1960s when the 'Left of Center' movement emerged, the CHP continues to be captive to the tension between the 'Ulusalcılar' (secularist nationalists) who favor military-bureaucratic tutelage and authoritarian secularism and oppose the West on one side, and those who envision rebuilding the CHP as a social democratic party by Western standards on the other. This tension is also reflected in civil society organizations and media close to the party. (At *Cumhuriyet*, the disagreement that emerged in the 1980s between those who want to make it a liberal left-leaning newspaper of record that everyone can safely read and those who advocate clinging tightly to the role of spokesperson for 'Ulusalcılık' has flared up again.) This tension prevents the CHP from playing an effective role in national politics. There are indications that the MHP might escape from its 'Trojan horse' role, but there is yet no sign that the CHP can escape from the tension that holds it captive. As long as this situation continues, the CHP will certainly continue to be another insurance policy for Erdoğan's power.

“The HDP (Peoples’ Democratic Party), which is the most feared opponent of the one-man government, has also fallen victim to the ‘confusion’ within the Kurdish political movement. HDP deputy Altan Tan best diagnosed the confusion revived by the escalating clashes between security forces and the PKK (Kurdistan Workers’ Party) since last July: ‘Are we going to establish a new democratic Republic of Turkey, or are we going to be divided by fighting, clashing, separating? Are we going to envision a Turkey and Middle East within the EU and Western bloc, or a Middle East on the Russia-Iran axis? Democratic autonomy: Are we going to achieve this with weapons, by fighting, by digging trenches, or by talking with Ankara, by making a new constitution?’ (*Hürriyet*, September 2, 2015) It is crystal clear that the Kurdish political movement settling on the first choices would lead Turkey toward democratization, while the second choices would lead to division.

“It is seen that some civil society organizations are making efforts to form a ‘Democracy Front’ against the autocratic regime and fragmentation that Erdoğan’s party is leading Turkey toward. For these initiatives to yield any results, as (former ECtHR judge and former CHP deputy) Rıza Türmen said, a union of forces must be realized in which ‘everyone without distinction who objects to the AKP’ participates and ‘differences are preserved.’ (A good example of this was given by those who ran the ‘Did you know: Journalism is not a crime…’ campaign.) Otherwise, it would take no prophet to say that nothing will come of these initiatives.”

The article concluded as follows: ***“The Ulusalcılar may be making calls for a return to military tutelage. However, military tutelage was tried in this country for many years; ultimately it paved the way for the disaster we face today. Our only way out is the struggle for liberal and pluralist democracy against autocracy. One hope still remains: a revival movement that could be initiated within the AKP for a return to the party’s ‘factory settings’ (the party program).”*** (July 14, 2016)

This article, which confirmed my stance against military rule, military intervention in politics, and military tutelage—positions I had maintained throughout almost my entire intellectual life—would, very ironically, be my last article before being locked up in Silivri on charges of supporting the July 15 coup attempt. One of the grounds on which the Constitutional Court’s ruling that characterized my detention as a rights violation was based would be the final paragraph of this article (which I have underlined).

CHAPTER XVII / JULY 15 AND SİLİVRİ

I spent most of July with Fatma in Ayvalık. On the night of July 15, 2016, feeling tired, I wanted to go to bed early, around 10 PM. I had just lain down when Fatma got me up, saying, “Something is happening in Ankara…” The television was broadcasting news and footage of what appeared to be a thoroughly unconvincing military coup attempt. Soldiers had blocked the crossing from Asia to Europe on the Bosphorus Bridge, but traffic continued in the other direction. It was a very strange situation… I called Hasan Cemal, Eser Karakaş, and Seyfettin Gürsel; they knew no more than I did. My son Acar kept calling from İstanbul, asking what was happening. A friend calling from Ankara had

arrived at Esenboğa Airport to fly to Edremit, but the plane was not taking off for unknown reasons. Others were calling too, asking: “What’s going on?…” I had no idea. After a while, when President Erdoğan appeared on television calling the people to take to the streets “against the coup attempt by FETÖ traitors,” I began to sense what was unfolding. The funeral prayers recited from the mosque right next to us until the early hours of morning—for those killed in the clashes in İstanbul and Ankara—created a demoralizing atmosphere unlike anything we had ever experienced. I was sleepy; I went to bed and slept.

In the early hours of July 16, we watched the news that “FETÖ’s coup attempt had been suppressed and Prime Minister Erdoğan was safe.” This bore no resemblance to any coup attempt we had known. And somehow it did not seem convincing. The news and commentary in the foreign press pointed in the same direction. When I went out in the morning to buy newspapers, I ran into a couple who had been planning to pay us a condolence visit that day on account of my sister-in-law’s death. I gathered they had cancelled the visit. As someone put it, on the night of July 15, “not only Turkey but the world had changed…” Looking at the newspapers, questions began swirling in my mind: Had Gülenist soldiers attempted a coup together with Kemalist and other opposition soldiers? Or was this a conspiracy against the Movement? Pro-government websites were writing that “members of FETÖ’s media wing” would be arrested, and my name was among them. It was plain as day that something was going to happen to me.

The evening before, we had arranged to meet Ayhan Aktar and Heath Lowry in Cunda. Sensing what was coming for me, they too were in low spirits; we cut the dinner and drinks short. I was receiving the news rather naively: “Yes, they might detain me, but it won’t last long,” I kept telling myself—and Fatma, who was anxious but maintained her usual composure with a “whatever will be, will be” attitude… If they were going to take me, it would be better for me to be in İstanbul. Besides, Fatma had doctor’s appointments.

When we arrived at Edremit airport on July 18 to fly to İstanbul, we were both wondering whether I would be able to board the plane. When I passed through the identity check without a hitch, we understood that the probable arrest warrant had not yet been put into effect. At least we would travel to İstanbul in peace. On the plane, we shared our troubles. How many times throughout our life together had I found myself in situations like this, where I did not feel safe.

Upon arriving in İstanbul, thinking I might be detained for a few months, I began making urgent visits to my doctors. One of them tried to console me, saying I would be locked up for a while but that this government could not last long. Another was of the opinion that Turkey had “entered a dark period that would last at least ten years.” (It has already been six years…) Fatma was going to see her doctor, my close friend Hasan Yazıcı. We went together. Hasan had just returned from Ankara; he was quite anxious. When he expressed the wish, “I hope you won’t be inside for too long…” we said goodbye with shared laughter. As we were leaving, Nazlı Ilıcak called from Bodrum, where she was staying, to ask what had happened to the newspapers we wrote columns for. Both had ceased publication. Ilıcak was even more naive in her outlook than I was. She said she

had cancelled her planned trip to the Greek island across from Bodrum so that people would not say she had “fled.” “Don’t worry, my dear Şahin, Turkey changes quickly…” she said. The next day we watched the news of her detention in Bodrum. I called a lawyer friend to ask whether he could take on my representation; upon his positive reply, I had a power of attorney drawn up at the notary and mailed it to his address. When Sweden’s Consul General in İstanbul called to say it would be useful for us to meet, I went to see him. “The situation looks concerning. If you want to go to Sweden, we will support you there. If you prefer, you can also take refuge here, at the consulate…” he said. In reply, I said, “I am not thinking of going to Sweden or taking refuge at the consulate. In either case, they would take my family hostage… Even if I am arrested, I do not think I will be held for long…”

Once we had finished our business, we decided to return to Ayvalık via Edremit on the 2:20 PM flight on July 26, 2016. On the night of July 25, Fatma and I stuffed all the Fethullah Gülen books in my library into bags and threw them into the garbage containers a few streets away. Then, for a reason I cannot recall, we had to postpone the flight by one day. As it turned out, this was fortunate timing. On the morning of July 27, around 6 AM, three plainclothes police officers—one of them a captain—from Counter-Terrorism came and informed me that I was to be detained by court order. They did not search the house thoroughly. They confiscated my laptop, my desktop computer’s hard drive, my tablet, and my mobile phone. They had our building superintendent and his wife sign a report about what had taken place. One of the officers asked, with a touch of irony—or perhaps not really expecting it—whether I had any “one-dollar bills” on me. As I was leaving the house, Fatma showed her usual thoughtfulness; she pressed into my hands a bag containing the CPAP breathing device I had been using for twenty years on account of my sleep apnea, a blood pressure monitor, and the medications I took regularly. We said goodbye in the belief that our separation would not be long. We were wrong… During my detention, which would last far longer than we expected, I would come to appreciate the true worth of that bag.

I was put into a police car after passing through the courtyard of my apartment building, where reporters and plainclothes officers were taking photographs and shooting video. I remember calling out to the cameras recording my removal from home, “I have committed no crime!” (That footage would appear on screens countless times on various occasions.) In the police car taking us to the Gayrettepe Police Public Order Division, the captain returned my wallet along with the Metropolitan Municipality’s Free Transportation Card inside it, saying I would need it on the way home—which I took as a sign that he was overly optimistic about what lay ahead for me. (I should note here that throughout my life, the police officers I dealt with never thought the charges attributed to me suited me…) At the Public Order Division, before I was stuffed into barred compartments, they took away the belongings I had brought with me. By begging and pleading, saying I would die if I was not allowed to use it, I managed to keep my CPAP device: however, even though they were kind enough to provide an extension cord so I could plug it in, it would prove impossible for me to actually use the device. (That day, Fatma and my daughter Elvan had somehow learned that I had been taken to the Public Order Division and came there hoping to see me. Naturally, this would not be possible.)

When I arrived there, I recognized no one among the few people I saw. But as the hours passed, those we had expected to join us turned up one by one. Reporters from *Zaman* and the Cihan News Agency, along with many others, were brought in. Over a hundred of us were crammed into three small rooms; we sat on the floor, we lay on the floor and slept. We staved off our hunger with food we would never have touched under other circumstances. Ali Bulaç, Mümtaz'er Türköne, and Ahmet Turan Alkan—who had been brought from Bursa—ended up in the same room with me. We learned that Nazlı Ilıcak, Nuriye (Akman) Ural, and Lale Kemal were in the women's detention facility in the adjacent building. Those detained at the Public Order Division were not only Zaman group employees. The number of people brought in kept growing, and the barred rooms became packed to capacity. Morale was low, but we tried not to show it, getting by through conversation.

The next day, July 28, Hilmi Yavuz, İhsan Dağı—brought from Ankara—Lale Kemal, and Mustafa Ünal (the Zaman bureau chief) also joined us. We were taken to Şişli Etfal Hospital for medical examinations. When we were brought out of Gayrettepe Public Order Division, we were led down the stairs handcuffed behind our backs, to be displayed for the press photographers waiting outside. (This was how I first made the acquaintance of the handcuffs that would be clamped onto my wrists every time I was taken out of Section 9 of Silivri prison, where I would spend approximately twenty months.) When my blood pressure was found to have risen to 220 at Şişli Etfal, I was given a sedative injection in the hip. When Ali Bulaç's blood sugar spiked—he had had quadruple bypass surgery—he was made to rest for a while. That evening, eighty-year-old Hilmi Yavuz fell ill and was taken to the hospital; the next morning we learned he had been released thanks to the intervention of Culture and Tourism Minister Nabi Avcı. (I could not help wondering why Avcı—with whom I had quite an old and friendly relationship, and who had once remarked to me about the AKP government, "We have boarded an omen, heading for doomsday"—had not also secured my release.) As I learned after my own release, when a mutual friend of ours called Interior Minister Süleyman Soylu to ask why I had been detained, the answer he received was: "In these extraordinary circumstances, naturally the green wood burns along with the dry…" On July 29, we *Zaman* writers were put into a minibus without handcuffs and taken to Haseki Research Hospital on Vatan Avenue. There we underwent a psychological examination by a very kind female doctor. (That day, Fatma and Elvan had somehow learned where we had been taken and went there to hand over a bag full of clothes to the police to give to me. But that bag would never reach me.)

On the morning of July 30, we *Zaman* writers were taken to the Counter-Terrorism Division on Vatan Avenue—all except Mümtaz'er Türköne, for reasons we could not understand. As we were leaving Gayrettepe Public Order Division, a young plainclothes officer approached me and said I would be released. (Mümtaz'er, too, had seen me off saying, "You'll celebrate your release tonight, brother…") But, in truth, I was not hopeful at all. I thought I would be arrested and spend a few months in prison. After being hosted for a time in a private room at Vatan with offerings of tea, we were taken one by one for police interrogation. On our way, we saw that the detention ward cells were packed full of people staring at us anxiously. During my interrogation, a young female lawyer

appointed by the İstanbul Bar Association was present, but she did not utter a word. A quite courteous plainclothes police official took my statement.

During the interrogation, I was taken aback when words I had uttered months earlier on the commentary program “Akıl Defteri” (Notebook of Reason)—which we did with Mehmet Altan and Eser Karakaş on Mehtap TV—were presented as though they had been spoken in July 2016. I had said them in utter astonishment upon first hearing the “FETÖ” allegation, to the effect of: “Fethullah Gülen is the world’s most peaceful Islamic scholar—how can he be a terrorist?…” Questions were put to me such as, “Did you know Fethullah Gülen? From whom were you receiving orders?…” The interrogating police officer said, “You may not believe it, but the Gülenists are a secret organization…” When he told another plainclothes officer, “We are not planning to hold these elderly ones for long—we will transfer them to Çağlayan,” we understood that we would be brought before a judge that very evening.

And indeed, in the evening hours we were taken to Çağlayan. First we were placed in the detention facility seven floors below the “Palace of Justice.” While waiting there, we tried to analyze what had happened to Turkey and to us. According to İhsan Dağı, from now on Turkey would follow China’s model, establishing a regime that provided bread but granted no freedom, and would gradually distance itself from the West. I objected: Turkey had no oil, unlike Russia or Iran. Its economy depended to a great extent on investment from the West and exports to the West. How could it leave NATO or the Council of Europe?… Ali Bulaç agreed with me: “Two hundred years of Westernization cannot be thrown in the trash,” he said. (Six years later, the answer to this question remains unclear.)

After a while, we were brought up to the 4th Criminal Court of Peace on one of the upper floors. Nazlı Ilıcak, Nuriye Akman, and Lale Kemal were also there. The lawyer Veysel Ok, whom the Platform for Independent Journalism (P24) had assigned for my defense, was waiting there. He told me that my wife Fatma and my children Elvan and Acar were waiting at the entrance to the building but had not been allowed inside. We gave our statements one by one to the judge of the 4th Criminal Court of Peace. In summary, I stated who I was; that until now I had only been able to see the positive face of the Movement; that I had contributed to the newspaper *Zaman* as an outside columnist; that throughout my career as a writer I had opposed military coups and the military’s role in politics; that I condemned everyone who had been involved in the July 15 coup attempt; and that a great evil had been inflicted upon the country.

While we waited for the decision, the lawyer Veysel Ok told me I might be released under judicial supervision, but I did not think it likely. The judge’s demeanor made us feel we would be arrested. One of the lawyers there voiced his pessimism: “Mr. Şahin, why did you come back from Sweden?…” And indeed, only İhsan Dağı—who had stopped writing for *Zaman* months earlier, alarmed by the way things were going—was released at the prosecutor’s request, while the rest of us were placed under arrest. Nazlı Ilıcak, Lale Kemal, and Nuriye Akman were taken to the women’s prison in Bakırköy; we reached Silivri prison in the early hours of July 31. We were processed and registered. I was deeply relieved that I was allowed to take the breathing device (CPAP), the blood

pressure monitor, and the medication box from my bag into the cell. Ali Bulaç, Ahmet Turan Alkan, Mustafa Ünal, and I spent the first two nights together in a temporary cell. An elderly corrections officer treated us very well; he even brought a small table into the cell for me to set my CPAP on. On one hand, I was relieved to have escaped the detention facility where we had been held in dreadful conditions and to have been brought to Silivri; on the other, my heart grew heavy knowing I would be separated from Fatma, my children, and my grandchildren for a time.

On the morning of August 1, we were distributed among the cells of Section 9, which we had heard would hold three persons each. Ali Bulaç and I were placed in Block C5, Room 34; Ahmet T. Alkan and Mustafa Ünal were sent to a different cell. Since there was so much to talk about with him, I was very glad to be together with Bulaç. From here on, you can find—in the section that follows—the diary I kept almost every day for approximately twenty months, from August 3, 2016—the first day we were able to buy notebooks and pens from the canteen—until March 16, 2018.

CHAPTER XVIII / THE LAST SIX MONTHS WITH FATMA

On March 17, 2018, around 2:30 in the morning, I was released from Silivri prison, where I had been detained for 20 months (600 days), to house arrest. A prison vehicle dropped me off at an intersection a few kilometers from the prison, where my wife Fatma, my daughter Elvan, my granddaughter Defne, as well as some news agency reporters were waiting. I embraced my loved ones… I had missed them so much…

Karin Karakasli, in her article published a few days later, inspired by the photograph of my reunion with my wife, wrote the following:

“Detained journalist Sahin Alpay, for whom the Constitutional Court ruled a rights violation for the second time, was released by Istanbul 13th High Criminal Court with a house arrest decision after 20 months of detention. The European Court of Human Rights (ECtHR) also ruled that Sahin Alpay and journalist and writer Mehmet Altan’s ‘rights to liberty, security, and freedom of expression were violated.’

After being released, Alpay, reunited with his family at the prison exit, expressed the common sentiment of many detainees: ‘I am extremely happy to be reunited with my family, but I cannot say I have regained my freedom. The 20 months were very difficult. Now that I am out, there are still thousands of people left behind who have no connection to terrorism or the coup. I believe that as long as they are not free, Turkey cannot be free either.’

Freedom is something else entirely. It exists in the necessity and naturalness of bread and water. Something that does not disappear with imprisonment, nor is regained by release. Connected to justice by an umbilical cord. For some of us.

Then a photograph came into my hands. A photograph of Mr. Sahin and his wife Mrs. Fatma… They are looking at each other. Deep into each other’s eyes. An

indescribable smile on Mrs. Fatma's face. The projection of a hardship that had to be overcome in a companionship tested by years. And something else. That nobility on Mrs. Fatma's face. That thing which has now gone out of circulation, considered almost a hindrance rather than a moral value. A story of an era. Knowledge of old times, different places. A refinement. Something no school could teach…" ("What photographs tell us to see…", Gazete Duvar*, March 22, 2018)*

Infinite thanks to Karin Karakasli for this article describing the great joy of reuniting with my loved ones and Fatma's nobility.

PHOTO

A day or two after my release, my son Acar, my daughter-in-law Gokce, and my granddaughter Leyla, who was then only 3.5 years old, came from London where they had settled, adding joy to my happiness. As a family, we were able to come together for the first time in 20 months, even if only for a few days. I will never forget Leyla running and throwing her arms around my neck. The only other day in my life when I was this filled with joy was in January 1974, when Fatma came to Stockholm, where I had been living as an exile/refugee since November 1972, together with my daughter Elvan, whom I hadn't seen for 3 years and who was 6 years old at the time.

House arrest meant, as the police officers at the Etiler station strictly warned, that I could not step outside the door of our apartment without permission from the court. From the first day of my house arrest, relatives and friends came to visit me in droves. We hosted them in three shifts: before noon, afternoon, and evening… As a result of consuming not only Fatma's cooking that I had missed so much, but also the foods brought by visitors that I had longed for, I went from 84 kilos when I left Silivri to 93 kilos by the end of my house arrest.

Many friends, including those I hadn't seen for years, even those I hadn't been in touch with for a long time for various (now seemingly ridiculous) reasons, set aside past meaningless disputes and came to see me. The "get well" phone calls from CHP (Republican People's Party) Chairman Mr. Kemal Kilicdaroglu and President Mr. Abdullah Gul greatly pleased me. Swedish Ambassador Lars Wahlund and Sweden's Istanbul Consul General Therese Hyden, who attended all the hearings in my trial and to whom I owe gratitude, also visited our home.

When I left home with court permission for doctor visits for health checkups, I received "get well" wishes on the streets and in hospitals from many citizens I didn't know. The solidarity I witnessed from society gave me the feeling that the great injustice I suffered —being accused of terrorism and coup involvement and imprisoned for nearly two years —was condemned in the public conscience; it consoled me to some extent.

During the house arrest days, the police officers, who behaved quite respectfully, came every evening to get my signature. Fatma always offered them a small treat (chocolate, Turkish delight, small pastries). Once when they came after midnight, after I had gone to bed, she scolded them: "If you come this late again, I won't open the door!" and made

them laugh too. We recalled the jokes of her late mother Leman Kaptan, who was originally from Surmene.

Fatma forbade me from talking about the days left behind or the possibility of being detained and imprisoned again. “From now on we will look forward and spend our remaining years thinking only of each other…” she said. I in turn promised her that from now on I would never disobey her, that I would never leave her side. We were finally together… The photograph that Elvan took, of Fatma and me holding hands, I think reflects our feelings in those days well.

PHOTO

Fatma told me about the fraud attempts she had experienced in my absence. Starting from November 2017, two people who introduced themselves as a prosecutor and a police captain began calling her by phone. They told her they could get me out of prison, but strictly warned her not to tell anyone about it, not even her children. Somehow, Fatma too (like a drowning person clutching at a snake) believed them, until they asked her to mortgage her olive groves in Ayvalik in exchange for these “services,” at which point she woke up and cut off contact with them… The fraud attempts didn’t end there. A person who presented himself on the phone as a Court of Cassation examining judge whom I knew, frequently called Fatma with promises of getting me out of prison. As Fatma told me these things, she was angry at herself, remembering how she had laughed at me years ago when she learned about the fraud attempt where someone playing the role of police and prosecutor had tried to swindle thousands of liras from me.

Undoubtedly, what was truly thought-provoking and instructive here was how widespread in Turkey’s society were these conscienceless people who felt no shame in trying to extort money by exploiting the vulnerabilities of suffering families.

The third hearing of the case in which I was being tried was held on April 5-6, 2018, in a courtroom in Silivri. In addition to Fatma and Elvan, my son Acar, who took three days off and came from London, also attended this hearing. This was my last trip to Silivri; because subsequent hearings (fortunately) were moved to the “Justice Palace” in Caglayan. At the fourth hearing held on May 10-11, 2018, we welcomed the lifting of house arrest with great joy! Instead, a requirement to sign in at the nearest police station on Sundays was imposed, but being able to go out on the street without court permission now felt like a step toward freedom.

My first task was to call Utku Cakirozer, a CHP parliamentarian and journalist colleague whom I greatly admired and loved, who had visited me in Silivri at least 5-6 times, to ask him when I could make a thank-you visit to him and Mr. Kilicdaroglu. Mr. Kemal had greatly boosted our morale by voicing the injustices done to us writers in group speeches and at almost every opportunity from the first days of our detention; he had made us feel that we were not alone. I have deep respect for him both for standing up for the rule of law and for this reason.

Cakirozer and I agreed to meet at the Turkish Grand National Assembly on Tuesday, May 15. We would have lunch at the parliament restaurant at 12:00, then go up to see

Mr. Kemal before the group speech. At the restaurant, we ran into Adnan Keskin (whom I had met in 1993 when I was working as an advisor to the CHP chairman, and who was the party's general secretary at the time). Mr. Adnan, bless him, immediately invited us to his table. Later, CHP parliamentarians Sezgin Tanrikulu and Musa Cam, who had long been my friends, also came and joined us. During the meal, some other CHP parliamentarians came to our table and said "get well." Then we went up to see Mr. Kemal.

Kilicdaroglu greeted me by saying, "Welcome, you honor us…" (In his office, I met and embraced Deputy Group Chairman Ozgur Ozel.) During my visit, we took a photograph with Mr. Kemal and had a brief conversation. I conveyed my gratitude to him; I told him that our hope for the restoration of democracy and the rule of law lay with him. As Mr. Kemal was leaving us to attend the group meeting, Cakirozer told me, "It would be better if you don't come; there are people there who don't like you…" I interpreted this as a reflection of the state the CHP was in. I said goodbye to Cakirozer as well and returned to Istanbul that evening.

Between May 28-31, we had a wonderful vacation, simply marvelous, organized by Elvan. Fatma, Elvan, my granddaughter Defne, my elder sister Olcay, and I flew to Antalya; from there we went to Olympos Lodge in Kemer/Cirali. We stayed there for three days and three nights. Fatma was quite energetic and cheerful throughout the trip. Her state made me very happy. On our return to Istanbul, on June 1, we visited Prof. Dr. Hasan Yazici (my classmate from Robert College and one of my closest friends) at his clinic. Hasan found her well; he saw nothing unusual in her health.

The fifth hearing of the case in which I was being tried was held on June 7-8, 2018. The prosecutor read his opinion on the merits. He repeated the accusation that I had committed the crime of violating the constitution, but showing some mercy (!) he now requested that I be sentenced to life imprisonment once instead of three times, and additionally up to 15 years for allegedly being a member of an armed terrorist organization. In my statement, I simply said, "Mr. Presiding Judge, Honorable Members, I was detained for 20 months. I was kept under house arrest for about two months. I have been signing in at the police station for a month. There is no question of me fleeing or tampering with evidence. I request that you lift the judicial control measures against me." My lawyer Aynur Yazgan Tuncel also said: "Two high courts have determined that there is no strong indication, which is the fundamental condition for detention as specified in Article 19 of the Constitution, regarding Sahin Alpay. Therefore, no form of judicial control can be applied where there is no condition for detention. I request the lifting of judicial control for our client for the reasons we have previously detailed in our petition." Our request was denied.

On June 23, together with Fatma, Elvan, and Acar and Gokce who had come from London a week earlier, I attended the wedding ceremony of my nephew Cihan Alpay (son of my late elder brother Acar Alpay and brother of Umit Boyner) and Ece Vahapoglu. We voted in the general elections held on June 24: for the presidency, we voted for Muharrem Ince (reluctantly, because he was the CHP's candidate), and for parliament, we voted for the HDP (Peoples' Democratic Party).

On July 5-6, 2018, the sixth and verdict hearing was held. The prosecutor presented new “evidence” against me in his opinion on the merits; he repeated his request that I be sentenced to life imprisonment for violating the constitution and up to 15 years for membership in an armed terrorist organization. I responded to the prosecutor’s accusations point by point. In its decision announced on July 6, the court panel did not consider the accusation of violating the constitution, but ruled that I be sentenced to 8 years and 9 months in prison on the grounds that I was a “member of an armed terrorist organization,” that the judicial control requiring me to sign in at the police station every week be lifted, and that the ban on traveling abroad continue. One of the judges, in a dissenting opinion, argued that while I was not a member of an armed terrorist organization, I should be sentenced to life imprisonment for violating the constitution on the grounds that my writings had paved the way for the July 15 coup attempt.

The indictment had started with a request for three aggravated life sentences, and in the end I was sentenced to 8 years and 9 months, but I remained free due to two Constitutional Court decisions and one ECtHR decision ruling that my detention was a rights violation. Thinking of the tens of thousands of unjustly detained victims, we kept saying, “Let’s still be grateful for our situation…” When I expressed concern about being detained again, my dear Fatma wouldn’t give in to my pessimism, saying, “We must look forward now, we must forget what’s left behind…”

Fatma and Elvan went to Ayvalik on July 8. I stayed in Istanbul until July 11 to meet with my Swedish journalist colleague and friend Bitte Hammargren. On July 14, my son Acar, his wife Gokce, and my granddaughter Leyla also came to Ayvalik. That same day, Swedish Ambassador Lars Wahlund, who had been appointed to Dublin, came to Ayvalik with his sister Anna and son Leonard, and stayed for one night. I hosted them at a restaurant in Cunda.

On July 18, on the late Captain Guner’s veteran boat, we set out as a family for Ayvalik’s paradise islands for the first time in two years; we swam in the sea behind Maden Island. On July 20, we went to Istanbul as a family in Acar’s car to attend the wedding of Nazli, daughter of Fatma’s cousin Salim. Acar, Gokce, and Leyla returned to London on July 22. (Sadly, these days in Istanbul would be the last days Fatma would spend with her beloved son and granddaughter Leyla.)

My friend Mehmet Altan had been released about two months after me, on June 27, but I had only been able to talk with him by phone since; we finally got together on July 22 at a restaurant in Arnavutkoy. After the last “Akil Defteri” program on Mehtap-TV, I had only been able to see him in the corridors of Silivri prison or behind the glass of lawyer visiting rooms, greeting him from afar. Although sentenced to life imprisonment, he had been released pursuant to Constitutional Court and ECtHR decisions; but the requirement to sign in at the police station every week continued. (He would be acquitted at the end of the trial.) With Mehmet, we took stock of what had happened to us.

The next day, on the evening of July 23, my dear Fatma and I flew to Ayvalik. On July 26, we lived one of the most enjoyable days of that last summer we spent together. My elder sister and my nephew and niece Sinan and Sedef with their spouses were in

Ayvalik, and we all went together to Ma'adra Winery on Mount Madra. We experienced a wonderful sunset there. Fatma greatly enjoyed this trip. On July 31, Fatma and I attended the traditional summer gathering of the Ayvalik International Music Academy, AIMA, of which our friend Filiz Ali was the president. It was only on that occasion that I was able to see many of our Ayvalik friends and acquaintances for the first time since Silivri. That night, Fatma was as beautiful and cheerful as always. On August 5, we had another boat trip with Captain Guner. Since a strong northeasterly wind was blowing, this time we went to the cove behind Ciplak (Naked) Island. Fatma was very well; she went swimming several times. (What would happen to her two months later was the farthest thing from our minds.) As always, she showed me great affection.

August and September were the last two months my dear Fatma and I lived happily together, just the two of us. At that time, taking into account the coming economic difficulties, I was trying to convince Fatma to vacate the apartment we had been renting in Istanbul for 33 years and settle in Ayvalik. I said we could go to Istanbul and stay with Elvan whenever necessary. My wish from then on was only to be together with my Fatma and to focus on writing my memoirs. However, one late afternoon, as we sat hand in hand on the terrace of our house in Camlik watching the sunset, she suddenly said, "I cannot stay here when the weather gets too cold to go out to the garden." We agreed to rent a small apartment in Istanbul and spend the winter months there… A touching memory from those days, the photograph of us holding hands that Fatma's niece Yesim took without our knowledge, seemed like a reflection of our hope and desire never to be separated again…

PHOTO

On August 20, our friends Nilufer (Kuyas) and her husband Tayfun (Ertan) came to Ayvalik and stayed with us for one night. Umit and Cem (Boyner) organized the traditional family dinner at their house in Cunda on August 22. On the way back, Fatma stepped into a hole and injured her ankle, but in general she looked quite healthy. On August 31, we took our last boat trip toward Maden Island with Captain Guner. My beloved enjoyed the sea. After "The Crown" and "Versailles," the series we used to watch in the evenings when we were in Istanbul, we started watching "Breaking Bad" on Netflix. We were in good spirits.

Our friends Sefik (Yuksel) and his wife Idil (Biret) came to Ayvalik on August 29 and stayed until September 5. Sefik, who had been a close friend since middle school, and I met almost every morning at our house; I listened to his memories about me and noted them down to use in my autobiography. Idil had come, as she did every summer, to teach talented students at AIMA's summer courses. And the courses, as every year, ended with a concert given by the students at the Ayvalik Municipality's hall on the hilltop of Cunda (on the evening of September 4). Fatma greatly enjoyed this concert; she was extremely cheerful. (Who could have imagined that a month later she would bid us farewell forever…) Our days were never empty: On September 5, our friends Binnaz Toprak and Nursen Baydar came for a day visit from Yesilyurt village. On September 6, we had a dinner where we spent a very pleasant time with our friends Seyfi-Tulin

(Gursel) and Ayhan (Aktar). On September 7, Vasif and Defne (Koryurek) were our guests for morning coffee.

On September 10, I went to Istanbul in the car of our friends and relatives Bulent and Simten (Comert) to meet with my lawyers. On the evening of September 12, we had dinner with Elvan and Defne at a restaurant in Nisantasi; we lamented that Fatma was not with us… On September 13, I attended the opening of an exhibition featuring works by alumni artists on the occasion of the 150th anniversary of the founding of Galatasaray High School, which Elvan also attended. After the exhibition, when I met for dinner with my journalist friend Michael Thumann from Die Zeit who had come from Germany, Seyfettin Gursel also joined us. On September 14, I returned to Ayvalik by plane. That evening we went to Altinova; we were guests of Fatma's cousin Salim and Oya (Kaptan), and we had a lovely dinner at a restaurant on the beach. Two evenings later, we hosted them at a restaurant in Ayvalik.

Our friends Zeynel and Serpil (Celikel) were suggesting that we take a trip to the Black Sea region with their car. Fatma had never seen Vakfikebir and Surmene, where her mother and father were from. I wanted her to see those places. But as September progressed, we had begun to hesitate because it would be too strenuous a journey. When Fatma put her foot down, we postponed the trip; we would fly to Trabzon in the spring… The Trabzon trip had been postponed, but Fatma's cousin Kemal (Kaptan), who lived in Antalya, had completed the preparations for a 3-4 day trip to Kas and its surroundings with a group of relatives.

Joining this trip was looming large in Fatma's mind. In fact, when reports came in (which would turn out to be wrong) that the weather in the region would be rainy on the designated dates of September 27-30, she wanted to cancel the trip at one point. Then, perhaps because I had instilled this idea in Kemal's mind, she said we should continue with the program so as not to be rude. Together with another cousin and our childhood friend Emine (Edremit), we drove to Izmir and flew from there to Antalya. On the way, Fatma had complained to Emine about shoulder pain, but she didn't tell me anything.

Kemal met us at Antalya airport. After having dinner at a kebab restaurant, we set off for Kas in his car. I don't recall Fatma making any complaints during the approximately three-hour journey. We arrived in Kas late in the evening and settled into a hotel at the tip of the peninsula. For the first time then, Fatma complained to me about the very humid weather and rheumatism pains. Since her pains would flare up from time to time and then subside, I honestly didn't pay much attention. Her main complaint was about the breathing machine I used for sleep apnea. The air leaking from the device was bothering her. "Let's have separate rooms now," she said.

The next day, September 28, we took a trip by car covering Kalkan, Patara beach, and the ancient city of Xanthos. We had lunch at a trout farm in Islamlar village, at an altitude of 700 meters. Fatma had no complaints at all. She loved Patara. We had dinner at a beautiful restaurant overlooking the sea in Kas. Before dinner, Fatma went shopping and bought a white summer dress to wear on the boat trip the next day. Along the way, I kept telling the relatives how I would obey all of Fatma's commands for the rest of my life,

how she would direct me with her one-syllable commands. The relatives were having fun with me.

On September 29, we went to Kekova by car and set out to sea on a boat. The scenery and the sea were wonderful, and Fatma went swimming several times during the day; she was content with her life. She didn't mention having pain even in the light rain that started in the afternoon. We had dinner at the hotel's restaurant. After breakfast in the morning, we departed for Antalya in Kemal's car to catch the flight to Izmir. We said goodbye to Kemal at the airport; we ate hamburgers while waiting for the flight. Fatma looked quite well.

PHOTO: My Fatma in the last photograph taken of her, wearing the white dress she bought in Kas…

In Izmir, we stopped by the house of Fatma's niece Asli and her husband Ali (Ulker), and picking up Emine who was also returning to Izmir with them, we departed for Ayvalik by taxi. There was heavy rain throughout the journey. Fatma had begun complaining more intensely about the pain in her shoulder. Our mood had soured. When we arrived home late at night, she felt very tired and went to bed immediately. When I was preparing to move to a separate room as she had wanted, she stopped me; "stay with me," she said. She must have been feeling an extraordinary weakness in herself.

The next day (October 1), I called our friend and her doctor Prof. Dr. Hasan Yazici. Fatma took the phone; it was noteworthy that she spoke directly about her complaints without any small talk… Hasan said she could take a mild painkiller 3-4 times a day. Fatma did so, but her pains were spreading. She asked me to rub Voltaren ointment on the left side of her back. The pains decreased somewhat with the medication, but Fatma was mostly lying down exhausted. Still, in the evenings, we were able to continue watching the "Breaking Bad" series on Netflix. The next day (October 2), I saw a large brown spot on the back of her right leg. There was yellowing on the front of her left leg. A large scab had also formed near her right wrist. I began to suspect that the liver insufficiency she had suffered from since the mid-1980s might have flared up. I called Hasan; I told him it would be good if he could see Fatma as soon as possible. "I'll be expecting you at the hospital at 9:30 on Friday morning, October 5," he said. He instructed that Fatma should come fasting for blood tests. On Thursday, October 4, I bought tickets for the Turkish Airlines flight departing from Edremit at 14:35.

When saying goodbye to her relatives in Ayvalik, she had said, "Hopefully I'll return soon…" Holding hands, we had a good journey. She could only eat half of the toast we had bought at the start of the trip. She had very little appetite. We arrived at our home in Akatlar around 5 PM. She said she was very tired and went to bed immediately. Elvan came. We ordered cop sis (grilled meat skewers) for dinner. She could only eat a little without getting out of bed and then fell asleep. When I woke up around 4 AM, I found her in the dining room, eating some bread and cheese in the dark. "I was very hungry," she said; and went back to bed right after. Honestly, I wasn't very worried; I was thinking that Hasan would make the necessary intervention and we would get through this crisis too.

On the morning of October 5, she got up around 8:30. She went to the bathroom, washed, did her hair. As always, she dressed up beautifully, got ready. Around 9, I called for a taxi; there were no cars at any stand. It was only after about fifteen minutes that I was able to find a taxi and bring it to the front of the house. On her way to the taxi, she had run into our doorman and said, “I’m very tired…” As we were crossing the Bosphorus Bridge, I asked, “My dear Fatma, I always get confused about the hospital’s location, can you give directions to the driver?” Her answer was, “Use Yandex…” She was conscious. We reached the hospital in exactly 13 minutes. As she was getting out of the car, something unprecedented happened: Fatma dropped her bag on the ground; the contents spilled onto the road. I was surprised; I attributed it to her tiredness… It took me 5-10 minutes to complete the registration; during that time, she waited for me quietly, standing. Then we went to Hasan’s office.

Hasan would tell me later: When she entered the room, she wasn’t looking like the usual Fatma; this was like a different Fatma… Hasan began asking her questions. Her answers were broken and fragmented. She could barely sit on the examination table; it was as if she couldn’t fully control her body… Then she opened her hands and looked at them with wonder-filled eyes… She was seeing things we couldn’t see… Hasan measured her blood pressure and without saying what he saw, said let’s get some blood drawn. He called the nurse and requested a wheelchair be brought and blood to be drawn at the nearby emergency department. As Fatma struggled to sit in the wheelchair with the nurse’s help, her shoe came off her left foot. I felt the urge to bend down and kiss her foot… My worry was increasing. Something extraordinary was happening, but what was it?

At the emergency department, they laid her on her back and drew blood from her arm. She was no longer conscious. She started to retch; fearing she would vomit and choke, I called out to the staff to come quickly. They came running and turned her on her side. I saw that her mouth was full of blood. One of the orderlies said, “She must have bitten her tongue…” Then there was a flurry of activity in the emergency department. They closed the curtains around her bed. Hasan came; a little later, he left there and headed to his office, calling me to follow. He suspected a liver crisis. He called Fatma’s liver doctor Prof. Dr. Sabahattin Kaymakoglu. They agreed on transferring her to Florence Nightingale Hospital. I called Elvan and told her to come as soon as possible. An ambulance arrived, but the transfer was called off as Fatma’s condition was rapidly deteriorating. I was in complete shock. Hasan said a brain CT scan was being taken on the floor below; I could go down and check on the situation. I did so.

The doctor performing the CT scan didn’t take long to come out; “Unfortunately, we are facing a very severe case of brain hemorrhage; recovery is impossible, but we are still calling our neurosurgeon. We will take the patient to intensive care…” he said. By this time, Elvan had just managed to reach the hospital. Together, in deep anxiety, we began waiting for the neurosurgeon in front of the intensive care room. The neurosurgeon arrived and went in to see Fatma. When he came out, he said, “Unfortunately, brain death has occurred; the rest is a matter of time. There is nothing we can do, I’m afraid…” Together with Elvan, we went in to see her. My beloved was lying there as if nothing was wrong, as if she were just sleeping, with her usual beauty, her pink and

white complexion… We understood that the time had come to say goodbye to her. I couldn't stay by her side for long… Everything had happened so fast (in a span of about an hour) that I couldn't comprehend what had befallen me…

I asked Hasan not to try to keep her alive. Her brain had died, meaning her selfhood had ended… Hasan said they would wait until Monday, and a decision would be made then. With our hearts bleeding, we left Fatma where she lay in intensive care, and Elvan and I returned home in a daze. That night, around 1:30 AM, Hasan called, "We've lost Fatma…" he said. I don't remember how we conveyed the sad news to London, to my son Acar. Acar and Gokce had applied to the British authorities for an extension of their residence and work permits. Hasan had written a letter to the authorities requesting the urgent return of their passports, and we had immediately sent it to Acar.

While receiving Fatma's death certificate from the hospital, the female clerk on duty offered her condolences; she told me that she too had lost her husband at a young age from a heart attack. "I understand what you're going through… I couldn't recover until a year and a half after my husband's death…" she said. Would I ever be able to recover?..

We would take Fatma, who had been placed in the hospital morgue, to our hometown Ayvalik and bury her there. I contacted our relatives in Ayvalik and asked them to make the necessary preparations. For the transport of the body, I first called the Mayor of Ayvalik, our friend Rahmi Gencer, but when I learned that the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality also provided this service, I applied to them. On Sunday afternoon, October 7, at Karacaahmet Cemetery, Fatma was washed and shrouded under the supervision of her daughter Elvan. Around 6 in the evening, a refrigerated vehicle heading toward Izmir came and took her along with three other bodies. With our hearts bleeding, we watched her being loaded into the vehicle and setting off on her journey. I stood staring after her… Our 55 years together had come to an end.

Acar, Gokce, and Leyla were waiting for their passports to arrive from Liverpool before they could set off. That night and for two more nights until October 10, we had to keep Fatma waiting in the morgue of Ayvalik State Hospital.

On Monday morning, October 8, Hasan called. When he and his hematologist colleague examined Fatma's final blood tests, they had concluded that the cause of death was, with 95 percent probability, a brain hemorrhage resulting from acute leukemia… We learned from acquaintances that there were others whom acute leukemia had killed within a week… When I returned to Istanbul, I spoke with Fatma's cardiologist Prof. Dr. Sabri Demircan. He was very saddened by the news. He said that the blood-thinning pills that had been prescribed due to the ablation procedure performed on Fatma in April 2015 to treat her increasingly rapid heart palpitations could also cause brain hemorrhage "with a one in two hundred probability."

The Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality Public Relations Directorate had called the day after Fatma was transported to Ayvalik; they had offered condolences on behalf of the Istanbul Mayor and told me to call them if there was anything they could do. The Ayvalik Municipality was also very helpful with the burial arrangements. I truly felt grateful for the attention and services provided by both municipalities.

During the days we spent waiting for Acar, our friends and loved ones showered us with condolence messages. Cengiz Candar, one of our closest friends, sent from Stockholm where he had been living for some time, an article he had written in memory of Fatma. I am including below Cengiz's article, which was also published in T24 on October 11, 2018.

Cengiz Candar wrote about Fatma Alpay:

Could a person love another person as much as she loved Sahin?



https://media-cdn.t24.com.tr/media/stories/2018/10/page_cengiz-candar-fatma-alpayi-yazdi-onun-sahini-sevdigi-kadar-bir-insan-bir-baska-insani-sevebilir-miydi_011082388.jpg

"She was the only Fatma in my life. Given that the name Fatma is very common, it would not have been possible for her to be the only Fatma who had entered my life. But I didn't know any other Fatma. Or she was such a dominant, powerful personality that even if I had known other Fatmas, I don't remember them.

She was my only Fatma. And my most beautiful Fatma. She was a very beautiful woman. I used to compare her to Catherine Deneuve, but Tuba would say "No, Faye Dunaway." Tuba was probably right. Even if she resembled Catherine Deneuve's beauty, she was more like Faye Dunaway because she had nothing of her coldness. Or she was simply herself, Fatma Alpay.

Fatma was an impossible and entirely unique combination of the grandeur of strength and the unpretentiousness of humility. I knew Leman Kaptan. What a charismatic strong woman is, what it means to radiate power with her stance and a single glance without saying a word, I had seen that in Leman Kaptan. On the other hand, she was a familiar figure. Leman Kaptan had traits I recognized in my maternal grandmother from Thessaloniki. Fatma, beside her, would give the impression of being both her docile daughter and the heir apparent who would inherit Leman Kaptan's throne as a powerful, commanding woman. She was different from her elder sisters. She was Leman Kaptan's daughter. But incomparably more affectionate than her mother…

When I met Sahin, he was married. A university student and married. There were only one or two others like him in the entire Faculty of Political Science. But none as famous as Sahin. Fatma too had become famous through Sahin. If Mulkiye had a King, it must also have a Queen, and Fatma was exactly that. I understood as soon as I met her: she was not Queen merely because she was the King's wife; she was Queen because she was a Queen.

As I write all this on the last day before she goes into the ground, it also occurs to me that I am a fortunate man. Even if I have never been free of trouble in my 70-year life, I believe I have lived a good and rich life. I have been thinking since October 5-6, 2018, that Fatma is among the foremost people who gave me this sense of richness. To know Fatma, to be one of the people she loved, to be among the people she loved - I understood better what an incredible wealth and what great fortune this has been for me.

I am a privileged intimate of the Fatma-Sahin-Elvan-Acar Alpay quartet. Fatma was the first to see Elvan, then Sahin, and very soon after, I did too. What a thing…

What luck that, when the Bahceli minibus coming from Cebeci stopped at the Kizilay stop and I got off, I came face to face with Sahin on the sidewalk, who had thrown himself onto the street to tell his loved ones about the birth of his daughter. I wasn't one of his closest friends at that time, but some divine power must have planned our future, because Sahin excitedly said, "I have a daughter, come let me show you my daughter," and took me to the nearby health center, I think, and we went up one or two floors and burst into Fatma's room. Aside from being the first person other than her mother and father to see Elvan in Fatma's arms, it was also the first time I had seen such a small creature since my sibling. I never forgot Fatma's expression at that moment.

When I started going in and out of their home in Ankara, Elvan would wander among us as a mischievous little one. She was the first and youngest of our entire circle of friends. Then Cemo came. Elvan was Elvan, and through experiencing her in that tiny form, I experienced the love of small children within me.

Acar is also special to me. The elder Acar's unexpected death had come right after some of Fatma's very close relatives had perished in another traffic accident, between Balikesir and Susurluk. Acar came into existence with the elder Acar's passing. He was wanted, planned, and born. We awaited him. After he was born, I experienced his early infancy in Ayvalik. I watched with excitement and curiosity as Fatma changed his diapers. If Elvan was the first newborn of my life, Acar was also one of the first whose infancy I observed closely.

In Elvan and Acar, I also came to know Fatma as a mother. She was a mother through and through. Authoritarian and at the same time completely affectionate, a mother through and through.

How many people Fatma was, all in one, with that calm manner of hers bringing together all her traits that seemed impossible to combine.

I wondered these past few days whether there could be a person of such powerful love on this earth. Could a person love another person as much as she loved Sahin?

In no period of Sahin's life did any of his views become Fatma's views. Fatma never

became a Marxist, nor a Maoist, nor a Swedish Social Democrat, nor this, nor that; she never identified herself with the SHP (Social Democratic Populist Party), or the CHP, or Cumhuriyet newspaper, or Sabah, or Milliyet, or Zaman because of her husband. She had no allegiance to any of these. But she considered all the friends Sahin made in his changing circles as her own friends, showed them love.

What kind of thing is this!?? How else can this be explained except by an unparalleled love for Sahin? Why then did she love Sahin, whose views she never adopted? Why did she live this life, starting from the Camlik days, marrying him as a university student, waiting for him without knowing where he was during the period he went to Palestine, trying to raise Elvan, then going to Sweden where she wasn't accustomed and standing by him, and afterward adopting without complaint the life he offered her in Istanbul?

Why?

Because she loved Sahin so much, had loved him so much, that she hadn't even questioned any of this. Why did she love him so? Because Fatma loved Sahin's essence, that incorruptible, uncorrupted, incorruptible pure essence.

She herself was so pure that such a pure person could only love someone with a pure essence this much, and Fatma loved Sahin like that. With a legendary love in the category of Asli loving Kerem, Leyla loving Mecnun, Juliet loving Romeo.

Remaining herself, she lived without the slightest reproach toward Sahin's life, without a murmur, quietly, with great humility, and without giving up even an iota of her own rock-solid personality. What an incredible thing this is, how special and unique it makes Fatma.

And she had such an enormous heart that she loved Elvan, Acar, Defne, and Leyla as much as she loved Sahin. She loved all of Sahin's close friends. I knew so well how much (and very much) she loved me, and I loved her so much too…

I realized how many memories I had accumulated with her. They all pass through my mind continuously like strips of film. While Sahin in Sweden was experiencing the hesitation of whether or not to return to Turkey, Fatma had come to Ankara to scout things out. We were sitting at Piknik, drinking our beers and eating sausage and french fries. That's how it was done at Piknik in the 60s and 70s. When she asked, "What do you think, can Sahin return?" I had said, "Look Fatma, if he had returned, he would be the one drinking beer and eating sausage and french fries in my place." What an enjoyable moment it was. We were talking, bursting with laughter. I was trying to convince her of something, I forgot what, she wasn't accepting, "Why should I do that?" she asked; I mumbled something like "For the people, for the interests of the workers." Fatma's face, with all its dynamic and mischievous manner, rang before my eyes with "What do I care!" I paused for a second or two, it was my turn to laugh; "By God, the smartest and most Marxist among us is you, Fatma. You're acting directly out of class interest. Of course, what do you care about all this…" I said, believing it. It was her turn

to laugh - with that never-diminishing timbre of her laughter.

Fatma was a smart woman. Very smart. On top of such a beautiful, pure heart, a sparkling, crystal-clear mind. Tuba calls her “a woman of the earth” to emphasize her solidity, her personality solidity, her groundedness. When a pure heart meets a crystal-clear mind - not granted to every servant of God - a rock-solid, steel-like unbending personality emerges.

Both solid and dignified, head held high. Dignified in English. There was always “dignity” in her. Nobility… Both nobility in the sense of a Camlik aristocrat, and nobility of spirit.

To go to military service in Canakkale, I had come from Istanbul to Ayvalik. When setting off on the military path from the house in Ayvalik, it had fallen to Fatma to see both of us off to the army.

Ahh, how many memories we have accumulated with Fatma at the milestones, at the important turns of my life…

While Omer Madra and I had turned our military service into desertion and were perhaps having the longest summer vacation of our lives, Sahin, with an unnecessary discipline toward the end of his service, wouldn’t stick his nose out of the barracks. In one of those last weeks, Omer and I decided to desert to Ayvalik for the weekend. Omer was broke and was going to wring out whatever money was due to him from Madra olive oils, come what may. We were going to Ayvalik. We couldn’t convince Sahin, who was in love with his wife, to desert no matter what we did. We came to Ayvalik. Omer sat me on a bench overlooking the sea in Camlik and went to rescue the money. And of course, he came back with a small amount, unable to rescue it. What did we do? “Let’s go,” we said, “let’s go to Fatma. Let’s take Fatma out to dinner, let’s spend the money.” We did so. What a beautiful night it was. Fatma, Omer, and I. A night spent making fun of Sahin, continuing with Fatma’s laughter. We wished it would never end.

How much Fatma used to laugh. How much she would make us laugh without ever trying to be witty.

What a wonderful, what a unique person you were, Fatma!

What great wealth you were in my life, in our lives. How fortunate I am; to have been in this world for nearly half a century together with you, knowing you, knowing that I was someone loved by you.

Sahin, Elvan, Acar, never forget that you are among the luckiest people in the world; one of you is Fatma’s unparalleled love, one is her daughter, one is her son. What more could you want from this world.

How lucky a girl Defne is that she knew her grandmother. Acar, Leyla is only 4 years old, she may not remember; always tell her about her grandmother. Always.

Goodbye my dear Fatma. Perhaps someday somewhere we'll meet…"

****

Fatma's death notice published in Hurriyet newspaper on October 9 was as follows:

OBITUARY

Daughter of the late Leman Kaptan and the late Mustafa Lutfi Kaptan, of Ayvalik's notable families; daughter-in-law of the late Sabiha Karatal and the late Ahmet Muharrem Alpay; sister of the late Hakki Kaptan and Suat Kaptan and the late Bingul Onen and Ayse Comert; paternal aunt of Yusuf Kaptan, Emine Edremit, and the late Ahmet Kaptan; maternal aunt of Ali Onen, Asli Ulker, Omer Onaran, Yesim Comert, and Cenk Comert; mother of Elvan Alpay and Acar Alpay; mother-in-law of Gokce Ozkaya Alpay; maternal grandmother of Defne Guler; paternal grandmother of Leyla Alpay; the love of Sahin Alpay

Fatma Nur Alpay

(Isik High School class of 1961)

has passed away. Her funeral will be held on Wednesday, October 10, 2018, following the afternoon prayer at Ayvalik Saatli Mosque, and she will be buried in the family cemetery.

HER FAMILY

On Wednesday, October 10, 2018, at noon, we brought her to her home in Camlik. By her coffin, before a large gathering of friends and relatives, I gave the following speech:

"Dear friends and relatives,

We have gathered to see my wife Fatma, whom we all loved very much, off on her last journey. Fatma was my love, my closest friend, the pillar of the family I built. That is why I want to say a few words in her memory.

I don't need to describe her to you. You know her with all her beauty, her intelligence, her fortitude, her self-confidence, her personality free in thought and free in conscience.

I fell in love with her in elementary school, I declared my love in middle school, I won her in university. We married at 21. While I was swept away by the winds of my mind and emotions, she always stood firm. She protected the family we built.

She made me one of the happiest husbands in the world. She gave me my children and grandchildren whom I love more than my own life. She stood strong through all the

hardships we went through and encouraged me to stand strong too. I want to thank her once again in your presence.

Of our 55 years together, I unfortunately spent three years in exile and two years in prison. I don't forgive myself for the five years I spent away from her. I ask for her forgiveness once more in your presence.

Although she did not share my views or condone some of my behavior, what was the foundation of my happy union with Fatma that lasted so many years?

If you asked her, it was for the sake of our children that she didn't leave me. According to some friends, she was pleased with my extraordinary personality. According to others, she was bound to me with love. Perhaps all of these were valid at once.

My only consolation as we bid her farewell is that she said goodbye to us in a manner befitting her dignity and personality. She neither suffered nor caused suffering…

She was very fond of her independence; she lived and died without being subject to anyone.

As you all know, living without Fatma will be very difficult for me…

I want to write the story of what we lived through together and then die.

Thank you all from the bottom of my heart for attending this farewell, for sharing our grief…"

Many of our friends and relatives from within and outside Ayvalik attended the funeral prayer held at Ayvalik Saatli Mosque during the afternoon prayer time. I am grateful to all of them. Heartfelt thanks to our friends and relatives who attended or could not attend Fatma's funeral, who conveyed their condolences by sending wreaths or making donations.

We buried Fatma in our family cemetery at Ayvalik Cemetery, next to the place I had reserved for myself. Elvan and Defne decorated her grave with flowers. Acar, Gokce, and Leyla, who could only arrive from London the next day, joined us; my children and grandchildren and I visited her. We couldn't believe she had left us…

When I search for consolations for myself, I find these: Yes, I couldn't get enough of her and never would have anyway. How fortunate I am to have spent half a century with the most beautiful woman and the best person in the world! From the time she began coping with liver insufficiency in the mid-1980s, my prayer was that she would at least live to see 70. On her 70th birthday, she had told a friend, "I didn't believe I would reach this age…" Every time she said to me, "I will die before you," my answer was, "I would rather die first…" The fact that she lived until 74 despite the liver insufficiency diagnosed in 1986, the rheumatoid arthritis diagnosed in 2000, the palpitations that started in 2015 and the operation she had for them, and the dozen medications she had been taking for

years is also a consolation. That she died without suffering is another… The fact that she passed away from a brain hemorrhage that began in the examination room of Prof. Dr. Hasan Yazici, her doctor of 20 years and our friend of 40 years, at a fully equipped hospital, does not allow me the remorse of feeling we didn't do everything to save her. Finally, if she had died while I was in Silivri prison, if I had had to attend her funeral handcuffed and surrounded by gendarmes carrying machine guns, what would I have done?…

With Fatma's death, my real life came to an end.

CHAPTER XIX / FINAL WORDS: MY PRIVATE LIFE IS A COMPLETE SUCCESS STORY

I am writing this final chapter, which provides a general assessment of my life, in August 2022, after having completed writing my story: I lived through times, years when I suffered greatly, experienced much distress and sorrow. But when I look at it overall, I had a happy life; I will have no regrets when I say farewell. I owe this peace with myself primarily to what I experienced in my private life, to the family I was born into and the one I built with Fatma. The family I was born into, as I briefly described above, had been dragged into a deep crisis heading toward disintegration starting from when I was just one year old. My father, who was extremely devoted to his wife and children, an extremely affectionate father, unfortunately suffered a severe mental breakdown at just 33 years of age, attributed to various reasons, and gradually became estranged from our family.

It was my mother who held our family together and took all her children under her wing. We weathered as a family the potential negative consequences of what befell my father through my mother's success in being both mother and father, especially to me as the youngest child but also to all her children, and by fostering our loving bond with each other. Perhaps because we grew up without a father, all siblings took the path of marrying at the earliest possible age to establish families of our own. Growing up in a fatherless, wounded family may have led me to seek a role outside the established order, while also causing me to develop self-confidence from an early age.

In the formation of my personality, I was influenced by my siblings as much as by my mother. My eldest sister Sumru had been a half-mother to me until she married and settled in Ayvalik when I was six years old, and it was not easy to accept why I had to be separated from her. She was a monument of character. Having lost her father when she was just one year old, she grew up with a stepfather who loved her dearly, found happiness in the family she built, in her husband and children, and weathered life's storms with great fortitude. She experienced every twist of fate, from being the child and then daughter-in-law of one of Ayvalik's wealthiest families to complete poverty, and took it upon herself not to be happy but to make others happy. She raised her children with great affection expecting nothing in return; she sheltered her husband, her youthful love, with deep devotion through two years of imprisonment and then ten years of suffering from Alzheimer's. May she rest in peace.

Olcay, the younger of my two elder sisters, is, fortunately, the sibling I had the most opportunity to be together with, first in Ankara between 1964-71 and after 1980 in Istanbul. What her classmates wrote about her when she graduated from the girls' section of Robert College describes her character well. Her presence leaves a "spring breeze" effect in every environment she is in. Although she is nine years older than me, since she became as close as a friend over time, it felt more appropriate to address her as "Olcay" rather than "sister." She perhaps experienced most deeply the negative effects that our father's depression had on our family; for this reason, like all of us siblings, she too became tightly attached to her husband and children. We celebrated my marriage to Fatma at her home; we shared all our joys and troubles with her. I am very fortunate that she was always by my side in good and bad times, during my time as a fugitive and in prison, never withholding her love and solidarity.

If I have been able to reach this age and can say that I have generally lived a happy life, I owe this significantly to the sacrifices my late elder brother Acar undertook. If I have certain qualities as a literate person, I acquired them through his guidance and his example. If, during the March 12 period, he had not risked everything solely because he was my elder brother and enabled my escape abroad, I would not have had anything I came to possess afterwards. If luck had not been on our side and I had been caught, not only my life but his could have been ruined; I could have been devastated by the harm I caused him, his wife, and children… He was the unluckiest member of our family. His greatest misfortune was undoubtedly losing his life at a very young age, just when he had found peace, in an impossible, unbelievable traffic accident. I was devastated that he said farewell to us at such a young age, before I could have enough of him, before I could find the opportunity to show him all my love and solidarity. I am even more saddened that he departed from among us without seeing the successes of his daughter Umit, who would become one of the most successful female executives not just in Turkey but in the world. Because of the deep love he showed me and the risks he took for me, I lived indebted to him, and I will die indebted.

If I can say "I generally had a good, happy life; I will have no regrets when I say farewell," I owe this primarily to my Fatma, who was my beloved, my wife, and my friend for 55 years, to my children she gave me, and to my grandchildren. During the days I spent in Silivri, I wrote the following letters to Fatma (which unfortunately I never had the chance to show her) and to my children she gave me, Elvan and Acar.

Letter to Fatma from Silivri

"My beloved, my life, my soul… Before being imprisoned in Silivri, I thought I had generally lived a full, rich, happy life, and I would say I wouldn't mind dying. But after spending more than 15 months here, my outlook on life has changed. Now, with the longing I feel for you, I want to live for many more years and be able to enjoy being with you. I pray for this.

Now I look back at our past life with regret. I say if only I hadn't been so headstrong, if only I had been fully aware of what a gift from God you were to me, if only I had lived only for you and with you; if only we had four children instead of two; if only we had more

grandchildren than two… At least, I say, if only after returning from Sweden, or failing that, after *Milliyet*, I had listened to her, if only I had set up a bookstore-publishing house and charted a path where I'd still be occupied with books and ideas but wouldn't end up a prisoner and once again far from Fatma… Unfortunately, regret is useless. Now I am burning only with the hope that I will be released in the not too distant future and will be reunited with you. Now perhaps I am more in love with you than ever…

I always think about the unique role you played in my life. You made me experience every kind of emotion. What passionate love, jealousy, anger, losing, winning, longing, the joy of reunion means, what it means to be forgiven… I learned all of these from you. The history of my love for you extends back to 1953, when we were just nine years old, to the days when we studied third grade together at Ayvalik Cumhuriyet Elementary School. That year, my getting upset and making up were the first expressions of my passion for you. When I heard that your late father had passed away in a traffic accident in 1956, thinking "my father-in-law has died…" is one of my most vivid childhood memories. And I never forget how, when I said "I think I'm falling in love with you…" in 1960 when I finished middle school, you responded with surprise saying "That's just how it seems to you…"

The year I started high school, I was burning with jealousy. Somehow that summer, in the summer of 1961, I had managed to attract your attention. I went to the USA with a burning heart, suffering. During the first months there, I didn't know how I would bear missing you. I consoled myself saying a year will pass quickly, then I'll be reunited with you and never be separated again. I wrote passionate love letters. Your responses became increasingly infrequent and after a while stopped altogether. In the summer of 1962 when I returned from the USA, I didn't even want to see you, but my passion for you had only turned to embers. This smoldering ember began to burn again with all its heat the following summer. When you made me feel you might perhaps return to me, the world was mine. I couldn't bear to lose you once more. I immediately gave up going to college in New York with the scholarship I had won. This was the best decision I ever made in my life. I lived the most beautiful days of my life in the period from the summer of 1963 to the fall of 1965 when we got married. When we married on November 29, I achieved my greatest ideal.

Unfortunately, during these happiest days when I was united with you, the paths that would lead me to much suffering were also being laid. I remember the spring of 1966 with regret: The ambition to have a cause was preparing the troubles I would experience. In the summer following March 1968 when our daughter was born, with the publication of *Aydinlik* magazine, I found myself caught between two fires: On one side my love for you and our daughter, on the other my intellectual, political ideal. Here I remember what your late mother said about me: "He has intelligence, but no sense…" There could be no better description of my state.

I could see that you were gradually cooling toward me, distancing yourself; while on one hand I struggled to prevent this, on the other I could see we were heading toward the end of our togetherness. The most painful day of my life was the day in June 1972 when I said goodbye to you before disappearing from sight. During the nearly nine months I

spent within the Palestinian resistance movement, I sought death; I hoped it would find me and put an end to the pain I was suffering.

But I must be a servant whom God favors, for I did not die, I did not end up in prison; just as I managed to seek refuge in Sweden through my brother's great sacrifice, I was able to persuade you to come together with me again under one roof. I was aware that I owed this essentially to the existence of our daughter Elvan. Your agreeing to come to Sweden, and coming with Elvan, gave me extraordinarily happy days again. Feeling that I was winning your heart again was like returning to life for me.

After returning to the country with the 1974 amnesty and completing my military service, I had to struggle greatly to obtain a passport, but in the end it became possible for me to return to Stockholm and begin my doctorate. Your acceptance to marry me again convinced me that I had won your heart back… Then we gained the strength to bear the pain of the successive deaths that deeply shook us - first your mother, then your maternal aunt, your elder sister and brother-in-law, then my elder brother - by holding on to life with the birth of our son Acar. The birth of our son gave us great happiness, just like the birth of our daughter ten years earlier.

If you had loved Sweden, I probably wouldn't have thought of returning to the country as soon as my work (doctorate) was finished. But your preference was more important than everything. However, we rushed. At the end of 1978, you took the children and returned to the country; I focused on finishing the doctorate with all its difficulties. If we had returned together, it might have been better for us and for Elvan. On the other hand, if we had delayed, our courage to return might have been broken, considering the hell that was being experienced in Turkey in the late 1970s.

When I finished my doctorate and returned to Turkey in 1981, I couldn't find the opportunity to work at a university. I was forced to turn to journalism. I became increasingly unhappy at *Cumhuriyet*. I exhausted you greatly by sharing this distress. Then I got a herniated disc; I was bedridden for months. The burden of caring for me in this state also fell on you. I upset and exhausted you greatly once again. Until I moved to *Sabah* in 1994, I worked for barely enough to get by. Weekends were spent on jobs I did for extra income; I couldn't spare proper time for you or the children. That our children grew up to be good people and good citizens is almost entirely your achievement. Not being able to give them enough attention is one of my greatest regrets.

Then your health problems caught up with us. First liver insufficiency, then rheumatoid arthritis, then heart palpitations… Thank God we found the means to cope with all of these. I cannot describe how much your ailments upset and worried me. I attributed your ability to cope with these to my prayers. When I went to Japan in 1987, I believed that hanging the amulet I got from a Shinto shrine at the head of your bed protected you.

I know our feelings are not mutual. Now, while lying in prison at 73, I feel more in love with you than ever. Recently, during a visit, you expressed your feelings about me as follows: Both love and anger… You are right to be angry at me for all I put you through. But no one could love you as much as I loved you. Therefore, I console myself thinking I deserve whatever love you have.

My beloved, if one aspect of my love for you relates to your personality, the other aspect certainly relates to your womanhood. Nothing in life made me as happy as being with you. Just looking at you was the greatest of happinesses. You gave me two children as precious as the world, two grandchildren as beloved as the world. All the virtues of our children are your creation. For this I owe you gratitude.

Let me confess that I was perhaps not the only but the most important obstacle preventing you from having a profession, a career where you could utilize your intelligence and talents. By promising you that you would be a happy diplomat's wife, I even blocked you from graduating from university. I am sorry for this. But this is also a fact: we were able to sustain our 52-year marriage, our 54-year togetherness until now (despite painful separations) thanks to this.

My beloved, you made me taste every kind of emotion in life. Passionate love, jealousy, longing, losing, winning, the pain of separation, the joy of reunion, being forgiven despite everything… I am not in love with you only as a woman/wife; as a human being, I have not known anyone more valuable than you. Intelligence, common sense, character, honor, courage, elegance, nobility, fortitude, standing tall, understanding, compassion, sacrifice - I found all virtues in you. If my family has remained standing, I owe it to you." (Silivri, November 13, 2017)

Letter to Elvan

My dear daughter, I am writing this letter to you from Silivri prison. This is a kind of letter thanking you for existing and at the same time apologizing to you.

You are the product of my love with Fatma, of our most beautiful days together. You were born on March 31, 1968. From August of that year, I (unfortunately) began pursuing my other passion, my search for a political cause, and the difficult days of our family began. I will never forget the day you were born: My mother, who had come to Ankara for Fatma's delivery, had gone to a "women's matinee" that morning with my mother-in-law and my elder sister Olcay. Then Fatma began showing signs of labor. I called her doctor from the grocery store across the street; he said "come to the maternity hospital without delay." And so we did.

When we arrived at Yenisehir Health Center on Selanik Avenue in the heart of Kizilay, the (well-known) doctor whose name I no longer remember was waiting for us, and they immediately took your mother to the delivery room. Shortly after, perhaps 15-20 minutes later, the door to the room where I was waiting excitedly for you opened and the nurse said, "Congratulations, you have a daughter!" (This was a surprise. In those years, the gender of the baby could not be known in advance. Your mother was trying to discover the gender by swinging a ring tied to a string over her belly.) Until they brought your mother, we were alone together for quite a while. You weren't making a sound; your eyes were open and you were looking at me as if trying to recognize your father. I cannot describe the happiness I felt in those minutes. I was face to face with a stunningly beautiful baby. On one hand I was thinking of the beautiful days we would live together, on the other I was experiencing an anxiety (still very deep down) because I was unemployed and because of uncertainties about my future.

Some time after they brought your mother to the room, I rushed out to convey the news to the family. By coincidence, the first person I encountered was Cengiz. Excitedly saying “I have a very beautiful daughter, come see,” I called him inside. Therefore, after your mother and father, Cengiz was the first to see you. Later, to share my joy, I ran to the house of my closest friend at the time, Nuri Colakoglu, who lived on nearby Izmir Avenue. He wasn’t home. I wrote a note saying “I have a daughter!” and hung it on the door. (Nuri kept that note for years but could never manage to get it to me. I’ll ask for it when I get out of here.)

When you were born, we were living in our first home, a small one-bedroom apartment on the seventh floor of Gunes Apt. in Maltepe. Later, toward the end of 1968, we would move to an apartment in a ramshackle building across from your Aunt Olcay on Kizilirmak Street, an apartment your mother never liked. In early 1970, we would settle in Cim Apt. on Tunus Avenue, which your mother acquired with the money from selling the three-story apartment building in Ayvalik, under whose roof both of us were born. (Throughout our marriage, we lived by selling off the things we inherited. Among the things we sold, of course later, the one I was most sorry about was the apartment building in Ayvalik.) You brought me luck. In May 1968, for the first time I had a seemingly solid job. Through Dogu Perincek’s mediation, I was hired as an assistant at Ankara University Faculty of Education. However, this job neither resembled the assistantship at SBF (the Faculty of Political Sciences) that I actually wanted, nor seemed like it would lead anywhere with the revolutionary fervor increasingly taking hold of me…

Shortly after your birth, you developed jaundice. You almost became a victim of my revolutionary enthusiasm. Sevim Hanim, the wife of Mihri Belli whom I had met in those days and whom I considered very important in my own way, was a pediatrician. I insisted that we must have her examine you. Despite all your mother’s resistance, we did so. (I cannot forget Fatma’s reluctance and uneasiness during this doctor visit.) From those days on, our preferences began to diverge and clash, unfortunately. But we both deeply regretted it. When Sevim Hanim said your blood needed to be changed, your mother said, “I’m going to take my daughter to a proper doctor,” and we did. The doctor would say that this type of jaundice can be seen in newborn babies, that it would pass with time, and required no treatment. (Your mother had been right, as she always would be.)

I have many memories about your infancy. Here I will talk about the most unforgettable ones. We celebrated your first birthday at our home on Kizilirmak Street, your second birthday at our home on Tunus Avenue. When you reached two years of age, your most unforgettable characteristic was your dislike of sleep. I would put you to bed and sit by you until you fell asleep. If I thought you were asleep and tried to leave, you would immediately jump to your feet in bed and raise a ruckus. I would both get angry at you and adore your sweetness.

My not paying enough attention to you began in those very days. Though I had a wife I was passionately attached to, a daughter I loved as much as my own life, I don’t know how I could have entered a path that would separate me from you, how I could have sunk so low as to say to Fatma, “If the revolution requires it, if my comrades want it, I

can abandon you…" I remember taking you to nearby Kavaklidere (Kugulu) Park on weekends. You were a chubby, pink and white, wonderfully beautiful baby. The photographs we had taken on your first birthday describe it well. You had a blue hooded coat. When I put the hood on, your cheeks would bulge out as if to say kiss me. And I would embrace and kiss you over and over. Your standing on the garden wall on the short little street descending from Tunali Hilmi to Tunus is engraved in my mind.

I lived one of the worst days of my life during our last visit to Kugulu Park together. The awareness that I wouldn't see you for a long time (perhaps never again) was painful. The March 12 military intervention had happened; I expected it would have a cost for me. Indeed, when my name appeared on the first "wanted" list published in May, I began hiding in the homes of some acquaintances. The pain of separation from our home, from your mother, from you was great. The most painful part was that I had knowingly and willingly put myself in this situation…

In May 1971, we separated for this reason; our reunion would come in January 1974. In the years in between, I very much wanted to die to escape the irreconcilable conflict between my passions. But God, Fate, or Fortune did not permit it; it gave me the opportunity to reorganize my life in Sweden. I owe our being able to reunite essentially to you. If you hadn't existed, your mother would not have given me another chance. And she would have been right. I owe being reunited with your mother, whom I passionately loved, to you as well. As for me, I left you fatherless perhaps in the years when you needed me most. I have a great sin against you. How fortunate that you did not grow cold toward me because of this.

Just like our last time alone together at Kugulu Park in May 1971, I remember with all its vividness our first day alone together in Stockholm in January 1974: I had bought a big doll to make you happy, we were talking together on the bus going to Lappis. I was so happy in those days that I had been able to bring my family together. Perhaps more than I had ever been… We immediately got a color television for the house. I remember your mother and you asking "What's he saying?… What's he saying?…"

and asking me to translate what was being said into Turkish, as if it were yesterday.

However, you quickly began learning Swedish. At the daycare you started attending, although new children were expected to come with their parents for at least the first week, your saying "Daddy, you can go now!" at the end of the very first day had greatly surprised the plump and very sweet caretaker Else Marie. Your surprising adaptation ability (and therefore your intelligence) had emerged there in all its brilliance. The result of quickly learning Swedish was this: We laughed a lot at how you gave away our family secrets by saying in Swedish to those who called asking for me, "Pappa inte hemma han stadar / Daddy's not home, he went to clean…"

In the first days after you arrived in Stockholm, we visited together the home of my American friend Fred Krimgold in Slussen, where I had also lived for a while. I think Fred took your first photographs in Stockholm there. My Swedish friend Klas also came to visit us at Lappis one day and took those wonderful photographs of us that we still keep and gave them to us as a gift.

In Stockholm, you attended daycare for one year and elementary school for three years. Because of my return to Turkey with the amnesty and then struggling for six months to get a passport after completing military service, you could only start in January 1976 at the elementary school that had opened in August. Despite this, we were extremely happy whenever we heard from your very sweet class teacher Babba (Barbro) that you were very successful in your classes. The navy blue down jacket and white hood you wore when going to elementary school are still before my eyes. At the beginning of the summer of 1978 when we decided to return to the country for good, we sent you to Turkey with a friend. In the days close to your departure, when we visited the home of my doctoral thesis advisor Tomas (Hammar) and his wife Stina, they were saying that you spoke Swedish like a true Stockholmer.

Shortly after the birth, on March 11, 1978, of your brother Acar, who came almost exactly ten years after you, we returned to the country. The result of our decision to return for good was dragging you from place to place again. You attended third grade at Ayvalik Sakarya Elementary School. You made the transition from one of Stockholm's most select schools to Ayvalik Sakarya Elementary School; from being entirely among Swedes to entirely among Turks. While your mother and you children spent the winter of 1978-79 in Ayvalik, I went back and forth to Stockholm to complete my doctorate; I left the responsibility of both our children on your mother's shoulders. If the family I built remained standing, it was possible thanks to your mother's sacrifices, common sense, and love for her children. In the winter of 1979-80, we moved to Istanbul. You attended fifth grade at Levent Elementary School with a class teacher you almost hated. I found consolation thinking that these radical environment changes, despite some drawbacks, essentially gave you a high adaptation/adjustment ability.

In later years, you would say you felt resentment toward us for not entering you in the entrance exams for American middle schools in Istanbul. There were two considerations your mother and I took into account when entering you in the Galatasaray High School exam: That GS High School was a free public school was an advantage for our family budget. On the other hand, with the assumption that you would learn English anyway, we thought learning French would also be beneficial. Unfortunately, you never really warmed to GS High School. Fortunately, in your second year of high school, through a connection that your Aunt Ayla helped us establish, finding the opportunity to spend that year as a guest with a family in Rochester, New York State, USA, and to attend senior year of high school there was, I think, a great, enriching experience for you. Coming to the USA years later on an invitation and visiting you in Rochester was very exciting for me.

The Rochester experience opened another door for you. Again thanks to contacts your Aunt Ayla established, we found the opportunity to have the equivalency of your American high school diploma approved. Unlike other fields, universities in the fine arts fields you wanted to study were accepting students through talent exams that year. You didn't get into Mimar Sinan University which you really wanted, but you passed the exam for Marmara University Faculty of Fine Arts. You were never very satisfied with the education you received there, but thanks to your natural talents, the path to becoming one of Turkey's most recognized, most valued visual artists was thus opened.

In 1994, you married Altan. This marriage started happily, but unfortunately did not continue that way. But from this marriage a great happiness was born for us: In 1997, our Defne came into the world. The days we spent in Princeton in the spring of 1998, witnessing Defne's first steps on the Princeton lawn, are among my happiest memories. Your mother and I, thinking of our Defne, expected you to do everything you could to maintain your marriage, but when you came one day and said you couldn't do it (just as when you said you wanted to get married), we supported you. How fortunate that you managed to stand on your own two feet with your extraordinary artistic talent. I admire your art… In my view, its clear, open, and distinct message is: the beauty of nature, and therefore of life. (I liken the clarity in your paintings to that of my writings.) That you couldn't establish a harmonious family always saddened me. For if I am going to die happy, I owe this primarily to the togetherness I managed to build with your mother.

Since your mother and I also came from broken families (one due to death, the other to divorce), we didn't want the divorce to have negative consequences for Defne, but the consequences of an unhappy marriage could have been heavier for her. How fortunate that my Defne has superior intelligence and language and expression abilities that can make her free and happy. The experiences abroad that she gained at a young age (first Lyon, then Chicago) did not turn out as expected, but I am sure they helped her know herself and the world, and develop her ability to adapt to different conditions.

And we come to what happened to me with July 15. I think you understand the reasons we experienced this. The conflict between my love for my wife and children on one side, and my search for giving meaning to my life on the other, unfortunately led to my imprisonment in Silivri for quite a long time, to being far from you. Let me confess to you that if I could have foreseen that the result would be this (imprisonment at 73), I probably would have thought of giving meaning to my life in a different way…

You, my wife, my children, and my grandchildren, are paying the price of my imprisonment. Here the greatest burden fell on you, my dear Elvan. Just as I abandoned you at three years old and didn't see you for three years, now too I left you alone with an imprisonment whose end date is unknown. I cannot describe how sorry I am for this. Sometimes I think, "it would have been better if I had died, they would have recovered by now," but immediately afterwards, thinking that these days will pass and I will be reunited with you, I pull myself together and find the strength to endure captivity.

I owe you gratitude for forgiving me despite all the wrongs I did against you, all the offenses I committed, and for not just forgiving but always supporting me with great affection. You are one of life's greatest gifts to me. Because you exist, I don't feel alone. I apologize to you for all the sorrows I caused. (Silivri, December 6, 2017)

Letter to Acar

My beautiful son in every way. I am writing this letter to you on perhaps the most distressing, gloomy day of my imprisonment, which has reached its 500th day. I was hoping to be released and be able to spend a few days with you, with Gokce, with my dear Leyla before your move to London. It didn't happen. I cannot describe the longing I felt while looking at you from afar at yesterday's hearing. I hadn't intended to start my

letter with such sad lines, but it was unavoidable for it to be a sincere address. I wish you and your family healthy, successful years in London.

Let me come to what I really want to say to you… We had been deeply shaken by the unexpected, tragic deaths of your maternal aunt in 1976 and your paternal uncle in 1977. We thought a new baby would connect us to life again. Indeed, your birth enabled us to embrace life again with all our might. (I calculate that you were conceived in July 1977, during the days we stayed at the Efes Hotel in Izmir. In this, I am inspired by the famous astronomer Joseph Keller. According to what I recently read, he calculated exactly which day he was conceived in his mother's womb and noted it in his diary!

Your mother was at the peak of her beauty during her pregnancy with you. You can look at the photographs I took in those days, in her burgundy velvet maternity dress.)

Of course I remember the day you came into the world on March 11, 1978, in all its details. When your mother's labor pains started, Uncle Sait (Kocas) drove us in his car to Danderyd's Sjukhus, perhaps one of the finest hospitals in Stockholm that we were registered with. When your mother's contractions began to intensify, they took her to the delivery room and invited me in as well. Therefore, while excitedly watching you emerge from your mother's belly, I held your mother's hand and prayed for a healthy delivery. (Your birth was not as easy as Elvan's; your mother suffered quite a lot of pain this time, but everything went well.)

In those years, the gender of the baby could not be known in advance. There was a very exciting aspect to this… The nurse gave the good news, "En pojke, en snygg pojke! / A son, a handsome boy!" We had a daughter; now we were blessed with a son too; I was flying with happiness. The nurse first put you in an incubator to maintain your body temperature; then took you out and gave you your shots. You and your mother stayed in the hospital for two nights; I went home, to Elvan who was waiting excitedly and joyfully for news of her little sibling.

One of the most vivid memories of those joyful days is this: We had laid our son, who was about a month old, between us in our bed. Your mother was expressing her admiration for you, saying "My God, is this beautiful boy really mine?!" On March 31, our stunningly beautiful daughter had turned 10, and our stunningly beautiful son was 20 days old. (I had started telling my friends "Elvan is my pre-revolution child, Acar is my post-revolution child.") Following your birth, my mother went abroad for the first time and came to Stockholm. My mother and I had put you in the baby carriage that Gulder and Sait gave us, Ceren's baby carriage, and strolled with you along the seaside of Lappis. That too is one of the most vivid memories of our family story for me.

A few months after your birth, we decided that the time had come to return to the country. For three reasons: 1) Ecevit had formed the government in December 1977 by transferring 12 members of parliament from the Justice Party; he was promising to end terrorism and bring order to the economy, raising hopes that things in the country would get on track. 2) Your mother had decided she did not want to live in Sweden and wanted to return to the country. 3) My doctoral work was nearing its end. In October 1978, when you were just 6 months old, we made our final return to the country.

However, this was a decision made much too early: 1) Ecevit couldn't do anything beyond talking frequently and at length, and when he lost the by-elections in June 1979 he resigned, Demirel formed a minority government. 2) We settled in Ayvalik, in your maternal grandmother's stove-heated house in Camlik. That winter was especially cold and very difficult for your mother. She almost regretted returning. My dear son burned his hand by pressing it against the stove. I was very upset. 3) I had thought that being alone in Stockholm would let me work more productively and return to the country sooner. The plan didn't work out, the opposite happened: I suffered a lot, I came to Ayvalik at every opportunity missing you all, my work dragged on.

After Elvan completed fourth grade in Ayvalik, in the fall of 1979 we moved to the apartment in Zerrin building on Peker Street, Levent, Istanbul. Even finding this house had been very difficult. That winter the country's economy hit rock bottom, heating fuel (fuel oil) had become impossible to find. We had to set up a wood stove in the living room. That winter too had been harsh. You loved playing with snow in the garden and you remained a snow-lover always. My strongest memories of 1-2 year old Acar in Zerrin apartment are these: Your starting to talk saying "Ba.. ku… / Look… bird…" Your playing with straight pins (without ever pricking your hand)… When you reached 5-6 years old, you and Cengiz playing football inside the house…

In the fall of 1985, we moved to Akatlar, to Hayran Apartment on Meydan Street. You started at Levent Elementary School. You were much luckier than Elvan when it came to your teacher. Yours was a very sweet, well-intentioned person with strong human qualities. My instilling Besiktas fandom in you happened around that time. When I saw a Galatasaray inclination developing in you with Elvan starting at GS High School, at the first opportunity I took you to a BJK match and outfitted you with a BJK beret and flag. This (what luck!) happened to coincide with the match on October 15, 1989, when BJK beat Adana Demirspor 10-0 at Ali Sami Yen stadium. From that date on, you became a fervent Besiktas fan. We had celebrated your elementary school graduation at a restaurant on the Bosphorus. When the man sitting at the piano started in a bland voice "Long live Fenerbahce…", I was delighted as your classmates, who made up the great majority there, silenced the man with chants of "Besiktas! Besiktas!"

Until second year of high school, you received your secondary education at Atanur Oguz College in Balmumcu. My most vivid memories about you from those years are these: Although you were an extremely well-behaved and calm child at home, teachers complained about your wildness at school. This made me happy, because I would say "My son will be a gentleman, but he will never let himself be trampled on." My sad memory, however, was when you were asked to write a composition introducing your father in English class, you wrote about me "He is fat and nervous…" (This may have been influenced by my troubles in work life in those days. Otherwise I was an affectionate father…)

Just as I couldn't be a guide for Elvan, unfortunately I couldn't be one for you either. I couldn't do the things I should have done to help develop your knowledge and culture, like taking you to movies, theater, museums, concerts, bookstores. I had my own excuse; I had to work hard. When you reached second year of high school, your mother,

who had taken on the main responsibility for raising our children, became alarmed. She wanted you to transfer to Isik High School in senior year to increase your chances of getting into a good university. This way, if you wanted, the path to continuing at Isik University could be opened. Since your mother's classmates were on the school's board of trustees, arranging this transfer was not difficult. You weren't very enthusiastic because you didn't want to be separated from your classmates, but you didn't object. You finished high school at Isik. I was moved at the graduation ceremony; for the first time in many years, tears poured from my eyes.

When we learned that Bilkent University Faculty of Fine Arts would be accepting students through talent exams, we were very happy. You too, like your sister, had artistic inclinations. An opportunity had arisen for you to study at a good university, in a field you had talent in, in a civilized environment. Indeed, you passed the graphic design department exam and studied happily at Bilkent until you graduated in 2002. We decided you should take advantage of the opportunity to do short-term reserve officer service. You did your military service during the winter period (December - June) at the Infantry Training Brigade in Sivas.

At the oath ceremony, tears poured from both your mother's and my eyes. During the six months you spent there, your mother and I came to Sivas three times to see you. Since there were no flights to Sivas at that time, we first flew to Ankara, then to Kayseri, and reached there by bus. On our second and third visits, you were allowed to stay with us at the hotel. On the first visit, I cannot forget the sight when you came to the hotel and took off your socks. Your feet had literally turned green with moss from walking in the snow. You did your military service under harsh conditions, but as always, you adapted and never complained.

After military service, it was time to find a job. Around that time, a close friend of mine, Fuat Atalay, had been appointed general manager of IKEA Turkey. Through him you started working at IKEA, but since it was a job that didn't allow you to develop your talents, you were rightfully uneasy from almost the first day; a few months later, with our support as well, you resigned. However, the few months you spent at IKEA were a great gain for you. You met Gokce there, who would become your wife, whom we also loved dearly, who had studied interior design at GS University. You found a job suitable to your education at an advertising agency in Bahariye, Kadikoy. Then when she too left IKEA and started working at an architecture firm, you and Gokce rented a place near us and started living together. Later we celebrated your engagement at a restaurant in Akaretler with both families. I had worked together with Gokce's eldest sister Yonca at *Cumhuriyet*. Her other elder sister, Yesim, was a very warm person. Her maternal uncle had done the layout for *Cumhuriyet*. I was very pleased that you became son-in-law to a family suited to us.

You didn't want a wedding, but your mother's wish prevailed. My Fatma said, "I didn't have a wedding, my daughter didn't either, I'm going to have a wedding for my son." When you said "In that case, let it at least be in Ayvalik," it crossed my mind, "Could it be in Umit and Cem's garden in Cunda?" When my Fatma called Umit and said "Make sure

you're in Ayvalik on July 25, 2009," didn't Umit immediately say "Let's do it in our garden…"!!!… I had sensed it…

In the Boyners' garden, in my opinion the most beautiful wedding ever held in Ayvalik took place. Yesim - Cenk Co. took on the garden organization and refreshments, and Omer - Elcin Co. took on the wedding cake. It was a very pleasant celebration with about three hundred guests. In my speech celebrating your marriage, I commemorated your paternal uncle. It was very touching for me, but unavoidable. Your wedding also reflected family solidarity (just as between my elder brother and me, among you cousins). Gokce's late mother, her paternal uncle, and her nieces and nephews; my close friends Mehmet (Atakan), Cengiz, Sabetay, Zeynel, Oguz, Seyfettin, and Nuri (Yildirim) also attended the wedding. It was one of the happiest events of my life. We loved our daughter-in-law, as I said in my speech at the wedding, "like our own daughter."

After the wedding, you moved to an apartment in Nisantasi. You started working at a PR agency in Levent, but you weren't satisfied because you couldn't show your creativity, though you had reached a good position. You had waited quite a while to have a child, but on November 20, 2014, we had such a grandchild that it seemed there couldn't be one sweeter, more beautiful, more lovable than her. While thanking Gokce for giving birth to my Leyla, I asked, "Did you expect her to be this sweet?" She said, "I was sure she would be sweet, but I didn't expect this much"…

The day my Leyla was born, I was in Thessaloniki, where I had gone to teach for a week at a university. We celebrated my Leyla with friends from the university at a tavern. The next evening, as soon as I landed in Istanbul, I rushed to Florence Nightingale hospital to see my Leyla. You know how much I have adored and been devoted to her since that day. I am very happy that I suggested her name be Leyla and convinced Gokce of it. She is my Leyla, and I am her Majnun grandfather. I am writing these lines in Silivri prison. Unfortunately, I could only be together with my Leyla until she was 2.5 years old. In the spring months of 2016, as if sensing that I would be left longing for her, almost every day I put her in her stroller and walked to Taksim, to Taslik.

In this morning's visit, I perhaps saw you for the last time before your migration to England. As I have said repeatedly, your primary responsibility is not to your mother and father, but to your wife and daughter. I wish you had gone after I was released (?), but it's not clear when that will be. Yes, our hopes for the ECtHR and the Constitutional Court continue, but hopes can also turn out to be empty.

My Acar, in my view you are the world's most gentlemanly, most intelligent, most talented, best, most honest person. From your birth, you gave us so much happiness. I embrace you over and over and wish you success in your new life in London. My greatest wish is to be released without too long a delay, to be reunited with you, and for you to bring my Leyla to me right away. (Silivri, December 9, 2017)

My Public Life, on the Other Hand, Is a Complete Story of Defeat

My private life, that is, the family I built with Fatma, what I experienced with my children and grandchildren, when looked at overall despite all the hardships I put myself through along the way, all the troubles and sorrows I brought upon myself, is a complete success story. In short, I will die content with my private life. In contrast, my public life, that is, my life as an educated citizen, an intellectual concerned with the country's political problems, when looked at from the perspective of what I wanted to do but couldn't accomplish, is in every sense a story of failure.

Thanks to my mother's fortitude, during my formative years I received the best education possible in the country. I attended elementary school at Nilufer Hatun Elementary School in Nisantasi, Istanbul, middle school at the English High School for Boys in Nisantasi, high school at Robert College in Bebek and with an AFS scholarship at Webb School of California in the USA, with great success. I gave up going to Columbia University in New York, one of the most select universities in the USA where I had won a four-year scholarship, but I graduated from the Diplomacy and Foreign Relations division of Ankara University Faculty of Political Sciences, one of Turkey's foremost higher education institutions at the time.

Perhaps due to the effect of growing up in a family that fell apart encountering various problems, perhaps with the subconscious belief that I could only distinguish myself in a different Turkey, from my early youth I was in search of a different order for Turkey. In 1962, when returning to Turkey from the USA where I had spent a year, the fundamental question in my mind was why Turkey was so poor and weak while the USA was so rich and powerful. Before long, with the help of the Workers' Party of Turkey founded in those years and the developing leftist discourse, I found the answer: Because Turkey was a country exploited, "kept backward" by Western imperialist countries, primarily the USA… This understanding (or paradigm) that settled in my mind led me to start from a Kemalist nationalist discourse and gradually arrive at an increasingly totalitarian worldview. By the late 1960s, I had become convinced that Turkey's "liberation from the yoke of imperialism; establishing an equal, free, and prosperous society" was only possible through a Marxist-Leninist-Maoist revolution.

However, when I looked from the perspective of the Marxist-Leninist theory I had adopted at that time, both the socio-economic conditions of Turkish society and the consciousness level of the people seemed very far from achieving such a revolution. The "objective and subjective conditions" of the revolution did not exist; a very long and difficult preparation process was needed, a process of raising the people's consciousness. My trust in the friends I had set out with, especially Dogu Perincek, had also been shaken. But one had to start somewhere. When my commitment to the revolutionary ideal combined with the conditions of the March 12 period when I started being sought by security forces, I decided to abandon my wife whom I loved and my beloved daughter who was only three years old, and walk the path of revolution.

I thought that socialist revolution could not happen through the struggle of a handful of intellectuals and students without the workers and peasants wanting it, but I couldn't

abandon the cause, I couldn't tarnish my valor. Dogu Perincek, just as he made me a member of the illegal Revolutionary Workers' and Peasants' Party of Turkey he had established with his friends (despite my not being convinced of its necessity), decided to send me to the Palestinian resistance movement so I could rid myself of my bourgeois tendencies and attachments (which, presumably, he didn't see in himself) and prepare for the armed struggle I intellectually advocated. My warning that the Democratic Front for the Liberation of Palestine (DFLP), led by Naif Hawatmeh, which I was deemed fit to join, was a Trotskyist organization was not taken into account by my "comrade" Halil Berktay who conveyed the assignment, on the grounds that I could "bring them to the correct revolutionary line" (!).

As I described in detail above, during the approximately nine months I spent in Palestine, in an environment where my commitment to the revolutionary ideal conflicted with my awareness of how far we were from its conditions and with my longing for my wife and daughter, I tried to be an exemplary militant as best I could. To escape the torment of the conflict in my consciousness, I also volunteered to take part in an operation against Israel. After returning to Turkey nine months later and investigating for a short time whether there were possibilities to continue the struggle, I concluded (with my thinking at the time) that the idea of revolution was extremely valuable but completely disconnected from Turkish reality, and I took refuge with my family. My elder brother risked his life, fortune smiled on us, and in the end I took refuge in Sweden. As the years passed, it would become abundantly clear how far Turkey was from socialist revolution, and socialist countries would also be seen to abandon socialism.

In Sweden, where I managed to escape to and obtain asylum at the end of 1972, after quite some time I concluded that although socialist revolution might be an ideal, I no longer had any connection with this ideal, and I found the opportunity to do a doctorate in political science at Stockholm University. Over time, the Marxist paradigm in my mind gave way to a Popperian, liberal paradigm. Turkey needed a libertarian democracy and social market economy modeled on Sweden. To correct the wrongs I had done in the past, I decided to serve this ideal from now on.

It was patently obvious that neither the Kemalist, secular nationalism widespread in one part of society, nor the Islamism developing in reaction to it in the other part, was compatible with my ideal of a liberal democratic Turkey. Kemalist nationalism needed to be transformed into liberal social democracy, and Islamism needed to be reconciled with pluralistic democracy. Now, it seems ridiculous, but (as I described above) for quite a long time (together with a handful of like-minded friends) I believed these transformations could be possible. Unfortunately, I probably only fully grasped that the ideal of establishing a liberal democratic regime in Turkey was just as far from reality as the ideal of establishing a Marxist-Leninist-Maoist regime when I found myself in Silivri Prison.

So how was it that in roughly the first half of my adult life I could believe in a Marxist-Leninist, even Maoist Turkey, and in the second half in a liberal social democratic Turkey, the exact opposite? How was it that I, who had received quite a distinguished education by Turkey's standards, could adopt ideals both of which were so far from the

country's realities, so disconnected, having no validity? And I spent my life for these ideals? I can list the explanations that come to mind as follows.

1) My Family: I mentioned above that having been born into a troubled family and grown up without a father may have directed me toward the belief that I couldn't be successful in the established order and toward the search for an alternative order.

2) My Subculture: My origins go back to a family established by those who came and settled in Turkey through population exchange, forced migration from Greece, in short, by those of Rumelian origin. At least as far as I know, this subculture group, as I described in detail above, carries cultural characteristics quite different from the Turkish and Muslim people of Anatolia. It has characteristics whose summary might be found in Kemalist nationalism: It is Muslim but its religious beliefs are superficial. It has a culture of approaching differences with understanding, brought by centuries of coexisting with different religions and cultures. Ayvalik, where I was born and grew up, perhaps most intensely carried the characteristics of this subculture, at least in the years I was raised. Not only the cultural structure of Ayvalik but also its sociological structure where class differences were very pronounced may have affected me; growing up in a relatively affluent family and environment may have strengthened my reaction against socio-economic inequalities and may have directed me toward the search for a more just order.

3) My Education: In the formation of my personality and thoughts, undoubtedly the schools I attended played as great a role as, perhaps an even greater role than, the family and social environment I grew up in. I think having done my secondary education at English and American schools made me a bit too Western, to some extent foreign to society. Having done my higher education at Mulkiye may have led me to become overly engaged with Turkey's political problems. (The slogan at the SBF I attended was "Today at Mulkiye, tomorrow in Turkey"; that is, it was believed that graduates of our school would shape the country.) Having done my doctorate at Stockholm University may also have undoubtedly led me to start seeing Sweden as an example/model country. Whatever the influence of Mulkiye was on my "Maoism" in my youth, it can be said that my "social democracy" in my mature age originated from my years at Stockholm University. In the sum of all these influences, it can be seen that I belong to a subculture group quite foreign, quite marginal to Turkish society.

4) Turkey's Complexity: The diversity and plurality of Turkish society in which I was born and grew up (the divisions between Native - Immigrant, Sunni - Alevi, Turk - Kurd, secular - religious subcultures), alongside the rapid socio-economic change it underwent during the years I lived through (increases in both population and urbanization and average income levels), may have made my efforts to understand society difficult. These difficulties, as much as the education I received and the values I acquired from the schools I attended, may have led me to rely on imitative solutions that saw first China, then Sweden as examples/models, rather than creative solutions to problems.

Because I remained quite foreign to Turkish society for the fundamental reasons I listed above, although I sincerely advocated libertarian and pluralistic democracy, it can be said that I ultimately found myself in Silivri prison on the accusation of advocating a

military coup. In summary I can say that, primarily thanks to my attachment to my late wife Fatma, I generally led a happy, worthwhile life; when looked at from the perspective of my political ideals that separated me from her, however, I was completely disappointed. The “Maoism” I advocated in my youth was completely remote from intellectual creativity and completely disconnected from reality. The “liberal social democracy” I advocated in my mature age, although it expresses the political values I am still committed to, is unfortunately as foreign to Turkish reality as “Maoism.” If it is possible to extract an essence from all the complexity of Turkish politics, as far as I can see, it can be said that Turkish politics today is shaped around the struggle between a kind of secular nationalism with its nuances on one side and a kind of Islamic/religious nationalism with its nuances on the other. Of course, Kurdish nationalism with its different interpretations, which conflicts with both, must also be added to these.

THE END

Translator’s Note

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